Current Affairs Study PDF July – 2026

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NATIONAL AFFAIRS

CABINET APPROVALS

Cabinet Approves Rs 30,000 Crore Additional Investment in NIIF, total commitment to Rs 60,000 Cr

In June 2026, the Union Cabinet chaired by the Prime Minister (**PM**) Narendra Modi approved an additional investment commitment of **Rs 30,000 Crore (Cr)** in National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (**NIIF**), accelerating infrastructure development in India.

- With the fresh infusion, the Government of India's (**GoI**) total commitment to NIIF has doubled to **Rs. 60,000 Cr**.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** Cabinet approved additional Rs 30000Cr in NIIF
- ✓ **Total Commitment:** Rs 60,000 Cr
- ✓ **Fund Usage:** Infrastructure Fund II
- ✓ **Focus:** transportation, energy, digital infrastructure, urban infrastructure, e-mobility
- ✓ **Additional Funds:** Additional bilateral funds – FY28-FY30

NIIF

- ✓ **What is it:** India's Sovereign Anchored Fund
- ✓ **Established in:** 2015
- ✓ **Shareholder:** 49% – GoI
- ✓ **Capital Commitment:** Rs 40,000 Cr

Investment Purpose

Fund Usage: This additional investment of **Rs 30,000 Cr** will be used to set up **NIIF's** second infrastructure focussed fund (Infrastructure Fund II), the successor to its first flagship fund.
Focus: The fund will focus on sector-specific platforms across transportation, energy, digital infrastructure, urban infrastructure and emerging areas such as e-mobility (Electric-mobility).
Additional Funds: The government also plans to launch additional bilateral and successor fund strategies during Financial Year 2027-28 (FY28)-FY30.

About NIIF

NIIF: NIIF, established in 2015 is India's Sovereign Anchored Fund, professionally run and managed by National Investment and Infrastructure Fund Limited (**NIIFL**).
Capital Managed: The Government of India is a **49%** shareholder, and NIIF currently manages capital commitments of about **Rs 40,000 Cr** across its funds and investment strategies.
Track Record: NIIF has a strong track record of capital deployment and has returned nearly **Rs 12,000 Cr** to investors through major portfolio exits.



Advisory Role: NIIF also plays a strategic advisory role, assisting central government departments and state entities on new PPP (Public Private Partnership) initiatives and investment ideas that can catalyse private sector investments.
Strategies: NIIF's four operational investment strategies:

- **Infrastructure Fund** (Rs 16,000 Cr)- India's largest domestic infrastructure fund, investing in transport, energy and digital infrastructure.

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- **Private markets Funds** – Invests in AIFs (Alternate Investment Funds) focused on climate, affordable housing, healthcare and VC/technology.
- **Strategic Opportunities Fund** – Focuses on financial services, healthcare and manufacturing.
- **India-Japan Fund**: A bilateral fund investing in climate, circular economy, energy transition and the India–Japan business corridor.

Investor Base: Its investor base includes several global sovereign wealth funds, pension funds, multilateral development banks and domestic financial institutions.

About National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF):

Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer (CEO): Sanjiv Aggarwal
Headquarters: Mumbai, Maharashtra
Established in: 2015

CCEA Approved Rs 14,115 Crore Two Highway Projects in Delhi, UP

In July 2026, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs **(CCEA),** chaired by Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi,** approved the two major highway projects with combined investment of **Rs 14,114.81 crore,** including a Rs 6,969.67 crore 6-lane tunnel project in Delhi and Rs 7,145.14 crore greenfield highway corridor in Uttar Pradesh (UP).

- These new projects are expected to enhance connectivity, reduce travel time, and boost economic connectivity under the Pradhan Mantri GatiShakti National Master Plan **(PMGS-NMP).**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of Two Major Highway Projects in Delhi and UP
- ✓ **Approved by:** CCEA, chaired by PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **Combined Cost:** Rs 14,114.81 crore
- ✓ **Approval-**1: 6-lane Tunnel Project in Delhi
- ✓ **Total Cost:** 6,969.67 crore
- ✓ **Total length:** 8.1 km
- ✓ **Implementing Agency:** NHAI
- ✓ **Execution Mode:** HAM
- ✓ Timeline: Within 5 years
- ✓ **Approval-2:** Greenfield highway corridor in UP
- ✓ **Total Cost:** Rs 7,145.14 crore
- ✓ **Total Length of Corridor:** 117.7 km
- ✓ **Execution Mode:** BOT Toll Model
- ✓ **Developed by:** NHAI
- ✓ **Timeline:** Within 2.5 years



Tunnel Project in Delhi:

Overview: The cabinet approved the construction of a six-lane road tunnel on National Highway (NH-148AE) connecting Dwarka Expressway (NH-248BB) with Nelson Mandela Marg in Vasant Kunj, Delhi.
Execution: The proposed project will be developed by the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) under the Hybrid Annuity Mode (HAM) as part of the National Highways (Original) [NH(O)] scheme, including the construction of a 3.14 kilometer (km) twin-tube tunnel beneath the Southern Ridge.

- The new tunnel project, expected to be completed within 5 years.

Key Components: The total length of project is 8.1 km which comprises 6.3 km main carriageway, 980 meters (m) tunnel approach ramps, 554 m of reinforced earth wall approaches, 2.556 km of elevated corridor, and 870 m of at-grade road.

Boost Connectivity: The project will improve connectivity between West and South Delhi by connecting the Urban Extension Road-2 (UER-II)/Dwarka Expressway corridor with Vasant Kunj. It is also expected to benefit commuters travelling from Gurugram, Dwarka, Indira Gandhi International Airport and West Delhi towards South Delhi.

- The project also features a 1.8-km elevated corridor along Nelson Mandela Marg, an additional flyover from Chhatarpur towards Mahipalpur, and an elevated U-turn, ensuring smoother traffic movement.

Greenfield Highway Corridor in UP:

Overview: The cabinet also approved the construction of a 117.7-km-long four-lane access-controlled greenfield highway between Kanpur and Kabrai (Mahoba district) in UP. It also includes the operation and maintenance of the existing Kanpur-Kabrai section of NH-34.

Development: The newly approved project will be implemented by the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) under Build-Operate-Transfer (BOT) toll model as part of Bhopal-Kanpur Economic Corridor under the NH(O) scheme.

Key Benefits: Designed for operating speeds of 80-100 kilometer per hour (kmph), the proposed corridor is expected to reduce travel time between Kanpur and Kabrai from the existing 3.5 hours to about 1.5 hours, thereby reducing the journey time by nearly 58%, enhancing road safety, lowering vehicle operating costs and facilitating faster movement of passenger and freight traffic.

Potential Outcome: The greenfield corridor, expected to be completed within 2.5 years (yrs).

- It is further expected to handle an annual average daily traffic of about 18,069 Passenger Car Units (PCUs) by Financial Year 2027-28(FY28).

About National Highways Authority of India (NHAI):

It is an autonomous body which works under the Ministry of Road, Transport and Highways (MoRTH).
Chairman- Santosh Kumar Yadav
Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi
Established in- 1995

Union Cabinet Approves Semicon 2.0 with Rs.1.27 Lakh Crore Outlay to Boost India's Semiconductor Ecosystem

In July 2026, the Union Cabinet chaired by the Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** approved the **Semicon 2.0 programme** a new semiconductor incentive programme with a total budget outlay of **Rs 1,27,500 crore,** aimed to develop India's semiconductor design and manufacturing ecosystem.

- The new initiative builds on the momentum of Semicon 1.0, reaffirms the Government of India (GoI)'s commitment to position India as a major global hub for semiconductor design, manufacturing and innovation through a holistic ecosystem-based approach.
- Semicon 2.0 has been structured around **six main pillars** which include: Design, Machines & Materials, Setting up More Fabs, ATMP/OSAT industry, Research & Development (R&D) and Talent development.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of Semicon 2.0 programme
- ✓ **Approved by:** Union Cabinet, chaired by PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **Total Budget Outlay:** Rs 1,27,500 crore

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- ✓ **Six Key Pillars:** Design, Machines & Materials, Setting up More Fabs, ATMP/OSAT industry, R&D, and Talent development

Key Pillars of Semicon 2.0 Programme:

Design: The initiative builds on the success of 105 startups that have already begun developing semiconductor chips, aims to create Intellectual Property (IP), chip designs and complete systems for both strategic and commercial applications. This move is expected to strengthen India's chip design ecosystem.

Machines and materials: Under this pillar, the GoI will offer incentives to companies engaged in manufacturing and R&D of the machines and materials, chemicals and gases that are critical for manufacturing semiconductors, thereby supporting the development of a sustainable semiconductor supply chain and boosting India's precision manufacturing capabilities.

Setting up more fabs: The third pillar of the programme targets to expand semiconductor fabrication capacity by encouraging more global manufacturers to establish fabrication facilities in India and attracting investments in silicon fabs, compound semiconductor fabs, discrete component fabs and display fabrication units.

- In major development of India's semiconductor ecosystem, the country's first semiconductor fabrication plant is scheduled to be commissioned in 2028.



ATMP/OSAT industry: In order to strengthen India's Assembly, Testing, Marking and Packaging (ATMP) and Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (OSAT) industry, the GoI plans to attract more advanced semiconductor packaging technologies to India and establish the country as an alternative global destination for semiconductor packaging.

Research & Development (R&D): While India's semiconductor journey has started with technologies ranging from 28 nanometres(nm) to 110 nm, the GoI now intends to support the development of more advanced semiconductor nodes and next-generation technologies by fostering collaboration with leading research institutions in India and overseas.

Talent development: So far, 315 universities nationally have trained nearly 68,000 students in advanced chip design using industry-standard Electronic Design Automation (EDA) tools.

- Under Semicon 2.0, the GoI plans to expand the training ecosystem, with greater industry participation in areas such as clean-room operations, semiconductor fabrication, fab construction and related skills.

Revised Incentive Structure: Compared to India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 1.0, Semicon 2.0 introduces a revised incentive structure. Capital expenditure (capex) support for silicon fabs has been reduced from 50% to 40%, while display, compound semiconductor, and other fabs will receive 35%. Incentives have also been set at 35% for advanced packaging facilities and 25% for conventional packaging units

Key Progress of ISM 1.0:

Total Projects Approved: So far, the GoI has approved 12 semiconductor manufacturing projects under India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 1.0, with a cumulative investment of more than Rs 1.64 lakh crore.

- These projects include one silicon fabrication plant, one silicon carbide fabrication unit, an integrated gallium nitride (GaN) Micro Light Emitting Diode (LED) display fabrication facility and nine semiconductor packaging units.

Current Status of Projects Approved: Of the 12 approved semiconductor manufacturing projects, 3 companies namely, Micron, Kaynes and CG Semi have already commenced commercial production, while another unit is expected to start production later in 2026.

Design: Till date, a total of 24 semiconductor design projects from startups and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) have been approved for financial support.

- Also, GoI has provided access to EDA tools to 105 startups and MSMEs.
- These startups and MSMEs are developing chips and Systems-on-Chip (SoCs) for a wide range of strategic and commercial applications, such as satellite communications, drones, surveillance cameras, Internet of Things (IoT) devices, LED drivers, Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems, among others.

About Semicon India Program:

Launched: It is flagship programme of GoI, officially launched by the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology (MeitY) in **2021** with total budget outlay of **Rs 76,000 crore** (or, around USD 10 billion).

Aim: To develop a full-stack semiconductor ecosystem locally, from design to manufacturing and testing.

Key Target: The mission has set the target to reduce India's dependence on chip imports (at present, India imports 65%-70% of chip components, mostly from China), promote domestic production, and make India hub for chipmakers globally.

About Ministry of Electronic and IT (MeitY):

Union Minister- Ashwini Vaishnaw (Rajya Sabha member- Odisha)

Minister of State **(MoS)-** Jitin Prasada (Constituency- Pilibhit, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

Union Cabinet Approves 'Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme' with Rs.62,500 Crore Outlay

On July 15 2026, the **Union Cabinet**, chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, approved the 'Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme **(MPMS)'** under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) with a budgetary outlay of **Rs. 62,500 crore**.

- MPMS was approved under the Make in India initiative, the scheme aims to strengthen domestic mobile phone manufacturing, increase value addition, boost exports, and enhance India's global competitiveness in the electronics manufacturing sector.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme approved
- ✓ **Approved By:** Union Cabinet
- ✓ **Ministry:** MeitY
- ✓ **Budget Outlay:** Rs. 62,500 crore (FY27 to FY31)
- ✓ **Replaces:** Production Linked Incentive Scheme for Large Scale Electronics Manufacturing
- ✓ **Sales Incentive**: 2.25%–5% (+ up to 1.5% for domestic sourcing; + 3% for Indian brands investing in design & R&D)
- ✓ **Target:** Rs.39 lakh crore production, Rs.15 lakh crore exports, 60,000 direct jobs.

About Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS):

Objective: To scale up mobile phone production, deepen domestic value addition, strengthen supply chains, enhance global competitiveness, and promote Indian brands through design and Research & Development (R&D).

Implementation: The MPMS will be implemented for **5 years** (from Financial Year 2026-27(FY27) to FY31 and succeeds the Production Linked Incentive Scheme for Large Scale Electronics Manufacturing **(PLI-LSEM)**, which concluded on 31 March 2026.

Incentives: Under the MPMS, eligible manufacturers will receive sales-linked incentives ranging from **2.25% to 5%.**

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- An additional up to **1.5%** incentive will be provided for higher domestic sourcing of key components and sub-assemblies, while Indian brands investing in product design and R&D will be eligible for an additional **3%** incentive on eligible sales.

Targets: Aims to achieve **Rs. 39 lakh crore** cumulative mobile phone production, **Rs. 15 lakh crore** exports, and create around 60,000 direct jobs opportunities.

Domestic Value Addition: India is the world's second-largest mobile phone manufacturer by volume, with **99.2% of mobile phones** used in the country manufactured domestically, while the scheme aims to increase domestic value in the next 4–5 years.

Significance: Strengthens the **Make in India** initiative, promotes technological sovereignty, enhances India's position as a global electronics manufacturing hub, and supports the creation of globally competitive Indian smartphone brands.

About Production Linked Incentive Scheme for Large Scale Electronics Manufacturing (PLI-LSEM):

Overview: The PLI-LSEM, launched in **2020**, approved 32 companies and surpassed its investment, production, and export targets by February 2026.

Achievements: The scheme, implemented by MeitY, recorded Rs.17,519 crore in investments, Rs.11.02 lakh crore in production, Rs.6.21 lakh crore in exports, and created 1.85 lakh direct jobs.

Impact: The initiative helped India become the world's second-largest mobile phone manufacturer, with production rising to Rs.5.5 lakh crore, exports reaching Rs.2 lakh crore by FY25, and over 300 mobile manufacturing units becoming operational.

About Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY):

Union Minister – Ashwini Vaishnaw (Rajya Sabha – Odisha)

Minister of State **(MoS)** – Jitin Prasada (Pilibhit, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

Cabinet Approves Developmental Projects: NIPU-2026, Railway Multitracking Projects, & Elevated Corridor Projects

In July 2026, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs **(CCEA)**, chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, approved the National Investment Policy for Urea-2026 for Atmanirbhar Bharat **(NIPU-2026)**, aimed at encouraging new investments in gas-based urea manufacturing units with an estimated 1 crore Metric Tonnes (MT) of additional production capacity.

- The cabinet also approved **two railway multitracking projects** of the Ministry of Railways (MoR), Paradeep–Haridaspur Doubling and Rajkharsawan–Dangoaposi Fourth Line with an estimated cost of **Rs. 3,907 crore** covering four districts across Odisha and Jharkhand.
- It approved two major elevated highway projects in Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh (UP), with a combined investment of over **Rs. 25,000 crore.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** CCEA approvals on three developmental projects
- ✓ **Approval 1:** NIPU-2026
- ✓ Implementation: DoF, MoC&F
- ✓ Features: Return on Equity (RoE): 12% (minimum) – 16% (maximum).
- ✓ **Approval 2:** Two Railway Multitracking Projects in Odisha & Jharkhand
- ✓ Implemention: MoR
- ✓ Total Cost: Rs. 3,907 crore (approx.)
- ✓ Projects: Paradeep–Haridaspur Doubling & Rajkharsawan–Dangoaposi Fourth Line
- ✓ **Approval 3:** Two Elevated Corridor Projects
- ✓ Implemention: NHAI; Model – HAM
- ✓ Investment: Over Rs. 25,000 crore

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- ✓ Projects: Ganga Elevated Corridor & Varuna Elevated Corridor

National Investment Policy for Urea-2026 (NIPU-2026):

Objective: NIPU-2026 aims to bridge the gap between domestic urea production and national demand, reduce import dependence, improve fertiliser security, strengthen India's self-reliance in urea production under the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat, and support sustainable agricultural productivity.

Framework: NIPU-2026 provides financial certainty through a transparent cost structure, a defined **12–16%** Return on Equity (RoE) mechanism, separation of fixed and variable costs, and measures to minimise foreign exchange risks by converting fixed costs into Indian Rupees (INR) after four years based on prevailing exchange rates.

Implementation: The Department of Fertilizers **(DoF)** under the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers (MoC&F) will implement NIPU-2026, under which all future gas-based urea plants will be eligible for policy support, encouraging 8–9 new units of about 12.7 lakh metric tonnes (LMT) annual capacity each and generating savings of over Rs. 250 crore per plant.

Background: The earlier New Investment Policy (NIP)-2012 resulted in six new urea plants, including four developed through joint ventures of public sector undertakings (PSUs) and two by private companies, but its investment period expired in October 2019.

About Urea: Urea ($CO(NH_2)_2$) is a nitrogen-based fertiliser containing 46% nitrogen and is the most widely used fertiliser in India.

- It accounts for about 56% of total fertiliser consumption and 80% of nitrogenous fertiliser use, supporting higher crop productivity.

Railway Multitracking Projects:

Overview: MoR will implement the two approved railway capacity enhancement projects **Paradeep–Haridaspur Doubling** in Odisha and the **Rajkharsawan–Dangoaposi Fourth Line** across Odisha and Jharkhand.

- These projects will expand the railway network by approximately 145 kilometres (km) and enhance rail capacity, connectivity, freight transportation, operational efficiency, and passenger services in eastern India.

Integration: The projects are planned under the Pradhan Mantri Gati Shakti National Master Plan **(PMGS-NMP)** to promote integrated multimodal infrastructure and logistics planning through coordinated stakeholder participation.

- They will improve connectivity to approximately 1,526 villages benefiting about 14 lakh people, enhance access to Lalitgiri Buddhist Complex, Shree Baladevjew Temple, and Meghahatuburu Hills, and generate employment and self-employment opportunities.

Freight: The upgraded routes will enable efficient transportation of coal, iron ore, dolomite, limestone, gypsum, and other industrial cargo, increasing freight capacity by 44 Million Tonnes Per Annum (MTPA), boosting logistics efficiency, and supporting regional industrial growth and mineral evacuation.

Benefits: The projects are targeted for completion by **2030–31** and are expected to reduce logistics costs, save 6 crore litres of oil imports, cut 29 crore kilogram (kg) of carbon dioxide (CO2) emissions, provide environmental benefits equivalent to planting 1 crore trees, and contribute to India's climate goals.

About PMGS-NMP: Launched on 13 October 2021, is a Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I) initiative and a Digital Master Planning tool developed by Bhaskaracharya National Institute for Space Applications and Geoinformatics (BISAG-N) on a dynamic Geographic Information System (GIS) platform for integrated planning and coordinated implementation of multimodal infrastructure projects.

- It aims to improve connectivity across seven key infrastructure sectors, enhance logistics efficiency, support economic development, and reduce project implementation delays.

Elevated Corridor Projects:

Approval: The CCEA approved the 46.039 kilometre(km), **six-lane Greenfield Ganga Elevated Corridor** connecting National Highway (NH)-19 with the Varanasi Ring Road and the **43.218 km,** predominantly six/four-lane Varuna Elevated Corridor connecting NH-31 with the Varanasi Ring Road under the Varanasi Decongestion Plan.

Implementation: Both projects will be implemented by the National Highways Authority of India **(NHAI),** Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), under the Hybrid Annuity Model **(HAM)**.

Project 1: Varuna Elevated Corridor.

Significance: Aligned with the PMGS-NMP, the corridors will enhance multimodal connectivity, tourism, logistics, and sustainable urban mobility.

- **Components:** The project comprises a predominantly elevated corridor with flyovers, loops, ramps, service roads, and supporting infrastructure to provide seamless connectivity between NH-31, Varanasi Ring Road, Kashi Railway Station, Varanasi Junction, Varanasi City Railway Station, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Junction, Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport, Ramnagar Port, Sampurnanand Sanskrit University, the Varanasi Ghats, and the adjoining Chandauli region.
- **Cost:** The project has a total capital cost of **Rs. 10,998.32 crore**, including Rs. 4,565.33 crore for civil construction and Rs. 934.91 crore for land acquisition.
- **Travel:** Designed for an operating speed of 80–100 km/h, the corridor will reduce travel time between NH-31 and Kashi Railway Station from 40 minutes to 20 minutes while improving passenger and freight movement.

Project 2: Greenfield Elevated Corridor along River Ganga

- **Components:** The project comprises a six-lane elevated carriageway, a 910-metre (m) cable-stayed bridge across the River Ganga, a 1.32-km extradosed Foot Over Bridge (FOB)-cum-Major Bridge with travelators, loops, ramps, link roads, service roads, a Rail Over Bridge (ROB) over the existing/proposed Malviya Bridge, emergency parking bays, noise barriers, and heritage-inspired façade lighting.
- **Cost:** The project has a total capital cost of **Rs. 14,447.64 crore**, including Rs. 6,037.85 crore for civil construction and Rs. 541.11 crore for land acquisition.
- **Connectivity:** The corridor will improve connectivity to Kashi Vishwanath Temple, Banaras Hindu University (BHU), Namo Ghat, Ramnagar Fort, the Ghats of Varanasi, Lal Bahadur Shastri Airport, and Ramnagar Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWAI) Port.
- **Benefits:** Designed for an operating speed of 80–100 km/h, the corridor will reduce average travel time from 60 minutes to 20 minutes and travel time between NH-19 and Kashi Railway Station from 50 minutes to 25 minutes.

About HAM: Introduced in January 2016, is a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) framework for highway projects in which the government funds 40% of the project cost and the private developer funds the remaining 60%, recovering it through fixed annuity payments.

About National Highways Authority of India (NHAI):

Chairman – Santosh Kumar Yadav
Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 1995

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Union Cabinet Approves Bill to Strengthen Anti-Paper Leak Law with Up to 10-Year Jail and Rs 10 Crore Fine

In July 2026, the **Union Cabinet** chaired by Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi**, approved a draft Bill to amend the **Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024**, proposing stricter penalties of **up to 10 years' imprisonment** and **a fine of up to Rs 10 crore** for organised paper leak offences, along with provisions for **fast-track courts** to ensure speedy disposal of examination fraud cases.

- The amendment aims to strengthen the legal framework against organised examination fraud, dismantle paper leak networks, and safeguard the integrity of public examinations.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval for amendments to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024
- ✓ **By whom?** Union Cabinet chaired by PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **Proposed Amendments:**
- ✓ Individual offences- 5-10 years Jail
- ✓ Organised crime– 10 years Jail & Rs 10 crore Fine
- ✓ **Existing Law (2024 Act):**
- ✓ Individual offences–3-5 years imprisonment & up to Rs 10 lakh fine
- ✓ Organised crime– 5-10 years imprisonment & minimum Rs 1 crore fine.
- ✓ **Fast-Track Courts:** Special courts to complete trials within 3 months
- ✓ **Coverage:** Exams conducted by UPSC, SSC, NTA, NEET, JEE, CUET, railway recruitment, banking recruitment, other central government examinations.

About Amendments to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024:

Background: The Act was enacted in June 2024 following nationwide outrage over the paper leaks in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) [NEET-UG] and the University Grants Commission–National Eligibility Test (UGC-NET).

- It was India's first central law aimed at curbing paper leaks, organised cheating, and other unfair practices in public examinations conducted by Central Government agencies.

Objective: The amendments seek to dismantle organised paper leak syndicates, improve transparency in recruitment and entrance examinations and protect the future of students through stronger legal deterrence.

Key Amendments: The proposed Bill increases the minimum imprisonment for paper leak offences to 5-10 years for individuals, while retaining a **maximum punishment of 10 years** and raising penalties with fines of **up to Rs 10 crore** for organised offences.

- Before the amendment, the Act prescribed **3–5 years' imprisonment** alongside a fine of up to Rs.10 lakh for individuals involved in unfair means and **5–10 years' imprisonment** with a **minimum fine of Rs 1 crore** for organised examination fraud.

Coverage: The Act applies to public examinations conducted by the **Union** Public Service Commission **(UPSC)**, Staff Selection Commission **(SSC)**, National Testing Agency **(NTA)**, railway recruitment agencies, banking recruitment agencies and other Central Government authorities.

Fast-Track Courts: The amendments provide for dedicated **fast-track courts** to hear paper leak cases. These courts are expected to complete investigations and trials within **three months** to ensure speedy justice.

Significance: The proposed legislation strengthens India's legal framework against examination malpractice by combining enhanced penalties, dedicated courts and faster adjudication to preserve the credibility of public examinations.

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About National Testing Agency (NTA):

NTA is a premier, specialist, autonomous, and self-sustained testing organization functioning under the Department of Higher Education (DHE), Ministry of Education (MoE), to conduct entrance examinations for admissions and fellowships in higher educational institutions across India.
Director General **(DG)** – Abhishek Singh
Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 2017

Cabinet Approved Rs 3,030 Crore BHAVYA Rasayan Scheme to Set up 3 Chemical Parks in India

In July 2026, the Union Cabinet chaired by the Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** approved a new scheme named "Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana Rasayan **(BHAVYA – Rasayan)"** to set up three dedicated large chemical parks in the country with total budget outlay of **Rs 3,030 crore.**

- The scheme, initially announced by Union Minister Nirmala Sitharama, Ministry of Finance (MoF) in the Union Budget of Financial Year 2026–27 (FY27), would run for a period of **5 years** from **FY27 to FY31.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of BHAVYA Rasayan Scheme
- ✓ **Approved by:** Union Cabinet, chaired by PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **Total Budget Outlay:** Rs 3,030 crore
- ✓ **Duration:** 5 years (FY27 to FY31)
- ✓ **Key Purpose:** To establish 3 Chemical Parks in India
- ✓ **Fund Sharing:** GoI (maximum Rs 1000 crore per park) and respective state government (minimum Rs 500 crore)
- ✓ **Other Key Approval:** Railway Multitracking Project
- ✓ **Coverage:** 3 Districts across Karnataka and AP
- ✓ **Total Budget:** Nearly Rs 1,264 crore
- ✓ **Network Expansion:** About 46 km

About BHAVYA-Rasayan Scheme:

Funding Allocation: Out of total financial outlay approved, **Rs 3,000 crore** will be used towards meeting the cost of establishing the **common infrastructure facilities** and basic utilities inside the park and remaining Rs 30 crores for administrative expenditure.
Fund Sharing: As per the new scheme, the central government will provide financial assistance of maximum Rs 1,000 crore for each chemical park, subject to a minimum contribution of Rs 500 crore by the respective state government.
Infrastructure: The proposed chemical parks will be developed by state governments through a **challenge-based selection** process.

- Each park will require at least 2,000 acres or 8 square kilometers (sq. kms.) of contiguous, encumbrance-free land.
- These parks will feature plug-and-play infrastructure customised to meet the needs of the chemical sector, including Common Effluent Treatment Plants (CETPs), Treatment, Storage and Disposal Facilities (TSDFs), water supply and distribution systems, solvent recovery and distillation facilities, steam generation and distribution networks, interconnected pipeline systems, and logistics and warehousing infrastructure.

Significance: The scheme is expected to promote the development of the chemical industry and its value chain, including upstream, downstream and ancillary industries, which will further help increasing exports and reducing import dependence.

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Railway Multitracking Project Across Karnataka and AP:

Approved: The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs **(CCEA),** chaired by PM Narendra Modi, approved the 3rd and 4th Line of Ballari – Guntakal section in Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh (AP).

- The newly approved project is expected to be developed at an estimated cost of nearly Rs 1,264 crore and will be completed by 2028-29.

Aligns with PMGS-NMP: The proposed project is planned under the Prime Minister-Gati Shakti National Master Plan (PMGS-NMP), focusing mainly on improving multi-modal connectivity & logistic efficiency through integrated planning and stakeholder consultations.

Network Expansion: The newly approved multi-tracking project covering three districts across the two states is expected to expand the Indian Railways network by **about 46 kms.**

Boost Connectivity: Also, the project is expected to improve connectivity to nearly 99 villages with a combined population of about 7 lakh. It will also enhance rail connectivity to several prominent tourist destinations across the country, including Ballari Fort (Karnataka), Sri Kumara Swamy Temple (Karnataka), among others.

Key Benefits: The proposed project will result in additional freight traffic of 16.22 MTPA Million Tonnes Per Annum (MTPA). Also, it will help in reducing oil import i.e. 1.32 Crore Litres(lt.) and lower Carbon Dioxide (CO2) emissions i.e. 6.67 Crore Kilogram (Kg) which is equivalent to plantation of 0.27 crore trees.

About Ministry of Chemical and Fertilizers (MoC&F):

Union Minister- Jagat Prakash (JP) Nadda (Rajya Sabha – Gujarat)

Minister of State **(MoS)-** Anupriya Patel (Constituency- Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

PARLIAMENT NEWS

FESTIVAL

LAUNCHES & INAUGURATION

PM Family Care Tracker Pilot Project Launched in Gandhinagar, Gujarat to Strengthen Welfare Delivery

On 28 June 2026, Union Minister **(UM) Amit Shah,** Ministry of Home Affairs **(MHA)** and the Ministry of Cooperation, launched the PrimeMinister **(PM)** Family Care Tracker **(PM-FCT)** pilot project in Gandhinagar, Gujarat, to strengthen beneficiary identification and ensure timely delivery of government welfare schemes.

- During the event, he administered polio drops to children and distributed nutrition kits to children, pregnant women and lactating mothers.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Scheme?** PM Family Care Tracker (PM-FCT)
- ✓ **Launched by:** Amit Shah
- ✓ **Launch Date:** 28 June 2026
- ✓ **Venue:** Gandhinagar, Gujarat
- ✓ **Purpose:** Integrated monitoring of health, nutrition, education and welfare benefits for children.
- ✓ **Coverage:** From pregnancy to 18 years of age.
- ✓ **Feature:** Child unique ID linked with Birth Registration Number/ABHA ID.

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About the PM Family Care Tracker Project:

Overview: The PM Family Care Tracker **(PM-FCT)** is an integrated digital platform for monitoring the health, nutrition, education and welfare benefits of children from pregnancy to **18 years.**

Features: Every child will receive a unique ID linked to the Birth Registration Number **(BRN)** or Ayushman Bharat Health Account **(ABHA)** ID.

- The platform integrates **birth and death registration** with government databases to identify beneficiaries, generate alerts, and provide a digital Health Passport for timely welfare delivery.

Objectives: The initiative aims to identify eligible beneficiaries, ensure timely delivery of government welfare schemes and strengthen monitoring of health, nutrition and education services.

Rollout: The pilot project has been implemented in Gandhinagar, Gujarat, through the Health, Women and Child Development, and Education Departments to improve Direct Benefit Transfer **(DBT)** and the delivery of healthcare and welfare services.

Related Initiatives: During the launch, **Health Passports** were issued, polio drops were administered to children, and the first phase of **PM e-Bus Sewa** was inaugurated in Gandhinagar, Gujarat.

About Ayushman Bharat Health Account (ABHA):

The Ayushman Bharat Health Account (ABHA) is a **14-digit unique** digital health ID launched in September 2021 under the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM).

- It enables individuals to securely create, store and share their digital health records with consent across healthcare providers.

About Ministry of Home Affairs:

Union Minister – Amit Shah (Constituency – Gandhi Nagar, Gujarat)

Minister of State (MoS) – Nityanand Rai (Constituency – Ujiarpur, Bihar), Bandi Sanjay Kumar (Karimnagar, Telangana)

OPSA Launches TRL Compass Platform and Signs MoU with DSCI

In June 2026, Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser **(OPSA)** to the Government of India (GoI), in partnership with the Data Security Council of India **(DSCI),** launched the Technology Readiness Level **(TRL) Compass platform** to standardise the TRL assessment across various sectors.

- This new initiative was launched under the chairmanship of **Prof. Ajay Kumar Sood,** PSA to GoI.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of TRL Compass platform
- ✓ **Launched by:** OPSA to GoI with DSCI
- ✓ **Purpose:** To standardise TRL assessment across sectors
- ✓ **Supports:** ANRF and RDI Fund
- ✓ **Focus Sectors:** Healthcare & Pharmaceuticals, and Software.

About TRL Compass:

Overview: The new platform adapts the internationally accepted **9-level** TRL scale to cater the specific needs of India's research and innovation ecosystem.

- It acts as a common national standard to evaluate projects that need public funding.

Supports National Initiatives: It is designed to support the effective implementation of key national initiatives such as the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) and the Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund.

Focus: The newly launched TRL features sector-specific annexures for Healthcare & Pharmaceuticals and Software that enables domain-specific assessments.

Signing of MoU: Vinayak Godse, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of DSCI, and Dr. Preeti Banzal, Adviser/Scientist "G", OPSA, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to facilitate collaboration on

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technology readiness assessments, capability mapping, and the development of a Technology Radar methodology.

Union Minister JP Nadda Launches Aarogya Setu 2.0 and Other Digital Initiatives for Health Sector

In June 2026, Union Minister **Jagat Prakash (J.P) Nadda**, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW) launched a series of **digital health initiatives,** in New Delhi, Delhi, to strengthen India's Digital Public Infrastructure for Health and promote the adoption of interoperable digital health solutions across the country.

- The initiatives include Aarogya Setu 2.0, Ayushman Application(app), Ayushman Sarathi WhatsApp Chatbot, National Health Claims Exchange (NHCX), Insurance Plan Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources (FHIR) Object Creator, e-Sushrut Clinic, Unified Health Interface (UHI), Drug Registry, Common Logical Observation Identifiers Names and Codes (LOINC) Codes for India (CLCI), and Bharat Health Terminology Service (BHTS).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Digital Health Initiatives under MoHFW
- ✓ **Launched by?** Union Minister J.P. Nadda, MoHFW
- ✓ **Purpose:** To strengthen India's Digital Public Infrastructure for Health
- ✓ **Key Platforms/Initiatives:** Aarogya Setu 2.0, Ayushman App, Ayushman Sarathi WhatsApp Chatbot, NHCX, Insurance Plan FHIR Object Creator, e-Sushrut Clinic, Unified Health Interface, Drug Registry, CLCI, BHTS
- ✓ **Developed by:** NHA & NRCeS
- ✓ **ABDM Highlight:** Over 90 crore ABHA accounts and 100 crore+ health records linked.

Event Highlights:

Key People: The event was attended by Union Minister of State (MoS) Prataprao Jadhav, MoHFW; Union MoS Anupriya Patel, MoHFW; Dr. M. Srinivas, Member (Health), National Institution for Transforming India(NITI) Aayog; Dr. Manik Saha, Chief Minister(CM) of Tripura; Rajendra Shukla, Deputy CM of Madhya Pradesh(MP); Brajesh Pathak, Deputy CM of Uttar Pradesh(UP); Dr. Rajiv Bahl, Director General (DG), Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR); and Dr. Sunil Kumar Barnwal, Chief Executive Officer (CEO), National Health Authority (NHA).

ABDM Progress: During the event, Union Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda highlighted the progress of the **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission** (ABDM), noting that over 90 crore ABHA accounts and more than 100 crore health records have been created, making India one of the world's largest digital health ecosystems.

Digital Health Initiatives:

Developer: The event witnessed the launch of several digital health initiatives, developed under the National Health Authority **(NHA)** and the National Resource Centre for Electronic Health Record (EHR) Standards **(NRCeS).**

Aarogya Setu 2.0: It is a comprehensive Personal Health Record (PHR) application for citizens. Building on the trust and reach gained during the COVID-19 pandemic, the revamped platform serves as a single gateway to multiple digital health services.

Ayushman App: It is a digital health platform designed to provide citizens with seamless access to **Ayushman Bharat health services**, enabling easy management and utilisation of healthcare benefits.

Ayushman Sarathi: A WhatsApp chatbot providing 24×7 access to Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY) services.

- **Services**: Enables eligibility checks, Ayushman Card application/download, digital Know Your Customer (KYC), and Ayushman Vaya Vandana (AVV) services for senior citizens.

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Insurance Plan FHIR Object Creator: It is a digital tool designed to standardise and structure health insurance plan data using FHIR standards, enabling better interoperability across India's digital health ecosystem.

Unified Health Interface (UHI): It is an open digital network under the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) that enables seamless connectivity between patients and healthcare providers across digital platforms.

- **Services**: Supports doctor consultation bookings, ambulance booking, blood bank search, and Jan Aushadhi Kendra (JAK) discovery, among other healthcare services

National Drug Registry: A standardized national medicines database developed under the ABDM and the 4th national registry after ABHA, Healthcare Professionals Registry (HPR), and Health Facility Registry (HFR).

- **Development**: Created in collaboration with the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) and the National Resource Centre (NRC) for EHR Standards.
- **Database**: Contains over 1.23 lakh branded medicines, 10,000 generic drugs, and 29,000 substances based on SNOMED CT standards

eSushrut@Clinic: A government-supported, cloud-based Hospital Management Information System (HMIS) developed by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) for Primary Health Centres (PHCs), small outpatient, and private clinics.

- **Features**: Supports Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) services, including Ayushman Bharat Health Account (ABHA) integration, Clinical Decision Support System (CDSS), and digital health records.

Other Key initiatives: Launched the National Health Claims Exchange (NHCX) for digital health insurance claims, along with Common LOINC Codes for India (CLCI) and Bharat Health Terminology Service (BHTS) to standardise healthcare data and medical terminologies.

About National Health Authority (NHA):

Background: The NHA is the successor of the National Health Agency (NHA), which functioned as a registered society from 23 May 2018.

- Following a Cabinet decision to grant full functional autonomy, the National Health Agency was reconstituted as the National Health Authority on 2 January 2019.

Governance Structure: It is governed by a Governing Board chaired by the Union Minister for Health and Family Welfare, and is headed by a full-time Chief Executive Officer (CEO).
Current Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** – Dr. Sunil Kumar Barnwal

Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan launches VB-GRAM G nationwide in Tirupati District, AP

In July 2026, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister (**CM**) N Chandrababu Naidu and Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Ministry of Agricultural and Farmers Welfare (**MoA&FW**) launched the '**Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Yojana (VB-G RAM G)**' nationwide from Mukkavaripalli village in Tirupati district, Andhra Pradesh (**AP**).

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** AP CM and MoA&FW launches VB-GRAM G in Tirupati district, AP
- ✓ **Financial Outlay:** Rs 7.5 lakh Cr – 5 years; Outlay – Rs 1.51 lakh Cr – Annually
- ✓ **Panchayat Level allocation:** 2.86 lakh GPs, panchayat – Rs 2 Cr per year
- ✓ **Day One:** 5 lakh employment provided

About VB GRAM G

- ✓ **Days:** 125 days of wage employment
- ✓ **Minimum wage:** Rs 300 per day
- ✓ **Funding pattern:** 60:40 – C:S, 90:10 NE and Himalayas, 100% UT without legislature

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- ✓ **National Average:** Rs 327.4 per day
- ✓ **Unemployment Allowance:** 15 days of no employment
- ✓ **Admin Expense:** 9%

Key Features and Announcements

Key Members: Additional key members who participated included Deputy CM Pawan Kalyan, Union Ministers of State Dr. Chandrashekhar Pemmmasani and Kamlesh Paswan, several Member of Parliaments (**MPs**) and Member of Legislative Assembly (**MLAs**).

Financial Outlay: The government has committed the target is to spend a total of **Rs. 7.5 lakh crore** under this scheme over the next five years**.**

- The annual outlay under the scheme is projected at around **Rs 1.51 lakh Cr**, of which the Centre will contribute over Rs 95,692.31 Cr, with the remaining amount coming from the States' **40%** share.

Panchayat Level Allocation: Under the scheme, the annual outlay will be distributed across the country's **2.86 lakh** GPs, with each Panchayat receiving an average allocation of over **Rs 2 Cr** per year.

Day one: On the 1st day of the scheme's implementation, over **5 lakh** people were provided employment across more than 50,000 locations nationwide.

Announcements made: The Government announced the procurement of **2,16,250** metric tonnes (**MT**) of Totapuri mangoes under the Market Intervention Scheme (MIS) to provide remunerative prices to Totapuri mango growers.

PMAY: During the occasion, around **74,212 houses** were sanctioned under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (**PMAY**).

- The Union minister handed approval letters for the construction of 146 rural roads, 19 bridges with a sanctioned amount of **Rs 422 Cr.**

About VB-GRAM G

VB-GRAM G: The VB-G RAM G Act, 2025 is a rural employment framework that officially replaced **MGNREGA** (Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme).

- It guarantees **125** days of wage employment to eligible rural households and establishes a guaranteed national minimum floor wage of **Rs 300** per day.

Funding Structure: The funding structure under the programme is:

- 60:40 between the Centre and states,
- 90:10 for North Eastern and Himalayan states, and
- 100% central funding for Union Territories (**UTs**) without legislatures.

National Average: The national average notified wage has increased from Rs 298.8 per day to **Rs 327.4 per day**, reflecting an average enhancement of more than **10%**.

Unemployment Allowance: It is mandatory to provide employment within **15 days** and if the work is not provided within the stipulated time, unemployment allowance is to be provided.

Administrative Expense: Under this latest scheme, the admin expenditure has been increased from 6% to **9%** for effective implementation.

Staff Provision: The scheme allocates over **Rs 13,000 Cr** for the salaries and welfare of contractual personnel at GPs), mates, and other field-level employees.

Work Decision: The right to decide works will remain with the GP and gram sabha.

No Work Period: An aggregated **60-day** no-work period to ensure the availability of agricultural labour during peak sowing and harvesting season.

Weaker GPs: The GPs will be categorised into 3 categories: **A, B and C** and more funds will be allocated to the weak GPs.

- In AP, a special amount of **Rs 7,707 Cr** from the centre is being given under the 'VB-GRAM G' for a period of 9 months.

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About Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (MoA&FW):

Union Minister– Shivraj Singh Chouhan (Constituency- Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh, MP)
Minister of State (**MoS**) – Ram Nath Thakur (Rajya Sabha- Bihar); Bhagirath Choudhary (Constituency- Ajmer, Rajasthan)

CCRAS Launches Three Research Initiatives to Strengthen Ayurveda Research and Digital Governance

In July 2026, **Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha,** Secretary of the Ministry of AYUSH (Ayurveda, Yoga & Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, Sowa-Rigpa, and Homeopathy), conducted the **5th** Executive Committee **(EC)** Meeting of the Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences **(CCRAS)**, the apex research body under the Ministry of AYUSH, in New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Event?** 5th EC Meeting of the CCRAS held
- ✓ **Where?** New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Chaired by:** Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary, Ministry of Ayush

Key Launches:

- ✓ Research Methodology Textbook under Ayurved Prabodhini Granthamala
- ✓ CCRAS PRAYATNA 2026–27 (Scientific Writing Initiative)
- ✓ CCRAS Digital Ecosystem Dashboard

Highlights of the Event:

Key Launches: During the meeting, CCRAS launched **three major initiatives**: Research Methodology Textbook, CCRAS PRAYATNA 2026–27, and the CCRAS Digital Ecosystem Dashboard, to strengthen evidence-based Ayurveda research, scientific writing, research education, and digital governance in the Ayurveda sector.

Dignitaries: The meeting was attended by Hoveyda Abbas, Additional Secretary & Financial Adviser, Ministry of AYUSH; Satyajit Paul, Senior Statistical Adviser, Ministry of AYUSH; N. Srikanth, Deputy Director General, CCRAS; and Deepak Kochhar, Deputy Director–Administration, CCRAS; along with other Executive Committee members.

About Three Major Initiatives Launched:

Research Methodology Textbook: CCRAS released a Research Methodology Textbook under the Ayurved Prabodhini Granthamala series.

- **Features:**
- Developed by 50 research scientists and faculty members.
- Prepared as per the Outcome-Based Dynamic Curriculum prescribed by the National Commission for Indian System of Medicine (NCISM).
- Intended for Doctor of Medicine (MD), Master of Surgery (MS) and Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) scholars to strengthen research methodology and evidence-based research skills.

CCRAS PRAYATNA 2026-27: CCRAS launched the Expression of Interest (EoI) for CCRAS PRAYATNA 2026–27, its flagship initiative for promoting scientific writing.

- **Objectives:**
- To enhance scientific writing and publication skills among postgraduate and **Ph.D.** scholars through institution-based workshops.
- To promote a stronger research culture and improve scientific communication in Ayurveda. This Initiative official poster was unveiled during the meeting.

CCRAS Digital Ecosystem Dashboard: CCRAS launched the **CCRAS Digital Ecosystem Dashboard**, an integrated digital platform that brings together the Council's web-based resources.

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- **Purpose:** To improve accessibility, transparency and public outreach by providing a unified platform for research outputs and institutional resources, while supporting digital governance in the Ayurveda research ecosystem.

Achievements of CCRAS:

NABH & NABL Accreditations: CCRAS secured 21 accreditations from the National Accreditation Board for Hospitals and Healthcare Providers (NABH) and the National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories (NABL) across its institutes, enhancing quality standards in healthcare and research.

Ayush Diksha Platform: Established the **Ayush Diksha** digital learning platform to strengthen online education, training and knowledge dissemination in the AYUSH sector.

Research & Anaemia Study: CCRAS expanded international collaborative research initiatives to promote global scientific validation and recognition of Ayurveda and successfully conducted a large-scale study on anaemia among adolescent girls, strengthening evidence-based public health research in Ayurveda.

About Ministry of AYUSH:

Minister of State **(MoS)**(Independent Charge (IC) – Jadhav Prataprao Ganpatrao (Constituency – Buldhana, Maharashtra MH)

Secretary – Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha

Union Minister Amit Shah Launches Key Initiatives at the 5th Foundation Day on July 6, 2026

On July 6 2026, Union Minister **Amit Shah,** Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and the Ministry of Cooperation, launched several key initiatives at the **5th Foundation Day** Ceremony of the Ministry of Cooperation held at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, Delhi.

- During the event, he announced that the Government of India (GoI) plans to establish a **Cooperative Life Insurance Company** to expand the cooperative sector.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoC celebrates 5th foundation day
- ✓ **When?** July 6, 2026
- ✓ **Where?** Bharat Mandapam, Delhi
- ✓ **Led by:** Union Minister Amit Shah, Ministry of Cooperation
- ✓ **Vision:** 'Sahakar Se Samriddhi'
- ✓ **Releases:** Model bye-laws for dairy cooperative societies and book on the Ministry of Cooperation's five-year achievements
- ✓ **Projects launched:** Transfer of 135 godowns; inauguration of 85 godowns; foundation stone laid for 47 grain-storage godowns
- ✓ **Key Initiatives:** e-PACS initiative, Bhoomi Pujan of Sahakar Van; tissue-culture facilities ; NCD 3.0; Geo-tag Mobile App; and NDDB Milk Supply Review Dashboard Portal
- ✓ **Dairy Initiatives:** Inauguration of CMPL and GCSL, NUCFDC Sahakar CBS and Sahakar Sahyogi
- ✓ **MoU:** Between BBSSL and ICAR to strengthen seed systems
- ✓ **Announcement:**
- ✓ Plans to establish a Cooperative Life Insurance Company
- ✓ Bharat Taxi to be expanded to 500 cities.

Programme Highlights:

Key Members: The event was attended by Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying (MoFAH&D), Bhajan Lal Sharma, Chief Minister (CM) of Rajasthan, Union Minister of State (MoS) Krishan Pal Gurjar, Ministry of Cooperation and other senior officers from various ministries.

Vision: The ceremony was held in line with the vision of "**Sahakar Se Samriddhi**" of the Prime Minister (**PM**) Narendra Modi.This vision of GoI aims to strengthen the cooperative movement across the country.
Progress: The Ministry of Cooperation has undertaken several transformative initiatives for Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (**PACS**), cooperative banks, dairy cooperatives, urban cooperatives, national-level and multi-level cooperative societies.

Initiatives and Projects Launched:

Releases: During the event, Union Minister Amit Shah released model bye-laws for dairy cooperative societies and a book highlighting the achievements of the Ministry of Cooperation over the past five years.
Projects: The various projects and initiatives inaugurated in this occasion are:

- Transfer of 1**35** godowns, inauguration of **85** godowns and lay the foundation stone for **47** grain storage godowns.

Key Initiatives: Several key cooperative initiatives were launched, including the:

- Bhoomi Pujan of Sahakar Van by Amul and NCCF (National Cooperative Consumers' Federation of India Ltd).
- Tissue culture facilities of Bharatiya Beej Sahakari Samiti Limited (**BBSSL**) at Barabanki, Uttar Pradesh (UP) and Jalgaon, Maharashtra.
- National Cooperative Database 3.0 (**NCD 3.0**) and the Geo-tag Mobile Application(app).
- National Dairy Development Board's (**NDDB**) Milk Supply Review Dashboard Portal.

Dairy Initiatives: Following dairy initiatives were also launched:

- Inauguration of the Cooperative Milk Producers Organisation Multi-State Limited (**CMPL**) and Gomay Cooperative Society Multi-State Limited (**GCSL**).
- Launch of NUCFDC's (National Urban Cooperative Finance and Development Corporation) Sahakar CBS (Core Banking Solution), a centralized core banking platform.
- Sahakar Sahyogi, a conversational AI (Artificial Intelligence)-powered platform for Urban Cooperative Banks.

e-PACS: GoI launched the e-PACS initiative for the digital transformation of **50,000** Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS).
MoU: During the programme, a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) was signed between **BBSSL** (Bharatiya Beej Sahakari Samiti Limited) and **ICAR** (Indian Council of Agricultural Research) for strengthening seed systems.

Other Announcements:

Bharat Taxi: Union Minister Amit Shah also announced that the government's Bharat Taxi initiative will be expanded to **500 cities** over the next two years, citing its strong early performance.

- Bharat Taxi is an initiative of Sahakar Taxi Cooperative Ltd, a driver-centric mobility platform based on the cooperative model.
- At present, Bharat Taxi has **6.37 lakh** registered drivers and **35.77 lakh** registered customers.

Network: India is home to around 8,50,000 cooperative societies with a combined membership of more than 300 million (Mn), making it one of the world's largest cooperative networks.

About Ministry of Cooperation:

The Ministry of Cooperation was established by the Government of India on 6 July 2021.
Union Minister – Amit Shah (Constituency – Gandhinagar, Gujarat)
Minister of State (**MoS**) – Krishnan Pal (Constituency – Faridabad, Haryana), Muralidhar Mohol (Constituency- Pune, Maharashtra)

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Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan Launches PRAGATI Initiative to Support 20 Lakh Farmers

In July 2026, Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare **(MoA&FW**) & Rural Development **(MoRD)** Shivraj Singh Chouhan launched the PRAGATI (Promoting Regenerative Agriculture Through Agri-Entrepreneurship Initiative) programme in New Delhi, Delhi.

- The initiative aims to empower **20,000 agri-entrepreneurs** and directly support **20 lakh smallholder farmers** across India by promoting sustainable and climate-resilient agriculture.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Initiative?** PRAGATI
- ✓ **Launched By:** Shivraj Singh Chouhan
- ✓ **Launch Place:** New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Beneficiaries:** 20,000 agri-entrepreneurs and 20 lakh farmers
- ✓ **Coverage:** 8 States
- ✓ **Key Targets:** 30% increase in farmer income; 15–20% increase in crop yield; 20% adoption of regenerative agriculture; 50% financial inclusion.
- ✓ **Supported by:** The PepsiCo Foundation, SBIF, Gates Foundation, IDH, Heifer International, EDF, Global Agri Entrepreneurship Academy, SAFIA, AEGF and TRIF.

Highlights of the PRAGATI Initiative:

Objective: PRAGATI aims to strengthen rural livelihoods through regenerative agriculture, technology-driven farming and improved market access.

Implementation: The programme will be implemented in Madhya Pradesh **(MP)**, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh **(UP)**, Assam, West Bengal **(WB)**, Jharkhand, Maharashtra **(MH),** and Rajasthan, building on the existing network of **26,000+ agri-entrepreneurs** supporting **26 lakh farmers**.

- Agri-entrepreneurs will provide soil testing, mechanisation, advisory services, financial linkages and market access at the village level.

Targets: PRAGATI aims to increase farmers' income by at least **30%**, improve yields of major crops by **15–20%**, promote regenerative agriculture among **20%** of participating farmers and enable financial inclusion for **50%** of associated farmers.

Vision: The initiative supports the **Viksit Bharat 2047** vision by promoting developed agriculture, prosperous villages and higher farmers' income.

Partners: The initiative is jointly supported by the PepsiCo Foundation, State Bank of India Foundation **(SBIF)**, Gates Foundation, IDH, Heifer International, Environmental Defense Fund (EDF), Global Agri Entrepreneurship Academy, Sustainable Agriculture Foundations International Association **(SAFIA)**, Agri Entrepreneur Growth Foundation **(AEGF)** and Transform Rural India Foundation **(TRIF)**.

About Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare (MoA&FW):

The MoA&FW is the apex governing body of the Government of India responsible for the formulation and administration of agricultural regulations, laws, and policies.

Minister of State **(MoS)**: Bhagirath Choudary (Constituency – Ajmer, Rajasthan), Ram Nath Thakur (Constituency – Rajya Sabha- Bihar)

Chitkara University Launches Rs. 20-Crore Atal Incubation Centre for Deep-Tech Startups

In July 2026, **Chitkara University**, Punjab, launched the Atal Incubation Centre–Chitkara Incubation Foundation **(AIC-CIF)** and **AIC-PRIDE Labs** with a combined investment of **Rs. 20 crore over five years** to strengthen India's deep-tech startup ecosystem by supporting startups in Drone Technologies, Agritech, and Renewable Energy.

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- The inauguration was attended by Amit Dhaka, Indian Administrative Service (IAS), CEO, Invest Punjab; Prateek Deshmukh and Deepakshi Jindal of AIM, NITI Aayog; and Dr. Ashok Chitkara and Dr. Madhu Chitkara of Chitkara University.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of AIC-CIF & AIC-PRIDE Labs
- ✓ **Where?** Chitkara University, Punjab
- ✓ **Investment**: Rs. 20 crore over 5 years
- ✓ **Supported By:** AIM, NITI Aayog, and Chitkara University
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Drone Technologies, Agritech, and RE
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote deep-tech startups, research commercialisation, entrepreneurship, and technology-led growth
- ✓ **Additional Launch:** ATLs Sarthi Punjab.

About Atal Incubation Centre–Chitkara Incubation Foundation (AIC-CIF):

Objective: The incubation centre will promote research commercialisation, entrepreneurship and technology-led economic growth by supporting deep-tech startups.

Collaboration: The initiative was launched in collaboration with the Atal Innovation Mission **(AIM)** under National Institution for Transforming India **(NITI Aayog),** Government of India (GoI), and Chitkara University.

Framework: Designed as a launchpad for high-impact technology ventures, the AIC-CIF will support entrepreneurs through structured acceleration programmes, expert mentorship, funding opportunities, product validation, industry partnerships, Intellectual Property (IP) facilitation, and regulatory guidance to help innovators transform breakthrough ideas into scalable enterprises.

ATL Sarthi Punjab: The inauguration also marked the launch of Atal Tinkering Labs **(ATLs) Sarthi Punjab,** an Atal Innovation Mission (AIM) initiative to strengthen and mentor ATLs across Punjab, creating an innovation pipeline from schools to startups.

Collaboration: The initiative brings together academia, industry, government and investors to nurture globally competitive technology ventures.

About Atal Innovation Mission (AIM):

The AIM is the Government of India (GoI's) flagship initiative to promote innovation and entrepreneurship.

Director – Dr. Deepak Bagla

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

Established – 2016

Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal Launches 'Seafarer-First' Initiative to Safeguard Indian Seafarers

In July 2026, Union Minister **Sarbananda Sonowal,** Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW), launched the **'Seafarer-First'** initiative to safeguard Indian seafarers operating in the Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz, and Gulf of Oman amid escalating maritime security concerns in West Asia.

- The initiative follows attacks on the merchant vessels MT Al Bahiyah and MT Mombasa in the Strait of Hormuz, which affected 30 Indian seafarers in the crew of 46.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Seafarer-First initiative launched
- ✓ **Launched By:** Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal, MoPSW
- ✓ **Objective:** Safeguard Indian seafarers amid maritime security threats
- ✓ **Regions Covered**: Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz & Gulf of Oman

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- ✓ **Implementing Agency:** Directorate General of Shipping
- ✓ **Key Mechanism:** Real-time vessel-by-vessel operational dashboard
- ✓ **Support:** Medical evacuation, repatriation, compensation & 24×7 grievance support system.

About Seafarer-First Initiative:

Objective: To safeguard Indian seafarers through a **whole-of-government** response, launched after a high-level inter-ministerial review meeting in New Delhi.

Operational Measures: The Directorate General of Shipping **(DGS)** will establish a real-time **vessel-by-vessel operational dashboard** to monitor every Indian seafarer, irrespective of the vessel's flag, appoint dedicated liaison officers, and coordinate with Indian Missions in Iran, Oman, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE).

- The dashboard will provide real-time information on vessel location, ownership, cargo, crew strength and welfare, threat assessment, voyage details, next port of call, and available facilities.

Safety Measures: Mandates fresh threat assessments before vessel transit and directs shipowners, vessel managers, and Recruitment and Placement Service Licence **(RPSL)** agencies to ensure no Indian seafarer sails without adequate information, protection, and support.

Support: Provides medical evacuation, repatriation, compensation, welfare assistance, and a **24×7** grievance support system for affected seafarers and their families.

Coordination: Implemented in coordination with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), Indian Navy (IN), and DGS.

Significance: Strengthens India's maritime emergency response through the International Maritime Organization (IMO), ensuring seafarer safety and uninterrupted global trade.

About Directorate General of Shipping:

The DGS is the **apex maritime authority of the** Government of India **(GoI)** Operating under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, it oversees maritime education, seafarer welfare, and the safety and security of Indian-flagged vessels.

Director General **(DG)** – Shyam Jagannathan

Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra

Established – 1949

NABARD Launches 'Gramodyam' Programme to Boost Rural Entrepreneurship

On July 13, 2026, Dr. Shaji K. V., Chairman of the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development **(NABARD)**, launched **'Gramodyam'**, an Entrepreneurship Development Programme (EDP), on the occasion of NABARD's **45th Foundation Day** to strengthen the rural enterprise ecosystem.

- The programme is being implemented in collaboration with the National Skill Development Corporation **(NSDC)** under the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE) through the Institute for Industrial Development **(IID)**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Entrepreneurship Development Programme 'Gramodyam'
- ✓ **Launched By:** Dr. Shaji K. V., Chairman of NABARD
- ✓ **Occasion:** NABARD's 45th Foundation Day
- ✓ **Implementation Partners:** NSDC & Institute for Industrial Development
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote rural entrepreneurship and enterprise development
- ✓ **Target:** 4,000 rural entrepreneurs in 3 years.

About Gramodyam:

Objective: To identify, train, mentor, and support rural entrepreneurs for sustainable enterprises and local employment generation.

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Implementation: Adopts a **digital-first hybrid model** with entrepreneurship training, psychometric assessment, mentoring, and enterprise establishment support across all States and Union Territories (UTs).

Framework: The programme offers end-to-end credit support, including preparation of bankable Detailed Project Reports (DPRs), linkage with Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) and other financial institutions for loans, access to government schemes and incentives, and digital assistance for loan applications to improve formal credit access.

Monitoring: Beneficiaries will undergo electronic Know Your Customer (e-KYC) verification through NSDC, and the programme will be integrated with the NSDC digital platform for real-time monitoring.

- The assessment framework will monitor enrolment, gender inclusion, training completion, certification, Goods and Services Tax (GST) and Udyam registrations, enterprise operationalisation, and business performance.

Target: The pilot phase aims to create around **4,000 rural** entrepreneurs over 3 years.

Significance: Promotes entrepreneurship-led rural transformation, financial inclusion, and local employment, supporting the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat and Viksit Bharat 2047.

About National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD):

The NABARD is India's apex development financial institution for promoting agriculture, rural development, and financial inclusion.

Chairman – Dr. K. V. Shaji

Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra

Established – 1982

MeitY-DFI launched NIDAR 2.0 to Develop Drones Powered by Indian-Made Chips

In July 2026, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology **(MeitY),** in partnership with Drone Federation India **(DFI),** launched the **2nd** edition of the National Innovation Challenge for Drone Application and Research (**NIDAR 2.0**) **for (2026-27)** under the **SwaYaan initiative,** during the programme held at Electronics Niketan, New Delhi (Delhi).

- During the programme, the problem statements, poster and rulebook for NIDAR 2.0 were formally launched by S. Krishnan, Secretary, MeitY.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of 2nd edition of NIDAR 2.0 for 2026-27
- ✓ **Launched by:** MeitY
- ✓ **Co-partner:** DFI
- ✓ **Key Focus:** To develop autonomous systems, indigenous avionics and core drone components
- ✓ **Key Features:** Two tracks (Drone Innovation and Component Innovation)
- ✓ **Prize Pool:** More than Rs 65 lakh

About NIDAR 2.0:

Key Focus: The focus of the latest edition of NIDAR 2.0 shifts from conventional systems to autonomous systems, indigenous avionics and core drone components, supported by indigenous VEGA processors.

Key Features: The challenge is built on two tracks i.e. **Track 1 (Drone Innovation)** and **Track 2 (Component Innovation).**

- Under Track-1 student teams will develop fully autonomous swarm drones for locating survivors and delivering medical parcels in a disaster zone without any external communication network, besides developing a Global Positioning System (GPS)-denied drone for industrial inspection.
- Under Track 2, student teams will be required to design an indigenous flight controller and autopilot built around the VEGA processor, using indigenous electronic components.

Evaluation: Following the technical evaluation, each of the top 100 teams will receive two VEGA processor kits for development, testing and integration.

Key Purpose of VEGA processor: VEGA processors, designed by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) under MeitY's Microprocessor Development Programme (MDP), based on the open-standard Reduced Instruction Set Computer Five (RISC-V) architecture, has been integrated within the Component Innovation track, to encourage students to build the control systems of Indian drones on Indian-made chips.

Key Offerings: NIDAR 2.0 offers a prize pool of **over Rs 65 lakh.** In addition, it will provide corporate internships, incubation support and cloud computing credits to the winning teams that would help them to turn their prototypes into commercial products

Previous Edition: The inaugural edition of NIDAR, formally launched in March 2025, witnessed the participation of 3,448 students from 22 states, 04 Union Territories (UTs) and 109 cities across the country, who built autonomous drone solutions for disaster management and precision agriculture.

- Of the 93 teams that reached the finals, 24 won prizes worth Rs 40 lakh.

About SwaYaan initiative: In July 2022, the MeitY approved SwaYaan initiative with total outlay of nearly Rs 89.87 crore for a period of 5 years, to build the skilled workforce required for India's drone sector.

- It is centered on the Hub-and-Spoke model of 30 premier institutions, including Indian Institute of Science (IISc-Bengaluru, Karnataka), Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), Indian Institutes of Information Technology (IIITs), National Institutes of Technology (NITs), C-DAC and National Institute of Electronics & Information Technology (NIELIT), across five work themes: Aeromechanics, Drone Electronics, Guidance, Navigation, and Control (GNC) Algorithms and Simulation, Drone Applications, and Allied Unmanned Aircraft Systems (UAS) Technologies.

About Drone Federation India (DFI):

DFI is a non-profit, industry-led non-governmental organization that serves as the apex body for India's drone and counter-drone ecosystem.

President – Smit Shah

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

Established – 2019

India Launches Campaign For UNSC Non-Permanent Seat For 2028–29 Term

In July 2026, **Union Minister Dr. S. Jaishankar,** Ministry of External Affairs **(MEA)** officially launched India's campaign for election as a **non-permanent member** of the United Nations Security Council (**UNSC**) for the **2028–29 term** at the United Nations (UN) Headquarters in New York, the United States of America (USA).

- The campaign, themed "**SHANTI**: Securing Holistic Advancement through Norms, Trust and Integrity", highlights India's commitment to global peace, security, equitable development, and reformed multilateralism.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of India's campaign for UNSC non-permanent seat
- ✓ **For Term:** 2028-29
- ✓ **Launched by:** Union Minister Dr. S. Jaishankar, MEA
- ✓ **Campaign Theme:** SHANTI – Securing Holistic Advancement through Norms, Trust and Integrity
- ✓ **Where?** UN Headquarters (New York, the USA)
- ✓ **Elections for 2028-29 term scheduled in:** June 2027
- ✓ **India Set to Compete Against:** Tajikistan (in Asia-Pacific Group)

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Key Details of Campaign:

Priority Areas: The GoI has identified areas like: countering terror financing, strengthening maritime security and promoting responsible governance of Artificial Intelligence (AI) as its key priorities for 2028-29 term.

Elections: The elections for UNSC non-permanent seat for the 2028-29 scheduled in June 2027. During these elections, India will compete against Tajikistan for the only seat in the Asia-Pacific group.

India's Representation at UNSC: So far, India has served 8-times as a non-permanent member at UNSC (i.e. 1950-51, 1967-68, 1972-73, 1977-78, 1984-85, 1991-92, 2011-12, and 2021-22).

About UNSC: It is one of the six principal organs of the UN, mainly responsible for maintaining international peace and security.

- It comprises 15 members of which 5 are permanent members with veto power: China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom (UK), and the United States of America (USA).
- And, the remaining 10 are non-permanent members who are elected annually by UNGA for a two-year term.
- In June 2026, the United Nations (UN) General Assembly (UNGA) elected 5 countries namely: **Austria, Kyrgyzstan, Portugal, Trinidad and Tobago, and Zimbabwe,** as UNSC non-permanent members for 2027-28 term.

MoFPI and NIFTEM, Thanjavur Launch Pilot 'Short-Term Skill Training Programme' at ITC-Trichy

In July 2026, the Ministry of Food Processing Industries **(MoFPI)** in collaboration with the National Institute of Food Technology Entrepreneurship and Management **(NIFTEM),** Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu (TN), launched a pilot 'Short-Term Skill Training Programme **(STSTP)'** on Assistant Baking Technician (NSQF Level 3) Certificate Programme at Imperial Tobacco Company of India- Integrated Consumer Goods Manufacturing and Logistics (**ITC–ICML**) facility at Trichy, TN.

- The programme was inaugurated by Prof. **V. Palanimuthu**, Director, NIFTEM, Thanjavur and **Surjeet Singh Roria**, General Manager (GM) & Head of ITC-ICML.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Pilot Short-Term Skill Training Programme launched
- ✓ **Where?** ITC-ICML, Trichy, TN
- ✓ **Organisations Involved:** MoFPI and NIFTEM, Thanjavur
- ✓ **Course:** Assistant Baking Technician (NSQF Level 3)
- ✓ **Objective:** Upskill youth in food processing, enhance employability, and promote entrepreneurship.

About Short-Term Skill Training Programme (STSTP):

Objective: The programme aims to upskill youth in food processing, manufacturing, and allied sectors, enhancing employability and promoting entrepreneurship in the food processing industry.

Certification: The programme will provide nationally recognised certifications for food processing skills, aligned with the NSQF.

Industry Training: The inaugural batch of 18 trainees will undergo practical on-site training under the Industry-Integrated Training (IIT) programme from 7 July to 20 August 2026, and all trainees are assured employment at ITC Limited.

Awarding Body: As a National Council for Vocational Education and Training (**NCVET**) recognised Deemed Awarding Body, NIFTEM-Thanjavur continues to deliver National Skills Qualifications Framework (NSQF)-aligned programs under MoFPI.

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India launches Rs 1,500cr Biomedical Research Career With Wellcome Trust support

In July 2026, Union Minister of State (MoS), Independent Charge (IC), **Dr. Jitendra Singh**, Ministry of Science & Technology (MoS&T) launched **Phase-III** of the Biomedical Research Career Programme (**BRCP**) with a total outlay of **Rs. 1,500 crore**, including **Rs. 1,000 crore** from the Department of Biotechnology (**DBT**), Government of India (**GoI**) and **Rs. 500 crore** from Wellcome Trust (**WT**), London, United Kingdom (UK).

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Phase III of Biomedical Research Career Programme.
- ✓ **Total outlay?** Rs 1,500 crore.
- ✓ **Launched by:** Union (MoS) (IC), Dr. Jitendra Singh, MoS&T
- ✓ **Collaborations:** Rs. 1,000 crore from the DBT and Rs. 500 crore from Wellcome Trust (UK)
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote biomedical research, strengthen infrastructure, and support translational studies

About Phase III of BRCP:

Implementation: The programme is jointly implemented by DBT in partnership with WT through the **DBT-WT India Alliance**, administered by a dedicated Special Purpose Vehicle (**SPV**).

Objective: The programme aims to nurture a globally competitive biomedical research workforce, including basic scientists, clinician-researchers, public health experts, science communicators, and research managers.

Innovation: Phase III aims to promote collaboration and **translational research**, accelerate scientific discovery, diagnostics, healthcare and build research ecosystems capable of addressing national as well as global health challenges

Significance: The programme promotes translational research to transform laboratory discoveries into clinical applications, diagnostics, and therapeutic innovations.

Leadership: India hosts nearly **12,000** biotechnology startups, ranks among the world's leading vaccine producers, and is strengthening its position as a global biotech hub.

- The bioeconomy expanded from **USD 10 billion** in 2014 to USD 195 billion in 2025, with projections of **USD 300 billion** by 2030.

About Biomedical Research Career Programme:

Phase I (2008–2009): Launched after Union Cabinet approval, the programme aims to raise Indian medical research to global standards through high-value biomedical fellowships.

Phase II (2018–2019): Expanded the funding portfolio to include specialized clinical and public health research pathways.

Contributions: Launched in 2008, the programme has supported over 500 researchers, strengthened biomedical research in more than 200 institutions, trained thousands of students and early-career scientists, and produced globally recognised scientific contributions.

Chief Executive Officer (**CEO**) – Dr. Apurva Sarin, DBT-WT India Alliance

About Department of Biotechnology (DBT):

Role: Acts as India's nodal agency for biotechnology, driving global competitiveness in life sciences, bioengineering, and medical research, while facilitating public-private partnerships and international collaborations.

Established – 1986

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

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Union Minister Pralhad Joshi Launches White Rabbit Technology-Based IST Distribution Demonstration Network

In July 2026, Union Minister **Pralhad Joshi**, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution **(MoCAF&PD)** and Ministry of New and Renewable Energy **(MNRE)**, inaugurated the **White Rabbit Technology**-based Indian Standard Time **(IST)** Distribution Demonstration Network at the Regional Reference Standards Laboratory (RRSL), Jakkur, Bengaluru, Karnataka.

- The initiative, launched under the vision of **"One Nation, One Time"**, aims to establish a uniform, highly precise, secure, and indigenous IST network, reducing India's dependence on foreign Global Positioning System (GPS)-based time sources and strengthening digital sovereignty.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of White Rabbit Technology-based IST Distribution Demonstration Network
- ✓ **Launched by:** Union Minister Pralhad Joshi, MoCAF&PD, MNRE
- ✓ **Initiative:** One Nation, One Time
- ✓ **Date:** 16 July 2026
- ✓ **Venue:** Regional Reference Standards Laboratory (RRSL), Jakkur, Bengaluru, Karnataka
- ✓ **Nodal Agency:** Legal Metrology Division, MoCAFPD

Key Highlights:

Critical Sector Applications: The indigenous time distribution system will benefit sectors requiring highly accurate time synchronisation, including banking, financial markets, telecommunications, power grids, defence, digital governance, stock exchanges and 5G/6G communication networks.

Technology Used: The network uses White Rabbit Technology, an Ethernet-based precision time synchronisation protocol capable of delivering sub-nanosecond accuracy over fibre-optic networks. It combines the Precision Time Protocol (PTP) with Synchronous Ethernet (SyncE) for highly accurate time transfer.

Implementation: The project is implemented by the Legal Metrology Division, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution (MoCAFPD), with National Physical Laboratory (NPL), Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL), and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), following Coordinated Universal Time (UTC) protocols.

NITI Aayog Launched a 10-year Roadmap Targets USD 691 bn Bioeconomy by 2035

In July 2026, the National Institution for Transforming India **(NITI Aayog)** launched the "Roadmap for Building India as a Leading Bioeconomy Powerhouse by 2035" at the National Media Centre, New Delhi, Delhi.

- The roadmap was formally launched by the **Union Minister of State (MoS)** (Independent Charge, IC) **Dr. Jitendra Singh,** Ministry of Science & Technology (MoST), in the presence of Prof. Gobardhan Das, Member, NITI Aayog; Nidhi Chhibber, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of NITI Aayog; among others.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of NITI Aayog's Roadmap for India's Bioeconomy
- ✓ **Formally Launched by:** Union MoS (IC) Dr. Jitendra Singh, MoST
- ✓ **Where?** National Media Centre (New Delhi, Delhi)
- ✓ **Developed by:** NITI-FTH
- ✓ **Key Targets:**
- ✓ **To scale India's bioeconomy:** To USD 691 billion (by 2035) and USD 2.6 trillion (by 2047);
- ✓ **Generate Jobs:** Over 30 million

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- ✓ **Global Presence:** To position India among world's top 3 biotechnology powers (by 2035)
- ✓ **Key Recommendation:** Six National BioMissions (GeneIndia, AgriBio 2.0, BioX Foundry, One Health Grid, Marine Biotechnology and BioPharmaNext)
- ✓ **BioEconomy Growth Fund:** Rs 50,000 crore (2026-2035)

Key Details of Roadmap:

Developed: The newly released roadmap was developed by NITI Frontier Tech Hub **(NITI-FTH)** in consultation with the Department of Biotechnology (DBT) which works under MoST; Association of Biotechnology Led Enterprises (ABLE), industry, academia and other stakeholders.

Key Target: To scale India's Bioeconomy to **USD 691 billion (by 2035)** and **USD 2.6 trillion (by 2047);** generate **over 30 million** high-value jobs; and position the country among the world's top 3 biotechnology powers.

Current Status of India's Bioeconomy: The roadmap highlighted India's bioeconomy has increased **16-times** over the last 10 years i.e. from USD 10 billion (in 2014) to **USD 195.3 billion (in 2025),** accounting **4.8%** of the country's Gross Domestic Product (GDP).

Six National BioMissions: In order to achieve its set goal by 2035, the roadmap recommends the creation of **six National BioMissions:** GeneIndia, AgriBio 2.0, BioX Foundry, One Health Grid, Marine Biotechnology and BioPharmaNext, covering advanced, therapeutics, climate-resilient agriculture, synthetic biology, pandemic preparedness, marine bio-technology and next-generation (NextGen).

- **GeneIndia:** It will be led by DBT, MoST in partnership with Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), to expand access to affordable gene and cell therapies as well as precision diagnostics.
- **AgriBio 2.0:** It will be led by DBT; Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) and Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare (MoA&FW), to develop climate-resilient crop varieties and quality-assured bio-inputs.
- **BioX Foundry:** It will be led by DBT and Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), to promote synthetic biology innovations from laboratory to the market.
- **One Health Grid:** It will be led by ICMR and the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW), to bolster Artificial Intelligence (AI)-assisted disease surveillance.
- **Marine Biotechnology:** It will be led by the Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES) in partnership with Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC), to promote seaweed cultivation and marine bio-products.
- **BioPharmaNext:** It will be led by DBT, Department of Pharmaceuticals (DOP) works under the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilisers (MoC&F) and Central Drug Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO), to establish India as a global hub for next-generation biologics, biosimilars, vaccines and AI-driven drug discovery.

Key Proposal: To create **Rs 50,000 crore** BioEconomy Growth Fund for 2026-2035 from within the existing Rs 1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) framework.

- The proposed fund would support scale-up, commercialization, biomanufacturing infrastructure, advanced therapeutics, fermentation platforms, biomaterials, diagnostics and synthetic biology.

Creation of New Institutions: It also proposes to create several new institutions like:

- **An Empowered Committee on National BioMissions** to set up a high-level, inter-ministerial committee to fast-track decisions, and oversee the implementation of national bioeconomy missions;
- **A National BioData Council** to oversee biological and health data governance;
- **A BioEconomy Investment and Policy Forum** to establish a dedicated platform to align government and private investment in biotechnology;

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- **A BioIP and Innovation Evaluation Agency** to help value biotechnology intellectual property and accelerate commercialisation.

About NITI Frontier Tech Hub (NITI-FTH):

In March 2025, NITI Aayog announced the establishment of NITI-FTH, designed as a frontier tech action tank to accelerate India's transition into a Frontier Tech Nation.

Chief Architect- Debjani Ghosh

Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi

EPFO Launches 'VISHWAS 2026' for Settlement of Penalty-Related Disputes

In July 2026, the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation **(EPFO)** under the Ministry of Labour & Employment (MoL&E), launched' **VISHWAS 2026**', a one-time **dispute resolution scheme** for amicable settlement of damages and penalty-related disputes under section 14B of the Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952 and Section 128 of the Code on Social Security, 2020.

- The scheme enables employers to settle eligible cases through a transparent, fully digital, and time-bound process, promoting voluntary compliance, reducing litigation, and ensuring speedy resolution of pending disputes.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** VISHWAS Scheme launched
- ✓ **Launched by:** EPFO
- ✓ **Purpose:** Amicable settlement of damages and penalty-related disputes
- ✓ **Applicable Laws:** Section 14B of EPF & MP Act, 1952 and Section 128 of Code on Social Security, 2020
- ✓ **Operational Period:** 6 months from (June 29, 2026)
- ✓ **Application Portal:** EPFO Employer Portal
- ✓ **Digital Filing:** Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) / e-Sign.

About VISHWAS Scheme:

Applicability: VISHWAS, 2026 was notified through G.S.R. 525(E) on **29 June 2026** under the EPF Scheme, 2026 and will remain operational for six months from the date of notification.

Coverage: The scheme covers cases where penalty/damages orders are under judicial challenge and final orders with pending or partial recovery, including Revenue Recovery Certificates **(RRC) cases.**

- It also covers cases where notices have been issued but final orders are pending and cases where penalty/damages notices are yet to be issued.

Implementation: EPFO has established **VISHWAS Cells** for smooth implementation. Cases involving fully recovered penalties, fraud, misappropriation, falsification of records, or unpaid statutory interest are excluded.

Penalty Rates: For defaults before **14 June 2024,** damages will be recalculated at reduced rates of 0.25% per month for defaults up to 2 months, 0.50% per month for defaults exceeding 2 months and less than 4 months, and 1% per month for defaults exceeding 4 months.

Digital Settlement: Applications can be submitted through the **EPFO Employer Portal** using Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) or electronic signature(e-Sign) for online verification and time-bound processing.

Conditions: Applicants must clear applicable statutory interest under Section 7Q of EPF & MP Act, 1952 or Section 127 of Code on Social Security, 2020 before applying. Cases involving fully recovered penalties, fraud, misappropriation, falsification of records, or unpaid interest are excluded.

About Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO):

Role: It is a statutory body in India under the Ministry of Labour & Employment (MoL&E). It manages mandatory retirement savings, pension, and insurance schemes for employees in the organised sector.

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Established: Established in 1952 under the Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions (EPF & MP) Act, 1952, EPFO is headquartered in New Delhi.
Central Provident Fund Commissioner **(CPFC) –** Ramesh Krishnamurthi

About Ministry of Labour & Employment (MoL&E):

Union Minister – Dr. Mansukh Mandaviya (Constituency – Porbandar, Gujarat)
Minister of State **(MoS) –** Shobha Karandlaje (Constituency- Bangalore North, Karnataka)

Union Minister Jyotiraditya M. Scindia launches "Mission Golden Spice" for Meghalaya's Lakadong Turmeric

In July 2026, Union Minister **Jyotiraditya M. Scindia**, Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (**MDoNER**) and Ministry of Communications (**MoC**) along with **Conrad K. Sangma**, Chief Minister (**CM**), Meghalaya launched the "**Mission Golden Spice** – Integrated Lakadong Turmeric Value Chain Enhancement Project" in New Delhi.

- The **Rs 175.45-crore** convergence-led initiative designed as a phased, five-year roadmap (2025–2030) aimed at transforming **Meghalaya's** Geographical Indication (GI)-tagged Lakadong turmeric into a globally competitive premium spice.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Mission Golden Spice
- ✓ **Who?** Union Minister Jyotiraditya M. Scindia, MDoNER along with Conrad K. Sangma, CM, Meghalaya
- ✓ **Official Title:** Integrated Lakadong Turmeric Value Chain Enhancement Project
- ✓ **Outlay:** Rs.175.45 crore
- ✓ **Duration:** Five-year roadmap (2025–2030)
- ✓ **Implementation:** Value Chain Strengthening (Phase 1) and Expansion & Scale-up (Phase 2)
- ✓ **Focus Crop:** GI-tagged Lakadong Turmeric
- ✓ **Objective:** Strengthen turmeric value chain (cultivation, processing, branding, export)

About Mission Golden Spice:

Roadmap: The Mission will be implemented as Value Chain Strengthening (Phase 1) and Expansion & Scale-up (Phase 2) for promotion of Meghalaya's Unique Selling Proposition (**USP**), GI-tagged Lakadong Turmeric.
Fund Allocation: The funding amount will be shared between the Meghalaya state government, Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare (**MoA&FW**) and **MDoNER** which is contributing **50%**.
Objective: The Mission aims to expand turmeric cultivation to **7,000 hectares**, supporting 17,500 farmers (99% women), and creating 3,000 additional employment opportunities.
Convergence Model: The Mission, anchored by **MDoNER** and the North Eastern Council (**NEC**) converges schemes and expertise from **MoA&FW**, Ministry of Food Processing Industries (**MoFPI**), **MoC**, Agricultural & Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (**APEDA**), Spices Board, National Turmeric Board, Indian Council of Agricultural Research (**ICAR**), Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (**MeitY**), National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (**NABARD**), Small Farmers Agribusiness Consortium (**SFAC**), and the Government of Meghalaya to build a holistic ecosystem for turmeric cultivation, processing, and marketing.
Infrastructure: The mission focus on establishing commercial-scale processing facilities, integrated cold chains, and curcumin extraction units to reduce post-harvest losses, boost quality, and enhance market competitiveness.

- It aims to double farmer income from Rs 30–40/kg (Kilogram) to ~Rs 80/kg by 2030

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Expansion: The mission will strengthen GI monetisation, quality standards, branding strategies, and international buyer linkages to access United States of America (**USA**), European Union (**EU**), Japan, and Gulf countries.

Strategy: Launched under Prime Minister (**PM**) **Narendra Modi**'s Northeast development vision, the mission forms part of the "**Ashtalakshmi**" strategy to promote unique products from all **8 Northeastern states** nationally and globally.

About Lakadong turmeric:

Overview: Lakadong turmeric, grown primarily in the West and East Jaintia Hills districts, is currently cultivated on about 2,600 hectares, yielding roughly 10,000 metric tonnes annually.

- Turmeric belongs to the genus **Curcuma** and is a rhizome crop used as a spice, dye, and medicinal plant.

GI tag: Lakadong Turmeric received the GI tag on **November 2023** under the GI of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, **1999**, highlighting its distinct quality tied to the soil and climate of Meghalaya's Jaintia Hills.

Note: Prime Minister Narendra Modi showcased Lakadong turmeric at the 52nd G7 Summit in Evian, France, which placed the crop in an international forum.

About Meghalaya:

Chief Minister (**CM**)- Conrad Kongkal Sangma
Governor– Chandrashekhar H. Vijayashankar
Capital – Shillong
Zoological Parks– Lady Hydari Park (Meghalaya Zoo), Nehru Park Cum Mini Zoo

Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw Launches Pilot Phase of 'Gems of India' Challenge

On 21 July 2026, Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, Ministry of Information & Broadcasting **(MIB)** launched the Pilot Phase of the **'Gems of India'** Challenge, a national initiative to identify, nurture and promote grassroots digital creators under the emerging **Orange Economy.**

- The challenge is hosted on **MyWAVES platform**, enabling creators to showcase their district's culture, heritage, tourism, traditions, history and unique achievements through digital storytelling.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Pilot Phase of 'Gems of India' Challenge launched
- ✓ **Who?** Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, MIB
- ✓ **Objective:** Identify, nurture and promote grassroots digital creators under the Orange Economy
- ✓ **Platform:** MyWAVES
- ✓ **Pilot Coverage:** A&N Islands, AR, Chandigarh, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Goa, and Ladakh
- ✓ **Awards:** District Level – Rs. 50,000; State Level – Rs. 2 lakh; National Level – Rs. 5 lakh

About 'Gems of India' Challenge:

Participation: The pilot phase will cover Andaman & Nicobar(A&N) Islands, Arunachal Pradesh (AR), Chandigarh, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Goa, and Ladakh, with creators submitting **1–3 minute original videos** through the **MyWAVES** section of WAVES OTT from 1 August to 31, 2026.

Partnership: The initiative involves Prasar Bharati (PB) My Bharat, State and District Administrations, with YouTube and Meta as ecosystem partners.

Awards: The challenge will provide **District-level (Rs. 50,000)**, **State-level (Rs. 2 lakh)**, and **National-level (Rs. 5 lakh) awards**, with entries evaluated by District and State Jury Committees comprising experts from culture, heritage, tourism, media and academia.

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Expansion: Based on the pilot phase outcomes, the challenge will expand across all States and Union Territories (UTs) to create a nationwide digital creator ecosystem.
About MyWAVES: It is a citizen creator platform under WAVES OTT for creating, uploading and sharing original content.

IAMAI Officially Launches E-Commerce Council of India in Bengaluru, Karnataka

In July 2026, the Internet and Mobile Association of India **(IAMAI)** formally launched the Electronic (E)-Commerce Council of India **(ECCI),** a nationwide platform, in Bengaluru, Karnataka, to strengthen India's digital commerce ecosystem through collaboration among industry, government, and other key stakeholders.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of the E-Commerce Council of India
- ✓ **Who?** Internet and Mobile Association of India
- ✓ **Purpose:** Promote digital commerce through policy advocacy, research, and ecosystem development
- ✓ **Members**: 70–80 member organisations onboarded
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** E-commerce, digital trade, logistics, MSME enablement, mobility, market access, and travel technology.

About E-Commerce Council of India (ECCI):

Members: The ECCI initiative has onboarded **70–80 members**, including major companies like Amazon, Flipkart, IndiaMART, ixigo, Uber, Rapido, Shiprocket, eBay, Urban Company, and Meesho.
Focus: ECCI will focus on digital commerce through electronic commerce (e-commerce) for products and services, digital trade, logistics & supply chain, mobility, Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) enablement, market access, and travel technology.
Collaboration: The ECCI brings together policymakers, marketplaces, brands, logistics providers, technology firms, MSMEs and academia to strengthen India's digital commerce ecosystem through policy advocacy, research, and collaboration.

- It will host the annual Indian E-Commerce Summit (**IECS**) to shape the sector's future.

About IAMAI: Established in 2004, the IAMAI is a not-for-profit industry association registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860, with its headquarters in Mumbai, Maharashtra. The current president of IAMAI is Dr. Subho Ray.

MoES Celebrates 20th Foundation Day in New Delhi; Launches New Weather and Ocean Science Initiatives

On July 27 2026, the Ministry of Earth Sciences **(MoES)** celebrated its **20th Foundation Day** at Prithvi Bhawan in New Delhi, Delhi, marking 20 years of contributions to weather forecasting, earth systems science, oceanography, seismology and polar research.

- The event was presided over by **Dr. N. Kalaiselvi,** Secretary, MoES and was attended by eminent scientists, including Padma Shri awardee Dr. A.E. Muthunayagam, the founding Secretary of the Department of Ocean Development (DOD) under MoES; and Padma Shri awardee Dr. Chandramouli Gaddamanugu, a veteran defence scientist associated with the Akash missile programme.
- The event witnessed the release of key scientific reports and the launch of new scientific initiatives, aimed to bolster early warning systems, disaster management, and weather-tracking capabilities across the country.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Celebration of 20th Foundation Day of MoES
- ✓ **Celebrated On:** 27 July 2026
- ✓ **Venue:** Prithvi Bhawan, New Delhi
- ✓ **Presided Over by:** Dr. N. Kalaiselvi, Secretary, MoES
- ✓ **IMD Initiatives:** 13 CoEs, IMD NOVA, WAADRU, Cyclone Warning Centre upgradation
- ✓ **NCMRWF Initiatives:** WINGS App, National Doppler Weather Radar Reflectivity Mosaic, Open Data Portal
- ✓ **NCS Initiatives:** Monthly Seismological Bulletins (2023–2024), Strong Motion Atlas of India (2010–2020)
- ✓ **CMLRE Initiatives:** Taxonomic manuals and SOPs for marine biological samples
- ✓ **NCCR Initiatives:** Sagar Prahari App and SAHAV 2.0
- ✓ **NIOT Initiatives:** Ballast Water Treatment Test Facility, 8 HDPE fish cages, Deep Ocean Mission outreach.

IMD-led Key Initiatives:

13 New CoEs: During the event, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) announced the establishment of **13** Centres of Excellence (CoEs) across the country.

- These new centres are dedicated to specialised areas such as: Desert Meteorology (Jaipur, Rajasthan); Mountain Meteorology (Dehradun, Uttarakhand); Thunderstorm Research (Patna, Bihar); and Agro-meteorological Research (Bengaluru, Karnataka).

Upgradation of Cyclone Warning System: In addition, IMD has also announced the upgradation of the Cyclone Warning Centre based in Thiruvananthapuram (Kerala) into an Area Cyclone Warning Centre, covering Kerala, Karnataka and Union Territory (UT) of Lakshadweep.

MoU to Set up WAADRU: Also, the IMD signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Indian Council of Agricultural Research-National Institute of Veterinary Epidemiology and Disease Informatics **(ICAR-NIVEDI)** to establish the **Weather Driven Animal Disease Risk Forecasting Unit** (WAADRU), which will forecast district-level livestock disease risks up to two months in advance.

Launch of Web Platform: Additionally, the department launched **IMD NOVA,** a web-based platform, designed to track, validate and archive thunderstorm nowcasts using lightning network and Automatic Weather Station (AWS) data.

NCMRWF-led Initiatives:

WINGS Mobile App: The National Centre for Medium Range Weather Forecasting (NCMRWF) launched the WINGS mobile application (app), a unified mobile platform offering numerical weather prediction, Artificial Intelligence (AI)/Machine Language (ML) predictions, and real-time mesoscale analysis.

Mission Mausam Initiative: The centre has also launched the National Doppler Weather Radar Reflectivity Mosaic, a near real-time visualisation system developed under 'Mission Mausam' to monitor severe weather systems.

Upgradation of Open Data Portal: In addition, the NCMRWF launched an upgraded Open Data Portal offering expanded weather and ocean datasets, including subseasonal-to-seasonal hindcasts, multi-source ensemble rainfall analysis, and 10 years of operational ocean analysis using Nucleus for European Modelling of the Ocean **(NEMOVAR).**

NCS-led Initiatives:

Monthly Seismological Bulletins: The National Centre for Seismology **(NCS)** released the Compendium of Monthly Seismological Bulletins for 2023 and 2024, providing validated earthquake catalogues and seismic data and hypocentral parameters from the National Seismological Network (NSN).

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Strong Motion Atlas of India: It has also published the Strong Motion Atlas of India (2010–2020), a compilation of strong ground-motion records for earthquakes of magnitude 4.0 and above to support earthquake engineering and hazard assessment.

CMLRE-led Initiatives:

Taxonomic Manuals: The Centre for Marine Living Resources and Ecology (CMLRE) released new taxonomic manuals which include a **pictorial identification guide** covering 100 species of Tintinnid ciliates from the eastern Arabian Sea and a publication on 225 seamount-associated species from the Lakshadweep Sea.

Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs): CMLRE also issued SOPs for the collection, preservation, and processing of marine biological samples using classical taxonomy, molecular systematics, and genomics.

NCCR-led Initiatives:

Sagar Prahari App: The National Centre for Coastal Research (NCCR) launched the Sagar Prahari App, an Artificial Intelligence (AI)-enabled mobile app, enabling citizens to geo-tag beach clean-up activities and automatically identify marine litter.

SAHAV 2.0: Also, the NCCR has also unveiled SAHAV 2.0, an advanced open-source, Geographic Information System (GIS)-based decision-support platform for Marine Spatial Planning (MSP) featuring geospatial analytics and ocean accounting modules.

NIOT-led Initiatives:

Infrastructure for Ballast Water Treatment: The National Institute of Ocean Technology (NIOT) inaugurated new infrastructure for its Ballast Water Treatment Test Facility at **Pamanji** in Andhra Pradesh (AP), featuring a marine pipeline trestle, boat landing facility, seawater intake system, and an Internet of Things (IoT)-enabled nearshore met-ocean observatory.

Deployment of Fish Cages at A&N Islands: In addition, the institute has deployed **8** circular HighDensity Polythene **(HDPE) floating fish cages** for open-sea mariculture of Asian seabass at Chidiyatappu in the Andaman and Nicobar (A&N) Islands.

Deep Sea Mining Outreach: It has also announced the launch of industry outreach initiatives, as part of its 'Deep Ocean Mission'. These initiatives are designed to explore 75,000 square kilometers (sq. kms) in the Central Indian Ocean Basin containing polymetallic nodules.

Ocean Olympiad India 2026: Also, the MoES launched Ocean Olympiad India 2026, a national-level multi-stage competition designed to promote ocean literacy among undergraduate students.

About Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES):

Predecessor: Initially, the Government of India (GoI) established the Department of Ocean Development **(DOD)** in July 1981 as part of the Cabinet secretariat under the charge of Prime Minister (PM) of India. Later, the GoI made DoD as a separate department in 1982.

Formation of MoES: In July 2006, the GoI reorganised the DoD into new Ministry i.e. MoES by bringing all agencies of meteorological (like IMD) and ocean developmental activities under its administration.

Union Minister of State **(MoS)** (Independent Charge, IC)**–** Dr. Jitendra Singh (Constituency- Udhampur, Jammu & Kashmir, J&K)

MoPR Launches Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme, SAMARTH Portal & Model OSR Rules to Strengthen PRIs

In July 2026, Union Minister **Rajiv Ranjan Singh**, Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR) and Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying (MoFAHD) launched the **Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme**, SAMARTH Panchayat Portal, and released the **Model** Own Source of Revenue **(OSR) Rules** at Krishi Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi.

- The initiative aims to strengthen the financial autonomy, digital governance and revenue generation capacity of Panchayati Raj Institutions **(PRIs)** in line with **Viksit Bharat @2047**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme, SAMARTH Panchayat Portal & Model OSR Rules.
- ✓ **By Whom?** Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, MoPR
- ✓ **Where?** Krishi Bhawan, New Delhi
- ✓ **Objective:** To Strengthen PRIs
- ✓ **Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme:**
- ✓ **Coverage:** 350 projects in 4 years (50 + 100 + 100 + 100).
- ✓ **Eligibility:** Gram Panchayats (OSR ≥ Rs.50 lakh); Block Panchayats (OSR ≥ Rs.1 crore).
- ✓ **Partners:** NABARD and HUDCO.
- ✓ **SAMARTH Portal:** First unified OSR management portal
- ✓ **Features:** Registration, e-payments, real-time monitoring.
- ✓ **Model OSR Rules:**
- ✓ **Framework:** Advisory framework for States/UTs on OSR.
- ✓ **Coverage:** Property tax, user charges, fees, and non-tax revenue.

About Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme:

Overview: The Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme is an initiative of the MoPR designed to enable Gram Panchayats and Block Panchayats to identify local assets and convert them into sustainable, revenue-generating projects, thereby strengthening their OSR and promoting financial self-reliance.

Objective: The programme aims to build financially empowered PRIs by promoting sustainable local revenue generation, reducing dependence on external grants and strengthening grassroots governance.

Support: The initiative receives technical support fromMoPR and financing through Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs), Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) contributions, convergence with government schemes, and bank finance.

- The National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) and the Housing and Urban Development Corporation (HUDCO) as institutional partners.

Coverage: The programme proposes the development of 350 projects over four years, including 50 projects in the first year and 100 projects annually during the subsequent three years.

Eligibility: Gram Panchayats with a minimum OSR of **Rs 50 lakh** and Block Panchayats with at least **Rs. 1 crore** in OSR and a minimum remaining tenure of **three years**, with relaxed eligibility norms for special category States.

About SAMARTH Panchayat Portal:

Overview: The SAMARTH Panchayat Portal is India's first unified digital platform developed by MoPR for end-to-end management of Panchayat OSR.

Objective: The portal seeks to improve transparency, efficiency and accountability in Panchayat revenue administration by digitising the complete revenue lifecycle from taxpayer registration to real-time monitoring.

Features: The portal enables digital taxpayer registration, demand generation, online payment, revenue collection and real-time monitoring, providing a configurable national platform for Panchayat financial management.

Implementation: The platform has been implemented in Chhattisgarh and Himachal Pradesh (HP), with onboarding underway in Maharashtra, Mizoram, Assam, Haryana, West Bengal (Wb)and Uttar Pradesh (UP).

About Model Own Source of Revenue (OSR) Rules

Overview: The Model OSR Rules provide an advisory framework for States and Union Territories (UTs) to strengthen the assessment, collection and management of Panchayat revenues, including property tax, user charges, fees and other non-tax revenues.

Objective: The Rules aim to establish transparent, uniform and efficient systems for Panchayat revenue mobilisation while enhancing the financial independence of PRI.

Framework: Prepared in accordance with the recommendations of the Sixteenth Finance Commission (XVI-FC), the Rules may be adopted or modified by States based on local legal and administrative requirements.

About OSR: It refers to the revenue generated by GPs through local taxes, fees, user charges, and rental income from community assets such as markets, buildings, and ponds.

Recognition at NAeG 2026:

Awards: At the 29th National Conference on e-Governance 2026 (NAeG) (Jaipur, Rajasthan, July 1–2, 2026), four Panchayati Raj initiatives received **3 Gold and 1 Silver** awards.

- Gold awards for the Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI), Kadepur Gram Panchayat (Sangli, Maharashtra), and e-Aarogya Dhamani (Zilla Parishad Nandurbar, Maharashtra), while Bijoy Nagar Gram Panchayat (West Tripura, Tripura) received the Silver award.

About the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR):

Union Minister– Rajiv Ranjan Singh (Lalan Singh) (Constituency – Munger, Bihar)
Minister of State **(MoS)** – S. P. Singh Baghel (Constituency – Agra, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

President Droupadi Murmu Launches Various Initiatives At Rashtrapati Bhavan To Mark Four Years of Her Presidency

In July 2026, **Droupadi Murmu,** President of India, launched various initiatives at **Rashtrapati Bhavan** and the **President's Estates** in New Delhi, Delhi to mark the completion of four years of her presidency.

- Murmu was sworn in as the 15th President on **July 25, 2022**, making her the country's first tribal head of state.
- Vice President **C.P. Radhakrishnan** released a set of **five** commemorative books highlighting President Droupadi Murmu's four-year journey and presented the first copies to the President at Rashtrapati Bhavan, New Delhi.

Exam Hint

- ✓ **What?** Launch of various initiatives
- ✓ **Occasion:** Completion of 4 years of President Droupadi Murmu's presidency
- ✓ **Launched By:** President Droupadi Murmu
- ✓ **Where?** Rashtrapati Bhavan, New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Initiatives Launched:**
- ✓ e-Audio Guide
- ✓ e-Upahaar (3rd Edition)
- ✓ Bachpan 'Bal Parisar'
- ✓ RAAHI (Rashtrapati Bhavan Access And Heritage Interconnector)
- ✓ Net Zero Energy Strategy service block
- ✓ Accommodation & Infrastructure Development
- ✓ **Book Released By:** Vice President C.P. Radhakrishnan
- ✓ **Books:** Rashtra Ka Bhavan, Seva Aur Samvedana, Samaveshi Sahbhaghita, Bharatiyata Ka Utsav, Ama Rashtrapati – Ama Gourav

Application-based Electronic (e-Audio) Guide:

Access: The platform is available in Hindi, English, and 14 other Indian regional languages, along with a dedicated sign language module for persons with disabilities (**Divyangjan**).

- The initiative has been launched to enhance the visitor experience at Rashtrapati Bhavan.

Third Edition of e-Upahaar:

- The initiative includes 300 curated Presidential gifts that will be made available for public auction from 5th August to 5th September 2026.
- Official portal upahaar.rashtrapatibhavan.gov.in

Previous editions: The inaugural edition of E-Upahaar in 2024, followed by the second edition in 2025.

Bachpan 'Bal Parisar':

- New facilities have been inaugurated for children residing in the President's Estate, including **Kilkari**, a dedicated children's play zone, and **Samarth Anganwadi-cum-Palna**, a safe and nurturing childcare facility.

RAAHI (Rashtrapati Bhavan Access And Heritage Interconnector):

Initiative: A fare-free 27-seater electric bus service with wheelchair accessibility has been introduced to promote green and inclusive mobility within the President's Estate, operated by women drivers and conductors.

Connectivity: The service ensures safe, accessible, and convenient transportation for women, children, senior citizens, and Divyang persons, while also providing connectivity to the nearby Metro station.

Highlights of President Droupadi Murmu's Presidency:

Heritage Promotion: To promote India's civilizational ethos, several initiatives were undertaken, including the unveiling of the bust of Chakravarti Rajagopalachari Ji, the inauguration of Param Vir Dirgha and Granth Kutir, and the Indianization of State Rooms.

Public Access: Amrit Udyan, Rashtrapati Niketan, and Rashtrapati Tapovan were opened for public access, enhancing citizens' engagement with India's presidential heritage and cultural spaces.

Commemorative Books:

Publications: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting **(MIB)** has published a series of books highlighting the journey and initiatives during the Presidency, including:

- **Rashtrapati Bhavan: Rashtra Ka Bhavan** – First year of Presidency
- **Seva Aur Samvedana** – Second year of Presidency
- **Samaveshi Sahbhagita** – Third year of Presidency
- **Bharatiyata Ka Utsav** – Fourth year of Presidency
- **Ama Rashtrapati – Ama Gourav** – A dedicated collection of articles published in Odia.

About the Office of President of India:

Overview: The President of India is the head of state, the first citizen of the country, and the supreme commander of the armed forces.

- **Article 52** states that there shall be a President of India.

Profile: Murmu became the second woman President of India after Pratibha Patil and the first President born after India's independence.

Official Residence: Rashtrapati Bhavan, New Delhi

MoPR Launches DAANVEER Initiative for Village Digital Infrastructure

In July 2026, the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (**MoPR**), launched a citizen participation initiative "**DAANVEER**" to strengthen digital infrastructure across gram panchayats (**GP**) through voluntary public participation, from New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints

✓ **What?** MoPR launched DAANVEER

- ✓ **Who launched?** SecretaryVivek Bharadwaj, MoPR
- ✓ **Purpose:** Computer access, Citizen participation in strengthening local institutions.
- ✓ **Collaboration:** Developed in collaboration with NIC and DigiHaat
- ✓ **Operates through:** Meri Panchayat Mobile app

Initiative Key Details

Launched by: The initiative was launched by Secretary **Vivek Bharadwaj,** MoPR in New Delhi, Delhi.
Key members: The launch was also attended by Mukta Shekhar, Joint Secretary (**JS**) MoPR; Palka Sahni, Joint Secretary MoPR; Vipul Ujwal, Director MoPR along with senior officials from the State Panchayati Raj Departments from Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra.
Objective: The programme is intended to:

- Address the immediate shortage of computers in village councils
- Establish a long-term framework for citizen participation in strengthening local institutions.

Purpose: The platform enables citizens and organisations to contribute computer systems directly to eligible village councils through the '**Meri Panchayat**' mobile application.
Development Partners: The platform has been developed in collaboration with the **National Informatics Centre (NIC)** and **DigiHaat**.
Grassroots Governance: India has nearly **2.5 lakh** GPs, which form the foundation of grassroots democracy and local service delivery.

About DAANVEER

Operations: The platform enables individuals and institutions to contribute standardised and quality-verified computer packages directly to eligible GP.

- It operates through the '**Meri Panchayat**' mobile application and follows the tagline "**Give Back to Your Village**".

Integration: The application is integrated with **DigiHaat** marketplace, enabling users to choose from pre-approved computer packages that comply with state-specific technical standards.

- The DAANVEER seeks to bridge digital infrastructure gaps and ensure that every GP is equipped to deliver citizen-centric services efficiently

About the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR):
Union Minister– Rajiv Ranjan Singh (Lalan Singh) (Constituency – Munger, Bihar)
Minister of State (MoS)– S. P. Singh Baghel (Constituency – Agra, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

MoEF&CC Inaugurates CoE on Human-Wildlife conflict in Coimbatore, TN

In July 2026, the Union Minister **Bhupender Yadav,** Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (**MoEF&CC)** inaugurated the Centre of Excellence (**CoE**) on Human-Wildlife conflict at Wildlife Institute of India-Sálim Ali Centre for Ornithology and Natural History (**WII-SACON**), Coimbatore, TamilNadu (TN).

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** MoEF&CC inaugurates CoE on Human-Wildlife conflict
- ✓ **Where?** WII-SACON, Coimbatore, TN
- ✓ **Purpose:** National Hub for research, innovation, capacity building, policy support
- ✓ **Suggestions:** Manage conflicts of tigers, leopards, elephants with humans
- ✓ **Portal:** National Human-Wildlife Conflict portal launched
- ✓ **Publication:** Current Status of Human–Wildlife Conflict in India: An Overview released
- ✓ **Workshop:** On Human-wildlife conflict organised

Event Highlights

Key member: Minister of State (**MoS**), **Kirti Vardhan Singh**, MoEF&CC, Secretary, **Tanmay Kumar**, MoEFCC, **Sushil Kumar Awasthi**, Director General of Forests and Special Secretary and few other senior officials also graced the ceremony.

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CoE Purpose: The CoE will serve as a national hub for research, innovation, policy support, capacity building and sharing best practices to strengthen scientific and evidence-based management of human-wildlife conflict.
Portal: During the inaugural session, the **National Human-Wildlife Conflict portal** was launched to facilitate data management, knowledge sharing and decision support for conflict mitigation.
Publication released: The first edition of a series of publications titled '**Current Status of Human–Wildlife Conflict in India: An Overview**' was also released.

- This provides a comprehensive assessment of the current status, trends and emerging challenges related to human–wildlife conflict in India.

Workshop Details

Workshop: After the inauguration, a **National Workshop** on Human-Wildlife conflict was organised, bringing together policymakers, forest officials, scientists, researchers, technology experts and conservation practitioners across India.
Purpose: The workshop served as a platform to exchange ideas and formulate effective strategies for addressing and mitigating human-wildlife conflict.

About Ministry of Environment, Forest, and Climate Change (MoEFCC):
Union Minister– Bhupendra Yadav (Constituency -Alwar, Rajasthan)
Minister of State (**MoS**)– Kirtivardhan Singh (Constituency- Gonda, Uttar Pradesh UP)

President Murmu Inaugurates 'Saushrutam 2026' at AIIA in New Delhi

In July 2026, the President of India **Droupadi Murmu** inaugurated '**Saushrutam 2026',** a three-day international seminar focused on Ayurvedic surgery, at the All India Institute of Ayurveda **(AIIA) in New Delhi** (Delhi) on the occasion of Sushruta Jayanti, celebrated in honour of Sushruta, known as the Father of Surgery.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Inauguration of Saushrutam 2026
- ✓ **Inaugurated by:** Droupadi Murmu, President of India
- ✓ **Where?** AIIA, New Delhi
- ✓ **Highlights:**
- ✓ **Launch:** AI-enabled 3 Tesla High-Field MRI at AIIA
- ✓ **Release:** NCISM study on the professional careers of women Ayurveda graduates.

About Saushrutam 2026:

Hosted by: The 3-day long seminar held from July 15 to 17, 2026, was hosted by AIIA, which brought together prominent surgeons, academicians and researchers from India and abroad to deliberate on advances in Ayurvedic surgery and integrative healthcare.
Participants: The seminar featured sessions on Shalya Tantra, Kshara Sutra, Agnikarma and integrative oncology and witnessed the participation of experts from 9 countries, including Thailand, Israel, Austria and the United Kingdom (UK).
Key Launches: During the event, President Murmu inaugurated an Artificial Intelligence (AI)-enabled 3 Tesla High Field Magnetic Resonance Imaging **(MRI)** at AIIA.

- She also released a National Commission for Indian System of Medicine **(NCISM) study** on the professional careers of women Ayurveda graduates.

Union Minister Amit Shah Inaugurates 'Shabdalok', India's First Immersive Language Museum in Kolkata, WB

In July 2026, Union Minister **Amit Shah**, Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and the Ministry of Cooperation,

inaugurated the first phase of **'Shabdalok** (The Museum of Word)', India's first immersive language museum, developed at a cost of **Rs 41 cror**e in the Belvedere House within the National Library campus, Kolkata, West Bengal (WB).

- The first phase features 2,282 square metres (sq. m.) of exhibition space on the first floor, with later phases adding ground-floor galleries, a Souvenir Shop, Café, and façade projection mapping.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Inauguration of India's first immersive language museum Shabdalok (Museum of Word)
- ✓ **Who?** Union Minister Amit Shah, MHA and Ministry of Cooperation
- ✓ **Where?** National Library campus, Kolkata, WB
- ✓ **Outlay:** Rs 41 crore
- ✓ **Developed by:** National Library
- ✓ **Purpose:** Preserve and showcase India's linguistic and literary heritage.

About Shabdalok:

Heritage: Developed by the **National Library** under the Ministry of Culture, the first phase of 'Shabdalok' showcases the diversity of Indian languages, scripts, and literary traditions.

Linguistics: The museum features nine galleries showcasing nearly 380 Indian languages, including 121 languages recorded in the Census 2011 and several historical languages that are no longer spoken.

Interaction: The museum combines immersive technologies like digital displays, holograms, motion sensors, audio-visual (**AV**) installations, augmented reality (**AR**) and virtual reality (**VR**), interactive exhibits, audio-visual presentations, and artefacts to present a comprehensive story of India's spoken and written heritage.

National Library: India's largest by collection volume, was established in 1953 under the Change of Name Act, 1948, evolving from the Imperial Library (1891) and Calcutta Public Library (1836).

Union Minister Rajnath Singh Virtually Inaugurates India's 1st Dedicated Department of Military Medicine in Lucknow, UP

In July 2026, **Union Minister Rajnath Singh,** Ministry of Defence (MoD), virtually inaugurated the Department of Military Medicine at the Command Hospital (Central Command) in **Lucknow**, Uttar Pradesh (UP).

- This newly launched facility, established under the Directorate General of Medical Services (DGMS) of Indian Army (IA), is **India's first** dedicated academic and operational department focused exclusively on military medicine.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Inauguration of India's 1st Dedicated Department of Military Medicine
- ✓ **Inaugurated by:** Union Minister Rajnath Singh, MoD
- ✓ **Where?** Command Hospital (Central Command) (Lucknow, UP)
- ✓ **Established under:** Directorate General of Medical Services (DGMS), IA
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen operational medical preparedness of the AFMS.

About Department of Military Medicine:

Aim: To strengthen operational medical preparedness of the Armed Forces Medical Services (AFMS) by enhancing combat medical readiness, promoting Research, development of indigenous doctrines, among others.

Phase-wise Development: The new facility will be developed in phases, with initial phase focusing on the development of academic programmes, followed by the establishment of Centres of Excellence (CoEs) for

Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR), and Chemical, Biological, Radiological, Nuclear and High-yield Explosives (CBRNE) defence.

Focus Areas: It will focus on military trauma, combat psychiatry, operational medicine, military medical logistics, CBRNE response, emergency medicine, disaster medicine, and HADR.

Programmes: The department will offer Postgraduate (PG) programmes in Military Studies, focusing on advanced education and research in defence and strategic affairs.

OTHER NATIONAL NEWS

MIB Announces Two Key Initiatives to Boost Indian Film Industry

In June 2026, the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting **(MIB)** announced two key initiatives: the Constitution of a **High-level Study Group** and **Model State Cinema Regulations,** aimed to strengthen India's film industry, enhance its global competitiveness, and drive the expansion of cinema infrastructure across the country.

- The decision regarding these initiatives was taken during a high-level review meeting chaired by **Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw,** MIB in New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announcement of Two Major Initiatives to Boost Indian Cinema
- ✓ **Announced by:** MIB
- ✓ **Decision Taken During:** High-level Meeting Chaired by Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, MIB
- ✓ **Initiatives:**
- ✓ Constitution of a high-level Study Group chaired by Prasoon Joshi
- ✓ Model State Cinema Regulations.

About High-Level Study Group:

Chairman: The MIB has appointed **Prasoon Joshi,** chairman of Prasar Bharti (PB), as the chairperson of the group. Other than chairperson, the panel will include industry experts and technology partners.

Key Functions: The group has been tasked to examine the opportunities and challenges facing Indian cinema, as well as recommend measures to make Indian films more competitive globally.

Terms of Reference (ToR): The group has also been tasked to explore the use of emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence (AI) and virtual production in filmmaking and study ways to enhance filmmakers' access to institutional finance and alternative funding sources.

Consultation with Stakeholders: The group will recommend a comprehensive policy framework for the long-term growth of the film industry in consultation with state governments and other stakeholders

Timeline: The newly formed group is required to submit its report to MIB **within 3 months.**

About Model State Cinema Regulations:

Regulations: These regulations are expected to facilitate the expansion of cinema halls and theatres, particularly in small towns and rural areas of the country. Following the approval from MIB, the model regulations have been circulated to all state governments for adoption.

Key Reason: As per the Constitution of India, regulation of cinemas comes under the jurisdiction of state governments which often result in delays and discouraging investment in cinema infrastructure.

Centre-Assistance: The Government of India (GoI) will provide assistance to states in implementation of these new model regulations.

About Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB):

Union Minister- Ashwini Vaishnaw (Rajya Sabha member- Odisha)

Minister of State **(MoS)-** Loganathan Murugan (Rajya Sabha member- Madhya Pradesh, MP)

GoI Identifies 25 TRs for Priority Reintroduction Calls for Science-led Recovery

In June 2026, the Government of India **(GoI)** identified **25** Tiger Reserves (TRs) across the country for priority recovery through targeted science-led interventions.

- The decision was taken based on the two reports i.e. on the roadmap for active tiger management and learnings from tiger reintroductions, released by **Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav,** Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC), during an event held in Alwar, Rajasthan, organised to mark 18 years of tiger reintroduction at Sariska Tiger Reserve (TR).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 25 Tiger Reserves identified for priority recovery
- ✓ **Identified by:** GoI
- ✓ **Based on:** Two reports on active tiger management & tiger reintroductions
- ✓ **Released by:** Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav, MoEFCC
- ✓ **Occasion:** 18 years of tiger reintroduction at Sariska TR in Alwar, Rajasthan
- ✓ **Key Challenges:** Low prey density, fragmented habitat connectivity and LWE disrupting protection in the Central-Eastern belt
- ✓ **Potential Recipients:** Kamlang and Namdapha (AR); Satkosia (Odisha); Kawal (in Telangana); among others
- ✓ **Source Reserves:** Jim Corbett (Uttarakhand), Bandipur (Karnataka), Kanha (MP) and Ranthambore (Rajasthan).

Key Details:

Key Concern: The report cautioned that despite India's tiger population growing at an annual rate of **6%,** about **25 of its 58 TRs**, which are low on tigers, have no tigers or low prey abundance, require priority interventions.

Potential Recipients: Some of the 25 TRs identified as **"potential recipient sites"** i.e. these reserves have ecological potential to hold tigers but population are currently absent, low or in decline, and these include: Guru Ghasidas-Tamor Pingla, Udanti-Sitanadi, Indravati and Achanakmar (Chhattisgarh); Palamau (Jharkhand);

- Kamlang and Namdapha (in Arunachal Pradesh, AR); Satkosia (Odisha);
- Kawal (in Telangana); Mukundra Hills and Ramgarh Vishdhari (in Rajasthan);
- Buxa (in West Bengal, WB); Dampa (in Mizoram); Ranipur (in Uttar Pradesh, UP);
- Kalakad-Mundanthurai (in Tamil Nadu, TN) and Nameri (in Assam).

Low-Density TRs: The roadmap has identified some **16 low-density TRs** which span across 11 different states in India.

Key Challenges: The roadmap highlighted **low prey density** as the most common challenge across these identified TRs.

- Also, TRs such as Ranipur, Achanakmar and Mukundra Hills suffer from fragmented wildlife corridors that reduce the natural dispersal from neighbouring tiger populations.
- Left Wing Extremism (LWE) in the Central-Eastern belt (Indravati, Palamau) has been disrupting protection efforts for years, which resulted in habitat degradation and encroachment.

13 Source Landscapes: Based on the findings of these newly released reports, identified **13 TRs,** including Jim Corbett (in Uttarakhand), Bandipur (Karnataka), Kanha (Madhya Pradesh, MP) and Ranthambore (Rajasthan), has been identified as healthy "source" landscapes with abundant prey and secure habitats that naturally supply dispersing tigers to surrounding forests.

- Jim Corbett alone houses around **260 tigers,** among the highest populations in any reserve in the country.

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- The roadmap emphasises on the protection of these source reserves as priorities through sustained anti-poaching efforts, secure dispersal corridors, among others.

Tiger Recovery Re-introduction: Since 2008, MoEFCC has undertaken science-led tiger recovery interventions across 12 TRs: Similipal (Odisha), Panna (MP), Satkosia (Odisha), among others.

- The reports highlighted the key success of the programme by citing the example of Sariska TR, which lost all its big cats to poaching in the mid-2000s and successfully repopulated to 56 tigers via science-led translocations.

About Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC):

Union Minister- Bhupendra Yadav (Constituency- Alwar, Rajasthan)
Minister of State (MoS)- Kirtivardhan Singh (Constituency- Gonda, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

Union Minister Rajnath Singh Released DFP-2026 to Empower DRDO and Accelerate Defence R&D Projects

In June 2026, Union Minister **Rajnath Singh**, Ministry of Defence (MoD) released the **Delegation of Financial Powers to** Defence Research and Development Organisation **(DRDO) (DFP-2026)**, a reform to enhance efficiency, accountability, and timely execution of strategic Research and Development (R&D) projects at New Delhi, Delhi.

- The event was attended by Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General **NS Raja Subramani**; Defence Secretary and DRDO Chairman **Rajesh Kumar Singh**, senior MoD officials, and DRDO representatives.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of DRDO DFP-2026
- ✓ **By Whom?** Union Minister Rajnath Singh, MoD
- ✓ **Purpose:** Improve efficiency, accountability, and timely execution of strategic defence R&D
- ✓ **Key Features:** Enhanced financial powers, streamlined R&D approvals, dedicated trial provisions, and separate innovation grants.

About Delegation of Financial Powers to DRDO (DFP-2026):

Objective: To strengthen self-reliance in defence technologies by accelerating the development, production, and induction of DRDO-developed systems, platforms, and technologies into the Indian Armed Forces, thereby enhancing national defence preparedness.

Features: Expanded functional and financial empowerment across DRDO; provisions for trial campaigns, testing, and evaluation; authorisation for pre-project R&D initiatives; segregated financial powers for Extra-Mural Research (EMR) projects, Defence Innovation Accelerator-Centres of Excellence (DIA-CoEs), and Technology Development Fund (TDF) initiatives.

Implementation: Operationalised at DRDO headquarters, New Delhi; coordinated with Indian Armed Forces, industry partners, and academic institutions to accelerate research-to-production pipeline.

Yamuna Water Project Agreement Signed to Resolve Haryana–Rajasthan Water Dispute

In June 2026, the Government of India **(GoI)**, along with the Governments of **Haryana** and **Rajasthan,** signed the signed a Memorandum of Agreement **(MoA)** to implement the **Yamuna Water Project** to resolve the long-pending inter-state water dispute, in New Delhi, Delhi.

- The agreement was signed under the chairmanship of Union Minister Amit Shah, Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), in the presence of Union Minister C.R. Patil, Ministry of Jal Shakti (MoJS), Bhajan Lal Sharma, Chief Ministers (CM) of Rajasthan and Haryana Nayab Singh Saini, CM of Haryana.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoA signed

- ✓ **Signed By:** Centre, Haryana & Rajasthan
- ✓ **Objective:** Implement Yamuna Water Project
- ✓ **Project Cost:** Rs. 34,102 crore
- ✓ **Water Source:** Hathnikund Barrage via the Western Yamuna Canal
- ✓ **Water Supply:** Around 580 MCM through three underground pipelines (July–October).

About Yamuna Water Project:

Objective: To implement the 1994 Upper Yamuna River Board (UYRB) Agreement and provide Rajasthan with its allocated share of Yamuna water.

Project: The **Rs. 34,102 crore project** will supply around 580 Million Cubic Metres (MCM) of Yamuna water from the Hathnikund Barrage through the Western Yamuna Canal to Rajasthan via three underground pipelines between July and October, benefiting both Rajasthan and Haryana.

Beneficiary Areas: The project will provide drinking water to Sikar, Churu, and Jhunjhunu districts in Rajasthan and benefit parts of Bhiwani and Fatehabad districts in Haryana.

Digital India Programme Marks 11 Years of Completion, Increases Focus on AI and Semiconductor Manufacturing

On July 1 2026, the **Digital India** programme, a flagship initiative of the Government of India (**GoI**) aimed at transforming India into a digitally empowered society and knowledge economy, completed **11 years.**

- The programme was launched by the Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi on **July 1, 2015** and has now expanded its focus to Artificial Intelligence **(AI)** and **semiconductor manufacturing.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Digital India completed 11 years
- ✓ **Implemented by:** MeitY
- ✓ **Next Focus Areas:** AI and semiconductor manufacturing

AI:

- ✓ **IndiaAI Mission:** Shared computer facility with 45,000 GPU
- ✓ **AI Kosh:** 12519 datasets, 307 AI models, 20 toolkits
- ✓ **CoE:** 18 CoE set up

Semiconductor Mission:

- **Projects Approved:** 12 projects, Investment – Rs 1.64 lakh Cr (1 fabrication unit, 2 compound fabrication unit, 9 package units)
- **Design Linked Incentive Scheme:** 24 projects, 105 companies received chip design tools, 23 chip design tapeouts
- **Electronics:** India is the world's 2nd largest mobile-phone manufacturer;
- Electronics is India's 3rd-largest export category.
- **UPI in FY26:** Recorded 24,162 crore transactions; accounted for 49% of global real-time digital transactions
- **Digital Infrastructure:** Broadband subscribers reached 106.58 crore;
- BharatNet connected 2.18 lakh Gram Panchayats; 5G covered 99.9% of districts.

About Digital India:

Ministry: The Digital India programme is implemented by Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (**MeitY**).

Key Vision: The three vision of the programme were:

- To provide every citizen with accessible, reliable, and secure digital infrastructure.
- To ensure seamless, integrated, and on-demand delivery of government services through digital platforms.

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- To promote digital literacy, universal access to digital resources, and citizen participation in governance.

Progress: Internet connections have grown around **four times** than earlier, and the cost of mobile data has fallen from Rs 269 per GigaByte (**GB**) to **Rs 8–10**, making digital access among the most affordable in the world.

Pillar 1: AI

IndiaAI Mission: The IndiaAI Mission aims to create a shared computer facility with over **45,000 GPU (**Graphics Processing Unit) to support AI research and deployment at a national scale.

- The mission was approved in 2024 with an outlay of Rs 10,372 Crore (Cr).

India AI Kosh: This is India's national **AI datasets** and resource platform openly accessible to researchers, startups and institutions across the country. It now hosts over 12,519 datasets, 307 AI models and 20 toolkits.

Solutions: Twenty AI solutions have been deployed across 12 sectors through challenges, hackathons and in-house development.

Beyond Cities: The AI Capability has expanded beyond metropolitan centres and have reached Tier II and Tier III cities by establishing **27 Data and AI Labs.**

YUVA AI Course: Under the YUVA AI Course, 684 Fellowships were awarded to students, and 8.4 million (Mn) learners were supported.

CoE: Eighteen Centres of Excellence (**CoE**) have been set up across the country, and **20** Indian AI startups have been supported for capacity building.

Summit 2026: The India AI Impact Summit 2026, which attracted nearly 15 lakh participants, was adopted by 92 countries and organisations.

- The event attracted AI-related investment commitments worth over USD 200 billion (Bn).

Pillar 2: Semiconductor

Projects Approved: Under the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) established in **2021:**

- 12 semiconductor manufacturing projects have been approved with an investment pipeline of approximately **Rs 1.64 lakh Cr.** This comprises of **one** semiconductor fabrication unit, **two** compound semiconductor fabrication units and nine packaging units.

Design led growth: Under the Design Linked Incentive (DLI) Scheme, 24 projects are being supported, 105 companies have received advanced chip-design tools, and 23 chip-design tapeouts have been completed at foundries.

Global Recognition: SEMICON India 2025 attracted 350+ companies from 48 countries and regions and signing 13 MoUs (Memorandum of Understanding) reflecting global confidence in India's semiconductor ecosystem.

Electronic Manufacturing:

Export Growth: The electronics sector has grown into **Rs 13 lakh Cr** industry, with electronics emerging as India's **third-largest export** category.

- Also, currently India is the world's **second largest** mobile phone manufacturer.

Decade of UPI

UPI Growth: In Financial Year 2025-26 (**FY26**), the Unified Payment Platform (UPI) recorded **24,162 Cr** transactions and accounts for

- Nearly **49%** of all global real-time digital transactions.
- Powers **81%** of India's digital payments.

Digital Growth:

Digital Infrastructure: As of March 2026, broadband subscribers have reached **106.58 Cr** and BharatNet has connected **2.18 lakh** Gram Panchayats (**GPs**) with high-speed broadband.

- India's 5G network now covers **99.9%** of districts, with **4.74 lakh** towers established.

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- To strengthen the data infrastructure at North East (**NE**), a National Data Centre (**NDC**) was established at **Guwahati**, Assam.

Innovation Ecosystem: FY 2025–26 recorded the highest-ever annual addition of **55,200+** DPIIT-recognised startups.

- These startups have created **23.36 lakh** direct employment opportunities, while **48%** have at least one-woman director or partner.
- Global Innovation Index ranking having improved from 81 in 2015 to **38** in 2025, and with **2,23,000** recognised startups driving innovation-led growth.

About Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY):

Union Minister– Ashwini Vaishnaw (Rajya Sabha – Odisha)
Minister of State (**MoS**)- Jitin Prasada (Constituency- Pilibhit, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

NBA Notifies Assam's 'Borjuli Site' as Biodiversity Heritage Site

In July 2026, the National Rainfed Area Authority **(NRAA)**, under the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (MoAFW), announced that the **Borjuli site** in Sonitpur district, **Assam**, has been notified as a Biodiversity Heritage Site **(BHS)** by the National Biodiversity Authority **(NBA)**.

- As of July 2026, Assam has three officially notified BHS: Majuli BHS, Borjuli Wild Rice BHS, and Hajong Tortoise Lake BHS.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Biodiversity Heritage Site for wild rice conservation notified
- ✓ **Site:** Borjuli site in Sonitpur district, Assam
- ✓ **By Whom?** National Biodiversity Authority
- ✓ **Announced by:** National Rainfed Area Authority
- ✓ **Legal Provision:** Section 37 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002
- ✓ **Project Implementation:** Funded by NRAA; implemented by ICAR-NBPGR & ASBB
- ✓ **Key Species:** Oryza rufipogon – wild progenitor of cultivated rice
- ✓ **Total BHS: Assam:** 3; India: 54(As of March 2026).

About Borjuli Wild Rice Biodiversity Heritage Site:

Background: The Borjuli site was declared a BHS by the Assam Government in 2022, and its notification by the NBA under Section 37 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, provides statutory recognition for long-term conservation.

Project: The Borjuli site identified under the National Rainfed Area Authority (NRAA)-funded *"In-situ Conservation and Management of Wild Rice (Oryza rufipogon) in Sonitpur District of Assam"* project, which has been implemented since 2022.

Implementation: The project is funded by NRAA and implemented by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research–National Bureau of Plant Genetic Resources (ICAR-NBPGR), in collaboration with the Assam State Biodiversity Board (ASBB).

Objective: The project aims to conserve the natural populations and genetic diversity of *Oryza rufipogon* through in-situ conservation, habitat protection, germplasm exploration, and genetic characterization to support future rice breeding and develop climate-resilient, high-yielding, and nutritionally superior rice varieties for sustainable agriculture and food security.

Significance: The notification strengthens the conservation of India's wild rice genetic resources and supports the development of climate-resilient, high-yielding, and nutritionally superior rice varieties.

Oryza rufipogon:

Characteristics: It is a perennial, photosensitive wild rice species found in marshes and aquatic habitats across eastern and southern Asia that flowers during short-day conditions (November–December), produces shattering seeds, and is tolerant of flooding, saline, and acidic conditions.

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Significance: It is the wild progenitor of cultivated rice (*Oryza sativa*) and an invaluable genetic resource for pest and disease resistance, crop improvement, climate adaptation, biodiversity conservation, and the development of climate-resilient rice varieties.

About Biodiversity Heritage Site (BHS):

Definition: BHS are well-defined terrestrial, coastal, inland water, or marine ecosystems that are unique and ecologically fragile, possessing rich biodiversity and significant ecological, evolutionary, cultural, ethical, or aesthetic value.

Criteria: Areas may qualify as BHS based on rich wild or domesticated biodiversity, high endemism, rare and threatened species, keystone species, species of evolutionary significance, wild ancestors of cultivated species, fossil beds, or their role in maintaining cultural diversity.

Provision: Under Section 37 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, the State Government may declare a BHS within its jurisdiction after consulting local bodies and considering suggestions from Biodiversity Management Committees and other competent authorities.

Status: The **Nallur Tamarind Grove** in Bengaluru, Karnataka, became India's first BHS in 2007 and as per NBA, the country has **54** BHS as of July 2026.

About National Rainfed Area Authority (NRAA):

Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** – Dr. Chandra Shekhar Kumar

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

Established – 2006

MoCA Approves First-Ever Satellite-Guided Landing Procedure for Helicopter Operations

In July 2026, the Ministry of Civil Aviation **(MoCA)** approved India's first Private Point-in-Space **(PinS) Instrument Approach Procedure** for helicopter operations at **Undavalli Heliport,** Amaravati, Andhra Pradesh (AP), in alignment with Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) regulations and International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) Standards and Recommended Practices (SARPs).

- The procedure was developed by the Airports Authority of India **(AAI)** and approved by the **DGCA**, marking a key advancement in satellite-based and precision helicopter navigation in India.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approves first-ever Satellite-Guided Landing Procedure for Helicopter operations
- ✓ **Approved By:** MoCA
- ✓ **Where?** Undavalli Heliport, Amaravati, AP
- ✓ **Developed by?** AAI, approved by DGCA
- ✓ **Purpose:** Improve safety and precision in helicopter landings
- ✓ **Technology Used:**
- ✓ GNSS-based Performance-Based Navigation (PBN)
- ✓ India's GAGAN satellite augmentation system.

About PinS Instrument Approach Procedure:

Framework: PinS procedure is based on Satellite-Guided Performance-Based Navigation (PBN) using the Global Navigation Satellite System (GNSS) along with India's GAGAN (GPS (Global Positioning System) Aided
GEO (Geostationary Earth Orbit) Augmented Navigation) system.

- It enables helicopters to execute safe and accurate approaches to heliports without dependence on ground-based radar or Instrument Landing System (ILS) infrastructure.

Capability: The system supports Instrument Flight Rules (**IFR**) operations in hilly and remote areas and during low-visibility adverse weather conditions, without requiring ground-based navigation support.

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Applications: The system benefits emergency medical services, disaster relief, tourism, offshore operations, pilgrimage services, corporate aviation and regional connectivity.
Leadership: It will strengthen India's position as a leader in modern aviation infrastructure, satellite-based navigation and global best practices.

About GAGAN:

Overview: India's indigenous Satellite-Based Augmentation System (SBAS), jointly developed by Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and AAI, enhances GPS accuracy by providing integrity and correction data for safer and more reliable aircraft navigation.
Global Standing: GAGAN has been fully operational since **2015**, placing India among a select group of nations, including the United States of America (USA), Europe, and Japan, with an active SBAS capability.
Architecture: GAGAN functions through an integrated network of ground monitoring stations, communication links, and geostationary satellites.

- These components continuously track GPS signals, compute real-time corrections, and transmit enhanced navigation data to aircraft for improved accuracy and safety.

About International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO):

Secretary-General – Juan Carlos Salazar Gomez
Headquarters – Montreal, Canada
Established – 1944

IIT Delhi–DRDO Develop Indigenous Tactical Aerostat for Surveillance up to 20 km

In July 2026, the Indian Institute of Technology **(IIT)** Delhi, New Delhi (Delhi), with the Defence Research and Development Organisation **(DRDO)** and a domestic startup, developed India**'s first indigenous tactical aerostat**, a low-cost high-altitude platform capable of carrying surveillance and communication payloads with an operational coverage of up to **20 kilometres** (km).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India's first indigenous tactical aerostat developed
- ✓ **Who?** IIT Delhi, DRDO, Domestic Startup
- ✓ **Coverage:** Up to 20 km
- ✓ **Features:** Cameras, IR sensors, communication systems
- ✓ **Advantage:** High endurance and persistent surveillance vs drones.

About Indigenous Tactical Aerostat:

Features: The indigenous tactical aerostat is a **balloon-based** high-altitude platform equipped to carry Electro-optical (EO) cameras, Infrared (IR) sensors, and Communication relay systems for extended aerial operations.
Operational Advantages: It offers higher endurance, payload capacity, persistent surveillance, and communication support compared to drones.
Applications: The system is intended for defence surveillance, with future potential in border security, disaster response, emergency communication, and civilian connectivity.
Significance: It strengthens India's indigenous defence ecosystem by reducing import dependence and promoting academia–**DRDO–startup** collaboration.
DRDO: The DRDO is India's premier military research agency established in 1958, its headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi.

COAS General Dhiraj Seth Unveils 'VIJAY' Transformation Roadmap for a Future-Ready Force

In July 2026, **General Dhiraj Seth** assumed charge as the **31st** Chief of the Army Staff **(COAS)** of the Indian Army (IA) and unveiled the '**VIJAY** (Vigilance, Innovation, Jointness and Integration, Aatmanirbharta and Yodha first)' roadmap, aimed at building a technology-driven, future-ready force.

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Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of 'VIJAY' transformation roadmap
- ✓ **Who?** General Dhiraj Seth, Chief of the Army Staff (COAS), IA
- ✓ **New Initiative:** 'VIJAY' Roadmap (Vigilance, Innovation, Jointness & Integration, Aatmanirbharta, Yodha-first)
- ✓ **Purpose:** To build a technology-driven, future-ready and multi-domain capable force
- ✓ **Alignment:** MoD's Decade of Transformation (2023–2032).

About VIJAY Framework:

Roadmap: Aligned with the Ministry of Defence's (MoD) **'Decade of Transformation (2023–2032)'**, it aims to build a digitized, technology-enabled, self-reliant (Aatmanirbhar), and multi-domain-capable force.
Formulation: Developed under the direction of the Chief of the Army Staff (COAS) and implemented across all operational commands.

Framework:

- **V** – Vigilance along borders and against emerging threats.
- **I** – Innovation and Transformation, which will focus on innovation in both doctrine and technological solutions for modern algorithmic warfare.
- **J** – Jointness and Integration, which prioritizes seamless operational synergy and synchronization with the **IA,** Indian Air Force (**IAF**) and the Indian Navy (**IN**) alongside military-civil fusion through a **Whole-of-Nation** approach to achieve the vision of **Viksit Bharat 2047**.
- **A** – Atmanirbharta emphasizes the need to build a **self-reliant Army** through indigenous capabilities and technologies developed within the country.
- **Y** – Yodha, focusing on human capital development through enhanced training standards, technological skilling, and welfare frameworks for Agniveers, veterans and Veer Naris.

About Indian Army (IA):

Chief of the Army Staff **(COAS)** – General Dhiraj Seth
Headquarters– New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 1895
Motto– Seva Paramo Dharma (Service Before Self)

DAC clears Rs 52,000 crore Modernisation Plan to strengthen Army, Navy and Air Force

In July 2026, **Defence Acquisition Council** (DAC), chaired by Union Minister **Rajnath Singh**, Ministry of Defence (MoD), granted **Acceptance of Necessity** (AoN) worth approximately **Rs 52,000 crore** for various acquisition proposals of the Indian **Army** (IA), Indian **Navy** (IN) and Indian **Air Force** (IAF).

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **Approved By:** Defence Acquisition Council (DAC)
- ✓ **Chairman:** Union Minister Rajnath Singh, MoD
- ✓ **Amount:** Rs 52,000 crore
- ✓ **Beneficiaries:** Indian Army, Indian Navy, Indian Air Force
- ✓ **Significance:** Strengthen operational capability, modernise platforms, and boost self-reliance

Indian Army Procurements:

AKASH TARANG System: An advanced Anti-Unmanned Aerial Vehicle **(Anti-UAV)** Electronic Warfare System custom-designed to detect, jam, and neutralize hostile drone formations targeting frontline military assets.
Man-Portable anti-tank guided missile (MPATGM) Systems: Procurement of man-portable **anti-tank guided missile** (ATGM) systems to significantly enhance infantry capability against enemy's armoured and mechanized units.

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Medium Range Surface-to-Air Missile (MRSAM): MRSAM weapon network provides medium-range air defence against diverse stand-off aerial threats.
Very Short Range Air Defence Systems (V-SHORADS): The V-SHORADS utilizes multi-spectral sensing technology to improve resilience against countermeasures while enhancing the Army's short-range air defence capability.
Active Protection System for Tanks: Designed to detect and automatically neutralize incoming anti-tank guided missiles, significantly enhancing the survivability of main battle tanks (**MBTs**).
Jet-Based Kamikaze Drones: High-speed loitering munitions with advanced electronic warfare capabilities to conduct lethal, cost-effective precision strikes deep inside hostile territory.

Indian Navy Procurements:

Multi Influence Ground Mines (MIGM): Designed to establish a dense **sea-denial** boundary, restricting adversary submarine and surface ship movements.
Naval Shipborne Unmanned Aerial Systems (NSUAS): High-tech, sensor-heavy drone fleets deployed directly from active warships to increase real-time reconnaissance and maritime situational awareness.
Land-Based Testing Facility (LBTF): A specialized ground testing lab for validating high-capacity electric propulsion systems and heavy motors for IN assets.

Indian Air Force Procurements:

Fixed-Wing High-Altitude Pseudo Satellites (FW-HAPS): The FW-HAPS will carry out persistent Intelligence, Surveillance & Reconnaissance (**SAR**), telecommunication and remote sensing for the IAF.

About Defence Acquisition Council (DAC)

Role: The apex decision-making authority for the armed forces, overseeing procurement, acquisition and modernisation of defence equipment.

- It approves capital acquisition proposals, ensuring budget utilisation, and promoting indigenisation.

Founded: 2001. (Post-Kargil War administrative reforms)
Ex-officio Chairman: Union Minister Rajnath Singh, MoD

GoI Approves expansion of PM-SETU Across 200 ITI Clusters Worth Rs 1,237.58 Crore

In July 2026, the Government of India (**GoI**) approved the nationwide expansion of **PM-SETU** (Pradhan Mantri Skilling and Employability Transformation through Upgraded ITIs (Industrial Training Institute)) across all **200** identified ITI clusters.

- The Centre has approved strategic investment plans worth **Rs 1,237.58 Cr** under the programme.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** GoI approved expansion of PM-SETU
- ✓ **Plan Cost:** Rs 1,237.58 Cr
- ✓ **Committee:** 4th NSC – under the chairpersonship **Debashree Mukherjee** approved the expansion
- ✓ **ITI Clusters:** Odisha, Gujarat, Telangana

State Wise Clusters

- ✓ **Odisha:** Hub institute – ITI Barbil,
- ✓ Anchor Industry Partner – Jindal Naveen Avasar Limited
- ✓ **Gujarat:** Hub Institute – ITI Surat,
- ✓ Anchor Industry Partner – ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel India
- ✓ **Telangana:** 3 clusters – Rs 757.17 Cr
- ✓ **Cluster_1:** Hub Institute – ITI Old City
- ✓ Anchor Industry Partner – Apollo MedSkills Limited

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- ✓ **Cluster_2:** Hub Institute – ITI Patancheru
- ✓ Anchor Industry Partner – Sri Siddharth Infratech & Services
- ✓ **Cluster_3:** Hub Institute – ITI Sangareddy
- ✓ Anchor Industry Partner – M/s Neuland Foundation

Expansion of ITI Clusters

Committee: The 4th National Steering Committee (**NSC**), held under the chairpersonship of **Debashree Mukherjee**, Secretary, Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (**MSDE**) approved the below expansion.

- The expansion is transition of PM-SETU from its pilot phase to a nationwide rollout across all 200 identified ITI clusters, enabling States and Union Territories to take up implementation based on industry readiness and implementation capacity.

Members: The meeting was also attended by Dilip Kumar, DG-DGT (Director General – Directorate General of Training), and Manasi Sahay Thakur, JS (Joint Secretary), along with senior representatives from state governments.

ITI Clusters: The committee approved five ITI clusters across **Odisha, Gujarat**, and **Telangana**, with private sector firms selected as anchor industry partners to implement the projects.

State-wise ITI Clusters

Odisha: Government ITI Barbil has been identified as the hub institute, while Government ITIs at Anandapur, Koira, Karanjia and Barkote have been included as spoke institutes.

- An investment of **Rs 240.21 crore (Cr)** has been approved for the cluster.
- **Jindal Naveen Avasar Limited** has been chosen as the Anchor Industry Partner for the project.

Gujarat: The Government ITI Surat has been selected as the hub institute. Government ITIs at Hajira, Bardoli, Sachin and Surat (Mahila) have been included in the same cluster.

- A total investment of **Rs 240.18 Cr** has been approved, and **ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel India** has been designated as the Anchor Industry Partner.

Telangana: Three separate ITI clusters have been approved in Telangana.

- The total proposed investment for Telangana is **Rs 757.19 Cr.**

Cluster_1: The first cluster has **Government ITI Old City** as the hub institute, with Government ITIs at Warangal, Nalgonda Boys, Vikarabad Girls and Panjaguda included as spoke institutes.

- An investment of **Rs 241.01 Cr** has been sanctioned for this cluster and **Apollo MedSkills Limited** has been selected as the Anchor Industry Partner.

Cluster_2: Government ITI **Patancheru** has been designated as the hub institute for the second Telangana ITI cluster, with Government ITIs at Shadnagar, Marpally, Nalgonda (New), and Bhongir serving as spoke institutes.

- The cluster has been approved with an investment of **Rs 275.24 Cr**, and **Sri Siddharth Infratech & Services** (India) Private Limited has been selected as the Anchor Industry Partner.

Cluster_3: And last ITI Cluster as Government ITI Sangareddy (Hub) with Government ITI Hathnoora, Government ITI Medak, Government ITI Dubbaka and Government ITI Yellareddy as spokes.

- The **M/s Neuland Foundation** has been selected as the Anchor Industry Partner with a proposed investment of **Rs 240.94 Cr**.

About PM-SETU

Objective: The PM-SETU is an initiative of the GoI aimed at strengthening the country's vocational education and skill development ecosystem.

- The scheme focuses on modernizing ITIs and aligning them with evolving needs of industries.
- It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (**CSS**) approved in 2024-25.

Apex Body: The Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (**MoSD&E**) constituted a National Steering Committee (**NSC**) as the apex body to guide the PM-SETU Scheme.

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Financial Outlay: The scheme has a total outlay of **Rs 60,000 Cr** over **five years**, comprising:

- Rs 30,000 Cr from the Central Government,
- Rs 20,000 Cr from State Governments, and
- Rs 10,000 Cr from industry partners.

Co-Financing: The scheme has co-financing to the extent of 50% of Central share by the **Asian Development Bank (ADB)** and the **World Bank (WB)**, equally.

Components: The scheme comprises of 2 components:

- **Component I:** Upgradation of **1,000** Government ITIs (200 Hub ITIs and 800 Spoke ITIs) in a Hub and Spoke model wherein upgradation includes smart classrooms, modern labs, digital content, and new courses aligned to industry needs.
- **Component II:** Capacity Augmentation of **five NSTIs** (National Skill Training Institutes) located in Bhubaneswar (Odisha), Chennai (TamilNadu), Hyderabad (Telangana), Kanpur (Uttar Pradesh), and Ludhiana (Punjab), including setting-up sector-specific National Centres of Excellence for skilling, with focus on advanced training of trainers with global partnership.

About Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE):

Minister of State (**MoS**) (Independent Charge, IC) – Jayant Chaudhary (Rajya Sabha – Uttar Pradesh, UP)

MoEFCC Notifies Mizoram's Natural History Museum as India's 21st Designated Repository

In July 2026, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (**MoEFCC**), Government of India (**GoI**) notified the Natural History Museum (**NHM**), Mizoram University, Aizawl,Mizoram as India's **21st Designated Repository** (DR) under Section 39 of the **Biological Diversity Act, 2002**, following the recommendation of National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) and after due examination of the proposal.

- This recognition enables the museum to serve as a custodian of biological specimens and genetic resources, enhancing India's biodiversity documentation and research infrastructure.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Notified as India's 21st Designated Repository
- ✓ **Institution:** Natural History Museum, Mizoram
- ✓ **Authority:** MoEFCC
- ✓ **Legal Provision: S**ection 39 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002
- ✓ **Recommendation by:** NBA
- ✓ **Role:** Custody, documentation and preservation of biological specimens and genetic resources.

About Mizoram's Natural History Museum:

Establishment: NHM was established in **2022** under Mizoram University Act (No. 8 of 2000) and is strategically located in the Indo-Burma Biodiversity Hotspot and recognised for its specialised taxonomic expertise.

Collections and Expertise: NHM has preserved over 500 specimens, including herbarium sheets and wet collections.

- It specialises in pteridophytes, macrofungi, fishes, moths, beetles and butterflies through a multidisciplinary team covering seven taxonomic groups.

Repository Functions: As a DR, NHM will maintain voucher and type specimens of regional flora and fauna, supporting species identification, traceability, biodiversity research and long-term conservation.

Conservation and Collaboration: The repository will document endemic species and collaborate with the Mizoram State Biodiversity Board, regional institutions, the Botanical Survey of India (BSI) and the Zoological Survey of India (ZSI).

- It supports Target 4 of India's National Biodiversity Strategy and Action Plan (NBSAP) 2024–2030 on ex situ conservation and genetic diversity, in line with the Kunming–Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework.

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About Designated Repository (DR):

Overview: A Designated Biodiversity Repository is a legally notified institution responsible for the protection, documentation, and preservation of India's biological resources, ensuring regulatory compliance and protection against bio-piracy.

Structure: It has a three-tier governance

- **National Level:** National Biodiversity Authority (NBA)
- **State Level:** State Biodiversity Boards (SBBs)
- **Local Level:** Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs)

About National Biodiversity Authority (NBA)

Chairperson- Virendra R. Tiwari

Headquarters- Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN)

Established- 2003

CSIR-IICT Develops India's First Indigenous Green Refrigerant Technology for HFO-1234yf

In July 2026, the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-Indian Institute of Chemical Technology **(CSIR-IICT**), Hyderabad, Telangana, developed **India's first** indigenous process technology for Hydrofluoroolefin-1234yf **(HFO-1234yf).**

- The technology is ready for industry transfer and will **replace** Hydrofluorocarbons **(HFCs)** in refrigeration and Air-Conditioning (AC) systems, supporting Atmanirbhar Bharat.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** CSIR-IICT Develops India's First Indigenous Green Refrigerant Technology
- ✓ **Technology:** Indigenous HFO-1234yf manufacturing process
- ✓ **Replaces:** Hydrofluorocarbons (HFCs)
- ✓ **Benefits:** Zero ODP, Low GWP, 11-day atmospheric lifetime
- ✓ **Other Development:** CSIR-CIMFR Develops Smart Algal Liquid Tree
- ✓ **Technology:** Photobioreactor using microalgae
- ✓ **Key Function:** Absorbs CO_2 and releases oxygen.

Highlights of the Development:

Technology: The indigenous process uses readily available raw materials, enabling domestic manufacturers to produce HFO-1234yf for commercial applications.

Environmental Benefits: HFO-1234yf has zero Ozone Depletion Potential (ODP), low Global Warming Potential (GWP) and an atmospheric lifetime of about 11 days, compared to 13.8 years for conventional HFC-134a.

Climate Commitment: The technology supports India's commitments under the Kigali Amendment to the Montreal Protocol for the phasedown of Hydrofluorocarbons (HFCs).

HFC Phase-down: India will reduce HFCs consumption by 10% (2032), 20% (2037), 30% (2042) and **85% (2047),** preventing emissions of up to 105 million tonnes (MT) of carbon dioxide equivalent (CO2e).

About CSIR-IICT: It is a Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) laboratory located in Hyderabad, Telangana, headed by Director D. Srinivasa Reddy.

CSIR-CIMFR Develops Mobile 'Liquid Tree' Air Purification System

In July 2026, the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-Central Institute of Mining and Fuel Research **(CSIR-CIMFR**), Dhanbad, Jharkhand, developed Smart Algal Liquid Tree **(SALT)**, a mobile 'Liquid Tree' that uses microalgae to **purify air** in densely populated urban areas.

Location: The patented technology has been installed at CSIR-CIMFR, Dhanbad, Jharkhand, and Northern Coalfields Limited (NCL), Singrauli, Madhya Pradesh (MP).

Technology: The Liquid Tree is a photobioreactor that uses microalgae to absorb CO_2, release oxygen(O), and reduce dust.

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Features: It operates **24×7** on solar power or electricity, monitors air quality in real time, and provides seating for 4–8 people.
Significance: Designed for space-constrained urban and industrial areas, it is a low-maintenance alternative to conventional trees, with commercial production under consideration.

About Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR):

The CSIR is India's premier public research and development organization. It spearheads scientific, industrial, and economic growth across diverse sectors ranging from aerospace and biotechnology to mining and materials.
Director General **(DG)** – Dr. N. Kalaiselvi
Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 1942

Adani Defence Invests Rs 2,500 Crore to Create Missile Manufacturing Complex in MP

In July 2026, **Adani Defence and Aerospace**, part of the Adani Group, invested **Rs 2,500 crore** to create South Asia's largest private-sector **missile ecosystem** by establishing a state-of-the-art facility in **Shivpuri**, Madhya Pradesh (MP).

- The foundation stone was laid by **Mohan Yadav**, Chief Minister (CM), MP and Union Minister **Jyotiraditya Scindia**, Ministry of Communications (**MoC**).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Adani Defence invests Rs 2,500 crore in a missile manufacturing complex
- ✓ **Where?** Shivpuri, MP
- ✓ **Project:** South Asia's largest private-sector missile ecosystem
- ✓ **Foundation Stone Laid By:** Mohan Yadav, CM of MP, and Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, Ministry of Communications
- ✓ **Key Feature:** India's first private-sector complex integrating composite propellant production, TNT manufacturing, and missile system integration at one location.

About Shivpuri facility:

Aim: The facility aims to develop an end-to-end missile ecosystem to enable indigenous production of medium- to long-range missile systems.
Integration: The proposed Shivpuri facility will be **India's first** private-sector complex to integrate composite propellant production, Trinitrotoluene (TNT) manufacturing, and missile system integration at a single location.
Production: It will manufacture ammunition, advanced weapons, mission-ready missiles, and high-tech defence equipment, while establishing facilities for composite propellants, TNT and explosive-grade material production.
Technology: The facility will use advanced manufacturing technologies, automated production systems and globally benchmarked safety standards to support multiple missile programmes simultaneously.

- It will meet the requirements of the Indian Armed Forces and trusted international partners, strengthening India's role as a supplier of precision-guided munitions.

ICMR to Set Up India's First Centre for High-Altitude Medicine in Himachal Pradesh

In July 2026, Union Minister **Jagat Prakash Nadda**, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW) laid the foundation stone of the Indian Council of Medical Research (**ICMR**) Centre for **High Altitude Medicine** and **Public Health Research** at Keylong in Lahaul and Spiti district, Himachal Pradesh (**HP**).

- The Centre will be India's first dedicated institution for research on high-altitude medicine and public health.

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Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Lays of foundation stone
- ✓ **For?** India's first dedicated centre for high-altitude medicine and public health research.
- ✓ **By?** Union Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda, MoHFW
- ✓ **Entity:** ICMR
- ✓ **Where?** Keylong, Lahaul & Spiti, Himachal Pradesh.
- ✓ **Purpose:** Research, diagnosis, and treatment of altitude-related health issues

Key Details of Centre:

Objective: The Centre will conduct long-term research on high-altitude and tribal populations, focusing on tribal health, disaster preparedness, and digital health innovation, while deploying telemedicine, drone-based logistics, and real-time surveillance to enhance healthcare delivery in remote areas.

Capacity Building: The Centre will upgrade ICMR's Keylong field station into a multidisciplinary hub for research, innovation, and capacity building focused on high-altitude and climate-sensitive regions.

Collaborations: The Centre will collaborate with the Armed Forces Medical Services (**AFMS**), Defence Research and Development Organisation (**DRDO**), HP Government, and national and international academic institutions to create an ecosystem for translational research and policy support, advancing **Atmanirbhar Bharat** in health research and climate-resilient, inclusive health systems.

Focus Areas: The Centre will focus on scientific studies and solutions covering high-altitude physiology, mountain medicine, emerging and climate-sensitive diseases, maternal, infectious and non-communicable diseases, child health, nutrition, mental health, environmental and occupational health, and disaster medicine.

About ICMR: ICMR is the apex body in India for the formulation, coordination, and promotion of biomedical research, is headquartered in New Delhi (Delhi) and led by Secretary & Director General (DG) Dr. Rajiv Bahl.

MSME Mandates TReDS for Settlement of All MSME Invoices by CPSEs

The Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises **(MSME)** through its official notification issued on June 30 2026, mandated all operating Central Public Sector Enterprises **(CPSEs)** invoices for goods and services procured from MSMEs through Trade Receivables Discounting System **(TReDS)** platforms authorised by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

- This move gives effect to a key announcement made by the Government of India (GoI) in the Union Budget for the Financial Year 2026–27 **(FY27).**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Notification regarding settlement of transactions of MSME Suppliers
- ✓ **Notified by:** MSME
- ✓ **Mandatory Transaction Through:** TREDs
- ✓ **Applicable to:** All operating CPSEs
- ✓ **Effective from:** June 30, 2026

Key Details:

Transparency and Accountability: CPSEs now required to disclose details of MSME invoices routed and settled through TReDS and obtain a statutory auditor's certificate of TReDS registration and compliance during their annual audit and facilitate MSMEs' access to collateral-free working capital by enabling invoice discounting before the payment due date.

Ensures Timely Payment: The new mandate is expected to position CPSEs as role models for timely payment discipline for large corporate buyers.

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Reforms: TReDS has been progressively expanded through mandatory onboarding of CPSEs and companies with turnover above Rs.500 crore (2018), lowering the threshold to Rs.250 crore (2024) and the Mandatory TReDS settlement from 30 June 2026.

About TReDS: It is an RBI-authorized digital platform, operational since 2017, has been designed to facilitate financing and discounting the trade receivables of MSMEs due from corporate buyers, government departments and Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs), through competitive bidding by multiple financiers.

- At present, five platforms are operational, including Receivable Exchange of India Limited (RXIL), M1xchange, Invoicemart, C2treds and Domestic Trade Exchange (DTX).

Lakhanpur in J&K Selected for PM SVANidhi Street Food Hub Initiative

In July 2026, **Lakhanpur** in Kathua district, Jammu & Kashmir **(J&K)** was selected among the first towns in India for the development of a **Street Food Hub** under the Pradhan Mantri Street Vendor's AtmaNirbhar Nidhi **(PM SVANidhi)** initiative of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA).

- The project was announced by Union Minister of State (MoS) (Independent Charge, IC) **Dr. Jitendra Singh**, Ministry of Science and Technology (MoS&T) to establish a Street Food Hub across two clusters in Lakhanpur Market, promoting Dogra cuisine, tourism, and street vendors.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Development of PM SVANidhi Street Food Hub
- ✓ **Location:** Lakhanpur, Kathua, J&K, 1st town in India
- ✓ **Scheme:** PM SVANidhi
- ✓ **Ministry:** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA)
- ✓ **Funding:** Rs. 4 crore financial assistance per project; 3 installments of 30%, 50%, 20%; additional Rs 25 lakh incentive.
- ✓ **Coverage:** 1,754.25 sq. m. area; up to 50 Street Food Hubs planned across India.
- ✓ **Convergence:** MoHUA, Ministry of Tourism, FSSAI

Highlights of the Initiative:

Objective: To develop organised and hygienic street food hubs, promote local cuisine, tourism and sustainable livelihoods for street vendors.

Funding: Each approved Street Food Hub will receive Rs. 4 crore in 3 installments of 30%-50%-20%, along with a **Rs. 25 lakh** incentive for Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) having a notified Street Vending Plan.

Implementation: The initiative targets up to 50 Street Food Hubs nationwide with support from **MoHUA**, Ministry of Tourism **(MoT),** and Food Safety and Standards Authority of India **(FSSAI).**

Lakhanpur Hub: Spread across 1,754.25 square metres (sq. m) in two clusters, the hub will provide modern vending infrastructure, and regional culinary traditions, generate local livelihoods by transforming Lakhanpur into a culinary destination.

About PM SVANidhi:

Launch: Launched in **2020** by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs **(MoHUA),** the scheme has been extended until March 2030.

Objective: Provides collateral-free working capital loans and promotes financial inclusion and digital transactions for street vendors.

Loan Amounts: Vendors can access tiered collateral-free loans: up to Rs.15,000 for the first cycle, up to Rs.25,000 for the second cycle, and up to Rs.50,000 for the third cycle.

About Jammu & Kashmir (J&K):

Chief Minister **(CM)** – Omar Abdullah

Governor – Manoj Sinha (Lt. Governor)

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Capital – Srinagar (From May to October), Jammu (From November to April)
National Park **(NP)** – Dachigam NP, Srinagar

CPWD Celebrates 172nd Annual Day at Vigyan Bhavan, MoH&UA unveils SANKALP framework

On 12 July 2026, the Central Public Works Department (**CPWD**), a premier engineering organization under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoH&UA) of the Government of India (**GoI**), celebrated its **172nd** Annual Day at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi.

- During this celebration, the Union Minister **Manohar Lal,** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (**MoH&UA**) unveiled the '**SANKALP'** framework.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** CPWD celebrates 172nd Annual Day
- ✓ **Where?** Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi
- ✓ **Books released:** India's Urban Transformation: Reflections from Policy and Practice
- ✓ India's Urban Momentum: Towards Making Our Cities Liveable
- ✓ **Digital Launch:** Technical Publications
- ✓ Nirman Bharati
- ✓ the newly developed e-NIRMIT ERP
- ✓ **Iconic Projects:** Adoption of modern construction technologies
- ✓ Implementation of the e-NIRMIT ERP modules, and
- ✓ Award-winning projects were screened during the event.
- ✓ **SANKALP:** Speed, Accessibility, Nekneeyat (good intent), Kartavyanishtha (dedication to duty), Adoption of Technology, Lokhit (public welfare) and Pardarshita (transparency)
- ✓ **Purpose:** Guide CPWD's transformation

CPWD Celebration Highlights

Key Members: Along with the Union Minister, Srinivas Katikithala, Secretary, (**MoH&UA**), Satinder Pal Singh, Director General (**DG**), CPWD, Mohd. Kamal Ahmad, Director General (Training), CPWD, Pradeep Kumar Jha, Joint Secretary (Works & Central Vista), (**MoH&UA**) also graced the occasion.

Books Released: On the occasion, the Union Minister also released the following books:

- **India's Urban Transformation: Reflections from Policy and Practice** and
- the MoH&UA's coffee table book "**India's Urban Momentum: Towards Making Our Cities Liveable**", highlighting India's remarkable urban development journey.

Digital Launch: During the inaugural session, the minister released:

- Technical Publications
- Nirman Bharati (CPWD's annual in-house publication)
- the newly developed e-NIRMIT (e-Nationwide Intelligent Resource Management with Information Technology) ERP (Enterprise Resource Planning) Modules

Iconic Projects: A documentary highlighting CPWD's key achievements,

- Iconic infrastructure projects
- Adoption of modern construction technologies
- Implementation of the e-NIRMIT ERP modules, and
- Award-winning projects were screened during the event.

Proposal: The Union Minister also proposed the establishment of a **National Council** for Public Works to promote innovation, knowledge sharing, capacity building and standardisation across public infrastructure agencies.

Modern Technologies: The Minister emphasized the need to adopt modern construction technologies such as Building Information Modelling (**BIM**), digital project management tools, advanced construction

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materials, automation, and other emerging technologies to improve productivity, quality and sustainability.

SANKALP

Acronym: The acronym SANKALP stands for:

- Speed
- Accessibility
- Nekneeyat (good intent)
- Kartavyanishtha (dedication to duty)
- Adoption of Technology, Lokhit (public welfare) and
- Pardarshita (transparency)

Purpose: The SANKALP principles would guide CPWD's transformation into a future-ready organisation and contribute to the vision of Viksit Bharat.

About Central Public Works Department (CPWD)

The CPWD is an agency of the Government of India (**GoI**). It functions as the centralized agency that takes charge of all forms of public service operations or development work in India.

Director General (DG): Satinder Pal Singh

Established in: July 1854

Railways unveils 8 more reforms under 'Reform Express' to modernise freight operations

In July 2026, Union Minister **Ashwini Vaishnaw**, Ministry of Railways (MoR) implemented **8 more structural reforms** under '**Reform Express**' initiative at Rail Bhawan, New Delhi, raising the total reforms under the programme to 17.

- These reforms are part of the MoR's target to implement **52 reforms** in **52 weeks** to enhance efficiency, promote innovation and strengthen the railway ecosystem.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** 8 new reforms under **Reform Express**.
- ✓ **Announced By?** Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, MoR
- ✓ **Programme:** Reform Express
- ✓ **Eight Reforms:** Fly Ash Transportation, Container Sector, Fertilizer Transportation, Skilling Artisans, Construction Reforms, Wagon Design, Petroleum Products Transportation and Foodgrains Transportation
- ✓ **Total Reforms:** 17
- ✓ **Purpose:** Modernise freight operations, improve efficiency, and enhance logistics competitiveness

8 New Strategic Reforms:

Modernisation: The new reforms will impact freight transportation, logistics, construction methods, project execution, wagon design, workforce skilling, and ease of doing business.

Objective: The new reforms aim to shift more freight from road to rail, cutting logistics costs and delivering environmental benefits, as rail transport emits nearly 90% less carbon than road transport.

Reform 10: Fly Ash Transportation

Problem: India generates around **340 million tonnes** of fly ash annually, of which nearly 96 million tonnes are utilised by the cement industry. Indian Railways (**IR**) transported only **13 million tonnes** (nearly 4%) of the total fly ash during FY 2025-26.

Reform: Shifting to International Organization for Standardization (**ISO-standard**) closed containers loaded via top-loading power plant loops, handled with **hydraulic reach stackers** to eliminate transit dust and ensure clean storage at cement manufacturing facilities.

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Reform 11: Reforms in the Container Sector

Problem: Under the 4-category **(I–IV)** route system, where Container Train Operators (**CTOs**) faced separate fees of **Rs. 50 crore** for Category I and **Rs. 10 crore** for other categories, along with route-specific restrictions and varied registration requirements.

Reform: IR has replaced the 4-category route restrictions with a single **Pan-India Container Train Operator licence** with a uniform Rs. 25 crore registration fee (non-refundable) valid for 20 years, with free future extensions.

Reform 12: Fertilizer Transportation

Problem: IR, handling 85% of India's fertiliser transport, faced operational challenges with a freight system of around **50 slabs**, where entire rakes remained detained until full unloading at a single destination.

Reform: The freight system for fertilisers has been rationalised to **per-tonne per-kilometre** (Km) charges with three variations. Containers can now be transported and individually unloaded at rake points, enabling phased distribution based on distributor demand and lifting capacity.

Reform 13: Policy for Skilling Artisans in Railway Projects and Works

Reform: Under the new skill certification policy, workers pass assessments conducted by designated authorities and receive individual Quick Response (**QR code**)-enabled certificates linked to a live database. The rollout starts with complex bridges, tunnels and all Zonal Railways (ZR) within 2 years.

Reform 14: Construction Reforms

Reform: Contracting rules now require full 10% performance security upfront, disqualify firms with pending litigation over **50% of net worth**, and mandate All Risk and Professional Indemnity insurance to mitigate risks.

Reform 15: Policy for Wagon Design Approval

Reform: Wagon design has been fully liberalised, enabling private industries to create custom specialised wagons. Wagon designs were primarily developed by the Research Designs and Standards Organisation (RDSO) now RDSO will acts as a five-stage advisory regulator, validating prototypes and dynamic tests by Chief Commissioner of Railway Safety and approval by Railway Board for induction into service.

Reform 16: Petroleum Products Transportation

Problem: IR's exclusive ownership of tank wagons constrained oil companies' ability to use specialised wagons tailored for petroleum, oil, and lubricant (**POL**) transport.

Reform: The elimination of structural barriers allows refiners to procure or lease petroleum tank wagons directly and manage their deployment on rail lines, enhancing scheduling and reducing losses in transit.

Reform 17: Foodgrains, Flour and Pulses Transportation

Reform: Bulk agricultural freight moves to tamper-evident, weatherproof containers, with **per-tonne-per-km charges** replacing the slab system, allowing flexible, phased unloading for distributors.

Reform Express initiative:

Overview: Indian Railways had implemented **9 major structural reforms**, including continuous on-board train cleaning, expansion of Gati Shakti Cargo Terminals, the RailTech policy and portal, digitisation of the Railway Claims Tribunal, specialised containers for salt and automobiles, **7 construction-quality reforms**, simplified ticket cancellation/refund rules, and digital boarding point changes.

Ashwini Vaishnaw announces Rail Bhoomi portal for land acquisition

RailBhoomi Initiative: A web-based platform by Centre for Railway Information Systems (**CRIS**), manages end-to-end land acquisition, accelerating approvals, improving project planning, and ensuring timely execution of railway infrastructure works.

Integration: It integrates key IR applications such as Indian Railway Project System for Management (**IRPSM**), Integrated Project Approval System (**IPAS**), and Human Resource Management System (**HRMS**),

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enabling seamless data exchange, online processing of major land acquisition stages, efficient workflow management, and real-time monitoring via dashboards and management information systems (**MIS**).

About Ministry of Railways (MoR):

Union Minister- Ashwini Vaishnaw (Rajya Sabha- Odisha)
Minister of State (MoS)- Veeranna Somanna (Constituency- Tumkur, Karnataka); Ravneet Singh Bittu (Rajya Sabha- Rajasthan)

MoPSW Approves Greenfield Shipbuilding Cluster in Porbandar & Ship Repair Facility at Vadinar under SbDS

On 15 July 2026, the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways **(MoPSW)** accorded in-principle approval to a **Greenfield Shipbuilding Cluster** in **Porbandar district** and a state-of-the-art **Ship Repair Facility at Vadinar** in the Gulf of Kutch, **Gujarat**, under the Shipbuilding Development Scheme (SbDS).

- The projects aim to strengthen India's indigenous shipbuilding and ship repair capabilities under the **Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047**, supporting the country's ambition to emerge as a global shipbuilding hub.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** In-principle approval for Greenfield Shipbuilding Cluster & Ship Repair Facility
- ✓ **Approved By:** Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways
- ✓ **Scheme:** Shipbuilding Development Scheme
- ✓ **Vision:** Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047
- ✓ **Greenfield Cluster:** Kuchhadi, Porbandar, Gujarat
- ✓ **Implementing Agency (Cluster):** National Shipbuilding and Heavy Industries Park-Gujarat (NSHIP-Gujarat)
- ✓ **Ship Repair Facility:** Vadinar, Gulf of Kutch, Gujarat
- ✓ **Developed By:** CSL & DPA
- ✓ **Project Cost (Vadinar):** Rs. 1,570 crore

Highlights of Greenfield Shipbuilding Cluster in Porbandar:

Location: The project will be developed at Kuchhadi in Porbandar district, Gujarat, over nearly **2,000 acres.**

Implementing Agency: It will be developed through the National Shipbuilding and Heavy Industries Park-Gujarat (NSHIP-Gujarat), a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) jointly promoted by MoPSW and the Gujarat Maritime Board (GMB).

Infrastructure: The integrated maritime manufacturing cluster will comprise modern shipyards, ancillary manufacturing units, common infrastructure, and capability development centres.

Production Capacity: It is designed to build large commercial vessels with an annual production capacity of **1.2–1.5 million** Gross Tonnage **(GT)**, significantly expanding India's domestic shipbuilding capacity.

Highlights of Ship Repair Facility at Vadinar:

Project Cost: The **Rs. 1,570 crore** facility will be jointly developed by Cochin Shipyard Limited **(CSL)** and the Deendayal Port Authority (DPA).

Scheme Support: The project has secured 25% financial assistance on eligible capital infrastructure under the Shipbuilding Development Scheme (SbDS).

Infrastructure: The brownfield expansion includes a **650-metre jetty,** two large floating dry docks, workshops, and supporting marine infrastructure.

Strategic Advantage: The facility leverages Vadinar's natural deep draft, strategic location on major international shipping routes, and proximity to Mundra Port and Deendayal Port.

Repair Capacity: Once operational, it will repair commercial vessels up to 300 metres in length, reducing India's dependence on overseas ship repair yards.

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About Shipbuilding Development Scheme (SbDS):

Launch: Launched in September 2025 with an outlay of Rs. 19,989 crore (till 31 March 2036) to support Greenfield shipbuilding clusters, Brownfield shipyard expansion, and strengthen India's shipbuilding ecosystem.

Financial Support & Target: Provides 100% capital support for Greenfield infrastructure and 25% assistance for Brownfield expansion, with the goal of increasing India's commercial shipbuilding capacity to 4.5 million Gross Tonnage (GT) per annum by 2047.

About Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW):

Union Minister – Sarbananda Sonowal (Rajya Sabha – Assam)
Minister of State **(MoS) –** Shantanu Thakur (Bongaon, West Bengal WB)

India's First AI-Integrated Vertical University Campus Inaugurates in Chennai TN

In July 2026, Padma Shri **Sridhar Vembu,** Chief Scientist and Co-founder of Zoho Corporation Pvt. Ltd., inaugurated VELS Institute of Science, Technology, & Advanced Studies **(VISTAS)'s Thiruvanmiyur campus** in Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN), regarded as **India's 1st** Artificial Intelligence (AI)-integrated vertical university campus.

- Dr. Ishari K. Ganesh, founder and Chancellor of VISTAS, along with Dr. Preetha Ganesh, Vice-President (VP) of VELS Group of Institutions, presided over the launch event.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Inauguration of India's 1st Artificial Intelligence (AI)-integrated vertical university campus
- ✓ **Name of Campus:** VELS Thiruvanmiyur Campus
- ✓ **Inaugurated by:** Padma Shri Sridhar Vembu (Co-founder of Zoho Corporation)
- ✓ **Other Key Highlight:** MoU signed to establishment flying school in UAE
- ✓ **Entities Involved:** VISTAS, Aspin Holding LLC Group, and MH Cockpit.

Key Details:

About Campus: The newly inaugurated campus features Industry-Academia Centres of Excellence **(CoEs),** established in partnership with Intel Unnati, Tata Consultancy Service (TCS) iON, Microsoft, Oracle Academy.

- These CoEs will enable the students to have experience in Artificial Intelligence (AI), cloud computing, and other emerging technologies.

Signing of MoU: During the event, VELS Institute of Science, Technology, & Advanced Studies (VISTAS) signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with Aspin Holding LLC Group, and MH Cockpit, to establish a flying school in the United Arab Emirates (UAE).

- This strategic partnership will foster collaboration in aviation education, pilot training, faculty exchange, internships, skill development, research and international career opportunities for students.

Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan Unveils Roadmap for 'Viksit Krishi and Samruddh Kisan' at ICAR's 98th Foundation Day

On 16 July 2026, Union Minister **Shivraj Singh Chouhan**, Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers' Welfare **(MoA&FW)** and Ministry of Rural Development **(MoRD)**, unveiled the roadmap for **'Viksit Krishi and Samruddh Kisan'** as a key pillar of Viksit Bharat 2047 during the **98th Foundation Day** of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research **(ICAR)** in New Delhi, Delhi.

- During the event, 43 new crop varieties, 17 technologies/products, and 14 publications were released, along with the signing of over 70 Memorandums of Understanding **(MoUs)** and technology licensing agreements to accelerate technology transfer to farmers.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Unveiled Roadmap for 'Viksit Krishi and Samruddh Kisan'
- ✓ **Who?** Shivaraj Singh Chouhan (MoA&FW) and (MoRD)
- ✓ **Occasion?** On 98th Foundation Day of ICAR
- ✓ **Date:** 16 July 2026
- ✓ **Venue:** New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Climate Smart Villages Target:** 100
- ✓ **Farmers to Benefit:** 100 million (10 crore)
- ✓ **Digital Initiative:** ICAR Open Digital Knowledge Platform
- ✓ **Innovation Initiative:** One Institute-One Grand Innovation
- ✓ **Financial Target:** Rs. 10,000 crore internal resource generation by 2029
- ✓ **Quality Motto:** "Quality over Quantity"

Highlights of 'Viksit Krishi and Samruddh Kisan':

Climate-Resilient: ICAR will establish **100 Climate Smart Villages** before its centenary to demonstrate climate-smart farming, integrated farming systems, water conservation, and climate adaptation models.

Mission ICAR-100: Krishi Vigyan Kendras **(KVKs)** will be transformed into innovation hubs, climate advisory centres, startup support centres, and farmer technology demonstration centres, with each KVK covering at least 100 villages.

Reaching 100 Million Farmers with ICAR Technologies:

Shri Chouhan announced that ICAR should aim to ensure that its scientific technologies, innovations and modern agricultural solutions reach at least 100 million farmers across the country.

Digital Outreach: Under the **'One Institute-One Grand Innovation'** initiative, every ICAR institute will develop **at least one transformational innovation** within **2 years**.

ICAR Open Digital Knowledge Platform:

Shri Chouhan proposed the creation of an ICAR Open Digital Knowledge Platform to make ICAR technologies, scientific advisories and instructional videos freely accessible on farmers' mobile phones.

- The proposed platform will provide farmers with scientific advisories, weather forecasts, soil testing guidance, crop advisories, and market information through mobile phones.

Quality-Centric Agriculture: ICAR will promote **"Quality over Quantity"** by focusing on climate-resilient farming, district-specific planning, and agricultural risk management., while advancing indigenous vaccines, improved crop varieties, and advanced technologies to strengthen India's self-reliance in seeds, fertilisers, and animal health.

Protection Measures: The Government proposed stricter legal provisions against counterfeit seeds and pesticides and urged the development of simple field-level technologies to help farmers verify input quality.

Financial Sustainability: ICAR targets **Rs. 10,000 crore** in internal resource generation by 2029 through technology commercialisation, while regularising **over 150 employees** to strengthen the organisation.

Dignitaries: The event was attended by Shivraj Singh Chouhan (MoA&FW) and (MoRD) ; Prof. S.P. Singh Baghel, Minister of State for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying (MoFAD &D); Bhagirath Choudhary, Minister of State for Agriculture & Farmers' Welfare; and Dr. M.L. Jat, Director General of the **(ICAR).**

About Indian Council of Agriculture Research (ICAR):

Role: India's apex body for coordinating, guiding, and managing agricultural research, education, and extension in agriculture and allied sectors. The President is the Union Minister for Agriculture & Farmers' Welfare (Shivraj Singh Chouhan), and the Director General is Dr. M.L. Jat.

Established: 16 July 1929 (as the Imperial Council of Agricultural Research); renamed ICAR in 1946. It functions under the Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers' Welfare (MoA&FW) and is headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi.

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Chhattisgarh Becomes First Indian State to Introduce Risk-Based Business Approval System

On 16 July 2026, the Chhattisgarh Legislative Assembly, led by Chief Minister (CM) Vishnu Deo Sai, passed the **Chhattisgarh Ease of Doing Business Act, 2026,** making Chhattisgarh the **first** Indian state to introduce a comprehensive Risk-based and trust-based business approval framework.

- The new system aims to simplify regulatory approvals, promote investment, and benefit over 15 lakh Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) through faster, transparent, and accountable business processes.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Act?** Ease of Doing Business Act, 2026 passed
- ✓ **Passed by:** Chhattisgarh Legislative Assembly
- ✓ **Significance:** First Indian State adopted
- ✓ **Objective:** Risk-based and trust-based business approval system
- ✓ **Beneficiaries:** MSMEs
- ✓ **Services Covered (Phase I):** 43 services.

Highlights of the Framework:

Approvals: Businesses will be classified by risk level, with low-risk enterprises receiving self-certification, simplified compliance, while high-risk projects will continue to undergo inspections.
Deemed Approvals: Eligible applications not processed within the prescribed timeline will receive **deemed (auto) approvals**, ensuring time-bound service delivery.
Reforms: The Act abolishes mandatory annual licence renewals, initially covers **43 services** across 8 departments, and is expected to benefit over 1.5 million MSMEs.
Governance: The Act will be implemented through a three-tier monitoring system headed by the Chief Secretary, District Collectors, and an Executive Council chaired by the CM.

L-G VK Saxena Commissions India's First 2 Geothermal Wells in Ladakh

In July 2026, **VK Saxena**, Lieutenant Governor (**Lt Gov**) of Ladakh, commissioned India's **first** and **deepest two 1,000** metre(**m**) **geothermal wells** at Puga Valley in Ladakh, executed by Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Limited (**ONGC**) Energy Centre.

- These two geothermal wells are critical to the successful implementation of a 1Megawatt (MW) Pilot Geothermal Power Plant at Puga Valley, located at an altitude of over 14,000 feet above sea level, which will be **India's first** demonstration-scale geothermal power project.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Commissioning of India's first two geothermal wells
- ✓ **Commissioned By?** Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, VK Saxena
- ✓ **Location:** Puga Valley, Ladakh
- ✓ **Capacity:** 1 Megawatt (MW) Geothermal Power Plant
- ✓ **Maximum Temperature:** At 400m depth, 135°C
- ✓ **Significance:** India's first operational geothermal wells for clean energy generation
- ✓ **Alignment:** PM Narendra Modi's Carbon-Neutral Ladakh mission.

About Geothermal Power Project:

Geothermal Energy: It provides direct heating using the Earth's interior heat, even in sub-zero Himalayan winters and generates clean, continuous electricity.

- India has identified geothermal resource zones across several regions, including Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh (HP), Uttarakhand, Gujarat, and the Andaman and Nicobar(A&N) Islands, for the development of geothermal energy.

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Project Revival: The geothermal power project in Ladakh had stalled after the expiration of the original tripartite Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Ladakh Administration, Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC)-Leh, and ONGC Energy Centre.

- Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena intervened to facilitate a renewed **5-year** tripartite MoU in June 2026

Evaluation: Pilot projects evaluate drilling, fluid behavior, thermal profiles, and energy conversion mechanisms before full-scale deployment.

Impact: The successful completion of the two wells would facilitate critical reservoir evaluation, power plant planning, and the eventual commercial development of geothermal resources in Ladakh.

- At **400m depth**, the wells reached a maximum temperature of **135°C** (degrees Celsius).

Significance: This initiative will enhance Ladakh's carbon-neutral development, energy security, environmental sustainability and serve as a blueprint for India's net-zero journey

Resources: Located in the Himalayan Geothermal Belt, Puga Valley and Chumathang hold India's most promising geothermal resources due to shallow magma chambers caused by tectonic activity.

Alignment: The project supports Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi's vision of a 'Carbon-Neutral Ladakh' and aims to strengthen clean energy generation and long-term energy security in the region.

About Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Limited (ONGC)

Overview: ONGC, a Maharatna central public sector undertaking under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), is India's largest crude oil and natural gas exploration and production company.
Chairman & Chief Executive Officer (**CEO**) – Arun Kumar Singh
Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi
Established- 1956

MoHUA Approves Rs 2,719.80 Crore for 6 Urban Development Projects in Ahmedabad Under UCF

In July 2026, the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs **(MoHUA)** approved projects worth **Rs 2,719.80 crore** under Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi's Urban Challenge Fund **(UCF) for six t**ransformative urban development initiatives in **Ahmedabad, Gujarat.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of six urban development projects under Urban Challenge Fund
- ✓ **Total Outlay:** Rs 2,719.80 crore
- ✓ **City:** Ahmedabad, Gujarat
- ✓ **Approved By:** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
- ✓ **Purpose:** Upgrade urban infrastructure, implement smart city solutions, and enhance citizen services
- ✓ **Major Projects:** Sewerage rehabilitation, Intelligent Water Management System (IWMS), Integrated Sludge Management Facility, Intelligent Traffic Management System (ITMS) and Automatic Fare Collection System (AFCS).

About Urban Development Projects:

Approved Projects: The approved projects include

- Rs 852.93 crore for rehabilitation of the main sewerage network in West Ahmedabad,
- Rs 551.35 crore for the East Ahmedabad sewerage network,
- Rs 290.24 crore for upgrading old sewerage networks across the city,
- Rs 215 crore for an Intelligent Water Management System (IWMS),
- Rs 479.25 crore for a 125 Tonnes Per Day (TPD) Integrated Sludge Management Facility, and
- Rs 331.03 crore for an Intelligent Traffic Management System (ITMS) and Automatic Fare Collection System (AFCS).

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Funding Pattern: The Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC) will receive **25%** (Rs 679.95 crore) each from the Central Government and the Government of Gujarat, while the remaining **50%** (Rs 1,359.90 crore) will be mobilised through municipal bonds, loans, or Public-Private Partnership (PPP) models.
Significance: Once operational, Ahmedabad's upgraded sewerage network will curb overflows and leakages, while enabling real-time digital monitoring and smart management of sewerage and stormwater systems.
Impact: The projects are expected to modernise Ahmedabad's urban infrastructure by reducing sewer overflows and leakages through rehabilitation of the ageing sewerage network and enabling real-time digital monitoring of the city's sewerage and stormwater systems.

- The Integrated Sludge Management Facility will convert sewage sludge into biogas and green energy, promoting a circular economy.
- The Integrated Transit Management System (ITMS) and Automatic Fare Collection System (AFCS) will integrate the Ahmedabad Municipal Transport Service (AMTS), Bus Rapid Transit System (BRTS), and Metro through a common mobility card and single journey application, while providing real-time passenger information, Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based route planning, and enhanced in-bus surveillance.

About Urban Challenge Fund (UCF):

Overview: It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) of the MoHUA with a Central assistance of **Rs 1 lakh crore** for the period Financial Year 2025–26 (FY26) to FY31, with the implementation period extendable up to FY34.

- UCF was launched to promote market-based financing and balanced regional development, supporting projects under three dedicated verticals namely: Creative Redevelopment of Cities, Cities as Growth Hubs, and Water & Sanitation.

Funding Pattern: Under the UCF, the Central Government provides 25% of the project cost, while cities are required to mobilise at least 50% through municipal bonds, bank loans, or Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs).

- The remaining 25% is to be contributed by States, Union Territories (UTs), Urban Local Bodies (ULBs), or additional market financing.

Allocation: Gujarat receives **Rs. 6,475 crore** in central funding under the UCF, enabling cities to implement projects worth **Rs. 25,900 crore** statewide.

About Gujarat:

Chief Minister **(CM)-** Bhupendrabhai Patel
Governor- Acharya Devvrat
Capital- Gandhinagar
National Parks **(NP)-** Gir NP, Marine NP

NIELIT to Establish Two CoE's for Semiconductor Skilling in Ahmedabad and Guwahati

In July 2026, The National Institute of Electronics & Information Technology **(NIELIT)** announced that it will establish two Centres of Excellence **(CoEs)** in **Ahmedabad** (Gujarat) and **Guwahati** (Assam) to strengthen India's semiconductor ecosystem through specialised skill development.

- The initiative supports the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0, which was approved with an outlay of Rs. 1.28 lakh crore, and aims to create a skilled workforce in semiconductor manufacturing and advanced packaging technologies.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Two Centres of Excellence (CoEs) for semiconductor skilling
- ✓ **Organisation:** National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology (NIELIT)
- ✓ **Locations:** Ahmedabad (Gujarat) and Guwahati (Assam)

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- ✓ **Mission:** India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0
- ✓ **Training Areas:** Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (OSAT) and Assembly, Testing, Marking and Packaging (ATMP)
- ✓ **Industry Partners:** Tata Electronics and Infineon
- ✓ **Manufacturing Partner:** Semiconductor Complex Limited (SCL), Mohali

Key Highlights:

Infrastructure: NIELIT will establish two **CoEs** to provide training in Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test **(OSAT)** and Assembly, Testing, Marking and Packaging **(ATMP)** technologies.
Skilling: NIELIT has partnered with Tata Electronics, Infineon, and Semiconductor Complex Limited (SCL), Mohali, and will introduce Bachelor of Technology (BTech), Master of Technology (MTech), and diploma programmes in semiconductors to build a skilled workforce.
AI: Under the India AI Mission, NIELIT has established **28** Artificial Intelligence (AI) Labs, operates 42 AI-focused programmes, and has trained over **20,000 individuals**, particularly in Tier-II and Tier-III cities.
About NIELIT: Established in 1994 as the Department of Electronics Accreditation of Computer Courses (DOEACC) Society and renamed NIELIT in 2011. It is headquartered in New Delhi (Delhi) and functions under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY).

India Becomes 123rd Member of WTO Fisheries Subsidies Agreement

On 20 July 2026, India became a party to the World Trade Organization **(WTO)** Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies (AFS) by depositing its **Instrument of Acceptance**, becoming the **123rd WTO member** to join the Agreement.

- The instrument was handed over by Rajesh Agrawal (Secretary), Department of Commerce, Ministry of Commerce and Industry Commerce (MoC&I), to WTO Director-General Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India Joined with WTO Fisheries Subsidies Agreement
- ✓ **Position:** 123rd WTO Member to accept the Agreement
- ✓ **Deposited By:** Rajesh Agrawal (Secretary), Department of Commerce, MoC&I
- ✓ **Received By:** Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala, Director-General, WTO
- ✓ **Adopted:** 12th WTO Ministerial Conference (MC12), Geneva, June 2022
- ✓ **Entered into Force:** 15 September 2025
- ✓ **Scope:** Marine wild capture fishing and fishing-related activities at sea
- ✓ **Excluded:** Aquaculture and inland fisheries

About the WTO Fisheries Subsidies Agreement:

Background: Adopted at the **12th Ministerial Conference** (MC12), Geneva, Switzerland (June 2022), the WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies (AFS) is the first WTO agreement with an environmental sustainability objective and entered into force on 15 September 2025.
Purpose: The WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies aims to promote sustainable fisheries and marine resource conservation by prohibiting subsidies linked to **illegal, unreported and unregulated** (IUU) fishing, overfishing of depleted stocks, and harmful fishing practices.
Benefit: The Agreement supports **traditional and small-scale fishers** by regulating harmful subsidies to large industrial fishing fleets, safeguarding their livelihoods and policy space, and enhances India's credibility as a responsible seafood exporter.
Exclusion: The Agreement applies to marine wild capture fishing and related activities at sea, while aquaculture and inland fisheries remain outside its scope, protecting India's aquaculture-based shrimp export sector.

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Domestic Framework: India's implementation of the Agreement is supported by the **Sustainable Harnessing of Fisheries** in the Exclusive Economic Zone **(EEZ)** Rules, 2025 and the Guidelines for Sustainable Harnessing of Fisheries in the High Seas by Indian-Flagged Fishing Vessels, 2025.

- Capacity building and sustainable fisheries management are further strengthened through initiatives under the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY).

About World Trade Organization (WTO):

The WTO is an international organisation that regulates global trade rules among member countries.
Director General **(DG)** – Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala.
Headquarters – Geneva, Switzerland
Established – 1995

GoI Raises Windfall Tax on Diesel, ATF Exports; Lowered Tax on Petrol Exports

In July 2026, the Government of India **(GoI)** increased the **windfall gains tax** on diesel and Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) exports, while reducing the tax on petrol exports.

- As per the Ministry of Finance (MoF) notification, the revised tax rates came into effect from **16 July 2026.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** GoI revised windfall gains tax on fuel exports
- ✓ **Raised on:** Diesel (Rs 15.5/l) and ATF (Rs 14.5/l) exports
- ✓ **Reduced on:** Petrol exports (Rs 2.5/l)
- ✓ **Tax Type**: Special Additional Excise Duty
- ✓ **Effective from:** 16 July 2026

Key Details:

Windfall Tax: It is a government-imposed tax on specific industries that have experienced sudden high profits due to external events such as geopolitical crises. The key objective is to redirect these profits towards societal benefits.

Export Duty on Diesel & ATF: As per the official notification, the Special Additional Excise Duty (SAED) on diesel exports has been increased from Rs 8.5/litre (l) **to Rs 15.5/l.**

- Similarly, the SAED on ATF exports have also been increased from Rs 7.5/l to **Rs 14.5/l.**

Export Duty on Petrol: The GoI has reduced the export duty on petrol from the existing Rs 4/l to Rs 2.5/l.
Background: Amid escalating tensions in West Asia, the GoI imposed an export duty on diesel and ATF on 27 March 2026 and has been revising the rates every fortnight.

India Approves First Dengue Vaccine 'QDENGA' After DCGI Clearance

In July 2026, **India** approved its **first dengue vaccine, QDENGA (TAK-003),** after the Drug Controller General of India (DCGI) granted market authorisation to **Takeda Biopharmaceuticals** India Private Limited under the New Drugs and Clinical Trials (NDCT) Rules, 2019.

- QDENGA has been approved for the prevention of dengue in individuals aged **4 to 60 years.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of India's first dengue vaccine – QDENGA (TAK-003)
- ✓ **Approved By:** DCGI
- ✓ **Developer:** Takeda Biopharmaceuticals India Private Limited
- ✓ **Approved For:** Individuals aged 4–60 years
- ✓ **Protection:** Covers all four dengue virus serotypes (DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 & DENV-4)
- ✓ **WHO Status:** Received WHO prequalification for quality, safety and efficacy standards.

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About QDENGA:

Vaccine: It is a live-attenuated tetravalent dengue vaccine designed to provide protection against all four dengue virus serotypes (DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4).

- It is administered as two subcutaneous doses of 0.5 millilitres (mL) given three months apart.

Prequalification: QDENGA has received World Health Organization (**WHO)** prequalification, confirming its compliance with global standards of quality, safety and efficacy, and making it eligible for procurement by international agencies such as UNICEF and the Pan American Health Organization **(PAHO).**

Clinical Trials: The approval of QDENGA in India was supported by Takeda's global clinical program, including 19 Phase I–III trials involving over 28,000 participants, the Phase III TIDES (DEN-301) trial with more than 20,000 participants across 8 countries, and data from the DEN-302 Phase III trial conducted among Indian participants.

Dengue Burden: Dengue is a mosquito-borne viral disease affecting over 125 countries worldwide and remains a major public health challenge. India contributes nearly one-third of the global dengue burden.

IIT Kanpur to Set up Centre of Excellence for Green Hydrogen

In July 2026, the Indian Institute of Technology **(IIT) Kanpur**, Uttar Pradesh (UP), announced the establishment of a Centre of Excellence (**CoE**) on Innovative and Integrated Ecosystem for Green Hydrogen (**ECOGEN**) under the **UP Green Hydrogen Policy 2024**.

- The CoE will be led by **Dr. Prabodh Bajpai**, Professor in the Sustainable Energy Engineering Department of IIT Kanpur, as Principal Investigator.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Establishment of CoE on Innovative and Integrated Ecosystem for Green Hydrogen
- ✓ **Who?** IIT Kanpur
- ✓ **Framework:** Uttar Pradesh Green Hydrogen Policy 2024
- ✓ **Led By:** Dr. Prabodh Bajpai, Professor, IIT Kanpur
- ✓ **Focus:** Research across green hydrogen generation, storage, transportation, utilisation and system integration.

About CoE for Green Hydrogen:

Approval: The Proposal for **ECOGEN** is approved by the authorised committee constituted by Government of UP and has been sanctioned by the UP New and Renewable Energy Development Agency (**UPNEDA**).

Objective: The CoE will advance research and development across the green hydrogen value chain, including energy generation, storage, utilisation, and system integration, aiming to lower production costs and enable sustainable energy solutions.

Ecosystem: It will conduct research across the entire Green Hydrogen (GH_2) ecosystem, covering all stages from hydrogen generation to storage, distribution, and end-use applications.

Green hydrogen: It is produced by splitting water through electrolysis using renewable electricity from solar or wind energy, making it a low-carbon fuel as it avoids carbon dioxide emissions from fossil fuel-based hydrogen production.

MoC Unveils 'AAROH': India's First Comprehensive Report on Scientific Mine Closure

In July 2026, the Ministry of Coal (**MoC**) released the '**AAROH: Annual Report on Mine Closure**', at the Oberoi, New Delhi, Delhi showcasing India's advancements in scientific mine closure, ecological restoration and sustainable utilization of post-mining land.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** MoC releases AAROH: Annual Report on Mine Closure
- ✓ **Report Purpose:** Documentation of scientific closure of mines
- ✓ **Mines closed:** 42 (33 last year), 147 to be closed next2-3 years

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- ✓ **Financial Measures:** Corpus – USD 5 Bn for scientific mine closure
- ✓ **Virtual Inauguration:** Coal NEER plants

Agreement Details

- ✓ **Agreement between:** Moc and GIZ
- ✓ **Funding:** EUR 10 Mn
- ✓ **Duration:** 4 years

Tripartite MoU

- ✓ **MoU_1:** BCCL, JRDA and Hindalco Industries Ltd
- ✓ **Purpose:** Establish Industry-Linked Skill Centre
- ✓ **MoU_2:** BCCL, JRDA and Rajdhani Universal Fabrics Private Limited
- ✓ **Purpose:** Establish world-class integrated technical textile

Launch Highlights

Key Members: The event was graced by Union Minister **G. Kishan Reddy,** Ministry of Coal and Mines (**MoC&M**), Minister of State (Independent Charge) **Dr. Jitendra Singh,** Ministry of Science & Technology, Earth Sciences (MoS&T, MoES), **H.E. Dr Philipp Ackermann**, German Ambassador, **Dr. Ewa Suwara**, Deputy Head of the EU (European Union) Delegation and other senior officials of central and state government.

Details of the Report

Prepared by: The **Coal Controller Organisation (CCO)** developed the "**ARROH report"**, India's 1st comprehensive documentation of scientific mine closure and repurposing practices.

Objective: The report documents the transformative journey of **42 scientifically closed coal mines** (33 closed in the last year alone)**,** highlighting structured mine closure and reclamation processes.

- The publication serves as a knowledge repository, highlighting successful models and providing valuable insights for future mine closure and repurposing efforts.

Target: The ministry has set an ambitious target of scientifically closing **147** more mines over the next two to three years.

Key Initiatives: The report highlights the following key initiatives of the Ministry of Coal, which promote scientific assessment, stakeholder participation, knowledge exchange:

- **RECLAIM** (Reviving Environment, Communities, Livelihoods Around Impacted Mines) Framework
- **L.I.V.E.S.** (Land repurposing, Institutional convergence, Village level participatory planning, Ecosystem regeneration, and Sustainable livelihoods) Framework
- **SUVIKALP (**Sustainable Utilisation of Vast Land Resources through Intelligent Planning**)** – Mine Repurposing Tool
- SUVIKALP Samvaad

Financial Measures: For the first time, 25% of the approved mine closure cost has been earmarked for community development, creating an investment potential of nearly **Rs 10,000 crore (Cr)** over the next decade.

- The Government has created a dedicated corpus of over **USD 5 billion (Bn)** (approximately Rs 40,000 Cr) for scientific and progressive mine closure, reinforcing its commitment to environmentally responsible mining.

Other Key Events

Agreement: The MoC and Germany's Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) signed an agreement for technical cooperation on '**To-be closed mines**'.

Funding Support: The project has been commissioned by the Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (**BMZ**) and is co-financed by the EU, with a total project volume of **EUR 10 million (Mn)** until 2030.

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Duration: The **four-year** cooperation will focus on developing innovative and sustainable approaches for the closure and repurposing of coal mines in India.

Virtual Inauguration: The minister also virtually inaugurated Coal NEER Plants established by Coal India Limited through its subsidiaries:

- Bharat Coking Coal Limited (**BCCL**),
- Central Coalfields Limited (**CCL**),
- Mahanadi Coalfields Limited (**MCL**), and
- South Eastern Coalfields Limited (**SECL**).

NEER plant objective: The initiative is aimed at strengthening access to safe and sustainable drinking water facilities in coal-bearing regions.

MoU Signed

Tripartite MoU: Bharat Coking Coal Limited (**BCCL**) and the Jharia Rehabilitation and Development Authority (**JRDA**) signed a tripartite Memorandum of Understandings (**MoU**) with:

- Hindalco Industries Limited and
- Rajdhani Universal Fabrics Private Limited.

Purpose: The MoU with Hindalco Industries Limited aims to establish an **Industry-Linked Skill Centre** that will equip the youth of the Dhanbad region with industry-relevant skills to work in world-class apparel manufacturing units.

- The MoU with Rajdhani Universal Fabrics Pvt Ltd aims to establish a **world-class integrated technical textile** manufacturing ecosystem, which will generate large-scale employment and strengthen skill development.

About Ministry of Coal:

The Ministry administers its key functions through its Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs), comprising Coal India Limited (CIL), its subsidiaries, and NLC India Limited (NLCIL).

Union Minister– Gangapuram (G.) Kishan Reddy (Constituency- Secunderabad, Telangana)

Minister of State (MoS)– Satish Chandra Dubey (Rajya Sabha – Bihar)

Cotton Blossoms as India's 'White Gold': India Tops in Cultivation, 2nd in Both Production & Consumption

In July 2026, the Government of India **(GoI)** released a **factsheet** highlighting **Cotton** as India's "White Gold", supporting the livelihoods of around 6 million farmers and 40–50 million people across the textile value chain.

- India ranks **1st** globally in cotton cultivation area, with 114.84 lakh hectares(ha) (38% of the world's cotton area), and **2nd** in both cotton production and consumption.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Factsheet of about Cotton
- ✓ **Released by:** GoI
- ✓ **Global Standing:** Ranks 1st (Cultivation); and Ranks 2nd (production and consumption)
- ✓ **Area Under Cultivation:** 114.84 lakh ha
- ✓ **Production (2025-26):** 290.91 lakh bales (or, 4.95 MT)
- ✓ **Consumption (2025-26):** 328 lakh bales (or 5.58 MT)
- ✓ **Cotton Exports (2024-25):** 18 lakh bales (or, 0.31 MMT) (approx. 3.37% of global cotton exports).
- ✓ **Exports Value:** USD 11.49 billion (FY25).
- ✓ **Top 3 Destinations:** The USA, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka.

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About Cotton:

Species: India is the only country that cultivates all four recognised cotton species: G. arboreum, G. herbaceum (Asian cotton), G. barbadense (Egyptian cotton), and G. hirsutum (American upland cotton).

- G. hirsutum accounts for nearly 90% of India's hybrid cotton production.

Zone-wise Cultivation: Cotton cultivation in India is mainly concentrated across 9 major producing states. These states are grouped into three different agro-climatic zones:

- **Northern Zone:** It comprises Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan;
- Central zone: It includes Gujarat, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh (MP);
- **Southern Zone: It includes** Telangana, Andhra Pradesh (AP) and Karnataka.
- Apart from these nine states, cotton is also cultivated in Odisha and Tamil Nadu (TN).

Key Facts:

Cotton Production: As per the Ministry of Textiles (MoT) data, India's cotton production is projected at **290.91 lakh bales** or, 4.95 Million Tonnes (MT) for 2025-26 (provisional).

- India contributes approximately 19% of global fibre production.

Cotton Consumption: Also, cotton domestic consumption, including non-textile segments, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME), and non-MSME, stood at 328 lakh bales or 5.58 MT, for 2025-26 (provisional).

Exports: The data estimated that India exported 18 lakh bales or, 0.31 million Metric Tonnes (MMT) of cotton in 2024-25, representing nearly 3.37% of global cotton exports (541.69 lakh bales or, 9.21 MMT).

- However, in terms of value, India's total cotton exports stood at USD 11.49 billion in Financial Year 2024-25 (FY25).

Top Destination Countries: The Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I) data showed the United States of America **(USA)** emerged as the largest destination for India's cotton fabrics and made-up exports (which accounts 26.35% of total exports); followed by Bangladesh (19.81%); Sri Lanka (5.11%); the United Kingdom (UK) (2.38%) and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) (2.32%).

Government Initiatives:

MSP Operations: The Minimum Support Price (MSP)was increased to **Rs. 8,267 per quintal** for medium-staple cotton and Rs. 8,667 per quintal for long-staple cotton for 2026-27, marking an increase of Rs 557 per quintal for both varieties.

- **Production:** Also, the Cotton Corporation of India Ltd. (CCI) procured 105.09 lakh bales (valued at Rs.41,530 crore) of cotton during the cotton season 2025-26, through 24 lakh procurement transactions with cotton farmers under MSP operations.
- **Procurement Centres:** The number of procurement centres increased from 508 in 2024-25 to **571** in 2025-26, covering 152 districts across 11 cotton-growing states.

Mission: In 2025-26, the GoI launched a **five-year Mission for Cotton Productivity** with the budget of Rs. 5,659.22 crore, to strengthen cotton production across the country.

- **Aim:** The mission promotes research, innovation, and field-level extension support to develop climate-resilient, pest-resistant, and high-yielding cotton varieties.
- **Key Target:** The Mission targets to increase the cotton production from 297 lakh bales to **498 lakh bales** by **2031**.

Special Project under NFSM: Since 2023-24, the GoI has been implementing a Special Project on Cotton under the National Food Security Mission (NFSM). Later, the project was extended to 2025-26 with a total outlay of Rs. 60.32 crore, including committed liabilities.

- **Focus Areas:** The project focuses on large-scale demonstrations of technologies suited to different agro-ecological zones, covering 8 major cotton-growing states nationwide.

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- **Technologies:** For the pilot basis, the project focuses on three key technologies: High-Density Planting System (HDPS), the Closer Spacing Planting System and Production technology for Extra Long Staple **(ELS) cotton**.
- **Key Progress:** So far, the project has covered **9,175 ha** (with budgetary support of Rs 41.87 crore); supported 14,740 ha (**Rs 50.98 crore**) during 2024-25.

Kapas Kisan App: The Kapas Kisan mobile application (app) has been introduced to streamline the procurement process under the MSP system by enabling cotton growers to complete self-registration and book procurement slots on a four weeks rolling basis.

- Till date, over 41 lakh farmers registered, strengthening transparency and efficiency in MSP operations.

Kasturi Cotton Bharat (KCB): It is a flagship initiative of the MoT, aimed to enhance the value and global positioning of Indian cotton through **traceability, certification, and branding.**

- **Execution:** The programme is being implemented by MoT in partnership with the CCI and the Cotton Textiles Export Promotion Council (TEXPROCIL).
- **Budget:** It has a total outlay of **Rs 30 crore,** of which **Rs 15 crore** contributed by trade and industry bodies and remaining amount from the MoT
- **Key Progress:** So far, 116 units, including 41 ginners and 75 supply chain members, have renewed registration under this initiative. As of 30 June 2026, **3,29,550 bales** have been certified, including **3,22,400 bales** from CCI.

About Cotton Corporation of India Limited (CCI):

CCI, a Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) which works under the Ministry of Textiles (MoT), is mainly responsible for undertaking Minimum Support Price (MSP) operations for cotton procurement in India.
Chairman and Managing Director **(CMD)-** Lalit Kumar Gupta
Headquarters- Navi Mumbai, Mumbai
Established – 1970

NCVET Recognises NIRDPR as Dual Awarding Body to Strengthen NSQF-Aligned Skill Certification

In July 2026, the National Council for Vocational Education and Training **(NCVET)** signed an **agreement** with National Institute of Rural Development and Panchayati Raj **(NIRDPR),** under the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD), granting **NCVET recognition** as an Awarding Body **(AB-Dual)**.

- The agreement-signing ceremony was chaired by Niranjan Kumar Sudhansu, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), and Executive Member of NCVET, in the presence of officials from NCVET and NIRDPR.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Recognition of Awarding Body (Dual)
- ✓ **By Whom?** NCVET
- ✓ **Recipient:** NIRDPR, MoRD
- ✓ **Recognition:** Can assess, certify, and award NSQF-aligned qualifications
- ✓ **Approved Courses:** Industrial General Pest Management Technician; Micro-Credential on Own Source Revenue by Panchayats.

About NCVET Recognition:

Certification Authority: The recognition enables NIRDPR to assess, certify, and award National Skills Qualifications Framework (**NSQF**) - aligned qualifications through its own and affiliated training centres, strengthening rural skilling, vocational education, and entrepreneurship.

Qualifications: Under the initial rollout, NCVET approved two NIRDPR qualifications: Industrial General Pest Management Technician and a Micro-Credential on Generation and Mobilisation of Own Source Revenue by Panchayats.
Planned Categories: NIRDPR will roll out NCVET-approved programmes for rural youth, SHGs, and Panchayati Raj functionaries, focusing on industry skills, entrepreneurship, and capacity building.
Awarding Bodies: NCVET-recognised Awarding Bodies certify NSQF-aligned qualifications under two categories: Standard (certificate awarding only) and Dual (assessment, certification, and awarding).

- As of July 2026, NCVET has recognised 52 Standard and 107 Dual Awarding Bodies.

DIBD and Goa Government Organised 'BHASHINI Rajyam' to Advance AI-Powered Governance in Konkani and Indian Languages

On 21 July 2026, the Digital India BHASHINI (BHASHa INterface for India) Division **(DIBD)** under Digital India Corporation (DIC), the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), in collaboration with the Department of Information Technology (IT), Electronics & Communications (EC), **Government of Goa**, organised the **'BHASHINI Rajyam: State Engagement Workshop'** in Panaji, Goa.

- The event was attended by Goa Chief Minister (CM) **Dr. Pramod Sawant** and **Rohan A. Khaunte,** Ministers for IT, EC, Tourism, Printing & Stationery, Goa.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** BHASHINI Rajyam: State Engagement Workshop
- ✓ **Entities:** DIBD & Government of Goa
- ✓ **Where?** Panaji, Goa
- ✓ **Objective:** To strengthen the Konkani language ecosystem & promote AI-powered multilingual governance
- ✓ **Key Platforms:** BHASHINI App Mitra, BHASHINI Mitra, BHASHINI Pravakta.

About BHASHINI Rajyam Workshop:

Aim: The workshop aimed to promote multilingual Artificial Intelligence (AI), strengthened the **Konkani language** ecosystem, and expanded AI-powered multilingual access to citizen-centric government services.
AI Solutions: The workshop showcased **BHASHINI App** (application) **Mitra**, **BHASHINI Mitra**, and **BHASHINI Pravakta**, with live demonstrations of AI-powered translation, speech recognition, transcription, text-to-speech, transliteration, multilingual Application Programming Interfaces (APIs), and a voice-enabled citizen journey.
About DIBD: Established in **2022,** under DIC, MeitY, is India's national platform for AI-powered multilingual digital inclusion.

- It supports over 800 government websites, processes around 8 billion AI inferences (including nearly 20 million AI inferences daily), and provides services in 36 Indian text languages, 23 Indian voice languages, and 35 international languages.

DPIIT's OEA Released Revised Series of Index of Core Industries with Base Year 2022-23

In July 2026, the Office of Economic Adviser **(OEA)**, Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoCI) released the revised series of Index of Core Industries **(ICI)** with **Base Year 2022-23,** replacing the existing series of ICI with Base Year 2011-12.

- In addition, the OEA also released the provisional **ICI for June 2026,** which recorded a **5%** Year-on-Year (Y-o-Y) growth compared to 3.2% growth recorded in May 2026.

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- This growth was driven primarily by robust growth in Iron Ore, Electricity, Cement, Steel and Coal.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Revised Series of ICI
- ✓ **Released by:** OEA, DPIIT (MoCI)
- ✓ **Revised Base Year:** 2022-23
- ✓ **Replaces:** 2011-12 as Base Year
- ✓ **ICI for June 2026:** Recorded 5% (Y-o-Y) growth
- ✓ **Increase in Number of Core Industries:** from 08 to 09 (with inclusion of iron core)
- ✓ **Cumulative weight of 9 industries:** 32.88%
- ✓ **Linking Factor for the series:** 1.47

About ICI 2022-23:

Recommended by: The key changes introduced in the revised ICI series was based on the recommendations of a committee formed in November 2025 under the chairmanship of Praveen Mahto.

Aligns with data from April 2023: As per the OEA, the updated ICI series is released with retrospective data from April 2023 onwards, with back series released for analysis of historical data.

Monthly Release: Also, OEA has informed that the provisional data for ICI will continue to be released on the 20th of every month, or the next working day if the 20th falls on a holiday.

Key Changes:

Inclusion of Iron Ore: The revised ICI included **Iron ore** in the list of core industries due to its intensive use in the production process, and contribution to industrial development, increasing the number of core industries to **Nine** from existing Eight: coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, fertilisers, steel, cement, and electricity.

Gross Steel Production Accounting: Replaced the previous net production metric for steel with gross production data, establishing procedural consistency with the IIP framework.

Elimination of Double-Counting in Coal: Narrowed the coal index to track raw coal exclusively, excluding coal middlings and washed coal since both are derived from raw coal.

Industry-wise Weightage: The weights assigned to the core industries: Coal (1.840%); Natural Gas (1.263%); Crude Oil (2.443%); Refinery products (7.422%); Fertilizers (0.898%); Steel (5.782%); Cement (1.450%); Electricity (10.171%) and Iron Ore (1.613%); and are proportionately adjusted to total 100.

- Together, these nine core industries comprise **32.88%** of the weight of items included in the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), lower than the weight (40.266%) of 8 core industries in base year 2011-12.

Revisions in Methodology: The new ICI uses gross production data instead of net production for compiling the steel index.

- Also, OEA retained only raw coal in the coal category, while excluding the coal middling and washed coal to eliminate double counting, as both are derived from raw coal.

Linking Factor: The linking factor between ICI (2011-12) and ICI (2022-23) series has been calculated by taking the ratio of Geometric Means of the monthly ICI of the old series for 2022-23 and the monthly ICI of new series for 2022-23, therefore, the linking Factor for overall ICI is **1.47** to facilitate comparison between the two datasets.

Key highlights of ICI June 2026:

Cumulative Growth Rate: The combined growth rate of ICI during the 1st Quarter (Q1: April-June) **of the Financial Year** 2026-27 (FY27) stood at **3.6%** (Provisional Estimate), over the **1.0%** growth recorded in the corresponding period of the previous year.

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Sector-wise growth: Among all the nine sectors, **Iron Ore** recorded the highest annual growth of +43.9%; followed by Electricity and Cement (each recorded +9.8%); steel production (+4.6%), and coal (+1.4%) during the month of June 2026.

- In contrast, sectors like: Natural Gas (-7.4%), Refinery Products (-4.7%), Crude Oil (-4.2%) and Fertilizers (-3.3%) registered negative Y-o-Y growth during the month.

About Office of Economic Adviser (OEA):

Principal Economic Advisor- Yogita Swaroop

Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi

Raghu Vamsi Aerospace to Set Up Rs 600 Crore Superalloy Manufacturing Facility in Telangana

In July 2026, **Raghu Vamsi Aerospace Group** announced an investment of over **Rs 600 crore** to establish an integrated nickel-based superalloy manufacturing facility in **Telangana**. The announcement was made during the Farnborough International Airshow 2026 in the United Kingdom (UK).

- The project aims to strengthen India's domestic manufacturing capabilities for high-performance superalloys used in the aerospace, defence, energy and other strategic sectors, while reducing dependence on imports.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What:** Integrated nickel-based superalloy manufacturing facility
- ✓ **By?** Raghu Vamsi Aerospace Group
- ✓ **Investment:** Rs 600 crore
- ✓ **Location:** Telangana
- ✓ **Facility Size:** 50 acres
- ✓ **Commercial Production:** Targeted by January 2028
- ✓ **Project Lead:** Dr. S. K. Jha
- ✓ **Production Capacity:** 5,000 tonnes per year
- ✓ **Material Produced:** Nickel-based superalloys

Highlights of the Manufacturing Facility:

Project Leadership: The project will be led by Dr. S. K. Jha, former Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of Mishra Dhatu Nigam Limited (MIDHANI), India's premier special metals manufacturer.

Facility: Raghu Vamsi Aerospace Group will establish a **50-acre facility** near Hyderabad, Telangana, with a **5,000-tonne** annual capacity to manufacture nickel-based superalloys and specialised products such as round bars, wires, forgings, castings and tungsten carbide powders.

Commercial Operations: Commercial production from the facility is expected to commence in January 2028 after completion of construction, product qualification and certification processes.

Significance: The facility will reduce India's import dependence and strengthen strategic applications, including defence platforms, aero engines, space systems, gas turbines, nuclear energy and hydrogen technologies.

Raghu Vamsi Aerospace Group: Established in 2015 and headquartered in Hyderabad, Telangana, is a precision manufacturing and deep-tech company serving the aerospace, defence and energy sectors.

Union Minister Rajnath Singh Flags In First-Ever Tri-Service All-Women 'Samudra Pradakshina' Expedition

In July 2026, **Union Minister Rajnath Singh**, Ministry of Defence (MoD), virtually flagged off '**Samudra Pradakshina**', India's first-ever Tri-Service all-women circumnavigation sailing expedition.

- Indian Army Sailing Vessel **(IASV) Triveni,** crewed by nine women officers from the Indian Army (IA), Indian Navy (IN) and Indian Air Force (IAF), successfully completed a **314-day**

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global voyage covering nearly 25,500 nautical miles across four oceans, arriving at Mumbai, Maharashtra.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Virtually flagged in 'Samudra Pradakshina'
- ✓ **Who?** Union Minister Rajnath Singh, MoD
- ✓ **Significance:** India's first-ever Tri-Service all-women circumnavigation sailing expedition
- ✓ **Vessel:** IASV Triveni
- ✓ **Crew:** Nine women officers from IA, IN, IAF
- ✓ **Duration:** 314 days
- ✓ **Distance Covered:** ~25,500 nautical miles.

About Samudra Pradakshina Expedition:

Flag-Off: The expedition was originally virtually flagged off by Union Minister Rajnath Singh on **11 September 2025** from the Gateway of India, Mumbai.

Global Circumnavigation: The IASV Triveni team crossed all meridians of longitude, the Equator twice, the International Date Line, and the Three Great Capes (Cape Leeuwin, Cape Horn, and Cape of Good Hope).

- The crew navigated the Drake Passage and rounded Cape Horn, earning membership in the **elite fraternity of Cape Horners**.

Symbolism: The expedition is a symbol of **Nari Shakti** (women's power), joint military integration across services, and India's commitment to maritime prowess and international goodwill.

Navika Sagar Parikrama: Completed in 254 days (10 September 2017 – 21 May 2018), this expedition marked India's first all-women naval circumnavigation, demonstrating maritime skill, endurance, and operational excellence.

CSIR Transfers Four Indigenous Technologies to Industry & Commercially Launched Smart Rural Water Monitoring System

In July 2026, the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (**CSIR**) has transferred **four** indigenous technologies to industry and commercially launched an Internet of Things (IoT)-enabled rural water service delivery, measurement and monitoring system during the Technology Transfer Event at CSIR headquarters in New Delhi, Delhi.

- The programme, organized by CSIR-Central Scientific Instruments Organisation (CSIR-CSIO), Chandigarh, witnessed the transfer of four indigenous technologies to **Pump Academy Private Limited** and Bharat Electronics Limited **(BEL)** developed by the **CSIR-CSIO**, Chandigarh, Punjab.
- The event was presided over by **Dr. N. Kalaiselvi**, Director General (DG), CSIR and Secretary, Department of Scientific and Industrial Research (DSIR)

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Licensing of four CSIR technologies and commercial launch of Smart Rural Water Monitoring Technology
- ✓ **Developed by?** CSIR-CSIO
- ✓ **Where?** CSIR Headquarters, New Delhi
- ✓ **Pump Academy Private Limited License:** MSCOPE, PU-MPPM, IPQA
- ✓ **BEL License:** Optical Module & Beam Combiner Assembly for SU-30 HUD
- ✓ **Significance:** Received Rs.1.67 crore in royalties from Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL)
- ✓ **Biometry Technologies Private Limited:** commercially launched IoT-enabled rural water service delivery

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- ✓ **Purpose:** Promote commercial uptake of indigenous technologies; enhance rural water monitoring and management

Pump Academy Private Limited, Bengaluru (Karnataka) License:

Induction Motor Stethoscope (MSCOPE): An advanced acoustic and vibrational diagnostic tool designed to detect early mechanical and electrical faults in industrial induction motors.

Portable & Universal Motor-cum-Pump Performance Monitor (PU-MPPM): A portable device for evaluating the performance and efficiency of motors and pumps in real time.

i-Power Quality Analyser (IPQA): Measures and analyses electrical power quality parameters to improve energy efficiency.

BEL, Panchkula (Haryana) License:

Optical Module and Beam Combiner Assembly for Head-Up Display (HUD): The Optical Module and Beam Combiner Assembly designed for integration into the HUD systems of Su-30 MKI fighter aircraft will bolster indigenous defence manufacturing and enhance India's self-reliance in military avionics systems.

- During the event, CSIR-CSIO also received Rs.1.67 crore in royalties from **BEL**, for the licensed production of indigenous defence technologies including HUD, Drogue Lights, Taxi Landing Lights, HUD Level-I Tester, Boresight Alignment Tool

Commercial Launch of IoT-enabled Rural Water Monitoring System:

Capabilities: The system leverages IoT-enabled sensing technologies to improve the management of rural drinking water infrastructure by monitoring water quality and quantity in real time and tracking service delivery.

About Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR):

Role: CSIR will conduct scientific research across fields including engineering, environment, defence, health, and agriculture, while also focusing on technology development, patenting, licensing, and commercialisation to industry.

Established: 26 September 1942

Director General (**DG**): Dr. N. Kalaiselvi

Headquarters: New Delhi, Delhi

Bihar to Establish Permanent NSTI (Women) Campus and Skill India International Centre in Patna

In July 2026, the Government of Bihar and Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship **(MSDE)** announced the permanent National Skill Training Institute for Women **(NSTI-W)**, Patna campus and Skill India International Centre **(SIIC)**, Bihar to boost women's skilling and global employment opportunities.

- The initiative was announced by Chief Minister (CM) of Bihar **Samrat Choudhary**, and Minister of State (Independent Charge**) Jayant Chaudhary,** MSDE & Minister of State for Education, Government of India. The foundation stone was laid by **Dilip Kumar**, Director General, Directorate General of Training (DGT).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Project?** Permanent campus of NSTI (Women), Patna & Skill India International Centre
- ✓ **Location:** Bihta, Bihar
- ✓ **NSTI (W) Investment:** Rs 99.97 crore
- ✓ **SIIC Investment:** Rs 7 crore
- ✓ **Annual Training Capacity:** 435 trainees
- ✓ **Implementing Ministry:** MSDE
- ✓ **Training Schemes:** CITS & CTS

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Highlights of NSTI-W campus and SIIC In Patna:

Campus: The permanent National Skill Training Institute for Women (NSTI-W), Patna campus will be developed at Bihta, Bihar with an investment of **Rs 99.97 crore** to provide modern infrastructure and industry-aligned training.

- The Skill India International Centre **(SIIC)**, Bihar will be established with an investment of **Rs 7 crore** to support global employment through language training, certification and safe migration assistance.

Significance: The initiatives will strengthen Bihar's skill ecosystem, promote **women-led development** and create domestic as well as international employment opportunities for youth.

About NSTI: NSTI-W, Patna, inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is Bihar's only Central Government skill training institute for women, offering CITS and CTS courses.

PM Narendra Modi Constitutes Exam Reform Task Force Led by Nandan Nilekani

In July 2026, the Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** announced the constitution of six member high-powered task force, under the leadership of Infosys co-founder **Nandan Nilekani** to recommend comprehensive reforms to the examination system in India.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** High-powered Exam Reform Task Force formed
- ✓ **Announced By:** PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **Head:** Nandan Nilekani (Infosys Co-founder)
- ✓ **Members:** S. Somanath, Tapan Deka, V. Kamakoti, Anita Karwal & Amrit Lal Meena
- ✓ **Objective**: To recommend reforms for India's examination system
- ✓ **Reason:** NEET-UG paper leak controversy and concerns over exam irregularities.

Task Force Details:

Driving Factors: The panel was formed in response to nationwide protests over education reforms and concerns regarding exam paper leaks, particularly after the **NEET** (National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test)-**UG** (Under Graduate) paper leak controversy.

Objective: The panel was formed to reform the National Testing Agency (**NTA**) through technological enhancement and structural reforms.

Measures: The task force aims to recommend measures to strengthen the examination system through a high-level task force and proposed amendments to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act 2024, enabling time-bound investigations, fast-track trials, and stricter penalties for paper leaks and organised exam fraud.

Anti-Leak Measures: The legislation seeks to curb examination-related offences, including paper-leaks, through stringent penal provisions, fast-track courts and time-bound investigations.

Task Force Members:

The high-level task force comprises experts from technology, education, intelligence, and administration:

- Nandan Nilekani, Technology Expert (Chairperson)
- S. Somanath, Former Chairman, Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)
- Tapan Deka, Former Director, Intelligence Bureau (IB)
- V. Kamakoti, Director, Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Madras
- Anita Karwal, Former Education Secretary, Ministry of Education (MoE)
- Amrit Lal Meena, Logistics & Administration Expert, Former Secretary, Ministry of Coal

About National Testing Agency (NTA):

It is an autonomous body under the Department of Higher Education (DHE), Ministry of Education (MoE).

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

Established – 2017

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Maharashtra Becomes First State To Qualify For Second RKVY Installment

In July 2026, **Maharashtra** became the first state in India to qualify for the release of the **second installment** under the Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana **(RKVY)** after achieving the prescribed fund utilisation benchmark set by the Government of India (GoI).

- The decision was taken during the virtual review meeting, chaired by **Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan,** Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare **(MoA&FW),** conducted to review the utilisation of funds released under RKVY.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Maharashtra becomes 1st state to qualify for second RKVY Installment
- ✓ **Announced by:** Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, MoA&FW
- ✓ **Where?** Virtual Review Meeting for RKVY
- ✓ **1st Installment under RKVY:** Rs 335 crore
- ✓ **Total Funds Utilised:** Approximately Rs 260 crore
- ✓ **Condition to Qualify:** 75% fund utilisation benchmark

Key Details:

First Installment: Previously, the Government of India (GoI) released Rs 335 crore as the 1st installment under RKVY to the Government of Maharashtra.

Funds Utilized: Of the total amount released as 1st installment of the scheme, the state government has utilised **nearly Rs 260 crore,** which is more than prescribed 75% utilisation benchmark, thereby making the state eligible for the 2nd installment.

2nd Installment: Following the approval, the GoI will release the second installment of Rs 335 crore to the state government.

About Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (RKVY):

Background: Launched in 2007-2008, RKVY is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme of the Department of Agriculture & Co-operation (DAC), MoA&FW, designed to ensure holistic development of agriculture and allied sectors by allowing states to choose their own agriculture and allied sector development activities as per the district or state agriculture plan.

Target: To achieve 4% annual growth in the agriculture sector during the Eleventh Plan period.

Funding Structure: Initially, the scheme was launched as a Central Sector Scheme i.e. 100% funding by the GoI. But, since 2015-16, the funding pattern for the scheme changed into the Centrally Sponsored Scheme i.e. financial assistance provided by the GoI and respective state governments.

- Funding Ratio for States: 60:40 (GoI: States);
- Funding Ratio for North Eastern (NE) states and Himalayan states: 90:10;
- And, 100% funding by the GoI for all UTs.

Key Objectives: The scheme aims to incentivize the states so as to increase public investment in agriculture and allied sectors; provide autonomy to the state governments in the process of planning and implementing agriculture and allied sectors schemes, among others.

Allied Sectors Covered: Some of the allied sectors covered under the RKVY are: Crop husbandry (including horticulture); Animal Husbandry, Dairy Development and Fisheries; Food Storage and Warehousing; Soil and Water Conservation, among others.

RKVY-RAFTAAR: In November 2017, the Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi approved the continuation of RKVY as Rashtriya Krishi Yojana- Remunerative Approaches for Agriculture and Allied Sector Rejuvenation (RKVY-RAFTAAR) for a period of 3 years.

- Other than promoting agri-entrepreneurship and innovations, the scheme focuses on pre- and post-harvest infrastructure.

PM-RKVY: In October 2024, the Union Cabinet chaired by PM Modi, approved the rationalisation of all CSS operating under the MoA&FW into two umbrella schemes i.e. Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVY) and Krishonnati Yojana (KY), with total budget outlay of **Rs 1,01,321.61 crore.**

- PM-RKVY is designed to promote sustainable agriculture while KY aims to address food security and agricultural self-sufficiency.

About Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (MoA&FW):

Union Minister- Shivraj Singh Chouhan (Constituency- Madhya Pradesh, MP)
Minister of State **(MoS) –** Ram Nath Thakur (Rajya Sabha- Bihar); Bhagirath Choudhary (Constituency- Ajmer, Rajasthan)

India to Use Producer Price Index (PPI) for GDP Deflation

In July 2026, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation **(MoSPI)** announced plans to use the output Producer Price Index **(PPI)** as a deflator for quarterly and annual Gross Domestic Product (GDP) estimates, replacing the Wholesale Price Index **(WPI)** wherever applicable.

- The PPI series was released by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade **(DPIIT)** in **June 2026** to support improved GDP measurement and align India's national accounts with international standards.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Index?** Output PPI
- ✓ **Implemented By:** MoSPI
- ✓ **Purpose:** Improve GDP accuracy
- ✓ **Replaces:** WPI
- ✓ **Deflation Method:** Double deflation method
- ✓ **Previous Method:** Single deflation method

Highlights of PPI Adoption:

GDP Deflation: The **output PPI** will be used for GDP deflation to improve the accuracy of real growth measurement and reduce distortions in GDP estimates.

- In **June 2026**, WPI inflation rose to **9.87%** from **9.68% in May 2026**, while output PPI inflation increased to **9.57%** from **9.38%**.

Methodology Change: The revised GDP series updated the base year to 2022–23 from 2011–12 and adopted double deflation, which separately adjusts output and input prices.
Replacement of WPI: The WPI will be phased out as a GDP deflator, while the CPI will continue for specific granular items; the earlier **single deflation method** using WPI for output and input prices was replaced due to growth estimation distortions.
Implementation: MoSPI plans to introduce the new PPI-based methodology with GDP estimates for the April–June quarter of 2026–27. The back series data under the revised GDP series will also be released.
About PPI: PPI measures price changes received by producers for goods and services and is used for accurate GDP deflation.

Union Minister Piyush Goyal Announces Task Force to Support Toy Sector, Targets 5% Global Market Share by 2032

In July 2026, Union Minister, **Piyush Goyal,** Ministry of Commerce & Industry (MoC&I), announced the formation of a **Task Force** to support India's **toy sector** during the stakeholder meet **"Team Up for Toys:** Driving Steering Committee for Advancing Local Value Add and Employment **(SCALE)**, **Innovation** and **Exports**" organised by Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade **(DPIIT)** at Vanijya Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi.

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- The task force aims to strengthen the toy sector and achieve a 5% share in the global toy market by 2032.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Announced?** Task Force for India's Toy Sector
- ✓ **Launched by:** Union Minister Piyush Goyal, MoC&I
- ✓ **Organised by:** DPIIT
- ✓ **Event:** Team Up for Toys: Driving SCALE, Innovation and Exports
- ✓ **Venue:** Vanijya Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Target:** 5% global toy market share by 2032

Highlights of Toy Sector Initiative:

Six Key Focus Areas: The Task Force will focus on integrating India's toy industry with global value chains, strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities, addressing value chain bottlenecks, creating a skilled workforce and generating employment, promoting design and innovation, and enhancing the ease of doing business to improve the sector's global competitiveness.

Launch of Toy Sector Playbook: A roadmap for manufacturers, startups, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises **(MSMEs)** and investors covering standards, skills, innovation, intellectual property and exports.

Growth: India's toy ecosystem includes **21,000+ MSMEs**, 770+ **DPIIT** recognised startups, 50 toy clusters and **1,800+** Bureau of Indian Standards **(BIS)** licensees.

About Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT): The DPIIT, established in 1995 (renamed from DIPP in 2019), functions under the MoC&I. Headquartered in New Delhi, it is headed by Secretary Amardeep Singh Bhatia.

MoA&FW Allows Use of Anhydrous Ammonia Fertilizer to Reduce Urea Import Dependence

In **July 2026**, the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare **(MoA&FW)** permitted the manufacture and agricultural use of **Anhydrous Ammonia fertilizer** under the **Clause 20A** of the **Fertiliser (Inorganic, Organic or Mixed) (Control) Order, 1985**, for a **three-year** period, allowing fertilizer with a minimum nitrogen content of 82% to reduce India's dependence on imported urea.

- The move aims to promote an alternative nitrogen fertilizer, improve fertilizer-use efficiency, and reduce India's dependence on imported urea.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval for Use of Anhydrous Ammonia Fertilizer
- ✓ **Ministry:** MoA&FW
- ✓ **Validity:** Three years
- ✓ **Objective:** Reduce dependence on imported urea and improve nitrogen-use efficiency

About the Approval of Anhydrous Ammonia Fertilizer:

Background: India produces nearly 300 lakh tonnes (LT) of urea annually but still imports around 100 LT to meet rising domestic demand, highlighting the need to strengthen fertilizer security and reduce import dependence.

Features: Anhydrous ammonia contains **82% nitrogen,** making it one of the most concentrated nitrogen fertilizers, and unlike urea (46% nitrogen), it is stored under pressure and requires specialised underground injection equipment for safe and efficient application.

Trials: Field trials by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research **(ICAR)** during **Rabi 2025–26** showed improved biomass and crop greenness in some plots, though uniform application methods still require standardisation before large-scale adoption.

Green Ammonia: Under the National Green Hydrogen Mission (NGHM), the Centre plans to procure 7.24 lakh metric tonnes (LMT) of green ammonia annually for green urea production, with the Department of

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Fertilizers (DoF), MoA&FW, issuing an Expression of Interest (EOI) for Green Urea plants; a 1,200 tonnes per day (TPD) green ammonia plant requires an investment of Rs.13,000–15,000 crore.

Green Urea: A 150 TPD Green Urea pilot plant will be developed at Pudimadaka, Andhra Pradesh (AP), by NTPC Energy Technology Research Alliance (NETRA), the research and development arm of NTPC Limited, integrating Carbon Capture and Utilisation (CCUS) with water electrolysis.

Policy Support: A differential subsidy mechanism has been proposed whereby the Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI) supplies Green Ammonia at market-linked Grey Ammonia prices while the DoF bears the price differential.

Measures: To strengthen fertilizer security, the Government has diversified imports, expanded domestic production through six new urea plants, approved the National Investment Policy for Urea-2026 **(NIPU-2026)** through the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), and strengthened supply monitoring through the Integrated Fertilizer Management System **(iFMS)**.

About Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (MoA&FW):

Union Minister– Shivraj Singh Chouhan (Constituency- Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh, MP)

Minister of State **(MoS)** – Ram Nath Thakur (Rajya Sabha- Bihar); Bhagirath Choudhary (Constituency- Ajmer, Rajasthan)

MHA: Over 12,000 Registered Against Cyber Financial Fraud in 2025, Delhi Tops the List Among 18 States & UTs

In July 2026, Union Minister of State **(MoS) Bandi Sanjay Kumar,** Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), informed the Lok Sabha (also, known as the House of the People) that **over 12,000** Electronic Zero(e-Zero) First Information Reports (FIRs) were registered against cyber financial fraud in **18** states and Union Territories (UTs) in 2025.

- Among these all states and UTs, **Delhi** recorded the highest number of e-zero FIRs, with a total of 6,115 FIRs registered since May 2025, followed by **UT Chandigarh** with 4,174 FIRs (since November 2025).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Over 12,000 e-Zero FIRs registered in 2025
- ✓ **Source:** MHA
- ✓ **Launched:** May 2025
- ✓ **Coverage:** 18 States & UTs
- ✓ **Top 3:** Delhi (6,115), Chandigarh (4,174), Uttarakhand (552)
- ✓ **Purpose:** Faster registration and investigation of cyber financial fraud cases.

About e-Zero FIRs:

State-wise Data: Uttarakhand has registered **552 FIRs** (since March 2026), which is the 3rd highest number of e-Zero FIRs registered since its launch in 2025; followed by Goa (446, since January 2026); Rajasthan (251, since January 2026); Assam (223); Haryana (165); and Maharashtra (131).

Registration Process: Launched by the Government of India (GoI) in May 2025, the system enables cyber financial fraud victims to lodge complaints through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal **(NCRP) or the 1930 helpline,** which are forwarded to the concerned police station.

- Complainants must visit the police station within 3 days to convert the e-Zero FIR into a regular FIR.

Implementation: As of now, e-Zero FIR system is being implemented in 18 states and UTs, including UT of Delhi, UT of Chandigarh, Madhya Pradesh (MP), Rajasthan, Goa, Uttarakhand, West Bengal (WB), Assam, Odisha, Haryana, Gujarat, Tripura, Maharashtra, UT of Jammu & Kashmir (J&K); Tamil Nadu (TN), Telangana, Bihar and the Andaman and Nicobar (A&N) Islands.

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Significance: It enables the automatic registration of Zero FIRs for eligible cyber financial fraud complaints, ensuring faster investigation without jurisdictional delays.

About First Information Report (FIR):

Overview: An FIR is the first official record of a **cognizable offence**, allowing the police to register the case and begin an investigation without prior approval from a magistrate.

Significance: It marks the formal commencement of the criminal justice process.

About Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA):

Union Minister- Amit Shah (Constituency- Gandhinagar, Gujarat)

Minister of State **(MoS**)- Bandi Sanjay Kumar (Constituency- Karimnagar, Telangana); Nityanand Rai (Constituency-Ujiarpur, Bihar)

STATE NEWS

Biswanath Sinha Takes Charge as Kerala Chief Secretary

In July 2026, **Biswanath Sinha,** a 1992-batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer of the Kerala cadre, assumed charge as the Chief Secretary (CS) of Kerala. His tenure will extend until September 2028.

- He succeeded **Dr A. Jayathilak,** a 1991-batch IAS officer, who retired from service on 30 June 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Assumed charge as the Chief Secretary of Kerala.
- ✓ **Who?** Biswanath Sinha
- ✓ **Predecessor:** A. Jayathilak
- ✓ **Tenure:** Untill September 2028
- ✓ **Previous Post:** Additional Chief Secretary, Home and Vigilance Department, Kerala.

About Biswanath Sinha:

Career: With over three decades of administrative experience, he has handled internal security, police administration, vigilance and disaster-management matters.

Key Roles: He served as District Collector of Kottayam, Wayanad, and Kozhikode, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Rebuild Kerala Initiative, and held key roles in Finance, Planning & Economic Affairs, Store Purchase Departments, and Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change **(MoEFCC)**, Government of India.

Previous Role: Before becoming CS, he served as the Additional Chief Secretary (ACS), Home and Vigilance Department, Government of Kerala.

Role as CS: As Kerala's senior-most civil servant and administrative head, he will advise the Chief Minister (CM) and Council of Ministers, coordinate government departments, oversee policy implementation, and lead the State civil service.

TN Appoints Ex-ISRO Scientist Mylswamy Annadurai as Chairman of CDC for School Education

In June 2026, Government of Tamil Nadu **(TN)** appointed former Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO) scientist Mylswamy Annadurai** as **Chairman** of Curriculum Design Committee **(CDC) for School Education**, for a 3-year tenure to lead curriculum modernization for 1.3 crore students across the state.

- The initiative aims to modernise the school curriculum by strengthening science, technology, Artificial Intelligence (AI), and critical thinking skills while bridging gaps between teaching and learning systems.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Chairman of CDC for school education

- ✓ **Who?** Ex-ISRO scientist Mylswamy Annadurai
- ✓ **By Whom?** TN Government
- ✓ **Tenure:** 3 year
- ✓ **Focus Areas**: AI integration, science & technology focus, critical thinking, curriculum redesign, teaching-learning gap analysis.

About Mylswamy Annadurai:

Career: A distinguished former ISRO scientist (1982–2018) widely known as 'Moon Man of India', he contributed to over 60 satellites, led Chandrayaan-1, and played key roles in Chandrayaan-2 & the Mars Orbiter Mission (Mangalyaan), making India the fourth nation to reach Mars orbit in 2014.

Current Role: He currently serves as Vice President (VP) of the Tamil Nadu State Council for Science and Technology (TANSCST).

Awards: Received the **Padma Shri**, India's fourth-highest civilian award, in **2016** in the field of Science and Engineering.

Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel Launches Namo Swachhta Abhiyan and Amrutpan Abhiyan in Gandhinagar

In July 2026, **Bhupendra Patel,** Chief Minister (CM) of Gujarat, launched the statewide **'Namo Swachhta Abhiyan** (cleanliness drive)' and **'Amrutpan Abhiyan** (maternal health)**'** during an event organised on the occasion of National Doctors' Day (July 1) celebrations in Gandhinagar, Gujarat.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Two Campaigns in Gujarat
- ✓ **Campaign Names:** Namo Swachhta Abhiyan (cleanliness drive) and Amrutpan Abhiyan (maternal health)
- ✓ **Launched by:** Bhupendra Patel, CM of Gujarat
- ✓ **Occasion:** National Doctors' Day (July 01)
- ✓ **Conducted from:** July 1 to 7, 2026.

About Campaigns:

Namo Swachhta Abhiyan: It is a week-long cleanliness drive, scheduled to be held from July 1 to 7, 2026 across all 11,935 government hospitals and healthcare institutions in the state.

- Under this campaign, old furniture, obsolete medical equipment, and unnecessary records will be discarded to create a clean and hygienic environment in healthcare facilities.

Amrutpan Abhiyan: It is designed to ensure the health of mothers and children. Through awareness campaigns, the state government aims to ensure that every child receives proper nutrition and care from birth.

AEL and IRH Partner for USD 11.5 Billion Integrated Aluminium Project in Odisha

In July 2026, Adani Enterprises Limited **(AEL)** and International Resources Holding **(IRH)**, an International Holding Company (IHC) group entity, signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with the **Government of Odisha** in Bhubaneswar, Odisha, to develop a **USD 11.5 billion** (Rs.1.08 lakh crore) **integrated greenfield aluminium project**.

- The project will be developed through a 50:50 joint venture between AEL and IRH. IRH is an Abu Dhabi-based natural resources investment platform through 2PointZero under the International Holding Company (IHC).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Integrated Greenfield Aluminium Project MoU
- ✓ **Entities:** AEL & IRH with Government of Odisha
- ✓ **Where?** Bhubaneswar, Odisha, India

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- ✓ **Value:** USD 11.5 billion (Rs.1.08 lakh crore)
- ✓ **JV Structure:** 50:50 joint venture (AEL & IRH)
- ✓ **Objective:** Aluminium value chain development
- ✓ **Phase Investment:** Phase I Rs.66,000 crore; Phase II Rs.44,000 crore
- ✓ **Components:** Alumina refinery, aluminium smelter, captive power plant, downstream park

About Odisha Aluminium Project:

Objective: The project aims to strengthen India's aluminium manufacturing ecosystem by integrating mining, refining, smelting, power generation, and downstream manufacturing into a single industrial value chain to enhance global competitiveness.

Components: The project includes a 4 million metric tonnes per annum (MMTPA) alumina refinery, a 2 MMTPA aluminium smelter, a 4,000 megawatt (MW) captive power plant, and a 1 MMTPA downstream manufacturing park along with supporting infrastructure facilities.

Investment Structure: The project will be developed in two phases, with Phase I investment of **Rs.66,000 crore** and Phase II investment of **Rs.44,000 crore**, generating about 53,500 jobs including direct and indirect employment across construction, operations, logistics, engineering, and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME)-linked sectors.

Significance: The proposed project is set to become Odisha's largest Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) and India's biggest FDI in the metallurgy sector, aimed at strengthening the domestic aluminium industry and enhancing India's position in the global aluminium supply chain.

Delhi Government to Launch Rs 8300 Cr Air Pollution Project with World Bank

In July 2026, the Delhi Government led by Chief Minister (**CM**) **Rekha Gupta** announced a **Rs 8,300 Crore (Cr)** programme to tackle the air pollution in the national capital.

- The programme will be implemented with the support of the World Bank (**WB**).

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** Delhi Government announces Air pollution programme
- ✓ **Title:** Clean Air, Healthy Delhi
- ✓ **Cost:** Rs 8300 Cr
- ✓ **Supported by:** WB
- ✓ **Prepared by:** Environment Department
- ✓ **Funding Patter:** WB: Delhi Government – 65:35
- ✓ **Timeline:** 7 years, August 2026 to September 2033
- ✓ **Pillars:** 2, 1st – Focus on strengthening air quality management, 2nd – reducing emissions from major pollution sources

Air Pollution Project Details

Title: The project is titled as **"Clean Air, Healthy Delhi"**.

- This project will run in parallel to the existing plans to reduce Delhi's pollution.

Objective: The project prepared by the Environment Department aims to accelerate the objectives of the National Clean Air Programme (**NCAP**).

Implementation: The programme will be jointly implemented by the Environment Department, the Delhi Pollution Control Committee, the Transport Department, the Public Works Department, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, the Delhi Jal Board, the Delhi Development Authority, the New Delhi Municipal Council and the Delhi Traffic Police.

- The Department of Economic Affairs and the World Bank will also be key partners.

Funding pattern: The project will be jointly funded by the Delhi Government and the WB.

- The WB will finance **65%** of the project cost and the government will contribute the remaining **35%**.

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Timeline: The project will be completed in **seven** years across all districts, from September 2026 to August 2033.
Focus: The project will focus on sectors such as transport, road dust, construction and demolition (**C&D**) waste, solid waste management, industry, green spaces and water pollution.
Two Pillars: The project is based on **two** major pillars.

- The first focuses on strengthening air quality management and the second focuses on reducing emissions from major pollution sources.

Pillar One: Under this pillar, a dedicated Project Management Unit (**PMU**) will be set up for implementation.

- Upgraded air quality monitoring systems and enhanced capabilities to analyse data will be developed.
- The project also plans closer coordination with states in the Indo-Gangetic Plain, scientific planning, public awareness campaigns and the adoption of new technologies.

Pillar Two: Under this, older and polluting vehicles will be phased out and Electric Vehicles (**EVs**) will be promoted.

- Also, an advanced Pollution Under Control (**PUC**) monitoring system will be developed to track vehicular emissions.

Air Pollution in India: World Air Quality Report 2025

- India ranked 6th among the world's most polluted countries, with an average PM2.5 concentration of 48.9 $\mu g/m^3$, nearly 10 times the WHO guideline of 5 $\mu g/m^3$.
- Loni (Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh) was the world's most polluted city, followed by Byrnihat (Meghalaya) (3rd) and Delhi (4th).

About National Capital Territory (NCT) Delhi:
Chief Minister **(CM) –** Rekha Gupta
Lieutenant Governor – Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu
Capital – New Delhi

WB Government Announces Rs 313 Crore Special Package for Tea Garden Workers under PMCSPY

In July 2026, **SuvendhuAdhikari,** Chief Minister (CM) of West Bengal (WB) announced **Rs 313 crore** special assistance for **tea garden workers** in the state, under the Pradhan Mantri Cha Shramik Protsahan Yojana **(PMCSPY).**

- The announcement was made following a state-level committee approved the implementation plan for PMCSPY.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announcement of Special Package for WB's Tea Garden Workers
- ✓ **Announced by:** Suvendhu Adhikari, CM of WB
- ✓ **Related Scheme:** PMCSPY
- ✓ **Total Amount:** Rs 313 crore
- ✓ **Key Allocation:** CSSY(Rs.177 crore); CSSSY(Rs.72 crore); CSAY(Rs.63 crore)
- ✓ **Executing Agency:** NBDD.

Key Details:

Component-wise Allocation: Rs 177 crore has been earmarked for Cha Shramik Shiksha Yojana (CSSY) component to boost educational infrastructure and quality interventions for families of tea workers.

- **Rs 72 crore** allocated for Cha Shramik Swasthya Suraksha Yojana (CSSSY) component to upgrade health facilities and ensure robust medical services in tea garden areas.

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- **Rs 63 crore** for Cha Shramik Aashray Yojana (CSAY) component to construct 321 resting sheds (88 in hilly areas and 233 in the plains), equipped with modern amenities such as off-grid solar power, clean drinking water, among others.

Implementing Agency: The North Bengal Development Department **(NBDD)** will serve as the nodal implementing agency for the effective execution of the scheme across the state.

About PMCSPY: It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS), designed specifically to enhance the living standards of tea garden workers and their families in two major tea-producing states (Assam and WB).

- It was initially launched for Financial Years 2024–25 (FY25) and 2025–26 (FY26) with an outlay of Rs.1,000 crore. Its implementation has been extended for one year, until FY27.

UP Cabinet Approves Renaming of Jalalabad Town as Parashurampuri

On 6 July 2026, the Uttar Pradesh **(UP)** Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister (CM) Yogi Adityanath, approved the proposal to rename **Jalalabad town** in Shahjahanpur district, UP, as **Parashurampuri**.

- The town's municipal body will also be renamed Parashurampuri Nagar Palika Parishad.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** UP approved the renaming of Jalalabad town
- ✓ **New Name:** Parashurampuri
- ✓ **District:** Shahjahanpur
- ✓ **Approval:** MHA issued a NOC in August 2025
- ✓ **Reason:** Birthplace of Lord Parashuram (Sixth avatar of Lord Vishnu).

Renaming of Jalalabad Town:

Reason: The renaming highlights the town's historical and religious significance as it is believed to be the **birthplace of Lord Parashuram.**

- The previous name Jalalabad was linked to Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar during the Mughal period.

Process: The proposal was supported by the Nagar Palika Parishad through resolutions passed in 2018 and 2023. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) issued a No Objection Certificate (NOC) on 19 August 2025 after receiving the State government's proposal.

Implementation: The new name will take effect after the completion of the required administrative and legal formalities.

Other Approvals: The UP Cabinet also approved 28 proposals, including the establishment of the Startup Mission Directorate, the UP Startup Policy, and the Data Centre Policy to promote innovation and digital infrastructure.

Assam FM Jayanta Malla Baruah Presents Rs 2.85 Lakh Cr budget for FY27

In July 2026, **Jayanta Malla Baruah**, Finance Minister (FM) of Assam, presented the State Budget for Financial Year 2026-27 **(FY27)** with a total outlay of **Rs 2,85,084 crore** (Cr) in the Assam Legislative Assembly in Dispur, Assam.

- The budget focuses on infrastructure development, social welfare, education, healthcare, agriculture, and economic growth of the state.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Assam FM presents Rs 2.85 lakh cr budget for FY27
- ✓ **Fiscal Position:**
- ✓ **Total Receipts:** Rs 2,88,309.45 Cr
- ✓ **Total expenses:** Rs 2,85,084.45 Cr
- ✓ **Deficit:** Rs 419.26 Cr, 3% of GSDP
- ✓ **Major Allocations:**

- ✓ Power Sector: Rs. 77,353 crore investment pipeline
- ✓ Infrastructure: Asom Mala 4.0 – Rs. 10,000 crore
- ✓ Aerotropolis: Rs. 2,100 crore for land acquisition
- ✓ Irrigation: Rs. 3,000–4,000 crore investment plan over 5 years
- ✓ Welfare Schemes: More than Rs. 6,000 crore allocated; Orunodoi Scheme (Rs. 1,500 per month)
- ✓ **Key Announcements:**
- ✓ Second Capital: Dibrugarh with Rs. 500 crore support
- ✓ Employment: Creation of 2 lakh jobs over the next 5 years
- ✓ Healthcare: One MBBS doctor at every sub-centre
- ✓ Education: Rs. 100 crore for Gauhati University and Rs. 2 crore each for 27 autonomous colleges.

Fiscal Indicators:

Receipts: The total receipts in the Consolidated Fund of Assam for FY27 are estimated at **Rs. 1,51,843.23 Cr**, comprising Rs. 1,18,562.23 Cr under the revenue account and Rs. 33,281 Cr under the capital account.
Expenditure: The total expenditure from the Consolidated Fund of Assam is projected at Rs. 1,56,714.88 Cr, comprising Rs. 1,18,562.23 Cr as revenue expenditure and Rs. 38,152.65 Cr as capital expenditure (CapEx).
Overall Estimate: The budget estimates total receipts at **Rs 2,88,309.45 Cr,** including transactions under the Public Account and Rs 2,000 Cr from the Contingency Fund, while total expenditure is pegged at **Rs 2,85,084.45 Cr**.
Deficit: The estimated surplus in transactions for the year is around Rs **3,225 Cr**.

- After adjusting the opening deficit of Rs 3,644.26 Cr, the overall deficit is projected at **Rs 419.26 Cr** by the end of the FY27.
- The state has set a fiscal deficit target of **3%** of the Gross State Domestic Product (**GSDP**) for FY27.

Tax Revenue: The budget also highlighted Assam's increased share in central tax devolution, rising from 3.128% to **3.158%**, which is expected to bring nearly **Rs 50,000 Cr** in additional Central funds over the coming years.

Key Allocations:

Infrastructure Development: Infrastructure remained a key focus area of the Assam Budget 2026-27.

- The government announced **Asom Mala 4.0** to construct 800 kilometer (km) of roads over the next five years with an estimated cost of Rs. 10,000 crore, along with an allocation of Rs. 2,100 crore for land acquisition for the proposed Aerotropolis near Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport and Rs. 500 crore over five years for developing the Dibrugarh State Capital Region.

Power Sector Development: The Assam Budget 2026-27 announced a **Rs. 77,353 crore** investment pipeline for the power sector to transform Assam into a power-surplus state.

- The proposed investments include Rs. 40,000 crore for a 3,200 MW thermal power plant, Rs. 27,100 crore for four pumped storage projects, Rs. 2,617 crore for 11 small hydel projects, Rs. 2,410 crore for the Lower Kopili Hydroelectric Project, Rs. 456 crore for solar projects, Rs. 170 crore for battery energy storage systems, and Rs. 4,600 crore for transmission and power evacuation infrastructure.

Agriculture & Irrigation: The Assam Government proposed an irrigation expansion programme with an estimated investment of Rs. 3,000–4,000 crore over the next five years.

- It allocated Rs. 200 crore in FY27 for preparing a comprehensive irrigation plan and Rs. 100 crore for promoting organic certification and agricultural exports.

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Welfare Schemes: The Assam Budget 2026-27 allocated more than **Rs. 6,000 crore** for flagship welfare schemes, including Orunodoi, pensions, student assistance, farmer support, and tea garden welfare programmes.

- **Orunodoi scheme:** Orunodoi scheme, which provides monthly support of **Rs 1,500 per month** to women-led households, covers nearly **40 lakh families** and the payments will resume from August 2026.
- Also, the government confirmed that it will continue to provide old age pension and widow pension schemes through **Orunodoi plus**.
- **Jibon Prerana:** The government will resume this initiative, which will provide financial assistance of **Rs 2500** per month to 48,366 graduates in their transition from education to employment.
- **Scooter Distribution:** This year, around **18,000** students will be eligible to get scooters under Dr. Banikanta Kakati Merit Award.
- **PM-KISAN:** The government shall continue supporting small and

marginal farmers through **Mukhya Mantrir Krishi Sa-Sajuli Yojana**, providing annual assistance of **Rs.11,000** to every eligible small and marginal farmer through convergence with PM-KISAN (Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi).

- **Farmers Assistance:** The other welfare schemes for farmers include:
- Rs 1,500 monthly assistance to 621 Udasin Bhakts (Monks)
- Rs 5 per litre gap support for dairy farmers
- **HIV/AIDs:** The government will resume targeted social support to HIV (Human Immunodeficiency Virus)/AIDS (Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome) affected families through financial assistance of **Rs.1 lakh**

each to eligible infected/affected children and widows of deceased HIV/AIDS patients.

Major Projects:

Colleges: Assam aims to raise the number of medical colleges to **28.**

- Four new medical colleges will come up in Goalpara, Hailakandi, Hojai and Bajali.

Education Roadmap: One university, one medical college and one engineering college will be set up in every district.

- Funding of Rs 100 Cr is proposed for Gauhati University and 27 autonomous colleges will receive Rs 2 Cr each

Revenue Mobilisation: To enhance revenue collection, the Assam Government proposed introducing a Geographic Information System (GIS)-based property valuation system, implementing an e-Khazana-based land revenue collection mechanism, expanding compulsory property registration, and launching a One-Time Settlement (OTS) scheme for pending tax and vehicle fitness dues.

Major Announcements:

Second Capital: The government will develop **Dibrugarh** as Assam's Second State Capital Region, with an initial support of **Rs 500 Cr.**

Health Plans: Every sub-centre will get at least one MBBS doctor.

- Every Assembly constituency will have at least one 50-bedded FRU (First Referral Unit).

Agriculture Support: Exporters will receive support through **Rs 100 Cr** NABARD (National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development)-backed funding.

- Subsidy for orthodox and specialty tea will rise from Rs 10/kg to Rs **15/kg (Kilogram).**

Tax Benefits: The FM proposes a **four-fold** increase in the tax exemption limit for small tea growers, a reduction in VAT (Value Added Tax) on piped natural gas by nearly **10%.**

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Job Creation:

Government Jobs: The government will create **2 lakh** additional employment opportunities over the next **5 years** across the public sector ecosystem.

- A task force headed by the **Chief Secretary** has been formed to prepare the recruitment roadmap.
- In the last 5 years, the Government has promised 1 lakh jobs and has exceeded the commitment by providing **1.64 lakh** appointments.

Healthcare: The state plans to recruit **33,000** healthcare personnel to strengthen public health services and continue teacher recruitment in universities, colleges and newly established educational institutions.

About Assam:

Chief Minister **(CM)**– Himanta Biswa Sarma
Governor– Lakshman Prasad Acharya
Capital– Dispur
National Parks **(NPs)**– Kaziranga NP, Manas NP

UP CM Yogi Adityanath Renames Ayodhya's Bhadarsa Town As 'Bharat Nagar'

In July 2026, Yogi Adityanath, Chief Minister (CM), Uttar Pradesh **(UP)** renamed the **'Bhadarsa town'** in Ayodhya district as **'Bharat Nagar'** to honor the town's cultural and spiritual heritage and its connection to the nearby historical site of **Bharat Kund**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Renaming of Bhadarsa town in UP
- ✓ **New Name:** Bharat Nagar
- ✓ **Announced by:** Yogi Adityanath, CM, UP
- ✓ **Purpose:** Promote cultural heritage and historical identity.

Context of Renaming:

Significance: The renaming aims to strengthen tourism and civic awareness, linking the town's identity with India's broader cultural narrative.
Honors: The renaming directly honors Bharat, the younger brother of Lord Ram, whose devotion and ultimate sacrifice serve as an enduring foundational pillar of Ayodhya's history.
Implementation: The UP Government has initiated the process of updating the new name in official records and administrative documents in accordance with the prescribed procedures.
Other Announcements: Also renamed the newly constituted **Khiloni-Suchitaganj** nagar panchayat in Ayodhya district as Maa Jwala Ji Nagar Panchayat.

Google India Signs MoU With Tripura to Build AI Ecosystem

In July 2026, **Google India** signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the Government of **Tripura** to enhance its Artificial Intelligence (**AI**) capabilities, cloud infrastructure and modernisation of citizen services, during **Destination Tripura Business Conclave 2026** held at the International Fair Ground in Hapania, Tripura.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to build AI ecosystem
- ✓ **Parties Involved:** Google India and Tripura
- ✓ **Occasion:** Destination Tripura Business Conclave 2026
- ✓ **Objective:** Enhance AI capabilities, cloud infrastructure, and digital services
- ✓ **Key Initiatives:** Tripura IT & Data Ecosystem Zone and AI CoE.

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Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The partnership will enable Tripura to leverage Google's technology expertise for promoting advanced solutions in governance, citizen services, education, entrepreneurship, workforce development, and public administration.

Focus: The MoU focuses on creating extensive training and digital literacy programs, aiming to cultivate Tripura's annual **5,000 technical graduates** into a skilled workforce for upcoming Global Capability Centres (**GCCs**), data facilities, and AI research hubs.

Ecosystem: The Tripura IT (Information Technology) & Data Ecosystem Zone (**TIDEZ**), along with a 10-acre IT Park housing an AI Centre of Excellence (CoE), will act as the physical backbone for these initiatives.

Other Collaborations: Tripura also signed 43 agreements worth more than Rs. 10,000 crore and 11 Expressions of Interest (EoIs) across the IT, healthcare, and infrastructure sectors.

About Google India: A subsidiary of Google LLC, it was established in 2004 and is headquartered in Hyderabad, Telangana.

TN CM C. JosephVijay Launched "Nalam TN" AI-powered Whatsapp Chatbot" for OP Registration

In July 2026, **C. Joseph Vijay,** Chief Minister (CM) of Tamil Nadu (TN) launched **"Nalam TN",** an integrated digital platform designed to provide fast and remote Outpatient (OP) registration and appointments at the government hospitals across the state, at an event held in Presidency College Auditorium, Chennai (TN).

- The Artificial Intelligence (AI)-powered WhatsApp chatbot enables users to book appointments remotely, eliminating physical registration queues and enhancing accessibility to healthcare services.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Naam TN, AI-enabled Whatsapp Chatbot
- ✓ **Launched by:** C. Joseph Vijay, CM of TN
- ✓ **Key Benefit:** fast and remote OP registration and appointments
- ✓ **Available at:** Government Hospitals across the state
- ✓ **Platform Live in:** 22 districts (including Chennai and Chengalpattu)
- ✓ **Portal:** Launched Tamil Nadu Health Foundation (Nalam TN)

Key Details:

Pilot-basis Launch: For the initial phase, the new health digital platform is live in 22 districts, including Chennai, and Chengalpattu, of the state.

Portal: He also launched the Tamil Nadu Health Foundation (Nalam TN) portal, a Section 8 non-profit company incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013, and functioning under the Tamil Nadu Health & Family Welfare Department, enabling individuals and corporates to transparently sponsor medical equipment or donate directly to specific government hospitals.

Other Key Launch: In addition, TN CM Vijay inaugurated healthcare infrastructure worth Rs 139.47 crore, aimed to expand medical facilities, including patient wards and diagnostic equipment; and handed over appointment orders to over 2,000 newly recruited healthcare professionals.

MP Secures USD 2 Billion Semiconductor Investment from Spain's Submer

In July 2026, Spain-based **Submer Group,** a technology company specialising in sustainable data centre cooling solutions, announced an investment of **USD 2 billion** (around Rs 19,000 crore) in **Madhya Pradesh**'s (MP) semiconductor sector.

- The investment was announced during the MP Tech Growth Conclave 3.0: GCC – Data Centres and Semiconductors held in Bhopal, MP.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announces USD 2 billion semiconductor investment in MP
- ✓ **By Whom?** Submer Group (Spain)
- ✓ **Announced At:** MP Tech Growth Conclave 3.0 in Bhopal, MP
- ✓ **Facilities:** Wafer fabrication, Assembly, Testing & Packaging for advanced Integrated Circuits
- ✓ **Aim:** Strengthen India's Semiconductor Mission and local manufacturing
- ✓ **Key MoU:** Google Play India and MPSEDC to strengthen the digital ecosystem.

Key Details of Investment:

Facilities: The USD 2 billion investment will establish wafer fabrication, assembly, testing, and packaging (ATMP) facilities for advanced integrated circuit (IC) manufacturing.

Aim: The project aims to strengthen local semiconductor manufacturing capabilities and support India's Semiconductor Mission and semiconductor policy.

MoU Exchange: During the conclave, a key Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was exchanged between Google Play India and the MP State Electronics Development Corporation (MPSEDC) to strengthen the state's digital ecosystem.

AR Signs MoU with Norway's Tidal Sail AS for India's First River Kinetic Energy Demonstration Project

In July 2026, the Government of Arunachal Pradesh **(AR)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with Norway's **Tidal Sail AS** to implement a 500-kilowatt (kw) **River Kinetic Energy Demonstration Project**, paving the way for **India's first** River Kinetic Energy Demonstration Plant.

- The project will be implemented through the Centre for Earth Sciences & Himalayan Studies **(CES&HS)** under the India-Norway Green Partnership, with support from the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) and Innovation Norway.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU for India's first River Kinetic Energy Demonstration Project
- ✓ **Project Capacity:** 500 kW
- ✓ **Who?** Government of AR & Tidal Sail AS (Norway)
- ✓ **Objective:** India's first River Kinetic Energy Demonstration Plant
- ✓ **Implemented By:** CES&HS
- ✓ **Partnership:** India-Norway Green Partnership

About the Energy Demonstration project:

Technology: The project will generate clean electricity from river currents without major civil infrastructure, offering a cost-effective renewable energy solution.

Energy Security: It will provide **decentralised power** to remote areas, reduce fossil fuel dependence and carbon emissions, and strengthen Arunachal Pradesh's clean energy portfolio.

India-Norway Cooperation: The initiative will enhance collaboration in renewable energy, geothermal energy, and sustainable infrastructure.

About River Kinetic Energy: River kinetic energy is a hydrokinetic renewable energy technology that generates electricity from the natural flow of river currents using submerged turbines, without the need for dams or reservoirs.

Telangana Teams Up with Microsoft to Set Up Green Skills CoE in Hyderabad

In July 2026, the Government of **Telangana** signed an MoU with **Microsoft, a** leading American multinational technology company, to establish a **Green Skills Centre of Excellence** (CoE) in **Hyderabad**, Telangana to equip students and professionals with industry-relevant green skills and support sustainable

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workforce development.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to establish a Green Skills CoE in Hyderabad
- ✓ **Entities:** Government of Telangana and Microsoft
- ✓ **Objective:** Develop AI and green manufacturing skills for youth
- ✓ Focus Area: Green Pharma
- ✓ **Collaborators:** Microsoft, 1M1B Foundation, and MeitY Startup Hub
- ✓ **Aligned With:** Next-Generation Life Sciences Policy 2026–30 and Green Pharma City strategy.

About Green Skills CoE:

Objective: The Green Skills CoE, expected to become operational by **August 2026,** aims to equip youth with skills in Artificial Intelligence (AI) and sustainable manufacturing, while supporting Telangana's life sciences and green manufacturing sectors.

Collaboration: The centre, with a focus on Green Pharma, is being established in collaboration with Microsoft, the **1M1B Foundation** (One Million for One Billion), and the **MeitY Startup Hub** under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY).

Alignment: The initiative aligns with Telangana's 'Next-Generation Life Sciences Policy 2026–30' and the state's 'Green Pharma City strategy.'

Sikkim CM Prem Singh Tamang Presents Rs 19,215 Cr Annual Budget for FY27, Prioritising Healthcare, Infrastructure and Social Welfare

In July 2026, the **Sikkim** Chief Minister (CM) and Finance Minister (FM) **Prem Singh Tamang** presented the

'Annual Budget for the Financial Year 2026–27 **(FY27)**', with a total outlay of **Rs 19,215 crore**, in the Sikkim Legislative Assembly at Gangtok, Sikkim.

- The FY27 Budget focuses on **five priorities:** productive sectors, infrastructure & connectivity, human capital, sustainable growth, and planned urbanisation

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Presented Rs 19,215 Cr annual budget for FY27
- ✓ **Presented by:** Prem Singh Tamang, CM & FM of Sikkim
- ✓ **Vision**: "Sunaulo, Samriddha ani Samarth Sikkim"
- ✓ **Fiscal Highlights:** Revenue Expenditure (Rs 11,733 Cr); Capital Expenditure (Rs 5,896 Cr)
- ✓ **GSDP (FY27)**: Rs 62,973 Cr; Target annual growth >13%
- ✓ **Key Initiatives:**
- ✓ Healthcare: HPV screening, 1st Renal Transplant Programme, ART Centre at STNM Hospital
- ✓ Education: 100 MBBS seats at Sikkim Government Medical College; SATHEE–IIT Kanpur collaboration
- ✓ Farmers: 1% KCC crop loan interest under State Interest Subvention Scheme
- ✓ Agriculture Mission: Mero Alaichi, Mero Dhan Mission for large cardamom revival
- ✓ Infrastructure: Rs 546 Cr for 570 km road upgradation; ADB-assisted SPSDP; 92,000+ smart meters
- ✓ **Key Bills:** AYUSH Medical Council Bill, Education Bills, Skill Education Repealing Bill & Fire Services (Amendment) Bill (EoDB)
- ✓ **New Reforms:** e-Sanction, e-Payment, e-Receipt System, e-Voucher System.

Fiscal Position:

Expenditure: The Revenue Expenditure (**RE**) has been estimated at **Rs 11,733 Cr** and **Rs 5,896 Cr** has been allocated for the Capital Expenditure (**CE**), excluding loans and advances.

- The net expenditure is **Rs 18,455 Cr,** after accounting Rs 760 Cr for recoveries.

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Receipts: The FY27 Budget estimates total receipts from tax revenue (Rs 2,275 crore), non-tax revenue (Rs 1,124 crore), the state's share of Central taxes (Rs 5,113 crore), Central grants (Rs 3,867 crore), borrowings (Rs 2,765 crore), and Rs 3,312 crore under the Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI) Scheme.

GSDP Outlook: The State Government has projected Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) at Rs 62,973 crore at current prices for FY27.

- The state recorded an average real GSDP growth of over 12.6% during the last eight years and aims to sustain annual growth above 13% through sound governance and strategic investments.

Key Allocations:

Vision: The FY27 Budget serves as a roadmap for "Sunaulo, Samriddha ani Samarth Sikkim", reaffirming the government's commitment to inclusive and sustainable development.

Scheme Allocation: The state has reserved **Rs 2,460 Cr** for Centrally Sponsored Schemes (**CSS**) to accelerate development across sectors.

- The FY27 Budget introduced a 'State Interest Subvention Scheme', reducing the effective interest rate on Kisan Credit Card (KCC) crop loans to 1% for eligible farmers who repay on time.
- It also launched the 'Mero Alaichi, Mero Dhan Mission' to revive the large cardamom sector through scientific research, disease-resistant varieties, and farmer field laboratories.

Healthcare Announcement:

Elimination of Cervical Cancer: The State government proposed to provide statewide Human Papilloma Virus **(HPV) screening** to around 1.5 lakh women aged 30 to 65 years as part of its efforts to eliminate cervical cancer.

Renal Transplant programme: The CM announced the operationalisation of Sikkim's first Renal Transplant Programme at STNM Hospital during the current financial year, enabling patients to undergo kidney transplantation within the state.

Fertility Center: An Assisted Reproductive Technology (**ART**) Centre will be established at STNM Hospital to help address the state's declining fertility rate.

Education Reforms:

Budget Allocation: Education remains one of the highest priorities of the government, with nearly **15%** of the State Budget dedicated to this sector.

MBBS Admission: Sikkim Government Medical College at Sochakgang will commence admissions with an annual intake of **100** Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery**(MBBS)** students from the 2026–27 academic year.

Collaboration: The government also plans to collaborate with Indian Institutes of Technology **(IIT) Kanpur** under the **SATHEE** (Self-Assessment, Test and Help for Entrance Exams) initiative to provide free national-level coaching.

- The SATHEE initiative is a free, interactive learning and assessment platform launched by the Ministry of Education (MoE) in association with IIT Kanpur.

Infrastructure Initiatives:

Road upgradation: The FY27 Budget provides **Rs 546 crore** to upgrade 570 kilometer(km) of roads with Mastic Asphalt Surfacing.

- It also continues the Asian Development Bank (ADB)-assisted Sikkim Power Sector Development Project (SPSDP), with 92,000+ smart meter already installed, alongside plans for satellite townships around Gangtok and the revitalisation of the capital's historic core.

Public Financial Management Reforms:

New Reforms: Introduction of electronic**(e)-Sanction** for digital approval of administrative and financial sanctions.

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- Strengthening of the **e-Payment** ecosystem through treasury-bank integration.
- Introduction of an **e-Receipt System** for government revenue collection and an **e-Voucher System** with complete digital audit trails.

Key Bills Introduced: The Sikkim Legislative Assembly introduced **few Bills**,

- Sikkim Medical Council for Indian System of Medicine Bill, 2026 to regulate AYUSH practitioners,
- Education-related Bills to strengthen private universities, open schooling, and vocational education
- National Council for Skill Education, Sikkim (Repealing) Bill, 2026 and
- Sikkim Fire and Emergency Services (Amendment) Bill, 2026 to decriminalise minor regulatory offences and improve the ease of doing business (EoDB).

About Sikkim:

Chief Minister **(CM)**– Prem Singh Tamang
Governor– Om Prakash Mathur
Capital– Gangtok
Ramsar site– Khachoedpalri Wetland

VTU, Google Enter Academic Agreement to Boost AI Skills and Campus Placements

In July 2026, Visvesvaraya Technological University (**VTU**), Bengaluru (Karnataka) signed an **academic collaboration** agreement with **Google LLC** to provide Artificial Intelligence (AI) and other industry-relevant skill modules to students and faculty of VTU.

- The agreement was signed by **Dr S. Vidyashankar**, Vice-Chancellor, VTU, and **Sanjay Jain**, Head of Google for Education, India in Bengaluru.
- VTU has also entered into similar collaborations with Qualcomm, and Bharat Skills Foundation.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Academic collaboration agreement signed
- ✓ **University:** Visvesvaraya Technological University (VTU)
- ✓ **Partnerships:** Google, Qualcomm, Bharat Skills Foundation
- ✓ **Objective:** Enhance AI and industry-relevant skills and improve campus placements
- ✓ **Training Areas:** AI, ML, Cloud Computing, Data Science, Cybersecurity, IoT, Embedded Systems, Product Prototyping.

Key Details of Agreement:

Objective: The collaboration aims to bridge the gap between academia and industry by integrating Google's AI technologies, certification programmes, and digital learning resources into VTU's academic ecosystem.

Access: Under the agreement, students will receive access to Google's educational content for a subsidised fee of Rs. 350

Industry Support: Stem Lore Innovators LLP, a subsidiary of Qualcomm, will provide training in Artificial Intelligence (AI), Internet of Things (IoT), embedded systems, and product prototyping, while also establishing a Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Edge AI.

Other Initiatives: The BSF will introduce skill-oriented courses on project-based learning, JavaScript, and data documentation.

- VTU will also launch the Skilling, Employability, and Entrepreneurship Learning (SEEL) programme through its Mysuru e-Learning Centre.

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GOVT SCHEMES

CENTRAL GOVT SCHEMES

MoF Retains Interest Rates on SSS unchanged for Q2FY27, No Revision for 9th consecutive quarter

On 30 June 2026, the Department of Economic Affairs (**DEA**) under the Ministry of Finance (**MoF**) kept the interest rates unchanged on all Small Savings Scheme (**SSS**) for **Q2 Financial Year 2026-27 (FY27)** i.e. from July 1, 2026 to September 30, 2026, maintaining the same rate as **Q1FY27 (**April 1, 2026 to June 30, 2026).

- This marks the **9th** consecutive quarter with no revision in SSS interest rates.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** MoF keeps the interest rates unchanged on SSS for Q2FY27
- ✓ **Unchanged for:** 9th Consecutive quarter
- ✓ **Last Revision:** Made in December 2024 for Q4FY24
- ✓ **Managed by:** DEA

Interest Rates

- ✓ **POSD:** 4.0%
- ✓ **1-Yr POTD:** 6.9%
- ✓ **2-Yr POTD:** 7.0%
- ✓ **3-Yr POTD:** 7.1%
- ✓ **5-Yr POTD:** 7.5%
- ✓ **5-Yr PORD:** 6.7%
- ✓ **KVP:** 7.5% (115 months)
- ✓ **PPF:** 7.1%
- ✓ **SSS:** 8.2%
- ✓ **NSC:** 7.7%
- ✓ **SCSS:** 8.2%
- ✓ **MIS:** 7.4%

SSS Overview

Last Revision: The interest rates in SSS were last changed in **December 2024** for the Q4FY24 (January – March 2024).

- In December 2024, the government increased the rates of Sukanya Samriddhi Account (SSA) and 3-year Post Office term deposit scheme

Factors: The three factors that determine the interest rates of SSS directly and indirectly are:

- Government-Security Yield (**G-Sec Yield**): This is the most important factor. Higher bond yields lead to higher small savings rates.
- **Inflation:** If inflation is higher, small savings schemes' rates are kept slightly higher and vice versa.
- **Monetary Policy:** Changes in the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s repo rate and liquidity affect G-Sec yields and thus small savings rates.

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Interest Rates on Small Savings Scheme for Q2FY27:

Instruments	Interest rates from July 1,2026 to September 30, 2026
Post Office Savings Deposit (POSD)	4.0%
1-Year Post Office Time Deposit (POTD)	6.9%
2-Year Post Office Time Deposit (POTD)	7.0%
3-Year Post Office Time Deposit (POTD)	7.1%
5-Year Post Office Time Deposit (POTD)	7.5%
5-Year Post Office Recurring Deposit (PORD)	6.7%
Kisan Vikas Patra (KVP)	7.5% (will mature in 115 months)
Public Provident Fund (PPF)	7.1%
Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana (SSY)	8.2%
National Savings Certificate (NSC)	7.7%
Senior Citizen' Savings Scheme (SCSS)	8.2%
Post Office Monthly Income Scheme (PO-MIS)	7.4%

About Small Savings Scheme

SSS: These are government backed financial instruments aimed at promoting household savings and offering secure investment options.

Managed by: These schemes are primarily managed by the DEA under the MoF and administered through Post Offices and designated banks.

Committee: The **Shyamala Gopinath Committee** formulated the method for determining the SSS interest rates in January 2023.

- Since 2016, MoF has been reviewing the interest rates on SSS on a **quarterly basis**.

Interest Rates: These rates should be **25 to 100 basis points** (bps) higher than the government bond yields.

NSSF: All deposits received under various SSS are pooled in the National Small Savings Fund (**NSSF**).

About Ministry of Finance (MoF)

Union Minister – Nirmala Sitharaman (Rajya Sabha – Karnataka)

Minister of State – Pankaj Chaudhary (Constituency – Maharajganj, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

PMKSY Completed Over 10 Years of Irrigation-led Agricultural Transformation

On July 1 2026, Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana **(PMKSY)**, a flagship initiative of Government of India (GoI), completed over **10 years** of advancing irrigation-led agricultural transformation in India

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through sustainable water management and the expansion of irrigation coverage.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Completion of 10 Years of Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana
- ✓ **Launched:** July 01, 2015
- ✓ **Budget for FY27:** Rs 6,587 crore
- ✓ **Key Components:**
- ✓ Accelerated Irrigation Benefit Programme (AIBP),
- ✓ Har Khet Ko Pani (HKKP),
- ✓ Watershed Development Component (WDC), and
- ✓ Per Drop More Crop (PDMC)
- ✓ **Key Accomplishments:**
- ✓ **Total Farmers Benefitted:** (As of August 2025), Over 27 million farmers;
- ✓ **Irrigation Expansion:** 24.61 million ha;
- ✓ **Micro-irrigation Adoption:** 11.09 million ha.

About PMKSY:

Background: On **July 1 2015**, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, approved PMKSY, with budgetary outlay of **Rs 50,000 cror**e for a period of 5 years.

Aim: To enhance physical access of water on farms and expand cultivable area under assured irrigation, improves on-farm water efficiency, and promotes sustainable water conservation.

- The initiative strengthens irrigation by promoting rainwater harvesting under 'Jal Sanchay' and ensuring efficient farm-level water distribution under 'Jal Sinchan'.

Merged 3 Schemes: PMKSY was formulated with merger of 3 different schemes:

- Accelerated Irrigation Benefit Programme (AIBP) of the Ministry of Water Resources, River Development, & Ganga Rejuvenation (MoWR, RD &GR), now Ministry of Jal Shakti (MoJS)
- Integrated Watershed Management Programme (IWMP) of Department of Land Resources (DoLR) under the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD);
- On Farm Water Management (OFWM), Department of Agriculture and Cooperation (DAC), MoAFW.

Extension of Scheme: In December 2021, CCEA under the chairmanship of PM Modi extended PMKSY for another 5 years i.e. from 2021 to 26 with an overall outlay of **Rs 93,068.56 crore.**

- In the Union Budget for Financial Year 2026–27 (FY27), GoI allocated **Rs 6,587 crore** to PMKSY for irrigation expansion, water-use efficiency, and sustainable water management.

Key Components of Scheme:

PMKSY integrates irrigation expansion with improved water-use efficiency through **four strategic components** that address the complete irrigation value chain.

Accelerated Irrigation Benefit Programme (AIBP): It helps in the faster completion of ongoing major and medium irrigation projects, specifically national projects.

- **Implemented by:** AIBP is being implemented by the Ministry of Jal Shakti (MoJS).
- **Central Assistance:** Since 2016–17, AIBP has received Rs 21,023 crore as financial assistance from the Government of India (GoI), benefiting 17.30 million farmers, which makes it the largest PMKSY component in terms of beneficiary coverage.
- **Sub-Component:** In 2025-26, the GoI introduced the Modernization of Command Area Development and Water Management (**M-CADWM)** as a sub-scheme of PMKSY-AIBP, with initial outlay of Rs 1,600 crore**,** providing water from major and medium irrigation projects through pressurized piped and micro-irrigation systems.

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Har Khet Ko Pani (HKKP): It aims to create new water sources through minor irrigation (both surface and groundwater) and expand cultivable areas under assured irrigation.

- **Key Accomplishment:** Under HKKP component, 3,462 Surface Minor Irrigation (SMI) and Repair, Renovation & Restoration (RRR) schemes have been completed and 5.93 lakh hectares (ha) of irrigation potential have been created, while groundwater interventions added 88.55 thousand hectares (ha) of irrigation coverage.

Watershed Development Component (WDC): It promotes the productive use of rainfed and degraded lands by using integrated watershed management.

- **Implemented by:** The WDC is being implemented by DoLR under the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD).
- **Key Accomplishment:** Since last 10 years, the GoI has provided financial assistance of Rs 12,432.09 crore, benefiting 1.34 million farmers and supporting sustainable natural resource management.

Per Drop More Crop (PDMC): PDMC, implemented by Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (AoFW), MoAFW, was a main component of the PMKSY from 2015-16 to 2021-22, with a key objective to maximize water use efficiency at the farm level.

- **Financial Assistance:** Under the PDMC component, small and marginal farmers receive 55% financial assistance, while other farmers receive 45%. Since its inception, the scheme has covered 110.92 lakh hectares, or about 7.98% of India's net sown area, under micro-irrigation.
- **Merged with PM-RKVY:** Since 2022-23, PDMC has been merged with Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVY), promoting micro-irrigation technologies such as Drip, and Sprinkler irrigation Systems.
- **Fund:** The Micro Irrigation Fund, established under the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD), promotes drip and sprinkler irrigation systems.

Key Accomplishments of PMKSY:

Irrigation Coverage: As of August 2025, PMKSY has benefited over 27 million farmers and created or restored irrigation potential across **24.61 million ha,** with budgetary support of Rs 64,407 crore, since 2016–17.

Micro-irrigation: Since the inception of PDMC component, **110.92 lakh ha** of land have been brought under micro-irrigation.

Sprinkler Irrigation: The adoption of sprinkler irrigation under PMKSY in 2016, resulted in increase of crop yields by 25-30%, reduction in use of water, electricity, labour and fertilizer requirements by 50%; and profits of around Rs 60,000-70,000 per ha.

About Ministry of Jal Shakti (MoJS):

Union Minister- Chandrakant Raghunath (C.R.) Patil (Constituency- Navsari, Gujarat)
Minister of State **(MoS)-** V. Somanna (Constituency- Tumkur, Karnataka); Raj Bhushan Choudhary (Constituency- Muzaffarpur, Bihar)

MoHUA Approves Guidelines for PARIVARTAN Scheme to Replace Old Trucks and Buses in NCR

On 16 July 2026, Union Minister **Manohar Lal Khattar**, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), approved the operational guidelines for the **PARIVARTAN** (Programme for Accelerated Renewal and Incentivization of Vehicle Assets for Reducing Transport Air Pollution and Network Emissions) Scheme.

- The scheme aims to facilitate the replacement of old, highly polluting trucks and buses operating in the National Capital Region (NCR) with **Bharat Stage (BS)-VI-**compliant or Electric Vehicles (EVs), supporting Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi's vision of cleaner mobility and improved air quality in Delhi-NCR.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** PARIVARTAN Scheme Guidelines Approved
- ✓ **Approved By:** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
- ✓ **Objective:** Replace old trucks and buses with BS-VI-compliant or electric vehicles
- ✓ **Implementing Ministry:** Ministry of Road Transport and Highways
- ✓ **Implementing Agency:** National Capital Region Planning Board
- ✓ **Total Outlay:** Rs. 9,585 crore (Central Support-Rs. 5,041 crore)
- ✓ **Key Benefits:** Tax concession, registration fee waiver, 5% interest subvention, minimum 8% OEM discount, fuel vouchers, and EV incentives
- ✓ **Digital Integration:** VAHAN, V-Scrap, DigiELV, and PFMS.

About PARIVARTAN Scheme:

Background: The scheme was approved by the Union Cabinet on 3 June 2026 with a total outlay of **Rs. 9,585 crore**, including Rs. 5,041 crore as Central Government support.

Implementation: It will be implemented by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways **(MoRTH)** through the National Capital Region Planning Board **(NCRPB)**.

Incentives: Eligible beneficiaries will receive Motor Vehicle Tax concessions, registration fee waivers, **5% interest subvention**, minimum **8%** Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) discount, fuel vouchers, and financial assistance for EV replacements.

Digital Delivery: Benefits will be delivered through an integrated platform linked with VAHAN (National Vehicle Registration Portal), V-Scrap, Digital End-of-Life Vehicle (DigiELV), Public Financial Management System (PFMS), and participating lenders for seamless, transparent implementation.

State Support: Rajasthan, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and the National Capital Territory (NCT) of Delhi have notified 10-year Motor Vehicle Tax concessions and registration fee waivers for new vehicles purchased under the scheme.

Industry Participation: A total of 11 Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs), representing over 95% of the commercial vehicle market, have signed MoUs with the MoRTH to provide OEM discounts to eligible beneficiaries under the scheme.

About the National Capital Region Planning Board (NCRPB):

A statutory body under the MoHUA responsible for coordinated planning, infrastructure development, and balanced regional development of the NCR.

President: Manohar Lal Khattar

Headquarters: New Delhi, Delhi

Established: 1985 under the National Capital Region Planning Board Act, 1985.

STATE GOVT SCHEMES

AP Launches 'Pillale Sampada' Initiative to Promote Balanced Population Growth

In July 2026, N. Chandrababu Naidu, Chief Minister **(CM)** of Andhra Pradesh (AP), launched the **'Pillale Sampada** (Children are Wealth)' initiative during the World Population Day (July 11) programme in Vijayawada, AP.

- The initiative aims to encourage **balanced population** growth by addressing declining fertility rates and the challenges of an ageing population.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Pillale Sampada initiative launched
- ✓ **Launched By**: N. Chandrababu Naidu, CM of AP
- ✓ **Occasion:** World Population Day 2026(July 11)
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote balanced population growth

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- ✓ **Birth Incentive:** Rs. 30,000 (3rd child); Rs. 40,000 (4th child).

About Pillale Sampada Initiative:

Financial Assistance: Under the scheme, families will receive Rs. 30,000 for the birth of a third child and Rs. 40,000 for the birth of a fourth child.

Focus Areas: Prioritises women's education, healthcare, maternal and child welfare, workplace childcare, and shared parenting responsibilities

Awareness Campaign: The programme focuses on creating public awareness about the importance of maintaining a balanced population through community outreach, awareness drives, and citizen engagement.

Implementation: The initiative will be implemented after stakeholder consultations as part of the State's new population policy.

HP CM Sukhvinder Singh Launches 'Mukhyamantri Machhuara Samman Nidhi Yojana' to Support Reservoir Fishermen

In July 2026, **Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu,** Chief Minister (CM), Himachal Pradesh (HP), launched the '**Mukhyamantri Machhuara Samman Nidhi Yojana**', a welfare-oriented scheme designed to provide financial assistance and social security to fishermen engaged in reservoir fisheries during the annual fishing ban period.

- The scheme is implemented at an estimated annual state expenditure of **Rs.1.20 crore**, providing eligible fishermen a lump-sum grant of **Rs.3,500** each during the fishing ban period.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Mukhyamantri Machhuara Samman Nidhi Yojana
- ✓ **Launched By:** Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, CM of HP
- ✓ Objective: Provide financial assistance and social security to reservoir fishermen during the annual fishing ban
- ✓ **Annual Expenditure:** Rs. 1.20 crore
- ✓ **Financial Assistance:** Rs. 3,500 per eligible fisherman.

About Mukhyamantri Machhuara Samman Nidhi Yojana:

Coverage: The scheme is structured to benefit around 3,700 fishing families across five major state reservoirs: Gobind Sagar, Pong Dam, Kol Dam, Chamera, and Ranjit Sagar.

Eligibility: Active fishermen engaged in reservoir fisheries through registered Fisheries Cooperative Societies with valid fishing licenses.

Application Process: Eligible beneficiaries must apply through their respective Fisheries Cooperative Societies by submitting their Aadhaar Card, Parivar Register details, and a valid National Fisheries Digital Platform (NFDP) registration.

Monitoring: The Directorate of Fisheries, HP government, will maintain records and conduct random verifications to ensure transparency.

Delhi Government Approves 'Delhi Lakshmi Yojana' for Rs.2,500 Monthly Assistance to Women

In July 2026, the Delhi cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister (CM) Rekha Gupta, approved the **'Delhi Lakshmi Yojana'**, to provide **Rs.2,500** monthly financial assistance to eligible women, with a total budget outlay of Rs.5,110 crore for 2026-27.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of Delhi Lakshmi Yojana
- ✓ **Approved by:** Delhi Cabinet
- ✓ **Purpose:** To provide monthly financial assistance to eligible women

- ✓ **Monthly Financial Support:** Rs 2,500
- ✓ **Age Criteria:** Between 21 and 60 Years
- ✓ **Income Cap:** Maximum Rs 2.5 lakh per year

About Delhi Lakshmi Yojana:

Registration & Disbursement: The online registration portal for the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana will be launched on 1 August 2026, with the first installment scheduled for **28 August 2026** on Raksha Bandhan.
Eligibility Criteria: As per the state government, women aged between **21 and 60 years,** with an annual family income of up to **Rs 2.5 lakh**, permanent residents of Delhi and have lived in the national capital for at least 10 years, are eligible for the scheme.
Exclusions: The 3-year scheme excludes women with more than three children, annual electricity usage above 2,400 units, income taxpayers, government employees and their family members, and those receiving pensions or financial assistance from other government schemes.
Disbursement Options: Beneficiaries can choose between 2 payment options: receive Rs. 1,500 in a Recurring Deposit (RD)/Fixed Deposit (FD) account and Rs. 1,000 in a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) digital rupee wallet, or receive the entire Rs. 2,500 in an RD/FD account.

Chhattisgarh Launches 'DWEEPTI Yojana' for Women-Led Solar Entrepreneurship

In July 2026, the **Chhattisgarh** Government launched Decentralised Women Empowerment on Energy and Policy for Transformative Inclusion (**DWEEPTI) Yojana**, India's first women-led distributed Renewable Energy (RE) policy to empower rural Self-Help Groups (SHGs) as solar entrepreneurs, targeting **5,000 enterprises** and **50,000 green jobs**.

- It was developed by Panchayat and Rural Development Department, Chhattisgarh with Transform Rural India **(TRI)** under the Green Economy Transition Mission.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What:** DWEEPTI Yojana launched by Chhattisgarh
- ✓ **DWEEPTI:** Decentralised Women Empowerment on Energy and Policy for Transformative Inclusion
- ✓ **Purpose:** Promote women-led rooftop solar entrepreneurship
- ✓ **First in India:** Women-led distributed RE policy
- ✓ **Partner:** Transform Rural India
- ✓ **Implementation Partner:** CSPDCL under PMSGMBY
- ✓ **First Implementation Site:** Kabirdham district
- ✓ **First Solar Didis:** 35 SHG women trained in rooftop solar installation with Tata's support.

About DWEEPTI Yojana:

Energy Access: The scheme aims to provide clean energy access to 5 lakh families and **10,000 public institutions** across Chhattisgarh.
Implementation: 13 Cluster Level Federations (CLFs) across 12 districts have been registered as authorised vendors under Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana **(PMSGMBY)** in partnership with Chhattisgarh State Power Distribution Company Limited (CSPDCL).
Implementation: Kabirdham district became the first implementation site, where the Vande Mataram Cluster Level Federation was registered as an authorised solar vendor with support from Zila Panchayat Kabirdham (Bihan).
Support: With **Tata's** technical support, around 35 women from Self-Help Groups (SHGs) were trained in rooftop solar installation, creating the first group of 'Solar Didis'.

- Flexible loans support SHG members in adopting solar solutions and building sustainable livelihoods under the Lakhpati Didi initiative.

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INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS

India & Saudi Arabia Sign MoU to Strengthen Cooperation in Water Resources

In June 2026, the Government of **India** (GoI) and the Government of **Saudi Arabia** signed a Memorandum of
Understanding **(MoU) on water resources cooperation** during the inaugural Saudi Water Week held in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia.

- The MoU was signed by Suhel Khan, India's Ambassador to Saudi Arabia, and Abdulrahman Abdulmohsen AlFadley, Minister of Environment, Water and Agriculture, Saudi Arabia, in the presence of Fahad Suri, Consul General of India in Jeddah.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed on Water Resources Cooperation
- ✓ **Who?** India–Saudi Arabia
- ✓ **Occasion:** Inaugural Saudi Water Week in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia
- ✓ **Signed By:** Suhel Khan (India) & Abdulrahman Abdulmohsen AlFadley (Saudi Arabia)
- ✓ **Objective:** Strengthen cooperation in water resources management, sustainable water use, irrigation, capacity building, and technical knowledge exchange.

India–Saudi Arabia Water MoU

Aim: To strengthen bilateral cooperation in sustainable water management, irrigation, capacity building, and technical knowledge exchange.
Collaboration Areas: The agreement will promote cooperation in efficient water use and long-term water security, reflecting the shared commitment of India and Saudi Arabia to address growing water challenges sustainably.
Knowledge Sharing: The initiative will promote knowledge sharing between institutions and encourage joint efforts to develop sustainable solutions for water conservation and resource management.
Significance: The initiative strengthens the **India–Saudi Arabia Strategic** Partnership and supports sustainable water conservation alongside energy, trade, investment, technology, agriculture, and environmental sustainability.

India's Mukesh Ambani, Sunil Mittal, Lakshmi Mittal Among 44 Founding Members of ITU's AI for Good Global Commission

In July 2026, the International Telecommunication Union **(ITU)**, a United Nations (UN)-backed agency, launched the Artificial Intelligence **(AI) for Good Global Commission** with **44 founding members**, in Geneva, Switzerland, to strengthen global AI governance, inclusion, and innovation frameworks.

- Among the founding members, **Mukesh Ambani,** Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of Reliance Industries; **Sunil Bharti Mittal,** Founder and Chairman of Bharti Enterprises Limited; and **Lakshmi N. Mittal,** Executive Chairman of ArcelorMittal S.A., represent India on the global stage as leading business figures.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of AI for Good Global Commission
- ✓ **By Whom?** ITU
- ✓ **Objective:** Reduce digital divide, promote responsible AI
- ✓ **Members:** 44 founding members
- ✓ **Co-Chairs:** Paul Kagame and Marc Benioff
- ✓ **Vice Chair:** Doreen Bogdan-Martin
- ✓ **Indian Members:** Mukesh Ambani, Sunil Bharti Mittal, Lakshmi N. Mittal

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- ✓ **Focus Areas:** AI Trust, AI Access, AI Impact
- ✓ **Event Link:** AI for Good Global Summit 2026 (7–10 July, Geneva).

About AI for Good Global Commission:

Objective: The commission aims to ensure AI is used as a force for global good by strengthening trust, expanding access, and promoting equitable digital inclusion while addressing global inequalities caused by the digital divide.

Members: The body brings together 44 founding members, including heads of state, global industry leaders, and heads of UN agencies to promote responsible, inclusive, and trustworthy artificial intelligence.

Leadership: The Commission is co-chaired by **Paul Kagame**, President of Rwanda, and **Marc Benioff**, Chair and Chief Executive Officer(CEO) of Salesforce while ITU Secretary-General **Doreen Bogdan-Martin** serves as Vice-Chair.

Other Members: Include Jensen Huang, Founder and CEO of NVIDIA; Brad Smith, Vice Chair and President of Microsoft; Andy Jassy, CEO and President of Amazon.com; Julie Sweet, Chair and CEO of Accenture; Dr. Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala, Director-General of the World Trade Organization (WTO) and others.

Focus Areas: The initiative is built on three pillars: **AI Trust** (responsible and safe AI deployment), **AI Access** (expanding digital infrastructure and inclusion), and **AI Impact** (using AI to solve real-world global challenges).

Global Concern: The ITU highlighted that around 2.2 billion people globally remain offline, making nearly one-fourth of the world population excluded from AI-driven advancements and digital transformation benefits.

Inaugural Meeting: The commission's inaugural meeting will take place during the **AI for Good Global Summit 2026** in Geneva, Switzerland, from July 7–10, alongside Geneva Digital Week.

- The event will also coincide with the UN-mandated Global Dialogue on AI Governance (6–7 July, 2026) and the WSIS Forum 2026 (6–10 July,2026).

About International Telecommunication Union (ITU):

Secretary-General – Doreen Bogdan-Martin
Headquarters – Geneva, Switzerland
Established – 1865

Union Minister Kirti Vardhan Singh Leads Indian Delegation to UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva, Switzerland

Union Minister of State (MoS) **Kirti Vardhan Singh**, Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) and Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC), led the Indian delegation at the **inaugural** United Nations **(UN) Global Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence (AI) Governance**, held in Geneva, Switzerland, from July 6-7, 2026.

- India reaffirmed its **'AI for All' vision,** promoting responsible, inclusive and human-centric AI through oversight, human-rights protection and safeguards against misuse.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **Event:** Inaugural UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance held
- ✓ **Where?** Geneva, Switzerland
- ✓ **Dialogue Chair:** Co-chaired by Paul Kagame, President of Rwanda and Marc Benioff, CEO of Salesforce
- ✓ **Indian Delegation:** Led by Union MoS Kirti Vardhan Singh, MEA, MoEFCC
- ✓ **Outcome**: Received the first annual report of the IISPA on AI capabilities, opportunities and risks.

About UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance 2026:

Overview: It is a universal, multi-stakeholder forum established under United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) Resolution 79/325 following the Global Digital Compact adopted under the Pact of the Future in

September 2024.
Purpose: To promote consensus-based, human-centric AI governance, strengthen AI capacity in developing countries, and ensure inclusive and sustainable technological development.
2026 Leadership: The Dialogue was co-chaired by **Paul Kagame**, President of Rwanda and **Marc Benioff**, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Salesforce, with **Doreen Bogdan-Martin**, Secretary-General of the International Telecommunication Union (ITU), serving as Vice-Chair
Outcome: The inaugural session received the first annual report of the **IISPA** on AI capabilities, opportunities, and risks.

CSIR Establishes International Centre for Civilizational Studies 'Manas and Mahabharata' in Kyrgyzstan

In July 2026, the Centre for Studies of International Relations **(CSIR)**, New Delhi, Delhi in collaboration with the Manas National Academy, established the International Centre for Civilizational Studies **'Manas and Mahabharata'** in Bishkek, **Kyrgyzstan.**

- The Centre aims to strengthen scientific, educational and cultural cooperation between India and Kyrgyzstan through comparative civilizational and epic studies.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** CSIR collaborated with Manas National Academy
- ✓ **Purpose:** To Establish International centre for civilizational Studies
- ✓ **Location:** Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Civilizational studies, epic traditions, humanitarian diplomacy
- ✓ **Major Achievement:** First Hindi translation of *Manas*

Highlights of the Initiative:

Inauguration: The Centre was inaugurated during the visit of an Indian delegation to Kyrgyzstan from **4–7 July 2026**.
Objective: The Centre will promote comparative civilizational studies, humanitarian diplomacy, international scientific cooperation and researcher training.
Translation: The first Hindi translation of the Kyrgyz epic **'Manas'**, translated by **Hem Chandra Pande** and **Ramakant Dwivedi**, was released during the inauguration.
Cooperation: A trilateral agreement was signed between the Manas National Academy, CSIR and seven Kyrgyz universities to strengthen academic collaboration.
About Manas National Academy: The Manas National Academy, headquartered in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, is the premier institution dedicated to researching, preserving, and promoting the Epic of Manas and supporting studies on the country's history, language, literature, and cultural heritage.

CAC49 Adopted 7 Codex Standards Developed under India's leadership

The **49th** Session of the Codex Alimentarius Commission **(CAC49)** held from July 06 to July 11 2026 in Geneva, Switzerland, adopted **seven codex standards** and guidelines developed under India's chairmanship and co-chairmanship, representing India's contribution to the development of science-based global food standards.

- In addition, the commission approved another proposal of the Government of India (GoI) to undertake new work for the development of a **codex standard for cashew kernels** under the Codex Committee on Processed Fruits and Vegetables (CCPFV).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Adoption of 7 codex standards developed under India's leadership
- ✓ **Adopted at:** 49th session of Codex Alimentarius Commission (CAC49)
- ✓ **Session Held in:** Geneva, Switzerland

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- ✓ **Other Key Achievements for India:** To undertake new work for the development of a codex standard for cashew kernels;
- ✓ Elected as co-chair of EWG
- ✓ **Indian delegation led by:** Rajit Punhani

Key Details:

Indian Representation: Rajit Punhani, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) led the Indian delegation and participated actively in the commission's deliberations along with technical experts from FSSAI and Spices Board.

Codex Standards Adopted: Among the adopted codex standards developed under India's leadership include:

- Dried Coriander Seeds: The standard for dried coriander seeds which is expected to facilitate trade in one of the world's most widely traded spices.
- Fresh Curry Leaves: Standard for fresh curry leaves which provides a global benchmark for this regionally important culinary herb.

Other India proposed codex standards adopted: Other five Codex standards developed under India's co-chairmanship were:

- Vanilla: Establishing globally harmonized quality requirements for these globally traded commodities
- Large Cardamom: Establishing globally harmonized quality requirements for these globally traded commodities
- Safe Water Use: Guidelines for the Safe Use and Reuse of Water in Food Production and Processing, framed to promote sustainable water management and ensure food safety
- Chicken Meat Safety: The Guidelines for the Control of *Campylobacter* and *Salmonella* in Chicken Meat, aimed to reduce foodborne illnesses associated with poultry;
- Food Labelling: The Provisions relevant to Joint Presentation and Multipack Formats under the General Standard for the Labelling of Prepackaged Foods, ensuring transparency and consistency in food labelling requirements.

India elected co-chair of EWG: During the CAC49 session, India has been elected co-chair of the Electronic Working Group (EWG) established regarding New Food Sources and Production Systems (NFPS), which is expected to review existing regulatory frameworks, identify gaps in Codex risk analysis principles, and others.

About Codex Alimentarius Commission (CAC):

Establishment- CAC is an integral part of the joint World Health Organisation (WHO) and Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO)-led standards programme, established in 1963.

Key Function- It sets international standards, guidelines and codes of ptactice to ensure the safety, quality and fairness of global food trade.

Members- At present, the commission comprises 189 codex members, including 188 member countries and 1 member organisation i.e. The European Union (EU). In 1964, India officially became the member of CAC.

Chairperson- Allan Azegele (Kenya)

Headquarters- Rome, Italy

Ukraine, 9 Other Nations Form 'Anti-ballistic Missile Coalition' To Protect Europe From Missiles

In July 2026, **Ukraine** and **nine other countries** announced the formation of an **'Anti-ballistic Missile Coalition'** to strengthen protection against the growing ballistic missile threat in Europe.

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- The announcement was made on the sidelines of the **'Coalition of the Willing (CoW) Summit'**, which brought together over 30 countries and at least 25 heads of state, in Paris, France.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announcement of formation of Anti-ballistic Missile Coalition
- ✓ **Total Members:** 10
- ✓ **Announced At:** Coalition of the Willing (CoW) Summit, Paris, France
- ✓ **Founding Members:** Ukraine, Denmark, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Spain, Sweden & the UK
- ✓ **Objective:** Build a shared ballistic missile defence capability for Europe
- ✓ **Future Plan:** Develop a mass-produced, low-cost anti-ballistic missile system within 12 months.

About Anti-ballistic Missile Coalition:

Other Members: Other than Ukraine, nine countries have agreed to join the new coalition: Denmark, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Spain, Sweden, and the United Kingdom (UK).
Key Goal: The newly announced coalition aims to build a shared ballistic missile defence capability for Europe, using the expertise gained during the Ukraine-Russia war.
Future Roadmap: During the summit, Volodymyr Zelensky, President of Ukraine, announced that Ukraine and its allies are expected to jointly develop a mass-produced, low-cost system within the next 12 months (1 year) that would enhance the anti-ballistic capabilities of the European countries.

About Coalition of the Willing Summit:

Overview: This year's summit was held under the Presidency of Emmanuel Macron, President of France. The summit was led by France along with the UK.
Expansion: The coalition has now been expanded to 37 countries, including two new members i.e. Moldova and North Macedonia.

About Ukraine:

President – Volodymyr Zelensky
Capital- Kyiv
Currency- Ukrainian Hryvnia (UAH)

Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath Inscribed on UNESCO World Heritage List; Becomes India's 45th WHS

In July 2026, the **Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath** in Uttar Pradesh (UP) was inscribed on the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization **(UNESCO) World Heritage List** during the 48th session of the World Heritage Committee (WHC) in Busan, South Korea.

- The inscription became India's **45th** World Heritage Site **(WHS)** and the fourth for UP after Taj Mahal, Agra Fort, Fatehpur Sikri.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Inscription on UNESCO World Heritage List
- ✓ **Where?** Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath (UP)
- ✓ **By Whom?** UNESCO
- ✓ **When?** July 2026 (48th session of WHC, Busan, South Korea).
- ✓ **India's Count:** 45 sites; ranks 6th globally, 2nd in Asia Pacific Region; 69 sites in Tentative List; UP's 4th.
- ✓ **Criteria:** Inscribed under (iii) and (vi) for Outstanding Universal Value.
- ✓ **Timeline:** Tentative List (1998); Nomination (Jan 2025); ICOMOS mission (Sep 2025); Inscription (July 2026).

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About Sarnath's UNESCO World Heritage Inscription:

Background: Sarnath was included in UNESCO's Tentative List in 1998, and India submitted its nomination dossier in January 2025 for the 2025–26 World Heritage cycle.

- Following an 18-month evaluation by the International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS) and approval by the World Heritage Committee, Sarnath was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List.

Objective: The inscription recognizes Sarnath's Outstanding Universal Value (OUV) as one of the world's most sacred Buddhist pilgrimage centres, where Gautama Buddha delivered his first sermon after enlightenment.

UNESCO Criteria: Sarnath was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List under Criteria (iii) and (vi).

- **Criterion (iii)** recognizes its exceptional testimony to the living Buddhist tradition and enduring spiritual significance.
- **Criterion (vi)** acknowledges its direct association with Gautama Buddha's first sermon (Dharmachakra Pravartana) and the establishment of the Buddhist Sangha.

Components: The UNESCO-listed serial property comprises two protected archaeological components: the Chaukhandi Stupa and the Archaeological Remains of Sarnath, including the Dhamekh Stupa, Dharmarajika Stupa, Mulagandhakuti Vihara, Ashokan Pillar, ancient monasteries, and other associated archaeological remains.

Significance: Sarnath preserves archaeological remains spanning from the pre-Mauryan period (5th–4th centuries Before Common Era, BCE) to the 12th century CE, reflecting nearly 16 centuries of continuous cultural development, and is the discovery site of the Ashokan Lion Capital, later adopted as the National Emblem of India.

About Sarnath:

Historical Importance: After attaining enlightenment at Bodh Gaya in the 6th century BCE, Gautama Buddha travelled to Sarnath and delivered his first sermon to his first five disciples, marking Dharmachakra Pravartana (Turning of the Wheel of the Law) and the establishment of the Buddhist Sangha.

Ancient Names: Sarnath was historically known as Rishipatana, Isipatana (Ishipatana), and Mrigadava (Deer Park) in Buddhist literature.

Significance: Sarnath is one of the four principal Buddhist pilgrimage sites, along with Lumbini (birthplace), Bodh Gaya (enlightenment), and Kushinagar (Mahaparinirvana).

UNESCO World Heritage Sites (WHS):

Overview: UNESCO WHS is a landmark or area of **Outstanding Universal Value** protected under an international treaty for its cultural, historical, scientific, or natural significance.

Convention: The programme operates under the **Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage**, adopted on 16 November 1972, which establishes the global framework for identifying, protecting, and preserving heritage sites.

- The first World Heritage List inscribed in 1978 featuring sites such as the **Galápagos Islands**.

About United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO):

Director General **(DG)** – Khaled Ahmed El-Enany Ali Ezz

Headquarters – Paris, France

Established – 1945

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VISITS

VISIT TO INDIA

Overview of Japan PM Sanae Takaichi's Visit to India from July 1 to 3, 2026

Sanae Takaichi, Prime Minister **(PM) of Japan** was on a 3-day official visit to India from July 1 to 3, 2026 for 16th India-Japan Annual Summit at the invitation of **PM Narendra Modi.**

- This visit marked her first ever visit to India since she assumed the office in February 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Japan PM Sanae Takaichi visited India
- ✓ **Invited by:** PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **16th India-Japan Summit (New Delhi):**
- ✓ **Summit Co-chaired by:** PM Modi and Sanae Takaichi, PM of Japan
- ✓ **Outcomes:** 16, including CBG initiative; Joint Declaration on Economic Security; 2027 as the India-Japan Year of Shared Horizons; among others
- ✓ **Japan-India Joint Economic Forum (New Delhi)**
- ✓ Inauguration of Maruti Suzuki's 4th vehicle manufacturing facility at Kharkhoda (in Haryana)
- ✓ Signing of 129 MoUs worth Rs 1 lakh crore
- ✓ **Investment Target in India:** JPY 10 trillion by next 10 years
- ✓ **Key Announcements:** First India–Japan defence co-development project, 4th India-Japan 2+2 Ministerial meeting in Tokyo and others.

Key Highlights of Visit:

Bilateral Meeting: PM Narendra Modi held a bilateral meeting with Japanese PM Takaichi at Hyderabad House, in New Delhi, Delhi.

- During the meeting, discussions were mainly focused on expanding economic ties, enhancing resilient supply chains for semiconductors, and strengthening cooperation in critical technologies.

Japan-India Joint Economic Forum: During her visit to India, Japanese PM Takaichi along with PM Modi, attended the Japan-India Joint Economic Forum, hosted by the Japan External Trade Organisation **(JETRO)** in New Delhi.

- **Key Inauguration:** The forum witnessed the inauguration of Maruti Suzuki's **4th** vehicle manufacturing facility at Kharkhoda (in Haryana), developed with an estimated investment of **Rs 35,000 crore.**
- **MoUs:** During the event, Indian and Japanese companies signed at least **129** Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) worth Rs 1 lakh crore, on technology, investment and Artificial Intelligence (AI).

16th India-Japan Annual Summit: During the visit, Japanese PM Takaichi participated at the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit, where both countries discussed ways to enhance cooperation in areas like: economic security, resilient supply chains, emerging technologies, defence and maritime security.

Outcomes of the Annual Summit:

Overview: Following the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit, both countries announced **16 key outcomes** expanding bilateral cooperation in Artificial Intelligence (AI), economic security, clean energy, critical minerals, mobility, biotechnology, pharmaceuticals and financial services.

Joint Declaration on Economic Security: Promotes project-based cooperation to strengthen joint resilience in semiconductors, critical minerals, Information and Communication Technology (ICT), including Artificial Intelligence (AI), clean energy, and pharmaceuticals.

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- The India–Japan Fact Sheet 2.0 highlights expanding Government-to-Government (G2G) and Business-to-Business (B2B) engagement in these sectors.

Joint Statement on Cooperation in AI: Elevates bilateral ties to a strategic Research and Development (R&D) partnership in AI, building on the India–Japan AI Initiative to promote safe, secure, trusted, inclusive, and human-centric AI across the technology stack.

Joint Statement on Energy Resilience: Signed between the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), Government of India (GoI), and Japan's Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry (METI), it strengthens cooperation in strategic stockpiling, reserve mechanisms for crude oil and petroleum products, and maritime energy-transport investments.

India–Japan Year of Shared Horizons: Outlines commemorative events for 2**027,** marking the **75th** anniversary of the establishment of India–Japan diplomatic relations.

MoUs Signed:

- **Biogas Expansion:** The Memorandum of Cooperation (MoC) for the India–Japan Cooperative Biogas for Growth (CBG) Initiative supports the establishment of 1,000 biogas and organic-fertiliser plants across India through dairy cooperative networks.
- **Battery Supply Chain:** The MoC on batteries promotes projects and business opportunities to develop a trusted, resilient, and sustainable battery supply chain.
- **Pharma and Medical Devices:** The MoC strengthens supply chains for Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs) and Key Starting Materials (KSMs) through bilateral investment, technical cooperation, business linkages, and industry–academia collaboration.
- **Critical Minerals: T**he MoC on geology and mineral exploration enhances upstream critical-mineral exploration through the exchange of technical expertise.
- **Artificial Intelligence (AI):** The MoC between IndiaAI Mission and Japan's Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry (METI) promotes collaboration with Japan's Generative AI Accelerator Challenge (GENIAC) initiative through Business-to-Business (B2B) matchmaking, policy webinars, joint projects, and computing-resource access.
- **Next-Generation Mobility:** The MoC on the Next Generation Mobility Partnership (NGMP) operationalises the partnership announced at the 15th India–Japan Annual Summit in August 2025, covering railways, automobiles, roads, aviation, shipbuilding, ports, logistics, and urban development.
- **Life Sciences Innovation:** The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Platforms (C-CAMP) and RIKEN promotes academic and translational research, start-up innovation, deep technology, and life sciences collaboration in healthcare, agriculture, and the environment.
- **Biology and Neuroscience:** The MoU between the National Centre for Biological Sciences (NCBS)–Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) and RIKEN establishes cooperation in basic biological and neuroscience research.
- **Large Language Models (LLMs):** The MoU between the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay (IIT Bombay), BharatGen Technology Foundation, and Japan's National Institute of Informatics (NII) supports joint research and exchanges on LLMs for scientific reasoning.
- **AI Foundation Models:** The MoU between Sarvam AI and Preferred Networks supports collaboration across the AI technology stack, including foundation models.
- **Internet Infrastructure:** The MoU between the National Internet Exchange of India (NIXI) and the Japan Network Information Center (JPNIC) promotes cooperation in National Internet Registry (NIR) operations, Internet Protocol version 6 (IPv6) adoption, internet security, capacity building, professional exchanges, and internet governance.

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- **Financial Technology:** The Exchange of Letters between the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) and Japan's Financial Services Agency (JFSA) strengthens cooperation in financial-services regulation, supervision, market information, Financial Technology (FinTech), and Regulatory Technology (RegTech).

Key Announcements:

India-Japan 2+2 Ministerial Meeting: During the Japanese PM visit to India, both countries agreed to convene 4th **India-Japan 2+2 Ministerial** meeting in Tokyo, the capital city of Japan by the end of 2026. They also reaffirmed their commitment to expand defence cooperation across design, manufacturing, military exercises, maritime security, and defence technology.

Supports India's bid for IEA: In addition, Japan has also extended its full support for India's full membership in the International Energy Agency (IEA).

Investment Target: In order to bolster bilateral trade, India and Japan have set the target of mobilising Japanese Yen **(JPY) 10 trillion** in Japanese investment into India over the next 10 years.

Strategic Outlook: Both countries have also adopted a Strategic Outlook to Expand Japan-India Cooperation in Africa. The newly adopted outlook aims to transform India into a major manufacturing hub for Africa-bound trade and investment by using India's industrial base and Japan's technological and financial expertise.

- The new framework will combine the existing mechanisms such as: the India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS), Japan's Tokyo International Conference on African Development (TICAD), and the Economic Region initiative of the Indian Ocean-Africa, to strengthen supply chains and investment corridors.

Defence and Industrial Collaborations:

Defence Technology: India and Japan announced their first joint defence co-development project to manufacture the Unified Complex Radio Antenna **(UNICORN) mast** for the Indian Navy (IN). The agreement makes India the second Asian country after the Philippines to receive Japanese defence technology.

- UNICORN Mast is an advanced integrated mast system that combines multiple communication systems and scattered antennas into a single unified radar mast, improving the stealth capabilities of naval platforms.

ACE Kato JV for Cranes in India: Action Construction Equipment Limited (ACE) has entered into a strategic partnership with Japan's KATO Corporation, to form a 50:50 Joint Venture (JV) **ACE Kato** for the manufacturing of high capacity cranes in India.

- The proposed JV will establish an 11-acre manufacturing facility in Haryana with an estimated investment of around 200 crore.

Mizoram and Toyota Kirloskar: The Government of Mizoram and Toyota Kirloskar Motor (TKM) signed a MoU to enhance educational opportunities for visually impaired persons in the state.

About Japan:

Prime Minister **(PM) –** Sanae Takaichi
Capital- Tokyo
Currency- Japanese Yen (JPY)

Overview of PM Narendra Modi's Visit to Rajasthan And Gujarat On July 4, 2026

On July 4 2026, Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** visited **Rajasthan** and **Gujarat.** During his visit, PM Modi inaugurated, dedicated to the nation several development projects in Rajasthan, including India's 1st greenfield refinery-cum-petrochemical complex, launch of Modified Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik (UDAN) scheme.

- He also inaugurated the CG Semi Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (OSAT) in Sanand (Gujarat).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** PM Narendra Modi visited Rajasthan and Gujarat
- ✓ **Date of Visit:** July 4, 2026
- ✓ **Visit to Rajasthan:**
- ✓ **Key Launches in Jodhpur:** Modified UDAN scheme; NTB at Jodhpur Airport
- ✓ **Key Projects in Balotra:** Inauguration, laying foundation stone for development projects (Balotra)
- ✓ **Total Cost of Projects:** Rs 1.06 lakh crore
- ✓ **Sectors Covered:** Aviation, Rail, Road, Metro, Energy, among others
- ✓ **Projects**: India's 1st Greenfield Petrochemical Complex; Phase 2 of the Jaipur Metro Rail Project
- ✓ **Key Launch in Gujarat:** Inauguration of OSAT Facility (Sanand, Ahmedabad)
- ✓ **Total Cost:** Rs7,500 crore
- ✓ **Developed under:** India Semiconductor Mission.

Highlights of Visit to Rajasthan:

Visit to Jodhpur:

- **Airport:** During the programme, he also inaugurated the New Terminal Building **(NTB) at Jodhpur Airport**, Jodhpur, Rajasthan developed at a total cost of Rs 480 crore. The NTB spans over an area of over 23,000 square metres (sqm.), is capable of handling up to 20 lakh passengers annually. It is equipped with modern passenger amenities to ensure a seamless and comfortable travel experience.
- **Modified UDAN Scheme:** During an event held in Jodhpur (Rajasthan), PM Modi launched the Modified UDAN Scheme, marking a significant step towards India's civil aviation landscape.
- **Objective:** In March 2026, the Union Cabinet, chaired by PM Modi approved the Modified UDAN Scheme with an outlay of approximately **Rs 28,840 crore** over the **next ten years**, aims to accelerate aviation-led development, focusing on multiple strategic components designed to ensure comprehensive and sustainable connectivity.
- **Expansion:** The newly launched Modified UDAN scheme emphasis on expanding regional aviation infrastructure through the development of 100 aerodromes from existing unserved airstrips with an investment of Rs 12,159 crore.
- **Other Key Proposals:** In addition, the scheme also provides Rs 2,577 crore towards Operations and Maintenance (O&M) support for regional airports. It also proposes the development of 200 modern helipads with an investment of Rs 3,661 crore, and continued Viability Gap Funding of Rs 10,043 crore to sustain regional airline operations.

Visit to Balotra:

- **Projects:** PM Narendra Modi dedicated, inaugurated and laid the foundation stone for several development projects worth around **Rs 1.06 lakh crore** during an event held in **Balotra**, Rajasthan. These development projects span across various sectors such as: energy, aviation, rail, road, metro and water sectors and are expected to strengthen connectivity, create employment and enhance ease of living.
- **Key Dignitaries:** Haribhau Kisanrao Bagde, Governor of Rajasthan; Bhajan Lal Sharma, Chief Minister (CM) of Rajasthan; Union Minister Rammohan Naidu Kinjarapu, Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA); and other eminent dignitaries, were present at the event.
- **India's 1st Greenfield Petrochemical Complex:** The newly inaugurated greenfield refinery-cum-petrochemical complex located in Pachpadra, Balotra, Rajasthan, was developed as a Joint Venture (JV)between Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL) and the Rajasthan Government at an investment of **Rs 79,450 crore.**

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- 9 Million Metric Tonnes Per Annum (MMTPA) state-of-the-art complex combines refining and petrochemical production, with a petrochemical capacity of 2.4 MMTPA.
- It features a high Nelson Mandela index of 17.0 and achieves petrochemical yields exceeding 26%, which aligns with international standards for efficiency and sustainability.
- **Phase-II Jaipur Metro Rail Project:** PM Modi laid the foundation stone for Phase 2 of the Jaipur Metro Rail Project, with an estimated cost of more than Rs 13,000 crore.
- Under Phase-II of the project, a 41-kilometer (km)-long metro corridor will be developed from Prahladpura to Todi Mod, linking the industrial and residential areas of Sitapura and Vishwakarma Industrial Area (VKI) through 36 stations.
- The proposed metro project, expected to be completed within the next 5 years, has been divided into 7 packages, of which 4 for civil construction and 3 for electrical and other system works.
- **300 MW Karnisar Solar Plant:** He also inaugurated NHPC Limited's 300 Mega-Watt (MW) Karnisar Solar Power Plant at Bikaner, Rajasthan. The new solar plant uses 7.75 lakh locally produced solar Photovoltaic (PV) cells and modules.
- It has an annual capacity of generating nearly 75 crore units of clean electricity.
- Additionally, he also dedicated the nation to SJVN Limited (formerly Satluj Jal Vidyut Nigam)'s 1,000 MW Bikaner Solar Energy Project, developed at a cost of around Rs 5,500 crore.
- **Other Key Launches:** Some of the key projects included: inauguration of the four-laning of National Highway (NH-125A), Jodhpur Ring Road Section-2 (Karwar–Dangiyawas), developed at a cost of around Rs 740 crore; inauguration of the transmission line (over Rs 1,900 crore) for power evacuation from the Rajasthan Renewable Energy Zone (REZ); and handing over appointment letters to around 54,000 youth recruited across various departments of the Government of Rajasthan.

Highlight of Visit to Gujarat:

Inauguration of OSAT Facility: During his visit to Gujarat, PM Modi inaugurated CG Semi OSAT facility at Sanand, Ahmedabad. The CG Semi facility began chip testing in August 2025 and commenced commercial chip packaging at the inauguration

- It is one of the four semiconductor projects approved under the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM), a flagship initiative of Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), launched in 2021 with total budget outlay of Rs 76,000 crore.

Developed by: The new facility is developed by CG Semi Pvt. Ltd. in partnership with Japan's Renesas Electronics and Thailand's Stars Microelectronics, at a cost of Rs 7,500 crore.

Annual Production Capacity: On its complete operationalisation, the new facility is expected to produce up to 5 billion semiconductor chips annually.

Key Applications: The facility is designed to cater to customers across the automotive, industrial, telecommunications, 5G, and Internet of Things (IoT) sectors.

About Rajasthan:

Chief Minister **(CM) –** Bhajan Lal Sharma
Governor- Haribhau Kisanrao Bagde
Capital- Jaipur
National Parks **(NPs)**- Keoladeo NP, Ranthambore NP

Overview of PM Narendra Modi's Visit to Haryana, Chandigarh and Punjab on July 17, 2026

Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** visited Haryana, Union Territory (UT) Chandigarh and Punjab on July 17, 2026. During his visit, he flagged off India's first Hydrogen train, laid the foundation stones and dedicated to the nation various development projects **worth over Rs 26,800 crore** in Haryana (14,700 crore); UT Chandigarh (over 4,700 crore) and Punjab (over 5,470 crore).

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Overview of PM Modi visit to Haryana, UT Chandigarh and Punjab
- ✓ **Date of Visit:** July 17, 2026
- ✓ **Key Highlight of Visit:** Flagging off India's 1st hydrogen train
- ✓ **Where?** Jind, Haryana
- ✓ **Train Route:** Between Jind and Sonipat (both cities of Haryana)
- ✓ **Total Projects Launched Worth:** Over Rs 26,800 crore
- ✓ **Key Highlight of Jind Visit:** laid the foundation stone and dedicated the nation's NH projects;
- ✓ **Total Cost of Projects:** Worth over Rs 12,470 crore
- ✓ **Key Projects:** Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway (Rs 9,680 crore); 33.81-km-long four-lane; Ambala-Kala Amb National Highway (NH) (around Rs 1,184 crore); Jind-Gohana Greenfield Highway; Hansi–Barwala Brownfield Highway Project; among others
- ✓ **Key Highlight of Visit to Kurukshetra:** Inauguration of Sikh Museum
- ✓ **To developed:** in Umri village (Haryana)
- ✓ **Estimated Cost:** Rs 170 crore
- ✓ **Key Highlight of Visit to Chandigarh:** inauguration and foundation stone for development projects
- ✓ **Total Cost of Projects:** Over Rs 4,700 crore,
- ✓ **Key Sectors:** healthcare, education and road infrastructure
- ✓ **Key Highlight of Visit to Jalandhar:** inauguration and laid the foundation stone of rail and road infrastructure projects
- ✓ **Total Cost:** Over Rs 5,470 crore
- ✓ **Key Railway Project:** Inauguration of 75 Redeveloped Railway Stations
- ✓ **Total cost:** Rs 1,570 crore
- ✓ **Total States:** 20
- ✓ **Redeveloped under:** Amrit Bharat Station Scheme.

Key highlights of Visit to Haryana:

India's First Hydrogen Train: PM Modi flagged off India's first hydrogen-powered train between Jind and Sonipat at Jind Railway Station in Haryana.

- **Eco-friendly:** The 10-coach hydrogen-powered train, designed and integrated indigenously, is powered by hydrogen fuel cells, generating electricity onboard while emitting water vapour as the only by-product, making it a zero-carbon-emission transport system.
- **World's Most Powerful Hydrogen-fuelled Train:** The newly inaugurated train is among the world's longest hydrogen-powered passenger trains, equipped with a 3,200 Horse Power (HP) propulsion system, which makes it one of the most powerful hydrogen-powered trainsets currently in operation.

Key Highway Projects: Later, he laid the foundation stone and dedicated the nation's National Highway (NH) projects worth **over Rs 12,470 crore** during an event held in Eklavya Stadium in Jind, Haryana.

- **Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway:** He inaugurated the 157.92-kilometer (km)-long four-lane Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway, constructed at a cost of around Rs 9,680 crore. The newly inaugurated greenfield corridor, part of the 667 km Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway, is expected to reduce travel time between Delhi and Katra (in Jammu, Jammu & Kashmir, J&K) from around 14 hours to nearly 6 hours, and Delhi and Amritsar (Punjab) from 8 hours to about 4 hours.
- **Ambala-Kala Amb Highway:** He also dedicated the 33.81-km-long four-lane, partially access-controlled Ambala-Kala Amb National Highway (NH) on NH-7 and NH-344, built at a cost of around Rs 1,184 crore.

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- Other Key Projects: 40.60 km long Jind-Gohana Greenfield Highway on NH-352A, expected to enhance connectivity to Rohtak, Panipat and Delhi-NCR and laid the foundation stone for the 24.27 km long Hansi–Barwala Brownfield Highway Project/
- **Elevated railway track:** PM Modi inaugurated the 5.9 km-long elevated railway track, constructed at a cost of Rs 447 crore, in Kurukshetra (Haryana). The project is executed by Haryana Rail Infrastructure Development Corporation (HRDC), a Joint Venture (JV) between the Haryana Government and the Ministry of Railways.

Medical Infrastructure: During his visit to Haryana, he dedicated major medical institutions to the nation, including Pandit Neki Ram Sharma Government Medical College (GMC), in Bhiwani; Maharishi Chyawan Medical College and Rao Tula Ram Hospital, in Koriawas, Narnaul.

- These new medical institutions are expected to enhance access to quality medical education in the state, increase the number of MBBS seats, improve the availability of specialist healthcare professionals, among others.

Cultural Infrastructure: He also laid the foundation stone of the Sikh Museum at Kurukshetra, Haryana, to be built in Umri village at a cost of Rs 170 crore. The proposed museum, spanning 5 acres of land, will showcase the history of Sikhism, the teachings of the Sikh Gurus, their courage, sacrifices, and the contribution of the Sikh community using modern technology.

Visit to Chandigarh:

Key Projects: PM Modi inaugurated and laid the foundation stone for development projects worth over Rs 4,700 crore, spanning sectors like: healthcare, education and road infrastructure, during an event held at Punjab Engineering College (PEC) in UT Chandigarh.

Healthcare: PM Modi inaugurated the Advanced Mother and Child Centre and the Advanced Neurosciences Centre at Post Graduate Institute of Medical Education & Research (PGIMER), Chandigarh.

- **Significance:** The newly launched centre, equipped with 300 beds and state-of-the-art medical facilities, are expected to strengthen maternal and child healthcare services and benefit thousands of families across the region.
- **Key Medical Services:** The Advanced Mother and Child Centre will provide comprehensive tertiary healthcare services for high-risk pregnancies, critically ill newborns and children requiring specialized treatment, while the Advanced Neurosciences Centre has been designed to provide integrated services in neurology, neurosurgery, neuro-critical care and advanced diagnostic facilities under single roof.
- **Other Key Launch:** In addition, he laid the foundation stone of a 150-bed state-of-the-art Critical Care Block under the Pradhan Mantri Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission (PM-ABHIM) at PGIMER, Chandigarh.

Education: Additionally, he inaugurated and laid the foundation stone for academic infrastructure projects, including the inauguration of Kurukshetra Boys Hostel & Mess at PEC; Hostel Block in Government College, Sector 46 and foundation stone of Research Scholars' Hostel at PEC.

Road Infrastructure: PM Modi inaugurated the six-lane Greenfield Highway linking Information Technology (IT) City and Kurali in Mohali district (Punjab) and laid the foundation stone of the Zirakpur Greenfield Bypass and the PR-7 Spur of the Ambala-Chandigarh Greenfield Highway.

Visit to Punjab:

Projects Launched: Prime Minister inaugurated and laid the foundation stone of rail and road infrastructure projects worth over Rs 5,470 crore, during a programme held at Jalandhar Cantonment in Jalandhar, Punjab.

Inauguration of Redeveloped Railway Station: The key highlight of the event was the inauguration of 75 redeveloped railway stations (at a cost of Rs 1,570 crore) in 20 states under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme.

- Among these 75 redeveloped railway stations, 4 are in Punjab: Jalandhar Cantonment, SAS Nagar (Mohali), Sri Muktsar Sahib and Sri Anandpur Sahib.
- He also virtually inaugurated redeveloped Harrawala railway station (Rs 19 crore), developed as a satellite terminal for Dehradun (Uttarakhand); and Shamlu railway station redeveloped (at a cost of nearly Rs 25 crore).

New Rail Line: He also inaugurated the Daulatpur Chowk-Kartoli new rail line, built at a cost of around Rs 830 crore as part of the Nangal Dam-Talwara-Mukerian New Rail Line Project.

- The project is expected to boost rail connectivity between Punjab and Himachal Pradesh (HP), benefiting the districts of Hoshiarpur (Punjab) and Una (HP).

Key Trains Flagged Off: During the event, he flagged off Amritsar (Chheharta)-Varanasi Sant Ravidas Express, establishing directrail link between Amritsar (Punjab) and Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh, UP).

- In addition, he flagged off the Kartoli-Ambala train service, expected to enhance connectivity across 3 states: Punjab, Haryana and HP.

NH Projects: In addition, he also inaugurated and laid the foundation stone of projects worth **more than Rs 3,070 crore,** including the inauguration of the 30.9-km-long Package-6 of the four-lane greenfield Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway; and the foundation stone for the development of the 25.2-km-long six-lane greenfield Southern Ludhiana Bypass, reducing travel distance and time between Ludhiana and Bathinda.

About Punjab:

Chief Minister **(CM)-** Bhagwant Singh Mann
Governor- Gulab Chand Kataria
Wildlife Sanctuaries **(WLSs)-** Bir Dosanjh WLS, Bir Bhadson WLS

Zanzibar President Hussein Ali Mwinyi Visits India from 17–20 July 2026

President of Zanzibar and Chairman of the Revolutionary Council, **Hussein Ali Mwinyi**, paid an official visit to India from 17–20 July 2026 at the invitation of Vice President C. P. Radhakrishnan, accompanied by First Lady Mariyam Mwinyi and a high-level delegation comprising ministers and senior officials.

- During the visit, both sides welcomed the expansion of bilateral trade, investment, and capacity-building initiatives, further reinforcing the India–Tanzania Strategic Partnership.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Zanzibar President Hussein Ali Mwinyi visited India
- ✓ **When?** 17–20 July 2026
- ✓ **Key Meetings:** VP C. P. Radhakrishnan; EAM Dr. S. Jaishankar
- ✓ **Major Event:** Chief Guest at the 63rd Convocation of IIT Madras
- ✓ **Key Announcement:** Unveiled the master plan for IIT Madras Zanzibar campus at Fumba Peninsula.

Highlights of the Visit:

Bilateral Talks: President **Hussein Ali Mwinyi** held bilateral discussions with Vice President (VP) **Radhakrishnan**, reviewing India–Tanzania relations and exploring cooperation in the blue economy, tourism, technology, health, education, trade, and investment, while inviting the Vice President to visit Tanzania.

EAM Meeting: He also met **Union Minister Dr. S. Jaishankar,** Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) to review the development partnership, including strengthening the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Madras Zanzibar as a Centre of Excellence (CoE) for higher education in Africa and India's support for water infrastructure and human resource development.

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IIT Zanzibar: He participated in the 63rd Convocation of Indian Institutes of Technology **(IIT) Madras** and unveiled the master plan for the 200-acre IIT Madras Zanzibar campus at Fumba Peninsula, India's first international IIT campus.

FOREIGN VISITS

Overview of Union Minister Piyush Goyal's Visit to UK from June 25 to 27, 2026

Union Minister Piyush Goyal, Ministry of Commerce and Industry **(MoCI),** undertook a 3-day official visit to London, the United Kingdom (UK), from June 25 to 27, 2026.

- The visit came ahead of the official implementation of the historic India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) and the companion Double Contribution Convention (DCC), which are set to come into force on **July 15, 2026.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal Visited UK
- ✓ **Significance:** Visit came ahead of official rollout of India-UK CETA and DCC
- ✓ **Effective from:** July 15, 2026
- ✓ **Bilateral Meeting:** Peter Kyle, UK Secretary of State for Business and Trade
- ✓ **Award:** Special Award for Exceptional Leadership in Elevating India–UK Relations
- ✓ **Presented by:** IGF at the 10th UK-India Awards 2026
- ✓ **Key Launch:** UK–India CETA Business Utilisation Manual
- ✓ **Developed by:** UKIBC & HSBC India
- ✓ **Key Announcements:** 1,000 advisory personnel and upgraded trade portal for CETA implementation
- ✓ **Key Benefit:** 5-year UK social security exemption for eligible Indian professionals
- ✓ **Trade Impact:** India–UK CETA expected to boost annual bilateral trade by GBP 25.5 billion.

Highlights of Visit:

Bilateral Meeting: During the visit, Union Minister Piyush Goyal held a high-level bilateral meeting with Peter Kyle, Secretary of State for Business and Trade, Government of the UK in London.

- The discussions were mainly focused on aligning regulatory roadmaps, streamlining cross-border customs coordination and finalising administrative mechanisms to facilitate the smooth roll out of CETA and the DCC.
- During the meeting, Ministers from both countries reviewed the preparedness for the implementation of CETA's tariff liberalisation commitments, which is expected to provide enhanced market access opportunities for Indian exports in the UK.

Honour: Union Minister Piyush Goyal was honoured with the **Special award for Exceptional Leadership** in Elevating India-UK Relations during the 10th anniversary of India Global Forum (IGF)'s UK-India Awards 2026 ceremony held in London.

- Also, the joint UK-India Free Trade Agreement (FTA) Negotiation Teams was honoured at the event.

UK-India CETA Business Utilisation Manual: Union Minister Piyush Goyal also launched the 'UK-India CETA Business Utilisation Manual', a practical activation guide for Indian and UK Businesses, during an event held in London, organised by Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI)and supported by UK India Business Council (UKIBC), ahead of the implementation of India-UK CETA.

- This newly launched manual was developed by UKIBC in partnership with HSBC India.
- The manual is designed to help businesses understand and utilise the opportunities arising from the trade pact.

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- As per the manual, bilateral trade between India and the UK reached around Pound Sterling (GBP) 47.9 billion (about USD 56-60 billion) by the ending of Q4 2025, marking a 10% increase compared to previous years.

Expansion of Bilateral Relations: While addressing the India Global Forum (IGF) Capital Frontiers Forum and other high-level engagements, the Minister highlighted that the India-UK partnership has expanded to cover key strategic sectors such as technology, sovereign Artificial Intelligence (AI), critical minerals, defence and clean energy.

- He also outlined some of the key regional partnerships, including Birmingham-Gujarat and Manchester-Maharashtra, as key drivers of future economic growth.

Key Announcements: While addressing the 10th Annual UK-India Week in London, Union Minister Goyal announced the deployment of **1,000 advisory personnel** across India to help businesses maximise the benefits of the India-UK CETA.

- He also announced the upgradation of the trade portal.
- He further mentioned that India-UK CETA, India's most comprehensive free trade pact to date, is expected to boost annual bilateral trade by Pound Sterling **(GBP) 25.5 billion.**
- Under the CETA, eligible Indian professionals will be allowed to work in the UK with a five-year exemption from social security contributions.

Other Business Engagements: During his visit to the UK, Union Minister Piyush Goyal participated in a series of Government-to-Business (G2B) engagements with industry leaders, investors and corporate representatives aimed to further deepen commercial partnerships between the two countries.

- He held key roundtables with global executives from organizations like HSBC (Global Trade Solutions), Deloitte, and Rolls-Royce, to discuss strategic investments, industrial collaboration and the expansion of manufacturing partnerships in India.

About the United Kingdom (UK):

Prime Minister **(PM) –** Keir Starmer
Capital- London
Currency- Pound Sterling (GBP)

Overview of PM Narendra Modi Visit to Seychelles From June 27 to 29, 2026

Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** undertook a 3-day official visit to Seychelles from June 27 to 29, 2026, at the invitation of **Dr. Patrick Herminie,** President of Seychelles.

- During his visit, he attended the Golden Jubilee celebrations of the National Day of Seychelles as the **Guest of Honour.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** PM Narendra Modi visited Seychelles
- ✓ **Invited by:** Dr. Patrick Herminie, President of Seychelles
- ✓ **Honour:** "Guardian of the Blue Horizon" title, 34th international honour
- ✓ **Key Engagements:**
- ✓ Bilateral talks with Seychelles President;
- ✓ Attended the Golden Jubilee (50 years) Celebrations of National Day of Seychelles
- ✓ Met Navinchandra Ramgoolam, PM of Mauritius
- ✓ **Indian Contingent:** 32-member IA contingent participated in the National Day parade
- ✓ **MoUs**: Signed 9 MoUs in defence, healthcare, digital payments, agriculture, maritime cooperation, space and infrastructure
- ✓ **Sectors Covered:** defence, healthcare, digital payments, agriculture, maritime cooperation, among others

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- ✓ **Key Outcomes:** Rs 1,250 crore LoC to Seychelles; handing over **FPV PS** LESPWAR, 6 ambulances, 10 utility vehicles and 5 laser radical boats to Seychelles, Seychelles joined CDRI, and others.

Highlights of Visit:

Bilateral Meeting: PM Narendra Modi held a bilateral meeting with **Dr. Patrick Herminie**, President of Seychelles, at the State House in Victoria, Seychelles, where both leaders agreed to strengthen cooperation in health, education, capacity building, digital transformation, sustainable development, social infrastructure, Renewable Energy (RE), maritime security, and defence.

- Following the bilateral meeting, leaders of both countries jointly released a joint **commemorative logo** marking **50 years** of the establishment of diplomatic relations between India and Seychelles.
- PM Narendra Modi highlighted India's **Special Economic Package of USD 175 million** for Seychelles, which was announced during the Seychelles President's visit to India in February 2026.

Address to Seychelles National Assembly: PM Narendra Modi became the first Indian Prime Minister to address the National Assembly of Seychelles. This also marked his 20th address to a foreign legislature.

Honour: PM Narendra Modi was conferred the honorary **"Guardian of the Blue Horizon" title**, Seychelles' highest distinction, by President Patrick Herminie. It recognises his leadership in climate action, the Blue Economy, sustainable ocean-resource management, and advancing the development aspirations of Small Island Developing States (SIDS).

- It was the first time Seychelles had awarded this honour and marked his 34th international honour from a foreign country.

Golden Jubilee Celebrations: The Indian Army **(IA) marching contingent** participated in Seychelles' Golden Jubilee National Day celebrations, marking the 50 years of the island nation's independence, held in Victoria.

- The Indian contingent, comprising 32 personnel from the Assam regiment (led by Captain Aryan H. Deolekar), marched alongside an Indian Navy (IN) contingent and military band at the event.

Other Key Engagement: On the sidelines of Golden Jubilee Celebrations, PM Modi held a bilateral meeting with **Dr. Navinchandra Ramgoolam, PM of Mauritius** in Victoria, Mahe, during which, both leaders reviewed a wide spectrum of the India-Mauritius Enhanced Strategic Partnership, including development cooperation, maritime security, trade, capacity building, and people-to-people ties.

- He also visited the Arul Mihu Navasakthi Vinayagar temple, the only hindu temple in the African island nation, located in Victoria.

PM Modi hands over Made-in-India FPV: During the visit, PM Modi handed over a "Made in India" Fast Patrol Vessel **(FPV) PS LESPWAR** to Seychelles, in the presence of Seychelles President Patrick Herminie during the ceremony held at the Coast Guard Base in Victoria.

- This specialised FPV, constructed by Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL), is expected to significantly improve Seychelles's maritime surveillance and Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) patrol capabilities.
- In addition, the PM handed over 6 ambulances, 10 utility vehicles and 5 Laser Radical Boats to Seychelles.

Gifts for Seychelles Leaders: PM Modi gifted a **Muradabadi brass tortoise**, a renowned brassware tradition of Moradabad in Uttar Pradesh (UP), to Dr. Patrick Herminie, President of Seychelles.

- He also presented a **Maheshwari Silk Stole** (from Madhya Pradesh, MP) and **Bidriware box** (from Karnataka), to Vernonique Herminie, the First Lady of Seychelles.
- Sebastian Pillay, the Vice President (VP) of Seychelles, was gifted an **orchid painting** (from Sikkim), depicting India's national bird (Peacock), adorned with delicate orchid blooms.

- And, Lina Pillay, the Second Lady of Seychelles, was gifted a **Kanchivaram silk fabric** (from Kanchipuram in Tamil Nadu, TN), woven from fine mulberry silk and is known for its durability, lustrous finish and intricate "zari" work.

Key MoUs:

Overview: During PM Modi's visit, India and Seychelles signed a total of 9 key Memorandums of Understanding (MoU) covering sectors like: defence, healthcare, digital payments, agriculture, maritime cooperation, space and infrastructure.

Umbrella LoC: Export-Import Bank of India (EXIM) signed **Rs 1,250 crore** umbrella Line of Credit (LoC) with the Government of Seychelles, aimed to support African island nation's development projects.

Digital Payment Infrastructure: The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) International Payments Limited **(NIPL)** signed a MoU with the **Central Bank of Seychelles** for the deployment of Unified Payments Interface (UPI) digital payment infrastructure in Seychelles.

Healthcare: A MoU was signed between **M/s HLL Lifecare Limited** and the Ministry of Health of the Republic of Seychelles, to facilitate the export of affordable generic medicines and medical supplies from India to Seychelles under Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana **(PMBJP).**

- In addition, a separate MoU was signed between India and Seychelles, outlining preliminary preparations for the establishment of the new Seychelles National Hospital.

Diplomatic Training: India's Sushma Swaraj Institute of Foreign Service (SSIFS) signed a MoU with Seychelles's Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Diaspora (MoFAD), aimed to bolster institutional training through exchanges, training programmes, and capacity building.

Extradition Treaty: India and Seychelles signed an extradition treaty that aims to bolster bilateral cooperation in tackling transnational crime and improving the legal framework for extradition of fugitives between two countries.

Maritime Cooperation: The Ministry of Ports, Shipping, and Waterways (MoPSW), Government of India (GoI) signed a MoU with Seychelles's Ministry of Transport, Ports and Civil Aviation, aimed to recognise Indian seafarers' training and certification for service on Seychelles-flagged vessels.

Space Cooperation: Both countries signed a MoU to bolster bilateral cooperation in satellite applications, space technology and capacity building.

Agriculture Cooperation: A MoU was signed between the Indian Council of Agricultural Research **(ICAR)** of GoI and the Agriculture Department under Seychelles' Ministry of Fisheries, Agriculture and Blue Economy, aimed to bolster bilateral cooperation in agricultural research, education, capacity building and technology transfer between the two countries.

- **Work Plan (2026-31):** For the implementation of the MoU, both countries signed a 5-year Work Plan (2026-31), which focuses on agriculture-related specific areas such as: climate-smart agriculture, horticulture, post-harvest management, livestock development and sustainable food and nutritional security.

Key Announcements:

Seychelles Joins CDRI: Among the key announcements made during PM Modi visit, Seychelles officially joined the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI), further strengthening bilateral cooperation in disaster resilience and sustainable infrastructure.

- Launched by India in 2019, CDRI promotes climate- and disaster-resilient infrastructure for sustainable development.

Food and Humanitarian Assistance: The GoI handed over 500 Metric Tonne (MT) of rice and 8500 MT of cement to the Government of Seychelles.

Upgradation of Dornier Aircraft: India upgraded a Dornier aircraft with a glass cockpit for Seychelles.

Refit PS Zoroaster: India has also announced the completion of refit PS Zoroaster for Seychelles Coast Guard.

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Education: Also, a virtual ground-breaking ceremony was organised for the professional and technical education centre.

About Seychelles:

President- Dr. Patrick Herminie
Capital- Victoria
Currency- Seychellois Rupee (SCR)

Overview of FM Sitharaman's Visit to France from July 1-4, 2026

Union Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Ministry of Finance (MoF), undertook a four-day official visit to **France** from 1 to 4 July 2026, holding high-level engagements to strengthen the India–France Strategic Partnership, expand economic cooperation and promote investment.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Union FM Nirmala Sitharaman visited France
- ✓ **Dates of Visit:** July 1 to 4, 2026
- ✓ **Key Event:** India-France Economic and Financial Dialogue (EFD)
- ✓ **Co-chaired by:** Union FM Nirmala Sitharaman (India) and Roland Lescure (France)
- ✓ **Key Focus Areas:** Critical minerals, resilient supply chains, cross-investments, urban infrastructure, climate, energy and technology cooperation
- ✓ **Key Engagements:** Roundtables with select global CEOs and business executives; Yann Gerardin, Deputy CEO (BNP Paribas Group);and Sebastian Bougon, President (Flying Whales)
- ✓ Visited International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor project.

Highlights of Visit to France:

Dialogue: Union Finance Minister **(FM) Sitharaman,** along with **Roland Lescure,** France's Minister of Economy, Finance, and Industrial and Energy Sovereignty, co-chaired the India-France Economic and Financial Dialogue (EFD) held at **Aix-en Provence** in Southern France.

- **Critical Minerals:** Both countries have agreed to boost cooperation on critical minerals as part of a wider conversation on securing resilient supply chains.
- **Financial Relations:** Both countries discussed ways to boost cross-investments, aimed at supporting greater trade, investment, and technology collaboration between India and France. They also acknowledged the prospects for future projects in areas like urban infrastructure, climate and energy.
- **Future Roadmap:** FMs of both countries committed to use the EFD as a key platform to address economic, financial, technological, investment and trade issues between India and France; and also agreed to explore the possibility of conducting the next edition of dialogue in 2027.

Business Engagements: She participated in high-level roundtables with global chief executive officers (CEOs) and business leaders, highlighting India's strong macroeconomic fundamentals, structural reforms, expanding investment opportunities and long-term growth potential.

- She met Yann Gerardin, Deputy CEO and Executive Chairman of Corporate and Institutional Banking BNP Paribas Group who highlighted global investors' confidence in India, supported by its strong Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI).
- She also met Sebastian Bougon, President of Flying Whales, who expressed interest in developing the company's manufacturing ecosystem in India, and Renaud Muselier, President of the Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur (PACA) Region, to discuss cooperation in investment, innovation, clean energy, technology and regional economic partnerships.

ITER Visit: She also visited the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor **(ITER) project at Cadarache**, France.

- The ITER project is considered to be one of the largest international scientific collaborations on nuclear fusion energy in the world, which involves over 30 partner countries, including India and France.
- Additionally, she visited the Campus Cyber, national centre for cybersecurity innovation, research and skill development of France, where she explored opportunities to foster collaboration in deepening cyber resilience, digital innovation and technology partnerships.

About France:

President- Emmanuel Macron
Capital- Paris
Currency- Euro (EUR)

Overview of PM Narendra Modi's Visit to Indonesia from July 6 to 8, 2026

Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** undertook a 3-day state visit to Indonesia from July 6 to 8 2026, at the invitation of **Prabowo Subianto,** President of Indonesia, to strengthen bilateral ties and strategic cooperation between India and Indonesia.

- This marked PM Narendra Modi's **4th** visit to Indonesia and 1st bilateral visit since India-Indonesia bilateral relations elevated to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP) in May 2018.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** PM Narendra Modi visited Indonesia
- ✓ **Parliament Address:** Became the first Indian PM to address Indonesia's Parliament.
- ✓ Unveiled the Ganga–Mahakam Vision
- ✓ **Honour**: Received the Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia (Medal of Honour)
- ✓ **Key Launches:** Prambanan Temple Restoration Project; **Restoration Project led by: ASI (GoI)**
- ✓ **Key Outcomes:** 20, including 14 MoUs and 6 major announcements
- ✓ **MoU:** defence, space, healthcare, agriculture, technology, and critical minerals, among others
- ✓ **Key Announcements:**
- ✓ India to supply 100 tonnes of high-quality DWR-162 wheat seeds to Indonesia;
- ✓ Deployment of ILO at IFC-IOR (in Gurugram, Haryana, India);
- ✓ 2026-27 as "Tagore-Dewantara Year of Cultural and Educational Diplomacy";
- ✓ IIM-B branch campus at Singhasari SEZ, Malang in Indonesia, among others.

Key Highlights of Visit to Indonesia:

Arrival: PM Narendra Modi arrived in Jakarta, the capital city of Indonesia which was first leg of PM Modi's three-nation tour that includes Australia and New Zealand.

- He was received by Indonesian President Subianto at the airport, where he was accorded a ceremonial welcome that featured an escort by an Indonesian Air Force fighter jet.

Bilateral Meeting: PM Modi held bilateral talks with Indonesian President Prabowo at Istana Merdeka (Presidential Palace) in Jakarta.

- where they reviewed cooperation in areas including defence and security, maritime affairs, trade and investment, the digital economy, science and technology, space, energy, agriculture, health, education, culture, and regional and global developments of mutual interest.

Addressed Indonesian Parliament: PM Narendra Modi became the **1st Indian PM** to address the Indonesian Parliament (Dewan Perwakilan Rakyat, DPR) in Jakarta, Indonesia

- During his address, he unveiled an ambitious "Ganga-Mahakam Vision", designed to foster long-term strategic partnership between the two countries, spanning maritime security, defence, connectivity, economic growth, and the Global South.

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Honour: During the visit, PM Modi was conferred with **'Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia'** also known **as the Medal of Honour,** the highest civilian honour of Indonesia, in recognition of his contribution to bolstering bilateral relations between the two countries. He became the second Indian PM, after Jawaharlal Nehru, to receive Indonesia's Bintang Adipurna award.

- Following this latest recognition, PM Modi has now received **35 international honours** from countries across Asia, Europe, Africa and the Americas since 2016, becoming the 1st Indian PM to receive the highest number of global honours.

Visit to Prambanan Temple: PM Narendra Modi, along with Indonesian President Subianto visited the **Prambanan Temple,** a 1,000-year old Hindu shrine dedicated to the Trimurti (Lord Shiva, Lord Vishnu and Lord Brahma), located on the island of Java in Yogyakarta, Indonesia.

- During his visit to the temple, he and the Indonesian President jointly inaugurated the Prambanan Temple Complex restoration project. The project will be led by Archaeological Survey of India **(ASI).**
- **Significance:** The Prambanan temple, recognised as United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO) World Heritage Site (in 1991), is the largest hindu temple complex in Indonesia and 2nd-largest in South-East (SE) after Angkor Wat (in Cambodia).

Outcomes of the Visit:

Joint Statement: Following the bilateral talks held between PM Modi and Indonesian President, both countries issued a joint statement.

- **Zero Tolerance Against Terrorism:** Both countries reaffirmed their commitment towards a zero tolerance approach to terrorism. They agreed to strengthen cooperation in preventing and countering terrorism through a series of measures such as: curbing terror financing, strengthening implementation of globally agreed anti-money laundering, among others.
- **Security:** They also welcomed the planned 3rd India-Indonesia Security Dialogue, which provides a platform to expand cooperation in counter-terrorism, cybersecurity, emerging technologies, maritime security, among others.
- **Trade:** They also reviewed the progress of Association of Southeast Nations (ASEAN)-India Trade in Goods Agreement (AITIGA) to strengthen bilateral cooperation in trade and investment.
- **Global Cooperation:** Indonesia has also extended its support for India's Chairship for BRICS (acronym for Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa) Summit scheduled in 2026.

MoUs & Agreements: PM Modi visit to Indonesia resulted in 20 key outcomes, including 14 Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) and agreements across defence, space, healthcare, agriculture, technology and critical minerals, along with six key announcements covering strategic, economic, technological and cultural cooperation.

- **Space Cooperation:** India and Indonesia signed an extension of framework agreement on cooperation in exploration and uses of outer space for peaceful purposes, aimed to boost space cooperation between the two countries.
- In addition, both countries agreed to promote joint research, technology sharing and capacity building in the space sector.
- **Healthcare:** Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation **(CDSCO)**, of Government of India (GoI) signed a MoU with Indonesia's National Agency of Drug and Food Control **(BPOM)** on cooperation in the field of medical products regulation. The MoU will provide greater access for Indonesian citizens to India's high-quality and affordable medicines.
- Also, a separate implementation agreement was signed between two countries to foster health workforce collaboration.

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- **Critical Minerals:** In order to strengthen supply chains in critical minerals, both countries signed an MoU on cooperation in the field of minerals.
- Also, a separate MoU was signed between Non-Ferrous Materials Technology Development Centre (NFTDC), Midwest Ltds., and PT Perusahaan Mineral Nasional (PERMINAS) for the development of rare earth magnets
- **Maritime Safety and Security Cooperation**: India and Indonesia extended their MoU and Implementation Agreement to strengthen cooperation in maritime safety and security, including information sharing, capacity building, coordinated operations and maritime-domain awareness.
- **Agriculture and Allied Sectors:** India and Indonesia signed a MoU to strengthen cooperation in agriculture and allied sectors, including agricultural research, technology exchange, capacity building, sustainable farming practices and trade in agricultural products.
- **Disaster Management:** A MoU was signed between India's National Disaster Management Authority (**NDMA**) and Indonesia's National Agency for Disaster Management to bolster cooperation in disaster management.
- **Electoral Cooperation:** The Election Commission of India (ECI) signed a MoU with the General Elections Commission (KPU) of Indonesia, aimed at strengthening democratic institutions in two countries. As part of the MoU, India will help Indonesia in developing Indonesia- specific Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs).
- **Defence Cooperation:** Both countries signed an agreement on BrahMos Missile System. As per the MoU, Indonesia will buy **BrahMos** supersonic missiles from India, becoming the **3rd South-East (SE) nation** (after the Philippines and Vietnam) to formalize the deal for the procurement of these supersonic missiles.
- In addition, India will support Indonesia to expand its BrahMoS missile inventory by supplying additional batteries, further deepening defence cooperation between two counties.
- **BrahMoS:** It was developed by **BrahMos Aerospace Pvt. Ltd.,** a Joint Venture (JV) between India's Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and Russia's NPO Mashinostroyeniya, to Indonesia
- **Supply of Astra Missiles:** Also, both countries signed a separate Air-to-Air Missile (AAM) cooperation agreement for the supply of all-weather **Astra** Beyond-Visual-Range Air-to-Air Missiles (BVRAAM), developed by DRDO for the Indian Navy (IN) and Indian Air Force (IAF), to Indonesia.
- **Steel:** India's Steel Authority of India **(SAIL)** signed a MoU with Indonesia's Pt. Krakatau Steel, aimed to explore a strategic JV between these two entities for the establishment of a stainless-steel slab manufacturing facility in Indonesia.
- Under this strategic partnership, Indonesia will provide access to one of the world's richest reserves of nickel, an essential raw material for stainless steel, while SAIL will bring its more than 50 years of experience in steel-making, and will oversee project execution and operationalisation of large integrated steel plants.
- **Other Key MoUs:** Also, both countries signed several other MoUs in the field of Telecommunications Technologies and Services; Research, Technology, and Innovation.

Key Announcements:

- **Deployment of Indonesian Liaison Officer:** Both countries have agreed for the deployment of an Indonesian Liaison Office (ILO) at the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR) in Gurugram, Haryana (India).

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- **Food Security:** During his visit to Indonesia, PM Modi announced that India will supply 100 tonnes of high-quality Dharwad Wheat Research (DWR) 162 wheat seeds to Indonesia, aimed at strengthening the island country's food security.
- **Cultural Cooperation:** India and Indonesia jointly announced the **2026-27** as the "Tagore-Dewantara Year of Cultural and Educational Diplomacy" to commemorate the centenary (100th year) of Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore's historic visit to Indonesia in **1927** and honour the enduring legacy of Indonesia's 1st education minister Ki Hajar Dewantara, who was deeply influenced by Tagore, through a series of joint cultural, educational, academic and people-to-people ties to be organised in both countries.
- **IIM-B Branch Campus:** Following the bilateral meeting with the Indonesian President, PM Modi announced the setting up of the Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore (IIM-B) branch campus at Singhasari Special Economic Zone (SEZ), Malang in Indonesia.
- **Launch of ION:** Also, both countries announced the launch of Indonesia Open Network (ION), based on Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) architecture in India
- **Sabang Port:** Also, India and Indonesia have agreed to jointly develop the Sabang Port, located on Weh Island in the north of Sumatra, Indonesia. The proposed project, roughly 100 miles away from the Great Nicobar port project of India, is expected to boost the planned transshipment hub and enhance the country's maritime connectivity.

India–Indonesia Trade:

Trade: Indonesia is India's second-largest trading partner in the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) region.

Growth: Bilateral trade increased from USD 4.3 billion in 2005–06 to USD 38.84 billion in 2022–23, before reaching USD 28.15 billion in 2024–25.

- During April 2025–February 2026, trade between the two countries stood at USD 22.72 billion. India's exports to Indonesia were valued at USD 5.38 billion in 2024–25, while imports amounted to USD 22.78 billion.

About Indonesia:

President – Prabowo Subianto
Capital – Jakarta
Currency – Indonesian Rupiah (IDR)

Overview of PM Narendra Modi's Visit to Australia from July 8-10, 2026

Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** undertook a 3-day official visit to Australia, 2nd leg of his three-nation tour (Indonesia, New Zealand), from **July 08 to July 10 2026,** at the invitation of **Anthony Albanese MP,** PM of Australia.

- The visit aimed at strengthening cooperation across sectors, including agriculture, science and technology, space, innovation and clean energy.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Overview of PM Modi visit to Australia
- ✓ **Dates of Visit:** July 08 to July 10, 2026
- ✓ **Invited by:** Anthony Albanese MP, PM of Australia
- ✓ **Key Engagements:** Australia-CEOs Forum and Economic Roadmap Business Reception
- ✓ **Held in:** Melbourne, Australia
- ✓ **Investment Commitment:** AUD 500 million in India's NIIF
- ✓ **Committed by:** AustralianSuper
- ✓ **Key Launch:** PACTS Framework

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- ✓ **Replaces:** 2020 Framework Arrangement on Cyber and Cyber Enabled Critical Technology Cooperation (2020 Framework)
- ✓ **Key Pillars:** 05 (supply chain resilience, critical technology, cybersecurity, digital resilience, and defence research and collaboration)

Key Highlights of Visit to Australia:

Ceremonial Welcome: During his visit to Australia, PM Modi received a ceremonial welcome and a Guard of Honour at the ceremonial event held at Government House Victoria in Melbourne, where he was received by Australian PM Anthony Albanese.

Australia-India CEO Forum: PM Modi along with his Australian counterpart Albanese, jointly addressed the Australia-India Chief Executive Officers (CEOs) Forum, originally established in 2012 and relaunched by Modi and Albanese in 2023, and the Economic Roadmap Business event held in Melbourne, Australia.

- **Call for Investment in India:** While addressing the forum, PM Modi invited Australian businesses to invest in India, outlining opportunities across sectors like: manufacturing, clean energy, Artificial intelligence, critical minerals, digital economy, infrastructure, aviation, logistics, food processing, financial services and advanced technologies.
- **Focus on Clean Energy:** He further emphasised that Australian technology, investment and resources could help India in achieving its national target of 500 Giga-Watt (GW) of Renewable Energy (RE) capacity by 2030 and net-zero emissions by 2070.
- **Economic Roadmap Business Reception:** Also, PM Modi urged businesses from both countries to jointly develop global solutions in areas such as rare earths, lithium, batteries, semiconductors, electric vehicles, AI and defence supply chains.
- **Investment Announcement:** During the event, AustralianSuper, largest pension fund of Australia pledged an investment of **AUD 500 million** in National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) of India. With this latest announcement, the total investment by the Australian pension fund in India now reaches **AUD 3.3 billion.**

Launch of PACTS: India and Australia launched "Australia-India Partnership on Cyber, Critical Technologies, and Supply Chains **(PACTS)",** a new framework aimed to promote secure supply supply chains, trusted digital infrastructure, technology innovation and cyber resilience across the Indo-Pacific region.

- **Succeeds:** The newly launched initiative succeeds and replaces the existing 2020 Framework Arrangement on Cyber and Cyber Enabled Critical Technology Cooperation (2020 Framework).
- **Key Pillars:** The new framework is structured around **5 key pillars:** supply chain resilience, critical technology, cybersecurity, digital resilience, and defence research and collaboration.
- **Administered by:** The new strategic partnership will be jointly administered by the Deputy National Security Advisor (NSA) of India and Deputy Secretary of the International and Security Group of Australia in the PM and Cabinet.
- **Annual Review Meeting:** The framework mandates an annual senior officials' meeting to review progress, identify emerging cyber and technology risks, and determine new collaborative projects under each pillar.

Expansion of Areas of Cooperation: Over the last 10 years, India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP) has been expanded to areas like: agriculture, science and technology, space, innovation and clean energy, complementing the growing strategic and economic engagement between the two countries.

- **Agriculture:** Since 2012, agricultural cooperation between the two countries has steadily expanded through regular Joint Working Group (JWG) meetings. The 6th Joint Working Group on Agriculture, held in Canberra in February 2025, reviewed progress in agricultural trade, research and market access.

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Science and Technology: India-Australia Strategic Research Fund (AISRF), established in 2005, continues to support collaborative research between institutions in both countries, with the 16th round of funding applications launched in 2025.

- **Climate Resilience:** The Australia-India Water Security Initiative (AIWASI) approved in 2022 and the 6th JWG on Water Cooperation held in November 2023, focusing on sustainable water management and climate resilience.
- **Space Cooperation:** In 2012, both countries signed an agreement on civil space cooperation that laid the foundation for growing collaboration between the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and the Australian Space Agency. Some of the key collaborations in the space sector include: AUD18 million investment by Australia (in 2024) to support three joint space projects under its International Space Investment programme; an agreement on crew and crew module recovery for India's Gaganyaan human spaceflight mission (in November 2024), among others.
- **Innovation:** Some of the key collaborations in the innovation sector include: India-Australia Rapid Innovation and Startup Expansion (RISE) Accelerator, launched by Atal Innovation Mission (AIM) and Australia's Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation (CSIRO) in 2023 to support startups working on circular economy technologies; the inaugural cohort selected 14 startups, with seven each from India and Australia.
- **IndAus ECTA:** In April 2022, both countries signed the India-Australia Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (IndAus ECTA) which later came into force on December 29, 2022. It is designed to provide a major boost to bilateral trade and investment.
- **CECA:** Both countries are negotiating for a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA), with eleven rounds of negotiations completed so far. The agreement is designed to further strengthen market access and deepen economic integration between the two countries.
- **Bilateral Trade:** Currently, India is the sixth-largest trading partner of Australia. The Bilateral trade between two countries in goods and services reaches AUD 48.9 billion (or, USD32.6 billion), registering a growth of 0.59% over Calendar Year 2022 (CY22). India's exports to Australia are valued at AUD13.7 billion (around USD 9.1 billion), and Imports from Australia total AUD 35.2 billion (around USD 23.5 billion)

About Australia:

Capital- Canberra
Prime Minister **(PM)-** Anthony Albanese
Currency- Australian Dollar (AUD)

Overview of PM Narendra Modi's Visit to Australia from July 8-10, 2026 – Part – II

Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** participated in the **3rd India-Australia Annual Leaders' Summit** hosted by Australian PM Anthony Albanese MP, in Melbourne.

- Following the annual summit, both countries unveiled a list of the **18 major agreements and initiatives,** spanning defence, maritime security, clean energy, critical technologies, education, skill development and cultural cooperation.
- Earlier, PM Modi held a bilateral meeting with Margaret Gardner AC, Governor of Victoria, at the Government House in Melbourne, where he signed the Visitor's Book.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Overview of PM Modi's Visit to Australia Part-II
- ✓ **Event:** India-Australia Annual Leaders' Summit in Melbourne, Australia
- ✓ **Edition of Summit:** 3rd
- ✓ **Hosted by:** Anthony Albanese MP, PM of Australia

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- ✓ **Key Outcomes of Summit:** 18
- ✓ **Key Sectors:** Defence, Maritime Security, Clean Energy, Critical Technologies, among others
- ✓ **Major Outcomes:** Adoption of JDDSC, Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap (MSCR); India-Australia Sports Collaboration Roadmap; and finalization of Administrative Arrangement India-Australia Civil Nuclear Agreement (supply of uranium to India), among others
- ✓ **Repatriation of Indian artifacts:** Granite Nandi sculpture; a bronze trident bearing the image of Goddess Bhadrakali; and a basalt sculpture of six-headed Skanda (Karttikeya)

Key Outcomes:

Nuclear Cooperation: One of the key outcomes of PM Modi's visit to Australia was the finalization of Administrative Arrangement of India-Australia Civil Nuclear Agreement (originally signed in 2014), facilitating the commercial supply of Australian uranium for India's civilian nuclear power programme.

- The newly signed agreement is expected to diversify energy sources of India, strengthen long-term energy targets in line with the Safe and Holistic Advancement of Nuclear Technology for India **(SHANTI) Act,2025** designed to expand the country's nuclear power capacity and ensure safe and responsible use of atomic energy.
- Also, both countries have agreed to jointly work on a critical minerals corridor.

India-Australia Sports Collaboration Roadmap: During his visit to Melbourne Cricket Ground (MCG), PM Modi along with his Australian counterpart Albanese, unveiled the India-Australia Sports Collaboration Roadmap, aimed at strengthening cooperation in sports training and capacity building, sports science and technology, and sports industry and investment between the two countries. It also proposes the launch of an India-Australia Youth Sports Festival.

- **Key Announcement:** During the event, both leaders announced the match of the upcoming edition of **Big Bash League**, which is scheduled to be held between the Melbourne Renegades and Perth Scorchers at MA Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN) in December 2026, marking the 1st official match of a foreign domestic cricket league played in India.

JDDSC: India and Australia signed a Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation **(JDDSC)** replacing the existing joint declaration on security (adopted in 2009).

- **Focus Areas:** The newly adopted declaration has identified key areas of defence collaboration such as: military interoperability, maritime security, defence industrial cooperation, cybersecurity, counter-terrorism, Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR), and unified approach in regional groupings like: Association of South East Asian Nations (ASEAN), the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) and the Pacific Islands Forum (PIF).
- **Appointment of Indian Military Instructor:** Apart from the adoption of joint declaration in defence cooperation, Australia announced the appointment of an Indian military instructor to serve at the Australian Defence College during 2028-29. This move is further expected to expand military-to-military engagement.

Maritime Security: Also, India and Australia unanimously adopted a Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap **(MSCR)** aimed to strengthen bilateral cooperation in maritime security through enhanced information sharing, capability development and operational coordination.

- Additionally, a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** was signed between the Indian Coast Guard **(ICG)** and Maritime Border Command **(MBC)** of Australia, designed to deepen collaboration in maritime law enforcement, maritime domain awareness and border protection.
- Both countries have also pledged to work closely in shipbuilding, ship repair and maintenance.

Energy Security: Both countries issued a Joint Statement on Energy Security reiterating their commitment to ensuring secure and resilient energy supply chains amid rising geopolitical uncertainties.

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Renewable Energy (RE): Additionally, leaders of both countries announced the operationalisation of the **Rooftop Solar Training Academy** at Pandit Deendayal Energy University (PDEU) in Gandhinagar, Gujarat (India).

- The proposed facility was established by India's Sector Skills Council for Green Jobs (SSCGJ), ReNEW Energy Global Plc, in collaboration with Australia's Department of Climate Change, Environment and Water (DCEEW).
- The initiative targets to train 2000 women and youth as solar technicians or installers or helpers in support of Prime Minister Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana (PMSGMBY) launched in January 2024.

Education: Both countries announced several initiatives to strengthen academic and vocational collaboration in the education sector.

- **Flinders University to Setup Campus in India:** The Government of Australia handed over a Letter of Intent (LoI) to Flinders University to set up a campus in Bengaluru, Karnataka (India).
- **Handing over Letter of Approval to Australia's VU:** Also, Australia's Victoria University **(VU)** received formal approval to operationalise its campus in Gurugram, Haryana (India) from August 2026, becoming the 1st university from the Australian state Victoria to set up a campus in Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR) under the National Education Policy (NEP 2020).

Skill Development: The Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship **(MSDE)** of Government of India (GoI) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Technical and Further Education **(TAFE**), the Government of Western Australia, to establish a Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Mining Equipment, Technology and Services (METS)at the National Skill Training Institute (NSTI) in Bhubaneswar, Odisha.

- The proposed facility will develop a centre of academic excellence in sub-domains of mining operations, mine safety, mineral processing, mine machinery, among others, while facilitating student and trainee exchanges.
- **LoI on Skill Development:** Also, a separate Letter of Intent (LoI)was signed between India's National Council for Vocational Education and Training **(NCVET**) and the Australian Skills Quality Authority (**ASQA**), aimed to strengthen quality assurance, occupational standards, regulatory cooperation and capacity building in vocational education and training.

Cultural Cooperation: Australia voluntarily announced to repatriate three significant Indian artifacts: granite Nandi sculpture (origins back to the 11th-12th century); a bronze trident bearing the image of Goddess Bhadrakali (11th Century) and a basalt sculpture of six-headed Skanda (Karttikeya) (12th-century).

Cyber, Critical Technologies, Supply Chains (PACTS): Builds on the 2020 Framework Arrangement to enhance cooperation in cyber security, critical technologies, resilient supply chains, and digital resilience, while supporting national and regional security.

Key MoUs:

Tripartite MoU in Technology: A trilateral MoU was signed under the Australia-Canada-India Technology and Innovation **(ACITI) Partnership,** designed to promote collaboration in critical and emerging technologies and innovation while complementing the existing bilateral initiatives among India, Australia and Canada.

- This newly formed strategic partnership is expected to support efforts towards achieving net zero targets and promote greater diversification of supply chains to build a secure, sustainable and resilient future.

Critical Minerals: The Geological Survey of India **(GSI)** and Geoscience Australia **(GA)** signed a renewed Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) in the field of critical minerals cooperation, built on the MoU on Scientific and Technical Cooperation originally signed in 2015.

- The newly signed MoU aimed to support advanced mineral exploration, technological modernisation, capacity building and scientific cooperation.

Scientific Collaboration: A MoU was signed between the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research **(CSIR)** of the GoI and the **University of Melbourne** of Australia, focusing on collaborative research, faculty exchanges, trainee programmes and drug discovery research between India and Australia.

- In addition, CSIR signed a separate agreement with IP Australia, providing access to India's Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (TKDL) to support patent examination and safeguard India's traditional knowledge.

Creative Cooperation: In order to deepen creative cooperation between the two countries, the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute **(SRFTI),** Kolkata (India) signed a MoU with Griffith Film School, South Brisbane, (Australia), aimed to foster collaboration in film education, workshops, academic exchanges and joint creative projects.

Gift Presentation:

Overview: During his three-nation tour, Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi presented Australian PM Anthony Albanese with a curated collection of Indian cultural gifts, including
Dhokra boat sculpture, the Colonial Cousins vinyl record **Indian Premium Coffee Box, s**howcasing India's tribal craftsmanship, musical heritage, and premium coffee traditions.

India-Australia Trade:

Ind-Aus ECTA: Since the operationalisation of India-Australia Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (Ind-Aus ECTA) in 2022, bilateral trade between the two countries increased significantly like: India's exports to Australia have more than doubled i.e. from USD 4 billion in Financial Year 2020-21 (FY21) to USD 8.5 billion in FY25.

Bilateral Trade: Also, the total bilateral trade between India and Australia reached USD 24.1 billion during FY25. During the same time period, India's exports to Australia registered a growth of 8% compared to the last year.

- In addition, India's total trade with Australia valued at USD 19.3 billion in FY26 (up to February).
- Also, India is the 5th largest trading partner of Australia with bilateral trade in goods and services stood at USD 54.4 billion in FY25.

Investment in India: Australia secured the 26th position in terms of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in India, registering a total investment of USD 1.67 billion (from April 2000 to September 2025).

Overview of PM Narendra Modi's Visit to New Zealand from July 10 to 11, 2026

Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** visited **New Zealand,** the final leg of his three-nation tour (Indonesia and Australia) from July 10 to 11, 2026, at the invitation of **Christopher Luxon,** PM of New Zealand.

- PM Narendra Modi arrived in Auckland (New Zealand), where he was received by New Zealand's PM Luxon at the airport, marking the 1st ever visit by an Indian PM to New Zealand in **40 years.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** PM Narendra Modi visited New Zealand
- ✓ **Dates of Visit:** July 10 to 11, 2026
- ✓ **Significance:** First visit by an Indian PM to New Zealand in 40 years
- ✓ **Highlights of Visit:** Accorded Māori powhiri ceremonial welcome; bilateral meeting with New Zealand PM
- ✓ **Where?** Government House (in Auckland, New Zealand)
- ✓ **Key Outcomes:** 18, including 2 trade partnerships, 10 agreements and 6 announcements.

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- ✓ **Key Sectors Covered:** Defence, trade, maritime security, disaster management, agriculture, tourism, sports, culture, among others
- ✓ **Bilateral Trade Target:** NZD 7 billion (around Rs 35,000 crore) by 2030.

Highlights of Visit:

Ceremonial Welcome: During the visit, PM Narendra Modi received a traditional **Māori powhiri** ceremonial welcome at Government House in Auckland, which reflected the Kiwi country's rich indigenous heritage and cultural traditions.

Bilateral Meeting: Following the ceremonial welcome, PM Narendra Modi held a wide-ranging bilateral talks with his New Zealand counterpart Christopher Luxon.

- During the meeting, extensive discussions were held in both restricted and delegation-level formats, covering the entire spectrum of bilateral cooperation, including trade and investment, defence and security, agri-tech, sports, education, tourism, culture and people-to-people exchanges.

Key Outcomes:

The meeting resulted in 18 key outcomes, including 2 trade partnerships, 10 agreements, and 6 announcements.

Elevation of Strategic Partnership: One of the key outcomes of bilateral talks held between leaders of India and New Zealand was the elevation of bilateral ties to the level of a Strategic Partnership (SP), strengthening cooperation in trade, defence, maritime security, tourism, culture, sports, agri-tech, people-to-people ties, and multilateral engagement.

- In addition, both countries adopted the **Roadmap to 2030,** formulating a strategic framework to guide structured implementation of the India–New Zealand SP across relevant ministries and stakeholders for the next four years.

Doubling Bilateral Trade by 2030: Both countries have set a target to double bilateral trade to **NZD 7 billion** (approximately Rs 35,000 crore) by **2030** to boost economic ties and expand market access, supported by the recently concluded India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA).

10 Key MoUs:

Maritime Security: The Ministry of Defence (MoD) of the Government of India (GoI) signed Memorandum of Arrangement (MoA) on maritime cooperation with the New Zealand Defence Force, aimed to strengthen cooperation in the Indo-Pacific through dialogue, coordination, information exchange, and joint activities.

Hydrography: India and New Zealand finalized the implementation arrangement concerning cooperation in the matters of Hydrography and Nautical Cartography between the two countries, enabling joint production of navigational charts, hydrographic data sharing and capacity building.

Logistics Support: Also, both countries announced an arrangement concerning the provision of Mutual Logistics Support between the Indian Navy (IN) and the New Zealand Defence Force.

- The new arrangement will facilitate reciprocal logistics support between the naval forces of the two countries, during approved activities and operations.

Counter-Terrorism: Also, India and New Zealand have agreed to establish a Joint Working Group (JWG) on Counter-Terrorism to bolster cooperation, intelligence sharing and coordination in combating terrorism.

Disaster management: The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) of GoI signed a Memorandum of Cooperation (MoC) with New Zealand's National Emergency Management Agency (NEMA) aimed to promote collaboration in disaster risk management, focusing mainly on earthquake resilience, tsunami preparedness, coastal hazard mitigation, knowledge exchange, policy dialogue, and capacity building.

Agriculture & Allied Sectors: A MoC was signed between the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying (MoFAH&D) of GoI and the Ministry of Primary Industries of the Government of New

Zealand, providing a framework for enhanced cooperation in animal husbandry and dairying through technical collaboration, knowledge exchange, and best practices.

Tourism: A MoA was signed between the Ministry of Tourism (MoT) of GoI and the Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment of New Zealand, aimed to promote greater tourist flows and strengthen economic and cultural ties between the two countries.

Sports Cooperation: Also, both countries unanimously adopted the India-New Zealand Joint Action Plan on Sport, establishing a framework for collaboration in high-performance sports, sports science, sports medicine and athlete development.

Cultural Cooperation: India's National Maritime Heritage Complex (NMHC) signed a MoA with the New Zealand Maritime Museum, for the development of the heritage complex at Lothal in Gujarat (India).

- In addition, India's Ministry of Culture and New Zealand's Ministry of Culture and Heritage, signed a separate arrangement to promote cultural cooperation through exchanges in arts, heritage, and cultural initiatives to strengthen mutual understanding and people-to-people ties.

6 Key Announcements:

Maritime Cooperation: Following the bilateral meeting held between the PMs of India and New Zealand, both countries agreed to establish a **Maritime Security Dialogue.**

- Also, the Government of New Zealand has identified Maritime Security as the priority pillar under the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative **(IPOI)** initiative, to undertake specific cooperation activities focused on combating Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated (IUU) Fishing.

Clean Energy: New Zealand announced its decision to join the GoI-led Global Biofuels Alliance (**GBA**), reinforcing global collaboration on sustainable biofuels and energy transition.

Horticulture: India and New Zealand jointly launched a **Kiwifruit Action Plan** under the Agricultural Productivity Partnership, part of the FTA.

- Also, they announced the establishment of two Centres of Excellence (CoEs) for Kiwifruit in Nagaland and Uttarakhand to promote agricultural innovation, skills development and productivity.

Scientific and Academic Cooperation: The National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research **(NCPOR)**, Goa (India) signed a MoU with the **University of Canterbury** (New Zealand) aimed to foster collaboration in Antarctic research through joint research, academic exchange, capacity building, and other mutually beneficial scientific and educational activities.

- In addition, an agreement was signed between National Institute of Food Technology, Entrepreneurship and Management, Kundli **(NIFTEM-K)** & **Massey University,** New Zealand to promote research, student mobility and academic exchanges.

India's Cultural Gift Diplomacy:

For New Zealand's Leaders: PM Narendra Modi presented two gifts, including a **hockey stick** signed by the entire Indian Women's Hockey team (celebrating their win at the 2026 FIH Hockey Women's nations cup held in New Zealand); and a **traditional Uttarakhandi Cap,** to New Zealand's PM Luxon.

- In addition, he also gifted a **Dhokra tree of life sculpture** (Bastar, Chhattisgarh), showcasing the ancient Dhokra metal craft using the lost-wax casting technique, to his New Zealand counterpart.
- PM Modi also gifted a Zari Zardosi Wall Hanging (Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh, UP) to New Zealand's Opposition leader Chris Hipkins.

For Indonesian Leadership: During his visit to Indonesia, PM Modi gifted a **Manohari Gold Tea** (from Assam) which is one of India's finest speciality teas, made exclusively from the buds of the P126 tea clone, to **Prabowo Subianto,** President of Indonesia.

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- In addition, the Indonesian President also received **Aipan art of Shiva,** a traditional folk art from the Kumaon region of Uttarakhand, dedicated to Lord Shiva; and a traditional Kashmiri **Papier-Mache bowl,** featuring hand-painted floral and bird motifs.
- PM Modi also presented Odisha Ikat (locally known as Banda), a traditional handloom silk famous for its intricate tie-and-dye technique, to Puan Maharani, Speaker of Indonesian Parliament.

About New Zealand:

Prime Minister **(PM)-** Christopher Luxon
Capital- Wellington
Currency- New Zealand Dollar (NZD)

Overview of President Droupadi Murmu's visits to Moldova, North Macedonia & Romania From July 19-25, 2026

President of India Droupadi Murmu was on a week-long state visit to **Moldova, North Macedonia, and Romania** from July 19 to 25, 2026, aimed at promoting relations in trade, technology, tourism and other sectors.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** President Droupadi Murmu's State Visit to three European nations
- ✓ **Visit Duration:** 19–25 July 2026
- ✓ **Countries Visited:** Moldova, North Macedonia & Romania
- ✓ **Objective:** Strengthen cooperation in trade, technology, investment, education and innovation
- ✓ **First-Ever Visits:** Moldova & North Macedonia by an Indian President
- ✓ **Moldova:**
- ✓ Launched 3Ts Roadmap
- ✓ **North Macedonia:**
- ✓ Unveiled a bust of Mahatma Gandhi
- ✓ India – North Macedonia Business Forum at Skopje
- ✓ **Romania:**
- ✓ Conferred Doctor Honoris Causa by the BUES
- ✓ MoUs signed: 3 (Science & Technology, Education, and Sports)
- ✓ Declare 2028 as the India–Romania Year of Innovation.

Visit to Moldova:

Arrival: On 20 July 2026, President Droupadi Murmu arrived in Chisinau, Moldova, on the first leg of her three-nation European tour at the invitation of President Maia Sandu, where she was received at Chisinau International Airport by Mihai Popșoi, Deputy Prime Minister (PM) and Minister of Foreign Affairs of Moldova.

- This marked the first ever visit by an Indian President to the Eastern European nation, since the establishment of diplomatic ties between two countries in 1992.
- She was accompanied by Union Minister of State (MoS) Nimuben Jayantibhai Bambhaniya, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution (MoCAF&PD); Dr. Dinesh Sharma, Member of Parliament, Rajya Sabha and Vijay Baghel, Member of Parliament, Lok Sabha.

Bilateral Engagement: Later, **President Droupadi Murmu** was accorded a ceremonial welcome and guard of honour at the Presidential Palace, where she was warmly received by Maia Sandu, President of the Republic of Moldova.

- President Droupadi Murmu and President Maia Sandu held bilateral and delegation-level talks to strengthen India–Moldova ties, with a focus on trade, investment, resilient supply chains, connectivity, and business engagement.

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- Both leaders also agreed to enhance cooperation in agriculture, logistics, infrastructure, healthcare, pharmaceuticals, Renewable Energy (RE), Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), Artificial Intelligence (AI), and innovation.

3Ts Roadmap: During President Murmu visit to Moldova, the Government of India (GoI) has laid out a **3Ts (Trade, Technology, and Talent) roadmap** that aims to boost economic ties between two countries.

- **Trade:** Both countries have set a target to double their current trade volume in the coming years. Also, India's latest Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) with the European Union (EU) will help India and Moldova to work more closely together on commerce.
- **Technology and Talent:** The GoI has decided to double the number of Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) training slots for Moldovan professionals, including specialised courses in AI and other emerging technologies. In addition, the Government of Moldova has offered participation of its diplomats in special courses on AI and Cyber diplomacy at the Foreign Service Institute of India (FSII).

Other Key Engagements: During her visit to Moldova, President Murmu also met **Igor Grosu,** the President of the Parliament of Moldova.

- She also interacted with members of the Moldova-India Parliamentary Friendship Group, and addressed the India-Moldova Business Forum held at Chisinau, the capital city of Moldova.

Visit to North Macedonia:

Arrival: After concluding her day-long visit to Moldova, President Murmu visited North Macedonia from July 21 to 22,2026, at the invitation of Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova, President of North Macedonia, marking first ever visit by an Indian President to North Macedonia.

Key Engagements: The President of India held bilateral talks with Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova, President of North Macedonia; met Hristijan Mickoski Prime Minister (PM); and also addressed the Assembly of North Macedonia 'Sobranie', at the Sobranie Palace in Skopje, North Macedonia.

- She also addressed the inaugural session of India – North Macedonia Business Forum at Skopje.

Other Key Engagements: President Droupadi Murmu, along with her North Macedonian counterpart Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova unveiled a **bust of Mahatma Gandhi** at the Museum of the City of Skopje.

- **Paid Tribute to Mother Teresa:** Earlier, she also visited the Memorial of Mother Teresa in Skopje, the birth place of Mother Teresa where she lived until 1928.
- **World Heritage Site Lake Ohrid:** Also, she visited the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO)-recognised World Heritage site, Lake Ohrid which is one of the deepest and oldest lakes of Europe, featuring a unique aquatic ecosystem with over 200 endemic species.

Visit to Romania:

Arrival: President Droupadi Murmu arrived at the Bucharest airport, part of the final leg of her three-nation tour, where she was received by Romanian Foreign Minister Oana-Silvia Toiu.

- She visited Romania at the invitation of Nicuşor Dan, President of Romania, marking the first state visit by an Indian President to Romania in nearly 30 years.

Bilateral Meeting: She held bilateral talks with Romanian President Nicusor Dan at the Cotroceni Palace (the official residence of the Romanian President) where she was accorded a ceremonial welcome and guard of honour.

- During the meeting, both leaders agreed to expand bilateral cooperation across key sectors: manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, health, RE, green hydrogen, agricultural production and fertilizers, science and technology, DPI and AI.

Honour: During her visit to Romania, President Murmu was conferred with the honorary title of **'Doctor Honoris Causa'** by the Bucharest University of Economic Studies (BUES), in recognition of her

distinguished public service, commitment to education and social welfare, and contribution to deepening of India-Romania relations.

Other Key Engagements: President Murmu addressed the **India-Romania Business Forum** held at Bucharest in the presence of her Romanian counterpart Dan, business leaders from both countries and representatives of Industry Associations of India and Romania.

Key MoUs: Both countries signed **three** key Memorandums of Understanding **(MoUs)** in the areas of science and technology, Education and sports:

- **Science & Technology:** Both countries have agreed to expand joint Research & Development (R&D) under the Programme of Cooperation in Science and Technology.
- **Cultural Cooperation:** Also, the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) will help in establishing the Indian Studies Chair at the University of Bucharest.

Key Announcements: Some of the key announcements made following the bilateral meeting between leaders of India and Romania.

- **Bilateral Trade:** India and Romania have set the target to double bilateral trade over the next three years.
- **Capacity Building:** The GoI has announced to double the number of training opportunities for Romanian nationals under the ITEC programme, including special courses on AI and cyber diplomacy.
- **India-Romania Year of Innovation:** In addition, both countries announced **2028** as the "India-Romania Year of Innovation" to commemorate 80 years of diplomatic relations.
- **International Cooperation:** Also, the Government of Romania has expressed interest to join the India-led Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) and the Global Biofuels Alliance (GBA).

About Moldova:

President- Maia Sandu
Capital- Chisinau
Currency- Moldovan Leu (MDL)

BANKING & FINANCE

RBI IN NEWS

RBI Imposes Rs 66.7 Lakh Penalty on BoB & GIC Housing Finance

In July 2026, the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** imposed a combined monetary penalty of **Rs 66.7 lakh** on **Bank of Baroda (BoB)** and **General Insurance Corporation of India** (**GIC) Housing Finance** for non-compliance with regulatory directions, including Know Your Customer (KYC) norms and lending guidelines.

- The action was taken after RBI observed deficiencies during supervisory inspection, including violations of the Fair Practices Code for Lenders and KYC norms.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** RBI imposes penalties on banks/NBFCs
- ✓ **Who?** Bank of Baroda & GIC Housing Finance
- ✓ **Regulator?** Reserve Bank of India (RBI)
- ✓ **Penalty Amounts?** Rs 63.6 lakh (BoB), Rs 3.1 lakh (GIC HF)
- ✓ **Key Violation?** KYC non-compliance & lending irregularities

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RBI Penalty Action

Bank of Baroda: RBI imposed a penalty of Rs 63.6 lakh for charging interest rates higher than the contracted rates, failing to upload KYC records to the Central KYC Records Registry (CKYCR) within the timelines, and non-compliance with the Fair Practices Code for lenders.

GIC Housing Finance: A penalty of Rs 3.1 lakh was imposed for deficiencies in compliance with Know Your Customer (KYC) guidelines.

About CKYCR Framework: The Central KYC Records Registry (CKYCR) is a centralized database managed by **Central Registry of Securitisation Asset Reconstruction and Security Interest of India (CERSAI)** on behalf of the Government of India (GoI) to store KYC records and streamline customer verification across financial institutions.

RBI Launched Three Key Surveys to Gather Inputs for Monetary Policy Formulation

In July 2026, the Reserve Bank of India **(RBI)** launched the Inflation Expectations Survey of Households **(IESH)**, Rural Consumer Confidence Survey **(RCCS)**, and Urban Consumer Confidence Survey **(UCCS)** to gather **household feedback** on inflation, economic conditions, employment, income, and spending across **19 cities** and **31 States/Union Territories (UTs)**.

- The surveys aim to assess inflation expectations and consumer confidence, providing key inputs for monetary policy formulation ahead of the Monetary Policy Committee **(MPC) meeting** scheduled for **August 3–5, 2026**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of 3 nationwide surveys
- ✓ **By Whom?** RBI
- ✓ **Surveys:** IESH, RCCS, UCCS
- ✓ **Coverage:** IESH and UCCS cover 19 cities, RCCS covers 31 States/UTs.
- ✓ **Features:** Measures household inflation expectations and consumer confidence through qualitative and quantitative responses.
- ✓ **Meeting:** MPC meeting scheduled for **August 3–5, 2026**.

About RBI's Three Monetary Policy Surveys:

Overview: The surveys aim to strengthen evidence-based monetary policy formulation by incorporating household expectations on inflation and economic conditions, thereby supporting the MPC in improving policy effectiveness.

Methodology: The surveys collect both qualitative perceptions and quantitative assessments from households, enabling the RBI to evaluate inflation expectations and consumer sentiment across different regions and demographic groups.

IESH: It was Conducted across 19 cities captures household assessments of price movements based on individual consumption baskets through qualitative responses on general and product-specific price changes over the next **three months and one year**, along with quantitative estimates of current, three-month-ahead, and one-year-ahead inflation.

RCCS: It collects household perceptions and one-year-ahead expectations on the general economic situation, employment scenario, overall price situation, household income, and spending across rural and semi-urban areas in 31 States and UTs.

UCCS: It is conducted across 19 cities to gather qualitative responses from households on the general economic situation, employment scenario, price levels, household income, and spending for the current period and one year ahead.

Survey Cities: The 19 cities covered under the IESH and UCCS are Ahmedabad (Gujarat), Bengaluru (Karnataka), Bhopal (Madhya Pradesh, MP), Bhubaneswar (Odisha), Chandigarh (UT), Chennai (Tamil Nadu, TN), Delhi, Guwahati (Assam), Hyderabad (Telangana), Jaipur (Rajasthan), Jammu (Jammu &

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Kashmir, J&K), Kolkata (West Bengal, WB), Lucknow (Uttar Pradesh, UP), Mumbai (Maharashtra), Nagpur (Maharashtra), Patna (Bihar), Raipur (Chhattisgarh), Ranchi (Jharkhand), and Thiruvananthapuram (Kerala).

About Reserve Bank of India (RBI):

Governor – Sanjay Malhotra
Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra
Established – 1 April 1935

RBI's FI Index Rises to 70 in FY26; Issues Final Prudential Norms on SNFA

In July 2026, the Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) released the composite data on the Financial Inclusion Index (**FI-Index**) for the financial year 2025-26 (**FY26**), which increased to **70** in March 2026 from 67 in March 2025.

- The RBI also issued new "**Prudential Norms on Specified Non Financial Asset (SNFA) acquired by Regulated Entities**", tightening norms governing the resolution of distressed loans. The new framework will come into effect from **October 1, 2026**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** RBI released FI Index for FY26
- ✓ **Score:** 70, improved from 67 in March 2025
- ✓ **Parameters:** Access (35%), Usage (45%), Quality (20%)
- ✓ **RBI Release:** Prudential norms on SNFA acquired by REs
- ✓ **Not Applicable buyers:** original defaulter, promoter of the defaulting entity, Related parties
- ✓ **Applicable from:** October 1, 2026
- ✓ **Timeline:** 7 years
- ✓ **Accounting rules:** Lowest of NBV or distress sale value.

About Financial Inclusion (FI) Index:

FI-Index: The RBI constructed the index in consultation with stakeholders and government to capture the extent of financial inclusion across the country, using a framework comprising **97** indicators.

Established in: The FI-Index was introduced by the RBI in **August 2021** for the FY21.

- The FI-Index has been constructed without any '**base year**'.
- It is published **annually** in **July** every year.

Score Range: The index captures information on various aspects of financial inclusion in a single value ranging between **0 and 100,** where:

- **0** represents complete financial exclusion and
- 100 indicates full financial inclusion.

Parameters: It comprises of **three** broad parameters:

- Access (35%): This measures the availability of financial services
- Usage (45%): It assessess how actively people use banking and financial products
- Quality (20%): It evaluates customer protection, financial literacy and the overall effectiveness of financial services.

RBI's New Norms on SNFA acquired by Regulated Entities:

In July 2026, the RBI issued final prudential norms under the' Resolution of Stressed Assets Directions, 2025', prohibiting Regulated Entities (REs) from selling **SNFA** back to defaulting borrowers.

Transfer Restriction: Under the revised norms, Regulated Entities (REs) cannot transfer SNFAs to the defaulting borrower, its promoters, related parties, or entities acting on the borrower's behalf.

- This restriction remains applicable even if the asset is subsequently reclassified as a non-SNFA.
- SNFA are immovable assets acquired by the lenders in full or partial settlement of outstanding claims against borrowers.

Applicable to: Commercial Banks **(CBs),** Small Finance Banks (**SFBs**), Non-Banking Financial Companies (**NBFCs**), Rural Co-operative Banks (**RCBs**), Urban Co-operative Banks (**UCBs**), Regional Rural Banks (**RRBs**), Local Area Banks (**LABs**) and All India Financial Institutions (**AIFI**).

Board Policy: The RBI has also directed RE to frame board-approved policies covering acquisition and disposal of SNFAs.

- These policies should specify limits on such assets as a share of total assets, eligibility criteria, delegation of powers, recovery efforts before acquisition and a maximum disposal period.

Acquisition Procedure: The RBI clarified that lenders can acquire an SNFA only after their exposure to a borrower has been classified as a Non-Performing Asset (NPA). The acquisition must occur against:

- Full settlement of outstanding dues (Or)
- partial settlement of outstanding dues on a non-recourse basis.

Timeline: Banks have been directed to dispose of such properties within the period specified in their internal policy, subject to a maximum of **seven years.**

Accounting Rules: An SNFA will have to be recorded in the balance sheet at the **lower of the net book value** of the extinguished loan or the distress sale value determined by at least two independent external valuers.

Disclosure Norms: While reporting SNFAs in their balance sheets, banks will exclude them from Gross Non-Performing Assets (Gross NPA), Net Non-Performing Assets (Net NPA), and stressed exposure calculations.

Timeline: The RBI has directed lenders to dispose of SNFAs through public auctions in accordance with the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002.

- Existing SNFAs outstanding as of 30 September 2026 must comply with the revised norms by 30 September 2027.

About the Reserve Bank of India (RBI):

Governor – Sanjay Malhotra
Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra
Established – 1935

DoLR & RBI Innovation Hub Explore Digital Land-Credit Infrastructure for Rural Lending

In July 2026, the Department of Land Resources **(DoLR)** under the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) held a high-level meeting with the Reserve Bank of India Innovation Hub **(RBIH)** to explore the convergence of Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) for land governance and digital lending.

- The initiative aims to create a secure, interoperable land-credit ecosystem to improve institutional credit access for farmers and rural citizens.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Explored Digital Land–Credit Infrastructure for rural lending
- ✓ **Entities:** DoLR & RBIH
- ✓ **Objective:** Integrate digital land records with the Unified Lending Interface (ULI) for secure, consent-based rural credit delivery.
- ✓ **Key Focus:** Digital land records, Kisan Credit Cards (KCC), agricultural loans, mortgage risk management, and financial inclusion.
- ✓ **Technology:** Adoption of ULPIN (Bhu-Aadhaar), API interoperability, and common data standards.

Key Highlights:

Chair: The meeting was chaired by **Narendra Bhooshan**, Secretary, DoLR, who interacted with **Sahil Kini**, Chief Executive Officer (CEO), RBIH, along with senior officials from both organisations.

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Focus: The discussions focused on integrating the DoLR's digital land governance initiatives with the Unified Lending Interface (ULI) to enable secure, seamless, and consent-based credit delivery, particularly for farmers and rural citizens.

Key Areas of Collaboration: The discussions covered secure access to authenticated digital land records, faster digital delivery of Kisan Credit Cards (KCC) and agricultural loans, improved loan processing, mortgage risk management, and greater financial inclusion through digital land-based credit.

- The meeting also emphasized common data standards, API interoperability, wider adoption of Unique Land Parcel Identification Number **(ULPIN) (Bhu-Aadhaar),** and stronger collaboration between land governance and financial sector stakeholders.

About ULI: Developed by the RBI as a DPI for lending, ULI enables faster and seamless credit delivery through data interoperability with consent-based sharing of information between borrowers, data providers, and lenders.

SEBI

SEBI Constitutes Expert Group to Review Debenture Trusteeship Framework

In June 2026, the Securities and Exchange Board of India **(SEBI)** constituted an Expert Working Group **(EWG)** chaired by former Whole-Time Member (WTM) **Ananta Barua** at New Delhi, Delhi, to review the regulatory framework for debenture trustees under the SEBI (Debenture Trustees) Regulations, 1993.

- The group will examine stakeholder representations and net-worth norms, and recommend measures to simplify, rationalise, and strengthen the regulatory framework by aligning it with evolving debt market developments and enhancing investor protection.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Formation of SEBI Expert Working Group on Debenture Trusteeship
- ✓ **Authority:** SEBI
- ✓ **Chair:** Ananta Barua (Former Whole-Time Member, SEBI)
- ✓ **Co-Chair:** Rajnish Kumar (Former SBI Chairman)
- ✓ **Feedback:** Public feedback submission by July 15, 2026
- ✓ **Framework:** Review SEBI (Debenture Trustees) Regulations, 1993;
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen trustees' role in safeguarding debenture holders

About Expert Working Group:

Composition: Chair – Ananta Barua (Former SEBI Whole-Time Member); co-chaired by Rajnish Kumar (Former State Bank of India (SBI) Chairman).

- Members include O.N. Ravi (Former Clearing Corporation of India Limited (CCIL) Executive Vice President, EVP), Rahul Choudhary (Axis Trustee Chief Executive Officer, CEO), Pratapsingh Nathani (Beacon Trustee CEO), Ashish Pahariya (DSK Legal), Vinod Kothari (Partner), Ajit Nath Jha (Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI)), Pranjal Sharma (The Chief Financial Officer, CFO Board), Mehul Pandya (CareEdge Ratings), Debashis Bandyopadhyay (SEBI Member Secretary), and a representative from the Finance Industry Development Council (FIDC).

Public Feedback: SEBI invited comments and suggestions from stakeholders and the public until **July 15, 2026,** focusing on streamlining provisions, removing redundancies, updating regulations, strengthening trustee functions, and easing compliance.

SEBI Approves Carnelian Asset Management to Launch MF Business

In July 2026, the Securities and Exchange Board of India **(SEBI)** approved **Carnelian Asset Management & Advisors** Private Limited to launch its Mutual Fund **(MF) business**, enabling the firm to offer active and

passive equity, debt and hybrid mutual fund schemes to retail investors and expand its integrated wealth management platform.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval for the launch of Mutual Fund business
- ✓ **By Whom?** SEBI
- ✓ **To Whom?** Carnelian Asset Management & Advisors
- ✓ **Objective:** To expand retail investment access and strengthen wealth management
- ✓ **Products:** Active and passive equity, debt, and hybrid MF schemes.

About Approval for MF Business:

Approval: The approval enables Carnelian to expand beyond Portfolio Management Services (PMS), Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs) and offshore investment strategies by offering regulated mutual fund products.

Products: The company plans to launch active and passive mutual fund schemes across equity, debt and hybrid asset classes to cater to a broader retail investor base.

Focus Areas: The company aims to deepen mutual fund penetration by expanding its reach across Tier-II, Tier-III, and rural India through greater financial awareness.

About Carnelian: It is a Mumbai (Maharashtra)-based asset management company founded in 2019 by Vikas Khemani, Manoj Bahety and Swati Khemani.

- As of 30 June 2026, the company managed over Rs.18,300 crore in assets, serving more than 8,600 clients through a network of over 710 partners across India.

LOANS ISSUED BY BANKS

ADB Approves USD 182.89 Million Loan to Upgrade Karnataka Public Schools

The **Asian Development Bank** (ADB) has approved **USD 182.89 million** (Japanese Yen equivalent) loan to **Karnataka** to strengthen the public school system by **establishing 500 integrated school clusters**, benefiting over **1 million** students from pre-primary to secondary levels.

- ADB has approved the loan under the **"Strengthening Karnataka Public Schools Program."**

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **Approved By:** Asian Development Bank (ADB).
- ✓ **Loan Amount:** USD 182.89 million
- ✓ **Where?** Karnataka, India.
- ✓ **Programme:** Strengthening Karnataka Public Schools Programme
- ✓ **Purpose:** To upgrade public schools and improve learning outcomes.
- ✓ **Key target:** More than 1 million students and 500 school clusters.

Components of the Programme:

Funding Mechanism: The programme is financed through the ADB's results-based lending mechanism and aligned with Karnataka government education reforms and the National Education Policy (**NEP**) 2020.

Additional Support: The programme will also receive a **USD 10 million** grant and a **USD 25 million** guarantee from the International Finance Facility for Education (**IFFEd**).

Focus: It will strengthen teacher competencies, curriculum and assessment systems, school governance and management, and Science, Technology, Engineering, Arts and Mathematics (**STEAM**) learning.

Skill Integration: The programme will introduce **industry-aligned skill modules** and integrate social inclusion and protection of women and girls into the life skills curriculum to enhance employability and higher education readiness.

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Skill Gap: As a fast-growing South Indian state, Karnataka has 70% of its population in the **15–64 working-age** group, but faces challenges with only **48.3% secondary education** completion and **30% of youth** lacking employable skills.

About Asian Development Bank (ADB):

Established – 1966
President – Masato Kanda (Japan)
Headquarters – Manila, the Philippines
Member nations: 69 (50 regional members, 19 from outside).
India & ADB: India is a founding member and currently the fourth-largest shareholder.

ADB Approves USD 230 Million Loan for Chennai Water Supply & Sanitation Modernisation

The Asian Development Bank **(ADB)** has approved a **USD 230 million** (approximately Rs 1,920 crore) loan to modernise and expand the water supply and sanitation infrastructure in Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN).

- The initiative aims to benefit around 4.5 million residents in the Greater Chennai area, addressing long-standing urban infrastructure gaps.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** ADB Approves USD 230 Million Loan
- ✓ **Purpose:** To modernise the water supply and sanitation infrastructure in Chennai, TN.
- ✓ **Beneficiaries:** 4.5 million residents
- ✓ **Features:** 170 km pipelines, 7 water and 38 sewer pumping stations.
- ✓ **Ring-Main System:** Chennai to implement India's first distribution System.
- ✓ **Scheme Alignment:** Project aligned with AMRUT 2.0 and Urban Challenge Fund.
- ✓ **Impact:** Improves safe water access, sanitation, climate resilience

About Chennai Urban Water and Sanitation Modernisation Project:

Aim: It aims to improves safe water supply, sanitation, service efficiency, climate resilience, and public health by addressing infrastructure gaps in Chennai.
Scheme Alignment: The project is aligned with Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation **(AMRUT) 2.0** and the Urban Challenge Fund, supporting India's urban infrastructure modernisation initiatives.
Infrastructure: The project includes construction of **170** kilometer **(km)** of pipelines, upgradation of **7 water** pumping stations, modernisation of **38 sewer pumping stations,** and use of performance-based contracts to improve efficiency and sustainability.
Ring – Main Water System: One of the key features of the project is the introduction of a comprehensive ring-main water distribution system, making Chennai the first Indian city to implement this model across its urban water network.

- The closed-loop system is designed to maintain uniform water pressure across the city, ensuring reliable and equitable supply while enhancing resilience during disasters and service disruptions.

Digital Transformation & Innovation: The project introduces real-time monitoring, data-driven systems, improved customer service, and advanced technologies to replace hazardous manual sewer inspections and enable faster blockage detection.
Outcomes: It Improves safe water access, sanitation, climate resilience, reduces health risks, and ensures sustainable urban utilities.

About Tamil Nadu (TN):

Chief Minister **(CM) –** C. Joseph Vijay
Governor – Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar

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Capital – Chennai
Zoological Park – Kurumbapatti Zoological Park, Chennai Snake Park

World Bank approves USD 890 million for India's rooftop solar programme

In July 2026, the World Bank Group **(WBG)** approved a **USD 890 million** financing package to accelerate **India's** Prime Minister Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana **(PMSGMBY)**, aimed at expanding rooftop solar installations, bringing clean energy to millions of households, and creating **1.7 million jobs** across the renewable energy value chain.

- The financing will support residential rooftop solar adoption, strengthen domestic manufacturing, and mobilise private investment to achieve India's clean energy targets.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Loan approval for rooftop solar
- ✓ **By:** World Bank Group
- ✓ **Amount:** USD 890 million
- ✓ **To Support:** Prime Minister Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana (PMSGMBY)
- ✓ **Target:** 1 crore households
- ✓ **Jobs:** 1.7 million
- ✓ **Private Investment:** USD 4.2 billion

Highlights of the Financing:

Funding: The financing comprises an **USD 820 million** loan from the International Bank for Reconstruction and Development **(IBRD)**, an **USD 60 million** concessional loan from the Clean Technology Fund **(CTF)**, and a **USD 10 million** grant from the IBRD Livable Planet Fund.
Private Insvestment: The World Bank (WB) will mobilise **USD 4.2 billion** in private financing through commercial loans to support rooftop solar installations for households.
Vision: The programme promotes residential rooftop solar, lowers electricity bills, strengthens domestic manufacturing, and creates jobs.
Significance: The initiative supports India's target of achieving **Net Zero** by 2070 and increasing the share of non-fossil fuel-based energy to **60%** of the electricity mix by 2035.
World Bank Support: Over the past decade, the World Bank has mobilised more than USD 2 billion, helping India's rooftop solar capacity increase from **500** Megawatt **(MW)** to over **27** Gigawatt **(GW)**.

About Prime Minister Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana (PMSGMBY):

The PMSGMBY was launched in **February 2024** by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) with an outlay of **Rs. 75,021** crore.
Objective: The scheme aims to provide **rooftop solar systems** to **1 crore** households, reduce electricity bills and promote clean energy adoption.
Benefits: The scheme encourages domestic manufacturing of rooftop solar equipment and supports India's transition towards clean and sustainable energy.

About World Bank (WB):

President – Ajay Banga
Headquarters – Washington, D.C., United States of America (USA)
Founded – 1944

ADB Approves USD 850 Million Loan to Boost Rooftop Solar Rollout in India under PMSG-MBY

In July 2026, the Asian Development Bank **(ADB)** approved **USD 850 million loan** to support the Government of India (GoI)'s Prime Minister Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana **(PMSG-MBY)** by accelerating rooftop solar adoption.

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- The funding will enhance incentives, improve access to finance, strengthen grid readiness, and build the capacity of grid personnel and rural entrepreneurs to expand rooftop solar deployment.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approved USD 850 Million to GoI
- ✓ **Who?** ADB
- ✓ **Purpose:** To boost the rollout of PMSG-MBY
- ✓ **Target:** 10 million (1 crore) households; 30 GW rooftop solar capacity by FY27
- ✓ **Key Outcomes:** 28.8 MT CO_2 emission reduction; support for 3.5 million rooftop solar installations
- ✓ **Women Focus:** Training and certification for 6,000 people, with at least one-third (33.33%) women.

Key Details of Funding:

Background: Subprogram 2 builds on Subprogram 1, approved in November 2025, which established the policy, institutional, digital, financing, and market framework for large-scale rooftop solar deployment.

Financing Program: The Subprogram 2 of the Accelerating Affordable and Inclusive Rooftop Solar Systems Development Program supports the PMSG-MBY.

Expected Outcomes: ADB's latest financial support will help India in achieving its set target of 30 Giga-Watt (GW) of cumulative rooftop solar capacity by Financial Year 2026-27(FY27), reduce 28.8 Million Tonnes (MT) of Carbon Dioxide (CO_2) equivalent emissions, and expand access to affordable solar energy.

Benefits: In addition, the program is expected to reduce upfront costs and drive adoption through financial support for **at least 3.5 million** rooftop solar installations, digital application and monitoring systems, among others.

- It will facilitate the development of model solar villages and innovative distributed solar projects; bolster the vendor accountability and improve the safe handling and recycling of Solar Photovoltaic (PV) panels and battery waste.

Women Participation: Also, the program is further projected to support training and certification of minimum 6,000 people, with at least 1/3rd (or 33.33%) being women, promoting women's participation in distributed Renewable Energy (RE).

About Prime Minister Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana (PMSG-MBY)

Background: In February 2024**,** the Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi approved the scheme, with budgetary allocation of **Rs 75,021 crore** and is to be implemented till Financial Year 2026-27 **(FY27).**

Target: The scheme aims to provide free electricity of 300 units per month to 1 crore households in India by March 2027.

Implemented by: The scheme is being implemented by the National Programme Implementation Agency **(NPIA)** at the national level and by State Implementation Agencies (SIAs) at the state level, which also include power Distribution Companies (DISCOMs) or power/energy departments, depending on the State or Union Territory (UT).

Subsidy: The scheme offers a subsidy of up to 40% which makes RE a viable option in terms of affordability and accessibility.

Key Progress: 18.71 lakh Rooftop Solar (RTS) systems were installed in FY26 (as of March 31, 2026), adding a cumulative rooftop solar capacity of 6.7 GW and benefiting 22.71 lakh households nationwide.

- Also, 39,72,447 RTS systems had been installed, benefitting 48,02,717 households across the country (as of July 2026).

About Asian Development Bank (ADB):

President- Masato Kanda (Japan)

Headquarters-Manila, the Philippines

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Members Nations- 69
Established- 1966

AGREEMENTS & MoUs SIGNED

SBI Life Partners with IIT Bombay to Build Indigenous AI-Powered Cyber Defence Systems for Insurance

In June 2026, **SBI Life Insurance** Company Limited, one of India's most trusted private life insurers, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay **(IIT-B),** Mumbai, Maharashtra, to establish the **'Bharat AI & Cyber Innovation Hub for Insurance',** a joint research and innovation centre aimed to build India's own deep-technology defence systems for the insurance sector.

- The MoU was signed by Prof. S.V. Kulkarni, Dean-Research and Development (R&D), IIT-B and Vishal Bhati, Chief Information and Digital Officer of SBI Life Insurance.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Signing of MoU
- ✓ **Entities:** SBI Life Insurance and IIT-B
- ✓ **Purpose:** To set up Bharat AI & Cyber Innovation Hub for Insurance
- ✓ **Aim:** To build indigenous AI-powered defence systems for the insurance sector.

Key Details:

Technology Development: The proposed innovation hub will undertake joint research across Artificial Intelligence (AI), cyber security, quantum technologies, and digital insurance systems.
Areas of Collaboration: The key focus areas of collaboration will be: executive education, talent development, strategic consulting, innovation incubation, and collaborative research between academia and industry.
Significance: The new initiative is expected to reduce India's dependence on imported security frameworks, strengthening India's institutional capacity to curb emerging digital threats in the financial sector.
SBI Life Insurance: Established in 2000, SBI Life Insurance is a Mumbai, Maharashtra-based joint venture (JV) between the State Bank of India (SBI) and BNP Paribas Cardif, the insurance arm of the France's BNP Paribas.

BoB Partners with Japan's Mizuho Bank to Enhance Collaboration in M&A Financing

In July 2026, Bank of Baroda **(BoB),** one of India's leading Public Sector Bank (PSB), entered into a strategic partnership with **Mizuho Bank** the banking arm of Japan's Mizuho Financial Group to enhance collaboration across Mergers and Acquisitions (**M&A**) financing and related services.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Forging of Collaboration
- ✓ **Entities Involved:** Bank of Baroda (India) and Mizuho Bank (Japan)
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Joint origination, structuring, underwriting and syndication of M&A deals
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen acquisition financing ecosystem and support cross-border corporate transactions

Key Details of MoU:

Key Role: The collaboration will combine Mizuho's extensive global network, cross-border capabilities and expertise in structured finance with BoB's strong domestic presence, deep corporate relationships in India.

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Areas of Collaboration: As part of the partnership, both banks will jointly work on acquisition finance, including joint origination, structuring, co-underwriting and syndication.
Other Focus Areas: In addition, both banks will collaborate on M&A advisory, risk distribution through sub-participation and secondary markets, foreign exchange, and interest rate hedging, escrow services, and the exchanges of best in acquisition finance.

NPCI Partners with HSBC India, JP Morgan to boost cross-border UPI payments

In July 2026, the National Payments Corporation of India **(NPCI)** collaborated with **HSBC India, JP Morgan Payments** to enable real-time Foreign Exchange **(FX) settlement** for cross-border Unified Payments Interface **(UPI)** transactions.

- The initiative aims to enhance the international payment experience for Indian users by improving transparency, speed, and efficiency in currency conversion and settlement.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Collaboration for real-time FX settlement in cross-border UPI transactions
- ✓ **Who?** NPCI, HSBC India, JP Morgan Payments
- ✓ **Purpose:** Enable real-time foreign exchange conversion and settlement
- ✓ **Global Reach:** UPI operational in 9 countries

Key Details:

Collaboration with HSBC: Under the collaboration, HSBC India will act as the banking partner, facilitating real-time FX rates via direct Application Programme Interface (API) integration.
Collaboration with JP Morgan: JP Morgan Payments, that will support real-time FX conversion and settlement across multiple currencies.

- The collaboration will combine UPI's growing global acceptance with foreign capabilities of JP Morgan, to streamline international digital transactions and enhance settlement efficiency across global markets.

Global Presence of UPI: At present, UPI is operating in 9 countries i.e. Singapore, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Nepal, Bhutan, Mauritius, France, Sri Lanka, Qatar, and Cambodia, enabling Indian travellers to make Quick Response (QR) code-based payments in Indian Rupee (INR).
UPI Growth: Globally, UPI transaction volumes nearly doubled to 1.48 million in Financial Year 2025-26 (FY26) from 0.75 million (FY25).

- Also, UPI transactions value reached Rs 330.43 crore in FY26 over Rs 258.53 crore in FY25.

Razorpay Partners with NBBL to Launch Banking Connect Mobile-First NetBanking Solution

In July 2026, **Razorpay** in partnership with NPCI Bharat BillPay Limited **(NBBL)**, a wholly owned subsidiary of National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), launched **Banking Connect,** a **mobile-first NetBanking solution** in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

- The platform modernises **NetBanking** through unified multi-bank integration, Quick Response (QR)-based and intent-driven payment flows, enhancing payment efficiency and user experience.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Banking Connect mobile-first NetBanking solution
- ✓ **Entities:** Razorpay & NBBL
- ✓ **Where?** – Mumbai, Maharashtra
- ✓ **Purpose:** To modernise NetBanking, simplify operations, and enhance digital payment experience.
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Multi-bank integration, QR-based payments, intent-based payment flows, streamlined reconciliation.

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About Banking Connect NetBanking Solution:

Background: Replaces multiple bank-specific integrations and complex reconciliation processes with a single integration layer connecting merchants to multiple participating banks.

Objective: The platform enables intent-based and QR-enabled mobile payments through a unified framework for settlement, reconciliation, refunds, and payment routing, improving transaction success rates and delivering seamless payment experiences for high-value transactions across multiple sectors.

Banking Ecosystem: Supported by State Bank of India (SBI), HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, Federal Bank, AU Small Finance Bank, and YES Bank, with more banks expected to join.

GIFT City & Vietnam's Da Nang Financial Hub Signed MoU to Enhance Cross-Border Investment

In July 2026, Gujarat International Finance Tec-City **(GIFT City),** India's International Financial Services Centre (IFSC), signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with Vietnam International Financial Center–Da Nang **(VIFC-DN)**, in New Delhi, Delhi.

- The MoU aims to support the development of Vietnam's international financial centre, promote cross-border investments, and strengthen financial and business linkages between India and Vietnam.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to Enhance Cross-Border Investment
- ✓ **Entities:** GIFT City (India) & VIFC-DN(Vietnam)
- ✓ **Purpose:** To share institutional knowledge, promote cross-border investment, strengthen the financial sector, & build capacity.
- ✓ **Other MoUs:** GIFT City with Tata Communications & CEPT University

Key Details of MoU:

Focus: The partnership covers financial services, financial technology (fintech), digital innovation, capacity building, financial sector development, and the exchange of institutional knowledge and best practices.

Collaboration: Both institutions will undertake joint research and publications, professional exchanges, conferences, seminars, outreach initiatives, and regular institutional engagement in areas of mutual interest.

Other MoUs: GIFT City also signed MoUs with Tata Communications Limited to promote Global Capability Centres (GCCs) and technology businesses, and with CEPT University(Gujarat) for research, knowledge exchange and capacity building.

AU Small Finance Bank Partners with Zaggle to Launch Co-Branded Retail Credit Card

In July 2026, AU Small Finance Bank Limited **(AU SFB)** partnered with Zaggle Prepaid Ocean Services Limited **(Zaggle)** to launch the **AU Zaggle Co-Branded Retail Credit Card**, on the Visa and RuPay networks through the **zagg.money** platform.

- The card offers customizable rewards, **Zagg Coins-to-cashback**, Unified Payments Interface (**UPI**) and contactless payment benefits, aiming to provide a personalized credit card experience with flexible rewards and digital convenience.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of AU Zaggle Co-Branded Retail Credit Card
- ✓ **By Whom?** AU SFB & Zaggle
- ✓ **Payment Networks:** Visa & RuPay

About AU Zaggle Co-Branded Retail Credit Card:

Partnership: The collaboration combines AU SFB's credit card infrastructure, customer-centric banking expertise and risk management capabilities with Zaggle's spend management, Software-as-a-Service

(SaaS)-based fintech platform and rewards ecosystem.
AU SFB: It was established in 1996 as a vehicle finance company and transitioned into a small finance bank (SFB) in 2017, is headquartered in Jaipur, Rajasthan, and is led by its Founder, Managing Director (MD), and Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Sanjay Agarwal.

DIBD and PNB Sign MoU to Advance Multilingual AI for Inclusive Banking

In July 2026, the Digital India BHASHINI(BHASha INterface for India) Division (**DIBD**), under the Digital India Corporation (DIC), Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), and Punjab National Bank (**PNB**) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) to collaborate on multilingual Artificial Intelligence (**AI**) solutions for inclusive banking and citizen-centric financial services through the BHASHINI for Seva/Sanchalan initiative.

- The MoU was signed by **Amitabh Nag**, Chief Executive Officer (CEO), DIBD, and **Atish Kumar Rout**, Chief General Manager (**CGM**) (Digital), Digital Banking Transformation Division, PNB.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed for multilingual AI banking.
- ✓ **Entities:** DIBD and PNB
- ✓ **Objective:** Develop multilingual AI solutions for banking, enhance financial inclusion
- ✓ **Integration:** BHASHINI Udyat, Mitra, AppMitra, Pravakta, and Bhashadaan.

Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The collaboration will use BHASHINI's language translation Application Programming Interfaces (**APIs**) and reference applications to integrate language-inclusive services into PNB's digital banking platform.
Integration: Under the MoU, PNB will integrate BHASHINI's multilingual AI tools, translation APIs, and platforms (including Udyat, Mitra, AppMitra, Pravakta, and Bhashadaan) into its digital banking services.
Significance: This will enable customers to access banking information and services in their preferred Indian languages, promoting inclusive banking, AI-driven innovation, improved customer experience, and greater financial inclusion.
BHASHINI: It is the Government of India(GoI's) AI-powered language translation platform developed under the National Language Translation Mission (NLTM).

PNB & AP Sign MoU to Establish India's First Bank-Led Quantum Finance Hub

In July 2026, Punjab National Bank **(PNB),** an Indian public sector bank, and the Government of Andhra Pradesh **(AP)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** to establish the **PNB Quantum Finance Hub,** India's first bank-led Quantum Finance Hub at Amaravati Quantum Valley (AQV), **Amaravati, AP**.

- With this collaboration, PNB became the **first bank** to join hands with a state government in setting up a dedicated Quantum Finance Facility.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to establish India's first bank-led Quantum Finance Hub
- ✓ **By Whom?** AP & PNB
- ✓ **Where?** AQV, Amaravati, AP
- ✓ **Objective:** Develop secure banking solutions
- ✓ **Significance:** PNB becomes the first bank to partner with a State Government for a Quantum Finance Hub.

About PNB Quantum Finance Hub:

Hub: The hub aims to develop secure, intelligent, and future-ready banking solutions using Quantum Computing (QC) & Artificial Intelligence (AI) through collaborative research, innovation, cybersecurity, and skill development.

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Functions: The Hub brings together industry, academia, startups, and research institutions to promote research, innovation, startup incubation, talent development, and secure digital financial innovation.
About PNB: Established on 19 May 1894 and commencing operations on 12 April 1895, PNB is India's second-largest PSB after the State Bank of India (SBI).

- It is headquartered in Dwarka, New Delhi, Delhi and its current Managing Director (MD) and Chief Executive Officer (CEO) is Ashok Chandra.

OTHER BANKING NEWS

Kakinada Cooperative Town Bank Attains Tier-III Status After Deposits Surpass Rs. 2,000 Crore

In June 2026, Andhra Pradesh (AP)'s **Kakinada Cooperative Town Bank**, an Urban Cooperative Bank (UCB), secured **Tier-III status** under the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) norms after its total deposits surpassed the Rs 2,000 crore mark with zero net Non-Performing Assets (NPAs).

- Following this, the bank has become the **2nd-largest** among the 46 UCBs in the state, with its total business exceeding Rs 2,040 crore.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** AP's UCB Attains Tier-III Status
- ✓ **UCB Name:** Kakinada Cooperative Town Bank
- ✓ **Deposit Required for Tier-Status:** Between Rs 1,000 crore and Rs 10,000 crore
- ✓ **Total Deposit of UCB:** Rs 2,040 Crore
- ✓ **Significance:** Became 2nd largest UCB in AP

Key Details of UCB:

Overview: Established 46 years ago in AP, the bank serves East Godavari, Kakinada, Konaseema, and Visakhapatnam districts through 18 branches and 8 Automated Teller Machines (ATMs), with plans for a Cash Deposit Machine (CDM), a 2,000-locker plaza, and new branches at Samalkot and Pithapuram.
Financials: As of 31 March 2026, the bank had Rs. 7,804.12 crore in advances, Rs. 552.14 crore in investments, 55,605 members, Rs. 28.63 crore share capital, Rs. 198.20 crore own funds, declared a 12% dividend, reported a net profit of Rs. 16.18 crore after Rs. 5.61 crore income tax.
Classification of UCB: Based on deposits, RBI has classified the UCBs into three main categories: Tier-I (with deposits below Rs 100 crore); Tier-II (deposits up to Rs 1,000 crore) and Tier-III (deposits between Rs 1,000 crore and Rs 10,000 crore).

Punjab & Sind Bank Launches New Digital Initiatives on 119th Foundation Day

In June 2026, Punjab & Sind Bank (**PSB**) celebrated its **119th Foundation Day** by unveiling a series of customer-centric digital banking initiatives, a new Vision & Mission Statement, and technology-driven banking solutions at an event held in New Delhi, Delhi.

- Debashish Prusty and Hari Har Mishra, Additional Secretaries of Department of Financial Services (DFS); Ashish Madhorao, Joint Secretary of DFS; and representatives from National Housing Bank (NHB), Industrial Finance Corporation of India (IFCI), Life Insurance Corporation (LIC), Coal India Limited (CIL), among others, were present at the event.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Series Digital Banking Solutions
- ✓ **Occasion:** 119th foundation day Celebrations of PSB
- ✓ **Digital Solutions:** Navjyoti Mobile App, PSB Bharat Connect Account, CBDC services, and Digital Gold Loan facility
- ✓ **Launched by:** Punjab & Sind Bank (PSB)
- ✓ **Held Where?** New Delhi, Delhi

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Key Highlights:

New Vision & Mission Statement: Introduced to reinforce the bank's commitment to customer-centric banking, innovation, sustainable growth, and operational excellence

Navjyoti Mobile App: Launched an in-house Human Resources (HR) application to streamline employee services, improve internal communication, and enhance workforce efficiency.

PSB Bharat Connect Account: Launched a specialised savings account for Central and State Government employees, offering customised banking benefits and digital banking services.

Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) Services: Rolled out CBDC (Digital Rupee) services to facilitate secure, seamless, and efficient digital transactions in line with the Reserve Bank of India(RBI) digital currency initiative.

Digital Gold Loan: Introduced a fully digital gold loan facility enabling customers to avail loans through a faster, paperless, and hassle-free process.

Key Accomplishments: PSB registered the highest Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) growth i.e. 30% increase in the banking sector, and Rs 1,322 crore as net profit.

Significance: The initiatives aim to accelerate digital transformation, enhance customer convenience, strengthen employee services, and promote financial inclusion, while supporting PSB customer-centric and technology-driven banking strategy.

About Punjab & Sind Bank (PSB):

History: In 1908, Bhai Vir Singh, Sunder Singh Majitha and Sardar Tarlochan Singh founded Punjab & Sind Bank (PSB) for the economic upliftment of weaker sections of society particularly, poor farmers.

- Post India's Independence, the Government of India (GoI) nationalized the bank on April 15, 1980.

Managing Director **(MD)** & Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)-** Swarup Kumar Saha

Tagline- "Where Service is a Way of Life"

Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi

Bank of Maharashtra Launched FinSpark'26, a National Level Cybersecurity Hackathon

In July 2026, Bank of Maharashtra **(BoM),** one of India's leading Public Sector Banks (PSBs), launched **"FinSpark'26",** a national-level cybersecurity hackathon, under the theme "Securing the Future of Banking".

- The nationwide hackathon is designed to encourage students and dropouts across the country to develop solutions for real-world challenges in the banking sector.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Nationwide Cybersecurity Hackathon
- ✓ **Hackathon Name:** FinSpark'26
- ✓ **Launched by:** Bank of Maharashtra
- ✓ **Theme:** "Securing the Future of Banking"
- ✓ **Incentive Pool:** Over Rs 10 lakh
- ✓ **Evaluation Parameters:** business potential and relevance, security considerations, scalability, and ease of development, among others

About FinSpark'26:

Key Offerings: The new initiative offers a prize pool of **more than Rs 10 lakh.** In addition, top 20 teams will get an opportunity to showcase their solutions at the Grand Finale at College of Engineering Pune (COEP) Technological University (Pune, Maharashtra).

- Also, winning teams will get a chance to demonstrate at Global FinTech Fest 2026.

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Organising Partners: BoM is organised FinSpark'26 in association with the Indian Banks' Association (IBA), the Department of Financial Services (DFS), Government of India (GoI), and COEP Technological University to encourage students and cybersecurity innovators to develop solutions for real-world banking security challenges.
Focus Areas: The cybersecurity hackathon will focus on critical areas like: banking security, including insider threat detection; privileged access misuse; Artificial Intelligence (AI)-driven correlation of cybersecurity telemetry; transaction behaviour analysis; fraud prevention and proactive threat identification.
Registration Process: Eligible participants are allowed to register for the hackathon either **individually** or in a group of **maximum 4 members.**
Evaluation: Following the registration, the participants are required to select a problem statement, develop a structured idea or prototype and then, their submissions will be evaluated based on parameters like: business potential and relevance, security considerations, uniqueness of approach, user experience, scalability, and ease of development and maintenance.

EbixCash Became India's 1st AD-II Entity to Receive RBI Approval for Trade Remittances

In July 2026, **EbixCash World Money Limited** became the **first** Authorised Dealer Category-II **(AD-II) entity** in India to secure the Reserve Bank of India **(RBI)** authorisation to offer **trade remittances** and family maintenance remittances, which was previously dominated by banks.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** RBI Approval to Non-Bank Entity for Trade Remittances
- ✓ **To Whom?** EbixCash World Money Ltd., AD-II entity
- ✓ **Trade Remittance Limit:** Maximum Rs 25 lakh per transaction
- ✓ **Under:** Revised FEMA (introduced in May 2026)

Key Details:

Expanded Services: The enhanced licence will enable EbixCash to facilitate trade remittances up to **Rs 25 lakh** per transaction and process family maintenance remittances under the updated Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), 1999 framework introduced in May 2026.
Support for MSMEs: The licence will enable EbixCash to directly serve Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) involved in import and export activities by facilitating trade-related remittance services.
Other Key Approval: EbixCash has also received RBI authorisation to maintain **Nostro accounts**, enabling direct settlements of international transactions without routing them through intermediary correspondent banks.
EbixCash: It was initially established as a Full Fledged Money Changer (FFMC) in 1999 and was later upgraded to RBI-regulated AD-II category entity. Its corporate headquarters is located in Noida, Uttar Pradesh (UP).

EnKash Introduces India's First Meal Card with UPI Payments

In July 2026, **Enkash,** India's leading business payments and spend management platform, became the **1st compan**y in India to launch Unified Payments Interface **(UPI)-based payments** on the **meal card.**

- This move will enable the employees to make direct payments from their meal balance by scanning eligible UPI Quick Response (QR) codes at food and grocery merchants.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of India's 1st Meal Card with UPI Payments
- ✓ **Launched by:** Enkash
- ✓ **Features:** Make payments from meal balance by scanning UPI QR codes

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- ✓ **Tax Benefit:** Meal benefits up to Rs 200 per meal.

About India's First Meal Card:

Supported by: The newly launched UPI-enabled Meal Card is supported by the company's existing payments and prepaid infrastructure, which offers businesses a wider payments suite covering prepaid cards, employee benefits, expense management, among others.

Benefit: The new initiative will provide meal benefits of up to Rs 200 per meal under both old and revised tax regimes, leading to annual tax savings of maximum Rs 1,05,600.

Enkash: Established in 2018, EnKash is India's first full-stack payments and spend management platform. It holds Payment Aggregator (PA), Prepaid Payment Instrument (PPI), and Bharat Connect (BBPOU) licences and is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

India Relaxes FDI Rules for Inventory-Based E-commerce to Enhance Exports of Indian-Made Goods

In July 2026, the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade **(DPIIT)**, under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I), relaxed the Foreign Direct Investment **(FDI)** policy by allowing foreign-funded e-commerce companies to operate an **inventory-based model** exclusively for the **export of goods** manufactured or produced in India.

- The policy change aims to boost exports by allowing foreign-invested e-commerce platforms to procure, stock, and export Indian-made products, giving domestic manufacturers and sellers easier access to global markets.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India relaxed FDI rules for inventory-based e-commerce
- ✓ **By Whom?** DPIIT, MoC&I
- ✓ **Objective:** Boost exports of Indian-made goods.
- ✓ **Key Change:** Foreign-funded platforms can now stock Indian goods strictly for export.
- ✓ **Existing Policy:** Foreign investment barred inventory ownership and direct B2C sales.
- ✓ **Effective:** Policy becomes effective after notification under FEMA Act 1999

About the FDI Policy Relaxation:

Previous Policy: FDI was limited strictly to Business-to-Business (B2B) e-commerce and marketplace models, strictly prohibiting foreign-funded inventory-based Business-to-Consumer (B2C) e-commerce to safeguard domestic retailers.

Policy Change: The updated policy permits foreign-funded entities to own inventory, purchase, warehouse, and directly export Indian-made goods to overseas consumers.

Implementation: The revised provisions will officially take effect once corresponding amendments are formally notified under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) 1999, through the Foreign Exchange Management (Non-Debt Instruments) Rules, 2019.

Benefits: This strategic policy shift aims to expand India's presence in global trade and strengthen its manufacturing ecosystem.

NSE Launches India's First Domestic Benchmark-Based Natural Gas Futures

In July 2026, the National Stock Exchange **(NSE)** announced the launch of **India's first** exchange-traded energy derivative the **'Indian Natural Gas Futures',** linked to a domestic benchmark, with trading set to commence from 27 July 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India's first Domestic Benchmark Natural Gas Futures launched
- ✓ **Launched by**: NSE
- ✓ **Trading Symbol:** NATGASIND

- ✓ **Regulator Approval:** SEBI
- ✓ **Benchmark:** IGX Gujarat (Dahej) hub price
- ✓ **Trading Segment:** Commodity Derivatives Segment
- ✓ **Trading Unit:** 250 mmBtu.

About Indian Natural Gas Futures:

Benchmark: The contract was launched under the symbol **NATGASIND** after receiving approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for trading in the Commodity Derivatives Segment.

- The cash-settled contract is linked to the Indian Gas Exchange **(IGX)** Gujarat (Dahej) hub price, quoted in **Rs. per mmBtu** (Metric Million British Thermal Units), with final settlement based on the monthly weighted average price of actual IGX deliveries.

Contract: The contract has a trading unit of **250 mmBtu**, is available from Monday to Friday, and is managed by NSE Clearing through clearing, settlement and margin mechanisms.

Significance: The contract provides gas producers, consumers, traders and power companies with a domestic benchmark-based instrument to manage price volatility and improve market efficiency.

About NSE: It was established in 1992 and is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

GoI Approves RBI Field Trials of Rs 10 and Rs 20 Polymer Currency Notes

In July 2026, the Government of India (GoI) approved the Reserve Bank of India's **(RBI) proposal** to conduct field trials of **one billion (Bn) polymer banknotes** each in the **Rs. 10 and Rs. 20 denominations,** marking a significant step towards evaluating more durable currency notes in India.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** GoI approves RBI field trials of polymer banknotes
- ✓ **Denominations:** Rs. 10 and Rs. 20
- ✓ **Trial Volume:** 1 billion notes each
- ✓ **Proposal Under:** Section 25 of the RBI Act, 1934
- ✓ **Purpose:** Assess durability, security features, and public acceptance.

About Polymer Notes Initiative:

Section: The RBI, with the recommendation of its Central Board, had sent a proposal to the government in terms of **Section 25** of the RBI Act, 1934, for the introduction of Rs 10 and Rs 20 polymer banknotes, worth **Rs 3000 crores (Cr)** for field trials.

Field Trials: The RBI has been authorised to conduct field trials of polymer banknotes under different climatic and usage conditions to evaluate their durability, security features, and public acceptance.

- Regular issuance of the polymer banknotes will begin only after the successful completion and evaluation of the field trials.

Polymer Notes: RBI polymer notes are printed on a non-fibrous and non-porous polymer substrate rather than conventional banknote paper.

Additional Option: The Central Government also confirmed that the polymer notes are being tested as an additional option, and there is no proposal to replace the existing paper substrate-based banknotes.

Benefits: The polymer notes are more **durable** and remain in circulation for longer periods, making them particularly suitable for economies like India where cash transactions continue to be widespread.

- Also, it could help reduce the replacement costs and also reduce the waste generated from discarded paper notes.

Security Features: The notes incorporate advanced security features, including transparent see-through windows, specialised security threads and improved anti-counterfeiting technology, enhancing the integrity of the currency system.

Global Adoption: Around 60 countries have adopted polymer banknotes. Australia pioneered the technology in 1988, followed by countries such as Canada, Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia, Thailand, and Romania.

About Indian Currency Notes:

Issuing Authority: Currency notes in India are issued by the RBI under the RBI Act, 1934, except the Rs.1 note, which is issued by the Government of India (GoI) under the Coinage Act, 2011.

- According to **Section 25** of the RBI Act, the Central Government approves the design, form, and material of new banknotes on the recommendation of the RBI's Central Board.

Asset Backing: In terms of **Section 33** of the RBI Act, 1934, all banknotes issued by RBI are backed by assets such as gold coin, gold bullion, foreign securities, rupee coin and rupee securities.

Material: At present, Indian banknotes are printed on paper substrate made primarily from cotton and cotton rag with embedded security features.

Languages Printed: Fifteen languages are appearing in the language panel of banknotes in addition to Hindi and English.

Current Series: India currently issues Mahatma Gandhi (New) Series banknotes in denominations of Rs.10, Rs.20, Rs.50, Rs.100, Rs.200, and Rs.500.

Printing Presses: India has four currency note printing presses. Two are operated by Security Printing and Minting Corporation of India Limited (SPMCIL) at Nashik (Maharashtra) and Dewas (Madhya Pradesh, MP), while the other two are managed by Bharatiya Reserve Bank Note Mudran Private Limited (BRBNMPL), a wholly owned subsidiary of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), at Mysuru (Karnataka) and Salboni (West Bengal, WB).

OmniCard Launches India's First Flexi Benefits Basket on UPI for Tax-Efficient Employee Benefits

In July 2026, **OmniCard Platform,** developed by Eroute Technologies Private Limited, launched **India's first Flexi Benefits Basket** on the Unified Payments Interface **(UPI)**, offering a single employee-controlled digital wallet for tax-efficient spending across multiple benefit categories.

- Built on its Reserve Bank of India (RBI)-licensed Prepaid Payment Instrument **(PPI)** platform, the wallet can be used at around **60 million UPI-accepting merchants.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of India's first Flexi Benefits Basket on UPI.
- ✓ **By Whom?** OmniCard (Eroute Technologies Private Limited)
- ✓ **Controls:** MCC-based spend controls ensure tax compliance and audit-readiness.

About OmniCard Flexi Benefits Basket on UPI:

Features: Enables efficient benefit administration and tax compliance, allowing employees to allocate benefits across meals, fuel, telecom, books, periodicals, gadgets, and other eligible categories, with Merchant Category Code (MCC)-based spending controls.

About OmniCard: It was launched in July 2021 as an Artificial Intelligence (AI)-powered corporate spend management platform and payment ecosystem in India.

IRDAI Approves Patanjali Ayurved & DS Group's Acquisition of Magma General Insurance

In July 2026, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India **(IRDAI)** approved the acquisition of Magma General Insurance by Patanjali Ayurved and DS Group from Adar Poonawalla-owned Sanoti Properties for **Rs 4,500 crore (Cr)**.

- The IRDAI has also approved a licence for **ProTec General Insurance**, a joint venture between the M Pallonji Group and True North's Divya Sehgal.

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Exam Hints

Approval 1:

- ✓ **What?** IRDAI gives approval to acquire Magma General Insurance
- ✓ **By Whom:** Patanjali Ayurved (73.56%) and DS Group (24.50%)
- ✓ **Value:** Rs 4500 Cr

Approval 2:

- ✓ **What?** IRDAI grants licence to ProTec General Insurance
- ✓ **Licence Type:** Certificate of Registration
- ✓ **Promoter group:** M Pallonji Group and Sehgal

Acquisition in Detail

Section: The approval has been granted under **Section 6A** of the Insurance Act, 1938, read with the IRDAI Regulations, 2024.

Validity: The approval shall remain effective for a period of **three months** from the date of the communication issued by the IRDAI.

Stake Acquisition: Under the share purchase agreement (SPA):

- Patanjali Ayurved will acquire a **73.56%** stake in Magma General Insurance
- DS Group will acquire **24.50%** stake in the insurance company

IRDAI Granted Licence to ProTec General Insurance

Approval: The IRDAI granted licence for **ProTec General Insurance** at the 137th authority meeting, marking the fourth insurance licence approval this year 2026, followingWestBridge-backed Kiwi General Insurance, Prudential HCL Health Insurance and Allianz Jio Reinsurance.

Licence: IRDAI also granted a Certificate of Registration (CoR) to ProTec General Insurance Limited, authorising the company to commence general insurance business under the applicable regulatory framework.

Investment: The licences reflect strong investor confidence in India's insurance sector and the reform momentum under the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (SBSR) Act, 2025, with one life insurer and one general insurer increasing foreign ownership from the earlier 74% cap to 100% following the latest amendment.

Other Approvals: During its meeting, the IRDAI approved reforms including liberalised investment norms, simplified capital-related approvals, perpetual registration for insurance intermediaries, and mandatory tagging of authorised salespersons for every policy.

- It also operationalised the Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) and approved the Manner and Procedure for Imposition of Penalties Regulations, 2026 to strengthen policyholder protection, grievance redressal, and regulatory enforcement.

About Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI):

IRDAI was established under the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority Act, 1999. It is an autonomous body under the jurisdiction of the Ministry of Finance (MoF) responsible for regulating and developing the insurance and re-insurance industries in India.

Chairperson– Ajay Seth

Headquarters– Hyderabad, Telangana

Established– 1999

SBI Card, Google Pay Launch Co-Branded Credit Card With UPI-Linked Rupay Option

In July 2026, **SBI Cards** and Payment Services Limited, in partnership with **Google Pay**, a digital payment app developed by Google, jointly launched a new co-branded credit card named **'Google Pay Flex SBI Card',** aimed to make daily spending more lucrative for users.

- The co-branded credit card is available on RuPay and Visa networks, with the RuPay variant supporting Unified Payments Interface (UPI) linkage for payments at UPI-enabled merchants.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Co-branded Credit Card
- ✓ **Launched by:** SBI Card with Google Pay
- ✓ **Credit Card Name:** 'Google Pay Flex SBI Card'
- ✓ **Networks:** RuPay & Visa
- ✓ **Joining Fee**: Rs. 499 (inclusive of taxes)
- ✓ **Annual Rewards:** Up to Rs. 18,000
- ✓ **Key Offerings:** Annual reward points, EMI conversion options and digital account management via Google Pay app, among others.

About Google Pay Flex SBI Card:

Reward: The card offers annual rewards of up to Rs. 18,000 on eligible spends, including groceries, utility bills, travel, shopping, and online & in-store purchases.

- Cardholders can earn up to 8 Stars (1 Star = Rs. 1) for every cumulative Rs. 500 spent on eligible transactions and redeem them instantly via the Google Pay app or for select vouchers.

Integration: The card is integrated with the Google Pay app that helps the users to apply for the card, monitor spending, redeem rewards and manage their account digitally.

Joining Fee: The customers can avail the benefits by paying a joining fee of **Rs 499** including applicable taxes, which is also charged as the annual renewal fee.

Benefits: Cardholders get a renewal fee waiver on annual spends of **Rs. 1 lakh** and can convert outstanding credit card dues into Equated Monthly Instalments (EMIs) through flexible repayment options.

SBI Card: Launched in October 1998, SBI Card is a joint venture (JV) between the State Bank of India (SBI) and GE Capital, with its headquarters in Gurugram, Haryana.

NCDEX Launches 'Nidhi' MF Transaction Platform to Expand Rural Penetration

In July 2026, the National Commodity and Derivatives Exchange Limited **(NCDEX)** launched **"NCDEX Nidhi",** a new Mutual Fund (MF) transaction platform to expand MF penetration in rural and semi-rural India by leveraging its network of 800 Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) and certified local MF distributors.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of new MF transaction platform
- ✓ **Platform Name:** 'Nidhi'
- ✓ **Launched by:** NCDEX
- ✓ **Purpose:** To expand MF penetration in rural and semi-rural areas of India
- ✓ **AMCs on Platform:** 6 (Nippon India MF, HDFC MF, Axis MF, LIC MF, Tata MF, and Invesco MF).

About NCDEX Nidhi:

Design: The platform has been built on Application Programming Interface (API)-first architecture, offering flexibility to MF distributors i.e. to either use the platform directly or integrate its APIs into their own systems.

Key Features: The platform offers various investor-friendly features that aim to enhance transparency and simplify the investment process like: Unified Payments Interface (UPI) AutoPay for Systematic Investment Plan (SIPs), end-to-end transaction time-stamping until Net Asset Value (NAV) allocation, detailed transaction failure reasons, among others.

AMCs on Platform: The platform has initially onboarded **6** Asset Management Companies (AMCs): Nippon India MF, HDFC MF, Axis MF, LIC MF, Tata MF, and Invesco MF, with around 20 more AMCs expected to join by 31 August 2026**.**

About NCDEX: Incorporated in April 2003, NCDEX is a Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)-

regulated digital commodity exchange focused on agricultural derivatives and risk management, with its headquarters in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

FINANCE NEWS

PayGlocal Launches Google Pay Card Payments for Global Merchant Transactions

In June 2026, **PayGlocal**, India's cross-border payments platform, launched **Google Pay Card Payments** on its **International Payment Gateway**, enabling Indian merchants to access over one billion customers across more than 90 countries through a single integration.

- The initiative aims to facilitate seamless global transactions, increase merchant activations by 40%, and enhance the efficiency of cross-border e-commerce.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Google Pay Card Payments on International Payment Gateway
- ✓ **By Whom?** PayGlocal
- ✓ **Key Benefits:** 40% higher conversions, secure payments, and over 60 local currencies.
- ✓ **Target Markets:** USA, UK, Australia, Canada, UAE, Singapore, Western Europe

About PayGlocal Google Pay Integration:

Integration: Google Pay integration provides secure, tokenized, and biometrically authenticated transactions, while Apple Pay is already live, with an intelligent routing and fraud prevention layer ensuring seamless global checkout.

Reach: With Apple Pay and Google Pay, Indian merchants can reach over one billion customers across major markets, including the United States (US), United Kingdom (UK), Australia, Canada, United Arab Emirates (UAE), Singapore, and Western Europe through a single integration.

About PayGlocal: Founded in 2021 and headquartered in Bengaluru, Karnataka, PayGlocal is a cross-border payments platform for Indian businesses. It is authorised by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) as a Payment Aggregator for domestic online and cross-border (inward and outward) payments.

IRDAI Grants Health Insurance Licence to Prudential HCL Joint Venture

In June 2026, the Insurance Regulatory Development Authority of India **(IRDAI)** granted final(R3) Certificate of Registration (CoR) to **Prudential HCL Health Insurance** Limited, becoming the **8th** standalone health insurer in India.

- The licence was granted during the IRDAI's 136th meeting held on June 29, 2026, marking the 3rd such registration issued by the regulator in Calendar Year 2026 (CY26).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Grants final R3 Certificate of Registration (CoR) to a standalone health insurer
- ✓ **To Whom?** Prudential HCL Health Insurance Limited
- ✓ **Granting Authority:** IRDAI
- ✓ **Status:** India's 8th standalone health insurer
- ✓ **Registration in CY 2026**: Third such registration granted by IRDAI.

Key Details:

License Process: A standalone health insurer must secure R1 for promoter and business-plan assessment, R2, for operational readiness, and R3, the final Certificate of Registration, to begin insurance operations.

Eligibility: The company must be an Indian insurance company or a Limited Liability Partnership (LLP) registered under the LLP Act, 2008 and have a minimum paid-up equity capital of Rs.100 crore.

- They must submit a five-year operational and financial business plan, while promoters, directors, and key management personnel must satisfy IRDAI's "fit and proper" criteria.

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Prudential HCL Health Insurance: It is a Joint Venture (JV) between the United Kingdom (UK)'s Prudential Group (owns 70% stake) and India's HCL Group (owns 30% stake), announced in March 2025.

Paytm Europe Secures Payment Institution Licence from Luxembourg Regulator

In July 2026, **Paytm Europe Payments S.A.**, the European arm of One97 Communications (Paytm), secured a Payment Institution **(PI) licence** from Luxembourg's financial regulator Commission de Surveillance du Secteur Financier **(CSSF)** and registered it on the official list of payment institutions effective from **July 2, 2026**

- The licence enables Paytm Europe to offer regulated payment services across the European Economic Area (EEA).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Secured a Payment Institution (PI) licence in Luxembourg
- ✓ **Who?** Paytm Europe Payments S.A
- ✓ **From:** Commission de Surveillance du Secteur Financier (CSSF)
- ✓ **Purpose:** To provide regulated payment services across the European Economic Area
- ✓ **Permitted Services:** Payment transactions, credit transfers and standing orders through payment accounts and credit lines; payment-acquiring services.

Key Details of Approval:

Capital Infusion: The regulatory approval follows Paytm's May 2026 announcement that Paytm Cloud Technologies Limited (PCTL) would invest an additional **EUR 9 million** in Paytm Europe Payments S.A. to meet its business funding requirements and increase its paid-up capital.

Services: The approval enables the company to execute payment transactions and credit transfers, including standing orders, through payment accounts and credit lines.

- It also authorises the company to provide payment-acquiring services.

About Paytm: Founded in 2010 and headquartered in Noida, Uttar Pradesh (UP), Paytm is a digital payments and fintech company operated by One97 Communications Limited, founded by Vijay Shekhar Sharma.

Axis Max Life Launches 'Smart RISE' Retirement Plan with Guaranteed and NIFTY 50-Linked Variable Annuity

In July 2026, **Axis Max Life Insurance Limited** launched Axis Max Life Smart Retirement Income with Sustained Earnings Plan **(Smart RISE),** a retirement-focused insurance product that combines a **Guaranteed Annuity** with a **Variable Annuity linked to the NIFTY 50 Index**.

- The plan aims to provide policyholders with a stable post-retirement income by combining guaranteed income with potential market-linked returns, while offering flexibility in retirement and supporting long-term legacy planning.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Insurance product Smart RISE
- ✓ **By Whom?** Axis Max Life Insurance Limited.
- ✓ **Product Type:** Retirement/Annuity Insurance Plan.
- ✓ **Unique Feature:** Combines Guaranteed Annuity with NIFTY 50 Index-linked Variable Annuity.
- ✓ **Purpose:** Provide stable retirement income with market-linked growth potential.

Key Features of Smart RISE:

Annuity: Smart RISE combines a guaranteed annuity, which provides fixed and predictable income throughout the annuity period, with a variable annuity linked to the NIFTY 50 Index, enabling policyholders to participate in potential equity market growth while receiving retirement income.

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Flexibility: The plan allows customers to choose a deferment period during which no annuity is paid, with regular annuity payments commencing after the deferment period ends.
Plan Variants: The plan offers Immediate Life Annuity, Immediate Life Annuity with Return of Purchase Price, and Deferred Life Annuity with Return of Purchase Price variants for both Single Life and Joint Life options.
Legacy: In the event of the annuitant's death, the **Return of Purchase Price(ROPP)** is payable to the nominee, subject to the policy's terms and conditions, supporting intergenerational wealth transfer.
About Axis Max Life Insurance Limited: Axis Max Life Insurance Limited, established in 2000 and headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana, is led by Managing Director (MD) & Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Sumit Madan.

Delhivery's financial services arm receives RBI nod for Type II NBFC licence

In July 2026, **Delhivery Financial Services Private Limited,** a wholly-owned subsidiary of logistics firm, Delhivery Limited, received the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) approval for the grant of a Certificate of Registration **(CoR)** as a **Type-II** Non-Banking Financial Company-Non-Deposit Taking **(NBFC-ND).**

- However, RBI has clarified that the issuance of the CoR is subject to submission of certain documents to the satisfaction of the central bank., as specified in the approval letter.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What**? RBI approval for Type-II NBFC-ND licence
- ✓ **Company**: Delhivery Financial Services Private Limited (DFSPL)
- ✓ **Parent Company**: Delhivery Limited
- ✓ **Approval Date**: 13 July 2026
- ✓ **Regulator**: Reserve Bank of India (RBI)

Key Details:

Significance: The approval will enable the company to expand its financial services offerings for its logistics ecosystem.
Key Plan: The company plans to reinforce Delhivery's logistics network by providing access to credit, payment solutions, FasTag aggregation, fuel cards and insurance for truckers, fleet owners, among others.
Delhivery Financial Services Pvt. Ltd.: The financial arm of Delhivery Limited was incorporated in January 2026 as a dedicated business vertical that aims to strengthen the company's logistics network through financial products.
About NBFC: It is a financial institution registered under the Companies Act, 1956 or Companies Act, 2013, offering loans and Advances, and acquiring stock, equities, and debts issued by the government or any other local authority. NBFCs are primarily regulated by RBI under the RBI Act, 1934.

- In terms of the type of liabilities, NBFCs have been categorised into NBFC-Deposit-taking (NBFC-D) and NBFC-ND.
- NBFC-ND has been further classified into two categories: Type-I NBFC-ND (which do not accept public funds and do not have a customer interface) and Type-II NBFC-ND (accept public funds and have customer interface).

SBI Life Insurance Partners with PCI as 'Principal Partner' of Indian Contingent for 2026 Para Sports Season

In July 2026, **SBI Life Insurance Company Limited,** one of India's most trusted private life insurers, entered into strategic partnership with the Paralympic Committee of India **(PCI),** becoming the **"Principal Partner"** of the Indian Contingent for **2026** para sport season.

- The partnership aims to recognise and highlight the journey of India's para-athletes, as high-performers who continue to redefine possibilities through their dedication and commitment.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** SBI Life Insurance Partners with PCI
- ✓ **Purpose:** Principal Partner for 2026 Para Sport Season
- ✓ **Key Role of SBI Life Insurance:** Act as Official Life Insurance Partner
- ✓ **For which sports events of 2026?** Commonwealth Para Games 2026 (Glasgow, Scotland); and Asian Para Games 2026 (Aichi-Nagoya, Japan)

Key Details:

Insurance Partner: Under the collaboration, SBI Life Insurance will act as the "Official Life Insurance Partner" for the Indian Contingent at the upcoming **Commonwealth Para Games 2026** in Glasgow, Scotland and the **Asian Para Games 2026** in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan.

Previous Association: Previously, SBI Life Insurance associated with India's Para athletes during the 2024 Paris Paralympic Games held in Paris, capital of France.

SBI Life Insurance: Incorporated in October 2000, SBI Life Insurance Company Limited, is registered with the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) in March 2001, offering a diverse range of insurance products to cater the needs of individuals as well as group customers through protection, pension, savings, and health solutions.

VIYONA Receives BBPS Approval to Offer Digital Bill Payment Services

In July 2026, **VIYONA Fintech,** a fintech infrastructure startup, received approval from the Bharat Bill Payment System **(BBPS**), now known as Bharat Connect, to operate as a Customer Operating Unit (COU), enabling it to provide interoperable digital bill payment services across India.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Approval?** Received Customer Operating Unit approval
- ✓ **Company:** VIYONA Fintech
- ✓ **Approved System:** Bharat Connect (BBPS)
- ✓ **Founder & CEO:** Ravindranath Yarlagadda
- ✓ **Purpose:** To offer interoperable digital bill payment services across India.

About Payment Services:

Services: The certification enables VIYONA to offer Bharat Connect-powered bill payment services across multiple categories, including electricity, water, gas, broadband, mobile recharges, Direct-to-Home (DTH) subscriptions, insurance premiums, loan Equated Monthly Installments (EMIs), educational fees, and other approved bill payments.

Integration: Furthermore, the approval enables Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs), banks, fintech companies, enterprises, and government organisations to integrate Bharat Connect services through VIYONA's platform.

Payment Capabilities: The approval strengthens VIYONA's digital payment infrastructure and adds to its National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) certifications, including Unified Payments Interface (UPI) Switch, Immediate Payment Service (IMPS), Banking Connect, Billers Operating Unit (BOU) and eKYC Setu.

About VIYONA: Established in 2018, VIYONA Fintech is a Hyderabad, Telangana, India-based fintech infrastructure startup.

Axis Finance Launches 'Drishti' Digital Platform to Strengthen Retail and MSME Lending

In July 2026, Axis Finance Limited **(AFL)** launched **'Axis Finance Drishti'**, an in-house Business Rules Engine (BRE) and configurable digital platform to strengthen credit decision-making and risk management across retail and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprise **(MSME)** lending.

- The platform aims to enable faster, data-driven and scalable credit assessments while improving customer experience and lending efficiency.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Axis Finance Drishti
- ✓ **Launched By:** Axis Finance Limited
- ✓ **Platform Type:** In-house Business Rules Engine
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen digital credit decision-making and risk management
- ✓ **Phase-I Coverage:** Personal Loans, Business Loans, Loan Against Property (LAP), Disha Home Loans.

About Axis Finance Drishti:

Overview: It is an in-house BRE developed by AFL to **automate** and **standardise credit decision**-making using advanced analytics, underwriting workflows, and statistical scorecards.

Phase-I: In its first phase, the platform has been deployed across Personal Loans, Business Loans, Loan Against Property (LAP), and Disha Home Loans to enable faster, consistent, and data-driven credit assessments.

Key Features: Drishti is a configurable digital platform that enables automated, policy-driven credit assessments, real-time decision-making, and Straight-Through Processing (STP) by integrating underwriting workflows, advanced analytics, statistical scorecards, and multiple data sources.

About AFL: It is a non-deposit-taking Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) and a wholly owned subsidiary of Axis Bank. It was incorporated in India in 1995 and is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

ECONOMY & BUSINESS

POWERGRID Secures JPY 80 Billion Green Loan from JBIC for RE Transmission Project

In July 2026, Power Grid Corporation of India Limited **(POWERGRID)**, a 'Maharatna' Central Public Sector Enterprise **(CPSE)** under the Ministry of Power (MoP), secured a Japanese Yen **(JPY) 80 billion green loa**n from the Japan Bank for International Cooperation **(JBIC)** for a Renewable Energy(RE) transmission project.

- The financing is among **India's largest green funding** arrangements for the power transmission sector and supports the integration of renewable energy into the national grid.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Secures 80 billion JPY green loan from JBIC
- ✓ **Who?** POWERGRID
- ✓ **For:** Khavda–Nagpur HVDC RE transmission project
- ✓ **Route: K**havda Renewable Energy Park, Gujarat to Nagpur, Maharashtra
- ✓ **JBIC Funding:** JPY 48 billion; the balance will be co-financed by SMBC, Kansai Mirai Bank, Kiraboshi Bank and The Joyo Bank.

About JBIC Green Loan:

Background: The loan agreement, signed in June 2026, will finance the Khavda–Nagpur High Voltage Direct Current **(HVDC) transmission project** to evacuate RE from the Khavda Renewable Energy Park, Gujarat, to Nagpur, Maharashtra.

- This project is among the world's largest HVDC projects and supports the Government of India's renewable energy targets.

Funding: JBIC will provide **48 billion JPY**, while the remaining amount will be co-financed by Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (SMBC), Kansai Mirai Bank, Kiraboshi Bank, and The Joyo Bank, with JBIC guaranteeing the co-financed portion.

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Target: The project supports India's goal of achieving 500 Gigawatt (GW) of RE capacity by 2030 and expanding the transmission network to 191,000 circuit kilometres (ckm) by 2032.
Sustainability: POWERGRID aims to achieve net-zero emissions by 2047, zero waste to landfill and become net water positive by 2030, while integrating Environmental, Social and Governance **(ESG)** principles into its operations.
Significance: The project will support the adoption and expansion of HVDC equipment in India, strengthening the country's power-transmission network. It is also expected to create business opportunities for Japanese HVDC equipment suppliers and help build a stable, sustainable supply chain.

About POWERGRID:

Headquarters: Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), established in 1989, is one of the world's largest power transmission utilities. It is headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana.
Network: As of 31 May 2026, it operated 291 substations, 185,750 ckm of transmission lines and 630,516 megavolt-amperes (MVA) of transformation capacity, maintaining over 99.5% transmission system availability.

About Ministry of Power (MoP):

It is responsible for the development of the power sector, including electricity generation, transmission, distribution and energy conservation in India.
Union Minister- Manohar Lal Khattar (Constituency- Karnal, Haryana)
Minister of State **(MoS)-** Shripad Yesso Naik (Constituency- North Goa, Goa)

AEL's KCL Secured LME Certification for "Adani Copper"

In July 2026, Kutch Copper Limited **(KCL),** a subsidiary of Adani Enterprises Limited **(AEL),** secured London Metal Exchange **(LME)** certification for its "**Adani Copper" Grade A cathodes.**

- The approval will enable Adani Copper cathodes to be delivered with warrants eligible for issuance against LME Copper futures contracts from **July 10, 2026.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Receiving of London Metal Exchange (LME) Certification
- ✓ **Received by?** Kutch Copper Limited **(**KCL**)**
- ✓ **Certification for:** "Adani Copper" Grade A cathodes
- ✓ **Delivery of Cathodes from:** July 10, 2026

Key Details:

Global Significance: The LME listing of Adani Copper places the brand among the world's leading copper brands, conferring global recognition and market credibility on the Group's entry into the metals sector.
LME Cathodes as Collateral: Also, LME-listed cathodes can be stored on warrant in approved warehouses and used as collateral, thereby enhancing the financing flexibility and global tradability.
Certification Process: It involves superior quality assurances which cover chemical composition, shape and weight, alongside strict responsible sourcing protocol.
About London Metal Exchange (LME): The LME is the world's largest exchange for trading industrial metals, including copper, aluminium, zinc, lead, nickel, and tin, and it provides global benchmark prices while facilitating the trading, hedging, and physical delivery of non-ferrous metals; it is headquartered in London, United Kingdom (UK), and was established in 1877.

IMF WEO Update – July 2026: India to Grow at 6.4% in FY27

In July 2026, the International Monetary Fund (**IMF**) released "**World Economic Outlook(WEO) Update – July 2026 titled** "Global Economy in Crosscurrents of War and Technology"**,** projecting **India's**

economy to grow by **6.4%** in Financial Year 2026–27 **(FY27),** marginally lower than the 6.5% forecast issued in April 2026.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** IMF released WEO Update July 2026
- ✓ **Title:** 'Global Economy in Cross currents of War and Technology'
- ✓ **India Growth:** 7.7% in FY26; 6.4% in FY27, 6.7% in FY28
- ✓ **Global Growth:** 3.0% in 2026; 3.4% in 2027
- ✓ **Trade Growth:** 3.5% (2026); 4.3% (2027)
- ✓ **Headline Inflation**: 4.7% (2026); 3.9% (2027).

India Specific Highlights:

Growth: The WEO Update, also projects that India will grow at **6.7%** in **FY28**, up from the earlier projection of 6.5%.

- India's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) grew by **7.7%** during the financial year ending March 2026 **(FY26).**
- India remains among the 'fastest growing' major economies, supported by strong momentum in private consumption and services activity.

Inflationary Pressure: The IMF also highlights that crude oil prices are projected to increase by 32%, food prices by 8% and fertilizer prices by 26% in 2026, which could put upward pressure on inflation in energy-importing countries like India.

Global Highlights:

Global growth: The global economy is projected to grow by **3.0%** in 2026, with growth expected to strengthen further to **3.4%** in 2027, reflecting a gradual improvement in global economic activity.

Reason: The global economy continues to face mixed trends, with the conflict in West Asia slowing economic activity, while rapid advances in artificial intelligence (AI) and the global technology cycle help support growth.

Trade Outlook: World trade volume growth is projected to slow sharply from 5.0% in 2025 to **3.5% in 2026,** before rebounding to 4.3% in 2027.

Headline Inflation: The global headline inflation is projected to rise from 4.1% in 2025 to **4.7%** in 2026 before easing to **3.9%** in 2027.

- Core inflation is projected to gradually return to target levels.

Region Specific Highlights:

Emerging Market and Developing Economies: In this region, growth is projected to slow to **3.8%** in 2026 before recovering to **4.5%** in 2027.

Middle East and Central Asia: Growth is projected to drop sharply to **0.7%** in 2026 before rebounding to **6.5%** in 2027.

Sub-Saharan Africa: Growth in sub-Saharan Africa is expected to remain broadly stable at **4.3%** in 2026.

About International Monetary Fund (IMF):

The IMF was established in July 1944 at the Bretton Woods Conference based on the proposals of Harry Dexter White and John Maynard Keynes. It formally came into existence in 1945 with 29 member countries.

Managing Director (**MD**)– Kristalina Georgieva

Headquarters– Washington., DC, United States of America (USA)

Member nations-190

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ADB Lowers India's FY27 GDP Growth Forecast to 6.6%; Raises Inflation forecast to 5.2%

In July 2026, the Asian Development Bank **(ADB)** lowered India's Gross Domestic Product **(GDP) growth** forecast for the Financial Year 2026-27 **(FY27)** to **6.6%** from 6.9% (projected in April 2026), citing high energy prices that are squeezing household incomes.

- While ADB retained its **FY28** growth forecast at **7.3%**, supported by policy measures, stronger exports, and improving global economic conditions.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Revision of India GDP and inflation projections
- ✓ **Who?** ADB
- ✓ **GDP Forecast:** 6.6%(FY27); 7.3%(FY28)
- ✓ **Inflation Forecast:** 5.2%(FY27); 4%(FY28)
- ✓ **South Asia Growth:** 6.0% (2026)
- ✓ **Developing Asia Growth:** 4.9% (2026)

Key Findings:

Inflation: ADB raised India's inflation forecast for FY2026–27 to **5.2%** from **4.5%**, citing higher global oil prices, a weaker rupee, and persistent food inflation, while retaining its **FY28** inflation forecast at **4.0%** on expectations of moderating fuel and food prices.

Regional Impact: The 2026 growth forecast was revised down to 6.0% for South Asia from 6.3%, and to 4.9% for Developing Asia-Pacific from 5.1%. The FY27 forecasts were retained at 7.3% for India and 5.1% for Developing Asia-Pacific.

Risks: Downside risks include geopolitical tensions, weather-related agriculture weakness, elevated energy and transportation costs, and uncertainty over remittances.

Policy Measures: ADB cited fuel tax cuts, targeted credit support, public capital expenditure, and strong services exports as factors supporting growth despite headwinds.

Comparative Estimates: ADB's FY27 GDP growth forecast of 6.6% remains higher than the International Monetary Fund (IMF)'s **6.4%** projection and is in line with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s revised estimate, while its FY28 forecast of **7.3%** also exceeds the IMF's **6.7%** projection, reaffirming India as one of the world's fastest-growing major economies.

About Asian Development Bank (ADB):

President – Masato Kanda
Headquarters – Mandaluyong, Metro Manila, Philippines
Established – 1966

GoI Approves Dixon-Vivo JV for Domestic Smartphone Manufacturing

In July 2026, the Government of India **(GoI)** approved the proposal of formation of a Joint Venture **(JV)** between **Dixon Technologies (India) Limited** and Vivo Mobile India Limited **(VMI)** for the manufacturing of electronic devices and smartphones in India.

- As per the JV agreement and shareholders' signed by the both entities, the JV will act as an Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) for electronic devices, specifically smartphones.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of JV for domestic smartphone manufacturing
- ✓ **Approved by:** GoI
- ✓ **JV Between:** Dixon Technologies (India) (51%) Limited and VMI (49%)
- ✓ **Initial Investment:** Rs 5 crore (proportion to their share in JV)

Key Details:

Shareholding: As per the JV agreement, Dixon will own **51%** stake in the proposed JV, while VMI will hold

the remaining **49%** stake.

Paid-up Capital: The newly approved JV will be formed with initial paid-up capital of Rs 5 crore by both entities in proportion to their shareholding.

Key Obligation: The approval enables the VMI to participate in the JV under Note 3 of 2020 issued by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I), which mandates the company to seek prior approval from the GoI for investments from countries sharing a land border with India, including China.

Key Change: No consideration has been exchanged as the JV is yet to be incorporated; upon incorporation, it will acquire selected manufacturing assets and enter into a manufacturing and packaging agreement with VMI to execute part of its OEM orders.

TCS Expands Partnership with ABB to Transform Global Network Operations

In July 2026, Tata Consultancy Services **(TCS),** an Indian multinational technology company, signed a multi-million, multi-year agreement with **ABB**, a global technology leader in electrification and automation, to transform its **global network operations** using Artificial Intelligence **(AI).**

- The agreement marks the next phase of the **20-year** partnership between TCS and ABB, expanding TCS's role to deliver end-to-end AI-driven global network operations.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** AI-driven network transformation deal
- ✓ **Entities:** TCS & ABB
- ✓ **Programme:** ABB Future Network Model
- ✓ **Technology:** AI – driven Network-as-a-Service (NaaS)
- ✓ **Partnership:** 20 years.

Key Details of Agreement:

Objective: Transform ABB's global network into a standardised, centrally managed, AI-driven digital infrastructure through an integrated Network-as-a-Service **(NaaS)** model.

Key Features: TCS will manage end-to-end global network operations using Service Integration and Management (SIAM), a Global Network Operations Centre (GNOC), advanced security, and modernised Local Area Network (LAN), Wide Area Network (WAN), and Software-Defined Wide Area Network (SD-WAN) systems.

Benefits: Enhances user experience, operational efficiency, security, compliance, scalability, and AI-powered monitoring.

ABB: A Swedish-Swiss technology company, formed in 1988 through the merger of ASEA (Sweden) and Brown, Boveri & Cie (BBC) (Switzerland), specialising in electrification and automation. It was headquartered in Zurich, Switzerland.

India's outward FDI Drops 47.9% to USD 3 billion in June 2026: RBI Data

In July 2026, according to provisional data released by the Reserve Bank of India **(RBI),** India's **outward** Foreign Direct Investment **(FDI)** declined by 47.9% Year-on-Year (Y-o-Y) to **USD 3 billion** in June 2026, compared to USD 5.74 billion in June 2025. It also decreased from USD 4.5 billion in May 2026.

- All three components of Outward FDI commitments: equity, debt, and guarantees, witnessed a decline in June 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Provisional Data related to India's Outward FDI
- ✓ **Released by:** RBI
- ✓ **India's Outward FDI:** USD 3 billion in June 2026

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- ✓ **Key Components:** Equity commitments (USD 738 million), debt commitments (USD 469.87 million) and guarantees (USD 1.78 billion).

Key Findings:

Equity Commitments: It further revealed that equity commitments decreased to **USD 738 million** (in June 2026) over USD 2.2 billion (in June 2025) and USD 1.25 billion (in May 2026).
Debt Commitments: Similarly, the debt commitments dropped from USD 568.54 million (in June 2025) and USD 645.75 million (in May 2026) **to USD 469.87 million** (in June 2026).
Guarantees: Also, the guarantees issued by Indian entities to their overseas subsidiaries and ventures dropped **to USD 1.78 billion** (in June 2026) against USD 2.97 billion recorded in the same month of last year and USD 2.6 billion (in May 2026).
Equity Commitments by Companies: As per the RBI data on major overseas investment commitments, ONGC Videsh Rovuma Limited **(OVRL)'s** made the largest FDI equity commitment in June 2026, with investment of USD 40 million towards its Mozambique-based Joint Venture (JV), Project R2 Mozambique.

- It is followed by Lenskart (USD 22 million) and GFCL EV products made equity commitments worth USD 30.13 million.

ICRA Projects India's GDP Growth at 6.4–6.6% in Q1 FY27

In July 2026, **ICRA Limited**, a domestic credit rating agency, projected India's real Gross Domestic Product **(GDP) growth** at **6.4–6.6%** for the first quarter **(Q1)** (April–June) of Financial Year 2026-27 **(FY27),** driven by broad-based economic activity despite elevated energy prices and limited input availability affecting margins across key sectors.

- India's real GDP grew by **7.8%** in Q4(January–March) of FY26.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** ICRA projected India's GDP growth
- ✓ **By Whom?** ICRA Limited
- ✓ **GDP growth:** 6.4–6.6% (Q1 FY27);7.8% (Q4 FY26)
- ✓ **BAM Growth:** June 2026 – 12% YoY; Q1 FY27 – 10% YoY
- ✓ **Other Projections:** Core Industries growth (June 2026)- 5%, IIP growth – 5–6%.

About ICRA's GDP Projection:

Growth: ICRA's Business Activity Monitor **(BAM)** recorded 12% year-on-year (YoY) growth in June 2026, the highest in 32 months, up from 9.4% in May 2026, with 13 of 16 high-frequency indicators showing faster growth.
Drivers: Growth was supported by the temporary United States of America (USA)–Iran ceasefire, a 40% rainfall deficit that extended construction and mining activity, and a favourable base effect, while 10 of 17 non-agricultural indicators improved during Q1 FY27.
Industry: Based on 5% YoY growth in the Index of Core Industries, ICRA projected the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) to grow **5–6%** in June 2026.
Significance: The report indicates sustained economic momentum driven by industrial and infrastructure activity despite rising energy prices, supply-side constraints, and pressure on manufacturing profit margins.

Sona Comstar & DENSO Sign Agreements to Establish Two JVs for Electric and Hybrid Powertrain Systems

In July 2026, Sona BLW Precision Forgings Limited **(Sona Comstar)** and **Japan-based DENSO Corporation** signed agreements to establish two Joint Ventures (JVs) in India for developing, manufacturing, and marketing advanced electric and hybrid powertrain systems for multiple vehicle

segments.

- The MoU was signed by **Vivek Vikram Singh,** Managing Director (MD) & Group Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Sona Comstar, and **Tsuneo Maebara**, Head of Powertrain Systems Business Group, DENSO Corporation.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What? MoU signed to establish Two JVs**
- ✓ **Partners:** Sona Comstar & DENSO Corporation
- ✓ **Purpose:** Development of electric and hybrid powertrain systems
- ✓ **JV1:** DENSO (51%) – High-voltage powertrain systems.
- ✓ **JV2:** Sona Comstar (51%) – Powertrain systems for two-/three-wheelers.

Highlights of Two JVs for Electric and Hybrid PowerTrain:

Objective: The partnership combines DENSO's electrification and research & development (R&D) expertise with Sona Comstar's engineering and manufacturing capabilities to develop globally competitive electric mobility solutions and support the transition towards vehicle electrification.

First JV: It will develop high-voltage liquid-cooled traction systems for electric and hybrid vehicles, with DENSO holding 51% stake and Sona Comstar holding 49% stake.

Second JV: It will develop will focus on two-wheelers and three-wheelers, manufacturing air-cooled traction inverters, traction motors, generators, with DENSO acquiring 49% stake (Rs. 1,750 crore) and Sona Comstar retaining 51% stake.

About Sona Comstar: It is headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana, and was incorporated on 27 October 1995 as Sona Okegawa Precision Forgings Limited, a joint venture with Mitsubishi Metal Corporation Limited.

- The company specializes in engineering mission-critical systems and components for the automotive industry.

Air India & Saudia Sign MoU to Strengthen Aviation Partnership

In July 2026, **Air India** and **Saudia**, the national flag carrier of Saudi Arabia, signed a **Memorandum of Understanding (MoU)** to expand their strategic cooperation between India and Saudi Arabia.

- The MoU was signed by **Ibrahim Al-Omar**, Director General (DG) of Saudia Group, and **Campbell Wilson**, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) & Managing Director (MD) of Air India.

Exam hints:

- ✓ **What?** Mou Signed to Strengthen aviation connectivity
- ✓ **MoU:** Air India – Saudia
- ✓ **Objective:** To expand strategic cooperation between India & Saudi Arabia
- ✓ **Cooperation:** Expansion of codeshare agreement.

Highlights of the MoU to Strengthen Aviation:

Objective: The partnership aims to provide passengers with improved connectivity, seamless transfers, greater travel flexibility, enhanced customer experience and wider destination choices.

Cooperation: The MoU adopts a phased approach to the partnership, beginning with the expansion of the existing codeshare agreement to provide passengers with access to a wider network through both airlines.

Key Areas: The airlines will enhance India–Saudi Arabia aviation connectivity by improving network connectivity, exploring terminal co-location, strengthening loyalty programme cooperation, extending collaboration to Air India Express and flyadeal, and providing passengers with greater flexibility and travel options.

About Air India: Air India, founded in 1932 and headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana, India, is a leading aviation and air transport company owned by the Tata Group.

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- Since its privatisation in 2022, Air India has expanded its global network through 25 codeshare partnerships, 120+ interline agreements and access to 1,000+ destinations.

Vizhinjam International Seaport Gets Customs Approval for EXIM Operations

In July 2026, the Vizhinjam International Seaport Limited **(VISL)**, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, received final approval from the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs **(CBIC)** to commence Export-Import **(EXIM)** cargo operations from 18 August 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Received Final Customs approval for EXIM cargo operations
- ✓ **Port:** Vizhinjam International Seaport Limited
- ✓ **Approved By:** CBIC
- ✓ **Customs Status:** Notified as a Customs Port under the Customs Act, 1962
- ✓ **Significance:** Enables direct EXIM operations and reduces dependence on foreign transshipment hubs.

About Customs Approval:

Approval: The CBIC notified the VISL as a Customs Port under the **Customs Act, 1962**, enabling direct EXIM operations, reducing reliance on foreign transshipment hubs, and enhancing India's international trade efficiency.

Customs Coordination: The CBIC will coordinate EXIM cargo regulation with VISL, Adani Vizhinjam Port Private Limited (AVPPL) and other concerned agencies.

Infrastructure: Developed under a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model by the Government of Kerala in collaboration with Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ).

About CBIC: It was established in 1964 and is headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi. It functions under the Department of Revenue (DoR), Ministry of Finance (MoF), and is headed by its Chairman Vivek Chaturvedi.

Edelweiss Mutual Fund Launches India's First REIT-Oriented Index Fund

In July 2026, **Edelweiss Mutual Fund** (MF) launched the **Edelweiss Nifty REITs & Realty Index Fund**, India's first Real Estate Investment Trusts **(REITs)-oriented open-ended passive index fund**, which tracks the **Nifty REITs & Realty** Total Return Index **(TRI).**

- The fund seeks to provide low-cost, long-term capital appreciation by offering diversified exposure to India's listed REITs and real estate companies through a single investment.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of India's first REIT-oriented Index Fund
- ✓ **By Whom?** Edelweiss Mutual Fund
- ✓ **Fund Name:** Edelweiss Nifty REITs & Realty Index Fund.
- ✓ **Minimum Subscription:** Rs 100 (in multiples of Re 1 thereafter)
- ✓ **Expense Ratio:** Maximum 0.90%.
- ✓ **No Exit Load:** Scheme carries no exit load.

About Edelweiss Nifty REITs & Realty Index Fund:

Benchmark: It tracks the Nifty REITs & Realty TRI, which currently allocates about **60%** to listed REITs and **40%** to listed real estate companies, with REIT allocation expected to increase as more REITs are listed.

Regulations: Under Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) regulations, Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) were reclassified as equity instruments from January 1, 2026 and became eligible for equity indices from July 1, 2026, while Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs) remain hybrid instruments and cannot be combined with REITs in a single passive index fund.

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NVIDIA, Microsoft, IBM and others launch Open Secure AI Alliance to strengthen AI security

In July 2026, **NVIDIA**, **Microsoft** Corporation and International Business Machines Corporation (**IBM**), along with several technology companies and research institutions, launched the Open Secure AI Alliance (**OSAA**) an open industry initiative aimed at enhancing the security, trustworthiness, and resilience of Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems through open collaboration and shared security standards.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Open Secure AI Alliance (OSAA)
- ✓ **Launched by:** NVIDIA, Microsoft, IBM and other industry partners
- ✓ **Objective:** Strengthen AI security through open collaboration
- ✓ **Purpose:** To strengthen AI security and address the emerging AI-related cyber threats

About Open Secure AI Alliance (OSAA):

Objectives: The alliance aims to improve the security, transparency and reliability of AI systems, promote secure-by-design AI development, facilitate information sharing on AI-related threats and vulnerabilities, and encourage the adoption of common security standards across the AI ecosystem.

Key Driver for Launch: This new initiative was launched days after the latest cyber incident at Hugging Face, where through an AI system, the company's infrastructure was breached during a security evaluation.

Alliance Members: The newly launched alliance comprises over 35 inaugural members spanning AI, cybersecurity, enterprise software, cloud computing and some of these are: Cisco, Dell Technologies, Cloudflare, Red Hat, Hugging Face, Salesforce, SAP, Service Now and the Linux Foundation, among others.

Key Role: The Alliances partners will contribute AI models, software, datasets and research to bolster cybersecurity and promote the adoption of AI across industries.

About NVIDIA: NVIDIA Corporation, founded in 1993, is a leading American technology company specializing in graphics processing units (GPUs), AI computing platforms and accelerated computing. It is headquartered in Santa Clara, California, United States of America (USA), and is led by Jensen Huang (President).

MoU's & AGREEMENTS

MCA Signs MoU with IIT Madras to Launch Corporate Mitra Scheme for MSMEs

In June 2026, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs **(MCA)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with the Indian Institute of Technology **(IIT) Madras,** Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN) **IIT Pravartak**, **SWAYAM Plus**, the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India **(ICAI)**, the Institute of Company Secretaries of India **(ICSI)**, and the Institute of Cost Accountants of India **(ICMAI)**, in New Delhi, Delhi, to launch the **Corporate Mitra Scheme**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU Signed to Launch Corporate Mitra Scheme
- ✓ **Entities:** MCA with IIT Madras; IIT Pravartak; SWAYAM Plus; ICAI; ICSI; ICMAI
- ✓ **Announced:** Scheme announced in Union Budget 2026–27
- ✓ **Training:** 150-hour online learning + 6-month internship
- ✓ **Fee:** Rs 3,000 + GST
- ✓ **Concession:** 50% for women and selected regions
- ✓ **Certification:** Corporate Mitra

About the Corporate Mitra Scheme:

Aim: The scheme aims to create a pool of trained Corporate Mitras to support Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) with regulatory compliance, taxation, accounting, financial governance, and business

growth under the Union Budget 2026–27 initiative.

Training: The programme includes 150 hours of online learning through SWAYAM Plus followed by six months of practical training. It is open to Indian nationals below 30 years who are graduates or final-year graduation students.

Registration: The course fee is Rs 3,000 plus Goods and Services Tax (GST), with a 50% concession for women and candidates from North Eastern States, Himalayan Regions, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and Lakshadweep. Registrations will open through the websites of the MCA, SWAYAM Plus, ICAI, ICSI and ICMAI.

Certification: Candidates completing the academic and practical training will receive Corporate Mitra Certification.

Ministry of Tourism Signs MoU with Google India to Boost Digital Tourism

In June 2026, the Ministry of Tourism (**MoT)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with **Google India** in New Delhi, Delhi to strengthen digital promotion of India's tourism destinations using Artificial Intelligence (AI), data-driven insights

- The MoU was signed in the presence of Union Minister **Gajendra Singh Shekhawat**, MoT to enhance global visibility of India's tourism.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU between MoT and Google India.
- ✓ **Venue:** New Delhi, Delhi.
- ✓ **Objective:** Digital promotion of tourism.
- ✓ **Technology:** AI and travel insights.
- ✓ **Agreement:** Non-commercial, non-binding, non-exclusive agreement
- ✓ **Initiative:** Incredible India

Highlights of the MoU:

Objective: The initiative leverages analytics, and digital platforms to enhance India's cultural heritage and diverse travel experiences, positioning the country as a global tourism hub showcasing its culture, nature, spirituality, wellness, and adventure offerings.

Features: The partnership includes digital tourism promotion, knowledge sharing, capacity building, AI-based engagement tools, campaign optimisation, and use of Google's digital ecosystem for enhanced outreach.

Nature of Agreement: The MoU is non-commercial, non-binding, and non-exclusive with no financial commitment from either party, focusing on collaborative knowledge and technology sharing under the Incredible India initiative.

Air India Signs MoU with SIA Engineering Company to Develop MRO Ecosystem in India

In July 2026, **Air India** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with SIA Engineering Company **(SIAEC)** in Mumbai, Maharashtra, to explore collaboration in the Maintenance, Repair, and Overhaul **(MRO)** sector, aiming to strengthen India's position as a global aviation MRO hub.

- The MoU was signed by Air India Chief Executive Officer (CEO) and Managing Director **Campbell Wilson** and SIAEC CEO **Chin Yau Seng**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed for MRO collaboration
- ✓ **Who?** Air India & SIAEC
- ✓ **Where Signed?** Mumbai, Maharashtra
- ✓ **Objective?** Develop an MRO hub in India
- ✓ **Focus Area:** Aircraft maintenance, repair & overhaul

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Air India–SIAEC MRO Partnership:

Objective: The MoU aims to deepen collaboration by leveraging SIAEC's MRO and technical expertise to strengthen Air India's operations and develop a **world-class MRO ecosystem** in India, including a potential joint venture (JV) for growing aviation market needs.
Past Collaborations: The partnership builds on earlier agreements, including a 12-year Inventory Technical Management (ITM) contract for **Airbus A320 fleet** support, on 21 February 2024, and SIAEC's role as a base maintenance partner for Air India's Bengaluru facility development on 11 May 2024.
Ownership Link: SIAEC is part of the Singapore Airlines Group, which holds a **25.1%** stake in Air India.
About Air India: Air India was founded in 1932 by J.R.D. Tata, as Tata Airlines, was nationalized in 1953 and officially reacquired by the Tata Group in January 2022.

- It is India's flag carrier, headquartered in Gurugram (Haryana), and currently co-owned by Tata Sons (74.9%) and Singapore Airlines (25.1%) following its merger with Vistara.

Sharnbasva University Signs MoU with Industrial University of Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam to Boost Academic Collaboration

In July 2026, **Sharnbasva University**, Kalaburagi, Karnataka, signed a 5 year Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with the Industrial University of Ho Chi Minh City (IUH), Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam.

- The MoU aims to strengthen academic collaboration, collaborative research, faculty and student exchange, and scientific and cultural cooperation between the two universities.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Event?** MoU signing
- ✓ **Indian Institution:** Sharnbasva University, Kalaburagi, Karnataka
- ✓ **Partner Institution:** Industrial University of Ho Chi Minh City (IUH), Vietnam
- ✓ **When:** July 2026
- ✓ **Duration:** Five years
- ✓ **Purpose:** Joint research, faculty & student exchange, and academic collaboration.

Highlights of the MoU:

Features: The collaboration will initially focus on Engineering, Technology and Management Studies.
Significance: The partnership is expected to enhance academic excellence, innovation and global exposure for students and faculty of both institutions.
Signatories: The agreement was signed by Bui Thanh Hung of the IUH and Lakshmi Patil Maka, Registrar of Sharnbasva University, in Kalaburagi, Karnataka.

Bisleri International Partners with ICG for Cleaner Coastlines and a Sustainable Future

In July 2026, **Bisleri International** Private Limited, one of India's largest premium beverage businesses, signed a Letter of Association **(LoA)** with the Indian Coast Guard **(ICG) (Kerala and Mahe)** through its flagship initiative Bottles for Change **(BFC),** to promote plastic waste management and support environmental sustainability across coastal regions.

- The collaboration expands the reach of Bottles for Change (BFC) to coastal and marine ecosystems, reinforcing Bisleri International's commitment to environmental sustainability.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Signing of LoA
- ✓ **Entities:** ICG (Kerala & Mahe) and Bisleri International
- ✓ **Purpose:** To advance plastic waste management across coastal regions
- ✓ **Initiative:** Bottles for Change
- ✓ **ICG Mission:** Plastic Free Oceans.

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Key Details of Agreement:

Signatories: The agreement, aligned with the ICG mission of **'Plastic Free Oceans',** was formally signed by Dr. Angelo George, Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Bisleri International; and Ashish Mehrotra, Deputy Inspector General (DIG) of ICG.

Plastic Waste Management: Under the collaboration, Bisleri's led BFC and ICG will jointly work to bolster plastic waste management systems by promoting responsible collection, segregation, and recycling of post-consumer plastic.

Key Objectives: In addition, the collaboration seeks to raise awareness, encourage behavioural change, and foster sustainable practices to prevent plastic waste from entering the marine ecosystems.

About Bisleri International: Established in 1969, Bisleri International is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra, and is best known for its Bisleri bottled water brand.

QCI and NSIC Sign MoU to Strengthen Quality, Competitiveness and Market Access for MSMEs

In July 2026, the Quality Council of India (**QCI**) and the National Small Industries Corporation (**NSIC**) signs Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) to enhance the quality standards, competitiveness, and market access of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (**MSMEs**) across India.

- The MoU was signed in the presence of **Dr. Subhransu Sekhar Acharya**, Chairman-cum-Managing Director (MD), NSIC and **Dr. A. Raj**, Senior Director and Head, National Division for Industry Excellence (NDIE), QCI, at the QCI Office, World Trade Centre, New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed between QCI and NSIC.
- ✓ **Purpose:** To improve quality standards, competitiveness, and market access for MSMEs.
- ✓ **Focus areas:** ZED Certification, MSME Global Mart, ONDC, testing, accreditation, and capacity building.
- ✓ **Mou Term:** 5 years
- ✓ **Accreditation Support:** NABL (For NSIC Testing Laboratories), NABET (For NSIC Skilling & Training Centres)

Key Details of MoU:

Accreditation: The partnership combines QCI's expertise in quality, accreditation, and certification with NSIC's MSME support ecosystem to promote global quality standards and boost the growth of Indian enterprises.

Joint Coordination Committee (JCC): The JCC, comprising representatives from **QCI** and **NSIC**, will meet **quarterly** to identify collaboration opportunities, monitor progress, and guide joint initiatives during the **5-year** MoU period.

Integration: The QCI–NSIC collaboration brings together MSME **ZED** (Zero Defect Zero Effect) Certification, MSME **Global Mart** & **ONDC** (Open Network for Digital Commerce) for digital market access and export promotion, and **TEAM** Initiative & **SPRS** (Single Point Registration Scheme) for digital onboarding and integrating quality certifications.

Quality Convergence: The collaboration will strengthen convergence between ZED Certification and NSIC's SPRS, support National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories **(NABL)** accreditation for NSIC testing facilities, and enable National Accreditation Board for Education and Training **(NABET)**-led assessment, accreditation, and customised capacity-building programmes for NSIC training centres and laboratories.

DoP and TRAI Signed MoU for India's Largest Village-Level Telecom Network Survey

In July 2026, the Department of Posts **(DoP)**, Ministry of Communications, and the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India **(TRAI)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(M**oU) in New Delhi, Delhi to conduct India's **largest** village-level telecom network performance survey.

- The one-year initiative will assess the mobile network performance of Bharti Airtel, Reliance Jio, Vodafone Idea (Vi), and Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL) across over **5.68 lakh villages** using an Android-based mobile application developed by TRAI.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU for India's Largest Village-Level Telecom Network Survey
- ✓ **Organisations:** Department of Posts (DoP) & TRAI
- ✓ **Coverage:** Over 5.68 lakh villages
- ✓ **Duration:** 1 year
- ✓ **Surveyed TSPs:** Bharti Airtel, Reliance Jio, Vodafone Idea (Vi) & BSNL
- ✓ **Survey Tool:** Android-based mobile application
- ✓ **Survey Personnel:** Gramin Dak Sevaks (GDSs)

Highlights of the Initiative:

Objective: To identify mobile connectivity gaps and support evidence-based telecom policy for improving rural telecom infrastructure.

Implementation: Over 1.40 lakh Gramin Dak Sevaks (GDSs) will collect field data during routine postal operations.

Roles: The DoP will conduct the survey, while TRAI will provide the app, training, technical support, and monitoring.

MoU: The agreement was signed by Manisha Bansal Badal (DoP) and S. M. K. Chandra (TRAI) to strengthen Digital India and improve rural telecom services.

About TRAI: Established in 1997, the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) is headquartered in New Delhi and is chaired by Anil Kumar Lahoti.

DBN, GFGNL, and BSNL Sign Addendum for Rs.5,629 Crore BharatNet Rural Broadband Rollout in Gujarat

In July 2026, Digital Bharat Nidhi **(DBN)** under the Department of Telecommunications (DoT), the Government of **Gujarat** (GoG), Gujarat Fibre Grid Network Limited (**GFGNL**), and Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (**BSNL)** signed an **addendum** to the existing agreement for implementing the Amended BharatNet Programme (ABP) in Gujarat under the State-led model, with a total outlay of **Rs. 5,629 crore,** at Sanchar Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Addendum signed for the Amended BharatNet Programme
- ✓ **For**: Gujarat
- ✓ **Parties Involve**d: DBN, DoT, Government of Gujarat, GFGNL, and BSNL
- ✓ **Outlay**: Rs. 5,629 crore
- ✓ **Signatories:** P. Bharathi (Gujarat) and Dinesh Kumar Garg (DoT)
- ✓ **Implementation Agency**: Gujarat Fibre Grid Network Limited
- ✓ **Coverage:** 14,287 Gram Panchayats (GPs) and 3,895 villages (on demand)
- ✓ **Home Fibre Connections:** Over 5 lakh rural households.

Key Details of Addendum:

Signatories: The agreement was signed by **P. Bharathi, Secretary,** Department of Science and Technology, GoG, and **Dinesh Kumar Garg**, Deputy Director General (DDG), Aadhaar & BharatNet

Programme (ABP) Implementation-I, DoT.

Significance: The agreement aims to strengthen rural digital broadband connectivity, enhancing last-mile connectivity and promoting inclusive digital growth across the state.

Implementation: GFGNL will implement the programme across 14,287 GPs, providing over 5 lakh rural home fibre connections and extending connectivity to 3,895 villages on a demand basis to strengthen last-mile broadband connectivity.

About BharatNet: Launched as the National Optical Fibre Network (NOFN) in 2011 and renamed BharatNet in 2015, it aims to provide high-speed broadband connectivity to around 2.5 lakh GPs across India.

DoT Signs MoU with TSDSI to Strengthen India's Global Telecom Standards Ecosystem

In July 2026, the Department of Telecommunications **(DoT)**, Ministry of Communications, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the Telecommunications Standards Development Society, India **(TSDSI)** during the **9th TSDSI** Technical Deep Dive (TTDD) 2026 in New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to strengthen India's telecom standards ecosystem
- ✓ **Entities:** DoT & TSDSI
- ✓ **Scheme:** Technology Development and Investment Promotion Scheme
- ✓ **Mission:** Bharat 6G Mission
- ✓ **Global Standards**: 3GPP, ITU & oneM2M.

Highlights of the MoU:

Objective: The MoU was signed under the Technology Development and Investment Promotion (TDIP) Scheme to strengthen India's participation in global Standards Development Organizations (SDOs), promote indigenous telecom innovation, and support startups and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) under the Bharat 6G Mission.

Financial Support: The scheme provides financial assistance for participation in global standards bodies such as 3rd Generation Partnership Project (3GPP), International Telecommunication Union (ITU), oneM2M (global Machine-to-Machine and Internet of Things standards initiative), global standards meetings and support for 3GPP Individual Membership (IM) fees.

Benefits: Eligible Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT)-recognised startups and MSMEs will receive up to **98%** support (turnover up to Rs. 10 crore) and **80%** support (turnover Rs. 10–500 crore), along with up to 80% travel assistance (maximum Rs. 5 lakh per international meeting).

TDIP Scheme: Launched by the DoT in 2026 with an outlay of Rs. 203 crore for 2026–2031, the scheme promotes indigenous telecom innovation under the Bharat 6G Mission.

Pi-labs Partners with Google Cloud to Deliver Mission-Ready AI Solutions for India

In July 2026, **pi-labs,** an Indian Artificial Intelligence (AI) and deepfake detection company focused on regional security operations and digital governance, entered into a strategic partnership with **Google Cloud** to advance the delivery of secure, scalable and **mission-ready AI solutions** for **India.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announcement of Strategic Partnership
- ✓ **Between:** Pi-labs (Indian AI company) and Google Cloud
- ✓ **Objective:** Deliver secure, scalable and sovereign AI solutions for India
- ✓ **Key Technology:** Google Distributed Cloud Tactical Appliance

Key Details of Collaboration:

Focus: pi-labs will use its indigenous AI capabilities, alongside premise Google Distributed Cloud Tactical Appliance to support the evolving requirements of public sector organisations, critical enterprise

infrastructure, and government institutions.

Key Roles: Under the collaboration, Google Cloud will provide the secure, scalable, and resilient infrastructure needed to host robust AI workloads, while pi-labs will provide localised AI models and capabilities purpose-built to align with governance ecosystem of India.

Significance: The strategic partnership is expected to help organisations address evolving challenges like secure threat detection, regional language processing, and assistive security analytics.

About pi-labs: pi-labs is an Indian cyber forensics, cybersecurity and intelligence company that develops Sovereign Artificial Intelligence (AI) solutions for security, digital governance and critical infrastructure. It is recognised under the National Association of Software and Service Companies (NASSCOM) DeepTech League and supported by the NVIDIA Inception programme.

Akasa Air and BPCL Sign Landmark MoU to Accelerate Sustainable Aviation Fuel Adoption in India

In July 2026, **Akasa Air**, an Indian airline, partnered with Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (**BPCL**) signed an Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) to promote the adoption of Sustainable Aviation Fuel (**SAF**) aims to reduce carbon emissions from aviation in India.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU Signed
- ✓ **Entities:** Akasa Air and BPCL
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote the adoption of SAF in India
- ✓ **Framework:** Supply and offtake of SAF-blended Aviation Turbine Fuel**.**

Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The initiative will support long-term SAF supply by sharing demand projections, aiding production planning, and progressively raising blending levels as India's domestic SAF ecosystem matures.

Collaboration: The partnership will jointly promote India's SAF ecosystem through knowledge sharing, policy advocacy, and engagement with government and industry stakeholders.

Focus: The collaboration will focus on establishing a framework for the supply and offtake of SAF-blended Aviation Turbine Fuel (**ATF)** at designated airports across India.

Global Standards: The partnership supports India's decarbonization goals and aligns with global aviation sustainability standards, including the International Civil Aviation Organization'(**ICAO**) Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation (**CORSIA**).

About Akasa Air: It is an Indian low-cost airline headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra, and was established in 2021.

CGPDTM Signs MoU With CSIR-NIScPR To Join National Knowledge Resource Consortium

In July 2026, the Office of the Controller General of Patents, Designs and Trade Marks (**CGPDTM**) and the CSIR (Council of Scientific and Industrial Research)-National Institute of Science Communication and Policy Research (**CSIR-NIScPR**) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to enable CGPDTM's participation in the National Knowledge Resource Consortium **(NKRC).**

- The MoU was formally signed by **Prof. (Dr.) Unnat P. Pandit,** CGPDTM, and **Dr. Geeta Vani Rayasam**, Director, CSIR-NIScPR at Saraswati Hall, Bouddhik Sampada Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed
- ✓ **Entities:** CSIR-NIScPR & CGPDTM
- ✓ **Why?** To participate in NKRC
- ✓ **Benefits:** Access to international scientific journals, e-books, databases, patents.

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Key Details of MoU:

Access: Under the MoU, CGPDTM will gain access to the NKRC digital knowledge platform, which provides a wide range of international scientific journals, e-books, databases, and other scholarly resources.

Purpose: The agreement will strengthen research, innovation and intellectual property administration by providing patent professionals and researchers with a broader range of high-quality digital knowledge resources.

NKRC: Managed by the CSIR-NIScPR, the NKRC secures national-level licences for international e-journals, patent databases, standards, bibliographic databases, and other scientific resources, providing member institutions with cost-effective access to global knowledge and research tools.

- NKRC currently serves **82 member institutions**, including organizations under CSIR, the Department of Science & Technology (DST), and the Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES).

AP Signs MoU with UN-Habitat to Promote Sustainable Urban Development

In July 2026, the Government of Andhra Pradesh **(AP)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with the United Nations Human Settlements Programme **(UN-Habitat)** to establish a long-term partnership for promoting sustainable, inclusive, and climate-resilient urban development in the state.

- The partnership aims to establish a Centre of Excellence **(CoE)** for Urban Affairs in Amaravati.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signing
- ✓ **Between:** Government of Andhra Pradesh and UN-Habitat
- ✓ **Purpose:** To Promote Sustainable Urban Development
- ✓ **Centre of Excellence (CoE):** Urban Affairs, Amaravati
- ✓ **Key Initiatives:** SURGE AP, RISE AP, UPLIFT AP, and P4 Programme

Highlights of the UN-Habitat:

Partnership: The Municipal Administration Department signed an MoU with UN-Habitat to promote inclusive and sustainable urban development across AP.

Focus: The partnership will establish a CoE for Urban Affairs in Amaravati to support urban planning, climate-resilient cities, digital governance, municipal finance, and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Initiatives: The collaboration will strengthen the state's Sustainable Urban Revitalisation and Growth Enhancement Andhra Pradesh (SURGE AP), Resilient, Inclusive and Sustainable Environment Andhra Pradesh (RISE AP), UPLIFT AP, and Zero Poverty vision through the P4 Programme.

Dignitaries Present: The MoU was signed in the presence of N. Chandrababu Naidu, Chief Minister (CM) of AP, and Anacláudia Rossbach, Executive Director, United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat), who participated virtually from Singapore.

ISRO's VSSC and CSIR-IICT Sign MoU to Develop Indigenous Eco-Friendly Blowing Agent Technology

In July 2026, the Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO)'s** Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre **(VSSC)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-Indian Institute of Chemical Technology **(CSIR-IICT)** to jointly develop indigenous technology for next-generation, environmentally sustainable blowing agents.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Signing of MoU
- ✓ **Entities Involved:** ISRO's VSSC and CSIR-IICT
- ✓ **Purpose:** To jointly develop indigenous and eco-friendly blowing agent technology
- ✓ **Key Agreement Between:** ISRO's HSFC and SCTIMST (Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala)

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- ✓ **Purpose:** To advance research and training in space medicine and Bioastronautics
- ✓ **Key Feature of MoU:** Launch of India's 1st Postdoctoral Fellowship programme in Bioastronautics
- ✓ **Time Period:** 2-year

Key Details:

Aim: The strategic partnership aims to support advanced space applications, reduce India's reliance on imported fluorochemicals, and bolster the country's capabilities in strategic materials research.

Key Role: As per the MoU, the CSIR-IICT's Research and Development (R&D) expertise in fluorochemical synthesis and process development, will help in the safe handling of anhydrous hydrogen fluoride (HF), crucial in next-generation fluorochemicals.

- Also, VSSC's applications-specific requirements and technical evaluation capabilities will help in validating the materials for aerospace missions.

ISRO'S HSFC and SCTIMST Signed MoU in Bioastronautics:

Also, ISRO's Human Space Flight Centre **(HSFC)** signed an Implementing Agreement (IA) with the Sree Chitra Tirunal Institute for Medical Sciences and Technology **(SCTIMST)**, Thiruvananthapuram (Kerala) at ISRO Headquarters in Bengaluru, Karnataka, to jointly undertake research and training in the emerging field of space medicine and Bioastronautics in India.

Key Details of Agreement:

Fellowship Programme: As part of the collaboration, both entities jointly launched India's 1st indigenous 2-year Postdoctoral Fellowship (PDF) programme in the field of Bioastronautics.

Significance: The newly launched fellowship programme will help the researchers to address the health and physiological challenges faced by astronauts during long-space missions like: microgravity, cosmic radiation, and isolation.

Eligibility Criteria: Individuals with Postgraduate (PG) medical degrees, super-speciality medical qualifications, and Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) degrees in relevant areas are eligible to apply for the fellowship programme.

Background: This strategic partnership is an extension of the collaboration forged between HSFC and SCTIMST in April 2025 by signing a MoU for cooperation in the field of space medicine research related to various human space missions of ISRO.

- Later in November 2025, a "Center for Space Medicine Research" was inaugurated at SCTIMST to facilitate joint academic and research activities between HSFC and SCTIMST.

About Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO):

Chairman- Dr. V. Narayanan
Headquarters- Bengaluru, Karnataka
Established in- 1969

ISSDA and GSSE Partner to Promote Stainless Steel for India's Clean Energy Transition

On 20 July 2026, the Indian Stainless Steel Development Association **(ISSDA)** and the Global Stainless Steel Expo **(GSSE)** entered into a strategic partnership to promote **stainless steel** as a key enabler of India's clean energy transition and sustainable industrial growth.

- The collaboration aims to expand **stainless steel** use in green hydrogen, renewable energy, mobility, infrastructure and industrial sectors.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Partnership announced
- ✓ **Entities:** ISSDA and GSSE
- ✓ **Purpose: P**romote stainless steel for India's clean energy transition
- ✓ **Policy Demand:** National Stainless Steel Policy

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- ✓ **Key Sectors:** Green hydrogen, Renewable Energy (RE), mobility, infrastructure, LNG, and chemicals.

About ISSDA-GSSE Partnership:

Objective: The partnership promotes advanced stainless steel applications through technical conferences, buyer-seller meets and industry collaborations.

Applications: Owing to its corrosion resistance and durability, stainless steel supports green hydrogen, Renewable Energy (RE), ammonia, ethanol, Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG), and chemical sectors.

- The partnership also advocated a National Stainless Steel Policy (NSSP) to strengthen manufacturing and raw material security.

Outlook: India's stainless steel market is projected to reach **USD 15.8 billion** (Rs. 1.36 lakh crore) **by 2030.**

- India has 7.5 million tonnes (MT) stainless steel production capacity, **60–65%** capacity utilisation, and 25–28% import dependency.

About ISSDA: Established in 1980, ISSDA is headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi, and is headed by Rajamani Krishnamurti (President), working towards the growth and promotion of India's stainless steel industry.

IIPA and ICAI Sign MoU to Strengthen Municipal Financial Governance

In July 2026, the Centre for Urban Studies (**CUS**), Indian Institute of Public Administration (IIPA) and the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India **(ICAI)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) to strengthen **municipal accounting systems** and improve financial management through research, training, and institutional capacity building.

- The MoU was signed in the presence of Union Minister of State (MoS) **Dr. Jitendra Singh**, Ministry of Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances, Pensions (MoPP&P); Dr. Surendrakumar Bagde, Director General (DG), IIPA; and CA. Prasanna Kumar D., President of ICAI.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed
- ✓ **Who?** Centre for Urban Studies (CUS), IIPA and ICAI
- ✓ **Validity:** 3 years
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen municipal accounting, financial management, and capacity building
- ✓ **Key Areas:** Research, training, advisory services, and technical support
- ✓ Target Beneficiaries: Urban Local Bodies.

Key Details of MoU:

Framework: The MoU establishes a framework for collaboration in research, knowledge development, training, advisory services, and technical support to strengthen municipal accounting systems and financial management.

- The MoU will remain valid for an initial period of **three years**.

Activities: Both institutions will jointly undertake policy research, surveys, documentation, knowledge products, and organise training programmes, workshops, seminars, conferences, and webinars for municipal officials.

Capacity Building: The partnership will develop learning resources and facilitate the exchange of professional expertise and best practices to improve financial accountability and governance in Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).

APEDB and UAE Sign MoU to Establish Food Cluster for Horticulture Exports

On 21 July 2026, the Andhra Pradesh Economic Development Board **(APEDB)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with the United Arab Emirates **(UAE) Food Cluster** to establish a food processing

cluster in AP in the presence of AP's Chief Minister (CM) N. Chandrababu Naidu and Abdulla bin Touq Al Marri at Amaravati, AP.

- The MoU was signed in the presence of N. Chandrababu Naidu, CM of AP and Abdulla Bin Touq Al Marri, UAE Minister of Economy, at Amaravati, AP.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to establish UAE Food Processing Cluster in AP
- ✓ **Who?** APEDB and UAE
- ✓ **Objective:** Boost food processing, horticulture exports, and UAE investments in AP
- ✓ **Investment:** Rs. 100 crore processing unit at Gangadhara Nellore, Chittoor
- ✓ **Key Crops:** Mangoes, bananas, cocoa, and other horticultural produce

About Food Processing Cluster:

Objective: The agreement aims to boost large-scale exports of AP's horticultural produce to global markets while attracting UAE-based investments in food processing and allied industries in the state.

Scope: The collaboration will establish food processing units for horticultural crops such as mangoes, bananas, cocoa, and other produce, while promoting value-added products, exports, and international trade.

Investment: A **Rs. 100 crore** processing unit is proposed at **Gangadhara Nellore** in Chittoor district, AP, to strengthen cold chains and export linkages with the UAE and global markets, serving as an export base for nearly 25 countries.

Significance: The Initiative will boost AP's food processing sector, agri-exports, investment opportunities and India-UAE economic cooperation.

NABARD Signs MoU with MAHAPREIT to Promote Green Infrastructure in Rural India

In July 2026, the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (**NABARD**) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with Mahatma Phule Renewable Energy and Infrastructure Technology Limited (**MAHAPREIT**), a Government of Maharashtra enterprise, to jointly finance and promote green, climate-resilient and sustainable infrastructure projects across rural India, with an initial focus on **Maharashtra.**

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed
- ✓ **Entities:** NABARD and MAHAPREIT
- ✓ **Where?** Rural India (initial focus on Maharashtra)
- ✓ **Purpose:** Finance and promote green, climate-resilient, and sustainable rural infrastructure
- ✓ **Key Focus Areas:** Renewable energy, rural clean infrastructure, community assets, biogas & bioenergy, solar-powered micro cold storage.

Key Details of MoU:

Partnership Role: The partnership seeks to combine NABARD's expertise in rural development finance and climate financing with MAHAPREIT's experience in Renewable Energy (RE) and sustainable infrastructure projects

Priority Areas: In the initial phase, the partnership will focus on green energy, decarbonisation of government buildings, Gram Panchayat (GP) infrastructure, rural public institutions, and water pumping schemes.

Clean Energy Projects: The collaboration will deploy clean energy solutions across Directorate of Technical Education (DTE) institutions, government and district hospitals, and other rural public service institutions.

Sustainable Financing: The partnership will finance biogas and bioenergy projects using agricultural residues and biomass, creating additional income opportunities for farmers and promoting the circular economy.

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- It will also support solar-powered micro cold storage infrastructure for village-level bodies.

Microsoft India and IIT Delhi Unveil 'UNNATI AI 2.0' to Accelerate India's AI Innovation Ecosystem

In July 2026, **Microsoft India**, in collaboration with the Foundation for Innovation and Technology Transfer (**FITT**), Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi, launched **UNNATI AI 2.0** ('Unnati se Pragati' means progress through growth), second phase of its flagship Corporate Social Responsibility (**CSR**) initiative.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of UNNATI AI 2.0
- ✓ **Who?** Microsoft India and FITT (IIT Delhi)
- ✓ **Target Locations:** AI ecosystem development in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** AI skilling, startup enablement, mentorship, and innovation partnerships
- ✓ **Objective:** Democratise AI access, strengthen AI talent pipeline, and promote responsible AI solutions in healthcare, education, agriculture, and sustainability.

About UNNATI AI 2.0 Initiative:

UNNATI AI 2.0: Builds on the first edition, it aims to strengthen India's Artificial Intelligence (AI) talent pipeline by democratizing AI access, fostering startups, nurturing talent, and expanding innovation opportunities in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities.

Objective: UNNATI AI 2.0 will expands AI skills across developers, entrepreneurs, researchers, students, innovators and facilitates startup enablement, mentorship, and real-world pilot deployments.

Significance: It strengthens India's innovation ecosystem and supports the country's technology-led progress by responsible, and scalable AI solutions across healthcare, education, agriculture and sustainability.

First edition: Launched in April 2025, UNNATI AI accelerated AI startups in healthcare, education, agriculture, and sustainability while providing nationwide AI skilling for developers.

- Within a year, it supported 10 AI startups, trained over 1,000 developers, and created a Rs. 1,690 crore portfolio.

Paras Semiconductors, MPSeDC Sign MoU to Establish Greenfield OSAT Facility in MP

In July 2026, **Paras Semiconductors** Private Limited, a subsidiary of Paras Defence and Space Technologies Limited (PDST), signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** with the Madhya Pradesh State Electronics Development Corporation **(MPSeDC)** to establish a **greenfield** Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test **(OSAT) facility** in the **Indore–Ujjain** region of MP with a proposed investment of **Rs.6,200 crore**.

- The project aims to strengthen India's semiconductor packaging ecosystem, enhance indigenous semiconductor capabilities, generate employment, and support the India Semiconductor Mission.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed to Establish Greenfield OSAT Facility
- ✓ **Entities:** Paras Semiconductors & MPSeDC
- ✓ **Where?** Indore–Ujjain region of MP
- ✓ **Investment:** Rs.6200 crore
- ✓ **Focus:** Advanced semiconductor packaging and testing

About OSAT Facility in MP:

Technology: The facility will undertake advanced semiconductor packaging operations, including Three-Dimensional (**3D) heterogeneous integration**, **2.5D/3D packaging**, hybrid bonding, ultra-high-density

fan-out packaging, chiplet integration, wafer bumping, flip-chip assembly, testing, and reliability validation.

Applications: The plant will initially manufacture semiconductor devices for sensor technologies, optical and optronic systems, and other strategic applications, with future expansion into Artificial Intelligence (AI) chips and advanced semiconductor products.

Significance: The project will strengthen MP as a semiconductor hub, reduce import dependence, and support the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) and India's semiconductor value chain.

NRDC and NCISM Sign MoU to Commercialise Traditional Medicine Research

In July 2026, National Research Development Corporation (**NRDC**) and the National Commission for Indian System of Medicine (**NCISM**), a statutory body under the Ministry of AYUSH (Ayurveda, Yoga & Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, and Homeopathy), signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) for promoting innovation, Intellectual Property (IP) management, technology transfer and commercialization of research outcomes in the Indian System of Medicine.

- The MoU was exchanged between Commodor **(Cmde). Amit Rastogi** (Retd.), Chairman & Managing Director (CMD), NRDC, and **Dr. Maneesha Kothekar**, Chairperson, NCISM.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU Signed
- ✓ **Entities:** NRDC and NCISM
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote translation of traditional medicine research into marketable products
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Technology transfer, IP management, start-up support, industry linkages.

Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The partnership aims to bridge gaps between research and commercialization by fostering innovation-led growth in Ayurveda, Unani, Siddha, and Sowa-Rigpa medicine systems.

Focus Areas: The partnership will strengthen IP protection, foster innovation and entrepreneurship, building institutional IP frameworks and promoting technology showcases, ideathons, hackathons, and digital dissemination of success stories.

NRDC Support: It offers end-to-end support for innovation including IP protection, patent and trademark facilitation, technology transfer, commercialization mentoring, incubation support, and industry collaborations.

NCISM Role: It provides structured facilitation for collaboration with regulated institutions, Research, Innovation, and Entrepreneurship Development (**RIED**) Cells, and registered practitioners.

NIELIT and SCL Mohali Collaborate to Make Indigenous 1.2 µm Process Design Kit Available on eChipHub

In July 2026, the National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology (**NIELIT**) under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with Semi-Conductor Laboratory (**SCL**), Mohali, Punjab to integrate and make India's indigenous **1.2 micrometre**(µm) **Process Design Kit** (PDK) available on the **eChipHub** platform.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU Signed
- ✓ **Entities:** NIELIT and SCL, Mohali
- ✓ **Purpose:** To integrate indigenous 1.2 µm PDK with eChipHub
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote practical IC design education, innovation, and capacity building using indigenous technology.

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Key Details of MoU:

Access: The initiative will provide students, researchers, faculty, startups, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), and industry professionals with access to an indigenous semiconductor process technology for Integrated Circuit (IC) design and prototyping, promoting practical semiconductor design education and innovation.

Integration: The SCL 1.2 µm PDK has been integrated with eChipHub through a secure Aadhaar-authenticated download system, creating India's first indigenous design-to-fabrication learning pathway for IC design.

Significance: The initiative strengthens India's semiconductor ecosystem and supports the India Semiconductor Mission (**ISM**) by providing access to indigenous semiconductor process technology for integrated circuit (IC) design and prototyping.

About eChipHub Platform: It is implemented and managed by NIELIT under a MeitY-funded project and jointly developed with SoCTeamup Semiconductors Pvt. Ltd., serving as India's national platform for semiconductor design education and capacity building.

EIL and CSIR-IMMT Signs MoU for Critical Minerals R&D

In July 2026, Engineers India Limited (**EIL**), a public sector undertaking under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research – Institute of Minerals and Materials Technology (**CSIR-IMMT**), Bhubaneswar, Odisha to strengthen collaboration in mineral processing, extractive metallurgy, and the critical and strategic minerals value chain.

- The MoU was signed by **Rajiv Agarwal**, Director (technical), EIL and **Ramanuj Narayan**, Director, CSIR-IMMT.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed
- ✓ **Entities:** EIL and CSIR-IMMT
- ✓ **Signatories:** Rajiv Agarwal (EIL) & Ramanuj Narayan (CSIR-IMMT)
- ✓ **Focus:** Mineral processing, extractive metallurgy, and critical & strategic minerals value chain
- ✓ **Objectives:** Joint R&D, technology development, technical expertise exchange, capacity building, and pilot-to-commercial project execution.

Key Details of MoU:

Collaboration: Under the MoU, EIL and CSIR-IMMT will jointly identify, evaluate, and undertake Research and Development (R&D) initiatives in the field of critical and strategic minerals.

Focus: The partnership will focus on the exchange of technical expertise, capacity-building programmes, technology scale-up, and the execution of pilot-scale as well as commercial deployment projects.

Other MoU: EIL has also signed an MoU with the Directorate General of Maritime Administration (**DGMA**), formerly known as the Directorate General of Shipping to provide engineering, technical advisory and consultancy services for the planning, development and modernisation of projects in the maritime sector.

Odisha Signs MoUs with HCL, Sarvam AI for Rs 14,257 crore AI Data Centre

In July 2026, the Government of **Odisha** signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with HCL Technologies (**HCLTech**) and **Sarvam AI** to establish its first artificial intelligence (**AI**) **data centre** at the Odisha Sovereign AI Park, Bhubaneswar, Odisha, with an outlay of **Rs. 14,257 crore**.

- The MoU was signed in the presence of Mohan Charan Majhi, Chief Minister (CM) of Odisha; Roshni Nadar Malhotra, Chairperson, HCLTech; C Vijayakumar, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) and Managing Director (MD), HCLTech; and Pratyush Kumar, Co-Founder, Sarvam AI.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Establishment of HCLTech's first AI data centre
- ✓ **Entities?** With Sarvam AI and Government of Odisha
- ✓ **Where?** Odisha Sovereign AI Park, Bhubaneswar, Odisha
- ✓ **Investment Outlay:** Rs.14,257 crore
- ✓ **Focus:** Strengthen India's sovereign AI ecosystem, support full-stack AI capabilities, and drive sector-specific AI applications

About AI Data Centre:

Objective: HCLTech will invest around Rs. 730 crore to establish the AI Data Centre, leveraging its full-stack AI expertise and Sarvam AI's foundation models to develop AI solutions for enterprises, government departments, and public sector organisations.

- It will be HCLTech's first AI Data Centre in India.

Integration: The facility will be integrated into the Odisha Sovereign AI Park, a strategic initiative designed to establish an AI-centric ecosystem that merges high-performance computing with indigenous Indian language models and AI services to support real-world applications.

Other Initiatives: The state government also signed an MoU to establish a **Global Development Centre** (GDC) in Bhubaneswar to deliver AI-led digital solutions to global enterprises, which will employ about 5,000 people and become fully operational by 2028.

About HCLTech: Founded in **1976** by Shiv Nadar and headquartered in Noida, Uttar Pradesh (UP).

MoT Signs MoU with Air India to Promote India as Global Tourism Destination

In July 2026, the Ministry of Tourism **(MoT)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU**) with **Air India** Limited in New Delhi, Delhi to promote India as a preferred global tourism destination under the **Incredible India** brand.

- The MoU was signed in the presence of **Union Minister Gajendra Singh** Shekhawat, Ministry of Tourism and Ministry of Culture.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed
- ✓ **Between:** MoT & Air India Limited
- ✓ **Purpose:** Promote India as a global tourism destination
- ✓ **Brand:** Incredible India
- ✓ **MoU Validity:** 2 years
- ✓ **Key Activities:** Co-branded global marketing campaigns, tourism exhibitions, roadshows, and familiarisation trips.

MoU Highlights:

Objective: The partnership aims to boost inbound tourism and position India as a global travel and transit hub by leveraging Air India's network.

Key Provisions: The MoU, valid for **2 years,** provides for co-branded global marketing campaigns across digital, social media, inflight, and other customer-facing platforms, while expanding 'Incredible India' branding across Air India's customer touchpoints.

Joint Promotion: The partnership includes joint promotional campaigns with tour operators, travel trade partners, and industry stakeholders through tourism exhibitions, roadshows, familiarisation trips, and other initiatives to boost inbound tourism.

About Air India: Established as Tata Airlines in 1932, Air India is India's national airline, founded by J. R. D. Tata, headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana, and has been owned by the Tata Group since 2022.

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Tripura Signs 3 MoUs with NSE to Boost Financial Literacy, Skills and Investment

In July 2026, the Government of **Tripura** signed **three** Memoranda of Understanding (**MoUs**) with the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (**NSE**) to strengthen financial literacy, skill development, entrepreneurship, and investment awareness across the state.

- The agreements were signed between the NSE and the State Institute of Public Administration and Rural Development (**SIPARD**), Directorate of Industries and Commerce, and the Directorate of Skill Development in the presence of Prof. (Dr.) Manik Saha, Chief Minister (CM) of Tripura at Pragya Bhavan in Agartala, Tripura.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Signing of MoUs
- ✓ **Entities?** Tripura and NSE
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote financial literacy, skill development, entrepreneurship and investment awareness
- ✓ **State Department:** SIPARD, Directorate of Skill Development, Directorate of Industries & Commerce
- ✓ **Funding:** 100% programme cost borne by NSE
- ✓ **Implementation:** Training infrastructure and venues provided by the Government of Tripura.

Key Details of MoU:

Significance: The partnership makes SIPARD, Tripura one of the first government training institutions in India to establish a strategic collaboration with the NSE, promoting institutional capacity building and financial inclusion.

Key Areas of Collaboration: The MoUs focus on financial literacy, skill development, and investment promotion through investor awareness programmes, training and certification in banking and capital markets, and industry engagement to strengthen Tripura's investment ecosystem and improve employability.

Implementation Support: NSE will fund the programme, while the Government of Tripura will provide the necessary training infrastructure and venues for its implementation.

FSID and C-DOT Sign Agreement to Set Up Telecom CoE at IISc Bengaluru

In July 2026, the Foundation for Science Innovation and Development **(FSID)** and the Centre for Development of Telematics **(C-DOT),** under the Department of Telecommunications (DoT), Ministry of Communications, signed an agreement with the Indian Institute of Science **(IISc), Bengaluru (**Karnataka) to establish a Centre of Excellence **(CoE) for advanced telecom research** focused on 5G, 6G, Artificial Intelligence (AI), cybersecurity and quantum communication technologies.

- The agreement was signed in the presence of Omprakash Subbarao, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of FSID, and Dr Rajkumar Upadhyay, CEO of C-DOT, in IISc, Bengaluru.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Agreement signed to set up Telecom CoE
- ✓ **Entities:** FSID & C-DOT
- ✓ **Where?** IISc, Bengaluru
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** 5G, 6G, AI, Cybersecurity & Quantum Communication
- ✓ **Significance:** C-DOT's 5th CoE.

About CoE for Advanced Telecom Research:

Focus: The CoE will support wireless communication research, prototype development, intellectual property (IP) creation and industry-academia collaboration.

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C-DOT Network: The IISc Bengaluru centre becomes **C-DOT's 5th CoE,** following centres at Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kanpur (Uttar Pradesh, UP), IIT Gandhinagar (Gujarat), IIT Roorkee (Uttarakhand) and IIT Hyderabad (Telangana).
Significance: The initiative will strengthen secure communication systems, bridge **industry-academia collaboration**, and promote innovation among startups, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises **(MSMEs)**, and researchers.
About FSID: Established in 2020, FSID is based at the IISc, Bengaluru, and is headed by Prof. B. Gurumoorthy, Director of IISc Bengaluru.

DoT and MP Sign MoU To Establish India's First Telecom Manufacturing Zone at Gwalior

In July 2026, the Department of Telecommunications (**DoT**), Ministry of Communications and the Government of Madhya Pradesh (**MP**) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi, to establish **India's first Telecom Manufacturing Zone** (TMZ), Phase-I at Gwalior, MP.

- The MoU was signed in the presence of Union Minister Jyotiraditya M. Scindia, Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (MDoNER) and Ministry of Communications, Dr. Mohan Yadav, Chief Minister (CM) of MP and Union Minister of State (MoS) Dr. Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani, Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed
- ✓ **Entities:** DoT and Government of MP
- ✓ **Purpose:** To establish India's first Telecom Manufacturing Zone
- ✓ **Where?** Gwalior, MP
- ✓ **Significance:** India's first dedicated Telecom Manufacturing Zone, Phase-I.

About India's First Telecom Manufacturing Zone:

Aim: The TMZ aims to build a robust ecosystem for telecom, data centres, semiconductor manufacturing, and allied technologies by attracting investments, fostering innovation, and promoting indigenous design and manufacturing.
Scope: Spread across about 350 acres, the zone will manufacture mobile phones, telecom equipment, optical fibre, semiconductors, and 5G/6G technology products.
Implementation: Following the agreement, a Special Purpose Company **(SPC) w**ill be established to implement the project.
Model: Under the MoU, the project is designed on a **plug-and-play** system to provide ready-to-use infrastructure for manufacturing units and enable faster industrial development.

MoTA Signs MoU with CSIR-NBRI for Conservation of RET Medicinal Plant Species

In July 2026, the Ministry of Tribal Affairs (**MoTA**) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research–National Botanical Research Institute (**CSIR–NBRI**), Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh (UP), for **three years** to conserve Rare, Endangered, and Threatened (RET) medicinal plant species and promote sustainable utilization of tribal medicinal resources.

- The MoU was signed by **Manish Thakur**, Additional Secretary, MoTA, and **Ajit Kumar Shasany**, Director, CSIR-NBRI.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Signing of MoU
- ✓ **Entities** MoTA and CSIR-NBRI
- ✓ **Signed By:** Manish Thakur (MoTA) and Ajit Kumar Shasany (CSIR-NBRI)
- ✓ **Focus:** Conservation and sustainable utilization of RET medicinal plants
- ✓ **Legal Framework:** Biological Diversity Act, 2002

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- ✓ **Key Areas:** R&D, ethnobotanical assessment, tissue culture, seed banks, biodiversity conservation, and tribal capacity building.

Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The collaboration aims to promote Research and Development (R&D) focused on the conservation and ethnobotanical assessment of tribal bioresources across India.

Focus: The initiative focuses on the conservation of Rare, Endangered and Threatened (RET) medicinal plant species. All field assessments and research will require Prior Informed Consent (PIC) from Gram Sabhas and tribal communities, in compliance with the B**iological Diversity Act, 2002.**

- Joint projects will also include dedicated funding for community development and capacity building.

Benefit Sharing: Intellectual property (IP) and project benefits will be shared equitably with tribal communities. Financial gains will be channelled through National/State Biodiversity Funds and MoTA welfare schemes.

Integration: The partnership will integrate traditional tribal knowledge with modern botanical science through collaborative research, knowledge exchange, and capacity building to promote sustainable conservation and preserve tribal heritage.

MoRD and PCI India Sign Non-Financial MoU to Strengthen Women-Led Enterprises through Public Procurement

In July 2026, Ministry of Rural Development (**MoRD**), through the Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana–National Rural Livelihoods Mission (**DAY-NRLM**) signed a Non-Financial Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with Project Concern International (**PCI**) India for **three years** (2026-2029) to strengthen the participation of Women-Led Enterprises (**WLEs**) and Self-Help Group (**SHG**) enterprises in government and institutional procurement.

- The MoU was exchanged between **Swati Sharma**, Joint Secretary (Rural Livelihoods), MoRD, and **Indrajit Chaudhuri**, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) & Country Director, PCI India, under the chairpersonship of **Rohit Kansal**, Secretary, Department of Rural Development, MoRD.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Signing of a non-financial MoU
- ✓ **Signed Between:** MoRD and PCI India
- ✓ **Tenure:** Three years (2026-2029)
- ✓ **Implemented Through:** Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana–National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM)
- ✓ **Initiative Background:** "Leveraging Public Procurement for Women's Economic Empowerment" (2022)
- ✓ **Focus Area:** Public procurement access for women-led rural enterprises
- ✓ **Goal:** Supports the vision of creating 6 crore Lakhpati Didis

Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The partnership builds on the 2022 initiative "Leveraging Public Procurement for Women's Economic Empowerment" and aims to institutionalise market access for women-led enterprises while supporting the vision of creating 6 crore Lakhpati Didis

Support Mechanism: A National Resource Cell (**NRC**)/Public Procurement and Business Model Support Cell will be established under DAY-NRLM with technical support from PCI India to strengthen procurement-linked enterprise ecosystems across State Rural Livelihood Missions (**SRLMs**).

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Capacity Building: The partnership will develop enterprise incubation frameworks, Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs), operational toolkits, knowledge products and standardised capacity-building modules for SHG enterprises.

Procurement Support: It will provide training and handholding support to State Rural Livelihood Mission (SRLM) teams and SHG enterprises on Government e-Marketplace (GeM) onboarding, tender participation, quality standards, documentation, and procurement compliance.

Implementation: The Financial Year (FY 2026–27) technical assistance will initially be provided to Assam, Bihar, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh (UP).

About Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana–National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM): DAY-NRLM is launched in 2011 under the MoRD, aims to reduce rural poverty by promoting sustainable livelihoods through SHGs, financial inclusion and entrepreneurship.

COMMITTEES & MEETINGS

India hosted the 12th BRICS Labour and Employment Ministers' Meeting in Hyderabad, Telangana

In July 2026, **India** hosted the **12th** BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa) Labour and Employment Ministers' Meeting in Hyderabad, Telangana under its BRICS Chairship 2026, which is themed "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability."

- The meeting concluded successfully with the adoption of the **BRICS Labour and Employment Ministers' Declaration,** which outlines four priority areas, including social protection, labour market reforms, women's workforce participation, skills development and digital employment services, for future cooperation.
- In addition, **BRICS CONNECT,** an initiative proposed by India to strengthen technical cooperation, knowledge exchange, and capacity building among BRICS nations, was launched at the meeting. The newly launched platform is designed to facilitate the exchange of best practices on labour market intelligence, future skills, digital employment services, social security systems and labour market reforms.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** BRICS Labour and Employment Ministers' Meeting
- ✓ **Edition:** 12th
- ✓ **Held in:** Hyderabad, Telangana
- ✓ **Key Outcomes:** Adoption of the BRICS Labour and Employment Ministers' Declaration and launch of BHARAT CONNECT
- ✓ **Organised under:** India's BRICS Presidency 2026
- ✓ **India hosted Other Key engagements:** Related to women empowerment; transport; drugs trafficking; and trade
- ✓ **Women Empowerment:** BRICS WWG Meeting (from July 06 to July 07, 2026) and BRICS WMM (from July 08 to July 09, 2026)
- ✓ **Held in:** Kochi, Kerala,
- ✓ **Drugs Trafficking:** BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies Meeting
- ✓ **Held in:** Guwahati, Assam
- ✓ **Organiser:** NCB, MHA
- ✓ **Key Outcome:** Adoption of the Guwahati Declaration
- ✓ **Transport:** 3rd BRICS Transport Ministers' Meeting (TMM)
- ✓ **Held in:** Nagpur, Maharashtra,

- ✓ **Chaired by:** Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH)
- ✓ **Key Outcome:** Adoption of the Ministerial Declaration
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** infrastructure, SAF, transport decarbonisation, urban mobility hub, among others
- ✓ **World's 1st BRICS Nations Hackathon:** GO-BRICS India-Russia Energy-o-thon 2026
- ✓ **Held in:** Bengaluru, Karnataka
- ✓ **BRICS Academic Conference Held in:** Moscow, Russia
- ✓ **Organisers:** ORF and the BRICS Expert Council Russia

Key Engagements Under India's BRICS Presidency 2026:

BRICS CCI: Union Minister of State (Independent Charge, IC) D**r. Jitendra Singh,** Ministry of Science & Technology (MoST) met a delegation of the BRICS Chamber of Commerce & Industry (BRICS CCI) in New Delhi (Delhi) where, they discussed ways to bolster industry-led global engagement and collaboration across the BRICS and BRICS Plus ecosystem through innovation, StartUps, emerging technologies, research collaboration and entrepreneurship.

- **Indian Delegation:** Sameep Shastri, Chairman of BRICS CCI led the Indian delegation which included Mr. Atul Bansal, Vice Chairman; Shabana Nasim, Vice Chairperson; and other office-bearers of the Chamber.

BRICS Women Ministerial Meeting: The BRICS Women Ministerial Meeting **(WMM)** held from July 08 to July 09, 2026 in Kochi (Kerala) under India's BRICS Chairship 2026, which brought together ministers and heads of delegation from member countries to deliberate on key issues relating to women's empowerment and advance the agenda of women-led development.

- **Inaugural Session:** The Union Minister Annpurna Devi, Ministry of Women and Child Development (MoWCD) addressed the inaugural session and emphasized for deeper collaboration among BRICS member countries under India's Chairship theme.
- **Preceded by:** Earlier, a two-day BRICS Working Group Meeting (WGM) was organised in Kochi, Kerala.
- **Key Outcome:** The key highlight of the meeting was the adoption of the Joint Statement of the 4th BRICS WMM, aimed at strengthening long-term collaboration under the BRICS Women Track.
- **Key Initiatives:** During the meeting, BRICS member nations agreed on two initiatives proposed by India: The BRICS Digital Repository of Best Practices (to facilitate and document the exchange of successful policies and programmes on women's empowerment) and the BRICS Digital Capacity Building (to foster institutional collaboration and strengthen capacity building).

BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies Meeting: India hosted the BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies Meeting held from July 06, to July 07, 2026 in Guwahati, Assam.

- **Aim:** To strengthen institutional cooperation among BRICS countries and transform the grouping's engagement on narcotics control from dialogue-based discussions to structured, action-oriented collaboration.
- **Organiser:** The two-day long meeting was organised by the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) under the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).
- **Indian Delegation:** Anurag Garg, Director General (DG) of NCB, led the Indian delegation at the meeting, where he addressed the inaugural session and highlighted that modern drug trafficking networks function across borders through darknet platforms, synthetic drugs, and New Psychoactive Substances (NPS).
- **Vision Document (2026-29):** While addressing the inaugural session of the meeting, NCB's DG Anurag Garg highlighted about India's Vision Document on Narcotics Control (2026–2029), designed to further strengthen institutional capacity and promote a whole-of-government, network-centric approach to tackling drug-related challenges.

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- **Priority Areas:** The meeting was mainly focused on three key priority areas: curbing synthetic drugs and the diversion of precursor chemicals, bolstering intelligence sharing and operational coordination among member countries, and enhancing institutional cooperation and capacity building.
- **Key Outcome:** During the meeting, the BRICS member nations unanimously adopted the **Guwahati Declaration** which reaffirms their commitment to bolster cooperation to prevent and combat illicit drug trafficking and related organised transnational crimes. The declaration emphasised the need to enhance the timely exchange of information, intelligence and best practices, in compliance with national laws and international obligations.
- **Key Proposal:** During the meeting, India proposed the establishment of a dedicated BRICS Virtual Working Group (VWG) to systematically address the evolving trends in drug trafficking and enhanced cross-border training initiatives.

World's 1st BRICS Nations Hackathon: The **GO-BRICS India-Russia Energy-o-thon 2026,** considered as the world's 1st BRICS nations hackathon was virtually organised in Bengaluru, Karnataka.

- **Entities Involved:** The hackathon was initiated by the GO-BRICS Business Forum and coordinated in India by the Rajiv Gandhi Institute of Petroleum Technology (RGIPT), an institute of National Importance under an Act of Parliament.
- **Theme:** The hackathon was structured around the theme "Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Digital Technologies in Energy for Advancing the ESG Agenda".
- **Participation:** The qualifying round of hackathon witnessed over 17,000 registrations from across India, with participants from the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), National Institutes of Technology (NITs) and IIITs and other leading engineering institutions.

3rd BRICS Transport Ministers' Meeting: India hosted the 3rd BRICS Transport Ministers' Meeting (TMM) held from July 11 to July 12, 2026 in Nagpur, Maharashtra, under the chairmanship of Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH).

- **Aim:** The two-day long meeting brought together transport ministers and senior officials from BRICS member countries to discuss sustainable infrastructure, mobility and transport cooperation.
- **Preceded by:** The meeting was preceded by the 3rd BRICS Transport Working Group (TWG) senior officials' meeting, organised from July 09 to July 10, 2026, during which member nations finalized the agenda outcomes and the Ministerial declaration.
- **Key Outcome:** The meeting concluded successfully with the unanimous adoption of the Ministerial Declaration, providing a comprehensive framework for collaboration on circularity in infrastructure, Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF), transport decarbonisation, urban mobility hub, logistics supply chain cooperation and BRICS Railway Research Network.

BRICS Academic Conference: The Observer Research Foundation (ORF) and the BRICS Expert Council Russia, jointly organised the BRICS Academic Thematic Conference on "Strengthening BRICS Connectivity: Fostering Cooperation" in Moscow, Russia, under India's BRICS Presidency 2026.

- **Participants:** The conference brought together around 120 participants, including policy-makers, diplomats, scholars, and experts, from 10 BRICS member and partner countries, to share their perspectives on strengthening BRICS cooperation and connectivity.
- **Key Sessions:** The conference featured 3 key sessions: "Crossing Continents: Resilient Connectivity" (focused on enhanced connectivity across infrastructure, trade, finance, among others); "Corridors of Cooperation Securing Critical Supply Chains" (to build resilient supply chains for critical minerals and other strategic sectors); and "High Technologies and AI: Prospects for BRICS Cooperation" (foster collaboration in frontier technologies and AI).

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About BRICS:

Formation: BRICS, an intergovernmental organization of major emerging economies, was initially formed as BRIC with Brazil, Russia, India and China as its founding members in September 2006. In September 2010, South Africa joined the bloc and was renamed as BRICS.

Expansion of Bloc: Later, BRICS was expanded to include countries: Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) (in 2024) and Indonesia (in 2025).

Previous Edition: Brazil under the Presidency of Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, President of Brazil, hosted the 17th BRICS Summit in Rio de Janeiro.

Global Presence: BRICS bloc accounts for nearly 49.5% of the global population, about 40% of world's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) and around 26% of global trade.

India Hosts 16th BRICS Health Minister's Meeting in Chandigarh, Adopts Health Ministerial Declaration

In July 2026, the **16th BRICS** (Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa**): Health minister's meeting** concluded in **Chandigarh** under India's BRICS chairmanship 2026, providing a platform for member countries to deliberate on key health challenges and reaffirm their commitment to strengthening health systems, promoting innovation, enhancing pandemic preparedness, and advancing Universal Health Coverage (UHC) through sustained cooperation.

- The meeting concluded with the unanimous adoption of the **'Health Ministerial Declaration'** as its key outcome.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 16th BRICS Health minister's meeting held
- ✓ **Where?** Chandigarh
- ✓ **Theme:** "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability"
- ✓ **Key Outcome: Health Ministerial Declaration unanimously adopted**
- ✓ **Releases:** BRICS GxP White Paper and BRICS Compendium on Digital Health Architecture
- ✓ **Initiatives:** BRICS Mission for Healthy Lifestyle, Healthy Lifestyle Promotion Roadmap (2026–2029), and BRICS Network of CoE on Mental Wellness
- ✓ **Working Groups:** BRICS Expert Working Group on TCIM and Sub-Working Group on BRICS Integrated EWS.

About 16th BRICS Health Minister's Meeting:

Theme: The meeting was conducted under the theme, "**Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability**".

Virtual Address: Union Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoH&FW) virtually addressed the meeting and welcomed the Health Ministers, Heads of Delegation, and senior officials.

Key Discussions: The Ministers discussed regulatory cooperation and promoted Digital Health Architecture to strengthen disease surveillance and expand quality healthcare through interoperable digital systems.

TB Status: BRICS countries collectively account for nearly **half** of the global tuberculosis (**TB**) burden and emphasized the strengthening of the BRICS TB Research Network.

- The network is expected to accelerate collaborative research, innovation, operational research and equitable access to new diagnostics, therapeutics and vaccines.

Major Initiatives:

Releases: The meeting released the **'BRICS GxP White Paper'** to strengthen regulatory excellence, harmonisation, capacity building, and the quality, safety, and efficacy of medical products.

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- It also unveiled the **'BRICS Compendium on Digital Health Architecture for Continuum of Care'** to promote knowledge sharing, best practices, and cooperation in expanding healthcare access, particularly in remote areas.

Frameworks: BRICS adopted the Operational Framework to Fight Diseases Driven by Social Determinants of Health (**DD-SDH**) and the Operational Framework for the BRICS Network of National Public Health Institutes (**NPHI**) to enhance scientific collaboration.

BRICS Training Hub Network: Member countries endorsed the establishment of a BRICS Training Hub Network to strengthen the health workforce through training, knowledge exchange, best practices, collaborative research, policy dialogue, and evidence-based mental health promotion across BRICS countries.

Initiatives: Two new BRICS health initiatives launched during the meeting were:

- **BRICS Mission for Healthy Lifestyle:** This is a collaborative initiative aimed at promoting healthier lifestyles across BRICS countries to reduce the incidence of lifestyle-related and non-communicable diseases.
- **BRICS Roadmap:** This Healthy Lifestyle Promotion (**2026–2029**) is a four-year implementation roadmap that outlines how BRICS countries will work together under the Healthy Lifestyle Mission.
- **Mental Health Initiatives:** Establishment of the BRICS Network of Centres of Excellence (**CoE**) on Mental Wellness, which will be coordinated by **NIMHANS** (National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences).

Working Group:

- **TCIM:** A BRICS Expert Working Group on Traditional, Complementary and Integrative Medicine (TCIM) was proposed under the BRICS Health Track to strengthen cooperation and promote traditional medicine.
- **EWS:** A Sub-Working Group on the BRICS Integrated Early Warning System (EWS) was established to enhance the prevention and response to mass infectious diseases.

BRICS Health Ministers' Declaration: The Health Ministerial Declaration reaffirmed BRICS' commitment to UHC, pandemic preparedness, digital health, regulatory cooperation, collaborative research, disease control, mental health, traditional medicine, and equitable access to affordable medicines, vaccines, diagnostics, and medical technologies.

About BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa):

Formation: BRICS was established as BRIC(Brazil, Russia, India, China) in September 2006 following United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) discussions and was formally institutionalized as an intergovernmental organization in 2009.

Members: The 11 members of this organization are: Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates(UAE), and Indonesia.

Overview: BRICS member countries together account for 49.5% of the world's population, contribute around 40% of global Gross Domestic Product (GDP), and represent nearly 26% of global trade.

BRICS Science Academies Forum Meeting 2026 Held at IIT Hyderabad, Telangana

The **2nd** meeting of **BRICS** (Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa) **Science Academies Forum 2026** held from July 22 to 23 2026 at the Indian Institute of Technology Hyderabad **(IIT-H)** in Hyderabad, Telangana under the theme of "Harnessing Artificial Intelligence for Sustainable Development and Strengthening Global South Cooperation".

- The two-day long event brought together member and participating countries from BRICS to deliberate on the **3C's** i.e. Collective, Collaborative and Context sensitive approaches towards Artificial Intelligence (AI).

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** BRICS Science Academies Forum Meeting 2026 held
- ✓ **Edition:** 2nd
- ✓ **Venue:** IIT-H (Hyderabad, Telangana)
- ✓ **Theme:** "Harnessing Artificial Intelligence for Sustainable Development and Strengthening Global South Cooperation"
- ✓ **Organiser:** INSA
- ✓ **Other BRICS Meeting:**
  - **BRICS Ministerial Meeting on DRR:** New Delhi (Delhi)- Joint Statement on DRR adopted and launch of 6 knowledge products
  - **BRICS Heads of Prosecution Services Meeting:** virtual mode- Presided over by the Attorney General for India, R. Venkataramani
  - **BRICS CCI WE:** Unveiling of Whitepaper titled "Women in Innovation, Science & Entrepreneurship (WISE): Challenges and Opportunities"
  - **BRICS WG Meeting on Geospatial Technologies:** Hosted by IIT-Tirupati and (IITNiFi)- at its Yerpedu campus in AP
  - **BRICS Network University Meet:** organised by MoE-BRICS Network University (NU), IGB Declaration adopted.

About BRICS Science Academies Forum 2026:

Participants: The forum witnessed the participation of member countries of BRICS as well as BRICS partner countries.

Hosted by: The Indian National Science Academy **(INSA),** a premier Research and Development (R&D) organisation which works under the Department of Science and Technology (DST), Ministry of Science and Technology (MoS&T), is leading the scientific collaboration across BRICS nations and its partner countries as India holds the 2026 BRICS presidency under the theme "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability".

Key Focus Areas: The forum outlined 5 priority verticals for Artificial Intelligence (AI)-driven interventions: Advanced Materials and Manufacturing; Healthcare; Climate Change and Environmental Sustainability; Agriculture and Food Security; and Disaster Prediction and Management.

Other BRICS Key Engagements:

BRICS Ministerial Meeting on DRR: India, hosted the 3rd BRICS Ministerial Meeting on Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR) under the chairmanship of Union Minister of State (MoS) **Nityanand Rai,** Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) in New Delhi, Delhi.

- During the meeting, the Union MoS Nityanand Rai outlined India's five strategic priorities for strengthening collaboration in science and technology, Early Warning Systems (EWSs), resilient infrastructure, nature-based solutions, and community resilience.
- The meeting concluded with the unanimous adoption of the BRICS Joint Statement on DRR and the implementation of the BRICS DRR Work Plan (2025–2028)
- During the meeting, India launched **six flagship knowledge products** to support evidence-based policymaking, institutional strengthening and capacity building in disaster risk reduction across BRICS countries.

Heads of BRIS NSBs: India hosted the meeting of Heads of BRICS National Standards Bodies (NSBs)from July 16 to 17, 2026 in Bengaluru, Karnataka.

- During the meeting, BRICS countries agreed to sign a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** for cooperation in **standardisation,** aimed to promote information sharing, exchange of best practices, technical collaboration and capacity building among member countries.

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BRICS Heads of Prosecution Services Meeting: The Department of Legal Affairs (DoLA) under the Ministry of Law and Justice (MoL&J) hosted the 8th Meeting of BRICS Heads of Prosecution Services meeting virtually with the theme "Exchanging Experiences and Best Practices in Criminal Adjudication from the Prosecution's Perspective", from July 20 to 21, 2026.

- The meeting was chaired by Attorney General for India R. Venkataramani and brought together Heads of Prosecution Services, senior officials, delegates, and legal leaders from BRICS member countries.
- The delegates deliberated on key mechanisms such as: developing a BRICS Model Framework for Judicial Cooperation to reduce delay and improve evidence sharing, as well as using platforms like India's National Forensic Sciences University (NFSU) as collaborative global platforms for legal research, capacity building, and knowledge exchange among prosecution services.

BRICS WG Meeting on Geospatial Technologies: The Indian Institute of Technology-Tirupati **(IIT-Tirupati)**, Yerpedu, Andhra Pradesh (AP) in partnership with its Navavishkar I-Hub Foundation **(IITNiFi),** hosted the 5th BRICS Working Group (WG) meeting on "Geospatial Technology and its Applications" at its Yerpedu campus in AP.

- Organised by the DST from 20–22 July 2026 in hybrid mode, the meeting brought together policymakers, scientists, academicians, industry leaders, startups, and research organisations from BRICS countries and partner nations to discuss the use of geospatial technologies for governance, disaster management, agriculture, urban planning, environmental protection, and sustainable development.

BRICS CCI WE: The Women Empowerment segment of the BRICS Chamber of Commerce & Industry (BRICS CCI WE) released a Whitepaper titled "Women in Innovation, Science & Entrepreneurship (WISE): Challenges and Opportunities", presenting a strategic roadmap to strengthen female participation in science, technology, innovation, and business ecosystems across member countries. The whitepaper stemmed from the BRICS CCI WE Trailblazers Roundtable 2026.

- The whitepaper identified seven structural challenges facing women in emerging economies, including social biases, funding gaps, intellectual property (IP) protection issues, low Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) participation, mid-career retention, policy gaps, and unrecognised unpaid work
- It recommends measures such as a BRICS Women in Innovation, Science and Entrepreneurship (WISE) Fund, gender-responsive procurement, digital literacy, career re-entry programmes, and a Women Entrepreneurs Digital Registry.

BRICS Network University Meet: India hosted the International Governing Board (IGB) meeting of the BRICS Network University (BRICS NU) and the BRICS Network University Conference on Traditional and Indigenous Knowledge Systems.

- The two-day engagement, organised by the Ministry of Education (MoE), was inaugurated by Dr. K. M. Praphullachandra Sharma, Joint Secretary in the MoE.
- The conference was mainly focused on the documentation, preservation and responsible digital dissemination of traditional and indigenous knowledge.
- The meeting presented the outcomes of the first BRICS Network University (NU) Conference on Traditional and Indigenous Knowledge Systems, with India proposing its inclusion as a new International Thematic Group under BRICS NU. The Board also reviewed the BRICS Network University Action Plan (2025–2028).
- The key outcome of the engagement was the adoption of the BRICS Network University (NU) IGB Declaration.

BRICS Internal Affairs Meeting: India also hosted the BRICS Ministers of Interior Meeting in New Delhi.

About Indian National Science Academy (INSA):
President- Shekhar C. Mande
Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi
Established- 1935

SUMMITS, EVENTS & CONFERENCE

Union Health Minister JP Nadda Chairs 16th CCHFW, Launched Several Healthcare Initiatives

In June 2026, **Union Minister Jagat Prakash (JP) Nadda**, Minister of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW) chaired the **16th** Conference of the Central Council of Health and Family Welfare (**CCHFW**) held at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi, Delhi.

- The conference witnessed the launch of a series of flagship healthcare initiatives, including Samagra Shishu Bal Swasthya Karyakram **(SSBSK),** revamped Anaemia Mukht Bharat (AMB) operational guidelines; Surakshit Matritva Aashwasan **(SUMAN) Roadmap 2030,** among others.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 16th CCHFW
- ✓ **Chaired by:** Union Minister JP Nadda, MoHFW
- ✓ **Where?** Vigyan Bhawan (New Delhi, Delhi)
- ✓ **Key Programmes Launched:** SSBSK, revamped AMB operational guidelines; SUMAN Roadmap 2030, among others.
- ✓ **Key Changes in AMB:** Transition to Anaemia Mukht Bharat Abhiyan (AMBA); Expansion to 7×7×7 strategy (introducing Low Birth Weight (LBW) babies (0-6 months); Eating Right Programme and digital tracking); and Transition to T4 Approach
- ✓ **Digital Initiatives:** National Drug registry; UHI; Ayushman Sarathi, WhatsApp Chatbot, and others

About 16th CCHFW:

Aim: To strengthen Centre-State cooperation in the health sector and deliberate on key policy priorities.
Thematic Sessions: were mainly centred on "National Health Mission (NHM) – Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) & Priorities", "Food & Drug Reforms" and "Allied Health Services", with discussions focused on reviewing ongoing initiatives, sharing best practices, addressing emerging challenges and formulating a coordinated roadmap to improve health outcomes across the country.
CCHFW: It is the apex advisory body of MoHFW, constituted under **Article 263** of the Constitution. It serves as a key institutional platform for promoting cooperative federalism through policy consultations and coordination between the Centre and States.

Key Initiatives Launched:

National Ambulance Services (NAS), 2026: Operational Guidelines for NAS 2026 were launched to establish uniform national standards for emergency medical transport services across all States and Union Territories (UTs).

- **Norms**: Prescribes standards for ambulance categorisation, population-based deployment, equipment, Emergency Medical Technician (EMT) training, and mandates compliance with AIS-125 standards.
- **Key Proposals:** Includes Global Positioning System (GPS)-based integrated command and dispatch centres, GIS-based mapping of hospitals and accident-prone areas, and phased integration with the national emergency response number 112.

SUMAN Roadmap 2030: A strategic framework to reduce the Maternal Mortality Ratio (MMR) to below 70 per one lakh live births by 2030, while lowering neonatal and infant mortality rates.

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- **Focus Areas:** Improves service quality, promotes respectful maternity care, and reduces preventable maternal and neonatal deaths.
- **Target Districts and States:** The roadmap proposed specific interventions for 130 districts across 13-high focus states such as: Assam, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh (MP), Odisha, Punjab, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh (UP), Uttarakhand and West Bengal (WB).

SSBSK: A unified programme integrating Home-Based Newborn Care (HBNC) and Home-Based Care for Young Child (HBYC) to provide home-based care for children from birth to 3 years.

- **Coverage**: Includes regular home visits, early illness detection, nutrition and child development counselling, and timely referrals.
- **Key Feature:** Adopts a risk-stratified approach with up to 9 home visits for at-risk newborns during the first 42 days and up to 8 visits for vulnerable children until 3 years of age.

Anaemia Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan (AMBA)Guidelines: The revised guidelines transition the programme from Anaemia Mukt Bharat to Anaemia Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan (AMBA).

- **Expansion to 7×7×7 strategy:** Expands the earlier 6×6×6 framework by adding Low Birth Weight (LBW) babies (0–6 months), the Eating Right Programme, and digital tracking.
- **Transition to T4 Approach:** The programme Upgrades from Test, Treat, Talk (T3) to Test, Treat, Talk & Track (T4) with beneficiary tracking for follow-up.
- **IV Therapy:** The programme will now include the introduction of Intravenous (IV) iron therapy using Ferric Carboxymaltose and iron sucrose for severe anaemia and non-responders among pregnant and lactating women.
- **Digital Tracking Mechanism:** The guidelines has proposed to establish a common digital platform for anaemia management, by integrating monitoring through the JANANI, Universal Immunisation WIN (U-WIN) and Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram (RBSK) platforms under a unified AMB portal.

About Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW):

Union Minister- Jagat Prakash (J.P.) Nadda (Rajya Sabha – Gujarat)

Union Minister of State (MoS)- Anupriya Patel (Constituency- Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh, UP); Jadhav Prataprao Ganpatrao (Constituency- Buldhana, Maharashtra)

29th National Conference on e-Governance Held in Jaipur, Rajasthan

In July 2026, the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances **(DARPG)**, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), and Government of **Rajasthan** organised the **29th** National Conference on e-Governance **(NCeG)** at Rajasthan International Centre, Jaipur, Rajastha.

- The conference, held from July 1-2, 2026, was inaugurated by Rajasthan Chief Minister (CM) Bhajan Lal Sharma and held under the theme, **"Viksit Bharat 2047: AI-enabled, Data-driven & Secure Digital Governance."**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 29th NCeG held
- ✓ **Where?** Jaipur, Rajasthan
- ✓ **Organisers:** DARPG, MeitY, Government of Rajasthan
- ✓ **Inaugurated by**: Bhajan Lal Sharma, CM of Rajasthan
- ✓ **Theme:** "Viksit Bharat 2047: AI-enabled, Data-driven & Secure Digital Governance "
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** AI, Deep Tech, Quantum Computing, Voice-First Solutions, Secure Digital Infrastructure

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- ✓ **National Awards for e-Governance 2026:** 17 awards, comprising 10 Gold Awards, 6 Silver Awards, and 1 Jury Award
- ✓ **Key Outcome:** Jaipur Declaration on e-Governance 2026.

About NCeG 2026:

Overview: The conference focused on promoting inclusive, transparent, and citizen-centric digital governance through artificial intelligence (AI), data analytics, cybersecurity, and emerging technologies, bringing together representatives from government, industry, and academia to discuss innovative e-governance initiatives.

Sessions: The event featured six plenary sessions and six breakout sessions covering Artificial Intelligence (AI), Deep Tech, Quantum Computing, Voice-First Solutions, and Secure Digital Infrastructure.

Awards: The National Awards for e-Governance 2026 presented 17 awards across **seven categories**, comprising 10 Gold awards (Rs.10 lakh each), 6 Silver awards (Rs.5 lakh each), and one Jury Award.

Exhibition: 42 exhibition stalls showcasing digital governance innovations, AI solutions, and award-winning projects by the Rajasthan government and other stakeholders.

Outcome: The conference concluded with the adoption of the **Jaipur Declaration on e-Governance 2026**, which outlines a roadmap for strengthening AI-enabled, data-driven, and secure digital governance across India.

Significance: Platform for knowledge-sharing, policy formulation, public-private partnerships, and scaling citizen-centric digital solutions, supporting Viksit Bharat 2047 vision.

About Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions (MoPP&P):

Union Minister – Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi (Constituency- Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh, UP)
Minister of State **(MoS)** (Independent Charge (IC)) – Dr. Jitendra Singh (Constituency- Udhampur, Jammu & Kashmir, J&K)

India, Mali launch inaugural export forum to Boost Bilateral Trade & Investment

In July 2026, India and Mali launched the inaugural India–Mali Forum for the Promotion of Exports in Bamako, Mali, under the theme **"Reinforcing Trade and Strategic Partnerships".** The forum, jointly organised by the Ministry of Industry and Trade of Mali, the Embassy of India in Bamako and the Malian Agency for the Promotion of Exports **(APEX-Mali)**, aims to enhance bilateral trade and investment.

- The Forum was presided over by the Prime Minister (PM) of Mali's Transition Government, Major General Abdoulaye Maïga. The Indian delegation was led by Amit Kumar, Joint Secretary (Foreign Trade–Africa), Department of Commerce, Government of India (GoI).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **Event:** Inaugural India–Mali Forum for the Promotion of Exports
- ✓ **When:** July 2026
- ✓ **Where:** Bamako, Mali
- ✓ **Theme:** "Reinforcing Trade and Strategic Partnerships"
- ✓ **Bilateral Trade (FY 2025–26):** USD 326.61 million (55% growth)
- ✓ **Key Trade Scheme:** Duty-Free Tariff Preference (DFTP) Scheme
- ✓ **Priority Sectors:** Cotton & textiles, mining & energy, agro-industry, pharmaceuticals and social infrastructure
- ✓ **Next Event:** Mali Investment Forum – 3–4 December 2026

Highlights of Export forum:

Trade performance: India–Mali bilateral trade reached USD 326.61 million in Financial Year 2025 - 2026(FY-26) registering 55% growth over FY 25. Supported by India's Duty-Free Tariff Preference (DFTP) Scheme, Mali has an estimated USD 3.96 billion untapped export potential in the Indian market.

Trade & Business: Mali exports raw cotton, leather, cashew, gum arabic, sesame and lead to India, while India exports pharmaceuticals, cotton fabrics, bicycles, and two- and three-wheelers. The forum also hosted Business-to-Business **(B2B)**, Business-to-Government **(B2G)** and Government-to-Government **(G2G)** meetings.
Outcomes: Both countries prioritised cooperation in textiles, mining, energy, agro-industry, pharmaceuticals, healthcare and education, besides discussing trade facilitation measures.
Future Roadmap: Under Vision Mali 2063, Mali announced an Investment Forum on 3–4 December 2026 to showcase bankable projects and attract global investors.
About DFTP Scheme: Launched by the GoI in 2008, the DFTP Scheme provides duty-free market access to **Least Developed Countries (LDCs)** to promote trade and economic cooperation.

Bharat Tex 2026 Held at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi from July 14 -17, 2026

In July 2026**, Union Minister Giriraj Singh,** Ministry of Textiles (MoT), inaugurated the **3rd edition of Bharat Tex,** India's flagship global textile event, held from 14 to 17 July 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, Delhi.

- Union Minister of State (MoS) Pabitra Margherita, MoT; Neelam Shami Rao, Secretary of MoT; among others, were present at the event.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **Event:** Bharat Tex 2026
- ✓ **Edition:** 3rd
- ✓ **Where?** Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi
- ✓ **Inaugurated by:** Union Minister Giriraj Singh, MoT
- ✓ **Organised by:** BTTF with MoT
- ✓ **State Partners:** Bihar, MP, Gujarat, UP, Punjab, Maharashtra, Karnataka and TN
- ✓ **Key Outcomes:**
- ✓ CITI–EURATEX launched EU–India Textile and Apparel Dialogue
- ✓ CITI Textile Sustainability Awards 2026
- ✓ **Total MoUs:** More than 30
- ✓ **Investment Commitments:** Rs 14,300 crore
- ✓ AP (worth Rs 4,100 crore); Karnataka (Rs 2,821 crore); Bihar (Rs 1,476 crore) and Maharashtra (Rs 1,095 crore).

About Bharat Tex 2026:

Organised: The 4-day long event was organised by the Bharat Tex Trade Federation **(BTTF),** an umbrella body of Textiles Export Promotion Councils (TEPCs) and trade associations, with the support of MoT.
Inspired by: The Bharat Tex 2026 was inspired by the Government of India (GoI)'s **5F vision** from Farm to Fibre to Factory to Fashion to Foreign, spanning the entire textile value chain, including fibre, yarn, fabric, apparel, home textiles, technical textiles, handlooms and handicrafts.
State Partners: States like: Bihar, Madhya Pradesh (MP), Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh (UP), Punjab, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu (TN) participated at the event as State Partners.
Participants: The event has attracted more than 6,000 buyers from over 130 countries and more than 1.3 lakh trade visitors, showcasing over 20,000 textile products.
Global Participation: The event also witnessed the participation of the ministerial delegations from New Zealand, Sri Lanka, Russia, Cambodia and Portugal, alongside representatives from the European Union (EU), and over 30 industry and international business delegations from countries including the United States of America (USA), Japan, the United Kingdom (UK), Spain, Italy, South Korea, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Australia, France and Germany, among others.

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Major Events:

Jharkhand Showcased 6-GI Tagged Products: During the event, Jharkhand showcased its six Geographical Indication (GI)-tagged handloom products at state's pavilion, which was inaugurated by Jharkhand's Industries Minister Sanjay Prasad Yadav promote its textile heritage and traditional craftsmanship among domestic and international buyers.

- Jharkhand pavilion, organised to promote its textile heritage and traditional craftsmanship among domestic and global buyers, featured Tassar Silk, Kuchai Silk, Bhagaiya Saree and Fabric, Tumka Chadar, Bhoya Saree and Fabric, and Pancho Saree and Fabric.

CITI Textile Sustainability Awards 2026: On the sidelines of Bharat Tex 2026, the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) hosted the CITI Textile Sustainability Awards 2026, recognising the organisations, institutions and individuals for their exceptional contributions across seven focus areas: resource efficiency, energy & emissions, circular economy, sustainable materials, social Responsibility, responsible business, and industry collaboration.

- **Segments:** The awards were bestowed across two main segments: **CITI Textile Sustainability Awards** (honors achievements in climate-resilient cotton production, circular economy, energy efficiency, among others) and **CITI Birla Economic & Textile Research Foundation Awards** (honours excellence in chemical management and compliance in wet processing).
- **Key Winners:** Tiruppur Exporters Association (TEA) won CITI-United Nations Industrial Development Organisation (UNIDO) Best Cluster Initiative Towards Sustainable Textile Production Award; Indo Count Industries Limited won the CITI-Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) Energy Efficiency in Textile Sector Award.
- **Key Announcement:** During the event, CITI announced collaboration with the Social & Labour Convergence Programme **(SLCP)** to support Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) in addressing the evolving sustainability trends, and responsible business practices.

Key Outcomes:

India-EU Bilateral Platform: On the sidelines of Bharat Tex 2026, the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry **(CITI)** forged a collaboration with the European Apparel and Textile Confederation **(EURATEX)** to establish a bilateral industry platform i.e. the European Union **(EU)-India Textile and Apparel Dialogue (TAD),** to support the effective implementation of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA) for the textile and apparel sector.

- In addition, the 1st meeting of the joint CITI-EURATEX monitoring committee, established under the TAD framework, was organised at the event.
- The EU emerged as the 2nd-largest market for India's textile and apparel exports, with total textile and apparel exports reaching USD 7.6 billion in 2025.

Secured Investments Worth Rs 14,300 Crore: The Bharat Tex 2026 concluded successfully with the generation of business enquiries worth about USD 2.8 billion and the textile investment commitments worth Rs 14,300 crore across various states.

- During the event, **over 30 MoUs** were signed by the participating states, including Andhra Pradesh (AP) which lead in terms of investment commitments (worth Rs 4,100 crore); followed by Karnataka (Rs 2,821 crore); Bihar (Rs 1,476 crore) and Maharashtra (Rs 1,095 crore). These investments are further projected to generate over 11,000 jobs in Karnataka and more than 40,500 in Bihar.

Signing of MoU: The inaugural ceremony witnessed the signing of a Letter of Intent (LoI) between the BTTF and Premiere Vision Paris, one of the world's leading textile and fashion sourcing platforms.

- The agreement was signed by Florence Rousson, Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Fashion Division, Premiere Vision SA; and Naren Goenka, Chairman of BTTF.

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- The partnership provides a comprehensive framework across 3 main areas, including an exhibition partnership between Bharat Tex and Premiere Vision Paris; Joint export promotion to improve the visibility of Indian and French manufacturers in Europe and a Joint Steering Committee to oversee the implementation.

About Bharat Tex Trade Federation (BTTF):

Chairman- Naren Kumar Goenka
Headquarters– New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 2024

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RANKING

Sustainable Development Report 2026: Topped by Finland and India Ranks 94th

In July 2026, The United Nations Sustainable Development Solutions Network (**UNSDSN**) released the 11th Edition of the Sustainable Development Report (**SDR**) 2026, **India** secured its highest-ever rank of 94th among 169 countries with a score of 68.3 out of 100, improving from 99th position in 2025.

- **Finland** has secured the first place with a score of 87.4, followed by Sweden with 86.3 and Denmark with 85.7.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of SDR 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** UNSDSN
- ✓ **Top 5 Countries:** Finland, Sweden, Denmark, Norway, Germany
- ✓ **India Rank:** 94 (From 112th in 2015)
- ✓ **Least 5 Countries:** Sudan, Somalia, chad, central African Republic and South Sudan
  - **Key Concern SDG for India:** SDG 2 (Zero Hunger)
- ✓ **Strong Progress Areas:** SDG 7 (Energy), SDG 9 (Infrastructure & Digitalisation)
- ✓ **India's Likely Achievement:** Only 33.3% SDG targets by 2030

About SDG and its Index 2026:

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are a set of **17 global** goals adopted in 2015 under the 2030 Agenda, aimed at ending poverty, reducing inequality, promoting sustainable development, and protecting the environment.

About 2026 Index:

The SDG Index 2026, published by the **UNSDSN**, ranks countries on a **0–100 scale** based on their SDG performance.

- It incorporates improved indicators, retroactive ranking updates, and expanded global assessments to enhance the measurement and tracking of sustainable development progress.

Top 5 Performing Countries:

These top 5 countries continue to lead the SDG Index, reflecting strong performance in sustainability, governance and social indicators.

Top 5 Rank	Countries	Score
1.	Finland	87.40
2.	Sweden	86.26

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3.	Denmark	85.68
4.	Norway	84.08
5.	Germany	84.02

Lowest performing Countries:

The 5 countries remain heavily affected by severe resource limitations, structural vulnerability and localized conflict, placing them at the bottom of the Index.

Rank	Countries	Score
165	Sudan	47.7
166	Somalia	46.2
167	Chad	43.9
168	Central African Republic	43.3
169	South Sudan	39.9

India's SDG Performance:

Performance: India improved by **18 ranks** since 2015, moving from 112th to 94th position, making it one of the fastest-improving economies. However, it still lags behind Bhutan, Maldives, Nepal, and Sri Lanka. Only **33.3%** of SDG targets are expected to be achieved by **2030**, showing uneven progress.

Challenges: India faces challenges in 13 of 17 SDGs, especially Zero Hunger, Health, Gender Equality, Sustainable Cities, Climate Action, and Governance. These issues reflect persistent gaps in nutrition, environment, urban growth, and institutional quality.

- **Zero Hunger** remains the biggest concern, with issues like child stunting, wasting, undernourishment, and rising obesity, despite improvement in cereal yield.

Positive Developments: India has shown progress in SDG 7 (electricity access) and SDG 9 (digital connectivity). Expansion in internet use and broadband access reflects improved infrastructure and digital inclusion.

Significance: As the world's most populous country, India's SDG progress significantly influences global achievement of the **2030 Agenda**, especially in poverty reduction, nutrition, climate action, and governance reforms.

Global SDG Performance:

Globally, no SDG is currently on track to be achieved by 2030, indicating substantial implementation gaps across countries.

Limited Target: Only around **16% of global SDG targets** are progressing at the required pace, showing that most development goals are falling behind schedule.

Global Gaps:

Major gaps persist in SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities), SDG 14 (Life Below Water), SDG 15 (Life on Land), and SDG 16 (Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions), highlighting weak progress in environmental protection and governance systems.

About United Nations Sustainable Development Solutions Network (UNSDSN):

President – Jeffrey Sachs

Headquarters – New York, United States of America (USA)
Established – 2012

GCS's Global Passport Index 2026: Sweden Tops the Rankings; India Ranked 125th

In July 2026, the residency and citizenship advisory firm Global Citizen Solutions **(GCS)** released the **5th** annual edition of the Global Passport Index **(GPI).** As per the index, India has been ranked at **125th** spot among 197 countries, with a composite score of **45.1** (highest in 5 years), dropping one place (124th) from its overall ranking compared to 2025 and jumping by just two places (127th) over the last 5 years.

- **Sweden** topped the rankings as the world's strongest passport with an overall score of **96.05** out of 100, as it performs consistently across all three categories: enhanced mobility (11th), investment (9th) and quality of life (2nd).
- It is followed by Switzerland, Finland, Germany and the Netherlands, securing 2nd, 3rd, 4th and 5th positions, respectively.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Global Passport Index 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** Global Citizen Solutions
- ✓ **Edition:** 5th
- ✓ **Countries Covered:** 197
- ✓ **Top 5 Countries:** Sweden, Switzerland, Finland, Germany, Netherlands
- ✓ **Overall India's Rank:** 125th (45.1)
  - Enhanced mobility index (136th rank); Quality of Live index (118th rank); investment index (94th rank)
  - Visa-free/visa-on-arrival access to 26 destinations.
- ✓ **Lowest Ranked Country:** Afghanistan secured the 197th (last) position.

About Global Passport Index (GPI):

Categories: GPI ranks the passports across three main categories, including

- Enhanced Mobility (50%) which measure the travel advantages offered by a passport;
- Investment (25%) assesses a country's economy as a destination for investment and business purposes;
- Quality of Live (25%) is used to determine a country's quality life, considering factors like: healthcare, education and personal safety.

Evaluation Process: The rankings are evaluated based on **14** different indicators using data from international organisations such as: the World Bank (WB), the World Economic Forum (WEF), and the Sustainable Development Report.

Key Findings:

Other Top 10 countries: Other top 10 countries featured on the index are: Denmark (6th), Ireland (7th), United Kingdom (8th), Norway (9th) and Singapore (10th).

- Among these countries, Singapore with a score of 92.75 is the only Asian country to be featured among the top 10.

European Countries Dominance: Nine of the world's 10 strongest passports belong to European countries (Sweden, Denmark, the Netherlands, Norway, among others).

Bottom 5 Countries: Afghanistan(197th) ranked lowest on the index, with an overall score of 23.10. It is followed by Somalia (196th), South Sudan (195th), Yemen(194th) and Syria (193rd).

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Top 5 Countries in GPI 2026:

Rank	Name of Country
1	Sweden
2	Switzerland
3	Finland
4	Germany
5	The Netherlands
125	India

India-Specific:

Category-wise Performance: The GPI 2026 showed category-wise India's performance: ranked at **136th** spot in enhanced mobility index (down from one place over 2025); 118th spot in the Quality of Live index (jumping by 11 places); 94th in the investment index (moving up by 3 places compared to 2025).

Visa-free access: As per the index, Indian passport provides visa-free access to **26 countries** including Bhutan, Jamaica, Macau, Nepal, Tunisia, Angola, among others.

- However, Indian citizens still require a visa for around 88 destinations, including the United States of America (USA), the UK, Germany, France, China, among others.

About Global Citizen Solutions (GCS):

Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)-** Patricia Casaburi
Headquarters- London, the United Kingdom (UK)
Established- 2016

UNCTAD's World Investment Report 2026: India Ranks 11th in Global FDI Inflows with USD 38.89 Billion in 2025

In July 2026, the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development **(UNCTAD)** released its latest report titled "2026 World Investment Report: International Investment in a Turbulent Era". As per the report, India emerged as the world's **11th** largest recipient of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI), moving up two places compared to 2024, with total inflows surging by approximately 44% to **USD 38.89 billion** in 2025.

- The United States of America **(USA)** continued to be the world's largest FDI destination with inflows of **USD 277 billion,** followed by **Singapore** (USD 151 billion), **Hong Kong,** Special Administrative Region (SAR) of China (USD 116 billion) ranked at 2nd and 3rd positions, respectively.
- As per UNCTAD's report, India moved up 2 places to **18th** among the world's top home economies for FDI as its overall FDI outflow increased 47% i.e. from USD 24.26 billion (in 2024) to **USD 35.66 billion** (in 2025).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of World Investment Report 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** UNCTAD
- ✓ **Report title:** 'International Investment in a Turbulent Era'
- ✓ **Global FDI Inflow:** USD 1.6 trillion

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- ✓ **Top 3 FDI destination:** USA (USD 277 billion), Singapore, Hong Kong SAR
- ✓ **Top 3 FDI source economies:** USA (USD 263 billion), Japan (2nd), China (3rd)
- ✓ **India's Rank:**
- ✓ FDI Inflow: 11th with USD 38.89 billion
- ✓ FDI-outflow: 18th with USD 35.66 billion
- ✓ **Developing Asia FDI inflows:** USD 644 billion in 2025.

About World Investment Report (WIR):

Overview: The WIR is an annual flagship publication of the UNCTAD. First published in 1991, it provides an overview of global FDI trends, international production and investment policies.

Coverage: The report analyses FDI inflows and outflows, cross-border mergers and acquisitions, greenfield projects, multinational enterprises, global value chains and sustainable-development finance.

Key Findings:

Global FDI Inflow: The report revealed that global FDI increased **6%** to **USD 1.6 trillion** in 2025, after witnessing two consecutive years of decline.

- Also, together, the world's top 20 FDI recipient economies accounted for over 80% of global FDI inflows.

Uneven Increase in Inflows: It further showed that developed economies registered an 11% growth in inflows, while developing economies recorded a modest growth of 2% in 2025.

World's Top 5 Source Economies: The USA also emerged as the world's largest source of FDI with its total outflow of **USD 263 billion** in 2025.

- It is followed by Japan (2nd), China (3rd), Luxembourg (4th) and Hong Kong, SAR of China (5th).
- Together, these top 5 source economies accounted for nearly 50% of global outflows.

Developing Asia: As per the report, developing Asia received USD 644 billion in FDI in 2025, representing nearly 40% of global investment and over 70% of flows to developing economies.

- Further, **South Asia region** witnessed sharp increase in its FDI inflows i.e. USD 34 billion (in 2024) to USD 46 billion (in 2025), driven by increase in investment in India.

Sectors: The report noted that worldwide investment is becoming more concentrated in strategic sectors such as: semiconductors, digital infrastructure, Artificial Intelligence (AI), advanced manufacturing and energy transition technologies, accounting for 44% of global greenfield investment project value in 2025 (over 16% registered in 2024).

Top 5 Host Economies: World Investment 2026

Global Rank	Country Name	FDI Inflows (Approximately in USD Billion)
1	The United States of America (USA)	277
2	Singapore	151
3	Hong Kong, Special Administrative Region (SAR) of China	116
4	China	105
5	Brazil	77
11	**India**	**39**

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Top 5 Home Economies: World Investment 2026

Global Rank	Country Name	FDI Outflows (Approximately in USD Billion)
1	The United States of America (USA)	263
2	Japan	186
3	China	174
4	Luxembourg	101
5	Hong Kong, SAR of China	95
18	**India**	**36**

India-Specific:

Key Drivers: The report highlighted certain policy measures undertaken by the Government of India (GoI) to attract investment into priority sectors (semiconductors, electronics, and allied manufacturing) and these include: Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes, Make in India, Startup India and the National Industrial Corridor Development Programme (NICDP).

Greenfield Investment Projects: The value of announced greenfield investment projects in India declined from USD 111.14 billion in 2024 to **USD 74.12 billion in 2025.** However, India attracted the world's largest announced greenfield investment project during 2025.

- The slowdown was mainly witnessed in manufacturing sector, where the value of announced investments declined from around USD 65 billion (in 2024) to USD 27 billion (in 2025).

Major Investments: USA's Alphabet Inc. announced a USD 14.5 billion investment in a data-centre project in India. In addition, Poland-based Hynfra announced a USD 4 billion investment in Andhra Pradesh(AP).

About United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD):

Secretary-General- Rebeca Grynspan
Headquarters- Geneva, Switzerland
Established- 1964

EIU's Global Liveability Index 2026: Delhi Ranked at 120th Among 173 Cities; Copenhagen Tops

In July 2026, the Economist Intelligent United **(EIU)** released the latest edition of Global Liveability Index 2026. As per the index, **New Delhi (Delhi)** topped among all the Indian cities featured in the index, securing **120th** spot globally with an overall score of **48.1.**

- **Copenhagen (Denmark)** retained the top position for the 2nd consecutive year, leading across all the categories which include perfect scores (100 out of 100) in stability, education and infrastructure, followed by Vienna (Austria), Melbourne (Australia), secured 2nd and 3rd spots respectively.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Global Liveability Index 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** EIU
- ✓ **World's Most Liveable City:** Copenhagen (Denmark)

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- ✓ **World's Least Liveable City:** Damascus (Syria)
- ✓ **Top 3 Indian Cities:** Delhi (120th); Mumbai, Maharashtra (121th) and Chennai, TN (123rd)
- ✓ **Average Score:** 76.1 out of 100

About EIU's Global Liveability Index:

Assessment: The EIU 2026 Index has ranked **173** cities across the world by assessing which location offers the best and worst living conditions.

Categories: The annual index ranks cities based on 30 qualitative and quantitative indicators, which are broadly classified into **5** categories:

- Stability (evaluates crime rates, terrorism, and policies);
- Healthcare (access to health systems, hospitals, and medications);
- Culture and environment (air quality, cultural activities, among others);
- Education (quality and access to education); and
- Infrastructure (transport systems, housing, utilities, telecommunications).

Average Score: As per the latest survey, conducted in May 2026, the average liveability score across all the cities was the same as last year i.e. **76.1** out of 100.

Key Findings:

Other Top 10 Countries: Sydney, Australia (ranked 4th); Zurich, Switzerland, (ranked 5th); Geneva, Switzerland (ranked 6th); Osaka, Japan (ranked 7th); Adelaide, Australia (ranked 8th); Vancouver, Canada (ranked 9th) and Tokyo, Japan (ranked 10th), are among the top 10 countries in the index.

Region-wise: Western Europe continued to be the strongest region in the index, with cities like: Copenhagen, Vienna, Zurich, and Geneva featured among the top 6 countries in the index.

- Among the top 20 cities in the index, 9 are from the Asian region and 7 from the Europe region.
- Vancouver is the only city from North America, featured on the index.

Bottom Countries: Damascus, the capital of Syria, again emerged as the world's least liveable city (ranked at 173rd spot, with score of 32), affected by war, poverty and poor stability. It is followed by Tripoli, Libya (172nd); Dhaka, Bangladesh (171st); Karachi, Pakistan (170th), and Algiers (Algeria).

- This year, Tehran, Iran (ranked at 164th spot) entered the bottom 10 countries in the index.

World's Top 5 Liveable Cities:

Global Rank	City Name & Country	Overall Score
1	Copenhagen, Denmark	98
2	Vienna, Austria	97
3	Melbourne, Australia	97
4	Sydney, Australia	96
5	Zurich, Switzerland	96

Top Indian Cities:

Global Rank	City Name & State
120	Delhi
121	Mumbai, Maharashtra

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123	Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN)
127	Bengaluru, Karnataka

India-Specific:

Other Indian Cities: Besides New Delhi, other Indian cities featured in the index are: Mumbai, Maharashtra (121st, score of 47.9); Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN) (123rd) and Bengaluru, Karnataka (127th).

Category-wise Performance: Both New Delhi and Mumbai performed better across categories on education, compared to healthcare; culture and environment i.e. In the education category, New Delhi and Mumbai secured 66.7 and 58.3 scores, respectively.

- In contrast, in the culture and environment category, New Delhi and Mumbai secured 35.4 and 33.3 scores, respectively.

About Economic Intelligence Unit (EIU):

EIU is the research and analysis division of the Economist Group, the sister company to the Economist newspaper.

Managing Director **(MD) –** Leon Calvert

Headquarters – London, The United Kingdom (UK)

Founded – 1946

WIPO Report 2026 Reaffirms India as Global Innovation Powerhouse; Intangible Investment Grows 7.9%

In July 2026, the World Intellectual Property Organization **(WIPO)** and Luiss Business School **(LBS)** released the **3rd edition of** World Intangible Investment Report 2026**,** highlighting **India** as the **fastest-growing major economy** in intangible investments.

- India's intangible investment reached **USD 78.2 billion** in 2023 after **7.9% annual growth**, driven by software, Research and Development (R&D), intellectual property, and innovation.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of World Intangible Investment Report 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** WIPO & LBS
- ✓ **India Growth:**
- ✓ India recorded 7.9% year-on-year growth in intangible investment (2022-23)
- ✓ India's intangible investment reached USD 78.2 billion in 2023
- ✓ Highest among 15 largest economies.
- ✓ **Global:** Global intangible investment crossed USD 10 trillion for the first time in 2025
- ✓ USA leads the total intangible investment.
- ✓ Sweden ranks highest in investment intensity.

About World Intangible Investment Report 2026:

Overview: The report evaluates global investments in knowledge-based intangible assets and their contribution to long-term economic growth.

India's Performance:

- **Growth:** India recorded the highest intangible investment growth among the world's 15 largest economies at 7.9%, surpassing Japan (4.8%), the Philippines (4.6%), and the United States of America (USA) (4.4%).
- **Composition:** India's intangible investments include R&D, software, databases, brands, design, organisational capital, and intellectual property, with software and databases accounting for 45%, followed by organisational capital (21.8%), research and development (R&D) (12.7%), design (11%), and brands (9.3%).

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- **Impact:** Software and databases were India's fastest-growing intangible asset category, expanding at an average annual rate of 8.2% (2013–2023), while intangible investment reached 10% of formal-sector Gross Domestic Product (GDP) in 2023 compared with 19.3% for tangible investment.

Global Trends:

- **Growth:** Global intangible investment exceeded USD 10 trillion for the first time in 2025, growing more than three times faster than tangible investment since 2008, with a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 3.5% between 2008 and 2025 compared with 0.98% for tangible investment.
- **Leaders:** USA, Japan, and Germany were the largest investors in absolute terms, while Sweden, USA, and France recorded the highest investment intensity.
- **Composition:** Globally, software and databases were the fastest-growing intangible asset category during 2013–2023, followed by organisational capital and brands.

Top 5 Countries in Intangible Investment 2025:

Rank	Country	Intangible Investment Value (in USD Purchasing Power Parity)
1	United States of America (USA)	4.9 trillion (2025)
2	Japan	810 billion (2024)
3	Germany	695 billion (2024)
4	France	664 billion (2024)
5	United Kingdom (UK)	610 billion (2025)
6	**India**	78 billion (2023)

Top 5 Economies by Intangible Investment Growth Rate:

Rank	Country	Growth Rate (%)	Actual Time Period Covered (Due to Lags)
1	**India**	7.9%	2022–2023
2	Japan	4.8%	2023–2024
3	Philippines	4.6%	2021–2022
4	United States of America (USA)	4.4%	2024–2025
5	Germany	3.3%	2024–2025

Note: Denmark was the only major economy to record negative intangible investment growth, contracting by 3.2%.

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About World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO):

Director General **(DG)** – Daren Tang
Headquarters – Geneva, Switzerland
Established – 1967

WDMMA 2026 Rankings: IAF Retains 3rd Spot Among National Air Forces Globally

In July 2026, the World Defense Military Analysis **(WDMMA)** Global Air Power Rankings 2026, ranked Indian Air Force **(IAF)** as the **3rd-**most powerful air force globally behind only the United States and Russia, maintaining its position ahead of **China's** People's Liberation Army Air Force **(PLAAF)** for the **5th** consecutive year (since 2022).

- IAF ranked at **6th position** overall when air arms of the Army, Navy and Air Force are considered together with True Value Rating (**TVR**) of **69.4** and Chinese Air Force ranks 7th with 63.8 TvR
- United States (**US**) **Air Force** tops with a TVR of **242.9** (5,004 aircraft)

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** WDMMA Global Air Power Rankings 2026
- ✓ **Global Rank:** IAF- 3rd-most powerful air force in the world behind US and Russia
- ✓ **Overall ranking:** 6th position (when air arms of the Army, Navy and Air Force are considered together)
- ✓ **Regional Comparison:** Ahead of China for the 5th consecutive year
- ✓ **Overall Top 5:** USAF, USN, RAF, US Army and USMC

About WDMMA 2026 Rankings:

Evaluation: The annual assessment evaluates **129 air services** across **103 countries** and analyses more than **48,000 military aircraft** worldwide.

Assessment: The rankings use WDMMA's proprietary **TVR system**, which evaluates fleet size, aircraft composition, technological sophistication, logistical support, modernisation, and overall operational capability.

World's Top 5 Most Powerful Forces: WDMMA 2026

Rank	Name of the Force	Name of the Country	Total Units (in Active Aircraft Inventory)	TruVal Rating (TVR)
1	United States Air Force (USAF)	The United States of America (USA)	5004	242.9
2	United States Navy (USN)	The USA	2504	142.4
3	Russian Air Force (RAF)	Russia	3667	114.2
4	United States Army	The USA	4333	112.6

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5	United States Marine Corps (USMC)	The USA	1211	85.3
6	**Indian Air Force (IAF)**	**India**	**1716**	**69.4**

Lowest Ranked Air Forces in WDMMA 2026

Rank	Name of the Force	Name of the Country	Total Units (in Active Aircraft Inventory)	TruVal Rating (TVR)
107	Afghan Air Force Afghanistan	Afghanistan	9	0.3
106	Syrian Air Force	Syria	231	3.6
105	Albanian Air Force	Albania	19	3.9
104	Yemen Air Force	Yemen	169	5.2
103	Air Force of Bosnia & Herzegovina	Bosnia & Herzegovina	19	5.8

Ranking Highlights:

Other Powerful Air Forces: Japan with 756 aircraft has 58.1 TvR, Israel Air Force with 581 aircraft has 56.3 TvR and the French Air Force with 511 units has 55.3 TvR.

Neighbouring Countries of India: While, the Air Forces of Pakistan (TVR score of 46.3) and Bangladesh (14.1) ranked at 18th and 83rd position, respectively.

IAF Fleet Components:

Inventory: IAF maintains **498 helicopters**, including 222 Mi-17 helicopters and 111 indigenous Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (**HAL**) Dhruv and Rudra platforms, in addition to 282 transport aircraft and 374 trainer aircraft.

Special Aircrafts: IAF maintains **20 special mission aircraft**, comprising airborne early-warning systems, intelligence-gathering platforms, and aerial refuelling assets, improving operational reach and situational awareness.

Combat Aircrafts: It makes up 31.6% of the IAF fleet, compared to 32% in the USAF. Including bombers and close-air-support aircraft, combat aircraft constitute around 41% of the USAF inventory.

Other Branches of Indian Forces: Apart from IAF, IN Aviation was ranked at 27th position with TVR of 41.2; followed by IA Aviation ranked at 36th spot with overall TVR of 30.

Acquisition: India plans to strengthen the Indian Air Force with 114 Rafale aircraft from France, 180 4.5-generation HAL Tejas Mark-1A jets, and the 5th-generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (**AMCA**) scheduled for induction after 2029.

About Indian Air Force (IAF):

Chief of Air Staff (CoAS)- Amar Preet Singh
Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi Established- 1932

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Brand Finance India 100 Report 2026: Adani Group Fastest to Enter India's top 10 Most Valuable Brands

In July 2026, **Brand Finance,** world's leading independent brand valuation consultancy, released the latest edition of "Brand Finance India 100 Report 2026". As per the report, the **Adani Group** ranked at **8th** spot (up from 13th spot in last year), thereby becoming the fastest company to enter into India's 'Top 10 Most Valuable Brands'.

- **Tata Group** retained its position as India's most valuable brand for the 10th consecutive year with a brand value of USD 33.616 billion, followed by Infosys (USD 16.143 billion) and LIC Group (USD 15.278 billion) in the 2nd and 3rd positions, respectively.
- Adani Group became India's 3rd-most valuable conglomerate with a brand valuation of USD 8.48 billion. Adani Power emerged as India's most valuable energy brand, with its brand value rising 152% to USD 1.8 billion.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Brand Finance India 100 Report 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** Brand Finance
- ✓ **Cumulative Brand Value:** USD 252.8 billion
- ✓ **India's Most Valuable Indian Brand:** Tata Group (USD 33.6 billion)
- ✓ **Fastest to Enter Top 10:** Adani Group (Rank 8th)
- ✓ **Fastest-growing Indian Brand:** Suzlon Energy
- ✓ **Top 3 India's Strongest Brands:** Taj Hotels, Zomato and Amul.

About Brand Finance Report:

Overview: It is an independent, data-driven ranking of India's leading brands, evaluated using Brand Finance's globally recognised brand valuation methodology which combines consumer perception, brand impact, and forecast revenues to examine long-term brand value.

Sub-sectors: This year's report showcases 10 sub-sector rankings covering banking, Information Technology (IT) services, hospitality, tyres, among others.

Evaluation Process: Companies/brands are ranked based on:

- Brand value i.e. the financial worth of a brand;
- Brand Strength Index (BSI) score assesses marketing investment, stakeholder equity, and business performance on a scale of 0 to 100.

Key Findings:

Total Valuation : As per the report, the total valuation of India's 100 leading brands stands at **USD 252.8 billion**, marking an increase of **7%** compared to the last year.

- The report further outlined the growth in total brand value of India's top 100 companies was supported by continued investment in digital

Other Top 10 Most Valuable Indian Brands: HDFC Group (rank 4th, USD 15.3 billion); Reliance Group (rank 5th, USD 10.8 billion); SBI Group (rank 6th, USD 9.8 billion); HCL Technologies Limited (rank 7th, USD 9.0 billion); Adani Group (rank 8th); and Larsen and Toubro (L&T) Group (rank 9th, USD 8.3 billion) and Airtel (rank 10th, USD 8.1 billion.)

Fastest-growing Indian Brand: As per the report **Suzlon Energy** emerged as the fastest-growing Indian brand in 2026, with its brand valuation surged 114% Year-on-Year (Y-o-Y) to USD 418 million.

Top 3 India's Strongest Brands: Taj Hotels with total brand valuation of USD 878 million, marking an increase of 32% compared to the previous year, has emerged as India's strongest brand for the 5th consecutive year, with overall Brand Strength Index (BSI) score of 93.5 out of 100 and an AAA+ brand strength rating.

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- It is followed by Zomato (BSI score of 93.2 and AAAA+ rating) and Amul (BSI score of 93 and AAA+ rating).

Top IT Brand: TCS retained its position as India's most valuable Information & Technology (IT) Services brand for 14 years in a row, valued at USD 21.2 billion.

- Also, it has maintained its position as the world's 2nd most valuable IT services brand for the 5th consecutive year.

Banking Sector: Yes Bank Limited emerged as India's fastest-growing banking brand, with its brand value increasing 79% to USD 458 million.

India's Top 5 Most Valuable Brands in 2026:

Rank	Company Name	Total Brand Valuation (in USD billion)
1	Tata Group	33.616
2	Infosys	16.413
3	LIC Group	15.278
4	HDFC Group	13.888
5	Reliance Group	10.833

About Brand Finance Plc.:

Managing Director **(MD)** and Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)-** David Haigh
Headquarters- London, the United Kingdom (UK)
Established- 1996

NITI Aayog's IFI 2026: Gujarat Leads Among All Large States, Followed by Maharashtra and TN

In July 2026, the National Institution for Transforming India **(NITI Aayog)** released its latest report titled "Investment Friendliness Index (IFI 2026)" which provides a comprehensive and data-driven framework to assess the capabilities of states and Union Territories (UTs) in attracting and sustaining investments. As per the index, **Gujarat** topped among all large states as well as in the overall ranking with a total score of **56.6.**

- The index further cited that Gujarat's performance was mainly supported by strong performances in infrastructure, business climate, financial health, regulatory ease and government policy.
- It is followed by **Maharashtra (overall score of 53.7)** and Tamil Nadu **(TN) (overall score of 53.3)** secured **2nd** and **3rd** positions in the index.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Investment Friendliness Index (IFI 2026)
- ✓ **Released by:** NITI Aayog
- ✓ **Top 3 States:** Gujarat (rank 1st, score 56.6); Maharashtra (rank 2nd, score 53.7) and TN (rank 3rd, score 53.3)
- ✓ **Key Pillars:** 08, including infrastructure, business climate, resources, government policy, regulatory ease, institutional environment, financial health and environmental resilience
- ✓ **Categories:** 04, including Top performers (score > 50); Frontrunners (score ranges from 45 to 50); Emerging performers (score ≥ 40-<45); and Aspiring States (score < 50)
- ✓ **Top Performers:** 05 states, including Goa, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Odisha, TN

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About IFI 2026:

Background: In February 2026, Union Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Ministry of Finance (MoF) announced the creation of IFI in the Union Budget for Financial Year 2025-26 (FY26), aimed to strengthen competitive and cooperative federalism by promoting reforms and investment-friendly ecosystems across states.

Key Pillars: The index has covered all **28 states** and **8 UTs** to evaluate their ability to attract investments across the **8 key pillars.**

- Among the 8 key pillars, the highest weightage is assigned to infrastructure (25%); followed by business climate (20%), resources (15%), government policy (10%), regulatory ease (12%), institutional environment (6%), financial health (7%) and environmental resilience (5%).

Indicators: The index also features 84 indicators which include both secondary data and perception-based measures derived from a primary surveys of investors.

Categories: The index measures the performance of the states on a scale of **100** and therefore, state have been categorised into 4 different groups:

- Top performers (score > 50); Frontrunners (score ranges from 45 to 50); Emerging performers (score ≥ 40-<45); and Aspiring States (score < 50).

Key Findings:

Top 5 States: Overall, Gujarat, Maharashtra, TN, Goa (rank 4th, score of 53.1); Odisha (ranked 5th, score of 52.4) featured among the top 5 states in the index.

- Together, these top 5 states account for **85%** of total Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) inflows.
- In contrast, the cumulative share of the North-East (NE) is less than 1% of total FDI inflows.

Top 5 States: IFI 2026

Rank	State/Union Territory (UT)	Overall Score
1	Gujarat	56.6
2	Maharashtra	53.7
3	Tamil Nadu (TN)	53.3
4	Goa	53.1
5	Odisha	52.4

Geographical Categorisation: Considering the diversity of India, the index has further classified states and UTs into **3 categories:** Large States; Hilly and North-Eastern States, and UTs and City States.

- **Large States:** Gujarat topped in large states category; followed by Maharashtra (ranked 2nd) and TN (ranked 3rd).
- **Hilly & NE States:** Uttarakhand emerged as the highest ranked state in this category; followed by Assam (ranked 2nd) and HP (ranked 3rd).
- **UTs and City States:** Goa secured top position in the UTs and City States category, followed by UT Delhi and UT Chandigarh.

Classification: Based on its overall assessment, the index has placed:

- **05 States in top performers category:** Goa, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Odisha, TN.
- **15 States/UTs in frontrunners category:** Andhra Pradesh (AP), Assam, UT Chandigarh, UT Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh (HP), among others.

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- **8 states/UTs in Emerging category:** Bihar, UT Jammu & Kashmir (J&K), Jharkhand, Meghalaya, Nagaland, UT Puducherry, Punjab and West Bengal (WB).
- **8 States/UTs in Aspiring category:** UT Andaman & Nicobar Islands, Arunachal Pradesh (AR), UT Ladakh, UT Dadra & Nagar Haveli, UT Daman & Diu, UT Lakshadweep, Manipur, Mizoram, and Sikkim.

Bottom 5 States/UTs: UT Lakshadweep ranked lowest in the index, with overall score of 24.5, followed by UT Ladakh (ranked 35th, score of 27.0); UT Andamand & Nicobar (A&N) Islands (ranked 34th, score of 30.2); Manipur (ranked 33rd, score of 32.3) and Sikkim (ranked 32nd, score of 36.6).

About National Institution for Transforming India (NITI Aayog):

Chairman- Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi
Vice-Chairperson- Ashok Kumar Lahiri
Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi
Established in- 2015

MHI Data: Maharashtra tops PLI-Auto scheme with 66 manufacturing units; Tamil Nadu has 38

In July 2026, the Ministry of Heavy Industries **(MHI)** presented data in the Lok Sabha (the Lower House of the Parliament) that showed **Maharashtra** topped among states in terms of manufacturing units established under the Production Linked Incentive **(PLI) scheme** for the automobile and auto component industry, with **66 units** (as of March 31, 2026).

- It is followed by **Tamil Nadu** (TN) (with 38 units); **Haryana** (35 units) and Karnataka (35 units), among the top 3 states with highest number of manufacturing units under the scheme.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of data related PLI-Auto scheme
- ✓ **Released by:** MHI
- ✓ **Total Units (set up under the scheme):** 225 (as of March 31, 2026)
- ✓ **Top 3 States:** Maharashtra (66 units), TN (38 units), and Haryana (35 units)
- ✓ **Investments:** Rs 44, 326 crore
- ✓ **Employment:** 67,820
- ✓ **Total Incentives Disbursed:** Rs 2,386.36 crore
- ✓ **Overall Investments (under PLI Schemes):** Over Rs 2.40 lakh crore
- ✓ **Overall Employment:** 14.15 lakh jobs

Key Progress Made under PLI-Auto Scheme:

Total Units: As per the data, so far, a total of **225** manufacturing units have been established nationwide under the PLI-Auto scheme.

Top 5 States: PLI-Auto Scheme

States	Number of Manufacturing Units (as of March 31, 2026)
Maharashtra	66
Tamil Nadu (TN)	38
Haryana	35
Karnataka	28
Uttar Pradesh (UP)	13

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Other States: Also, states like: Uttar Pradesh (UP) (13 units), Gujarat (10 units), Uttarakhand (9 units), Rajasthan (7 units), Madhya Pradesh (MP) (6 units), and Telangana (5 units), lead in PLI-Auto scheme.

- However, states like: Andhra Pradesh (AP) and Jharkhand (2 units each), and Assam, Kerala, Union Territory (UT) Puducherry and Punjab (one unit each), trail in the establishment of these units.

Key Outcomes: By the end of Financial Year 2025-26 (FY26), the PLI-Auto scheme has attracted investments **worth Rs 44, 326 crore** and generated 67, 820 jobs.

- In addition, the scheme has recorded incremental sales of **Rs 52, 414 crore** over the base year FY20.
- So far, the Government of India (GoI) has disbursed Rs 2,386.36 crore in incentives under the scheme.

PLI-Auto Scheme: In September 2021, the GoI approved the PLI Scheme for Automobile and Auto Component Industry in India (PLI-Auto) with a budgetary outlay of Rs 25,938 crore.

- **Aim:** to enhance India's manufacturing capabilities for Advanced Automotive Products (AAT).
- **Pan-India Scheme:** It allows approved applicants to set up manufacturing units anywhere in the country. Also, no state is entitled to get any special incentive from the GoI.

About PLI Scheme:

Background: The PLI Scheme, a flagship initiative of the GoI, launched in **March 2020,** aimed to boost India's manufacturing capabilities, reduce reliance on imports and promote exports by offering financial incentives directly related to measurable outcomes such as higher production and incremental sales.

Key Sectors: Initially, the scheme was launched to target **three** industries: mobile manufacturing and electric components; pharmaceutical (critical key starting materials/active pharmaceutical ingredients); and Medical device manufacturing.

- Later it was extended to a total of **14** sectors such as: manufacturing of medical devices, automobiles and auto Components, specialty steel, among others, with a total budgetary outlay of **Rs.1.97 trillion.**

Implementation: The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoCI), acts as the nodal department for overall coordination and monitoring of the schemes, while their execution is managed by the respective ministries and departments.

Key Progress: As of March 31, 2026, the PLI Schemes have attracted investments worth over Rs 2.40 lakh crore and generated more than 14.15 lakh jobs, while exports under the schemes have surpassed Rs 15.2 lakh crore, since their inception.

- **Sector-wise Distribution:** The high efficiency solar PV modules have attracted the maximum investments (Rs 64,873 crore); followed by pharma (Rs 45,158 crore); speciality steel (Rs 23,896 crore); and the large-scale electronics manufacturing sector (Rs 20,580 crore).

About Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI):

Union Minister- Haradanahalli Devgowda (H.D.) Kumaraswamy (Constituency- Mandya, Karnataka)
Minister of State **(MoS)-** Bhupathi Raju Srinivasa Varma (Constituency- Narasapuram, Andhra Pradesh, AP)

Henley Passport Index: India Dropped to 81st Spot, Singapore Retained Top Position

In July 2026, **Henley & Partners,** a British consultancy expertized in investment migration, released the **20th** anniversary edition of Henley Passport (HPI) Global Ranking– July 2026. As per the index, India dropped to 81st position globally with access to 55 destinations, down from the 75th position (in February 2026 edition). India shares the rank with countries like: Mauritania, Algeria.

- **Singapore** retained its position as the world's most powerful passport with access to 192 destinations without a prior visa, followed by **Japan, South Korea** and **the United Arab Emirates (UAE),** sharing the 2nd position with access to 188 destinations; and Sweden which ranked at 3rd position with access to 187 destinations.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Henley Passport Index July 2026 edition
- ✓ **Released by:** Henley & Partners
- ✓ **Top 3 Countries:** Singapore (ranks 1st, 192 destinations); Japan, South Korea, the UAE (ranks 2nd, 188 destinations); and Sweden (ranks 3rd, 187 destinations)
- ✓ **India's Rank:** 81st (55 destinations)
- ✓ **Most Powerful Passport:** Singapore (192 destinations)
- ✓ **Least-Powerful Passport:** Afghanistan (ranks 104th, 22 destinations)

About Henley Passport Index:

Overview: HPI is a global ranking of passports based on travel freedom. It measures how many countries a passport holder can visit without needing a visa in advance.

Data Source: The index uses data from the International Air Transport Association (IATA) and covers 199 passports and 227 travel destinations. It includes visa-free, visa-on-arrival, and Electronic Travel Authorization (eTA) access.

Frequency: It is updated annually to reflect diplomatic changes, agreements, or geopolitical developments.

Ranking Methodology: A higher visa-free score symbolizes a passport enables more visa-free international travel, which denotes greater global mobility.

Top 5 Countries: HPI July 2026

Rank	Country Name	Number of Visa-free Access Destinations
1	Singapore	192
2	Japan, South Korea, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE)	188
3	Sweden	187
4	Belgium, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Ireland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, and Spain	186
5	Austria, Greece, Malta, Portugal, Switzerland	185
81	**India, Mauritania & Algeria.**	**55**

Key Findings:

Average Visa-free Access to Destinations: Since the launch of HPI in 2006, the average passport providing visa-free access has doubled from just 58 destinations to **108** destinations worldwide.

Strongest Performer: The UAE has emerged as the strongest performer on the index over the past 20 years, gaining 153 visa-free destinations since 2006 and climbing 3 places to 2nd.

Bottom 5 Countries: Afghanistan continued to be ranked lowest in the index with access to only 22 destinations, followed by Syria (ranked 103rd, 25 destinations), Iraq (ranked 102nd, 28 destinations), Pakistan (ranked 101st, 29 destinations), and Yemen (ranked 100th, 30 destinations).

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About Henley & Partners:
Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** – Dr. Juerg Steffen
Headquarters – London, United Kingdom (UK)
Established – 1997

BIMCO-ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026: India Becomes World's 2nd Largest Supplier of Seafarers

In July 2026, According to the BIMCO-ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026, released by the Baltic and International Maritime Council **(BIMCO)** and the International Chamber of Shipping **(ICS)**, India became the world's **2nd largest** supplier of seafarers with **311,936** professionals, accounting for 12.16% of the global workforce, ranking after the Philippines and ahead of China, Russian Federation and Indonesia.

- The maritime reforms and initiatives under the leadership of Prime Minister **(PM)** Narendra Modi, along with efforts led by Union Minister, Sarbananda Sonowal, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways **(MoPSW)**, contributed to India's emergence as the world's second-largest supplier of seafarers.

Exam hints:

- ✓ **What?** BIMCO-ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026
- ✓ **Released By:** BIMCO & ICS
- ✓ **India's Rank:** 2nd Largest Supplier of Seafarers
- ✓ **Indian Seafarers:** 311,936 Maritime Professionals
- ✓ **Global Workforce Share:** 12.16%
- ✓ **Top Supplier:** Philippines
- ✓ **India's Previous Rank (2015):** 5th Position
- ✓ **India's Share (2015):** 5.2%
- ✓ **Global Seafarer Supply:** 2.57 Million
- ✓ **Global Seafarer Demand:** 2.55 Million

Highlights of Seafarer Workforce Report 2026:

Growth Journey: India's maritime workforce improved from the 5th position in 2015 with **5.2% global share** to the 2nd position in 2026 with its contribution more than doubling over the decade and establishing India as a major maritime manpower hub.

Maritime Strength: India contributes significanctly to the global shipping industry, including **140,718 officers** (13.41% of global officers) and 171,218 ratings (11.29% of global ratings) serving on merchant vessels.

Global Demand Scenario: The BIMCO-ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026 estimates the global seafarer supply at **2.57 million** against demand of 2.55 million, highlighting a shortage of qualified maritime professionals, especially officers.

Growth Reforms: India's rise is supported by maritime education, skill development, modern training infrastructure, digital seafarer certification through the Directorate General of Shipping, and compliance with Standards of Training, Certification and Watchkeeping (STCW).

- The key reforms include Inland Vessels Act, 2021; Merchant Shipping Act, 2025; Indian Ports Act, 2025; Coastal Shipping Act, 2025; Bills of Lading Act, 2025; and Carriage of Goods by Sea Act, 2025.

Significance: India's rise as the 2nd largest seafarer supplier strengthens its maritime talent hub status, while **Mission 20%** aims to make one in five global seafarers Indian, supporting Maritime India Vision 2030 and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047.

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Top 5 Seafarer-Supplying Countries (BIMCO-ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026):

Rank	Country	Officers
1.	Philippines	203,179
2.	India	140,718
3.	China	110,893
4.	Russia Federation	85,816
5.	Indonesia	72,304

About Baltic and International Maritime Council (BIMCO):

Background: BIMCO was established in **1905** and is headquartered in Bagsværd, Denmark.

About Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW):

Union Minister – Sarbananda Sonowal (Constituency – Dibrugarh, Assam)
Minister of State **(MoS)** – Shantanu Thakur (Bangaon, West Bengal WB)

REPORTS

MoSPI Releases 2026 SDG Publications Highlighting India's Progress under NIF

On 29 June 2026, the occasion of the 20th Statistics Day, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (**MoSPI)** released a series of publications on the Sustainable Development Goals (**SDGs**), highlighting India's progress across social, economic and environmental indicators under the National Indicator Framework (**NIF**).

- The MoSPI developed the NIF, in consultation with ministries, NITI (National Institution Transforming India) Aayog, UN (United Nations) agencies and other stakeholders, to monitor the SDGs at the national level.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoSPI releases series of publications on SDG
- ✓ **When?** 29 June 2026 (20th Statistics Day)
- ✓ **Publications:**
- ✓ SDGs – National Indicator Framework (NIF) Progress Report, 2026
- ✓ Data Snapshot on SDGs – NIF Progress Report, 2026;
- ✓ SDGs – NIF, 2026 (along with metadata)
- ✓ Transforming Lives: India's Achievements under the People Dimension of the SDGs.
- ✓ **Purpose:** Monitor SDGs at national level
- ✓ **SDGs – NIF Progress Report, 2026**
- ✓ NIF Indicators: 277 national indicators covering all 17 SDGs
- ✓ Social Protection Coverage: 65.3% (2026)
- ✓ MMR: 87 (2022–24)
- ✓ Sex Ratio at Birth: 918 (2022–24)
- ✓ Unemployment Rate (UR): 3.1% (2025)
- ✓ RE Capacity: 193.36 watts per capita (2025–26)
- ✓ Internet Subscriptions: 969.10 million (2025).

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About SDG Progress Reports:

Publications: As part of its annual Statistics Day observance, the MoSPI released the following publications.

- SDGs – National Indicator Framework (NIF) Progress Report, 2026
- Data Snapshot on SDGs – NIF Progress Report, 2026;
- SDGs – NIF, 2026 (along with metadata)
- Transforming Lives: India's Achievements under the People Dimension of the SDGs.

SDGs – NIF Progress Report, 2026:

Overview: This report presents the latest time-series data on SDG national indicators to monitor progress towards the 17 SDGs and support evidence-based policymaking.

Indicators: The NIF, 2026 consists of **277** national SDG indicators, covering all 17 SDGs.

Coverage Expansion: The proportion of population covered by social protection systems/floors increased from 22.0% in 2016 to **65.3%** in 2026.

MMR: Maternal Mortality Ratio (MMR) declined from 122 per 100,000 live births during 2015-17 to **87** during 2022-24.

Sex Ratio: The Sex Ratio at Birth (in Per 1,000 male live births) improved from 896 females per 1,000 males in 2015–17 to **918** in 2022–24, reflecting a positive trend towards a more balanced gender ratio at birth.

UR Rate: The unemployment rate (**UR**) declined from 6.1% in 2017-18 to **3.1%** in 2025.

Gender Parity: The ratio of female to male workers employed as Professionals and Technical Workers increased from 48.7% in 2023–24 to **51.3%** in 2025.

Genetic resources conserved: Plant genetic resources conserved increased from 4,32,564 in 2014–15 to **4,91,864** in 2025–26.

- Animal genetic resources rose from 1,40,364 to **3,61,794**
- Fish genetic resources more than doubled from 47 to **105**

Renewable Energy (RE): Installed RE generating capacity in the country increased from 64.04 watts per capita in 2014-15 to **193.36** watts per capita in 2025–26.

Recycling Infrastructure: The number of waste recycling plants installed increased from 829 in 2019–20 to **3,236** in 2025–26 reflecting a strong expansion in waste management.

Ramsar Site Area: The area of Ramsar sites as a percentage of total wetland area increased from 4.15% in 2016 to **8.66%** in 2026.

Digital Connectivity: The total number of internet subscriptions more than tripled from 302.36 million (Mn) in 2015 to **969.10 Mn** in 2025.

Data Snapshot on SDG-NIF Progress Report, 2026:

Overview: A handbook version of the SDG-NIF Progress Report, 2026, presenting national-level time-series data on SDG indicators in a concise, user-friendly format for quick reference and analysis.

Sustainable Development Goals – National Indicator Framework (NIF), 2026 (with Metadata):

Overview: A handbook edition of the SDG-NIF Progress Report, 2026, featuring all national SDG indicators along with comprehensive metadata, including definitions, data sources, and methodologies for each indicator.

SDG Bulletin:

Overview: 'Thematic Bulletin: Transforming Lives: India's Achievements under the People Dimension of the SDGs', highlights India's progress on SDGs 1–5 (No Poverty, Zero Hunger, Good Health, Quality Education, and Gender Equality).

Framework: It is part of MoSPI's thematic SDG bulletin series aligned with the **5Ps** of the 2030 Agenda: People, Planet, Prosperity, Peace, and Partnerships, and showcases key initiatives and policies supporting inclusive human development.

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About Sustainable Development Goals (SDG):

SDG: The SDG is a set of **17** interconnected global goals adopted by all 193 member states of the United Nations (**UN**) in 2015 as part of the **2030 Agenda** for sustainable development.

Target: All UN member states committed to fulfilling these goals by the target year of **2030.**

- Before the SDGs, the world followed the Millennium Development Goals (**MDGs**) from 2000 to 2015.

About Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI):

Minister of State (**MoS**) (Independent Charge, IC) – Rao Inderjit Singh (Constituency- Gurugram, Haryana)

NITI Aayog Releases 'Strategic Roadmap for Making Ayurveda Global' Report for Viksit Bharat@2047 Vision

In July 2026, National Institution for Transforming India **(NITI) Aayog** released "Strategic Roadmap for Making Ayurveda Global" , outlines a phased plan to develop Ayurveda into a globally recognised, evidence-based healthcare system by 2047, aligned with the **Viksit Bharat@2047** vision.

- The report was launched by **Dr. Ashok Kumar Lahiri**, Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog, in the presence of Prof. (Dr.) M. Srinivas, Member of NITI Aayog, and Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary, Ministry of AYUSH (Ayurveda, Yoga & Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha and Homoeopathy), in New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of 'Strategic Roadmap for Making Ayurveda Global' report
- ✓ **Released by:** Dr. Ashok Kumar Lahiri, Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog
- ✓ **Prepared by:** PwC (PricewaterhouseCoopers)
- ✓ **Goal:** Transform Ayurveda into a globally recognised, evidence-based healthcare system by 2047
- ✓ **Framework:** Three-pillar – Availability, Acceptability, & Propagation
- ✓ **Vision:** Viksit Bharat@2047, One Earth One Health
- ✓ Targets:
- ✓ Integration in 20 countries' health systems by 2047
- ✓ Global Information Portal proposed
- ✓ Short-term goal (2029): 10,000 registered practitioners.

About Ayurveda:

Overview: Ayurveda is one of India's traditional systems of medicine and forms part of the AYUSH framework, which also includes Yoga, Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, Sowa-Rigpa, and Homoeopathy.

Global Reach: Ayurveda exports increased from USD 1.09 billion in 2014 to USD 2.16 billion in 2023, reaching around 150 countries.

Recognition: It is recognised as a medical discipline in nearly 30 countries, including the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Switzerland, and is included in the World Health Organization's International Classification of Diseases 11th Revision (ICD-11) Module 2 for traditional medicine.

About Ayurveda Global Roadmap:

Objective: The report aims to transform Ayurveda into a globally recognised, evidence-based healthcare system by strengthening research, regulatory alignment, education, exports, and international collaborations.

Study Methodology: The Health Division of NITI Aayog conducted the study with PricewaterhouseCoopers **(PwC**), using stakeholder consultations, global benchmarking, and evidence-based analysis to assess opportunities and challenges in globalising Ayurveda.

Framework: The roadmap is structured on three pillars: **Availability** (global workforce, exports, Research and Development (R&D), education), **Acceptability** (regulation, insurance coverage,

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collaborations, adaptability), and **Propagation** (branding, global visibility, medical value travel, international engagement).

Implementation: The roadmap proposes integrating Ayurveda into **20 national health systems by 2047**, expanding insurance coverage to 10 countries, and establishing a Global Ayurveda Register (GAR) under the National Commission for Indian System of Medicine (NCISM) along with international centres to strengthen global reach.

Phasing: The roadmap outlines short-term (up to 2029), medium-term (up to 2035), and long-term (up to 2047) milestones, including World Health Organization Good Manufacturing Practice (WHO-GMP) certification, strategic international agreements, and formal integration into multiple national health systems.

Recommendations: It also suggests a Global Information Portal, Mutual Recognition Arrangements (MRAs) with Group of Twenty (G20), BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa), and ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) nations, inclusion of Ayurveda in international medical curricula, and creation of 10 Centres of Excellence (CoE).

Benchmarking: The report compares Ayurveda with Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM), highlighting that TCM's global expansion is driven by large-scale state support, strong research and development funding, and active global standards diplomacy.

About National Institution for Transforming India (NITI) Aayog:

Establishment: NITI Aayog was established on **January 1, 2015**, by a Union Cabinet resolution, replacing the Planning Commission (1950–2014), and functions as a non-constitutional, non-statutory executive think tank of the Government of India.

Mandate: It serves as the apex public policy advisory body promoting cooperative federalism through a bottom-up planning approach that involves States and Union Territories (UTs) in national economic policymaking.

Leadership: The Prime Minister (PM) of India (Narendra Modi) acts as the ex-officio Chairperson, while the Vice-Chairperson (**Ashok Kumar Lahiri)** (appointed by PM) and the Chief Executive Officer (CEO), (**Nidhi Chhibbera**) senior Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer, manage executive and administrative functions.

Composition: The Governing Council includes Chief Ministers (CM)of all States and Lieutenant Governors/Administrators of UT, supported by full-time members, part-time members, and ex-officio Union Ministers nominated by the Government of India (GoI).

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi.

MoE Releases the Report on UDISE+ 2025-26 on School Education in India

On July 7 2026, the Ministry of Education **(MoE)** released the 'Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) 2025-26' report, providing comprehensive data on school education, including enrolment, teachers, infrastructure, retention, transition and gender parity.

- According to the report, the number of **teachers** rose by 8.3% to **1,02,73,020** in 2025–26, from 94,83,294 in 2022–23.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of UDISE+ 2025-26 report on school education in India
- ✓ **By Whom?** MoE
- ✓ **Purpose:** Enhance quality, access, equity, gender parity, and technology adoption in school education
- ✓ **Key Data:**
- ✓ **Teachers:** 1,02,73,020 (8.3% increased) female teachers at 54.9%
- ✓ **PTR:** Foundational (10), Preparatory (12), Middle (17), Secondary (21)

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- ✓ **Dropout Rates declined:** Preparatory (1.8%), Middle (3.6%), Secondary (7.0%)
- ✓ **Improved Retention Rates:** Middle (83.7%), Secondary (51.9%)
- ✓ **GER (Secondary):** Increased to 71.7% (2025-26)
- ✓ **Zero Enrolment Schools:** Declined by 29% to 5,663.

About Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+):

Overview: The Department of School Education and Literacy (DoSE&L) under MoE introduced UDISE+ in 2018–19 as one of the world's largest education management information systems.

- It was initially launched as the UDISE in 2012–13 by integrating separate information management systems for elementary and secondary education.

Management: The UDISE was initially managed by the National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration (NIEPA).

Data Management: UDISE+ enables online school-level data uploading with inbuilt validation checks and multi-level verification at the block, district, and state levels to ensure reliable and timely data.

Highlights of UDISE+ 2025-26 Report:

Data Collection: The report is based on data voluntarily uploaded through the online Data Capture Format (DCF) by schools with active UDISE+ codes for 2025–26, with 31 March 2026 as the cut-off date.

Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR): The PTR was 10 at the Foundational level, 12 at the Preparatory level, 17 at the Middle level and 21 at the Secondary level, all below the **30:1 ratio** recommended under the National Education Policy (NEP).

Dropout Rates: Dropout rates declined across levels: Preparatory **1.8%** (from 2.3% in 2024-25), Middle **3.6%** (from 3.5% in 2024-25), Secondary **7.0%** (from 8.2% in 2024-25), reflecting improved student retention.

Student Retention: Retention improved at Middle (83.7%) and Secondary (51.9%) levels; Foundational and Preparatory levels saw slight declines from prior years due to earlier consecutive improvements.

GER: Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) at Secondary increased to 71.7% (from 68.5% in 2024-25), indicating greater access and student participation at higher levels.

Transition Rate: Foundational to Preparatory (99.2%), Preparatory to Middle (93.8%), and Middle to Secondary (88.3%), indicating stronger progression of students through the education system.

Infrastructure Improvements: Basic school infrastructure improved, with 95% of schools having electricity, 99.5% drinking water, 98.5% girls' toilets, 97.2% boys' toilets and 96.9% handwashing facilities.

- Libraries were available in 90.5% of schools, while 58.2% had ramps with handrails for students with disabilities.

Female Representation: Female teachers increased to 54.9% and girls' enrolment reached 48.4%, reflecting progress toward gender parity.

Key School Education Indicators in India:

Educational Indicator	Category/Level	2024–25	2025–26
Teachers (Number)	Total Teachers	1,01,22,420	1,02,73,020
Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR)	Foundational	10	10
	Preparatory	13	12
	Middle	17	17

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	Secondary	21	21
Dropout Rate (%)	Preparatory	2.3	1.8
	Middle	3.5	3.6
	Secondary	8.2	7.0
Retention Rate (%)	Foundational	98.9	98.5
	Preparatory	92.4	91.1
	Middle	82.8	83.7
	Secondary	47.2	51.9
Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) (%)	Middle	90.3	89.6
	Secondary	68.5	71.7
Transition Rate (%)	Foundational to Preparatory	98.6	99.2
	Preparatory to Middle	92.2	93.8
	Middle to Secondary	86.6	88.3
Schools (Number)	Single Teacher Schools	1,04,125	1,00,843
	Zero Enrolment Schools	7,993	5,663
Infrastructure (%)	Computer Access	64.7	69.9
	Internet Facility	63.5	67.4
	Electricity	93.6	95.0
	Drinking Water	99.3	99.5
	Girls' Toilets	97.3	98.5
	Boys' Toilets	96.2	97.2
	Handwash Facility	95.9	96.9
	Playground	83.0	81.9
	Library	89.5	90.5
	Rainwater Harvesting	29.4	29.9

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	Ramps with Handrails	54.9	58.2
Female Representation (%)	Girls' Enrolment	48.3	48.4
	Female Teachers	54.2	54.9

About Ministry of Education (MoE):

Union Minister– Dharmendra Pradhan (Constituency- Sambalpur, Odisha)
Minister of State **(MoS)**– Jayant Chaudhary (Rajya Sabha- Uttar Pradesh, UP); Dr. Sukanta Majumdar (Constituency- Balurghat, West Bengal, WB)

MoE Released PGI 2.0-S and PGI-D Reports for 2025-26; No States/UTs with highest performance grade

In July 2026, the Ministry of Education (**MoE**) released the Report on Performance Grading Index 2.0 for States/Union Territories (UTs) (PGI 2.0-S) and Performance Grading Index for Districts (PGI-D) for 2025-26, with no State or UT securing the highest performance grade for yet another year.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** MoE released PGI 2.0-S and PGI-D for 2025-26

PGI 2.0-S

- ✓ **Purpose:** Measure performance of states in school education
- ✓ **By Whom?** DoSEL
- ✓ **Indicators:** 70, weightage – 1000 points
- ✓ **Source:** UDISE+, PARAKH, PM POSHAN, PRABAND, Vidyanjali Portal
- ✓ **Grade Type:** Utkarsh, Uttam -1,2,3, Prachesta -1,2,3, Akanshi – 1,2,3
- ✓ **States Performance:** Chandigarh – Uttam Range – 766, Lowest Score: Meghalaya

PGI-D

- ✓ **Focus:** Educational Outcomes
- ✓ **Sources:** UDISE+, PRS 2024, PRABANDH Portal
- ✓ **Weightage:** 600 points
- ✓ **Indicators:** 70
- ✓ **Top Performer:** Chandigarh

PGI 2.0 -S Overview

PGI: This is an index introduced in **2017** to measure the performance of states in school education undertaken by the Department of School Education &Literacy (**DoSEL**).

Evaluation: This index evaluates the performance of states and UTs by categorising them into different grades or levels.

- This grading approach allows multiple states and UTs to be placed within the same performance band.

Indicators: The PGI 2.0 State/UT structure comprises total weightage of **1000 points** across **70** indicators, which are grouped under 2 Categories:

- Outcome
- Governance and Management.

Domains: The categories are further divided into 6 domains:

- Learning Outcomes and Quality (LO) – 9 indicators
- Access (A) – 7
- Infrastructure & Facilities (I&F) – 15
- Equity (E) – 16

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- Governance Processes (GP) – 15
- Teacher Education & Training (TE&T) – 8

Source: The data for 70 indicators are sourced from:

- Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+)
- PARAKH (Performance Assessment, Review, and Analysis of Knowledge for Holistic Development) Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024
- PM POSHAN (Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman) Portal
- PRABAND (Project Appraisal, Budgeting, Achievements and Data Handling System) Portal
- Vidyanjali Portal

Grade Types: The highest achievable Grade is called **Utkarsh (941-1000)**, which is for State/UT scoring more than **90%** of the grade range.

Grade Range	Score range	Grade
91% to 100%	941-1000	Utkarsh
81% to 90%	881-940	Uttam-1
71% to 80%	821-880	Uttam-2
61% to 70%	761-820	Uttam-3
51% to 60%	701-760	Prachesta -1
41% to 50%	641-700	Prachesta -2
31% to 40%	581-640	Prachesta -3
21% to 30%	521-580	Akanshi-1
11% to 20%	461-520	Akanshi-2
Up to 10%	401-460	Akanshi-3

States Performance: No State/UT reached the Utkarsh, Uttam-1 and Uttam-2 categories.

- **Chandigarh** became the first State/ UT in the PGI 2.0 series to enter the Uttam range, scoring 766 out of 1,000 in 2025-26.
- Chandigarh was followed by DNH&DD (Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu), Punjab, Kerala & Delhi.
- The lowest score was recorded by **Meghalaya**.

Performance Gap: The report noted that the highest score recorded in 2025-26 was **766**, while the lowest was 525.7, resulting in a gap of 240.3 points (31.4%).

PGI-D Highlights

PGI-D: The DoSEL, Ministry of Education (**MoE**) extended the PGI exercise to District level by creating a PGI for District (PGI-D).

- The index evaluates districts using common parameters, with focus on educational outcomes.

Sources: The data for PGI-D are drawn from several sources:

- UDISE+,
- PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024 (PRS 2024) and
- the PRABANDH Portal.

Indicators and Categories: The PGI-D framework comprises a total weightage of **600 points** across **70 indicators**, which are grouped under 6 categories:

- Outcomes – 21
- Effective Classroom Transaction (ECT) – 19
- Infrastructure Facilities & Student Entitlements (EF&ST) – 11
- School Safety & Child Protection (SS&CP) – 7
- Digital Learning (DL) – 5
- Governance Process (GP) – 7

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Total Districts: The PGI-D 2025–26 comprises **784 districts**, whereas the PGI-D 2024–25 comprised 782 districts.

- This is due to the addition of 2 new districts during 2025-26 in Arunachal Pradesh namely **Bichom** and **Keyi Panyor**.

Grade Types: Uttam-1 is for the district having PGI score of 81% to 90%, Uttam-2:71% to 80%, Uttam-3: 61% to 70%, Prachesta-1:51% to 60%, Prachesta -2: 41% to 50%, Prachesta-3: 31% to 40%, Akanshi-1:21% to 30%, Akanshi-2: 11% to 20%. The last one, namely Akanshi-3 is for scores upto 10%.

Performance: Total of **473** districts improved their PGI score in 2025-26 as compared to 2024-25.

- Out of these, **89** districts have made Grade level improvement.

Top Performers: No district attained the highest grade, "**Utkarsh**", or the second-highest grade, "**Uttam-1**", in the overall PGI-D rankings.

- A total of **19 districts** secured the Uttam-2 grade in 2025–26, up from 16 districts in 2024–25.
- **Chandigarh (UT)** scored the highest, with the overall score, **437.**

About Ministry of Education (MoE):

Union Minister– Dharmendra Pradhan (Constituency- Sambalpur, Odisha)
Minister of State (**MoS**)– Jayant Chaudhary (Rajya Sabha- Uttar Pradesh, UP); Dr. Sukanta Majumdar (Constituency- Balurghat, West Bengal, WB)

MeitY Releases 2nd Edition of 'Digital Threat Report 2025-26' for India's BFSI and Payments Ecosystem

In July 2026, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (**MeitY**), released the second edition of the Digital Threat Report 2025–26 for the Banking, Financial Services and Insurance (**BFSI**) and payments ecosystem.

- The report was jointly released by the MeitY, the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (**CERT-In**), the Computer Security Incident Response Team in Finance (**CSIRT- Fin**) and SISA (SISA Information Security).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 2nd Edition of 'Digital Threat Report 2025-26 released
- ✓ **Who?** MeitY with CERT-In, CSIRT-Fin, SISA
- ✓ **Purpose:** Assessment of emerging cyber threats
- ✓ **Research:** Based on DFIR research
- ✓ **Attack Trends:** Attacks evolved from isolated threats into routine attack vectors
- ✓ **Timeline:** 18 months
- ✓ **Risk Management:** Continuous risk assessment required
- ✓ **New Framework:** Anatomy of Cyber Failure – 4 layer Gap Archetype Framework.

Highlights of the Report:

Objective: The report provides a comprehensive assessment of emerging cyber threats, evolving attack patterns, and key cybersecurity trends.

- It aims to serve as a strategic resource for policymakers, government agencies, industry stakeholders, and cybersecurity professionals in enhancing preparedness against current and future digital risks.

Research Foundation: The report is based on extensive Digital Forensics and Incident Response (DFIR) research, analysis aligned with CERT-In and CSIRT-Fin observations, and in-depth research on adversarial Artificial Intelligence (AI).

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Cyber Threat Trends: The report stated that six of seven predictions from its previous edition have become a reality, with the gap between cyber threat emergence and exploitation reducing from years to months or weeks.

- It highlighted that established threats like social engineering, credential theft, supply-chain compromise and cloud exploitation are increasingly disguised as legitimate activities, making attacks harder to detect.

Attack Trends: The assessment highlights that social engineering, credential theft, supply-chain attacks, and the exploitation of cloud environments have evolved from isolated or emerging threats into routine attack vectors.

- They are now employed to target financial institutions and the technology ecosystem.

AI-Driven Cyber Risks: The report identified **AI asymmetry** as a major risk for financial institutions, noting that cyberattacks once requiring expert skills and extensive resources can now be executed rapidly by low-resource threat actors, while defensive and regulatory systems struggle to keep pace.

- The report highlighted that threats such as social engineering, credential theft, supply-chain attacks and cloud exploitation have become common attack methods, with cybercriminals increasingly disguising malicious activities as legitimate transactions or user actions.

Timeline: The report sets out an **18-month** roadmap for financial institutions.

Risk Management: The report highlights the need to move beyond periodic security interventions towards **continuous risk assessment**, coordinated response and stronger information sharing.

New Framework: The report introduces a new analytical framework called the '**Anatomy of Cyber Failure – 4 layer Gap Archetype Framework**'.

- It is a model that explains how a cyberattack progresses from initial weakness to a **full-scale security breach** by identifying gaps across four layers of an organisation's cybersecurity.

About Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In):

CERT-In was formed by the Government of India (GoI) under Section 70B of the Information Technology Act, 2000. It functions under the MeitY.

- It is the national nodal agency for responding to computer security incidents as and when they occur.

Director General **(DG) –** Dr. Sanjay Bahl
Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 2004

India's Exports Reach USD 232.73 Billion in Q1 FY27: MoC&I Data

In July 2026, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry(**MoC&I**) released the Trade data for the **Q1** (Quarter 1: April-June) of Financial Year 2026-27 (**FY27**) and for the month of June 2026.

- As per the data, India's total exports during Q1FY27 stood at **USD 232.73 Billion (Bn),** recording a positive growth of **11.37%.**
- Similarly, the total imports during April-June 2026-27 is estimated at **USD 270.15 Bn,** registering a growth of 17.55%.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoC&I released the Q1FY27 and June 2026 Trade data
- ✓ **Q1 FY27 Data:**
- ✓ **Exports:** Total (USD 232.73 Bn); Merchandise (USD 129.32 Bn); Service: (USD 103.41 Bn)
- ✓ **Imports:** USD 270.15 Bn (Total); Merchandise (USD 216.18 Bn); Service (USD 53.97 Bn)
- ✓ **Trade Gap:**
- ✓ Service Trade Surplus: USD 49.43 Bn
- ✓ MerchandiseTrade Deficit: USD 86.86 Bn

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- ✓ **June 2026:**
- ✓ Total Exports: USD 73.45 Billion
- ✓ Total Imports: USD 88.76 Billion
- ✓ **Top Export Growth Markets (Q1 FY27):** Tanzania, Sri Lanka, Singapore, South Africa & China
- ✓ **Top Import Growth Sources (Q1 FY27):** Oman, Brazil, Russia, China & USA.

Q1 FY27 Findings:

Exports: Merchandise exports during Q1 FY27 stood at **USD 129.32 Bn**, compared to USD 111.57 Bn during Q1 FY26.

- Non-petroleum and non-gems & jewellery exports during the same period stood at USD 99.04 Bn, compared to USD 87.88 Bn the previous year.
- The estimated value of service exports during April-June 2026-27 is USD 103.41 Bn as compared to USD 97.41 Bn in April-June 2025-26.

Imports: Merchandise imports during Q1 FY27 stood at **USD 216.18 Bn**, compared to USD 180.31 Bn during Q1 FY26.

- Non-petroleum and non-gems & jewellery imports during the same period stood at USD 140.22 Bn, compared to USD 117.92 Bn the previous year.
- The estimated value of service imports during April-June 2026-27 is USD 53.97 Bn as compared to USD 49.51 Bn in April-June 2025-26.

Trade Gap: Merchandise trade deficit during Q1 FY27 was **USD 86.86 Bn** as compared to USD 68.75Bn during Q1 FY26.

- The services trade surplus for April-June 2026-27 is USD 49.43 Bn as compared to USD 47.90 Bn in April-June 2025-26.

June 2026 Findings:

Total Exports: India's total exports (Merchandise and Services combined) for June 2026 is estimated at **USD 73.45 Bn**, registering a positive growth of **9.48 %** vis-à-vis June 2025.

- Merchandise exports during June 2026 were **USD 40.41 Bn** as compared to USD 34.98 Bn in June 2025.
- Non-petroleum and non-gems & jewellery exports in June 2026 were **USD 33.13 Bn** compared to USD 28.73 Bn in June 2025.

Total Imports: The total imports (merchandise and services combined) for June 2026 are estimated at **USD 88.76 Bn**, reflecting a 26.85% increase over June 2025.

- Merchandise imports during June 2026 amounted to **USD 70.84 Bn**, compared with USD 54.08 Bn in June 2025.
- Non-petroleum, non-gems & jewellery (gold, silver & precious metals) imports in June 2026 were **USD 48.25 Bn** compared to USD 36.73 Bn in June 2025.

Services Performance: Services exports for June 2026 are estimated at **USD 33.03 Bn**, compared to USD 32.11 Bn in June 2025.

- Services imports for June 2026 are estimated at **USD 17.92 Bn**, compared to USD 15.90 Bn in June 2025.

Export Destinations:

June 2026: The top five export destinations showing positive growth in export value were Oman (189.6%), South Africa (114.04%), Malaysia (99.18%), Singapore (48.91%), and China (31.49%).

Q1 FY27: The top five export destinations showing positive growth in export value compared to April–June 2025-26 were Tanzania (146.89%), Sri Lanka (124.63%), Singapore (101.16%), South Africa (76.49%), and China (27.54%).

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Import Destinations

June 2026: The top five import sources, in terms of value growth during June 2026 compared to June 2025, were: Russia (85.02%), China (40.26%), the United States of America (USA) (33.86%) the United Arab Emirates (24.62%) and Taiwan (135.03%).

Q1 FY27: The top 5 import sources registering highest growth in import value during April-June 2026-27, compared to the previous year were: Russia (52.68%), China (27.94%), Oman (221.81%), the USA (23.82%) and Brazil (174.69%).

Trade Data of June 2026 and Q1 FY27:

		June 2026 (USD Bn)	April-June 2026-27 (USD Bn)
Merchandise	Exports	40.41	129.32
	Imports	70.84	216.18
Services	Exports	33.03	103.41
	Imports	17.92	53.97
Total Trade	Exports	73.45	232.73
	Imports	88.76	270.15

About Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I):

Union Minister – Piyush Goyal (Rajya Sabha, Maharashtra)
Minister of State (**MoS) –** Jitin Prasada (Pilibhit, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

MoSPI Releases the First Trial Index of Services Production for India's Services Sector

In July 2026, the National Statistics Office (**NSO**), Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (**MoSPI**) launched the **1st** trial Sub-sectoral "**Index of Services Production (ISP)**", India's first official monthly indicator of services-sector output, complementing the Index of Industrial Production (**IIP**).

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** NSO releases 1st trial sub-sectoral ISP
- ✓ **Purpose:** Capture the performance of service sector
- ✓ **Significance:** Service sector contribute 50% of GVA, 30% employment, 40 million jobs
- ✓ **Base Year:** 2024-25
- ✓ **Released:** 29th every month, 60 days lag

Coverage Details

- **Sectors:** 19, 60% of service sector, only formal sector enterprises
- **Excluded:** Informal and non-market sectors

ISP Framework

- **Compilation:** TAC-ISP provided the guidance

Top Sectors

- **Monthly growth:** Top 5 sub-sectors: Accommodation and food (37.2%), Retail trade (30.8%), Administrative & support services (28.7%), Real estate (27.7%) and Telecommunications (22.8%).
- **Yearly Growth:** Top 5 sub-sectors: Accommodation and food (35.6%), Retail trade (30.5%), Repair services (25.1%), Wholesale trade (23.6%) and Road transport (22.6%).

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- **Deflators:** WPI, CPI-general, CPI-Services

ISP Purpose

Objective: The ISP is a new macroeconomic indicator to capture the performance of the services sector.

- It is India's first **high-frequency indicator** dedicated to measuring services sector output.
- It tracks short-term changes in the volume of output produced by the **formal services** sector relative to a specified base year.

Service Sector Significance: Service Sector is the largest contributor to India's GDP (Gross Domestic Product), contributing over **50%** of the Gross Value Added (GVA) since 2013-14.

- The sector accounts for **30%** of total employment across India and generated **40 million** jobs over the past six years.
- The Government aims to position India as a world leader in services, targeting a **10%** share in global services by 2047.

Base Year: The base year of ISP has been selected as **2024-25.** It is aligned with other sub-sectors that use the new Consumer Price Index (**CPI**) series.

Released: The ISP will be released on the **29th** of each month, with a lag of 60 days.

Coverage Details

Coverage: The MoSPI released the ISP for April 2026 covering **19** services sub-sectors, accounting for around 60% of India's services sector.

- Out of the 19 sub-sectors, **14** recorded double-digit growth in April 2026, compared to April, 2025.
- The index covers only formal sector enterprises.

Excluded: Services linked to core government functions or dominated by the informal and non-market sectors are not included in the index.

ISP Framework

ISP Compilation: The Technical Advisory Committee on Index of Services Production (**TAC-ISP**) constituted in May 2025 provided the conceptual & methodological guidance on compiling ISP.

Data Sources

Sources: The three principal data sources are:

- **Administrative/secondary data** for ISP of Air Transport, Railway Transport, Water Transport, Banking and Insurance.
- **ASISSE** (Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises) data (once available) for health and education (excluding Government) sectors.
- **GST** (Goods and Services Tax) data for sectors including Wholesale and Retail Trade, Accommodation & Food, Road Transport, Telecommunications, Real Estate, IT Services, Professional Services and Administrative Services.

Top Sectors

Monthly Growth: Top 5 sub–sectors with strong monthly growth include:

- Accommodation and food (37.2%)
- Retail trade (30.8%)
- Administrative & support services (28.7%)
- Real estate (27.7%) and
- Telecommunications (22.8%).

Yearly Growth: The yearly top 5 sub-sectors for 2025-26 include:

- Accommodation and food (35.6%),
- Retail trade (30.5%)
- Repair services (25.1%)
- Wholesale trade (23.6%) and

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- Road transport (22.6%).

Use of Deflators

Deflators: At present, for compiling ISP:

- Wholesale Price Index (**WPI**) is used as a deflator for wholesale trade and for other subsectors
- **CPI–General** is applied to repair & maintenance, banking, and insurance
- **CPI–Services** is used for sectors where a specific CPI is not available.

Note: Primary service data is collected in value terms, capturing both price changes and value addition. A price deflator is applied to remove the effect of price changes from nominal service revenue.

- A price deflator transforms "**value-based**" (nominal) data into "**volume-based**" (real) data, providing accurate measurement of actual changes over time.

Important Terms

Wholesale Price Index (WPI): It is an index which tracks the changes in the prices of goods at the wholesale level in an economy. The base year is 2022-23.

Consumer Price Index (CPI): The index measures the changes in the price level of basket of consumer goods and services purchased by the households. The base year is 2024=100.

Index of Industrial Production (IIP): The IIP is a key statistical tool used to measure the short-term changes in the volume of production in Indian industries. The base year is 2022-23.

About Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI):

Minister of State (**MoS**) (Independent Charge, IC) – Rao Inderjit Singh (Constituency- Gurugram, Haryana)

UN Releases First Scientific Report on AI, Urges Stronger Global Governance

In July 2026, the United Nations **(UN)** released the Preliminary Report of the Independent International Scientific Panel on Artificial Intelligence **(AI),** the first UN-commissioned scientific assessment of AI.

- The report warns that AI development is **outpacing global governance** and urges governments to strengthen regulatory frameworks.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of UN's first scientific report on AI
- ✓ **Name of Report:** *'Preliminary Report of the Independent International Scientific Panel on AI'*
- ✓ **Panel Size:** 40 member panel co-chaired by Yoshua Bengio & Maria Ressa
- ✓ **Objective: S**cientific assessment of AI opportunities, risks, and governance
- ✓ **Global AI Leaders:** USA (75% compute capacity, 59 AI models), China (15%, 35 AI models), Rest of World (10%, 13 AI models).

Highlights of the Report:

Panel: Prepared by a **40-member** Independent International Scientific Panel on AI, comprising scientists and experts from all five UN regions, co-chaired by Turing Award laureate **Yoshua Bengio** and Nobel Peace Prize laureate **Maria Ressa.**

Objective: Provides an independent scientific assessment of AI opportunities, risks, and governance for evidence-based policymaking.

Coverage: Evaluates AI's impact across science, healthcare, education, agriculture, economy, security, environment, human rights, democracy, governance, and reliability.

Key Concern: The report warns that frontier AI development is advancing faster than global governance, causing fragmented safeguards and concentration of AI capabilities among a few countries and companies.

- The report highlights the global AI imbalance, with the United States of America (USA) leading with 75% of global compute capacity and 59 AI models, followed by China with 15% compute capacity and 35 AI models, while the Rest of the World accounts for 10% compute capacity and 13 AI models.

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PLFS Monthly Bulletin – June 2026: UR Remains Unchanged at 5.5%

In July 2026, the National Statistical Office (**NSO**) under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) released **Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Monthly Bulletin: June 2026, 15th** in the series covering both rural and urban areas.

- As per this report, India's overall Unemployment Rate (**UR**) for people aged 15 years and above remained unchanged at **5.5%** in June 2026, compared with May 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** PLFS Monthly Bulletin – June 2026 released
- ✓ **Released By:** National Statistical Office, MoSPI
- ✓ **Unemployment Rate (UR):**
  - Overall: 5.5% (Age 15 years & above); Rural: 5.0%; Urban: 6.6%
- ✓ **Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR):**
  - Overall: 54.4%; Rural: 56.6%; Urban: 50.1%
- ✓ **Worker Population Ratio (WPR):** Overall: 51.4%; Rural: 53.8%; Urban: 46.8%.

About Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS):

Launch & Conducting Agency: The PLFS is a continuous survey conducted by the NSO under the MoSPI, launched in April 2017.

Objective: It estimates key employment and unemployment indicators, including Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR), Worker Population Ratio (WPR), and Unemployment Rate (UR).

Methodology Update: From January 2025, the PLFS methodology was revised to provide monthly labour market estimates for the entire country, improving data timeliness and coverage.

Data Approach & Importance: The Current Weekly Status **(CWS)** approach is used for monthly and quarterly estimates, assessing activity status during the seven days preceding the survey date.

- PLFS data supports evidence-based policymaking for employment generation, skill development, and poverty reduction.

Key Finding PLFS – June 2026:

Sample Size: At the all-India level, the monthly estimates are based on information collected from a total number of **3,72,852** persons surveyed.

- The number of persons surveyed in rural areas was 2,12,390 (48,996 households) and 1,60,462 (39,979 households) in urban areas.

Unemployment Rate (UR):

Definition: A person was considered as unemployed in a week if he/she did not work even for **1 hour** on any day during the reference week.

UR: The rural UR for persons of age 15 years and above decreased marginally from 5.1% in May 2026 to **5.0%** in June 2026**,** while urban UR increased slightly from 6.4% to **6.6%.**

Rural Area: The UR among rural male of age 15 years and above was **4.9%** in June 2026 and UR of rural females was around **5.0%.**

Urban Area: In urban areas UR (%) among females of age 15 years and above during June, 2026 was **8.4%** compared to **6.0%** observed for male of the same age group.

Age 15-29 years: The UR among persons of age 15-29 years during June 2026 was **16.2%**.

- The UR among male was **14.6%** and **20.7%** among females.

Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR):

Definition: Labour force, according to CWS, is the number of persons either employed or unemployed on an average in a week of **7 days** preceding the date of survey.

Above 15 years: The LFPR for persons of age 15 years and above in the country stood at **54.4%** in June 2026.

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- LFPR (%) in CWS for persons of age 15 years and above in rural and urban areas stood at **56.6%** and **50.1%**, respectively.

Rural Areas: In June 2026, the LFPR among persons aged 15 years and above was **77.9%** for rural males and **36.6%** for rural females.

Urban Areas: In urban areas, LFPR (%) among females of age 15 years and above during June, 2026 was **24.8%** compared to **75.3%** observed for male of the same age group.

Age 15-29 years: The LFPR among persons of age 15-29 years during June 2026 was **40.3%**.

- The LFPR among male was **60.3%** and **20.1%** among females.

Worker Population Ratio (WPR):

Definition: The estimate of workforce in the CWS provides the number of persons who worked for at least 1 hour on any day during the **7 days** preceding the date of survey.

Above 15 years: In June 2026, the WPR based on the CWS for persons aged 15 years and above was **51.4%** at the all-India level, with **53.8%** in rural areas and **46.8%** in urban areas.

Rural Areas: In June 2026, the WPR among persons aged 15 years and above was **74.1%** for rural males and **34.7%** for rural females.

Urban Areas: Among urban persons aged 15 years and above, the WPR stood at **70.7%** for males and **22.7%** for females in June 2026.

Age 15-29 years: The WPR among persons of age 15-29 years during June 2026 was **33.8%**.

- Among this age group, the WPR stood at **51.5%** for males and **15.9%** for females.

UR, LFPR and WPR – June 2026:

Type	Rural	Urban	Overall
Unemployment Rate (UR)	5.0%	6.6%	5.5%
Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR)	56.6%	50.1%	54.4%
Worker Population Ratio (WPR)	53.8%	46.8%	51.4%

About Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI):

Minister of State (**MoS)** (Independent Charge, IC) – Rao Inderjit Singh (Constituency: Gurgaon, Haryana)

MoSPI Releases Quarterly Update of PAIMANA Dashboard to Track Infrastructure Sector in India

In July 2026, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation **(MoSPI)** released the quarterly update of the 'Project Assessment, Infrastructure Monitoring & Analytics for Nation-building (PAIMANA)' performance dashboard which presents the performance of key infrastructure sectors through a set of standardized indicators.

- The latest quarterly release has added **44 new indicators**, thereby expanding India's infrastructure monitoring framework to **165** indicators.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of Quarterly Update of PAIMANA Dashboard
- ✓ **Released by:** MoSPI
- ✓ **Purpose of Dashboard:** To track the performance of key infrastructure sectors
- ✓ **Expansion of Dashboard:** to 165 indicators (44 new indicators)
- ✓ **Key Sectors Covered:** 6 (Civil Aviation, Roads, electricity, Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Telecommunications, and Railways)

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- ✓ **Civil Aviation:** Cargo transport 98,920.10 tonnes (+115% YoY); operational aerodromes increased to 165
- ✓ **Telecommunications**: Mobile data usage 2,85,376 PB; tele-density 93.26%.
- ✓ **Roads:** 9,360 km of National Highways constructed during FY26
- ✓ **Railways**: Broad Gauge wagon carrying capacity increased to 64 tonnes/wagon
- ✓ **Power**: Energy storage requirement projected to rise from 87 GWh to 888 GWh by 2035–36.

About PAIMANA Dashboard:

Aim: The performance monitoring dashboard, originally launched on 16th April 2026, aimed to strengthen infrastructure monitoring and evidence-based policymaking to provide a comprehensive overview of the performance of key infrastructure sub-sectors.

Key Sectors: The dashboard is designed to track infrastructure performance across 6 key sectors, including civil aviation (31 indicators), roads (8 indicators), electricity (14 indicators), ports, shipping and waterways (62 indicators), telecommunications (13 indicators), and railways (37 indicators).

Assessment: The dashboard examines sector-wise infrastructure performance using a standardized framework based on **five key dimensions** that include: access, quality, fiscal cost & revenue, utilization, and affordability.

Sector-wise Performance:

Civil Aviation: The quarterly update revealed a total of 98,920.10 tonnes of cargo was transported in April 2026, marking an increase of 115% compared to April 2025.

- **Operational Aerodromes:** Also, the number of aerodromes nearly doubled over the last 10 years, from 81 (2014) **to 165 (at present).**
- **Key Progress:** In the 1st two months of Financial Year 2026-27 (FY27) i.e. from April 2026 to May 2026, passenger traffic reached 7.1 crore and cargo handled stood at 7.3 lakh tonnes (registering 10.6% growth over the same period of last financial year), and facilitated 10.52 lakh foreign tourist arrivals.

Telecommunications: As per the data, wireless/mobile data consumption reached **2,85,376 petabytes (PB)** during FY 26, registering 24.7% growth Year-on-Year (Y-o-Y).

- **Telephone subscribers:** During the same time period, the number of telephone subscribers increased to 133.06 crore (from 120.17 crore in FY25), recording a 10.7% growth.
- **Telecom Infrastructure:** Also, the total number of mobile towers has increased to 8.55 lakh (3.7% growth YoY) and similarly, total number of Base Transceiver Stations (BTS) reached 32.25 lakh (7.4% growth YoY) in FY26.
- **Tele-density:** The data also showed that tele-density reached 93.26% in FY26, reflecting deeper digital connectivity.

Road, Transport and Highways: 9,360 kilometres (kms) of National Highways (NHs) were constructed during FY26.

- **Digital Tolling:** Also, electronic toll collection transactions reached Rs. 88 crores (39.7% YoY) in FY 27 (up to May, 2026).

Ports, Shipping & Waterways: During FY 25, non-major ports recorded 2.06 crore passenger traffic. Also, the coastal cargo handling at major and non-ports increased to 196,808.7 thousand tonnes (+3.09% Y-o-Y) and 142,219.4 thousand tonnes, respectively.

Railways: The average carrying capacity of BroadGauge wagons increased to a record 64.0 tonnes per wagon in 2024–25, against 60.8 tonnes in 2015–16.

- Also, the average number of passengers carried per day reached 19.98 million in 2024-25, registering 5.8% growth over the previous year.

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Power: As per the report, India's storage requirements is estimated to increase **more than 10-times** over the next 10 years i.e. from 87 Gigawatt-hour (GWh) (in 2027–28) **to 888 GWh (by 2035–36),** driven by the rapid deployment of Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) and Pumped Storage Plants (PSPs).

- It further projected that energy storage capacity would increase significantly across both major technologies i.e. to 94 GW for PSP and 80 GW for BESS, by 2035-36.

About Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementaion (MoSPI):

Minister of State **(MoS)** (Independent Charge, IC)-Rao Inderjit Singh (Constituency- Gurugram, Haryana)

UN SOFI Report 2026: Global Hunger Eases Marginally, Zero Hunger Target Remains Off Track

In July 2026, the United Nations (UN) Food and Agriculture Organization**(FAO)** released its latest report titled "The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI 2026): Understanding and Addressing the High Cost of a Healthy Diet". The report estimated **645 million people** (accounting for **7.8%** of the global population) faced hunger in 2025, marking a slight decline compared to the previous year (8.1%).

- However, the world is still far off track to meet the UN-mandated Sustainable Development Goal (SDG-2) i.e. zero hunger by 2030.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of UN's SOFI Report 2026
- ✓ **Released by:** UN FAO
- ✓ **Report Prepared by:** UN's 5 agencies, including FAO, IFAD, UNICEF, WFP and WHO
- ✓ **Global Hunger (2025):** 645 million people (7.8% of the global population).
- ✓ **Key Projection for 2030:** 511-520 million decrease in undernourished people
- ✓ **Region-wise Undernourished People:** Africa (309 million people); Asia (292 million people)
- ✓ **Global Average of CoHD:** USD 4.28 per person per day in PPP (2025)
- ✓ **India's Performance:** Undernourished people (142.5 million, -42% in 20 years); CoHD (USD 4.11 per person per day in PPP); People unable to afford a healthy diet (520.1 million)

About UN's SOFI Report:

Overview: It is the UN system's flagship assessment of global hunger, food insecurity and malnutrition. It monitors the progress towards SDG-2 goal through latest global and regional estimates on food insecurity, diet quality and the nutrition targets

Prepared by: The report is prepared by **5** specialized agencies of the UN: Food and Agriculture Organisation **(FAO),** International Fund for Agricultural Development (**IFAD)**, UN Children's Fund (**UNICEF)**, World Food Programme (**WFP**) and World Health Organisation (**WHO**).

Global Scenario:

Global Hunger Trend: Despite the decline, the number of hungry people in 2025 remained 61 million higher than pre-COVID-19 (2019) levels.

- While the global hunger prevalence fell slightly to 7.8% in 2025 from 8% in 2015, the total number of people facing hunger has increased by nearly 50 million over the same period.

Key Risks: The report outlined **three emerging risks** that could reverse recent progress before the deadline of 2030: the 2026 conflict in West Asia, the extreme weather events, and cuts to official development assistance and humanitarian funding.

Key Projection for 2030: The report further estimated that the number of chronically undernourished people could decrease to nearly **511 million by 2030** under a quick-recovery scenario.

- But, if disruption to oil, gas and fertilizer supplies persists, then, the number could be as high as 522 million.

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Epicentre of Hunger: For the first time since such data has been tracked, **Africa** has replaced Asia as the region with the largest number of undernourished people, reaching 309 million people in 2025 (20% of global population), compared with 292 million in Asia (6%).

- As per the report, one in five people in Africa now face hunger, marking an increase of 81% since 2010, driven by conflict, climate change, debt and dependence on food imports.

Cost of Healthy Diet (CoHD): The CoHD increased by nearly 25% over the last 4 years, reaching **USD 4.28** per person per day in Purchasing Power Parity (PPP) in 2025 over USD 3.44 in 2021.

Healthy Diets: The report highlighted that **2.69 billion people** (37.4%) in 2025 could not afford a healthy diet compared to 2.97 billion 2021.

- It further showed regional disparities remained significant as 66% of Africa's population could not afford a healthy diet, more than double the share in Asia, and Latin America and the Caribbean.

India-Specific:

Undernourished People: As per the report, India's undernourished population has declined by nearly **42%** over the last 20 years i.e. from 243.9 million (21.1%) in 2004-06 to **142.5 million** (9.8%) in 2023-25. But, still 100 million people face hunger in the country.

- The report further showed that 520.1 million people (35.5% of the population) fell into the undernourished category, down from 59.8% (in 2017).

Healthy Diet: The report further showed that the number of Indians unable to afford a healthy diet also declined 29% over the last 6 years (2019-25), to 520.1 million in 2025.

CoHD: The report showed that the cost of a healthy diet in India increased to USD 4.11 per person per day in PPP terms in 2025.

- However, the cost of a healthy diet in India was the lowest among all South Asian countries except Pakistan, whose cost stood at USD 3.94, while in Bangladesh (USD 4.59), Sri Lanka (USD 5.21) and Bhutan (USD 6.17).

Performance across other Key Indicators: In 2024, close to a third of Indian children (nearly 32.9%) under five, were stunted, down from 41.7 % (in 2012), child wasting, indicator to measure malnutrition, was 18.7% during the same time period, still higher than average global rate.

- In contrast, obesity in children continues to increase i.e. from 2.1 % to 3.7% over the same period.
- The report further showed anaemia among women (aged 15 to 49) increased from 50.1% to 53.7%.

About Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO):

Director-General **(DG)-** Qu Dongyu
Headquarters- Rome, Italy
Established- 1945

APPOINTMENTS & RESIGNATIONS

ACC Reappoints Ravi Agrawal as CBDT Chairman for Another Six Months

In June 2026, the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet **(ACC)**, chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, approved the re-appointment of **Ravi Agrawal** as Chairman of the Central Board of Direct Taxes **(CBDT)** on contract basis for another 6 months, starting from **July 1, 2026.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Re-appointment of Chairman of CBDT
- ✓ **Who?** Ravi Agrawal

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- ✓ **Re-appointed by:** ACC
- ✓ **Term:** 6 Months (from July 01, 2026)

Key Details of Re-appointment:

Term of Service: As per the official notification, he will remain at the post **till December 31, 2026,** or until further orders, whichever is earlier, on the usual terms and conditions applicable to re-employed central government officers, in relaxation of the recruitment rules.

Previous Tenure: He was initially appointed as chairman of CBDT for one-year term in June 2024, succeeding **Nitin Gupta.**

- Later, the Government of India (GoI) extended his tenure by one year i.e. until June 2026.

Previous Role: Prior to his appointment as CBDT Chairman, he served as Member (Administration) in CBDT from July 2023.

About CBDT: It is the apex body for direct tax administration under the Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance (MoF). It was established in 1964 and is headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi.

HDFC Bank Appoints Rajiv Kumar as Part-time Chairman

In July 2026, **HDFC Bank Limited** appointed **Rajiv Kumar,** former Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) of India, as its part-time Chairman for a period of **3 years,** effective from the date as approved by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Part-time Chairman of HDFC Bank
- ✓ **Who?** Rajiv Kumar
- ✓ **Term:** 3 years
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Keki Mistry
- ✓ **Additional Charge:** Additional Director (Independent)(4 years)

Key Details of Appointment:

Predecessor: He will take over from **Keki Mistry,** who was appointed as interim chairman of the bank, after **Atanu Chakraborty,** who voluntarily step-down in March 2026 citing ethical concerns.

Additional Charge: He has also been appointed as an **Additional Independent Director** of HDFC Bank for a term of four years, effective from June 30, 2026.

About Rajiv Kumar:

Administrative Career: He is a 1984-batch Indian Administrative Officer (IAS) officer.

Role at Centre Government: Previously, he served as Secretary of Department of Financial Services (DFS) which works under the Ministry of Finance (MoF), from 2017 to 2020.

- He also served as 25th CEC of India, monitoring the 2024 Lok Sabha (Lower House of the Parliament) elections.

Financial Sector: Other than his administrative career, he headed most prominent financial bodies in India such as: the Central Board of RBI, the
Financial Stability and Development Council (FSDC), Bank Boards Bureau (BBB), to boards of State Bank of India (SBI) and National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD).

- Post-his retirement from public service, he briefly served as Chairman of the Public Enterprises Selection Board (PSEB).

About HDFC Bank:

Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer **(MD & CEO) –** Sashidhar Jagdishan
Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra
Established – 1994

RBI Appoints Ravi Shankar as its Executive Director

In July 2026, the Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) appointed **Ravi Shankar** as Executive Director (ED), effective from **1 July 2026**. He will oversee the Department of Statistics and Information Management **(DSIM).**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed Executive Director of RBI.
- ✓ **Who?** Ravi Shankar.
- ✓ **Effective from?** July 1, 2026.
- ✓ **Portfolio?** Department of Statistics and Information Management.

About Ravi Shankar:

Profile: A central banker and statistician with over three decades of experience at RBI, working across banking statistics, corporate data, government securities markets, settlement systems, debt management and economic analysis.

Previous Role: Shankar was serving as **Adviser-In-Charge** of the **DISM**

DSIM: It is responsible for statistical data collection, compilation and analysis at the RBI, covering banking and corporate statistics, surveys, and data used for monetary and financial analysis.

About RBI: Established in 1935 under the **RBI Act, 1934**, RBI is India's central bank responsible for monetary policy, currency management and regulation of the financial system.

RBI Structure: RBI has **15 EDs** and **1 Chief Financial Officer** (CFO) overseeing key departments, with Gunveer Singh recently appointed as ED of the Department of Payment and Settlement Systems (**DPSS**).

Air Marshal 'Ashutosh Dixit' Assumes Charge as 51st Vice Chief of Air Staff of IAF

On 1 July 2026, Air Marshal **Ashutosh Dixit**, former Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (CISC), assumed charge as **51st** Vice Chief of Air Staff (**VCAS**) of the Indian Air Force (**IAF**) at Air Headquarters, New Delhi, Delhi.

- He succeeded Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor, who retired from IAF on 30 June 2026 after nearly four decades of distinguished service.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of 51st VCAS of IAF
- ✓ **Who?** Air Marshal 'Ashutosh Dixit'
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor (retired on 30 June 2026)
- ✓ **Previous role:** CISC from 1 May 2025 to 30 June 2026
- ✓ **Honours:** PVSM (2026), AVSM (2023), VM (2006), and VSM (2011).

About Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit:

Leadership: Previously served as CISC from 1 May 2025 to 30 June 2026, contributing to tri-service operational integration, joint doctrines, RanSamwad 2025–26, Combined and Joint Commanders' Conferences, and the Defence Forces Vision 2047 roadmap.

Commands: Commanded a Mirage-2000 squadron, key fighter bases, and the Flight Test Squadron at the Aircraft and Systems Testing Establishment (ASTE), besides serving as Assistant Chief of Air Staff (Projects & Plans) (ACAS), Deputy Chief of Air Staff (DCAS), and Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief (AOC-in-C), Central Air Command (CAC).

Operations: Participated in Operation Safed Sagar (Kargil War, 1999) and Operation Rakshak (counter-insurgency in Jammu & Kashmir, J&K).

Honours: Awarded the Param Vishisht Seva Medal (PVSM) (2026), Ati Vishisht Seva Medal (AVSM) (2023), Vayu Sena Medal (VM) (2006), and Vishisht Seva Medal (VSM) (2011).

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Bijay Kumar Mohanty Assumes Additional Charge as CMD of IREDA

In July 2026, **Bijay Kumar Mohanty**, currently serving as Director (Finance) and Chief Financial Officer **(CFO)** of the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Limited **(IREDA)**, assumed additional charge as Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of IREDA for the period of **three Months.**

- The appointment is effective from 1 July 2026, following the superannuation of **Pradip Kumar Das** on 30 June 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Bijay Kumar Mohanty Assumes Additional Charge
- ✓ **Position:** CMD (Additional Charge), IREDA
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Pradip Kumar Das
- ✓ **Effective Date:** 1 July 2026
- ✓ **Roles:** Director (Finance) and CFO, IREDA; Director, IREDA Global Green Energy Finance IFSC Ltd
- ✓ **Experience:** 27+ years in Indian power and renewable energy sector

About Bijay Kumar:

Position: He serves on the Board of IREDA Global Green Energy Finance IFSC Limited, a wholly-owned subsidiary of IREDA.

Professional Experience: He has over **27 years** of experience in India's power and renewable energy sector, having served in senior positions at REC Limited, REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited (RECPDCL), Central Electricity Company of Odisha limited (CESCO), and Grid Corporation of Odisha Limited (GRIDCO).

Areas of Expertise: Expertise in project financing, financial management and accounts, treasury operations, project appraisal and execution management, and commercial and legal functions.

About IREDA: IREDA is a Government-owned Navratna Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), Government of India. It provides financial support for renewable energy projects including solar, wind, hydro, green hydrogen, and energy storage.

Keiko Fujimori Wins Peru Presidential Election 2026 in a Runoff

In June 2026**, Keiko Fujimori,** leader of the conservative Popular Force party, was declared the **winner** of Peru's **2026 presidential election** following a closely contested runoff.

- She is scheduled to assume office on 28 July 2026, succeeding **interim President José María Balcázar** and becoming Peru's 10th President in a decade.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Winning at Peru Presidential Election
- ✓ **Who?** Keiko Fujimori
- ✓ **Party:** Popular Force Party
- ✓ **Vote Share:** 50.135%
- ✓ **Assumption of Office:** 28 July 2026
- ✓ **Succeeds:** Interim President José María Balcázar

Election Result:

Victory: Keiko Fujimori won Peru's presidential runoff election on 7 June 2026, receiving 50.135% of the votes and defeating **Roberto Sánchez,** who secured 49.865%.

Margin: Fujimori's victory margin was fewer than 50,000 votes out of around 18 million ballots cast, making it a closely contested election.

First-Round Contest: The presidential runoff followed the first round held in April 2026, which saw 33 candidates contesting the election.

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About Keiko Fujimori:

Profile: She is the daughter of former Peruvian President **Alberto Fujimori** and a leading figure of the Fujimorism political movement.

First Lady of Peru: She served as the First Lady of Peru from **1994 to 2000**, representing the ceremonial role during her father's presidency.

Member of Congress: She was elected as a Member of Congress for Lima (2006–2011), marking her formal entry into national politics.

Leadership: She has led the Popular Force Party since 2010, strengthening the Fujimorist political base, and contested the presidential elections four times (2011, 2016, 2021, and 2026), finally securing victory in 2026 after earlier defeats.

About Peru:

Capital – Lima

Currency – Peruvian Sol (PEN)

Rear Admiral C. Raghuram Assumed Charge as New CMD of HSL

In July 2026, **Rear Admiral (Retd.) Chadrasekhran (C.) Raghuram,** officially took charge as the new Chairman and Managing Director **(CMD)** of Hindustan Shipyard Limited **(HSL)** in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh (AP).

- He succeeded **Captain Ganti Venkateswarlu,** who had been holding the additional charge since January 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** New CMD of HSL
- ✓ **Who?** Rear Admiral (Retd.) Chandrasekhran (C.) Raghuram
- ✓ **Succeeded:** Captain Ganti Venkateswarlu
- ✓ **Previous Role**: Assistant Chief of Materiel, IN.

About Chadrasekhran Raghuram:

Career: He was commissioned into the Indian Navy (IN) on November 10, 1989, brings over 35 years of experience in naval engineering, ship maintenance and strategic planning.

Previous Role: Prior to his appointment as CMD of HSL, Raghuram was serving as the Assistant Chief of Material, monitoring the maintenance of key naval platforms.

Leadership Roles: He held various senior leadership positions in the IN, including Commanding officer of Indian Naval Ship (INS) Valsura, Principal Director (Electrical Engineering) at the Integrated Headquarters of the Ministry of Defence (MoD) (Navy); Command Electrical Officer at the Eastern Naval Command (ENC), among others.

Award: He was honoured with the Vishisht Seva Medal (VSM) in 2017.

About HSL: Established in 1941, HSL is a 'Miniratna Category-I' Central Public Enterprise (CPSE) which works under the Ministry of Defence (MoD). It is headquartered in Visakhapatnam, AP.

Sikkim mountaineer Tshering Choden Scales Europe's highest peak Mount Elbrus

In July 2026, **Tshering Choden**, mountaineer from Sikkim, successfully scaled **Mount (Mt.) Elbrus,** Europe's highest mountain peak located at an altitude of **5,642 metres (m).**

- The successful ascent represents a major milestone in her ongoing Seven Summits challenge, which involves climbing the highest mountain on each of the seven continents.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Tshering Choden scaled Mount Elbrus, Europe's highest peak
- ✓ **Choden Hails from:** Gangtok, Sikkim
- ✓ **Mt. Elbrus:** 5,642 m

- ✓ **Significance:** 2nd successful ascent
- ✓ **Previous Expedition:** Mount Kilimanjaro, Africa's highest peak
- ✓ **Ascent Part of:** Seven Summits Challenge (7 highest peaks on each of 7 continents)
- ✓ **Remaining 5 Summits:** Mt. Everest (Asia), Aconcagua (South America), Denali (North America), Mount Vinson (Antarctica), and Mount Kosciuszko (Australia).

Key Details:

About Choden: Choden who hails from Chongay in Gangtok (Sikkim), is a graduate of the Basic Mountaineering Course from the Indian Himalayan Centre for Adventure and Eco-tourism (IHCAE) in Chemchey, South Sikkim.

Previous Summit: Also, this marked her **2nd** successful ascent in the Seven Summits challenge. Previously, she had scaled **Mount Kilimanjaro (5,895 m),** the highest peak in Africa, in August 2025.

Seven Summits: Mt. Elbrus is one of the Seven Summits which include Mt. Everest (Asia), Aconcagua (South America), Denali (North America), Mount Kilimanjaro (Africa), Mount Vinson (Antarctica), and Mount Kosciuszko (Australia).

About Mt. Elbrus:

Significance: Mount Elbrus is the highest mountain in Russia and Europe.

Location: Mt. Elbrus, part of the Caucasus mountain range, is located near the Georgian border in the south of Russia.

Twin Summits: It is a dormant stratovolcano, featuring two summits i.e. West Summit (at 5,642 m) and East Summit (at 5, 595 m).

Geographical Significance: It is home to 22 glaciers that feed 3 rivers namely: Balkan, Malka and Kuban.

1st Person to Summit Mt. Elbrus: Russia's Kabardinian Killar Khashirov, was the 1st person to summit Mt. Elbrus in 1829.

About Sikkim:

Capital- Gangtok

Chief Minister **(CM)-** Prem Singh Tamang

Governor- Om Prakash Mathur

Ramsar Site- Khachoedpalri Wetland

Govt Appoints New Chiefs for BPR&D, NCRB and SVPNPA

In July 2026, the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (**ACC**), chaired by Prime Minister (**PM**) **Narendra Modi**, approved the appointments of senior Indian Police Service (**IPS**) officers for three key police and law enforcement institutions based on proposal submitted by the Ministry of Home Affairs (**MHA**).

- **Alok Kumar Mittal** was appointed as Director General (DG) of the Bureau of Police Research and Development (BPR&D), **Amit Garg** as Director of the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), and **Sujeet Pandey** as Director of the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel National Police Academy (SVPNPA).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of new chiefs for key police institutions
- ✓ **Institutions?** BPR&D, NCRB, and SVPNPA
- ✓ **Approved By:** Appointments Committee of the Cabinet
- ✓ **BPR&D**: Alok Kumar Mittal as Director General
- ✓ **NCRB**: Amit Garg as Director
- ✓ **SVPNPA**: Sujeet Pandey as Director.

Alok Kumar Mittal as DG of BPR&D:

Tenure: A 1993-batch IPS officer of the Haryana cadre, he will hold the position from the date of assuming

charge until 30 June 2029, the date of his superannuation, or until further orders, whichever is earlier.
Responsibilities: He will lead the organisation responsible for police research, training, and policy under the MHA.
Previous Role: He currently serves as Director General (DG) of Prisons, Haryana.
Other Roles: : Served in the National Investigation Agency (NIA) and held key positions in Haryana Police, including Additional Director General (ADG), Criminal Investigation Department (CID), and Managing Director (MD), Haryana Police Housing Corporation (HPHC).

Amit Garg as Director of NCRB:

Rank Elevation: The appointment was made by temporarily elevating the Director's post to the rank of DG on a personal basis.
Tenure: Amit Garg, a 1993-batch IPS officer of the Andhra Pradesh(AP) cadre, will serve as Director of the NCRB until 31 October 2027 or until further orders. He succeeds **Alok Ranjan,** a 1991-batch IPS officer.
Previous Role: He currently serves as Director of SVPNPA.

Sujeet Pandey as Director of SVPNPA:

Succeeds: Sujeet Pandey, a 1994-batch IPS officer of the Uttar Pradesh(UP) cadre, succeeded **Amit Garg** as Director of the SVPNPA after Garg's appointment as Director of the NCRB.
Tenure: He will serve until July 31, 2028, the date of his retirement, or until further orders.
Responsibilities: He will oversees the foundational and in-service training of all IPS officer trainees.

About National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB):

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 1986

NPCI's Dilip Asbe Appointed to SWIFT Global Supervisory Board

In July 2026, **Dilip Asbe**, Managing Director (MD) and Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), was appointed to the **Supervisory Board** of the Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication **(SWIFT).**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed to SWIFT Supervisory Board
- ✓ **Who?** Dilip Asbe, MD & CEO of NPCI
- ✓ **Significance:** Strengthens India's role in global financial messaging, cross-border payments and digital-payment governance.

Highlights of Appointment:

Governance Restructuring: Asbe's appointment coincides with SWIFT's transition from a single-tier Board of Directors to a two-tier governance structure comprising a Supervisory Board and a Management Board.

- The Supervisory Board will have 12 members, expandable to 15 in exceptional cases, including eight shareholder-affiliated directors and four independent directors to meet the one-third independence requirement.

Significance: The appointment strengthens India's role in global financial messaging. The SWIFT Supervisory Board provides strategic oversight of the organisation while ensuring balanced regional representation.
About NPCI: Established in 2008, the NPCI is the umbrella organisation for retail payment systems in India, promoted by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Indian Banks' Association (IBA). It is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

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RBI Appoints Muralidhar Pai as MD & CEO of South Indian Bank

In July 2026, Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) approved the appointment of **Mahesh Muralidhar Pai** as the Managing Director **(MD)** and Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** of South Indian Bank **(SIB)** for a **3-year term** beginning on **1 October 2026.**

- He succeeds **P.R. Seshadri,** who will step down as MD & CEO of SIB and remain in office until September 30, 2026.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of MD & CEO at South Indian Bank.
- ✓ **Appointee:** Muralidhar Pai
- ✓ **Tenure:** 3-year term begins on 1 October 2026.
- ✓ **Succeeds:** P.R. Seshadri (remain in office until 30 September 2026)
- ✓ **Previous Role:** CGM at Canara Bank, Director on the Boards of KSFC and Canara Bank Securities.
- ✓ **Other Roles:** Director, Canara Bank Tanzania
- ✓ **Other Appointments:** Vishwanathan as Non-Executive (Part-time) Chairman of Axis Bank Limited.

About Muralidhar Pai:

Profile: Pai is recognized for his strategic leadership and execution capabilities, with nearly three decades of experience across governance, strategy, treasury, foreign exchange, retail banking, agriculture, and MSME (Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises) credit.

Previous Role: He currently serves as Chief General Manager (**CGM**) at Canara Bank (public-sector bank, PBS), Served as Director on the Boards of Karnataka State Financial Corporation (KSFC) and Canara Bank Securities Limited (CBSL).

Other Roles: Served as Director in Canara Bank Tanzania, representing industry bodies, including the Fixed Income Money Market and Derivatives Association of India (FIMMDA), SWIFT (Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication) India Domestic Services Private Limited and the Secondary Loan Market Association (SLMA).

RBI Approves Re-Appointment of N. S. Vishwanathan as Axis Bank's Non-Executive Chairman

RBI approved the re-appointment of Nurani Subramanian **(N. S.) Vishwanathan** as Non-Executive (Part-time) **Chairman** of **Axis Bank Limited** for three years, effective from **October 27, 2026**, to October 26, **2029**.

Approval: The approval is subject to his reappointment as an **Independent Director** by shareholders at the bank's 32nd Annual General Meeting (AGM) scheduled on July 31st.

Career: N. S. Vishwanathan, a veteran central banker who joined the RBI in 1981 and served as Deputy Governor from July 2016 to March 2020, is widely recognized for his expertise in financial regulation, macro-prudential oversight, and banking risk management.

About South Indian Bank (SIB):

Established- 1929

Headquarters – Thrissur, Kerala

Tagline – Experience Next Generation Banking

InsuranceDekho Appoints Sourav Ganguly as Brand Ambassador; Launches 'Khul Kar Khelo' Campaign

In July 2026, **InsuranceDekho**, an Insurtech platform, appointed former India cricket captain **Sourav Ganguly** as its brand ambassador and launched the **'Khul Kar Khelo' campaign** to empower insurance advisors across India.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed as Brand Ambassador of InsuranceDekho

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- ✓ **Who?** Sourav Ganguly
- ✓ **Campaign:** 'Khul Kar Khelo'
- ✓ **Objective:** To empower insurance advisors to expand their businesses, earnings and customer reach.

About 'Khul Kar Khelo' Campaign:

Theme: The campaign reflects Sourav Ganguly's image as a fearless captain who supported his team and developed a generation of successful players.

Aim: The campaign aims to help insurance advisors grow their businesses, increase earnings and expand their reach. It also seeks to strengthen their role as micro-entrepreneurs and enhance financial protection for families across India.

- The campaign will be promoted through television, digital and broadcast platforms.

About Sourav Ganguly: He was India's 39th Test captain and led the team to the 2003 ICC Cricket World Cup final. He also served as President of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) from 2019 to 2022.

About InsuranceDekho: Founded in 2016, InsuranceDekho is headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana, and operates under the legal name Girnar Insurance Brokers Private Limited.

Indian Tennis Legend Leander Paes Joins ATF as Player Ambassador

In July 2026, **Leander Paes** former, Indian professional tennis playerand Olympic medallist, was appointed as a **Player Ambassador** of the Asian Tennis Federation **(ATF)** to promote grassroots tennis, encourage youth participation and strengthen the sport across Asia.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed as Player Ambassador of the ATF
- ✓ **Who?** Leander Paes
- ✓ **Role:** Promote tennis development, grassroots programs, and youth engagement in Asia
- ✓ **Olympic Medal:** Bronze medal at the 1996 Atlanta Olympic Games
- ✓ **Awards:** Arjuna Award (1990), Padma Shri (2001), Padma Bhushan (2014).

About Leander Paes:

Profile: Leander Paes, one of India's most successful tennis players, had a professional career spanning over three decades before retiring in 2021.

Achievements: A former World No. 1 in doubles, he won the bronze medal in men's singles at the 1996 Atlanta Olympic Games in the United States of America (USA), remaining India's only tennis player to win an Olympic medal.

- He secured 18 Grand Slam titles and completed a Career Grand Slam in both categories. He also won eight Asian Games medals, including five gold medals, between 1990 and 2006.

Awards: The Government of India (GoI) honoured him with the Arjuna Award (1990), Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna Award (1996–97), now known as the Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award, Padma Shri (2001) and Padma Bhushan (2014) for his contribution in the field of Sports(tennis).

Honours: In 2024, he was inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame under the player category.

Three Indian-Origin Experts Named to Lead US Federal Reserve Monetary Policy Review Task Forces

In July 2026, the United States Federal Reserve **(US Fed)** appointed three Indian-origin experts: **Raghuram Rajan, Raj Chetty,** and **Asha Sharma**, to lead three of its five task forces reviewing the Fed's monetary policy framework under Fed Chair Kevin Warsh.

- The appointments are part of five task forces announced by US Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed to lead US Federal Reserve Monetary Policy Review Task Forces
- ✓ **Announced by:** US Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh
- ✓ **Total Task Forces:** 5
- ✓ **Indian Appointees:** Raghuram Rajan, Raj Chetty & Asha Sharma
- ✓ **Purpose:** Review the US Fed's monetary policy framework

About the Appointees:

Raghuram Rajan: Professor of Finance, University of Chicago Booth School of Business and former Governor, Reserve Bank of India **(RBI)**, appointed to the **Balance Sheet Policy** task force to review the costs, benefits, and institutional implications of the Federal Reserve's balance sheet framework.

Raj Chetty: Professor of Economics, Harvard University and Director, Opportunity Insights, appointed to the **Data** task force to improve the quality and timeliness of economic data used for monetary policy decisions.

Asha Sharma: Executive Vice President (EVP) and Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)**, Microsoft Xbox Division, appointed to the **Productivity and Jobs** task force to assess the impact of Artificial Intelligence **(AI)** and other emerging technologies on productivity, employment, and wages.

Other Task Forces: The remaining panels on Communications and Inflation Frameworks aim to modernise the US Federal Reserve's monetary policy framework.

About US Fed: Established in 1913, the US Fed is the central banking system of the United States of America (USA). It conducts a comprehensive review of its monetary policy framework approximately every five years.

Ukraine's Parliament Appoints Serhii Koretskyi as Prime Minister

On 16 July 2026, Ukraine's Parliament (Verkhovna Rada) approved the appointment of **Sergii Koretskyi,** Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Naftogaz of Ukraine, as the country's Prime Minister **(PM)**, succeeding **Yulia Svyrydenko,**

- He secured 289 votes in the 450-member Parliament, paving the way for his appointment as Ukraine's PM.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed as PM of Ukraine
- ✓ **Who?** Sergii Koretskyi
- ✓ **Parliament Vote:** 289 votes in the 450-member
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Yulia Svyrydenko
- ✓ **Previous Position:** CEO, Naftogaz of Ukraine.

Background:

Nomination: He was nominated by Ukrainian President **Volodymyr Zelenskyy** for the post of PM as part of a cabinet reshuffle aimed at strengthening governance during the ongoing war.

Reason for Appointment: Selected for his energy sector leadership, Sergii Koretskyi assumes his first government role to strengthen Ukraine's winter preparedness, energy security, and critical infrastructure, despite having no prior political experience or party affiliation.

About Sergii Koretskyi:

Profile: He is an engineer, economist, and energy sector executive with extensive experience in Ukraine's energy industry.

Career: He began his career at Continuum Group in 1997, later headed the West Oil Group (WOG) fuel retail chain, and served as CEO of Ukrnafta and Ukrtatnafta (since November 2022), with over two decades of experience in the energy sector.

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Professional Expertise: Has extensive experience in energy management, petroleum, corporate leadership, business strategy, investment projects, and mergers & acquisitions (M&A).
Current Position: Since May 2025, he has served as the CEO of Naftogaz of Ukraine, the country's largest state-owned oil and gas company, leading the firm during the ongoing Russia–Ukraine war.

About Ukraine:

President – Volodymyr Zelenskyy
Capital – Kyiv
Currency – Ukrainian Hryvnia (UAH)

Mindaugas Sinkevicius Sworn in as Lithuania's New PM

In July 2026, **Mindaugas Sinkevicius,** leader of Lithuanian Social Democratic Party (LSDP) was sworn in as 20th Prime Minister (**PM**) of **Lithuania** after the Lithuanian Parliament (**Seimas**) approved his party's government Manifesto.

- He succeeds **Inga Ruginienė**, who stepped down on 14 July 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Sworn in as Lithuania's PM
- ✓ **Who?** Mindaugas Sinkevičius
- ✓ **Party:** Lithuanian Social Democratic Party
- ✓ **Succeeded:** Inga Ruginienė
- ✓ **Coalition:** LSDP, For Lithuania (DLV), and Lithuanian Farmers and Greens Union (LFGU).

Background:

Election Outcome: Out of the **141**-member Seimas, **72** lawmakers voted in favor of the manifesto, **29** voted against it, and 4 abstained.

- The opposition Nemunas Dawn Party (NDP) was ousted from the government amid legal controversies.

Coalition: Mindaugas Sinkevičius formed a centre-left three-party coalition comprising the LSDP, For Lithuania (DLV), and the Lithuanian Farmers and Greens Union (LFGU).

About Mindaugas Sinkevicius:

Profile: He was a prominent economist and politician with prior experience in parliamentary committees, economic policy formulation, and regional governance.
Early Career: He began his political career after being elected to the Jonava District Municipality Council in 2007.

- He was first elected as the Mayor of Jonava District Municipality in 2011 at the age of 26, becoming one of Lithuania's youngest mayors, and was re-elected in 2015 and 2019 through direct mayoral elections.

Ministerial Role: In 2016, Sinkevičius was appointed as the Minister of Economy of Lithuania and resigned in 2017.
Other Roles: He served as the Vice-President of the Lithuanian Youth Council (LiJOT) in 2008 and acting Chairman of the LSDP in May 2025.

About Lithuania:

Overview: Lithuania, a member of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) and the European Union (EU), shares land borders with the Russian Federation and the Republic of Belarus.
President – Gitanas Nausėda
Capital – Vilnius
Currency – Euro (EUR)

Policybazaar Appointed Amitabh Bachchan as Brand Ambassador for Insurance Awareness Campaign

In July 2026, Policybazaar, India's online insurance marketplace, appointed veteran actor **Amitabh Bachchan** as its Brand Ambassador to spearhead a nationwide awareness campaign **"Parivaar Sabse Pehle"** (Family Comes First), developed by **MagicCircleon Communications.**

- The campaign, aims to raise awareness of health and term insurance, promote timely financial protection for families, and support the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India **(IRDAI)** vision 2047 of expanding insurance coverage across India.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Brand Ambassador
- ✓ **Who?** Amitabh Bachchan
- ✓ **Company:** Policybazaar
- ✓ **Campaign:** Parivaar Sabse Pehle
- ✓ **Objective:** Health and Term Insurance Awareness
- ✓ **Aligned With:** IRDAI's Insurance for All by 2047
- ✓ **Creative Agency:** MagicCircle

Highlights of the Appointment:

Focus: The initiative aims to **encourage Indian families** to purchase health and term insurance without delaying financial protection decisions.

Campaign Reach: The integrated campaign is being rolled out across television, digital platforms, Over-the-Top **(OTT)** services, social media, and other digital channels, targeting audiences in urban, semi-urban, and rural India.

About Policybazaar: Founded in 2008, Policybazaar, a PB Fintech Limited company headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana, is one of India's leading online insurance marketplaces, with Sarbvir Singh serving as the Joint Group Chief Executive Officer (CEO) and Executive Director (ED) of PB Fintech Ltd.

MoR Appoints Rahul Himalian as Additional CMD of IRCTC

In July 2026, the Ministry of Railways **(MoR)** appointed **Rahul Himalian**, Director (Tourism & Marketing), Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation Limited **(IRCTC),** as the **additional** Chairman & Managing Director **(CMD)** of IRCTC following the resignation of **Sanjay Kumar Jain**.

- His appointment as additional CMD of IRCTC will take effect from 20 July 2026, while he will continue to hold the post of Director (Tourism & Marketing), IRCTC.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed as Additional CMD of IRCTC
- ✓ **Who?** Rahul Himalian
- ✓ **Appointed by:** MoR
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Sanjay Kumar Jain
- ✓ **Current Position:** Director (Tourism & Marketing), IRCTC.

About Rahul Himalian:

Profile: A 1999-batch Indian Railway Traffic Service (IRTS) officer, Rahul Himalian has over 26 years of experience in Indian Railways and IRCTC and has served as a Whole-Time Functional Director on the IRCTC Board since 16 February 2024.

Recognition: He was awarded the **President's Gold Meda**l for being the Best All-Round Student.

Current Role: He has been serving as a Whole-Time Functional Director on the Board of IRCTC since 16 February 2024 and heads key areas including Tourism, Information Technology, Human Resource Development, Infrastructure, Administration, and Rajbhasha.

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About IRCTC: Established in 1999, IRCTC is a Schedule 'A' Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE) under the MoR, providing railway ticketing, catering, tourism, and hospitality services. It is headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi.

Andy Burnham Takes Charge as UK's New Prime Minister

In July 2026, **Andy Burnham** became the **59th Prime Minister** of the United Kingdom **(UK)** after **Keir Starmer** resigned from the post. He was invited by King Charles III at Buckingham Palace to form a new government in a traditional ceremony known as "kissing hands."

- He secured nearly **55% of the vote** in the leadership election, defeating **Reform UK's Robert Kenyon** by a margin of **more than 9,000 votes**, with a record turnout of **59%**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of New Prime Minister
- ✓ **Who?** Andy Burnham
- ✓ **Country?** UK
- ✓ **Appointed by:** King Charles III
- ✓ **Political Party:** Labour Party
- ✓ **Succeeded:** Keir Starmer
- ✓ **Previous Position:** Mayor of Greater Manchester (2017–2026)

About Andy Burnham:

Early Life: Born in Aintree, Lancashire, Andy Burnham joined the Labour Party at the age of 15 and worked in journalism before becoming a parliamentary researcher.

Political Career: Elected as Member of Parliament (MP) for Leigh in 2001, Andy Burnham served as Chief Secretary to the Treasury, Culture Secretary, and Health Secretary under Tony Blair and Gordon Brown, and later held key Shadow Cabinet roles.

Mayor of Greater Manchester (2017–2026): He became the first Mayor of Greater Manchester in 2017 and launched the Bee Network, bringing local bus services under public control. He was recognised as the "King of the North" for advocating Northern England's interests.

Vision: As the **7th UK Prime Minister since 2016**, Burnham's first address at 10 Downing Street and described his leadership as **"Circuit breaker for Britain"** and emphasised political stability, collaborative governance, and practical problem-solving.

- His **10-year national renewal plan** focuses on improving living standards, tackling cost-of-living issues, strengthening public services, and shifting power from **Westminster to regions** for greater decision-making and economic rebalancing.

Senegal's President Bassirou Faye Elected As New Chairman Of ECOWAS

In July 2026, **Bassirou Diomaye Diakhar Faye**, President of Senegal, was elected as the new Chairman of the Economic Community of West African States (**ECOWAS**) during the **69th Ordinary Session** of the ECOWAS Authority of Heads of State and Government held in Freetown, Sierra Leone.

- He will serve a mandatory one-year term and succeed President Julius Maada Bio of Sierra Leone, who has served as Chairman since June 2025.
- Senegal assumes the ECOWAS top post for the first time since the bloc's establishment in 1975.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Chairman of ECOWAS
- ✓ **Who?** Bassirou Diomaye Diakhar Faye, President of Senegal
- ✓ **Term:** One year mandatory
- ✓ **Predecessor:** President Julius Maada Bio (Sierra Leone)

- ✓ **Summit:** 69th Ordinary Session of ECOWAS Authority of Heads of State and Government at Freetown, Sierra Leone.
- ✓ **Other Appointments:** Biram Diop was appointed as President of the ECOWAS Commission, succeeding Dr Omar Touray for 2026 to 2030 term
- ✓ **Significance:** Senegal assumes the ECOWAS top post for the first time since the bloc's establishment in 1975.

Key Details of Appointment:

Other Appointments: Biram Diop (Senegal) was appointed as President of the ECOWAS Commission, succeeding Dr Omar Touray (Gambia) for the **2026 to 2030 term.**

Challenges: Faye assumes leadership amid ongoing challenges, including regional security threats, political instability, and withdrawals of Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger from the bloc, reducing membership from 15 to 12 countries.

Role: Faye will focus on revitalizing regional cooperation, sustaining diplomatic dialogue with breakaway states, and implementing reforms to strengthen governance, accountability, and youth participation.

About Bassirou Diomaye Diakhar Faye:

Profile: Faye is a Senegalese politician, former tax inspector, and legal scholar serving as the 5th President of Senegal since April 2024.

- Elected at the age of 44, he made history as Africa's youngest democratically elected president.

Key Roles: Faye served as Secretary-General of PASTEF from 2022 to 2024

Achievement: He was the first opposition candidate to win Senegal's presidential election since independence from France in 1960.

Co-Founder: In 2014, Faye and Sonko co-founded **PASTEF** (African Patriots of Senegal for Work, Ethics and Fraternity), a left-wing political movement centered on anti-corruption, pan-Africanism, and monetary sovereignty.

About the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS):

Overview: ECOWAS, established in 1975 by 15 nations through the Treaty of Lagos, aims to achieve economic union, collective defense, and development across West Africa.

Member Countries: The 12-member ECOWAS bloc includes Benin, Cabo Verde, Côte d'Ivoire, The Gambia, Ghana, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, Liberia, Nigeria, Senegal, Sierra Leone, and Togo.

- India became an Observer to ECOWAS in 2004.

Headquarters: Abuja, Nigeria

Centre Appoints Senior IAS Officer Anurag Jain as NITI Aayog CEO

In July 2026, Government of India (**GoI**) appointed Anurag Jain as new Chief Executive Officer (**CEO**) of (National Institution for Transforming India) **NITI Aayog**, approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (**ACC**) as per the Department of Personnel and Training (**DoPT**) order.

- He succeeds **Nidhi Chhibber,** , Director General (**DG**) of NITI Aayog's Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office (**DMEO**), who had been holding the additional charge of **CEO** since February 24, 2026, following the completion of B.V.R. Subrahmanyam's extended tenure in February 2023.
- He assumes charge immediately for a tenure of **two years** or until further orders, whichever is earlier.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment as CEO of NITI Aayog
- ✓ **Who?** Anurag Jain, 1989-batch, Madhya Pradesh cadre IAS officer
- ✓ **Approved By:** Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC)
- ✓ **Term:** Two-year term (or until further orders)

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- ✓ **Succeeds:** Nidhi Chhibber, DG of NITI Aayog's DMEO, holds additional charge as CEO
- ✓ **Previous Role:** Chief Secretary (**CS**) of MP

Key Details of Appointment:

Responsibilities: As CEO of NITI Aayog, Jain will steer national policy formulation, strategic governance reforms, cooperative federalism initiatives, and long-term development planning across sectors.

About Anurag Jain:

Profile: A 1989-batch Indian Administrative Service (**IAS**) officer of the Madhya Pradesh (**MP**) cadre with nearly four decades of administrative experience, having held several key positions in both the Central and State governments.

Previous Role: Jain assumed the post of Chief Secretary (**CS**) of MP in October 2024 with his tenure set to conclude on 31 August 2026.

Union level Roles: Jain served as Secretary in the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways (**MoRTH**) and Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (**DPIIT**).

- He served as Joint Secretary (JS) in the Prime Minister's Office (**PMO**) from 2011 to 2015, handling infrastructure, urban development, industrial policy, and investment promotion portfolios.

About National Institution for Transforming India (NITI) Aayog:

NITI Aayog is India's premier policy think tank, established to replace the Planning Commission.

Established – 2015

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

Chairperson – Prime Minister (PM) of India (Narendra Modi)

Harjit Singh Grewal Assumes Charge as Chairman of NCM

In July 2026, **Harjit Singh Grewal** assumed charge as the **Chairman** of the National Commission for Minorities **(NCM)** for a three-year tenure, following his appointment by the Ministry of Minority Affairs (MoMA) under the NCM Act, 1992. He succeeded **Iqbal Singh Lalpura**, whose tenure ended in April 2025.

- With the induction of the new leadership, the National Commission for Minorities aims to further strengthen efforts towards justice, equality, empowerment and inclusive development.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Assumed charge as Chairman of NCM
- ✓ **Who?** Harjit Singh Grewal
- ✓ **Term of Office:** 3 years
- ✓ **Appointed By:** Ministry of Minority Affairs
- ✓ **Succeeded:** Iqbal Singh Lalpura
- ✓ **Other Appointees:**
- ✓ Vice Chairperson: S. Munawari Begum
- ✓ Members: Glenn Souza Ticlo, Berjis Desai.

Other Key Appointments:

Vice Chairperson: S. Munawari Begum assumed office as the Vice Chairperson of NCM on to strengthen minority rights protection and promote equal opportunities.

Christian Member: Glenn Souza Ticlo joined as a Member of NCM representing the Christian community and served as a Goa Legislative Assembly (MLA) member from the Aldona constituency for two consecutive terms (2012–2022).

Parsi Member: Berjis Desai joined NCM as a Member representing the Parsi community and is a senior High Court advocate and writer.

About NCM: It is a statutory body established under the National Commission for Minorities Act, 1992 to safeguard the interests of minority communities.

- Constituted on 17 May 1993, it is mandated to protect and monitor the safeguards of the six notified religious minority communities in India: Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Parsis (Zoroastrians), and Jains.

India's World Chess Champion Viswanathan Anand Becomes Interim President of FIDE

In July 2026, **Viswanathan Anand**, India's five-time World Chess Champion and Deputy President of the International Chess Federation (FIDE), assumed charge as the **Interim President of FIDE** after incumbent President **Arkady Vladimirovich Dvorkovich** voluntarily suspended his duties following sanctions imposed by the European Union **(EU)** and Switzerland over Russia's war against Ukraine.

- In accordance with **Article 19.2 of the FIDE Charter**, Anand automatically assumed the role to ensure uninterrupted governance and continuity of FIDE's global activities.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Interim President of FIDE
- ✓ **Who?** Viswanathan Anand
- ✓ **Succeeded:** Arkady Vladimirovich Dvorkovich
- ✓ **Legal Basis:** Under Article 19.2 of the FIDE Charter, Deputy President serves as Interim President when President is under restrictive measures.
- ✓ **Previous Role:** Elected FIDE Deputy President in August 2022
- ✓ **Awards:** Arjuna Award (1985), Padma Shri (1988), Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award (1991–92), Padma Bhushan (2001), and Padma Vibhushan (2008).

About Viswanathan Anand:

Early Career: Born on 11 December 1969 in Mayiladuthurai, Tamil Nadu (TN), he earned the nickname **"Lightning Kid"** and became India's first Chess Grandmaster (GM) in 1988, ushering in a new era for Indian chess.

Championships: He won the World Chess Championship five times in 2000, 2007, 2008, 2010, and 2012, and remains the only Indian to have won the title multiple times.

FIDE Role: In August 2022, he was elected Deputy President of the International Chess Federation (FIDE).

National Honours: He received the Arjuna Award (1985), India's second-highest national sports honor; the Padma Shri (1988) in the field of Sports, India's fourth-highest civilian honour; the Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award (1991–92), India's highest sporting honour; the Padma Bhushan (2001) in the field of Sports, India's third-highest civilian honour; and the Padma Vibhushan (2008) in the field of Sports, India's second-highest civilian honour.

International Recognition: He won the Chess Oscar six times (1997, 1998, 2003, 2004, 2007, and 2008), received the British Chess Federation Book of the Year Award (1998) for *My Best Games of Chess*, the Sportstar Millennium Award (1998), and several lifetime achievement recognitions for his contribution to world chess.

About International Chess Federation or Fédération Internationale des Échecs (FIDE):

FIDE is the global governing body for chess, uniting national chess federations worldwide and overseeing international chess competitions.

Headquarters – Lausanne, Switzerland

Established – 1924

Infosys Appointed Ashiss Kumar Dash as CEO-Designate

In July 2026, **Infosys Limited,** India's second-largest Information Technology (IT) services company appointed **Ashiss Kumar Dash** as its Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Designate. He will assume charge as the Managing Director (MD) & CEO from **1 April 2027,** following the completion of **Salil Parekh's** second term.

- Dash's appointment is for a **five-year** term (2027–2032), subject to shareholders' approval. Parekh will continue to serve until 31 March 2027 to ensure a smooth leadership transition.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Infosys Appointed New CEO-Designate
- ✓ **Who?** Ashiss Kumar Dash
- ✓ **Effective Date:** 1 April 2027
- ✓ **Tenure:** Five years (subject to shareholders' approval)
- ✓ **Succeeded:** Salil Parekh
- ✓ **Appointment Approved By:** Infosys Board of Directors
- ✓ **Recommended By:** Nomination and Remuneration Committee

About Ashiss Kumar Dash:

Appointment: The appointment was approved by the Infosys Board of Directors based on the recommendation of the Nomination and Remuneration Committee.
Profile: Dash is an Infosys veteran with over 30 years of experience and currently serves as Executive Vice President (EVP) & Global Head – Services, Utilities, Resources, Energy & Enterprise Sustainability.
Experience: He has led customer-facing businesses, delivery operations, global business units, and Artificial Intelligence (AI) led digital transformation initiatives across multiple geographies.
About Infosys: Infosys, founded in 1981, is an Information Technology (IT) Services company headquartered in Bengaluru, Karnataka.

Union Minister Pralhad Joshi Takes Additional Charge as Education Minister

In July 2026, Union Minister **Pralhad Venkatesh Joshi,** Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution **(MoCAF&PD)** and Ministry of New and Renewable Energy **(MNRE)** was given additional charge as the **10th Union Minister of Education** of India following the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan at Kartavya Bhavan, New Delhi, Delhi.

- Acting on the advice of Prime Minister (PM) **Narendra Modi,** President **Droupadi Murmu** accepted the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan from the Union Council of Ministers, with immediate effect, under **clause (2)** of **Article 75** of the Constitution of India.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Education Minister
- ✓ **Who?** Pralhad Joshi (additional charge)
- ✓ **Existing Portfolios:** Holds charge of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, and New and Renewable Energy
- ✓ **Succeeds:** Dharmendra Pradhan, who resigned from the position
- ✓ **Appointment Authority:** President of India, acting on the advice of PM Narendra Modi under clause (2) of Article 75 of the Constitution of India.

Appointment Details:

Transition: Dharmendra Pradhan submitted his resignation, taking moral responsibility for the controversial National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) **NEET-UG 2026 paper leak** issue and the resulting nationwide student protests.

About Pralhad Venkatesh Joshi:

Profile: Pralhad Joshi is a senior Indian politician and a veteran leader of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) known for his expertise in parliamentary affairs, policy implementation, and administrative leadership.
Lok Sabha: He was first elected to the **14th Lok Sabha** in 2004 from the Dharwad constituency and subsequently won five consecutive terms in 2004, 2009, 2014, 2019, and 2024.
Cabinet Portfolios: Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs, Coal, and Mines (2019–2024), MoCAF&PD and MNRE since 2019.

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Key Roles during his tenure:

Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs: He was instrumental in the passage of landmark legislation, including the Abrogation of **Article 370** (2019) and the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (**2019**).

Union Minister of Mines: He spearheaded the 2023 legislative amendments to the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) **Act, 1957**, aiming to enhance deep mineral exploration and improve transparency in the sector.

Other Secretary Appointment in MoE:

Department of Higher Education: Naresh Pal Gangwar (1994-batch IAS officer) took charge, replacing Vineet Joshi.

Department of School Education & Literacy: T.K. Anil Kumar (1995-batch IAS officer) assumed the role

About Ministry of Education (MoE):

Union Minister– Pralhad Venkatesh Joshi (Constituency- Dharwad, Karnataka)

Minister of State (MoS)– Jayant Chaudhary (Rajya Sabha- Uttar Pradesh, UP); Dr. Sukanta Majumdar (Constituency- Balurghat, West Bengal, WB)

ACC Appoints Satya Pal Kumar as Director of FIU – IND

In July 2026, the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet **(ACC)** appointed **Satya Pal Kumar**, a 2005-batch Indian Revenue Service (IRS) officer of the Income Tax cadre, as the **Director** of the Financial Intelligence Unit-India **(FIU-IND)** under the Department of Revenue (DoR), Ministry of Finance (MoF), as part of a Joint Secretary-level reshuffle.

- He succeeded **Pankaj Kumar Mishra** (IRS, 1989 batch), who had served as Director of FIU-IND since May 2016.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointed as Director of FIU-IND
- ✓ **Appointed by:** ACC
- ✓ **Appointee:** Satya Pal Kumar
- ✓ **Tenure:** 5 Years
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Pankaj Kumar Mishra.

Key Details of Appointment:

Tenure: Satya Pal Kumar was appointed for a 5-year tenure at the rank of Joint Secretary to the Government of India (GoI). Prior to this appointment, he served as Commissioner of Income Tax (Appeals), Mumbai, Maharashtra.

Significance: The appointment strengthens India's financial intelligence framework to combat money laundering, terror financing, and suspicious financial transactions, supporting the country's Anti-Money Laundering (AML) and Combating Financing of Terrorism (CFT) framework.

About FIU-IND: Established in 2004 and headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi, FIU-IND analyses and disseminates information on suspicious financial transactions.

AWARDS

HP Secures 8 New GI Tags; Total GI Products Rised to 17

In July 2026, Himachal Pradesh (**HP**) secured **Eight** new Geographical Indication (**GI**) registrations, taking the total number of GI-tagged products in the state from **9 to 17**. The registrations were facilitated by the Himachal Pradesh Council for Science, Technology and Environment (**HIMCOSTE**). Chief Minister (**CM**) **Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu** welcomed the achievement, stating that it strengthens the state's cultural identity, traditional knowledge, and rural economy.

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- The newly registered products include Seabuckthorn (Chharma) of Spiti, Salooni Safed Makka (White Maize) of Chamba, Chamba Metal Art, Sirmauri Loiya, Kinnauri Topi, Kinnauri Apple, Kinnauri Jewellery, and Sepuvadi of Mandi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** New GI tagged products
- ✓ **From:** Himachal Pradesh
- ✓ **New GI Products:** Seabuckthorn (Chharma), Salooni Safed Makka, Chamba Metal Art, Sirmauri Loiya, Kinnauri Topi, Kinnauri Apple, Kinnauri Jewellery, Sepuvadi.
- ✓ **Total GI Products:** 17
- ✓ **Facilitated by:** HIMCOSTE

Key Details of GI- Tag Products:

Seabuckthorn (Chharma) – Spiti: A nutrient-rich medicinal berry naturally grown in the cold desert region of Spiti. It is widely valued for its nutritional and medicinal properties.

Salooni Safed Makka (White Maize) – Chamba: A traditional white maize variety cultivated in the **Salooni region of Chamba**. It is known for its distinctive taste and nutritional value.

Chamba Metal Art – Chamba: A traditional handcrafted metal craft produced by skilled artisans of **Chamba**. It reflects the region's rich artistic and cultural heritage.

Sirmauri Loiya – Sirmaur: A traditional handwoven woollen gown worn in **Sirmaur**. It is an important part of the district's cultural identity and craftsmanship.

Kinnauri Topi – Kinnaur: A traditional cap of **Kinnaur**, recognised for its colourful design and fine woollen weaving. It represents the cultural identity of the Kinnauri community.

Kinnauri Apple – Kinnaur: A premium apple variety grown in the high-altitude orchards of **Kinnaur**. It is known for its superior quality, flavour, and long shelf life.

Kinnauri Jewellery – Kinnaur: Traditional handcrafted silver jewellery worn by the **Kinnauri** community. It showcases the region's unique craftsmanship and cultural traditions.

Sepuvadi – Mandi: A traditional lentil-based delicacy from **Mandi**, prepared using local ingredients and indigenous culinary techniques. It is a popular part of Himachali cuisine.

Significance: The GI recognition will protect the authenticity of traditional products, enhance their branding, market value and export potential, while promoting rural entrepreneurship, sustainable livelihoods, and preserving Himachal Pradesh's cultural heritage.

Previous GI Registrations: Before the latest registrations, Himachal Pradesh had **9 GI -tagged** products: Kullu Shawl, Kangra Tea, Chamba Rumal, Kinnauri Shawl, Kangra Painting, Himachali Kalazeera, Himachali Chulli (Apricot) Oil, Chamba Chappal, and Lahauli Knitted Socks and Gloves.

Upcoming GI Registrations: The Government of HP is pursuing GI registration for four indigenous products: Bhot Jau (Barley) from Pangi (Chamba), Chamba Chukh, Plectranthus Honey from Bharmour (Chamba), and Sirmaur Ginger.

About Geographical Indication (GI):

Definition: A GI identifies products whose quality, reputation, or characteristics are linked to their geographical origin.

Nodal Authority: The Ministry of Commerce and Industry **(MoCI)**, through its Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade **(DPIIT)** and the Controller General of Patents, Designs and Trade Marks **(CGPDTM),** administers GI registrations in India via the Geographical Indications Registry.

Legal Framework: GI is governed by the Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999, administered by the Geographical Indications Registry, Chennai, Tamil Nadu **(TN)**, which came into force on September 15, 2003 and protected under the Agreement on Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights **(TRIPS)** of the World Trade Organization **(WTO)**.

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Time Period: The registration of GI is valid for a period of 10 years from date of registration and can be renewed from time to time for a further period of 10 years each.

About the Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoCI):

Union Minister **(UM)** – Piyush Goyal (Constituency – Mumbai North, Maharashtra **MH**)
Minister of State – Jitin Prasada (Constituency – Pilibhit, Uttar Pradesh **UP**)

Ministry of Steel Granted Mini Ratna Category-I Status to MECON Limited

In July 2026, the Ministry of Steel **(MoS)** granted **Miniratna Category-I** status to **MECON Limited,** a Schedule 'A' Central Public Enterprise which works under the MoS, following the company fulfilling the eligibility criteria prescribed by the Department of Public Enterprises (DPE), Ministry of Finance (MoF).

- The approval is aimed to strengthen high-performing Central Public Enterprises (CPSE) by offering greater operational flexibility and enhancing their role in India's infrastructure and economic growth.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Grating Miniratna Category-I Status to MECON Limited
- ✓ **Granted by:** Ministry of Steel (MoS)
- ✓ **Positive Net Worth:** Rs 535.42 crore (as of March 2026)
- ✓ **PBT in Last 3 Years:** Rs 77.62 crore (FY24) (restated), Rs 32.08 crore (FY25) (restated) and Rs 104.53 crore (FY26)

Key Details:

Net Worth: As per the MoS, the CPSE registered the net worth of Rs 535.42 crore (as of March 31, 2026), meeting one of the key requirements for Miniratna Category-I status.

Continuous PBT for Last 3 Years: As per the criteria laid down by DPE, the CPSE has continued to be profitable over the last 3 financial years, recording a Profit Before Tax **(PBT)** of Rs 77.62 crore in Financial Year 2023-24 (FY24) (restated), Rs 32.08 crore (FY25) (restated) and Rs 104.53 crore (in FY26).

Significance: The new status will give more autonomy to MECON's Board of Directors regarding investment decisions, undertaking technology upgradation, and implementing modernisation projects with greater speed and flexibility.

About Miniratna:

Background: In October 1997, the Government of India introduced the Miniratna scheme and classified CPSEs for Miniratna scheme into two different categories: Miniratna Category-I and Miniratna Category-II.

Criteria for Miniratna Category-I: The CPSEs which have made profit consecutively for 3 years, pre –tax profit is **Rs 30 crore or more** in at least 1 of 3 years and have positive net worth are eligible to be considered for grant of Miniratna Category-I status.

- Some of the Miniratna Category-I CPSEs in India are: Airports Authority of India (AAI), Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL), Antrix Corporation Limited, Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL), among others.

Criteria for Miniratna Category-II: The CPSEs which have made profit consecutively for 3 years and have positive net worth are eligible to be considered for grant of Miniratna-II status.

- Some of the Miniratna Category-I CPSEs in India are: Engineering Projects (India) Limited (EPL), Bharat Pumps & Compressors Limited, Central Electronics Limited, among others.

Other Conditions: In addition, conditions prescribed for both categories of Miniratna CPSEs include that they should have not defaulted in the repayment of loans or interest payment or any loans due to the Government; and shall not depend upon budgetary support or Government Guarantees.

Key Benefits: For capital expenditure and Joint Ventures (JVs) and Subsidiaries: The Boards of Miniratna category-I CPSEs can incur expenditure on new projects, modernisation, purchase of equipment, without any need of government approval up to Rs 500 crore or equal to net worth, whichever is less.

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- And, Category-II CPSEs can incur maximum capital expenditure (without government approval) of Rs 250 crore or equal to 50% of the net worth, whichever is less.

About MECON Limited:

Chairman and Managing Director **(CMD)-** Sanjay Kumar Verma
Headquarters- Ranchi, Jharkhand
Established- 1959

WB adds 23 new GI – Tagged Products; Ranks 3rd Nationally with 59 Registrations

In June 2026, **Kalyan Chakraborty**, Minister of Science & Technology and Biotechnology, West Bengal (WB), announced that **WB** has received **23** new Geographical Indication **(GI) tags,** taking its total to **59** GI registrations and making it the **third-highest** GI-tagged state in India after Uttar Pradesh (UP) (83) and Tamil Nadu (TN) (76).

- The recognition covers heritage sweets, handicrafts, textiles, agricultural products, and regional specialties to protect authenticity, promote artisans, and enhance domestic and global market value.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** WB Adds 23 new GI Tags
- ✓ **Total Count:** State's total GI registrations now stand at 59
- ✓ **National Rank:** Ranks 3rd among Indian states for GI registrations
- ✓ **Top States:** Uttar Pradesh (83) leads, followed by Tamil Nadu (76)
- ✓ **Major sectors:** Heritage sweets, handicrafts, textiles, agricultural products, and regional specialties
- ✓ **Key products**: Jolbhora Sandesh, Mecha Sandesh, Kanakchur Popped Rice, Santiniketan Batik, Clay Doll of Krishnanagar

About GI Recognition for West Bengal:

Objective: The registrations aim to legally protect products linked to their geographical origin, preserve traditional knowledge, strengthen branding, improve producer income, and enhance domestic and international market competitiveness.

Coverage: The newly registered products include traditional sweets, agricultural products, handicrafts, textiles, musical instruments, handloom products, boats, jewellery, and regional specialties from different districts of WB.

Products: The newly GI-tagged products include jalbhora sandesh from Chandernagore, monohara from Janai, Santiniketan batik and ektara from Birbhum, mecha sandesh from Beliatore in Bankura, Banglar nolen gur, kanakchur popped rice, Krishnanagar clay dolls, sitalpati from Cooch Behar, the Bengal singing bowl from Bikrampur, Balagarh boats from Hooghly, and traditional jewellery from Kolkata.

Authentication: The Government of WB proposes using the GI logo and Quick Response (QR) code to verify genuine GI products and prevent counterfeit goods.

Promotion: The state plans authorised user registrations, awareness campaigns, quality assurance initiatives, branding support, marketing assistance, GI entrepreneurship promotion, dedicated GI outlets, and participation in national and international exhibitions.

Pending Applications: WB has also applied for GI recognition for seven additional products, including Radhatilak Rice, Dudher Swar Rice, Bengal Rasamalai, Bengal Mishti Doi, Rhododendron (Guras) Wine/Raksi, Sarbhaja, and Sarpuria.

About Geographical Indication (GI):

Definition: A GI identifies products whose quality, reputation, or characteristics are linked to their geographical origin.

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Nodal Authority: The Ministry of Commerce and Industry **(MoCI)**, through its Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade **(DPIIT)** and the Controller General of Patents, Designs and Trade Marks **(CGPDTM),** administers GI registrations in India via the Geographical Indications Registry.
Legal Framework: GI is governed by the Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999, administered by the Geographical Indications Registry, Chennai, Tamil Nadu **(TN)**, which came into force on September 15, 2003 and protected under the Agreement on Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights **(TRIPS)** of the World Trade Organization **(WTO)**.
Time Period: The registration of GI is valid for a period of 10 years from date of registration and can be renewed from time to time for a further period of 10 years each.

About West Bengal (WB):

Chief Minister **(CM)** – Suvendu Adhikari
Governor – R. N. Ravi
Capital – Kolkata
National Park (NP) – Sundarban NP, Jaldapara NP

USISPF Presents 2026 Leadership Award to 'Sunil Bharti Mittal' for Transforming India-US Economic Ties

In June 2026, the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum **(USISPF),** a Non-Profit Organisation (NPO), presented the **2026 Leadership Award** to **Sunil Bharti Mittal**, founder and chairman of Bharti Enterprises Limited, at the IX Leadership Summit, in Washington, D.C., United States of America (USA), themed "America At 250".

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** USISPF presents 2026 Leadership Award
- ✓ **Recipient:** Sunil Bharti Mittal
- ✓ **Where?** IX Leadership Summit, Washington, D.C., USA
- ✓ **Recognised for:** Telecom transformation & India-USA economic ties advancement
- ✓ **Other Awardees:** V. Prem Watsa, Christopher T. Calio.

About USISPF Global Leadership Award:

Event: The award recognises leaders advancing strategic, commercial, and innovation-driven partnerships between **India and the USA**, particularly through technology, business expansion, and bilateral trade facilitation.
Leadership: Sunil Bharti Mittal was recognised for transforming India's telecommunications sector, expanding digital connectivity, fostering innovation, attracting international investment, and building a diversified business group spanning multiple sectors.
Other Awardees: V. Prem Watsa, Chairman & Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Fairfax Financial Holdings, and **Christopher T. Calio,** Chairman & CEO, RTX Corporation, were also honoured for strengthening the India–USA economic corridor.

Nita Ambani Receives 'AAPI Humanitarian Award' and 'Key to City of Tampa' for Philanthropic Contributions

In July 2026, Reliance Foundation Founder and Chairperson **Nita Ambani** was conferred the American Association of Physicians of Indian Origin **(AAPI) Humanitarian Award** and the **Key to the City of Tampa**, in recognition of her philanthropic contributions to healthcare, education, sports, culture, and community development.

- The honours were presented during the 44th Annual Convention & Scientific Assembly of the AAPI held in Tampa, Florida, United States (USA).

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** AAPI Humanitarian Award & Key to City of Tampa
- ✓ **Recipient:** Nita Ambani (Reliance Foundation Founder & Chairperson)
- ✓ **Reason:** For Philanthropic Contributions
- ✓ **Where?** Tampa, Florida, USA
- ✓ **Awarding Body:** AAPI
- ✓ **Civic Honour Given By:** Tampa Mayor Jane Castor
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Healthcare, education, sports, culture, community development

About the Honour:

AAPI Humanitarian Award: Conferred by AAPI, it is the organisation's highest honour recognizing exceptional contributions to public welfare and humanitarian service.

The Key to the City of Tampa: Presented by Tampa Mayor Jane Castor, it is a symbolic civic honour given to individuals who have made an extraordinary impact on humanity and society.

Significance: The recognition highlights the Reliance Foundation's role in advancing inclusive development across healthcare, education, sports, culture, and community empowerment, while reinforcing global acknowledgement of Indian philanthropic leadership and its humanitarian contributions.

Global Biofuel Alliance Selected 15 Fellows Including 2 Indians for GBCF Programme

In July, India-led Global Biofuel Alliance **(GBA)** selected **15** early-career researchers from leading universities and research institutions globally, for its flagship Global Biofuel Champion Fellowship **(GBCF) programme,** launched during a high-level hybrid convening held at the India Habitat Centre in New Delhi, Delhi.

- These selected global fellows will act as **GBA Ambassadors** over the **next two years,** to accelerate sustainable bioenergy solutions and global clean energy partnerships.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** GBA selected 15 global researchers
- ✓ **Selected for:** GBA's GBCF Programme
- ✓ **Where?** India Habitat Centre
- ✓ **Purpose:** To advance research, knowledge exchange and global collaboration in sustainable biofuels
- ✓ **Research Grant:** USD 15,000
- ✓ **Fellowship Tenure:** Two Years
- ✓ **Indians:** Ruchi Agrawal, TERI and Abhishek Sahoo, IIT-D

About GBCF Proggramme:

Overview: It is a flagship initiative of the GBA, supporting outstanding early-career researchers via research grants, mentorship and global engagement.e about biofuels into practical solutions for the clean energy transition.

Key Objectives: It aims to bolster international cooperation in biofuel research and help translate scientific knowledg

Monetary Assistance: Under the GBCF programme, each selected fellow will receive a research grant of **USD 15,000**.

Indian Representation: The selected cohort of GBCF includes two researchers from India: **Ruchi Agrawal** from The Energy and Resources Institute **(TERI)** (Delhi) and **Abhishek Sahoo** from the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi **(IIT-D)** (Delhi).

Selection Process: These fellows were selected through a **3-stage** global evaluation process which involved the screening of applications received from 32 countries.

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Global Representation: The inaugural cohort represents global institutions including the University of Michigan (United States of America, USA), the University of Manchester (United Kingdom, UK), Monash University (Australia), Polytechnique Montreal (Canada), and leading research institutes across Africa, Brazil and India.

About Global Biofuel Alliance (GBA):

Background: In September 2023, Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, along with leaders of the United States of America (USA), Brazil, Italy, Argentina, Singapore, Bangladesh, Mauritius and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), officially launched the GBA on the sidelines of Group-20 (G20) summit held in New Delhi, Delhi.

Aim: To bolster global energy security, support decarbonisation and promote sustainable economic development via deployment of biofuels.

Members: As of now, **34** countries, including eight G20 countries (Argentina, Brazil, Canada, India, Italy, Japan, South Africa and USA) and **14** international organisations such as: Asian Development Bank (ADB), World Economic Forum (WEF), International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA), among others, already joined the alliance.

Interim Director General (DG)- Dr. Neeraj Mittal, Secretary, of Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), Government of India (GoI)

Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi

Nepal's Jestha Varna Mahavihar receives 2025 UNESCO Asia-Pacific Heritage Award

In July 2026, 17th-century **Jestha Varna Mahavihar**, a historic Buddhist monastery in **Lalitpur, Nepal** received the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation **(UNESCO) Asia-Pacific Heritage Award 2025** for its outstanding conservation and restoration following the **2015 Gorkha earthquake damage**.

- The Indian Embassy in Kathmandu handed over the Award of Merit to the Jestha Varna Mahavihar.
- **Jaco Du Toit**, UNESCO Representative in Nepal, presented a metal plaque and official certificate to **Jestha Varna Mahavihar User Committee** during a ceremony in Lalitpur, Nepal in the presence of Rakesh Pandey, Deputy Chief of Mission, Embassy of India, Kathmandu.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **Award:** 2025 UNESCO Asia-Pacific Heritage Award
- ✓ **Site:** Jestha Varna Mahavihar
- ✓ **Location:** Lalitpur, Nepal
- ✓ **Award Presented By:** Jaco Du Toit, UNESCO Representative in Nepal
- ✓ **Received by:** Jestha Varna Mahavihar User Committee
- ✓ **Restoration Support:** Government of India (Grant Assistance)
- ✓ **Grant:** NPR 13.78 crore
- ✓ **Significance:** Exemplary heritage conservation promotes India-Nepal cultural cooperation

Jestha Varna Mahavihara:

Recognition: It was recognised by UNESCO for its exemplary **community-centred approach**, combining modern seismic retrofitting with the preservation of Newari woodcarvings and architecture, while sustaining the living heritage and practices of the Newar Buddhist community.

Overview: Also known as **Jyaba Bahi or Chakrabahil**, it is a historic site located just 300 meters from the UNESCO-listed Patan Durbar Square in Lalitpur.

Structure: The complex comprises a sunken central courtyard, a multi-tiered sattal housing the main shrine and revered Kwapadhyo shrine with its principal stupa.

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Craftsmanship: Celebrated for its intricate Newari artistry, featuring detailed wooden window frames, carved timber beams, traditional brick façades, and historic wall paintings at the main shrine entrance.

Key Details of Restoration Project:

Inauguration: The project was inaugurated on **March 22, 2024,** by Naveen Srivastava, Ambassador and Dhan Bahadur Budha, then Minister of Urban Development (**MoUD**), Government of Nepal (**GoN**).

Grant Assistance: The conservation of Jestha Varna Mahavihar was funded through the Government of India's (**GoI's**) post-earthquake cultural heritage reconstruction grant in Nepal, in Nepalese rupees (**NPR 13.78 crore)**.

Collaboration: Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (**INTACH**) served as the Project Management Consultant (**PMC**) under the GoI reconstruction initiative, collaborating with Nepal's Central Level Project Implementation Unit (**CLPIU**) of the **GoN** and the local community

About Nepal:

Prime Minister **(PM)**– Balendra Shah

Capital-Kathmandu

Currency-Nepalese Rupee (NPR)

Sirsa Kinnow Gets GI Recognition as Haryana's First Exclusive GI Product

In July 2026, the Geographical Indication Registry **(GIR)** under the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I), granted Geographical Indication (GI) tag to **Haryana's Sirsa Kinnow,** becoming the state's 1st fruit to receive such recognition.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 1st Fruit from Haryana Secured GI Tag
- ✓ **Which Fruit:** Sirsa Kinnow
- ✓ **Granting Authority:** GIR, DPIIT under MoCI
- ✓ **Facilitated by:** Kharisureran Farmer Producer Company Limited (Sirsa, Haryana)
- ✓ **Additional Recognition:** Sirsa Kinnow Emblem

Key Details:

Certification Granted to: Kharisureran Farmer Producer Company Limited in Sirsa district, Haryana, received the GI tag for Sirsa Kinnow.

Sirsa Kinnow Emblem: In addition to the GI tag, Sirsa Kinnow has secured its own logo featuring an orange kinnow with a green leaf inside a circular "Sirsa Kinnow" emblem.

About Sirsa Kinnow:

Origin: Kinnow is not a native fruit to Haryana, or even to India. Its origin traces back to the early 20th Century in California, the United States of America (USA), where it was developed by renowned Horticulturist **Howard B. Frost.**

Hybrid Citrus Fruit: It is a hybrid citrus fruit developed by crossing the King Mandarin (Citrus nobilis) and the Willow Leaf Mandarin (Citrus x deliciosa).

Key Features: It has a unique sweet and sour taste, and is rich in Vitamin C and minerals like: Calcium (Ca) and Potassium (K).

GI Status of Haryana:

Before Sirsa Kinnow, Haryana was represented on India's GI map through two shared GI-tagged products:

- Basmati Rice (GI registered in 2016), jointly shared with six other states and Union Territories.
- Phulkari (GI registered in 2010), jointly shared with Punjab and covering only parts of Haryana.
- Sirsa Kinnow has now become Haryana's first exclusive (standalone) GI-tagged product, marking the state's first independent GI registration.

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Current Status of GI-tagged Products:

Total GI Products: At present, the total number of GI-tagged products in India stands at 822, of which, 125 were alone registered between April 2025 to March 2026.

Eastern Indian Dominance: Out of 125 GIs registered over the last one year, **26** were from Madhya Pradesh (MP) comprises handicraft products (Khajuraho Stone Craft, Betul Bharewa Metal Craft, Gwalior Paper Mache Craft); 04 traditional tribal crops (Sitahi Kutki, Baigani Arhar, Nagdaman Kutki, Chhatriya Paddy).

- MP is followed by West Bengal (WB) (24); Jharkhand (11).

Other states & UTs: Himachal Pradesh (HP) which recorded 13 GI registrations; followed by Gujarat and Union Territory (UT) Ladakh (7 each); Assam (6); Uttar Pradesh (UP), Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu (TN), and Goa (5 each).

Category-wise Contribution: Handicrafts account for more than about 53% of the 822 GI-registered products; followed by agricultural products (31%).

About Geographical Indication (GI) Tag:

Overview: GI tag indicates that a product has a specific geographical origin and possess qualities or a reputation inherent to that location.

- Darjeeling tea holds the distinction of being the 1st Indian product to receive a GI tag in 2004.

Administered by: GI tags in India, are administered by the Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999, which came into force on September 15, 2003.

Time Period: The registration of GI is valid for a period of **10 years** from date of registration and can be renewed from time to time for a further period of 10 years each.

About Geographical Indication Registry (GIR):

Headquarters- Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN)

Established- 2003

DoT's Samriddh Gram Wins WSIS Prize 2026 Under Action Line C6

In July 2026, the Department of Telecommunications (**DoT**), under the Ministry of Communications, Government of India (GoI), received the World Summit on the Information Society (**WSIS) Prize 2026** under **Action Line C6 – Enabling Environment** for its flagship initiative, **"Samriddh Gram: Integrated Phygital Service Delivery Model Enabled by BharatNet.**

- The award was presented during the **WSIS Forum 2026** held in Geneva, Switzerland. The initiative was declared the Global Winner by the International Telecommunication Union (**ITU**).

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** WSIS Prize 2026.
- ✓ **Received by?** DoT, under the Ministry of Communications
- ✓ **For:** Samriddh Gram, Integrated Phygital Service Delivery Model Enabled by BharatNet
- ✓ **Category:** Action Line C6: Enabling Environment.
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen enabling environment for ICT-based rural development

About the WSIS Award:

Framework: Under the WSIS framework, led by the ITU, the WSIS Prizes are among the world's most prestigious awards for projects that use Information and Communication Technologies (**ICTs**) to promote sustainable development.

Multi-stage evaluation process: The process included project submission, international screening, global online voting, selection of the top five Champion Projects in each category, and final adjudication by the WSIS Expert Committee.

- During the global online voting phase, over **2.2 million votes** were cast worldwide across all nominations.

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Recognition: This recognition highlights India's innovative use of digital public infrastructure and telecom connectivity for inclusive rural development through an integrated service delivery model.

- It also supports **WSIS Action Line C6** by enabling a policy and implementation environment for inclusive digital development.

Champion Projects: Among the **18 award categories** under the WSIS Prizes 2026, only **2 projects** from India were selected as Champion Projects titles

About Samriddh Gram:

Framework: Powered by **BharatNet**, Samriddh Gram is a rural digital transformation initiative that leverages connectivity to provide healthcare, education, digital banking and livelihood services through village-level Samriddhi Kendras.

Implementation: Samriddhi Kendras serve as **one-stop village-level hubs** delivering integrated phygital services through reliable telecom connectivity, digital platforms and assisted physical service delivery.

Integration: The initiative integrates diverse citizen-centric services under one roof, including healthcare, education, agriculture, financial inclusion, skilling, Electronic (e-Governance), and e-commerce.

Services: The Samriddh Gram Centre ensures seamless access to essential services, promotes inclusive, technology-driven rural transformation, and its services include:

- Tele-consultation, diagnostic services via Health Automated Teller Machines (**Health ATMs**)
- Medicines through Pradhan Mantri Jan Aushadhi Kendras **(PMJAKs)**.
- Augmented Reality (**AR**)/Virtual Reality (**VR**)-based education and skill training
- Internet of Things (**IoT**) and drone-enabled agricultural solutions
- Common Services Centres (**CSC**)/e-Governance and banking services
- e-commerce of local products,
- Fiber-to-the-Home (**FTTH**) and Pradhan Mantri Wi-Fi Access Network Interface (**PM-WANI**) connectivity.
- Closed-Circuit Television **(CCTV**)-based village surveillance
- Community digital facilitation

BharatNet: One of the world's largest rural broadband initiatives, has connected over 2.17 lakh Gram Panchayats, enabling digital access and opportunities across rural India.

About International Telecommunication Union (ITU):

Secretary-General – Doreen Bogdan-Martin
Established – 1865
Headquarters – Geneva, Switzerland

Founder of Reliance Foundation Nita Ambani Received Fortune India MPW Honour

In July 2026, **Nita Ambani,** founder and chairperson of Reliance Foundation, felicitated with the **Fortune India Most Powerful Women (MPW) honour** for her visionary leadership, commitment to building institutions and inclusive development across India, at the Fortune India MPW event held in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Received Fortune India Most Powerful Women Honour 2026
- ✓ **Who?** Nita Ambani, Founder & Chairperson of Reliance Foundation
- ✓ **Where?** Fortune India MPW event (Mumbai, Maharashtra)
- ✓ **Honoured for:** Visionary leadership, institution building, and inclusive development
- ✓ **Top 5 MPW 2026:** Nita Ambani (1st), Roshni Nadar (2nd), Reddy Sisters (3rd), Savitri Jindal (4th), Dr. Priti Adani (5th).

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Key Details of Event:

Key People: She was honoured in the presence of Jishu Deve Varma, Governor of Maharashtra; Union Minister of State (MoS) Anupriya Patel, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW), among others.

Other Global Honor: Earlier in July 2026, she was honoured with the AAPI Humanitarian Award by the American Association of Physicians of Indian Origin (AAPI) for her exceptional contributions across healthcare, education, sports, culture and community development, during an official ceremony organised in Tampa, Florida, the United States of America (USA).

Fortune India MPW 2026:

Launch of MPW 2026 List: The event also witnessed the launch of Fortune India MPW 2026 list, recognising 100 women for shaping the country's economic and business scenario.

Top 5 MPW in India: Other that Nita Ambani, Roshni Nadar, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of HCL Technologies (ranked at 2nd spot); Reddy Sisters: Shobana Kamineni; Sangita Reddy; Preetha Reddy; Suneeta Reddy; owners of Apollo Hospitals Enterprise (collectively ranked at 3rd spot); Savirti Jindal, Chairperson Emeritus, OP Jindal Group (ranked at 4th spot) and Dr. Priti Adani, founder of Adani Foundation (ranked at 5th spot); featured among India's top5 MPW list.

About Fortune India:

Editor-in Chief- Sourav Majumdar

Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi

Established- 2010

FIU-IND Named as Runner-up at BECA 2026 For its Case Regarding Large-scale Cyber Fraud

In July 2026, the Financial Intelligence Unit – India **(FIU-IND)** was named **runner-up** at Best Egmont Case Award **(BECA) 2026,** one of the Egmont Group's highest honours, for uncovering a large-scale cyber fraud and demonstrating excellence in financial intelligence and global cooperation.

- **Anil Mohan Govil,** Director of FIU-IND, received the award during the Egmont Group Plenary held in Baku, Azerbaijan.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Best Egmont Case Award (BECA) 2026
- ✓ **Received by**? FIU-IND
- ✓ **Award Ceremony Held at:** Egmont Group Plenary (Baku, Azerbaijan)
- ✓ **Recognised for:** Case regarding large-scale Cyber fraud

Key Details:

Key Accomplishment: During its investigation, the FIU-IND traced a sophisticated money laundering network which involved cyber fraud proceeds of nearly Rs 868 crore, over 5,000 mule bank accounts and complex cryptocurrency transactions spanning multiple transactions.

Key Outcome of Investigation: Based on FIU-IND's investigation findings, the Directorate of Enforcement **(ED)** seized **Rs 47 lakh** in cash and cryptocurrency (USDT) valued at approximately Rs 13.6 crore.

- The agency further attached assets worth Rs 8.67 crore, and filed two Prosecution Complaints under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

Winner: Taiwan's Anti-Money Laundering Division (AMLD) won the BECA 2026 for its complex investigation, innovative financial intelligence, and strong international cooperation.

FIU-IND: Established in November 2004 as a central national agency, FIU-IND is mainly responsible for receiving, processing, analyzing and segregating information related to suspicious financial transactions.

Gujarat's Unjha Cumin & Fennel Receive Geographical Indication (GI) Tags

In July 2026, the Geographical Indications Registry **(GIR),** under the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade **(DPIIT),** Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MoC&I), granted Geographical Indication

(**GI**) tag to **Gujarat's** two agricultural products: **Unjha Cumin** and **Fennel,** both originating from Unjha region in north of the state.

- With this latest recognition, the list of GI-tagged agricultural products from Gujarat has now been expanded **to 6** (which already includes Gir Kesar mangoes, Bhalia wheat, Kachchhi Kharek and Amalsadi chikoo).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Granting of GI tag
- ✓ **To:** Gujarat's two agricultural products
- ✓ **Granting Authority:** GIR
- ✓ **Name of Products:** Unjha Cumin and Fennel
- ✓ **GI-tagged Agricultural Products:** 06 (from Gujarat)

Key Details:

Facilitated by: The GIs tag for these products were facilitated by the Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC), Unjha, the Department of Horticulture and Farmers' Welfare of Gujarat Government; the Sardarkrushinagar Dantiwada Agricultural University (SDAU), the Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India (EDII), Gujarat and the Government of India (GoI).

About Fennel Seeds:

Origin: Unjha in Mehsana district, Gujarat, is India's largest fennel-producing region and one of Asia's largest fennel trading hubs.

Cultivation: Grown in a semi-arid climate with well-drained sandy soils and cool winters.

Key Features: Rich in anethole, giving the seeds a sweet aroma and distinctive green colour.

Key Benefit: Known for digestive properties and rich in fibre, Vitamin C, Calcium (Ca), Iron (Fe), Magnesium (Mg), and Potassium (K).

About Unjha Cumin:

Origin: Cultivated in the dry, sandy soils of the Unjha region of Gujarat.

Key Features: Rich in cuminaldehyde, which imparts its strong aroma, distinctive flavour, and high essential oil content.

Key Contributions of NABARD in GI Registrations:

GI Support: The National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) has facilitated the GI registration of 28 new products, taking its total GI-supported products to 176.

Categories: The 28 new GI products include handicrafts, handloom textiles, bamboo crafts, metalwork, pottery, paintings, and musical instruments.

- These include Nalanda Bawan Buti Saree & Fabrics, Gaya Pattharkatti Stone Craft (Bihar), Kuchai Silk Saree & Fabrics (Jharkhand), Ba Shilp (Bamboo Craft), and Bihu Pepa (Assam).

NABARD's GI-led Interventions: NABARD's GI initiatives have connected 13,000+ artisans and producers to markets, generating 50,000+ direct jobs.

Supports REPOs: NABARD has supported 14 Rural Enterprise Producer Organisations (REPOs) for GI products across Madhya Pradesh (MP), Uttar Pradesh (UP), Bihar, Jammu & Kashmir (J&K), Karnataka, and Gujarat.

Setting Up GI Facilitation Centres: NABARD has established GI Facilitation Centres at the Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India (EDII), Ahmedabad (Gujarat), Bihar Agricultural University (BAU), and Madurai Agri-Business Incubation Forum (MABIF), Tamil Nadu (TN).

About Geographical Indication (GI) Tag:

Overview: A GI identifies products whose quality, reputation, or characteristics are linked to a specific geographical origin.

Administered by: The Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999, effective from 15 September 2003.

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Time Period: A GI registration is valid for 10 years and can be renewed for successive 10-year periods.
First GI-tagged Product: Darjeeling Tea (2004).
Total GI Products: 822 (as of July 2026).
Top 3 States: Uttar Pradesh (UP) with a total of 83 GI registrations, leads among all states in India, followed by TN (76) and West Bengal (WB) (59).

About Gujarat:

Capital- Gandhinagar
Chief Minister (CM)- Bhupendrabhai Patel
Governor- Acharya Devvrat
National Parks (NP)- Gir NP, Marine NP

India Wins 5 Gold Medals at 56th International Physics Olympiad 2026 in Bucaramanga, Colombia

In July 2026, **India** recorded its best-ever performance at the **56th International Physics Olympiad** (IPhO 2026), held in Bucaramanga, Colombia, from 4 to 12 July 2026, with all **five** Indian participants winning **gold** medals.

- **India** secured **joint first place** in the overall medal tally alongside Russia, China, Kazakhstan, South Korea, and Taiwan.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 56th International Physics Olympiad 2026 held
- ✓ **Where?** Bucaramanga, Colombia
- ✓ **India's Performance:** 5 Gold Medals
- ✓ **Overall Rank:** Joint 1st (with Russia, China, Kazakhstan, South Korea & Taiwan)
- ✓ **Indian Gold Medal Winners:** Kanishk Jain, Riddhesh Anant Bendale, Rishit Garg, Shresth Suraiya & Svarit Joshi.

Highlights of IPhO 2026:

Indian Gold Medal Winners: Kanishk Jain (Pune, Maharashtra), Riddhesh Anant Bendale (Indore, Madhya Pradesh, MP), Rishit Garg (New Delhi, Delhi), Shresth Suraiya (Mumbai, Maharashtra), and Svarit Joshi (Ahmedabad, Gujarat).
India's Performance: This was India's **27th participation** in the IPhO, with every Indian participant over the last decade winning either a gold or silver medal.
National Olympiad Programme: The Indian team was selected and trained by the Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education (HBCSE), a National Centre of the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) under the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE).
About IPhO: Established in **1967**, the IPhO is an annual international competition that tests the theoretical and experimental physics skills of pre-university students.

Social Activist Dr. Nandini Azad Receives Bharat Samman 2026 for Women's Empowerment

In July 2026, **Dr. Nandini Azad**, President of the Working Women's Forum (India) (WWF-I) and the Indian Cooperative Network for Women (ICNW), received the **Bharat Samman 2026,** in recognition of her lifelong contributions to women's empowerment, financial inclusion, and grassroots social development.

- The award was presented at an event held in Dehradun, Uttarakhand, by the International Institute of Education and Management **(IIEM)** in association with the Economic Growth Foundation **(EGF)**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Bharat Samman 2026 awarded

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- ✓ **Recipient:** Dr. Nandini Azad, President of WWF-I and ICNW
- ✓ **Presented by:** IIEM & EGF
- ✓ **Awarded For:** Lifetime contribution to women's empowerment.

About Bharat Samman 2026:

Award: The Bharat Samman is a national honour presented to individuals for their exceptional contribution to nation-building, social development, public service, education, healthcare, culture, and women's empowerment.

Recognition: It honours Dr. Nandini Azad for her lifelong contributions to women's empowerment, financial inclusion, grassroots social development, and gender equality, social justice, and sustainable community development, through transformative grassroots institutions.

Leadership: Dr. Azad has led one of India's largest and most influential women-led grassroots cooperative movements, expanding the organisations to more than 615,000 women members across four southern states and providing them with access to microcredit, livelihood opportunities, leadership training, and social support.

Gujarat Bags Agriculture Leadership Award 2026 for Horticulture

In July 2026, **Gujarat** was honoured with the **Agriculture Leadership Award 2026** for its performance in horticulture at the 17th Agriculture Leadership Conclave-2026 held in New Delhi, Delhi.

- **Union Minister Rajnath Singh,** Ministry of Defence (MoD), presented the award to **Jitu Vaghani,** Agriculture Minister, Government of Gujarat in the presence of Haribhau Kisanrao Bagde, Governor of Rajasthan.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Agriculture Leadership Award 2026 awarded
- ✓ **Recipient:** Gujarat Government
- ✓ **Presented By:** Union Minister Rajnath Singh, MoD
- ✓ **Received By:** Jitu Vaghani, Agriculture Minister, Gujarat
- ✓ **Event:** 17th Agriculture Leadership Conclave-2026, New Delhi, Delhi.

About National Agriculture Leadership Award 2026:

Award: Introduced in **2008** on the recommendation of agricultural scientist **M. S. Swaminathan**, the Agriculture Leadership Award by **Agriculture Today Group** recognises exceptional innovations and performance in the agriculture sector by states and institutes.

Jury: The award selection committee is headed by Justice P. Sathasivam, former Chief Justice of India (**CJI**), reflecting the award's credibility, transparency and prestige.

Agricultural Growth: Gujarat's agriculture was transformed through Krushi Mahotsav, Soil Health Card, and drip irrigation, achieving 9.9% growth during the Tenth Five-Year Plan (2002–2007).

- The state's horticulture sector grew significantly with improved irrigation, modern farming techniques, and government support.

Legacy: Gujarat secured the Agriculture Leadership Award for Best Agriculture State in 2009, 2014, 2018, and was honoured for exceptional performance in animal husbandry in 2019.

72nd National Film Award for the Year 2024: 'Article 370' Named Best Feature Film award

In July 2026, The jury of the 72nd National Film Awards announced the list of winners of the National Award for the year **2024**, recognising excellence across feature films, non-feature films and writing on cinema.

- The awards were announced by Jayaraj, Chairperson of Feature Film Jury; Aseem Sinha, Chairperson of Non-Feature Film Jury; and A. Chandrasekhar, Chairperson of Best Writing on Cinema Jury, in New Delhi, Delhi.

- **Article 370,** directed by **Aditya Suhas Jambhale,** won the Best Feature Film award for 2024. In addition, the film won two more awards in "Best Actress" and "Best Music Direction" categories.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Winners of the 72nd National Film Awards announced
- ✓ **For Year:** 2024
- ✓ **Best Feature Film:** Article 370 (Hindi), directed by Aditya Suhas Jambhale,
- ✓ **Best Actor for feature film:** Mammootty (Bramayugam)and Actor Kartik Aaryan (Chandu Champion)
- ✓ **Best Actress:** Yami Gautam for Article 370 (Hindi)
- ✓ **Best Popular Film:** Kalki 2898 AD
- ✓ **Best Debut Director:** Randeep Hooda for "Swatantrya Veer Savarkar" (Hindi)

Key Winners:

Best Actor: Renowned Malayalam Actor Mammootty and Actor Kartik Aaryan were jointly named as the Best Actor in Leading for their acclaimed performance in Bramayugam (Malayalam film) and Hindi sports drama Chandu Champion, respectively.

- With this honour, Mammootty won his 4th National Film Award after Oru Vadakkan Veeragatha and Mathilukkal (1989), Ponthan Mada and Vidheyan (1994) and Dr. Ambedkar (1999).
- The actors will share the Rajat Kamal (Silver Lotus award) and the cash prize of Rs. 2 lakhs.

Best Actress: This year, renowned actress **Yami Gautam** bagged the "Best Actress" for the Hindi film (Article 370), marking her career 1st-ever National Film Award. She will be honoured with a silver lotus award and a cash prize of Rs. 2 lakhs.

Best Direction: Rajkumar Periyasamy won the National Award for Best Direction for Tamil film "Amaran".

Best Popular Film: Mythological sci-fi action film, Kalki 2898 AD, directed by Nag Ashwin, bagged the award for Best Popular Film Providing Wholesome Entertainment.

Best Debut Director: Famous Actor Randeep Hooda won the Award for Best Debut Film of a Director for film Swatantrya Veer Savarkar (Hindi), biographical drama focused on the life of Hindutva ideologue Vinayak Damodar (VD) Savarkar.

Special Mention: Tamil actor and filmmaker Dhanush honoured with a Special Mention for his exceptional performance in Captain Miller.

- In addition, his directorial film Raayan won the Best Tamil Film award.

Some of the key Winners in Non-Feature: Bhangaar (Marathi and English), directed by Sumira Roy, won the Best Non-Feature Film award.

- Bharatbala Ganapathy directed Ram-Nami, was named Best Documentary.
- Ravi Raj won the Best Debut Film of a Director award for film Angen (Santhali).
- Famous filmmaker Aanand L. Rai won the Best Direction award for the documentary "Statue of Unity – Ekta ka Prateek".

About National Film Awards:

Established: The National Film Awards, the most prominent film award, established in **1954** by the Government of India (GoI) to celebrate excellence in cinema across all languages, regions, and formats.

Administered by: National Film Development Corporation (NFDC) under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB).

Sections: The awards are divided into **three sections** such as Feature films, Non-Feature films, and Best Writing on Cinema.

Categories: Six categories from the Feature film section, Two from the Non-Feature films and Best Writing on Cinema sections have been made eligible for Swarna Kamal (Golden Lotus Award), and the rest of the categories for Rajat Kamal (Silver Lotus Award).

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Films Certified by: The awards for 2024 were given to the films certified by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) between January 01 and December 31, 2024.

Winners of 72nd National Film Awards – Feature Film

Category	Film (Language)	Awardee	Medal & Cash Prize
Best Feature Film	Article 370 (Hindi)	Producer: Jio Studios & B62 Studios Director: Aditya Suhas Jambhale	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakhs each
Best Debut Film of a Director	Swatantrya Veer Savarkar (Hindi)	Director: Randeep Hooda	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakh
Award for Best Popular Film Providing Wholesome Entertainment	Kalki 2898 AD (Telugu)	Producer: Vyjayanthi Movies Director: Nag Ashwin Singireddy	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakhs each
Best Feature Film Promoting National, Social and Environmental Values	Captain Miller (Tamil)	Producer: Sathya Jyothi Films Director: Arun Matheswaran	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakhs each
Best Children's Film	35- Chinna Katha Kaadu (Telugu)	Producer: S Originals & Waltair Productions Pvt. Ltd. Director: Nanda Kishore Emani	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakhs each
Best Direction	Amaran (Tamil)	Director: Rajkumar Periasamy	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakh
Best Actor in a Leading Role	Bramayugam (Malayalam)	Actor: Mammootty	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakhs (shared)
	Chandu Champion	Actor: Kartik Aaryan	
Best Actress in a Leading Role	Article 370 (Hindi)	Actress: Yami Gautam	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Actor in a Supporting Role	Bhakshak (Hindi)	Supporting Actor: Sanjay Mishra	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh

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Best Actress in a Supporting Role	Maharaja (Tamil)	Supporting Actress: Sachana Namidass	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakhs each
	Mithya (Kannada)	Supporting Actress: Ropashree Varkady	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakhs (shared)
Best Child Artist	Mithya (Kannada)	Child Artist: Athish S Shetty	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (shared)
	35- Chinna Katha Kaadu (Telugu)	Child Artist: Arundev Pothula	
	Onko Ki Kothin (Bengali)	Child Artist: Riddhiman Banerjee Tapomoy Deb Gitashree Chakraborty	
Best Male Playback Singer	Gharat Ganpati (Marathi)	Male Playback Singer: Abhay Jodhpurkar (For Song: Navasachi Gauri Mazi)	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Female Playback Singer	A.R.M. (Malayalam)	Female Playback Singer: Vaikom Vijayalakshmi (For Song: Angu Vaana Konilu)	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Cinematography	Bramayugam (Malayalam)	Cinematographer: Shehnad Jalal	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Screenplay	Pushpa (The Rule Part-02) (Telugu)	Screenplay Writer (Original): Bandreddi Sukumar	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh each
	Swargandharva Sudhir Phadke (Marathi)	Screenplay Writer (Adapted): Yogesh Deshpande	
	Lucky Baskhar (Telugu)	Dialogue Writer: Venky Atluri	
Best Sound Design	Bhool Bhulaiyaa (Hindi)	Sound Designer: Manas Choudhary	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh

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Best Editing	Amaran (Tamil)	Editor: Kalaivannan	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Production Design	Kalki 2898 AD (Telugu)	Production Designer: Nitin Zihani Choudhary	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Costume Design	Pushpa (The Rule Part-02) (Telugu)	Costume Designer: Deepali Noor & Sheetal Sharma	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (shared)
Best Make-up	Committee Kurrollu (Telugu)	Make-up Artist: P Ravi Kumar	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Music Direction	Article 370 (Hindi)	Music Director (Songs): Shashwat Sachdev	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
	Amaran (Tamil)	Music Director (Background Music): G.V. Prakash Kumar	
Best Lyrics	Maidaan (Hindi)	Lyricist: Manoj Muntashir (For Song: Janne Do)	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Choreography	Stree 2 (Hindi)	Choreographer: Vijay Gangu (For Song: Aaj ki Raat)	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Action Direction (Stunt Choreography)	Maharaja (Tamil)	Stunt Choreographer: Anl Arasu	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh

Best Feature Film Language-wise:

Category	Film	Awardee	Medal & Cash Prize
Best Feature Film in each of the language specified in the Schedule VIII of the Constitution			
Best Assamese Film	Juiphool	Producer & Director: Jadumoni Dutta	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)

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Best Bengal Film	Chalchitra Ekhon	Producer: Anjan Dutt Production Director: Anjan Dutt	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Hindi Film	Srikanth	Producer: Super Cassettes Industries Pvt. Ltd.; Chalk N Cheese Films Production LLP Director: Tushar Hiranandani	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Kannada Film	Mithya	Producer: Paramvah Pictures & KRG Studios Director: Sumanth Bhat	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Malayalam Film	Feminichi Fathima	Producer: 1001 Stories & AFD Cinemas Director: Fasil Muhammed	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Marathi Film	Mukkam Post Bombilwadi	Producer: Vivek Films; Mayasabha Karamanuk Mandali LLP Director: Paresh Mokashi	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Odia Film	Lahari	Producer: Jhilik Motion Pictures Director: Amartya Bhattacharyya	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Tamil Film	Raayan	Producer: Sun TV Network Limited Director: Dhanush	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Telugu Film	Committee Kurrollu	Producer: Pink Elephant Pictures; Shree Radha Damodara Studios Director: Yadhu Vamsee	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Gujarati Film	Maaran	Producer: Anjan Dutt Production Director: Anjan Dutt	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Manipuri Film	Sunita	Producer: Skyline Pictures, Khuman Leipak Pictures, H.M. Production & Cultural Society Khuman Maheikol Production Director: Yumnam Ajit Singh	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Konkani Film	Mog Asum	Producer: Flowing Mandovi Films LLP, RS Creations Kathputlee Arts and Films Pvt. Ltd.	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)

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Best Feature Film in each of the Languages other than those specified in Schedule VIII of the Constitution			
Best Tulu Film	IMBU	Producer: Pichchar Studio Director: Shivadhwaj Shetty	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Garhwali Film	Dholi	Producer: SC Pharmachem Pvt. Ltd. Director: Dinesh P. Bhonsle	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Special Mention	Captain Miller	Actor: Dhanush	Certificate
	Meiyazhagan (Tamil)	Film Sound Mix Engineer: Suren G.	

Winners of 72nd National Film Awards: Non-Feature Film

Category Award	Film (Language)	Awardee	Medal & Cash Prize
Best Non-Feature Film	Bhangaar (Marathi & English)	Producer & Director: Sumira Roy	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakh (each)
Best Debut Film of a Director	Angen (Santhali)	Director: Ravi Raj Murmu	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakh (each)
Best Biographical/ Historical Reconstruction/Compilation Film	Kakori (Hindi)	Producer: KSR Brothers, Minti Mishra Director: Kamlesh K Mishra	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Arts/ Culture Film	Main Nida (Hindi)	Producer: Sampreshan Multimedia Pvt. Ltd. Director: Atul Pandey	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Documentary	Ram-Nami (Hindi)	Producer: BBP Studio Virtual Bharat Pvt. Ltd. Director: Bharatbala Ganapathy	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)

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Best Non-Feature Film Promoting Social and Environmental Values	Piplantri: A Tale of Eco Feminism (Hindi, Rajasthani, and English)	Producer: Johnsons Suraj Films International Director: Suraj Kumar	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Animation Film	Touched as Water (Silent)	Producer: JB Productions Director & Animator: Joshy Benedict	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Short Film (Up to 30 mins.)	Hamsafar (Marathi)	Producer: Anushka Motion Pictures and Entertainments Director: Abhijeet Arvind Dalvi	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh (each)
Best Direction	Statue of Unity-Ekta ka Prateek (Hindi)	Director: Aanand L. Rai	Swarna Kamal and Rs 3 lakh
Best Cinematography	Life Loom (English, Tamil, Hindi, Assamese and Bengali)	Cinematographer: Edmond Ranson	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Sound Design	Blue (Tamil)	Sound Engineer: T S Hari Hara Sudhan	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Editing	NDA (Hindi)	Editor: Manvir Jarotia	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Music Direction	Parat 41°chya Magavar (On the Trail of 41°)	Music Director: Shivpal Singh Kang	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Narration/ Voice Over	Little Planet: A Tale of Frogs (English)	Narrator: Soundarya Jayachandran	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh
Best Script	Obur (Hindi & Kashmiri)	Script Writer: Faraz Ali	Rajat Kamal and Rs 2 lakh

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Special Mention	Bhadra-Kali Natakam (Malayalam)	Director: Ananda Jyothi (Jose Antony)	Certificate
	Chola Dora aur Sui (Hindi)	Director: Jaymin Modi and Lokesh Ghai	Certificate (each)

72nd National Film Awards: Best Book on Cinema

Title of the Book	Language	Name of the Author	Name of the Publisher	Medal and Cash Prize
Naaniruvude Nimagaagu Naadiruvude Nanagaagi: Kannada Cinemada Thathvamatthu Rajakeeya	Kannada	Kenchanuru Pradeep Kumar Shetty	Mirror Pusthaka	Swarna Kamal and Rs 1 lakh (each)

72nd National Film Awards: Best Film Critic

Name of Critic	Language	Medal and Cash Prize
Sanjeev Shrivastava	Hindi	Swarna Kamal and Rs 1 lakh

About Directorate of Film Festivals (DFF):

In 2022, the Government of India (GoI) merged the DFF into the National Film Development Corporation (NFDC) and since then, the all film festival and promotion are managed by NFDC.

Chairperson of NFDC- G. Krishnakumar

Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi

Established in: 1973

NSA Ajit Doval Selected for Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026

In July 2026, Dr. Rohit Tilak, President of the Lokmanya Tilak Trust announced the selection of National Security Advisor **(NSA) Ajit Doval** for Lokmanya Tilak National Award for 2026.

- He will receive the award in recognition of his outstanding contribution to strengthening the country's national security, counter-terrorism, and border security.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Winner of Lokmany Tilak National Award for 2026
- ✓ **Who?** NSA Ajit Doval
- ✓ **Official Ceremony Scheduled:** On August 01, 2026 (Pune, Maharashtra)
- ✓ **Occasion:** 106th death anniversary of Lokmanya Tilak

About Lokmanya Tilak National Award:

Ceremony: Union Minister Amit Shah, Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) will present the award on **August 01, 2026** in Pune (Maharashtra) on the occasion of the **106th** death anniversary of a freedom fighter Bal Gangadhar Tilak, widely known as Lokmany Tilak.

Background: The award was instituted in 1983, to recognise the individuals for their outstanding contributions to the country's progress and development.

- Socialist Leader SM Joshi was the 1st recipient of Lokmanya Tilak National Award

Presented: The award is presented annually on August 01, by Lokmanya Tilak Trust.
Prize: The recipient of the award receives a memento, a citation and a cash prize of Rs 1 lakh.
Previous Winners: Since its inception, the award has been presented to several distinguished personalities such as Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, former PMs of the country (Dr. Manmohan Singh and Atal Bihari Vajpayee) and former President of India Dr. Pranab Mukherjee and veteran leader and founder of CP Sharad Pawar.
Ajit Doval: Doval, a 1968-batch Indian Police Service (IPS) officer of Kerala cadre, is the currently India's longest-serving NSA.

- During his career, he play a major role in several national security initiatives such as: Operation Black Thunder, Balakot air-strike.

Eight-Year-Old Iya Krish Becomes Youngest Asian to Summit North Africa's Highest Peak 'Mount Toubkal'

In July 2026, **Iya Krish**, an eight-year-old mountaineer from **Thrissur, Kerala**, successfully scaled **Mount Toubkal (4,167 metre, m)**, the highest peak in **North Africa**, in Morocco's Atlas Mountains, becoming the **youngest person from Asia** to achieve the feat after a three-day expedition led by Greenway Adventures Travel & Tourism LLC.

- The summit involved covering approximately **42 kilometers (km)** with an **elevation gain of over 2,900 m**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** The youngest Asian to summit Mount Toubkal.
- ✓ **Who?** Eight-year-old Iya Krish
- ✓ **Native:** Thrissur, Kerala
- ✓ **Where?** Atlas Mountains, Morocco
- ✓ **Trek:** Duration-3 days, Distance-42 km, elevation gain-2900 m
- ✓ **Mount Toubkal:** Height – 4,167 m, North Africa's highest peak

About Iya Krish:

Preparation: Living in Fujairah, United Arab Emirates (UAE), Iya prepared through regular weekend trekking in the mountains of Ras Al Khaimah and Fujairah, along with Kalaripayattu training to improve endurance and fitness.
Previous Record: At the age of 5 years 11 months, Iya had already climbed Jebel Jais (1,934 m), the highest mountain in the UAE, marking the beginning of her mountaineering journey.
Future Goals: Her future mountaineering ambitions include climbing Mount Elbrus in Russia, Mount Kilimanjaro in Tanzania, and ultimately Mount Everest located on the Nepal–Tibet (China) border, with the goal of summiting Everest before the age of 12.

DBS Named World's Best Corporate Bank by Global Finance

In July 2026, **DBS Bank Limited**, a Singaporean multinational banking and financial services corporation, was awarded the **World's Best Corporate Bank** at the **2026 Global Bank Awards** by 'Global Finance magazine', becoming the first Southeast Asian bank to win this accolade since the category's inception in 2005.

- DBS also won the titles of Asia's Best Bank and Singapore's Best Bank at the 2026 Global Bank Awards.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** World's Best Corporate Bank awarded
- ✓ **Bank:** DBS Bank Ltd (Singapore)
- ✓ **Event:** 2026 Global Bank Awards

- ✓ **Awarding Body:** Global Finance magazine
- ✓ **Significance:** First time a Southeast Asian bank has won this award since its launch in 2005
- ✓ **Other Titles:** Asia's Best Bank and Singapore's Best Bank.

About 2026 Global Bank Awards:

Evaluation: Global Finance magazine's editorial board, with input from corporate financial executives, analysts, and bankers worldwide, selected winners based on annual performance, reputation, and management excellence.

Recognition: The award recognises DBS's leadership in corporate banking, deep client trust, innovative infrastructure and advanced digital solutions tailored for global corporate clients.

Other recognitions in 2026: Other major winners at the 2026 Global Bank Awards included Santander (Spain) as World's Best Bank, State Bank of India (India) as World's Best Consumer Bank, BBVA (Spain) as World's Best Emerging Markets Bank, Ecobank (Togo) as World's Best Frontier Markets Bank, and CIBC Mellon (Canada) as World's Best Sub-Custodian Bank.

- Best Corporate Bank in Asia (Coalition Greenwich, United States of America (USA)), Best Bank for Financial Institutions in Asia-Pacific (Global Finance, USA), Best Transaction Bank in Asia-Pacific (Global Finance, USA), and Best Bank for SMEs (Small and Medium-sized Enterprises) in Asia & Singapore (Euromoney, United Kingdom (UK))

About DBS Bank:

Established – 1968

Headquarteres – Marina Bay Financial Centre, Singapore

Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** – Tan Su Shan

Prem K. Vora Honoured with Rashtriya Ashok Samman (Bharat Samman) in New Delhi

In July 2026, **Prem K. Vora,** President of the Electric Merchants Association **(EMA)** for **2025-26,** was honoured with the **Rashtriya Ashok Samman (Bharat Samman)** at the National Leadership Conclave held in New Delhi, Delhi.

- He received the honor in recognition of his exceptional contribution to India's electrical trade sector and his commitment to ethical business practices, and his dedication to strengthening Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) while driving sustainable industry growth.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **Award:** Rashtriya Ashok Samman (Bharat Samman)
- ✓ **Winner:** Prem K. Vora, President of EMA for 2025-26
- ✓ **Award Felicitated at:** National Leadership Conclave (New Delhi, Delhi)
- ✓ **Recognition:** Honored for his exceptional contribution to India's electrical trade sector

Key Details:

Leadership: Under the leadership of Vora, who serves as the youngest President of EMA, EMA has actively promoted digital transformation, encouraged the adoption of sustainable business practices via the "Green Electricals" initiative and bolstered the industry representation for the electrical trade.

Other Awards: Previously, he was honoured with various national awards for his visionary leadership and outstanding contributions to the electrical industry such as: Global Youth Ambassador Award 2025, Global Youth Ambassador Award 2026, and the Iconic Emerging Leader in the Electrical Industry 2025.

About EMA: Established in 1937, EMA is a not-for-profit making body that serves the electrical industry and trade to protect and promote the interests of the industry. It is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

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Union Minister Jyotiraditya M. Scindia confers Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya Telecom Excellence Awards-2025

In July 2026, Union Minister **Jyotiraditya M. Scindia,** Ministry of Communications, Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (MDoNER) conferred the **Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya Telecom Excellence Awards for 2025** to two organizations namely, **Amantya Technologies Pvt. Ltd**. and **Finaara,** for their exceptional contributions in Telecom Technology.

- The awards were felicitated at the theme launch of the **10th** edition of the India Mobile Congress (**IMC 2026**), which is scheduled to be held from **October 7 to 10, 2026**, at Yashobhoomi, India International Convention & Expo Centre (IICEC) in **New Delhi, Delhi.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya Telecom Excellence Awards (2025)
- ✓ **Winners:** Amantya Technologies Pvt. Ltd. and Finaara
- ✓ **Conferred by:** Union Minister Jyotiraditya M. Scindia, Ministry of Communications, MDoNER
- ✓ **Where?** At the theme launch event of IMC 2026
- ✓ **Cash Prize:** Rs 2 lakh (each recipient)
- ✓ **Awards Presented Annually by:** DoT under the Ministry of Communications
- ✓ **Theme for IMC 2026:** "Scale without Boundaries"
- ✓ **IMC 2026 held in:** New Delhi, Delhi.

About Pt. Deendayal Upadhyaya Telecom Excellence Awards:

Overview: The awards have been instituted by Department of Telecommunications (DoT) which works under the Ministry of Communications, to promote breakthrough innovations in the telecom sector.

Key Focus Areas: The awards are presented annually to the successful telecom skilled people and institutions of India for their exemplary contributions in the areas of telecom innovations, telecom skilling, telecom services, telecom manufacturing for different fields such as agriculture, commerce, health, education and others.

Selection: The selection process for the awards include: nomination by all Indian citizens as well as institutions registered in India through Rashtriya Puraskar Portal managed by Director General (DG), Awards at the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).

Recipient Limit: A maximum of 5 awards are given each year to individuals, organisations or institutions, subject to a condition of a suitable candidate being selected by the award committee for that particular year.

Cash Prize and Citation: Each recipient receives a shawl, citation, plaque, and a cash prize of Rs 2 lakh.

Key Highlights of the Event:

Theme Launch for IMC 2026: Union Minister Jyotiraditya M. Scindia unveiled **"Scale without Boundaries"** as the theme for IMC 2026, Asia's largest digital technology forum.

About IMC 2026:

Thematic Pillars: This year's IMC will be structured around four thematic pillars:

- **Srishti –** Building the Future, focusing on innovation and next-generation digital infrastructure.
- **Suraksha –** Strengthening Trust, ensuring secure and resilient digital ecosystems.
- **Sashakt –** Expanding Opportunities, aimed at using technology for inclusive growth and expanding digital access.
- **Samvardhan –** Accelerating Growth, reflecting the role of digital technologies in driving investment, entrepreneurship, job generation and India's emergence as a global technology leader.

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Technologies: The 10th edition of IMC will showcase innovations across technologies including 5th Generation(5G), 6G, Artificial Intelligence (AI), Internet of Things (IoT), cloud and edge computing, electronics manufacturing, quantum technologies, among others.

Participants: IMC 2026, organised by the **DoT** in partnership with Cellular Operators Association of India **(COAI)**, is expected to bring together leading global and Indian technology companies, telecom operators, policymakers, startups, investors, researchers and innovators under one platform.

About Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI): The COAI, established in 1995 and headquartered in New Delhi, is the apex industry body representing India's telecom and digital communications sector.

2026 Fields Medal Awarded to Yu Deng, John Pardon, Jacob Tsimerman, and Hong Wang

In July 2026, the International Mathematical Union **(IMU)** named **John Pardon, Yu Deng, Jacob Tsimerman** and **Hong Wang** as winners of **2026 Fields Medal,** which is also known as **the "Nobel Prize of Mathematics".**

- The medals were awarded at the opening ceremony of the International Congress of Mathematicians **(ICM)** held in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, the United States of America (USA).
- **Yu Deng** and **Hong Wang** became the 1st Chinese nationals to receive the award, since 1982 (after Shing-Tung Yau, Tshinghua University).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Winners of 2026 Fields Medal
- ✓ **Field Medal commonly Referred as:** "Nobel Prize of Mathematics".
- ✓ **Winners Name:** John Pardon, Yu Deng, Jacob Tsimerman and Hong Wang
- ✓ **Official Award Ceremony:** At the International Congress of Mathematicians (Philadelphia, the USA)
- ✓ **Eligible Age:** Under the age of 40 years
- ✓ **Cash Prize:** CND 15,000

About 2026 Winners and their Contribution:

John Pardon: He is currently working as professor in the State University of New York at Stony Brook (Stony Brook University) Simons Centre (the USA) for Geometry and Physics.

- **3rd Member from Stony Brook:** Also, he became the 3rd faculty member from Stony Brook University to receive the award after John Milnor (1962); Sir Simon Donaldson (1986).
- **Key Achievements:** Pardon was honoured for his achievements in symplectic geometry, including new approaches to virtual fundamental cycles, Fukaya categories of certain manifolds and counting holomorphic curves. In addition, he also made significant contributions to other areas like: geometry and topology (including knot theory).

Yu Deng: Dung, a mathematician at the University of Chicago (the USA).

- **Key Contribution:** He received the award in recognition of his contribution in partial differential equations, including the Boltzmann equation from hard-sphere dynamics for rarefield gases; and work in the derivation of wave kinetic equations from non-linear dispersive systems, among others.

Jacob Tsirmerman: Tsirmerman, a professor of mathematics at the University of Toronto (Canada), became the 1st scholar based at a Canadian institution, and the 2nd Canadian, to receive the award.

- **Key Contribution:** He received the award in recognition of his contribution in proving the decades-old mathematics problem, Andre-Oort conjecture for Siegel modular varieties, Griffiths' conjecture on the algebraicity of images of the period maps and recasting of o-minimality.

Hong Wang: She is currently serving as a professor at New York University (NYU) and a permanent professor at the Institut de Hautes Etudes Scientifiques (IHES) in France.

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- **Historic Milestone:** She scripted history becoming only the 3rd female winner in the 90-year history of the Fields Medal, after Maryam Mirzakhani (2014) and Maryna Viazovska (2022).
- **Key Contribution:** She received the award for solving the century-old mathematics problem, "Kakeya conjecture".

About Fields Medal:

Background: In 1936, Canadian mathematician **John Charles Fields** established a trust-fund, which resulted in the establishment of Fields Medal, named after him.

Aim: To honour outstanding mathematical achievement for existing work and for the promise of future achievement.

Quadrennial Award: It is awarded once **every 4 years** by IMU during the International Congress of Mathematicians

Selection Criteria: The medal is given to a selected cohort of **2 or 4** mathematicians under the **age of 40,** at the 1st of the year of the congress at which the field medals are awarded.

Cash Prize and Medal: Each recipient receives a cash prize of Canadian Dollar (CND) 15,000 (nearly USD 10,600) and a gold medal featuring the image of the Greek mathematician Archimedes.

Funding Support: The medals and monetary prizes are funded by a trust established by J.C. Fields at the University of Toronto.

- This year, the prize fund received financial support from the Fields Institute.

Indian Recipients: So far, only two Indian-origin mathematicians: Manjul **Bhargava (2014)** and **Akshay Venkatesh (2018),** honoured with the Fields Medal.

About International Mathematical Union (IMU):

President- Hiraku Nakajima

Headquarters- Berlin, Germany

Founded in- 1920

ACQUISITION & MERGERS

CCI Clears DWS Group's Nippon Life India AIF Deal and Aditya Birla-led RCB Buyout

In July 2026, the Competition Commission of India (**CCI**), under the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (**MCA**), approved **two** major acquisition proposals under the provisions of the **Competition Act, 2002** in India's **asset management** and **sports business** sectors.

- **Approval 1:** Germany-based DWS Group GmbH & Co. KGaA (**DWS Group**) acquisition of 40% Stake in **Nippon Life India** Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) Management Limited (**NIAIF**) valued at around **Rs.733 crore.**
- **Approval 2:** An **Aditya Birla Group-led consortium** acquired 100% shareholding in **Royal Challengers Sports Private Limited** (RCSPL), owner of the Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) franchise from **United Spirits Limited** (USL) through an all-cash deal worth **Rs.16,660 crore** (approximately USD 1.78 billion), one of the largest sports franchise acquisitions globally.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Two Acquisition approvals by CCI
- ✓ **Nodal Entity:** Ministry of Corporate Affairs
- ✓ **Approval-1:** Acquisition of 40% Stake in NIAIF by DWS Group
- ✓ **Services:** Private credit, listed equities, real estate and venture capital
- ✓ **Approval-2:** Aditya Birla Group-led consortium acquired 100% shareholding in RCSPL from United Spirits Limited

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CCI Clears DWS Group's Acquisition of 40% Stake in Nippon Life India AIF Management

Transaction Details: It was announced in March 2026, makes DWS Group a strategic minority shareholder in NIAIF through the subscription of newly issued equity shares.

NIAIF: Its operations include alternative asset management, manager and/or sponsor to Securities and Exchange Board of India (**SEBI**)-registered AIFs, and providing co-investment portfolio management services.

Significance: The partnership combines NIAIF's domestic expertise with DWS Group's global investment capabilities to strengthen NIAIF's alternative investment platform across **private credit, listed equities, real estate and venture capital**.

DWS Group: It is a Frankfurt-headquartered, Germany-based global asset manager offering investment and portfolio management solutions across diverse asset classes.

CCI Clears Aditya Birla-led Consortium's Rs.16,660 Crore Buyout of IPL Franchise RCB

Aditya Birla Group-led consortium: The consortium comprises Big Banyan Holdings (Aditya Birla Group), Bolt IPL Holdings (Bolt Ventures), Times Internet Limited, Times Cricket LLP (The Times Group), ICQ Opportunities RC Holdco Limited (ICONIQ Group), and Asia Investment Topco II Pte. Limited (Blackstone's BXPE strategy) and other investors.

RCSPL: It owns and operates the RCB franchises in the Indian Premier League (**IPL**) and Women's Premier League (**WPL**).

RCB franchise Appointment: Following the acquisition, **Aryaman Vikram Birla,** Director, Aditya Birla Group as chairman and **Satyan Gajwani,** Chairman of The Times of India Group as Vice Chairman.

About Competition Commission of India (CCI):

Role: Oversees mergers, acquisitions, and corporate combinations while curbing anti-competitive practices and promotes fair competition in India

- **Established-** 2003 (Operational since 2009)
- **Chairperson** – Ravneet Kaur
- **Administrative Ministry-** Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MoCA)
- **Headquarters –** New Delhi, Delhi

Kotak Mahindra Bank to Acquire Deutsche Bank's India Retail and Wealth Business for Rs 281.7 Crore

In July 2026, Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited (**KMBL**), a Private Sector Bank, announced the acquisition of **Deutsche Bank's** India's retail, private banking, and wealth management business for **Rs 281.7 crore**.

- The deal is expected to be completed by **September 2027**, subject to regulatory approvals including the Competition Commission of India **(CCI)**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Acquires Deutsche Bank India retail and wealth business
- ✓ **Who?** Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited
- ✓ **Deal Value:** Rs 282 crore
- ✓ **Regulator:** CCI

Key Details of the Acquisition:

Acquired Business Portfolio: The acquisition includes approximately Rs.29,000 crore in loans, Rs.16,000 crore in deposits, and Rs.10,500 crore in assets under management (AUM).

- The business serves around 1.5 lakh customers and employs nearly 1,000 people.

Strategic Expansion: The acquisition will strengthen Kotak Mahindra Bank's presence in the affluent, private-banking and small and medium enterprise (SME) segments.

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- Both banks will work together to ensure uninterrupted customer services during the transition period.

About Deutsche Bank: Deutsche Bank India is the Indian arm of Deutsche Bank (Germany), operating in India for over **45 years** with services in corporate, investment, retail, private banking, and wealth management.

BPCL Signs Pact To Acquire 40% Stake in Tiki Tar–Shell India JV

In July 2026, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited **(BPCL),** a 'Maharatna' Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) which work under the administrative control of Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), signed a share purchase agreement for the acquisition of **40%** equity stake in Tiki Tar and Shell India Private Limited **(TTSIPL)** for **Rs 85 crore.**

- The acquisition aimed to strengthen BPCL's presence in the bitumen and road infrastructure materials segment.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** BPCL Signed Agreement to Acquire Stake in TTSIPL
- ✓ **Total Stakes to Acquire:** 40%
- ✓ **Total Value:** Rs 85 crore
- ✓ **Timeline:** Within 90 days

Key Details of Acquisition:

Regulatory Approval: The acquisition was approved by the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) which works under the Ministry of Finance (MoF), and is expected to be completed **within 90 days.**

Acquisition process: As per the agreement, BPCL will acquire proposed stakes in TTSIPL (target company) from Shell Overseas Investments B.V.

Key Outcome: Once the transaction completed, BPCL will become the equal Joint Venture (JV) partner in TTSIPL, alongside the existing shareholder.

About TTSIPL: TTSIPL, incorporated in October 2019, manufactures wide range of bitumen-based products (such as modified bitumen, emulsions) used in road construction, and maintenance.

BPCL Acquires 100% Stake in IBV Brazil Petroleo for Rs.2,312 crore

In July 2026, the Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited **(BPCL)**, through its overseas arm BPRL Ventures BV (Bharat PetroResources Limited Ventures BV), acquired the remaining **34.6%** stake of Videocon Energy Brazil Limited **(VEBL)** in IBV Brazil Petroleo Limitada**.**

- With this acquisition, BPCL increased its total shareholding in IBV Brazil Petroleo Limitada from 65.40% to **100%** through a **Rs.2,312 crore deal,** making it a wholly owned subsidiary of BPRL Ventures BV under BPCL.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** BPCL Acquires 100% Stake in IBV Brazil
- ✓ **Arm Involved:** BPRL Ventures BV
- ✓ **Target Company:** IBV Brazil Petroleo Limitada (Brazil)
- ✓ **Stake Acquired:** 34.6% from VEBL
- ✓ **Earlier Holding:** 65.40% stake.

Key Details of Acquisition:

Approval: BPCL completed the stake purchase under the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process **(CIRP)** of VOVL Limited, with approvals from the Government of India **(GoI)** and subject to final registration by Brazilian authorities, as per the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order.

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Asset Details: IBV Brazil Petroleo Limitada holds participating interests in Brazilian oil and gas assets, including the BM-Seal-11 concession, which is under development.
Significance: The acquisition expected to add around 1 million tonnes of oil equivalent (MTOE) to BPCL's annual equity production once output begins from the BM-SEAL-11 block.
About BPCL: It is a 'Maharatna' Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG). Established in 1952 and headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

State Bank of India to Acquire NHB's 10% Stake in RDCL

In June 2026, the State Bank of India (**SBI**), India's largest and oldest Public Sector Bank (PSB), announced the **acquisition** of the National Housing Bank's **(NHB's) 10% stake** in RMBS Development Company Limited **(RDCL)**, a middle-layer Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) focused on residential mortgage-backed securitisation.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Announced to acquire NHB's stake in RDCL
- ✓ **Acquirer:** SBI
- ✓ **Stake Acquired:** 10%
- ✓ **Seller:** National Housing Bank
- ✓ **Company:** RMBS Development Company Limited (RDCL).

Key Details of Acquisition:

Shareholding Change: Following the transaction, the National Housing Bank's **(NHB's)** shareholding in RDCL will decline from 39% to **29%.**
Impact: The acquisition will strengthen RDCL's role in developing a deeper secondary mortgage market by enabling banks and non-bank lenders to pool housing loans, convert them into tradable securities, unlock capital, improve liquidity, and support fresh lending.
About RDCL: RDCL was established in 2024 with a paid-up capital of Rs.500 crore to deepen India's Residential Mortgage-Backed Securities (RMBS) market.

- LIC holds a 10% stake in RDCL, while HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, and Bajaj Finance hold 7% each. Aditya Birla Housing Finance, Tata Capital Housing Finance, Truhome Finance, Grihum Housing Finance, Hero Housing Finance, and IIFL Home Finance each hold a 5% stake.

TPG, GIC & ICICI Bank to Acquire Aseem Infrastructure Finance from NIIF

In July 2026, Global alternative asset management firm TPG Inc., signed definitive agreements to acquire a **100% stake** in Aseem Infrastructure Finance Limited **(AIFL)** from the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund **(NIIF)** and other shareholders for an undisclosed amount.

- The acquisition will be made through 'TPG Rise Climate', TPG's dedicated climate investing platform, in partnership with Government of Singapore Investment Corporation **(GIC)** and **ICICI Bank** Limited.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Acquisition of Aseem Infrastructure Finance
- ✓ **Acquirer:** TPG Inc., in partnership with GIC and ICICI Bank
- ✓ **Stake Acquired:** 100% stake in AIFL
- ✓ **Seller:** NIIF and other shareholders
- ✓ **Investment Platform:** TPG Rise Climate
- ✓ **ICICI Bank's Stake:** Up to 5% equity stake in AIFL.

Highlights of the Acquisition:

Deal: TPG and GIC will acquire Aseem Infrastructure Finance, while ICICI Bank Limited will hold up to 5%

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equity stake after the transaction.

Objective: The acquisition aims to strengthen climate financing and sustainable infrastructure development in India through TPG Rise Climate's Global South Initiative, launched in partnership with ALTÉRRA to scale climate solutions across emerging markets.

About AIFL: Established in 2020, Aseem Infrastructure Finance is a Mumbai, Maharashtra-based sustainable infrastructure debt financier incubated by the NIIF.

Aviva Set to Become First Foreign Insurer to Fully Own Indian Life Insurance Business

In July 2026, United Kingdom (UK's) insurance giant **Aviva Plc** announced the acquisition of remaining **26%** stake in Aviva Life Insurance Company India limited **(Aviva India)** from its Joint Venture (JV) partner, Dabur Invest Corp. **(DIC),** becoming the **1st foreign insurer** to fully own its **Indian life Insurance business.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 1st overseas insurer to fully own India life business
- ✓ **Acquirer:** Aviva Plc (UK)
- ✓ **Mode of Acquisition:** Purchase of remaining 26% stake in Aviva Life Insurance Company India Limited.
- ✓ **Stake Acquired From:** Dabur Invest Corp. (DIC)
- ✓ **FDI Cap:** Permitted 100% FDI in the Insurance Sector

Key Details of Acquisition:

100% FDI in Insurance Sector: The announcement of acquisition was made following the Government of India (GoI) allowing 100% Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the insurance sector in May 2026.

Key Change: On the completion of the transaction, the shareholding of Aviva in the company will be raised from existing **74% to 100%.**

- Also, the transaction will terminate Dabur's more than 20 years of association with the insurer.

Background: In 2001, Aviva entered the insurance sector of India through a JV with DIC, and over the last few years, it has raised its stake from 49% (2016) to 74% in 2022.

SBI Sells 1.42% Stake in SBI Funds Management for Rs. 1,655 Crore Ahead of IPO

In July 2026, the State Bank of India **(SBI)** sold a **1.42% stake** in its asset management subsidiary, SBI Funds Management Limited **(SBIFM)**, to 30 institutional investors for **Rs. 1,655 crore** through a pre-Initial Public Offering **(IPO)** placement.

- The stake was sold at **Rs. 574 per share**, the upper end of the IPO price band, ahead of the Rs. 11,700 crore IPO, scheduled to open on 14 July 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** SBI sold 1.42% stake in SBI Funds Management
- ✓ **Stake Sold:** 1.42%
- ✓ **Value:** Rs. 1,655 crore
- ✓ **Investors:** 30 institutional investors

Highlights of the Stake Sale:

Pre-IPO Placement: SBI sold 2.88 crore equity shares to 30 institutional investors, including Tata AIG General Insurance, Go Digit General Insurance, 360 ONE Funds and Bennett Coleman.

Ownership: SBI and Amundi India Holding will together divest about 10% of SBIFM's paid-up equity. As the IPO is an OFS, SBIFM will not receive any proceeds from the issue.

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About SBI Funds Management: SBI Funds Management Limited (SBIFM) is India's largest asset management company (AMC) and a joint venture between State Bank of India (SBI) and Amundi, Europe's largest asset manager.

Fairfax Financial Holdings to Acquire 60.72% Stake in IDBI Bank

In July 2026, Canada-based Fairfax Financial Holdings Limited **(Fairfax)** emerged as the preferred bidder to acquire a **60.72%** stake in Industrial Development Bank of India **(IDBI)** Bank Limited from the Government of India (GoI) and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) in a Rs. 52,932 crore **(USD 5.5 billion)** deal.

- If approved, the acquisition will become the largest foreign investment in an Indian bank, subject to approvals from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), the Competition Commission of India (CCI), and a mandatory Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)-mandated open offer to public shareholders.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Fairfax to acquire Majority Stake in IDBI
- ✓ **Acquirer:** Fairfax Financial Holdings Limited (Canada)
- ✓ **Target:** IDBI Bank Limited
- ✓ **Deal Value:** Rs. 52,932 crore (USD 5.5 billion)
- ✓ **Stake Acquired:** 60.72%
- ✓ **Government Stake Sale:** 30.48%
- ✓ **LIC Stake Sale:** 30.24%
- ✓ **Subject to Approval:** RBI and CCI

Highlights of the Acquisition:

Stake Divestment: GoI and LIC, which hold 45.48% and 49.24% of IDBI Bank, respectively, will divest 30.48% and 30.24% stakes, amounting to a combined 60.72% stake sale.

Preferred Bidder: Fairfax emerged as the preferred bidder after revising its offer to **Rs. 81 per share**.

Significance: The proposed acquisition is expected to strengthen foreign investor confidence in India's financial sector while supporting the Government's asset monetisation and banking sector reform agenda.

About IDBI Bank: Established in 1964, IDBI Bank Limited is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra. Rakesh Sharma serves as its Managing Director (MD) & Chief Executive Officer (CEO), and its tagline is "Bank Aisa Dost Jaisa."

RBI Approves Areion Group's Rs. 936 Crore Acquisition of Aviom India Housing Finance

In **July 2026**, the Reserve Bank of India **(RBI)** approved **Areion Group's Rs. 936 crore acquisition** of **Aviom India Housing Finance,** a fraud-hit housing finance company marking a key step in the company's insolvency resolution process.

- The RBI also granted **'fit-and-proper' approval** to **Manish Lalwani**, promoter of Areion Group, which is mandatory for a change in control of a regulated financial institution.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** RBI approval for acquisition
- ✓ **Acquirer:** Areion Group
- ✓ **Target:** Aviom India Housing Finance
- ✓ **Deal Value:** Rs. 936 crore
- ✓ **Promoter:** Manish Lalwani
- ✓ **Recovery:** 65% for lenders
- ✓ **Higher Bidder:** Unity Small Finance Bank

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- ✓ **Higher Bid:** Rs. 977.5 crore

Highlights of the Approval:

Background: Aviom India Housing Finance entered the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process **(CIRP)** in **February 2025** due to debt defaults and accounting irregularities.

Acquisition: Areion Group emerged as the successful resolution applicant with an unconditional resolution plan worth Rs. 936 crore, offering lenders an estimated recovery of around 65%.

Why Areion's Bid Was Selected: Although Unity Small Finance Bank submitted a higher bid of Rs. 977.5 crore, secured lenders representing 98.2% of the voting share unanimously approved Areion's proposal, citing its greater execution certainty.

Areion Group's Presence: Areion Group operates in the financial services sector through Areion Asset Management Company (AMC) and Omkara Asset Reconstruction Company (ARC).

Final Process: Following RBI approval, the resolution plan will proceed to the National Company Law Tribunal **(NCLT)** for final approval and completion of ownership transfer.

About RBI: The RBI was established on 1 April 1935 under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra, and is headed by Sanjay Malhotra (Governor, RBI).

CCI Approves Merger of Go Digit Infoworks Services with GDGIL

In July 2026, the Competition Commission of India **(CCI),** under the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MoCA), approved the proposed merger of Go Digit Infoworks Services Private Limited **(Infoworks)**, with Go Digit General Insurance Ltd. **(GDGIL)** (Digit General), a public limited company engaged in providing general and health insurance products and services across India.

- The transaction marks the first merger between an insurance company and a non-insurance holding company under the **Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Act, 2025.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval of Merger of Go Digit Infoworks with GDGIL
- ✓ **Approved by:** CCI
- ✓ **Surviving Entity:** GDGIL
- ✓ **Significance:** First merger under the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Act, 2025
- ✓ **Post-Merger Stake:** Fairfax Group to hold 57.28% stake in GDGIL.

Key Details of Merger:

Merger Structure: Under the scheme, Go Digit Infoworks Services will be merged into Go Digit General Insurance, removing the holding company layer and enabling shareholders to hold shares directly in the insurance company.

Surviving Entity: As per CCI, GDGIL will remain the surviving entity, after the merger of Infoworks with the insurer.

Key Outcome: On the completion of the proposed transaction, **FAL Corporation,** part of Canadian Fairfax group, which operates in property and casualty insurance, reinsurance and investment management, will hold **57.28%** stake in GDGIL.

About GDGIL: Established in December 2016, GDGIL is headquartered in Pune, Maharashtra, and is backed by Fairfax Financial Holdings.

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SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

DGCA Conducts India's 1st SLS Approach Trial on Airbus A320 Using GAGAN System at Udaipur, Rajasthan

In June 2026, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (**DGCA),** under the Ministry of Civil Aviation (**MoCA**)**,** successfully completed India's 1st satellite-based landing system (**SLS**) approach on a commercial jet aircraft using an **IndiGo Airbus A320** at Maharana Pratap Airport, **Udaipur, Rajasthan.**

- The demonstration used the indigenous **GAGAN** (Global Positioning System (GPS) Aided GEO (Geostationary Earth Orbit) Augmented Navigation) system to execute a Localiser Performance with Vertical Guidance **(LPV) approach**, marking a major step toward satellite-guided precision landings in India.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** First satellite-guided landing of a commercial jet aircraft using GAGAN system
- ✓ **By Whom?** Authority – DGCA; Aircraft – IndiGo Airbus A320
- ✓ **Where?** Maharana Pratap Airport, Udaipur, Rajasthan
- ✓ **Approach used:** LPV
- ✓ **LPV Expansion:** From 23 to 40
- ✓ **Satellite Landing:** Used SLS instead of Convention ILS
- ✓ **Supervision:** DGCA

GAGAN:

- ✓ **GAGAN:** India's SBAS for civil aviation
- ✓ **Developed by:** ISRO and AAI
- ✓ **Purpose:** Improves accuracy of standard GPS signals
- ✓ **Regional First:** India

Demonstration Highlights

LPV Approach: The procedure provides pilots with both lateral (left-right) and vertical (up-down) guidance to the runway, offering precision similar to an Instrument Landing System (ILS) approach without requiring specialised equipment to be installed at the airport itself.

LPV Expansion: At present, 23 LPV approaches have been published, with the number expected to exceed 40 by the end of the year.

Satellite Landing: The flight used a SLS approach instead of the conventional ILS, enabling precision landings through satellite-based corrections while reducing dependence on costly ground-based landing infrastructure.

Supervision: The DGCA-supervised demonstration marks a major step towards enabling precision landings at airports without the need for costly ground-based navigation infrastructure.

About GAGAN

GAGAN: It is India's own Satellite-Based Augmentation System (**SBAS**) for civil aviation, developed jointly by the Indian Space Research Organisation (**ISRO**) and the Airports Authority of India (**AAI**).

Purpose: GAGAN enhances standard GPS signals using correction data transmitted through geostationary satellites and a network of ground reference stations, improving positioning accuracy to about 3 metres (m) while ensuring greater accuracy, integrity, continuity, and availability of navigation services.

Components: The system comprises 15 Indian Reference Stations (INRES), two Indian Master Control Centres (INMCC), three Indian Land Uplink Stations (INLUS), and the geostationary satellites GSAT-8 and GSAT-10 (with GSAT-15 as a spare) for signal correction, data processing, and broadcasting.

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Coverage: GAGAN provides coverage across the Indian Flight Information Region (FIR), with the capability to expand to neighbouring FIRs, while its geostationary satellite footprint extends from Africa to Australia.
Applications: Besides aviation, GAGAN supports railways, maritime navigation, surveying, natural resource management, disaster management, and defence.
Regional First: India is the first country in the Asia-Pacific region to have an operational SBAS system, placing it among a select group of nations with this capability.

Note:

Instrument Landing System (ILS): It is a suite of highly specialised radio transmitters physically installed along airport runways to guide descending aircraft.

About the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA):

The DGCA is a statutory body of the Government of India (GoI) to regulate civil aviation in India. It became a statutory body under the Aircraft (Amendment) Act, 2020.
Directorate General (**DG**) – Vir Vikram Yadav
Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 1946

Agnikul Cosmos Partners with ICEYE to Develop and Launch India's SAR Satellite Systems

In July 2026, **AgniKul Cosmos** Private Limited, India's private space startup, and **ICEYE**, a Finland-based Earth observation company, signed a Memorandum of Understanding **(MoU)** to co-develop, launch, and operate an end-to-end Synthetic Aperture Radar **(SAR) Earth-observation ecosystem** from India.

- The agreement was signed during the 'Bharat Innovates Summit', held in Nice, France, from 30 June to 1 July 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** MoU Signed
- ✓ **Partners:** Agnikul Cosmos (India) and ICEYE (Finland)
- ✓ **Where?** Bharat Innovates Summit, Nice, France
- ✓ **Purpose:** To develop and launch SAR Satellite Systems in India
- ✓ **Application:** Defence, disaster management, climate monitoring.

Key Details of MoU:

Collaboration: The collaboration brings together ICEYE's SAR **satellite technology** and Agnikul's indigenous **launch capability** to establish a sovereign end-to-end space ecosystem with reduced dependence on foreign systems.
Technology: SAR satellites use **radar** instead of optical cameras to capture high-resolution images of the Earth's surface, regardless of cloud cover or time of day.
Production: The partnership focuses on establishing satellite manufacturing in India and launching satellites using Agnikul's rockets, along with developing a repeatable satellite-to-launch model for long-term deployment for Indian and global customers.
Applications: They are widely used in disaster management, border surveillance, environmental monitoring, and defence.
About AgniKul Cosmos: It is an Indian private aerospace manufacturer and commercial launch-service provider, established in 2017. It is based at the Indian Institute of Technology Madras (IIT Madras), Chennai, Tamil Nadu (TN).

China Launched New Marine Satellite "HY-2E" For Enhanced Marine Monitoring

In July 2026, **China** launched its latest oceanographic satellite named **"Haiyang (HY)-2E"** aboard a **Long March 4B rocket** from the Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center in Northwest China.

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- This marked China's **47th** space mission in 2026 and **654th** flight of the Long March rocket series.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of China's Latest Marine Satellite
- ✓ **Satellite Name:** HY-2E
- ✓ **Launch Vehicle:** Long March 4B Rocket
- ✓ **Launched from Where?** Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center (NW China)
- ✓ **Previous Variant:** HY-2B (launched in 2018)
- ✓ **Key Components:** radar altimeter (measure sea surface height); microwave radiometer (measures sea surface temperature); microwave scatterometer (monitors sea surface wind speed); and calibration radiometer

About HY-2E:

Replaces Previous Variant: The HY-2E satellite is designed to replace the **HY-2B** satellite (launched in 2018).

- Also, it will work alongside the existing operational HY-2 series satellites (HY-2C and HY-2D) for monitoring the global marine dynamic environment.

Developed by: The newly launched marine satellite was developed by the China Academy of Space Technology (CAST).

Key Components: The satellite features four microwave remote sensing payloads namely:

- Radar altimeter will be used to acquire data about sea surface height;
- Microwave radiometer will be used to record the surface temperature of the sea;
- Microwave scatterometer is designed to monitor sea surface wind speed and direction; and calibration radiometer.

Key Applications: The satellite will provide critical data support for marine weather forecasting and El Nino phenomenon research, and assist in early warning of tsunami.

- The Automatic Identification System (AIS) integrated into HY-2 satellites, enables to track the exact location and speed of vessels.

Background: In May 2002, China launched its 1st oceanographic research satellite named "HY-1A".

- So far, China launched over 10 "HY-2" series satellites, providing data services for national marine disaster prevention and mitigation, resource development, marine security and oceanographic research.

About Long March 2B Rocket:

3-Stage Spacecraft: It is a 3-stage liquid propellant launch vehicle capable of carrying various types of satellites, with a payload capacity of 2.5 tonnes to a Sun-synchronous orbit at an altitude of 700 kilometers (kms).

Developed by: The spacecraft was developed by Shanghai Academy of Spaceflight Technology.

About China Academy of Space Technology (CAST):

President- Daming Li

Headquarters- Haidan district, Beijing

Founded in- 1968

China Achieved First Controlled Recovery of Reusable Long March-10B Rocket Booster

In July 2026, **China** successfully achieved its first controlled recovery of an orbital-class reusable rocket booster following the maiden launch of the **Long March-10B** carrier rocket from Hainan Province, China.

- The achievement marks a major milestone in China's reusable space technology, more than a decade after **SpaceX** became the **1st** to recover an orbital-class rocket booster in 2015.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** China's First Controlled Recovery of Reusable Rocket Booster
- ✓ **Rocket:** Long March-10B
- ✓ **Launch Site:** Hainan Province, China
- ✓ **Recovery Method:** Sea-based net-capture platform
- ✓ **Payload Capacity:** 16 tonnes to Low Earth Orbit (LEO)
- ✓ **Comparison:** SpaceX first achieved orbital-class booster recovery in December 2015

Highlights of the Mission:

Mission: The Long March-10B, developed by the China Academy of Launch Vehicle Technology **(CALT)**, successfully placed its payload into orbit, while its first-stage booster was recovered on a sea-based net platform, marking China's first controlled recovery of an orbital-class reusable rocket.

Features: The reusable Liquid-fuelled Long March-10B is **63 metres** tall, 5 metres in diameter, with a 760-tonne lift-off mass, **890-tonne thrus**t, and a 16-tonne payload capacity to Low Earth Orbit **(LEO)**

Significance: Unlike SpaceX's Falcon 9, the Long March-10B uses landing hooks for sea-based net recovery. The first stage booster is planned to be reused by the end of 2026, advancing China's reusable rocket programme

ISRO Successfully Carries Out Three Major Tests of Gaganyaan Crew Module Systems

In July 2026, the Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO)** successfully conducted **3 critical tests** of the **Gaganyaan Crew Module (CM) systems** as part of India's human spaceflight programme.

- It validates splashdown recovery, module separation and parachute deployment of the crew module marks significant milestone towards India's first crewed orbital mission.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Three major qualification tests for Gaganyaan crew module systems.
- ✓ **Organisation:** Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)
- ✓ **Programme:** Gaganyaan Human Spaceflight Mission
- ✓ **Systems tested?** Crew Module Uprighting System, Service Module Connect & Disconnect System, and Apex Cover separation loads.
- ✓ **Purpose:** Validate safety, structural integrity, and performance of crew module
- ✓ **Significance:** Key milestone in India's first crewed space mission

1.Crew Module Up-righting System (CMUS)

Crew Safety Test: A stored cold-gas-based uprighting system was developed and tested to ensure the crew module maintains an upright position after splashdown, fulfilling one of the most important crew safety requirements.

Validation: A system-level Crew Module Uprighting System (CMUS) setup was realised, and primary inflation module tests successfully deployed the flotation using stored high-pressure gas through control valves, meeting all functional and performance requirements.

2.Umbilical Separation Testing of the Connect-Disconnect System (CS-CDS)

Test: It examines the separation of Crew Separation Unit (**CSU-1**) (Crew Module (**CM**) side), housing astronauts and CSU-2 (Service Module (**SM**) side), which provides power and propulsion, are linked by an electrical and hydro-pneumatic "**umbilical cord**," transferring data and vital fluid lines for the Environment Control & Life Support System (**ECLSS**) takes place through CS-CDS.

Validation: During Earth re-entry, the SM separates from the CM after CSU-1 disconnects, followed by CSU-2 just before re-entry. A separation test of CSU-2 from the simulated CM confirmed clean separation and structural stability of the CM panel and interfaces.

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3.Apex Cover Separation

Apex cover Test: It protects parachutes and associated subsystems from heat during launch and re-entry and is blasted away by pyrotechnic thrusters at a predetermined altitude to deploy the main parachutes.
Validation: To verify structural integrity during apex cover separation, an instrumented test rig and simulated crew module were used, applying approximately 1.75 times the expected reaction loads at designated locations.

About Gaganyaan Mission:

Overview: The Gaganyaan Mission is India's maiden human spaceflight program by ISRO, which aims to launch a 3-member crew into a **400 km** Low Earth Orbit (**LEO**) for a 3-day mission and bringing them safely back to Earth.

- The maiden human spaceflight is on track for launch in 2027

Launch Vehicle: The mission will use a human-rated version of ISRO's Launch Vehicle Mark-III **(LVM3)**, called **HLVM3**, equipped with advanced safety features including a Crew Escape System **(CES)**.

About the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO):

Chairman– Dr. V. Narayanan
Headquarters– Bengaluru, Karnataka
Establishment– 1969

Russia Launches 'Soyuz MS-29 Mission' Carrying NASA Astronaut and Two Cosmonauts to ISS

In July 2026, **Russia** successfully launched the **Soyuz MS-29 crewed mission** to the International Space Station (ISS) from the Baikonur Cosmodrome in Kazakhstan. The launch was attended by NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman, marking the first visit by a NASA chief to the Baikonur Cosmodrome since 2018.

- The mission was carried out using the **Soyuz-2.1a launch vehicle** and transported National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) astronaut **Anil Menon** and Roscosmos cosmonauts **Pyotr Dubrov** and **Anna Kikina** to the orbital laboratory for the 75th long-duration expedition rotation.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Soyuz MS-29 crewed mission to the ISS
  Launch Site: Baikonur Cosmodrome, Kazakhstan
- ✓ **Launch Vehicle:** Soyuz-2.1a
- ✓ **Mission**: Expedition 75 (approximately 8-month ISS mission)
- ✓ **Crew:** Anil Menon (NASA, USA); Pyotr Dubrov & Anna Kikina (Roscosmos, Russia)
- ✓ **Key Activities:** Scientific research, technology demonstrations, station maintenance & microgravity experiments.

About Soyuz MS-29 Mission:

Crew: The mission carried NASA astronaut Anil Menon on his first spaceflight and Roscosmos cosmonauts Pyotr Dubrov and Anna Kikina on their second missions, with Kikina being the **only woman** among Russia's 23 active cosmonauts, to join seven astronauts already aboard the ISS.
Mission: The crew is scheduled to spend about **eight months** aboard the ISS as part of Expedition 75.

- During their stay aboard the ISS, the crew will conduct scientific research, technology demonstrations, station maintenance, and collaborative microgravity experiments.

Cooperation: The mission highlights the continued NASA–Roscosmos partnership through cross-flight agreements, allowing NASA astronauts to fly aboard Soyuz spacecraft and Russian cosmonauts to travel on United States of America (USA) commercial spacecraft.
Challenges: NASA and Roscosmos are jointly addressing air leaks affecting the ageing ISS while preparing for its planned retirement after 2030.

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About Soyuz Programme:

Programme: The Soyuz programme is Russia's long-running human spaceflight programme, operated by Roscosmos.

Legacy: Since its first launch in 1967, Soyuz spacecraft have been among the world's most reliable vehicles for transporting astronauts and cosmonauts to and from the International Space Station (ISS).

About Roscosmos (State Corporation for Space Activities):

Director General **(DG)** – Dmitry Vladimirovich Bakanov

Headquarters – Moscow, Russia

Established – 1992

HEX20 Launches Second Satellite KOYO aboard SpaceX Transporter-17

In July 2026, Kerala based **HEX20**, a private spacetech startup, successfully launched its second satellite **KOYO** (Kinetic Optical Yaw Observer) aboard **SpaceX's Transporter-17** mission from Vandenberg Space Force Base, California, the United States of America (USA).

- The satellite, carrying 81 payloads, successfully entered orbit as a multi-payload test platform for in-orbit technology validation and commissioning of international payloads.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Satellite KOYO from Vandenberg Space Force Base, USA
- ✓ **By:** Kerala's HEX20
- ✓ **Launch Vehicle:** SpaceX Transporter-17 rideshare mission
- ✓ **Mission Duration:** 18–24 months
- ✓ **Purpose:** Multi-payload technology demonstration satellite
- ✓ **Key International Partners:** Aegiverse, Amplified Space, National Central University, ET Space Power
- ✓ **Technologies Validated:** Solar panel deployment mechanism, deployable monopole antenna, hinge system, AX CubeSat platform.

About HEX20's KOYO Mission:

Mission: KOYO functions as a technology demonstration satellite for qualifying space hardware before operational deployment, carrying payloads from international partners including **Aegiverse** (Taiwan), **Amplified Space** (USA), **National Central University** (Taiwan), and **ET Space Power**.

Technology: The mission validated several HEX20-developed technologies, including a new solar panel deployment mechanism, deployable monopole antenna, hinge system, and the company's AX CubeSat platform.

Operations: Designed to operate for 18–24 months, KOYO successfully decoded over 1,500 beacon packets and executed more than 75 ground commands during commissioning, confirming stable performance before payload operations.

Background: Building on the success of **NILA** (2025), India's first private-sector rideshare satellite and Kerala's first privately built satellite, HEX20 plans to expand its commercial portfolio with six upcoming missions: NILA III, SAISI, COSPAR-1, MAYA-V1, DINK-N1, and the Emirates Asteroid Mission Asteroid (EMA) Impactor Probe.

Skyroot Aerospace Successfully Launches India's First Private Orbital Rocket 'Vikram-1' Under Mission Aagaman

In July 2026, Hyderabad (Telangana)-based **Skyroot Aerospace** Private Limited successfully launched **Vikram-1**, India's first privately developed orbital-class launch vehicle, under **'Mission Aagaman**(arrival)' from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre (SDSC-SHAR), Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh (AP).

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- The mission made **India** the **third country**, after the United States of America (USA) and China, to achieve private orbital launch capability following **the Indian Space Policy 2023.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of India's First Private Orbital Rocket Vikram-1
- ✓ **By Whom?** Skyroot Aerospace
- ✓ **Where?** SDSC-SHAR, Sriharikota, AP
- ✓ **Rocket:** Vikram-1, Type – Four-stage orbital launch vehicle
- ✓ **Mission:** Mission Aagaman
- ✓ **Significance:** India's first privately developed orbital-class rocket, India's first successful private orbital launch
- ✓ **Orbit:** 450 km LEO, Payload Capacity – Up to 350 kg
- ✓ **Technologies:** All-carbon composite structure, 3D-printed engines, Indigenous propulsion technologies
- ✓ **Payloads:** Skyroot SCOPE, SOLARAS S3 (Grahaa Space), Embrace Robotic Arm (Cosmoserve Space), DCUBED technology payload, Cosmic Bloom, PM Narendra Modi's handwritten postcard

About Mission Aagaman:

Overview: Mission Aagaman is the maiden orbital flight of Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 launch vehicle, demonstrating India's capability to design, develop and launch an orbital-class rocket entirely through the private sector.

Objective: The mission aimed to validate the launch vehicle's propulsion, stage separation, guidance, navigation, avionics and flight performance while demonstrating commercial orbital launch capability for small satellites.

Launch: The **four-stage**, seven-storey-tall Vikram-1, India's first successful private orbital launch, successfully injected all payloads into a 450-kilometre (km) Low Earth Orbit (LEO) at an inclination of 60 degrees on its maiden flight, achieving a successful orbital launch.

Technology: The launch vehicle incorporates an **all-carbon composite structure**, three-dimensional **(3D)-printed engines**, indigenous propulsion systems and high-thrust solid rocket boosters to enable rapid manufacturing and low-cost launches.

Payloads: The mission carried Skyroot Aerospace's in-house SCOPE payload, Grahaa Space's SOLARAS S3 technology demonstration satellite, Cosmoserve Space's "Embrace" robotic arm for future space debris removal, and Germany's DCUBED technology demonstration payloads (uD3PP and mD3RN).

- The mission also carried **Cosmic Bloom**, a lotus artwork made from lab-grown diamonds, and an **18-karat gold micro-rocket** containing microscopic sculptures of **Sir C.V. Raman**, **Dr. Vikram Sarabhai**, and **Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam**.
- The mission also carried a handwritten postcard by **Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi** bearing the message **"Vande Mataram"**, along with hundreds of handwritten postcards from scientists, engineers, and well-wishers.

Performance: The mission validated critical onboard systems including propulsion, navigation, telemetry, guidance and vehicle control systems, providing engineering data for future commercial missions.

Commercial: Vikram-1 aims to provide on-demand dedicated launch services for small satellites, enabling customers to avoid waiting for shared launch opportunities while strengthening India's competitiveness in the global small satellite launch market.

Significance: India's space startup ecosystem has grown from one startup in 2014 to over 400 startups in 2026, driven by reforms such as the Indian Space Policy, 2023.

About Vikram-1 Launch Vehicle:

Overview: Vikram-1 is Skyroot Aerospace's first orbital launch vehicle and the successor to Vikram-S, India's first privately developed suborbital rocket launched in 2022, and is named after Dr. Vikram

Sarabhai, the father of India's space programme.
Design: The four-stage, seven-storey-tall rocket is built with an all-carbon composite structure and indigenous propulsion technologies to reduce weight, manufacturing time, and launch costs, and can carry payloads of up to 350 kilograms (kg) to LEO.
Role: Vikram-1 is expected to support regular commercial launches for domestic and international customers requiring dedicated small satellite missions.

About Skyroot Aerospace Private Limited:

Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** – Pawan Kumar Chandana
Headquarters – Hyderabad, Telangana
Established – 2018

Indian Analog Astronaut Capt Aman Johri Conducts Microgravity Space Research on Maharashtra Crops

In July 2026, **Captain Aman Johri**, Indian Analog Astronaut, successfully completed a **microgravity research flight** under **Project Astra Farm,** marking a significant milestone in India's efforts to develop space biotechnology and sustainable food systems for future space missions.

- The mission focused on Maharashtra-grown onions and potatoes, flown aboard a specially designed passive microgravity payload in collaboration with the National Research Council Canada **(NRC-CNRC)** to study their behaviour in microgravity conditions.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Microgravity Space Research conducted
- ✓ **Who?** Capt Aman Johri
- ✓ **Project Name:** Project Astra Farm
- ✓ **Crops studied:** Onions and potatoes (Maharashra)
- ✓ **Research Focus:** Crop response under microgravity for space agriculture
- ✓ **Key Partners:** National Research Council Canada (NRC-CNRC), Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC), Hindustan Agro Co-Operative Ltd.

About Microgravity Research Flight:

Objective: The initiative integrates aerospace research and agricultural innovation to position Maharashtra as global hub for space agriculture and food innovation, applying cutting-edge science to support astronauts and improve farming practices.
Experiment: Agricultural samples were exposed to microgravity conditions to study how plant tissues and cells respond to reduced gravity.

- The project is among India's first initiatives integrating space agriculture, food technology, and crop resilience to support future space missions and food security.

Methodology: This pioneering mission combines space agriculture and advanced crop resilience to prepare for future human life beyond Earth and improve global food security.
Findings: The experiment exposed agricultural samples to microgravity, facilitating in-depth studies on how plant tissues and cellular structures adapt to reduced-gravity environments.
Nuclear Post-Processing: The crop samples will be irradiated using nuclear food technology at **BARC** (Bhabha Atomic Research Centre) under the Department of Atomic Energy (**DAE**), in collaboration with Hindustan Agro Co-Operative Limited, supported by Government of Maharashtra.
Comparative Analysis: Scientists will analyze irradiated and non-irradiated crops to study biological, physiological, and cellular changes, aiming to advance future space farming and resilient agriculture.
Space Agriculture: The results are expected to contribute to future food systems for human spaceflight, lunar bases, and Mars missions, overcoming technological challenges in crop production and long-term preservation.

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About Capt. Aman Johri:

Profile: Over 3 years, he completed an astronaut training programme encompassing analog missions, spaceflight ground school, neutral buoyancy lab (**NBL**) exercises, zero-gravity and high-G flights, gravity-offset simulations, Extravehicular Activity (**EVA**) operations, and orbital mission preparation.

Leadership: Capt. Aman Johri unfurled the Indian National Flag during the microgravity flight, symbolizing India's scientific progress and expanding ambitions in human space exploration.

About Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC)

Role: BARC is India's premier multidisciplinary nuclear research facility, which serves as the backbone of India's nuclear power and research programs.

Director – Vivek Bhasin

Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra

Established – 1954

Reliance Jio gets IN-SPACe approval for 1,600-satellite LEO network

In July 2026, Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited (**Jio**), the telecom arm of Reliance Industries Limited (RIL), secured technical approval from the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (**IN-SPACe**) for its proposal to deploy a Low Earth Orbit **(LEO) satellite constellation** of around 1,600 satellites.

- The assessment was carried out in consultation with the Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO)** and the Wireless Planning & Coordination **(WPC)** wing of the Department of Telecommunications (DoT), under the Ministry of Communication.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** IN-SPACe approval for Jio's LEO satellite network
- ✓ **Company:** Reliance Jio Infocomm
- ✓ **Constellation Size:** Around 1,600 Low Earth Orbit (LEO) satellites
- ✓ **Estimated Capacity:** 4.5–5 Tbps
- ✓ **Purpose:** Satellite broadband, Direct-to-Device (D2D) connectivity, and cellular backhaul
- ✓ **Technical Assessment:** Conducted with ISRO and WPC Wing.

Key Details of Approval:

Clearance: Backed by Indian Government's regulatory support, it plans to file for orbital slots worldwide to deploy **India's first** home-grown satellite broadband constellation under International Telecommunication Union (**ITU**), which regulates satellite frequencies and satellite locations

Framework: Reliance Jio plans a **4.5–5 Tbps** (terabits per second) satellite internet constellation with **20–22** Indian ground stations, delivering superior capacity over existing satellite internet projects.

Services: Reliance Jio plans to provide Fixed Satellite Services (**FSS**) like broadband and cellular backhaul, along with Mobile Satellite Services (MSS) offering Direct-to-Device (**D2D**) connectivity, targeting both consumer and enterprise users.

Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited: Established in 2007 and headquartered in Ghansoli, Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra, is a subsidiary of Jio Platforms under Reliance Industries and stands as one of India's largest telecom and digital services providers.

NASA Webb Telescope Discovered New Exoplanet 'Beta Pictoris d'

In July 2026, Astronomers using National Aeronautics and Space Administration **(NASA)'s James Webb Space Telescope (JWST)**, discovered a new giant exoplanet called '**Beta Pictoris d'** located 63 light-years from Earth and about 23 million years old.

- With this latest discovery, Beta Pictoris has become only the second known planetary system with at least three directly imaged planets.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Discovery new exoplanet
- ✓ **Exoplanet Name:** Beta Pictoris d
- ✓ **Discovered by:** NASA's JWST
- ✓ **Location:** 63 light-years from Earth
- ✓ **Orbital Speed:** Approximately 30 AU.

About Beta Pictoris d:

Variants: The new exoplanet orbits the nearby star Beta Pictoris, which was already known to be home of Beta Pictoris b, one of the 1st exoplanets ever directly imaged, and Beta Pictoris c.

Discovery: Unlike its previous two variants (Beta Pictoris b and c), JWST's Near-Infrared Spectrograph (NIRSpec) detected the unique chemical fingerprint of the exoplanet's atmosphere.

Size and Orbit: The newly discovered exoplanet is estimated to be at least **two-times** the mass of Jupiter, making it the smallest of the three known giant planets in the Beta Pictoris system.

- Further, the exoplanet orbits nearly 30 Astronomical Units (AU) from its star, which places it at a distance comparable to planet Neptune.

The USA Air Force's YFQ-44A Fury drone successfully fired its first live AIM-120 AMRAAM

In July 2026, the United States of America **(USA) Air Force's YFQ-44A Fury drone,** successfully fired its first live Air Intercept Missile **(AIM)-120** Advanced Medium-Range Air-to-Air Missile (**AMRAAM**) at a digital target at Edwards Air Force Base over the Mojave desert in California, the USA.

- This marked the 1st live missile launch by a US Collaborative Combat Aircraft.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Missile test
- ✓ **By?** USA Air force
- ✓ **Aircraft:** YFQ-44A Fury
- ✓ **Developer**: Anduril Industries
- ✓ **Missile Name:** AIM-120 AMRAAM
- ✓ **Where?** Mojave Desert, California, USA

Key Details:

Team: The live-fire test of the aircraft was conducted in coordination with the 412th Test Wing's Air Dominance Combined Test Force, which included active-duty military, government civilians, and government contractors, who have expertise in validating the models required for a safe live-fire execution.

Developed by: YFQ-44A Fury drone, an advanced, semi-automatic Unmanned Combat Aerial Vehicle (UCAV), was developed by Anduril Industries

Key Functions: The aircraft operates with crewed fighters like: the F-35 and F-22, facilitating additional sensors, weapons, and operational support during missions.

- Also, CCA platforms are designed to perform multiple tasks other than missile carriage, like: electronic warfare, reconnaissance, and other battlefield operations.

Paninian India Launches India's First Private-Sector Turbofan Engine Programme

In July 2026, **Paninian India** Private Limited, a deep-tech and aerospace startup, launched the **Yantur 4.5 kilo-Newton (kN) Turbofan engine** programme, envisaged as India's first privately developed turbofan engine in its class.

- The newly launched programme marks a significant step towards establishing indigenous private-sector capability in compact aerospace propulsion for next generation autonomous systems.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of India's First Private-Sector Turbofan Engine Programme
- ✓ **Launched by:** Paninian India
- ✓ **Name:** Yantur 4.5 kN Turbofan engine programme
- ✓ **Purpose:** To address the operational requirements of MoD's Make-I programme for LRLACM

About Yantur Engine:

Purpose: The Yantur engine is being developed to power **Svayatt L1,** a long-range autonomous cruise missile platform of Paninian, is expected to address the key operational requirements of the Ministry of Defence (MoD)'s Make-I programme for the Long-Range Land Attack Cruise Missile (LRLACM).
Expansion: The Yantur engine has the potential to be expanded to 12.5 kN to power its Svayatt Collaborative Combat Aerial Vehicle (CCAV) platform, which is expected to support different types of propulsion systems for future autonomous aerospace applications.
Patent Claims: The Yantur and Svayatt L1 programmes feature 5 patent claims covering innovations in engine family architecture, combustor, and diffuser-nozzle design, compressor technology, digital-twin health monitoring and advanced manufacturing techniques.
Paninian India: Incorporated in 2018, Paninian India Pvt. Ltd. is an Indian deep-tech and aerospace startup based in Hyderabad, Telangana.

DRDO's GTRE Develops India's First Indigenous 350 kg Thrust Class Expendable Turbojet Engine

In July 2026, Gas Turbine Research Establishment **(GTRE)**, a laboratory of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), designed and developed **India's first indigenous 350 kg (kilogram) thrust class Expendable Turbojet Engine**.

- It was formally handed over by **Rakesh Chopdar**, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Azad Engineering, to **Dr K. Rajalakshmi Menon**, Director General (DG) of Aeronautical Systems and **Dr S.V. Ramanamurty,** Director at GTRE.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India's First indigenous expendable turbo jet engine developed
- ✓ **Developed by:** DRDO's GTRE
- ✓ **Manufacturer:** Azad Engineering
- ✓ **Thrust class:** 350 kg
- ✓ **Purpose:** Enhance indigenous aero-engine capability
- ✓ **Applications:** The engine is designed for NASM, MR-ADS, UAVs, AAM and ASM platforms.

About Indigenous Expendable Turbojet Engine:

Industry Partner: Azad Engineering Limited, Hyderabad (Telangana), served as the industry partner for the project, supporting manufacturing and assembly activities.
Project Execution: The GTRE holds the design responsibility, while Azad Engineering Limited carried out the manufacturing and assembly of the project.
Technology: The expendable turbojet engine incorporates advanced precision engineering, metallurgy and manufacturing technologies, with such propulsion systems mastered by only a handful of nations.
Development: The engine was developed in approximately 24 months, converting the DRDO's design into a flight-ready propulsion system using superalloys and precision manufacturing processes.
Working: A turbojet engine is a gas turbine engine that generates thrust by compressing air, burning fuel and expelling high-speed exhaust gases through a nozzle.

- While expendable turbojet engines are designed for single-use or limited-use applications such as missiles and unmanned systems.

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Applications: The 350 kg thrust-class engine is intended for Naval Anti-Ship Missiles (NASM), Medium-Range Anti-Drone Systems (MR-ADS), Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), Air-to-Air Missile (AAM) and Air-to-Surface Missile (ASM) platforms.

Significance: The engine strengthens India's self-reliant propulsion capabilities, marking a key milestone in indigenous aero-engine development and advancing Atmanirbhar Bharat in defence manufacturing.

About Gas Turbine Research Establishment (GTRE):

GTRE is a laboratory of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) that designs and develops gas turbine engines and related technologies for military applications.

Director – Dr. S V Ramanamurthy

Headquarters – Bengaluru, Karnataka

Established – 1959

China Launches Gravity-1 rocket from sea, sends 9 satellites into orbit

In July 2026, Chinese aerospace company **Orienspace** launched its **Gravity-1 Y4** carrier rocket from a sea-based platform in the East China

Sea, placing **9** satellites into their designated orbits.

- This mission marked the rocket's **3rd** flight and **1st** long-range sea launch.

Exam Hints

- ✓ **What?** Chinese Aerospace Orienspace launches Gravity-1 Y4 rocket
- ✓ **Satellites launched:** Nine satellites: Dongpo-13, Dongpo-14, Dongpo-17 to Dongpo-20, Xiguang-2 01, Tianyi-49 and Lilac-3.
- ✓ **Dongpo Satellites:** 2 satellites: Optical imaging system, remaining 4: SAR satellites
- ✓ **Lilac-3:** Test next generation satellite platform
- ✓ **Xiguang-2 01 and Tianyi-49:** Mineral exploration, urban planning, and agriculture.
- ✓ **Gravity-1:** 1st medium-life launch vehicle, 30 m, mass – 405 tons
- ✓ **Assembly:** Oriental Aerospace Port, launched under Taiyuan Satellite Launch Center.

Details of the Satellites

Satellites carried: The rocket carried **nine satellites** which included – Dongpo-13, Dongpo-14, Dongpo-17 to Dongpo-20, Xiguang-2 01, Tianyi-49 and Lilac-3.

Dongpo satellites purpose: Two of the satellites are equipped with optical imaging systems and onboard artificial intelligence (**AI)** capable of target recognition, intelligent image analysis and faster data processing.

- The remaining four are synthetic aperture radar (**SAR**) satellites designed to fly in formation and provide millimetre-level ground deformation monitoring.

Lilac-3: This will test next-generation satellite platform and attitude-control technologies through in-orbit demonstrations.

Xiguang-2 01 and Tianyi-49: These will provide Earth observation for -mineral exploration, urban planning, and agriculture.

- Xiguang-2 01 is China's first satellite featuring onboard computing.
- Instead of sending raw data back to Earth to be processed, it processes images directly in space for faster decision-making.

Rocket in Detail

Gravity-1: This is the world's 1st medium-life launch vehicle with strap-on boosters that are all powered by solid propellant motors.

- The 30 meter (**m**) launch vehicle has a mass of 405 tons and liftoff thrust of 600 tons.
- Its payload to low Earth orbit is 6.5 tons, and its payload to 500-kilometre (**Kms**) sun-synchronous orbit is 4.2 tons.

Assembly: The rocket was assembled at the Oriental Aerospace Port in Shandong and launched under the direction of the **Taiyuan Satellite Launch Centre**.

About China:

President– Xi Jinping
Capital– Beijing
Currency– Renminbi (RMB)

NASA Plans AI-powered 'PRAXIS' Mission to Collect and Analyze Saturn Ring Particles Directly

In July 2026, National Aeronautics and Space Administration (**NASA**) researchers proposed an AI (Artificial Intelligence) mission concept called **PRAXIS** (Planetary Rings Autonomous EXploration with In-situ Sampling) under **Phase I** of the NASA Innovative Advanced Concepts (**NIAC**) 2026 program to enable the first-ever direct collection and analysis of particles from Saturn's rings.

- The project will be led by **Dr B. Marco Quadrelli**, a Principal and Group Supervisor of the Robotics Modelling and Simulation Group at the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL), California, United States of America (**USA**).

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Proposal of PRAXIS mission concept
- ✓ **Agency:** National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA)
- ✓ **Programme:** NASA Innovative Advanced Concepts (NIAC) 2026 – Phase I
- ✓ **Objective:** First direct collection and analysis of millimetre- to centimetre-scale (mm–cm) Saturn ring particles
- ✓ **Target:** Saturn's dense ring system
- ✓ **Mission Lead:** Dr. B. Marco Quadrelli

Key Details of PRAXIS Mission:

Objective: PRAXIS is designed to deliver the first direct observations of millimetre- to centimetre-sized (**mm–cm scale**) ring particles, addressing a key priority identified in planetary science decadal surveys.
Significance: Direct study of raw ring particles will provide critical insights into the age, origin, and evolutionary processes of planetary ring systems.
Applications: Technologies validated by PRAXIS could enable future exploration of fainter ring systems around Uranus, Neptune and minor bodies such as Centaurs Chariklo and Chiron.

Mission Development Phases:

- **Phase I** focuses on simulation studies and system design to validate mission feasibility.
- **Phase II** involves the development of a physical prototype based on the outcomes and learnings from Phase I.

About PRAXIS spacecraft:

Explorer: It will hover safely above Saturn's dense ring system and use an Artificial Intelligence (**AI**)-powered bio-inspired robotic explorer for collision avoidance, precision sampling, and in-situ scientific analysis.
Design: Inspired by sports casting techniques, the spacecraft's long, flexible deployable boom will capture free-floating ring particles for detailed scientific study and retract safely before the spacecraft moves away.
In-Situ Sample Analysis: Miniaturised onboard instruments will enable real-time analysis of collected ring samples in space while the spacecraft performs safe touch-and-go sampling operations near moving particles.
Examination: The instruments will examine particle size, porosity, composition, and internal structure, providing crucial insights into whether Saturn's rings originated from a shattered moon, remnants of planet formation, or another unknown process.

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Previous Exploration

Saturn's Rings: They are primarily composed of water ice particles mixed with rocky material, with particle sizes ranging from tiny grains smaller than sand to massive chunks comparable in size to mountains.

Mission Cassini (1997–2017): The Cassini spacecraft provided extensive observations of Saturn's ring system, revealing key insights into ring structure and dynamics, interactions between rings and moons, and the role of Enceladus in supplying material to Saturn's E-ring.

About NASA

Established- 1958

Headquarters- Washington, D.C., USA

Administrator- Jared Isaacman

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

IN Participates in 30th Edition of Maritime Exercise 'RIMPAC' in Hawaii, USA

In June 2026, Indian Navy **(IN)** participated in the **30th edition** of the Rim of the Pacific (**RIMPAC 2026)**, the world's largest multinational maritime warfare exercise, hosted by the United States (US) Navy under the U.S. Pacific Fleet at Joint Base Pearl Harbor-Hickam (JBPHH), **Hawaii,** the United States of America (USA).

- RIMPAC 2026 is being held from 24 June to 31 July 2026 as a five-week multinational maritime warfare exercise.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** RIMPAC 2026 Exercise Begins
- ✓ **Edition:** 30th
- ✓ **Venue:** at Joint Base Pearl Harbor-Hickam, Hawaii, USA.
- ✓ **Duration:** 24 June to 31 July 2026
- ✓ **Where?** Hawaii, USA
- ✓ **Host:** US Navy
- ✓ **2026 Theme:** "Partners: Integrated and Prepared"
- ✓ **Participants: 3**0 nations, 30+ warships, 5 submarines, 206+ aircraft & 30,000 personnel
- ✓ **Commander:** Vice Admiral Jeffrey T. Jablon (U.S. Navy)
- ✓ **Key Drills:** ASW, Air Defence (AD), Tactical Missile Exercises, HADR, Counter-Piracy, Mine Countermeasures (MCM), Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD), Diving & Salvage.

Background:

Overview: RIMPAC began in 1971 as an annual naval exercise initiated by Australia, Canada, and the USA, before transitioning into a biennial multinational maritime warfare exercise.

- IN was integrated as a permanent participant in **2014**

Objective: Provides a joint training platform for allied and partner navies to improve coordination and cooperation.

Previous Exercise: The 29th RIMPAC exercise was held from 27 June to 1 August 2024.

About RIMPAC 2026:

Theme: The Theme for 30th edition: "Partners: Integrated and Prepared", highlights collective defence readiness, interoperability and a shared commitment to a free, open and inclusive Indo-Pacific.

Participation:

- **Surface and Sub-Surface Fleet:** Over 30 surface warships and 5 submarines.
- **Aviation and Ground Forces:** 15 national land forces, more than 206 aircraft and 30,000 personnel will train and operate in and around the Hawaiian Islands

Exercise Leadership:

- **Combined Task Force (CTF) Commander:** Vice Admiral Jeffrey T. Jablon, U.S. Navy and Deputy Commander of the U.S. Pacific Fleet.
- **Deputy CTF Commander:** Commodore Andres Howard of the Chilean Navy.
- **Vice CTF Commander:** Rear Admiral Takuo Kobayashi of the Japan Maritime Self-Defence Force (JMSDF).
- **Combined Forces Maritime Component Commander:** Rear Admiral In-Ho Kim of the Republic of Korea (ROK) Navy.
- **Combined Forces Air Component Commander:** Brigadier General J. S. Davis of the Royal Canadian Air Force (RCAF).

Training Components:

Operations: Multi-ship task forces will conduct advanced Anti-Submarine Warfare (**ASW**), coordinated Air Defence (**AD**) operations and tactical missile exercises.

Operational Areas: Includes counter-piracy, mine clearance, Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD), and diving & salvage operations.

Missions: The exercise includes Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (**HADR**), counter-piracy operations, sea mine clearance, Explosive Ordnance Disposal (**EOD**), and diving and salvage missions.

Logistics: The Naval Supply Systems Command (**NAVSUP**) Fleet Logistics Center (**FLC**) Pearl Harbor serves as the multinational logistics hub, coordinating fuel, transport and supply support for participating forces.

About Indian Navy (IN):

Chief of Naval Staff (**CNS**) – Admiral Krishna Swaminathan

Headquarters– New Delhi, Delhi

Established-1950

Motto – "Sam no Varunah"

IAF Participates in 45th Edition of Exercise 'Pitch Black 2026' in Australia

In July 2026, the Indian Air Force (**IAF**) participated in the **45th Edition** of **Exercise Pitch Black 2026**, hosted by the Royal Australian Air Force (**RAAF**) at RAAF Base Darwin in **northern Australia**, which starts from 20 July 2026 and continues till 7 August 2026.

- Exercise Pitch Black is the RAAF's premier **Biennial** (every 2 years) multinational air combat exercise, bringing together air forces from **20 nations**, including the United States of America (USA), France, Germany, Spain, Japan, and South Korea.
- Exercise Pitch Black 2024 was held from 12 July to 02 August 2024 hosted by the RAAF at RAAF Base Darwin in northern Australia

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Participation of IAF in Exercise Pitch Black 2026 (Biennial Exercise)
- ✓ **Host:** Royal Australian Air Force (RAAF)
- ✓ **When?** 20 July to 7 August 2026 (3 Weeks)
- ✓ **Where?** RAAF Base Darwin, Northern Australia
- ✓ **IAF Assets Deployed:** Rafale fighter jets (4), C-17 Globemaster III (2), IL-78 aerial refuelling aircraft and Air Warriors (120)

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- ✓ **Participating Nations:** 19 Partner Nations (Including USA, France, Germany, Spain, Japan, and South Korea)

About Exercise Pitch Black 2026:

Overview: First conducted in 1983, Exercise Pitch Black is one of the Indo-Pacific region's largest and most complex air combat training events.

- The exercise is named for its focus on night-time flying across the expansive, sparsely populated areas of northern Australia.

Participation: The exercise involves up to **100 fighter** and support aircraft and more than **2,500 military personnel** operating from Darwin, Tindal and Amberley bases.

Operations: Exercise Pitch Black 26 validates long-range expeditionary air operations, boosts multinational interoperability, and strengthens professional partnerships across the Indo-Pacific region.

IAF Fleet Deployment:

Participation: IAF deployed an integrated frontline combat and support team of over 120 Air Warriors, including pilots, flight test engineers, technicians, air traffic controllers, and subject-matter experts.

- **Rafale Jets (4):** Multi-role combat aircraft for air superiority, strike, and precision engagement missions
- **C-17 Globemaster III (2):** Strategic airlift of troops, equipment, and logistics
- **IL-78 MKI:** Air-to-Air Refueling aircraft to extend combat endurance and operational reach

IAF Participation: The IAF took part in Exercise Pitch Black in 2018, 2022, and 2024, strengthening defence cooperation and regional security in the Indo-Pacific.

About Australia:

Prime Minister (**PM**) – Anthony Albanese
Capital – Canberra
Currency- Australian Dollar (AUD)

TESTING

ISRO Conducts First Ground Test of SOLVE for Gaganyaan Crew Module Parachute Validation at Sriharikota, AP

In July 2026, the Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO)** successfully conducted the **first ground test** of the Sub-Orbital Launch Vehicle for Experiments **(SOLVE)**, at the Static Test Facility in Satish Dhawan Space Centre **(SDSC), Sriharikota**, Andhra Pradesh (AP).

- The test validated the solid motor for integrated parachute trials of the **Gaganyaan Crew Module** by using ISRO's SOLVE, a solid motor-based test vehicle that simulates deceleration at altitudes between **10 kilometre (km)** and **17 km** before human spaceflight.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** First Ground Test of SOLVE conducted
- ✓ **Organisation:** ISRO
- ✓ **Where?** SDSC, Sriharikota, AP
- ✓ **Purpose:** Validate Crew Module parachute deceleration system under sub-orbital flight conditions
- ✓ **Altitude:** 10–17 km for Crew Module separation
- ✓ **Vehicle Features:** Derived from PSLV strap-on motor, slow burn-rate propellant, straight nozzle, SITVC.

About Sub-Orbital Launch Vehicle for Experiments (SOLVE):

Objective: To test the Crew Module's deceleration system, parachute deployment, and safe recovery under realistic mission conditions for Gaganyaan.

Features: It is equipped with a modified Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) strap-on motor using slow-

burning solid propellant, a straight nozzle with Secondary Injection Thrust Vector Control (SITVC), and a 10-stage parachute deployment system.

Significance: It provides a cost-effective and flexible platform for repeated validation of critical crew safety technologies, reducing technical risks by identifying and resolving issues before human missions while strengthening India's human-rated spaceflight capabilities and crew safety systems.

ISRO Successfully Conducts Flight Acceptance Hot Test of CE20 Cryogenic Engine for LVM3-M7 Mission

On July 6 2026, the Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO)** successfully conducted the flight acceptance **hot test of the CE20 cryogenic engine** for the seventh operational mission of the Launch Vehicle Mark-3 (LVM3-M7) at the Main Engine & stage Test facility (MET) in ISRO Propulsion Complex **(IPRC)**, **Mahendragiri**, Tamil Nadu (TN).

- During the test, the engine operated at 19.5 tonnes (t) of thrust for 45 seconds and 22 t for 25 seconds, verifying its performance for the LVM3-M7 mission.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Successfully Conducts Flight Acceptance Hot Test of CE20 Cryogenic Engine
- ✓ **Who?** ISRO
- ✓ **Where?** IPRC, Mahendragiri, TN
- ✓ **Thrust Profile**: 19.5 tonnes for 45 seconds and 22 tonnes for 25 seconds.
- ✓ **First-Time Feature:** Nozzle Protection System (NPS).
- ✓ **Next Step:** Integrated with the C32 cryogenic stage for the LVM3-M7 vehicle.

Highlight of the Test:

Nozzle Protection System (NPS): The CE20 cryogenic engine was tested with the NPS) for the first time, and the test confirmed the satisfactory performance of both the engine systems and the NPS.

- The NPS simplifies high-altitude engine testing, requires fewer resources and enables longer test duration.

Integration: The engine will be refurbished and integrated with the C32 cryogenic stage for the LVM3-M7 vehicle.

About CE20 Engine: The indigenously developed CE20 cryogenic engine powers the upper stage of LVM3 and operates at 19–22 tonnes of thrust. It has successfully powered 8 consecutive LVM3 missions, including Chandrayaan-2, Chandrayaan-3, and three commercial missions, and is qualified for the Gaganyaan mission.

DRDO Successfully Flight-Tests Pinaka Long-Range Guided Rocket, with 60-km Minimum Range

In July 2026, Defence Research & Development Organisation (**DRDO**) conducted a successful flight test of **Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket** (LRGR) with a user-specified minimum range of **60 km** (kilometres) at the Integrated Test Range (**ITR**), Chandipur, Odisha.

- The flight trial was coordinated by DRDO's **ITR** and Proof & Experimental Establishment (**PXE**), Chandipur.
- The LRGR followed its planned maneuvers and impacted the target with **exact precision** along the **predicted trajectory**, with continuous tracking by all range instruments.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Successful flight test of the Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket
- ✓ **Where?** Integrated Test Range (ITR), Chandipur, Odisha.
- ✓ **Range:** User-specified minimum range of 60 km

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- ✓ **Validated by:** ITR and the Proof & Experimental Establishment
- ✓ **Trial Result**: Target with exact precision along the predicted trajectory

Key Details of Trial:

Development: The Pinaka LRGR rocket is designed by **Armament Research and Development Establishment,** Pune, Maharashtra in association with **High Energy Materials Research Laboratory**, with support from Defence Research and Development Laboratory (DRDL) and Research Centre Imarat (RCI), Hyderabad, Telangana.

Launcher: The rocket was launched from an **operational Pinaka** launcher (Multi-Barrel Rocket Launcher (**MBRL**)), highlighting its versatility and its ability to fire Pinaka variants with multiple ranges from a single launcher.

About Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket:

Overview: Pinaka LRGR is the guided version of the indigenous Pinaka multi-barrel rocket launcher system, designed to deliver precision strikes at extended ranges with a maximum range of **120km.**

Navigation: It uses a hybrid navigation system combining an indigenous Inertial Navigation System (**INS**) with Global Positioning System (**GPS**) and the Navigation with Indian Constellation (**NavIC**) satellite tracking.

Features: The system dynamically corrects the flight path mid-air, drastically minimizing the Circular Error Probable (**CEP**) to strike precise target coordinates.

About Odisha:

Chief Minister (**CM**) – Mohan Charan Majhi
Governor – Hari Babu Kambhampati
Capital – Bhubaneswar
Wildlife Sanctuary (**WLS**) – Lakhari Valley WLS, Karlapat WLS

ISRO Successfully Conducts Integrated Main Parachute Airdrop Test for Gaganyaan G1 Mission in MP

On July 7, 2026, the Indian Space Research Organisation **(ISRO)** successfully conducted the Integrated Main Parachute Airdrop Test-05 **(IMAT-05)** for the Gaganyaan G1 mission at the Aerial Delivery Research and Development Establishment (ADRDE) drop zone in **Sheopur,** Madhya Pradesh **(MP)**.

- The test was conducted to validate the **Main Parachute System** under maximum expected load conditions for the first uncrewed **Gaganyaan G1** mission.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Integrated Main Parachute Airdrop Test-05 conducted successfully
- ✓ **Who?** ISRO
- ✓ **Mission:** Gaganyaan G1
- ✓ **Test Location:** ADRDE, Sheopur, MP
- ✓ **Drop Altitude:** 2.5 km from IAF's IL-76 aircraft
- ✓ **Objective:** Validate the Main Parachute System under maximum load conditions.

About Parachute Airdrop Test:

Objective: The test evaluated the Main Parachute System for structural integrity and design margins under maximum expected load conditions

Test: During IMAT-05, a simulated payload was dropped from an altitude of 2.5 kilometres(km) using an Indian Air Force (IAF's) IL-76 aircraft, validating the performance and reliability of the Main Parachute System.

Deceleration System: The Gaganyaan Crew Module uses 10 parachutes of 4 types: Apex Cover Separation, Drogue, Pilot and Main parachutes, to ensure a safe splashdown after atmospheric re-entry.

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Parachute Deployment: The test successfully deployed the extractor, drogue, and main parachutes, with the main parachute reducing the payload's descent to a safe terminal velocity.
About ISRO: It is India's national space agency, established on 15 August 1969. It is headquartered in Bengaluru, Karnataka, and is currently headed by Chairman V. Narayanan.

Japan Successfully Conducts First Lift-off and Landing Test of Reusable Rocket Prototype

In July 2026, the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency **(JAXA)** successfully conducted the first lift-off and landing test of its RV-X reusable rocket prototype at the Noshiro Testing Center, Akita Prefecture, Japan.

- The prototype rose to about **10 metres (33 feet)**, remained in flight for around **40 seconds**, and landed safely, marking a major step towards developing reusable launch vehicle technology and reducing space launch costs.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** First lift-off and landing test of reusable rocket prototype
- ✓ **Country:** Japan
- ✓ **Space Agency:** Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA)
- ✓ **Rocket:** RV-X
- ✓ **Location:** Noshiro Testing Center, Akita Prefecture
- ✓ **Flight Duration:** Around 40 seconds
- ✓ **Altitude:** About 10 metres

Highlights of the Test:

Mission: RV-X successfully completed **Japan's first** lift-off and landing test of a reusable rocket prototype technology.
Features: Jointly developed by JAXA and Mitsubishi Heavy Industries (MHI), the RV-X is **7.3 metres** long and **1.8 metres** in diameter, featuring an enhanced-durability engine and four shock-absorbing landing legs.
Significance: The successful test advances Japan's reusable launch vehicle programme, supporting the development of **next-generation reusable** launch systems to succeed the **single-use H3 launch vehicle**, reduce launch costs, and strengthen Japan's global competitiveness.

- The test marks Japan's progress in reusable rocket technology, a field pioneered commercially by **SpaceX's Falcon 9** launch system.

Future Plan: JAXA plans higher-altitude test flights of around 100 metres and continues collaboration with France and Germany to validate the technology before integrating it into future reusable launch vehicles.

About Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA):

JAXA is Japan's national space agency responsible for space exploration, satellite development, and aerospace research.
President – Hiroshi Yamakawa
Headquarters – Chofu, Tokyo, Japan
Established – 2003

DRDO Successfully Conducts Maiden Flight Test of 'Kusha' LR-SAM

In July 2026, Defence Research & Development Organisation (**DRDO**) successfully conducted the maiden flight test of '**Kusha**' Long-Range Surface-to-Air Missile (**LR-SAM**) from **APJ Abdul Kalam Island** off the coast of **Odisha**.

- The missile system successfully intercepted an electronic target simulating a high-speed, high-altitude aerial threat, demonstrating its precision and operational readiness.

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Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Maiden flight test of the 'Kusha' Long-Range Air Defence Missile
- ✓ **Who?** Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO)
- ✓ **Where?** APJ Abdul Kalam Island off the coast of Odisha.
- ✓ **Target:** Electronic target simulating high-speed, high-altitude aerial threat
- ✓ **Purpose:** Demonstrate precision, guidance, and operational readiness
- ✓ **Significance:** Part of Mission Sudarshan Chakra for multi-layered air and missile defence by 2035

About Kusha LR-SAM:

Kusha missile system: A versatile air-defence platform designed to intercept and neutralise fighter aircraft, stealth platforms, unmanned aerial vehicles (**UAVs**), cruise missiles, precision-guided munitions (**PGMs**), and select classes of ballistic missile threats across an extended range and altitude envelope.

Development: All weapon system elements, including the missiles, radars, command and control centre, have been indigenously developed by various DRDO laboratories in collaboration with Indian Industry partners.

Milestone: The successful test strengthens India's long-range air defence programme, which aims to match the capabilities of Russia's **S-400 Triumf** and the United States' (**US**) **MIM-104 Patriot** surface-to-air missile (SAM) platforms.

Multi-Tier Interceptor Variants:

Overview: Kusha employs three distinct interceptor missile variants for targeting incoming projectiles at different ranges.

- **M1 Missile:** Short-to-medium-range interceptor missile that can take down a target within an operational range of **150 km** (kilometres).
- **M2 Missile:** Medium-to-long-range interceptor having a **250 km** range
- **M3 Missile**: Long-range missile with an extended reach up to **350–400 km**.

Capabilities:

Interceptor: The interceptors are designed to travel at speeds of approximately **Mach 5.5** and are supported by advanced radar systems, fire-control mechanisms, and network-centric command infrastructure for precise engagement.

Defence Shield: Once operational, Kusha will intercept incoming fighter jets, stealth aircraft, drones, cruise missiles, precision-guided munitions, and select ballistic missile threats.

Integration: The project combines long-range interceptors, quick-reaction surface-to-air missiles (**QR-SAMs**), very short-range air defence (**VSHORAD**) systems, directed energy weapons, and indigenous ballistic missile defence (**BMD**) capabilities.

Mission Sudarshan Chakra: Project Kusha plays a pivotal role in Mission Sudarshan Chakra, which aims to establish a multi-layered national air and missile defence shield by 2035.

Background: The Defence Acquisition Council granted Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) in September 2023 for the procurement of five squadrons of Project Kusha for the Indian Air Force. **Bharat Electronics Limited** (BEL) is the principal industry partner for radar systems and overall integration.

About Odisha:

Chief Minister (**CM**) – Mohan Charan Majhi
Governor – Hari Babu Kambhampati
Capital – Bhubaneswar
Wildlife Sanctuary (**WLS**) – Lakhari Valley WLS, Karlapat WLS

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SpaceX's Starship Completes 13th Test Flight, Deploys 20 Starlink V3 Satellites

In July 2026, **SpaceX** successfully completed the **13th** integrated test flight of its **Starship** launch system from Starbase, Texas, United States of America (USA), deploying 20 next-generation **Starlink Version 3 (V3) satellites** for the first time before making a controlled splashdown in the Indian Ocean.

- The mission, which marked the second test flight of Starship V3, was closely monitored by the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) for its future 'Artemis' lunar missions.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Mission?** 13th integrated test flight of Starship completed
- ✓ **Company:** SpaceX
- ✓ **Launch Site:** Starbase, Texas, USA
- ✓ **Satellites Deployed:** 20 Starlink V3 Satellites
- ✓ **Mission Purpose:** Test satellite deployment and technologies.

Highlights of the SpaceX's Starship:

Launch: The 124 metres(m) **Starship rocket** launched successfully from Starbase and deployed 20 Starlink V3 satellites with advanced communication capabilities through laser links.

Testing: The Starship upper stage completed a successful re-entry and soft splashdown in the Indian Ocean, providing critical data on heat shield performance and spacecraft systems.

Purpose: The mission tested hardware, software, satellite deployment and flight systems to support NASA's Human Landing System (HLS) for future Artemis lunar missions and **SpaceX's long-term goal** of human exploration of Mars.

About NASA: Established in 1958, NASA is the USA space agency headquartered in Washington, D.C., USA, led by Jared Isaacman, Administrator.

DEALS & MoU's

DRDO Signs Two Contracts for AEW&C Mk-II Programme to Enhance India's Airborne Surveillance Capability

On 22 July 2026, the Defence Research and Development Organisation **(DRDO)** signed **2 major industry contracts** for the **Airborne Early Warning and Control (AEW&C) Mk-II Programme** to enhance India's indigenous airborne surveillance and air defence capabilities.

- The contracts were signed by the Centre for Air Borne Systems **(CABS)**, a DRDO laboratory, with AI Engineering Services Limited **(AIESL)**, New Delhi and Adani Defence Systems and Technologies Limited **(ADSTL)**, Ahmedabad in the presence of Rajesh Kumar Singh, Defence Secretary, Secretary (DRDO) and Chairman, DRDO, in New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** AEW&C Mk-II Programme Contracts
- ✓ **Who?** DRDO with AIESL and ADSTL
- ✓ **Date:** 22 July 2026
- ✓ **Venue:** New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Objective:** Airborne surveillance enhancement
- ✓ **Aircraft Platform:** Six Airbus A321 aircraft
- ✓ **Nodal Lab:** Centre for Air Borne Systems (CABS)
- ✓ **DcPP:** Adani Defence Systems and Technologies Limited (ADSTL)
- ✓ **Conversion Partner:** AI Engineering Services Limited (AIESL)

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Highlights of the AEW&C Mk-II Programme:

Background: Approved by the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) in **July 2025** with an outlay of **Rs. 19,000 crore,** the programme uses Airbus A321 aircraft acquired from Air India, with induction planned for 2032–2033.

Aircraft Conversion: CABS partnered with AIESL for the conversion of six Airbus A321 aircraft from commercial to green configuration, which will serve as the AEW&C Mk-II platform.

Mission Development: CABS selected ADSTL as the Development-cum-Production Partner **(DcPP)** for developing mission systems.

- The integrated aircraft will undergo flight testing with the Indian Air Force (IAF) and certification by Centre for Military Airworthiness and Certification (CEMILAC) and Directorate General of Aeronautical Quality Assurance (DGAQA).

Capabilities: The AEW&C Mk-II, with CABS as the nodal laboratory, is an advanced airborne surveillance and command system equipped with radar and communication systems. It will enhance surveillance, endurance, secure communication, situational awareness and command-and-control capabilities.

Defence Indigenisation: The programme strengthens **Aatmanirbhar Bharat** by promoting indigenous aerospace manufacturing, technology development and private sector participation in advanced defence systems.

About DefenceResearch and Development Organisation (DRDO):

Role: It Develops indigenous defence technologies, systems and equipment to strengthen India's defence capabilities and promote self-reliance in defence manufacturing.

DRDO: DRDO was established in 1958, headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi, functions under the Ministry of Defence (MoD), Government of India (GoI), and is headed by Rajesh Kumar Singh (Chairman, DRDO & Secretary, Department of Defence Research and Development).

CUK Signs MoU with IN to Foster Academic and Research Collaboration

In July 2026, the Central University of Kerala (**CUK**) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the Indian Navy (**IN**) to strengthen collaboration in maritime studies, defence research, innovation, and strategic knowledge development.

- The agreement was signed by **V.B. Sameer**, Registrar, CUK, and Commodore **Kalesh Mohanan**, Officer-in-Charge, Naval History Division (**NHD**), IN at the CUK campus in Kasaragod, Kerala.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** MoU signed for academic and research collaboration
- ✓ **Entities:** CUK & IN
- ✓ **Signed by:** V.B. Sameer (CUK) and Commodore Kalesh Mohanan (IN)
- ✓ **Focus Areas:** Maritime studies, defence research, AI, cybersecurity, ocean sciences, logistics and innovation
- ✓ **Key Activities:** Joint research, knowledge exchange, academic training and capacity building.

Key Details of MoU:

Objective: The agreement aims to promote academic excellence, interdisciplinary research, knowledge sharing, and capacity building in areas of mutual interest, with a special emphasis on maritime studies and strategic research.

Focus: The MoU will focus on interdisciplinary research in emerging fields such as maritime technologies, Artificial Intelligence (AI), cybersecurity, ocean sciences, environmental sustainability, logistics, and innovation.

Significance: The partnership establishes a platform between the central university and the IN to promote defence innovation, maritime security research, and initiatives aligned with national strategic priorities.

ARMY, NAVY & AIR FORCE NEWS

Indian Navy commissions indigenous stealth frigate INS Mahendragiri into Eastern Fleet

In July 2026, the **Indian Navy** (IN) commissioned the indigenous stealth frigate Indian Naval Ship **(INS) Mahendragiri** (Pennant Number: F38), the **sixth** Nilgiri-class **(Project-17A)** frigate, into the **Eastern Fleet** (Sunrise Fleet), strengthening maritime warfare and stealth capabilities under the vision of **MAHASAGAR** (Maritime Security Strategy for the Indian Ocean Region).

- The commissioning ceremony was presided over by Union Defence Minister **Rajnath Singh**, Ministry of Defence (MoD) at Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh (**AP**).

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Commissioning of INS Mahendragiri.
- ✓ **Class:** 6th Nilgiri-class (Project-17A) Stealth Frigate
- ✓ **Where?** Eastern Fleet (Sunrise Fleet), Visakhapatnam, AP
- ✓ **Commissioned By:** Indian Navy
- ✓ **Designed by:** Warship Design Bureau
- ✓ **Built by:** Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited
- ✓ **Purpose:** Strengthen India's maritime combat capability, stealth operations, and indigenous shipbuilding

About Stealth Frigate 'Mahendragiri':

Naming: The ship is named after the Mahendragiri mountain peak located in the Eastern Ghats of Odisha, it symbolises strength, steadfastness and indomitable resolve, and bears the motto '**Mighty, Majestic, Matchless**'

Design: It was designed by the Warship Design Bureau (**WDB**) and built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (**MDL**), Mumbai, Maharashtra

- The other ships already delivered to the IN include INS Nilgiri, INS Himgiri, INS Udaygiri, INS Taragiri, and INS Vindhyagiri.

Operations: INS Mahendragiri will conduct a full spectrum of maritime operations, including fleet air defence, anti-surface and anti-submarine warfare, maritime interdiction, surveillance, and humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (**HADR**).

Propulsion: The platform uses a Combined Diesel or Gas (**CODOG**) propulsion system, integrating diesel engines and gas turbines with controllable pitch propellers, along with an Integrated Platform Management System (**IPMS**), ensuring high efficiency and optimal performance.

Capabilities: INS Mahendragiri features a reduced Radar Cross-Section (**RCS**) and an upgraded design over the earlier Shivalik-class frigate, with its primary offensive weapon being the BrahMos Supersonic Cruise Missile (**SSCM**), one of the world's fastest and most lethal cruise missiles.

- It has a displacement of approximately **6,670 tonnes** and reaches speeds of up to **28 knots**, integrating multifunction radar with Medium-Range Surface-to-Air Missiles (**MR-SAM**) for aerial defence.

Arsenal: The ship is equipped with an indigenous rocket launcher, torpedo launchers, an Integrated Anti-Submarine Defence System (**IASDS**), an Electronic Warfare (**EW**) suite, an embarked multi-role helicopter, Close-In Weapon System (**CIWS**), and network-centric combat systems.

About Project 17A:

Overview: Project 17A (Project 17 Alpha) is an initiative approved by the Government of India (GoI) to build seven advanced warships and frigates for the IN. **Achievements:** The first P17A (Nilgiri-class) ship was launched by MDL on 20 December 2024, with 75% indigenous content.

Other Five Ships: The first ship of the series, INS Nilgiri, was commissioned in January 2025, followed by INS Udaygiri and INS Himgiri in August 2025, INS Taragiri in April 2026, and INS Dunagiri in June 2026.

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About Indian Navy (IN):
Chief of Naval Staff (CNS)-Admiral Krishna Swaminathan
Headquarters– New Delhi, Delhi
Established- 26 January 1950

USA Delivered 21st MH-60R Seahawk Helicopter to Indian Navy, Strengthening India-USA Defence Partnership

In July 2026, The United States of America **(USA)** delivered **21st MH-60R Seahawk** multi-role maritime helicopter, manufactured by **Lockheed Martin Corporation**, to the **Indian Navy** (IN) at Kochi, Kerala, reinforcing the India–USA defence partnership and enhancing India's maritime security capabilities.

- IN will further enhance its operational readiness, strengthen its anti-submarine warfare capabilities, and improve interoperability with the USA Navy in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 21st MH 60R seahawk Helicopters Delivered to IN
- ✓ **Where?** Kochi, Kerala
- ✓ **Developed By:** Lockheed Martin
- ✓ **Nickname:** "Romeo"
- ✓ **Variant:** Maritime variant of the Black Hawk helicopter
- ✓ **Procurement:** FMS agreement between India & USA for 24 MH-60R Seahawk helicopters

Highlights of MH-60R Seahawk Helicopters:

Procurement: India signed a Foreign Military Sales (FMS) agreement with the USA in February 2020 to procure 24 MH-60R Seahawk helicopters at a cost of **USD 2.6 billion** to replace the ageing Sea King fleet, strengthen naval aviation capabilities, with 21 have been delivered, two more are scheduled for delivery, and the final helicopter remains pending.

- The first Indian Navy MH-60R squadron, Indian Naval Air Squadron (INAS) 334, was commissioned at Indian Naval Ship (INS) Garuda, Kochi, Kerala, in March 2024, following initial deliveries that began in 2021.

Support: In November–December 2025, the Ministry of Defence (MoD) approved Letters of Offer and Acceptance (LOAs) worth **Rs.7,995 crore** (about USD 946 million) for a five-year sustainment package covering maintenance, logistics, spare parts and operational support for the 24-helicopter fleet.
Capabilities: The "Romeo" MH-60R Seahawk is an all-weather, multi-role shipborne maritime helicopter as a maritime variant of the Black Hawk, capable of Anti-Submarine Warfare (ASW), Anti-Surface Warfare (ASuW), surveillance, intelligence gathering, search and rescue, medical evacuation, vertical replenishment and shipborne operations.
Systems: The helicopter is equipped with dipping sonar, sonobuoys, multi-mode radar, electro-optical systems, electronic support measures, high-resolution daylight cameras, infrared thermal imagers, Mk-54 lightweight torpedoes, Air-to-Ground Missile (AGM)-114 Hellfire missiles and machine guns, and has a crew of 3–4, capacity for 5 passengers, 3,000 kilogram (kg) payload, 330 kilometre per hour (km/h) top speed, 830 kilometre (km) operational range and twin turboshaft engines.

About Lockheed Martin:
Chairman, President and Chief Executive Officer **(CEO)** – James Donald Taiclet Jr
Headquarters – Bethesda, Maryland,
Established – 1995

Indian Navy Commissions INS Malvan Warship to Strengthen Coastal Anti-Submarine Capabilities

In July 2026, the Indian Navy **(IN)** commissioned Indian Naval Ship (**INS) Malvan (Yard 524)**, Second of Eighth Mahe-class Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft (**ASW-SWC**), during a ceremony held at **Naval Base Karwar,** Karnataka.

- The ceremony was presided over by Air Chief Marshal **AP Singh**, Chief of the Air Staff (**COAS**), in the presence of Vice Admiral **Sanjay Vatsayan**, Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Naval Command in Kochi, Kerala.
- INS Malvan becomes the **first Indian** naval vessel ever to be commissioned at **Karwar** and the **7th** warship inducted by the Navy in 2026.

Exam Hint

- ✓ **What?** Commissioning of INS Malvan
- ✓ **By Whom?** Indian Navy
- ✓ **Where:** Karwar Naval Base, Karnataka
- ✓ **Class:** 2nd of 8th Mahe-class ASW-SWC
- ✓ **Builder:** Cochin Shipyard Limited
- ✓ **Role:** Coastal anti-submarine warfare, undersea surveillance, escort and maritime security operations

About INS Malvan:

Legacy: It named after the historic coastal town of Malvan, Maharashtra, which celebrates the maritime legacy of **Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj** and continues the lineage of the previous INS Malvan (in service until 2003).

Significance: The induction occurs amid increased submarine activity in the Indian Ocean Region (**IOR**), including China's People's Liberation Army Navy (**PLAN**) deployments and Pakistan's Hangor-class submarines.

Design: Constructed by Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL), Kochi, Kerala, the vessel incorporates over 80% indigenous content, aligning with the Aatmanirbhar Bharat vision.

- The programme includes contributions from domestic companies such as Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), Mahindra Defence Sysytem Limited (MDS) and Larsen & Toubro (**L&T**).

Specifications:

Dimensions: The vessel has 70-80 metres (m) long, displaces over 896-1,100 tonnes, has a beam of 11.36 m and shallow 2.7m draft, optimized for operations in littoral zones.

Pump-Jet Propulsion Engine: Powered by three **6 MW** (Mega Watt) marine diesel engines coupled to waterjets, making it the largest class of IN warships to utilize pump-jet propulsion for high agility and reduced acoustic signatures.

Endurance: Capable of reaching a top speed of 25 knots (approximately 45 kilometre per hour, km/hr) with an operational range of 1,800 nautical miles at 14 knots and an endurance of 14 days.

Stealth Profile: Built with reduced radar cross-section (**RCS**), low acoustic signatures, and infrared suppression technologies to operate undetected near enemy coastlines.

Operation: It is designed to conduct anti-submarine operations in coastal and shallow waters, and support low intensity maritime operations (**LIMO**) and mine warfare.

- The vessels are equipped for search-and-attack missions, while also performing search-and-rescue (**SAR**), and port-protection roles.

Anti-Submarine Weapons: Equipped with a forward-mounted **RBU-6000** anti-submarine rocket launcher, triple **324 mm** (millimetre) lightweight torpedo tubes armed with Advanced Light-Weight Torpedoes **(ALWT)**, and anti-submarine mine-laying rails.

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Surface Guns: Fitted with a 30 mm naval gun and two 12.7 mm stabilized Remote-Controlled Weapon Stations (RCWS).

About ASW-SWC:

Overview: ASW-SWC is a class of small surface vessels designed for anti-submarine warfare in littoral waters, with 16 vessels planned for the IN.

Development: The Ministry of Defence (MoD) signed separate contracts worth Rs.6,311 crore each with Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) on 29 April 2019 and CSL on 30 April 2019 to build eight vessels each, with GRSE deliveries scheduled for 2022–2026 and CSL required to complete its order within 84 months.

Purpose: The vessels are being developed to replace the Indian Navy's Abhay-class corvettes and strengthen near-shore anti-submarine capabilities through enhanced automation, manoeuvrability, and endurance.

Classes: The Arnala class, built by GRSE for the Eastern Fleet, comprises Arnala (18 June 2025), Androth (6 October 2025), Anjadip (27 February 2026), Agray (21 June 2026), Amini, Abhay, Ajay, and Akshay, while the Mahe class, built by CSL for the Western Fleet, comprises Mahe (24 November 2025), Malwan (22 July 2026), Mangrol, Malpe, Mulki, Magdala, Machilipatnam, and an eighth vessel under construction.

About Indian Navy (IN):

Fleet: The IN currently operates an active fleet of approximately 145 warships and submarines, with an aggressive modernisation plan to reach a 200-ship fleet by 2035.

Chief of Naval Staff (CNS) – Admiral Krishna Swaminathan

Headquarters – New Delhi, Delhi

Established – 26 January 1950

CSL launched 'Machilipatnam' Seventh Anti-Submarine Warfare Vessel for IN

In July 2026, Cochin Shipyard Limited (**CSL**) launched **Machilipatnam** (Yard BY 529), **seventh** of eight Mahe-class Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft (**ASW-SWC**) indigenously constructed for the Indian Navy (**IN**), during a ceremony held at Cochin Shipyard, Kerala.

- The vessel was launched by **Goolrukh Anand** in the presence of Vice Admiral **Atul Anand**, Additional Secretary, Department of Military Affairs (**DMA**) and **Jose VJ,** Director (Finance) and Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) as Additional Charge, CSL.

Exam Hint

- ✓ **What?** Launch of Machilipatnam (Yard BY 529)
- ✓ **Launched By:** Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL) for the IN
- ✓ **Where?** Cochin Shipyard Limited, Kochi, Kerala
- ✓ **Class:** 7th of 8th Mahe-class ASW-SWC
- ✓ **Role:** Coastal anti-submarine warfare, undersea surveillance, escort and maritime security operations

About Machilipatnam (Yard BY 529):

Legacy: The vessel is named after the historic port city of Machilipatnam in Krishna district, Andhra Pradesh (**AP**), recognising its rich maritime heritage and its centuries-old role as a prominent trading hub along India's eastern coastline.

Design: Constructed by CSL, Kochi, Kerala, the vessel incorporates over 80% indigenous content, aligning with the Aatmanirbhar Bharat vision.

Specifications:

Dimensions: The vessel is 78 metres (m) long, 11.36 m wide with a draught of about 2.7 m and a displacement of around **900 tonnes**.

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Endurance: Equipped with waterjet propulsion systems, the vessel can achieve a maximum speed of **25 knots** and has an operational endurance of **1,800 nautical miles**.
Advanced Sonar Capability: The vessel is equipped with state-of-the-art indigenously developed Hull-Mounted Sonar (**HMS**) and Low-Frequency Variable Depth Sonar (**LFVDS**) systems for advanced underwater target detection and surveillance.

About ASW-SWC:

Overview: ASW-SWC is a class of small surface vessels designed for anti-submarine warfare in littoral waters, with 16 vessels planned for the IN.
Development: The Ministry of Defence (MoD) signed separate contracts worth Rs.6,311 crore each with Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) on 29 April 2019 and CSL on 30 April 2019 to build eight vessels each, with GRSE deliveries scheduled for 2022–2026 and CSL required to complete its order within 84 months.
Purpose: The vessels are being developed to replace the Indian Navy's Abhay-class ASW corvettes and enhance Maritime Domain Awareness (**MDA**) through enhanced automation, manoeuvrability, and endurance.
Classes: The Arnala class, built by GRSE for the Eastern Fleet, comprises Arnala (18 June 2025), Androth (6 October 2025), Anjadip (27 February 2026), Agray (21 June 2026), Amini, Abhay, Ajay, and Akshay, while the Mahe class, built by CSL for the Western Fleet, comprises Mahe (24 November 2025), Malwan (22 July 2026), Mangrol, Malpe, Mulki, Magdala, Machilipatnam, and an eighth vessel under construction.

About Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL):

Overview: CSL is India's largest shipbuilding and ship repair facility and a Miniratna Category-I Central Public Sector Enterprise (**CPSE**) under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (**MoPSW**).
Established: 1972
Headquarters: Kochi, Kerala
Chairman and Managing Director (**CMD**): Jose VJ (Additional Charge)

SPORTS

US Open 2026 Badminton: Chinese Taipei's Su Li-yang Wins Men's Singles Title; India's Kidambi Srikanth Finishes Runner-Up

The 2026 United States **(U.S.) Open Badminton** (officially known as the Yonex US Open 2026), held at California State University, Fullerton, California, United States of America (USA) on **23-28 June 2026**, where Indian badminton player **Kidambi Srikanth** finished as runner-up in the men's singles event.

- Chinese Taipei's **Su Li-yang** won the men's singles title, while Denmark's **Line Christophersen** claimed the women's singles crown at the 2026 US Open.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** US Open 2026 Badminton held
- ✓ **Where?** California, USA
- ✓ **Organiser:** USA Badminton & BWF
- ✓ **Indian Winner:** Kidambi Srikanth, runner up in the men's singles event
- ✓ **2026 Winners:**
- ✓ **Men's Singles:** Su Li-yang (Chinese Taipei)
- ✓ **Women's Singles:** Line Christophersen (Denmark)
- ✓ **Men's Doubles:** Hiroki Okamura / Kyohei Yamashita (Japan)
- ✓ **Women's Doubles:** Sumire Nakade / Miyu Takahashi (Japan)
- ✓ **Mixed Doubles:** Liu Kuang-heng / Hsu Yin-hui (Chinese Taipei).

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About US Open 2026 Badminton:

Edition: The 2026 U.S. Open Badminton Championships is the **61st** edition of the tournament, held since 1954, and the **17th** tournament of the Badminton World Federation (BWF) World Tour 2026 as a Super 300 event.

Organisation: The tournament is organised by USA Badminton and sanctioned by the BWF.

Prize: The tournament offers a total prize purse of **USD 250,000,** with winners receiving USD 18,750 in singles and USD 19,750 in doubles, while runner-up receive USD 9,500 in both categories.

Highlights:

Men's Singles: Kidambi Srikanth (World No. 38) finished runner-up after losing to Su Li-yang (World No. 46) **15–21, 21–16, 9–21** in the 69-minute final, having defeated Lee Zii Jia and Yudai Okimoto en route.

Women's Singles: Line Christophersen (Denmark) defeated Kaloyana Nalbantova (Bulgaria) 21–16, 16–21, 21–11.

Men's Doubles: Hiroki Okamura/Kyohei Yamashita (Japan) defeated Chen Zhi-Ray/Lin Yu-Chieh (Chinese Taipei) 21–18, 16–21, 21–16.

Women's Doubles: Sumire Nakade/Miyu Takahashi (Japan) defeated Lin Chih-Chun/Yang Chu-Yun (Chinese Taipei) 21–16, 21–10.

Mixed Doubles: Liu Kuang-heng/Hsu Yin-hui (Chinese Taipei) defeated Wu Hsuan-yi/Yang Chu-Yun (Chinese Taipei) 21–9, 21–11.

Winners of the US Open 2026:

Event	Champion(s)	Runner(s)-Up
Men's Singles	Su Li-yang (Chinese Taipei)	**Kidambi Srikanth (India)**
Women's Singles	Line Christophersen (Denmark)	Kaloyana Nalbantova (Bulgaria)
Men's Doubles	Hiroki Okamura / Kyohei Yamashita (Japan)	Chen Zhi-Ray / Lin Yu-Chieh (Chinese Taipei)
Women's Doubles	Sumire Nakade / Miyu Takahashi (Japan)	Lin Chih-Chun / Yang Chu-Yun (Chinese Taipei)
Mixed Doubles	Liu Kuang-heng / Hsu Yin-hui (Chinese Taipei)	Wu Hsuan-yi / Yang Chu-Yun (Chinese Taipei)

About Badminton World Federation (BWF):

President – Khunying Patama Leeswadtrakul (Thailand)
Headquarters – Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia
Established – 1934

Austrian Grand Prix 2026: Mercedes' George Russell wins

In June 2026, **George Russell**, a United Kingdom (UK) Formula One (**F1**) driver representing **Mercedes**-AMG Petronas F1, won the **2026 Austrian Grand Prix** (officially known as the Formula 1 Lenovo Großer Preis von Österreich 2026) serving as Round 8 of the Fédération Internationale de l'Automobile (FIA) F1 World Championship held at the Red Bull Ring in Spielberg, Styria, Austria.

- George Russell secured his **seventh** F1 Grand Prix (GP) victory and **second win** of the 2026 season (following his season-opening win in Australia)

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Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Austrian Grand Prix victory 2026
- ✓ **Winner:** George Russell (Mercedes)
- ✓ **Podium:** Max Verstappen (Red Bull Racing, 2nd), Andrea Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes, 3rd)
- ✓ **Where?** Red Bull Ring, Spielberg, Styria, Austria.

Key Highlights:

- **Performance:** George Russell finished **1.611 seconds ahead** of Max Verstappen with a race time of **1:26:37.979**, propelled back to P2 in the Drivers' Championship
- **Podium: Max Verstappen** of Red Bull Racing finished second and **Andrea Kimi Antonelli** of Mercedes AMG Petronas F1 finished third.

Top 3 positions of F1 Austrian Grand Prix 2026

Rank	Driver	Brand	Country
1	George Russell	Mercedes AMG Petronas F1	United Kingdom
2	Max Verstappen	Red Bull Racing	Netherlands
3	Andrea Kimi Antonelli	Mercedes AMG Petronas F1	Italy

Top 5 Drivers – Championship Standings After Austrian Grand Prix 2026

Rank	Driver	Team	Points
1	Kimi Antonelli	Mercedes AMG Petronas F1	171
2	George Russell	Mercedes AMG Petronas F1	131
3	Lewis Hamilton	Scuderia Ferrari HP	125
4	Oscar Piastri	McLaren Mastercard F1	80
5	Lando Norris	McLaren Mastercard F1	79

About Austrian Grand Prix:

Overview: Nestled in Austria's Styrian mountains, the Austrian GP is renowned for its short lap, dramatic elevation changes and passionate fan atmosphere.

- First held as a World Championship event in 1964

Circuit: The Barcelona-Catalunya circuit spans **4.318** kilometers (km) per lap, with a total of **71 laps** covering a race distance of **306.452 km.**

Most Driver Victories: Max Verstappen (4 Wins) – 2018, 2019, 2021, 2023

India Women's Cricket Team Secure Direct Qualification for Los Angeles 2028 Olympics

In June 2026, the International Cricket Council **(ICC)** confirmed that the **Indian women's cricket team** secured direct qualification for the Los Angeles **(LA) 2028 Olympic Games** following the conclusion of the group stage of the ICC Women's T20 (Twenty20) World Cup in England.

- The qualification pathway ensures continental representation by awarding one automatic berth each to Asia, Africa, Europe, and Oceania for the LA 2028 Olympics, marking cricket's historic return to the Games.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Direct Qualification for LA 2028 Olympics Games
- ✓ **Who?** India Women's Cricket Team, Captained by Harmanpreet Kaur
- ✓ **Announced by:** ICC
- ✓ **Olympics:** LA 2028 Olympics to be held in Pomona, California, USA from 12–29 July 2028
- ✓ **Qualified Teams:** Australia (Oceania), South Africa (Africa), Great Britain/England (Europe), India (Asia)

About Cricket at Los Angeles 2028 Olympics:

India's Qualification: Indian women's team, captained by Harmanpreet Kaur, secured Asia's sole automatic berth under the ICC qualification pathway by finishing ahead of Sri Lanka on a better Net Run Rate (NRR).

Qualified Teams: Qualified women's teams are India (Asia), Australia (Oceania), South Africa (Africa), and Great Britain (represented by England in ICC events), while the United States of America (USA) may receive the host quota and the final spot will be decided through the ICC Olympics Qualifier 2027.

Format: Cricket will return to the LA 2028 Olympics after 128 years since Paris 1900, with separate men's and women's T20 tournaments featuring six teams each, 15-member squads, two groups of three, gold and bronze medal matches, and a total of 28 matches.

Venue: All cricket matches will be played at a purpose-built venue in Pomona, California, USA from 12–29 July 2028.

Australia Clinched 7th Women's T20 Cricket World Cup Title by Defeating England in Finals

The 2026 International Cricket Council **(ICC) Women's Twenty20 (T20) Cricket World Cup** was held from 12 June to 5 July 2026, culminating in the final at Lord's Cricket Ground in London, England, where **Australia** defeated **England** by seven wickets chasing down 151 with 153/3 in 17.1 overs to secure a record-extending **seventh** title.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **Event:** 2026 ICC Women's T20 World Cup
- ✓ **Host:** England and Wales Cricket Board
- ✓ **When?** 12 June to 5 July 2026
- ✓ **Tournament Edition:** 10th ICC Women's T20 World Cup
- ✓ **Champion:** Australia Women – 7th title
- ✓ **Runner-up:** England Women
- ✓ **Leading Wicket Taker:** Shree Charani (India)
- ✓ **Key Players:** Beth Mooney (Australia – Player of the Final & Tournament), Phoebe Litchfield (Australia)
- ✓ **Prize Pool:** USD 8.76 million; Winners-USD 2.34 million, Runners-up – USD 1.17 million

About ICC Women's T20 World Cup 2026:

Overview: The 2026 ICC Women's T20 World Cup was the 10th edition of the biennial international cricket tournament for women in the Twenty20 International (WT20I) format, hosted by the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) across seven venues.

Format: Twelve teams competed in two groups of six in a round-robin format. The top two from each group advanced to semi-finals.

Organiser: The tournament was organised by ICC.

Background: The inaugural edition was held in England in 2009, marking the beginning of the premier global championship for women's T20 cricket.

Prize Money: Total pool – USD 8.76 million; Winners – USD 2.34 million, Runners-up – USD 1.17 million; USD 31,154 per win for group stage matches

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India's Significance:

Shree Charani: Indian bowler Shree Charani headlined the tournament by taking **14 wickets**, finishing as the Leading Wicket-Taker of the 2026 Women's T20 World Cup. Charani also set the national record for the most wickets by an Indian in a single edition.

Indian Team Position: India Women's Cricket Team finished 3rd in Group A of the 2026 ICC Women's T20 World Cup and failed to qualify for the semi-finals.

Key Performances:

- **Beth Mooney** (Australia): 64 runs, Player of the Final and Tournament, first player to win two Player of the Tournament awards in T20WC history (2023 and 2026)
- Ellyse Perry (Australia) equalled Alyssa Healy's (Australia) record of seven Women's T20 World Cup final appearances

Shabnim Ismail Creates History in ICC Women's T20 World Cup 2026

Milestone: South Africa fast bowler **Shabnim Ismail** became the first player to claim 50 wickets in the **ICC Women's Twenty20 (T20) World Cup**.

- Ismail extended her tally to 51 wickets to remain the leading wicket-taker in Women's T20 World Cup history, ahead of Australia's Megan Schutt (48), Australia's Ellyse Perry (44), England's Anya Shrubsole (41), and South Africa's Marizanne Kapp (39).

About International Cricket Council (ICC):

Chairman – Jay Amitbhai Shah

Headquarters – Dubai, United Arab Emirates (UAE)

Established – 1909

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi Breaks Sachin Tendulkar's Record, Becomes India's Youngest International Debutant

In July 2026, **Vaibhav Sooryavanshi** became **India's youngest international cricket debutant** at **15 years** and **99 days**, making his senior Twenty20 International (**T20I**) debut against England at Old Trafford, Manchester, England

- He broke Sachin Tendulkar's **36-year-old record**, who debuted for India against Pakistan in 1989 at 16 years and 205 days (Test) and 16 years and 238 days (One Day International (ODI)).
- He also broke the record of **Shafali Verma**, India's youngest overall international debutant at 15 years and 239 days against South Africa in 2019.

Exam Hint:

- ✓ **What?** Youngest Indian cricket debutant
- ✓ **Who?** Vaibhav Sooryavanshi
- ✓ **Age:** 16 years and 210 days
- ✓ **Previous Record Holder:** Sachin Tendulkar (16 years and 205 days (Test))
- ✓ **Team:** India National Cricket Team
- ✓ **Format:** Twenty20 International (T20I)
- ✓ **Against:** England at Old Trafford, Manchester, England

About Vaibhav Sooryavanshi:

Profile: Born in 2011 in Tajpur, Bihar, he made his first-class debut as a right-handed batsman at 12 years 284 days in 2024 and scored a 58-ball century in India Under-19 Youth Test against Australia the same year.

Performance: Sooryavanshi earned his maiden national call-up after scoring 776 runs at a strike rate of 237.30, including 1 century and 5 fifties, and hitting a record 72 sixes for Rajasthan Royals (RR) in Indian Premier League (IPL 2026), finished as tournament's top run-scorer.

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Under-19 World Cup: In his maiden season in 2026, he helped India win the title, scoring 439 runs in 7 innings at an average of 62.71 and strike rate of 169.49, with a century, 3 fifties, best of 175, and 30 sixes.
Honours: He became the first player in IPL history to win the Orange Cap, Most Valuable Player (MVP) and Emerging Player awards in the same season, along with Super Striker and Super Sixes awards.

India Secures 41 Medals at the U15, U20 Asian Wrestling Championships 2026 in Pattaya, Thailand

The United World Wrestling **(UWW)** organised the Under-15 (U15) & U20 Asian Wrestling Championships 2026 in **Pattaya, Thailand** from June 27 to July 5, 2026.

- Indian wrestlers secured **20 medals** in the **U20** category, including 4 gold, 7 silver, and 9 bronze medals, and **21 medals** in the **U15** category, comprising 8 gold, 6 silver, and 7 bronze medals.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** U15, U20 Asian Wrestling Championships 2026 held
- ✓ **Where?** Pattaya, Thailand
- ✓ **Organiser:** UWW
- ✓ **Category:** Men's Freestyle, Greco-Roman, Women's Wrestling.
- ✓ **Indian Medals:**
- ✓ **U15:** 21 medals (8 gold, 6 silver, and 7 bronze)
- ✓ **U20:** 20 medals (4 gold, 7 silver, and 9 bronze)
- ✓ **Standings:** India finished second in WW, third in Men's FS, third in GR

About U15, U20 Asian Wrestling Championships 2026:

Overview: The U15 and U20 annual event serves as a pivotal bridge for identifying elite athletic progression in the Asian zone.
Disciplines: The tournament followed standard International Wrestling Regulations (IWR) and featured Men's Freestyle (FS), Greco-Roman (GR), and Women's Wrestling (WW).
Format: The competition used a single-elimination bracket with a repechage system for wrestlers defeated by the eventual finalists.
Rules: Matches consisted of two 2-minute periods for U15 and two 3-minute periods for U20, with each national federation allowed to enter a maximum of one wrestler per weight category.

Categories:

- **U15:** FS and GR featured 38 kilogram (kg), 41kg, 44kg, 48kg, 52kg, 57kg, 62kg, 68kg, 75kg, and 85kg, while WW included 33kg, 36kg, 39kg, 42kg, 46kg, 50kg, 54kg, 58kg, 62kg, and 66kg.
- **U20:** FS and GR were contested in 57kg, 61kg, 65kg, 70kg, 74kg, 79kg, 86kg, 92kg, 97kg, and 125kg, while WW comprised 50kg, 53kg, 55kg, 57kg, 59kg, 62kg, 65kg, 68kg, 72kg, and 76kg.

India's Standings:

Under-15: Uzbekistan topped the standings with 171 points, followed by Kazakhstan with 167 points and India with 150 points. India won the **bronze** team trophy.
Under-20: India finished second in Women's Wrestling (WW) with 184 points, behind China (189) and ahead of Japan (142). It also secured third place in Men's Freestyle (FS) with 152 points, behind Kazakhstan (170) and Iran (164).

Medal Tally of India at U15 & U20 Asian Wrestling Championships 2026:

Category	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total Medals
Under-20 (U20)	4	7	9	20

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U15	8	6	7	21
Grand Total	**12**	**13**	**16**	**41**

Indian Gold Medal Winners at U15 & U20 Asian Championships 2026:

Championship	Category	Wrestler	Weight Class in kilogram (kg)
U20	Women's Freestyle	Parveen	50 kg
	Women's Freestyle	Muskan	53 kg
	Women's Freestyle	Kajal	76 kg
	Men's Freestyle	Sumit Kumar Laxman Bharaskar	70 kg
U15	Greco-Roman	Darpan Raju Chaudhari	62 kg
	Women's Freestyle	Samruddhi Satish Patil	33 kg
	Women's Freestyle	Vinakshi	46 kg
	Women's Freestyle	Disha Shokeen	66 kg
	Men's Freestyle	Prathamesh S. Patil	52 kg
	Men's Freestyle	Naitik	62 kg
	Men's Freestyle	Keshav Harshad Chemte	75 kg
	Men's Freestyle	Vivek Chauhan	85 kg

About United World Wrestling (UWW):

Overview: UWW is the international governing body for wrestling, responsible for regulating the sport and overseeing major international competitions, including the World Wrestling Championships and the Olympic wrestling events.

Establishment: It was founded in 1921 as the International Amateur Wrestling Federation (IAWF), later renamed Fédération Internationale des Luttes Associées (FILA) before becoming UWW in 2014.

President – Nenad Lalović

Headquarters – Lausanne, Switzerland

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Aswath S Becomes India's 98th Chess Grandmaster at Pune International GM

In July 2026, 17-year-old **Aswath S** from Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu (TN), became India's **98th Grandmaster (GM)** after securing his third and final GM norm by finishing runner-up at the Pune International Grandmaster Round Robin Tournament in Mundhwa, Pune, Maharashtra.

- He sealed the historic achievement with a must-win final-round victory over United States of America (USA)'s International Chess Federation (FIDE) Master (FM) **Kannan Vaidyanathan** with black pieces to secure the norm.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India's 98th Chess Grandmaster
- ✓ **Who?** Aswath S
- ✓ **Where?** Pune International GM Round Robin Tournament, Pune, Maharashtra
- ✓ **Norms:** First GM norm at Grenke Open 2025, second at First Saturday GM Round Robin Budapest Dec 2025, 3rd norm with 7 points/9 rounds at Pune
- ✓ **Final Round:** Defeated USA's FM Kannan Vaidyanathan with black pieces to secure the norm.

About Aswath S:

GM Journey: Aswath secured his first GM norm by winning the Grenke Open A in Germany with 8/9 points in April 2025, earned his second by winning the First Saturday GM Round Robin in Budapest with 7/9 points in December 2025 while crossing the 2500 FIDE rating mark, and completed his third and final norm by finishing runner-up with 7/9 points in Pune.

Recognition: Aswath received the runner-up trophy with a cash prize of Rs.75,000, is set to compete at the Serbia Open with a target of crossing the 2600 FIDE rating mark, and his achievement further strengthens India's growing presence in global chess.

Note: GM Abhijeet Gupta won the 2026 Pune International Grandmaster Round Robin Tournament, finishing as the sole champion with 7.5 points from nine rounds.

FIDE Criteria for Chess GM Qualification:

Three GM Norms: Players must perform exceptionally well in FIDE-approved tournaments against strong, titled opponents.

2500 Elo Rating: They need to reach a FIDE rating of at least 2500 at any point in their career.

International Tournaments: The norms must be earned in events featuring players from different countries.

Performance Rating: Each norm should show a performance level of around 2600 or above

About International Chess Federation or Fédération Internationale des Échecs (FIDE):

President – Arkady Vladimirovich Dvorkovich

Headquarters – Lausanne, Switzerland

Established – 1924

Ferrari's Charles Leclerc Wins F1 British Grand Prix 2026

In July 2026, Monaco's **Charles Leclerc** of Ferrari won the **British Grand Prix (GP) 2026** (officially known as the Formula One (F1) Pirelli British GP 2026), the ninth round of the 2026 F1 World Championship, held at the **Silverstone Circuit** in Northamptonshire, England.

- The victory marked Charles Leclerc's first victory of the 2026 Formula 1 season, his ninth Formula 1 GP career win, and Ferrari's 250th F1 GP triumph.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** F1 British Grand Prix 2026 held
- ✓ **Where?** Silverstone Circuit in Northamptonshire, England
- ✓ **Winner:** Monaco's Charles Leclerc of Ferrari

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✓ **Runner-ups:** George Russell of Mercedes; Lewis Hamilton of Ferrari.

Highlights of 2026 British Grand Prix:

2026 Podium Finishers: Mercedes' **George Russell** secured second place, while Ferrari's **Lewis Hamilton** finished third.

- Mercedes' Kimi Antonelli, who started from pole position, was classified 16th after a brake-duct failure and a post-race penalty.

Sprint Race: Kimi Antonelli won the Sprint race, followed by Lewis Hamilton in second place and McLaren's Lando Norris in third place. The Sprint race results determined the starting grid for the main race.

Championship Standings: Kimi Antonelli led the Drivers' Championship with 179 points, followed by George Russell with 154 points and Lewis Hamilton with 147 points.

- In the Constructors' Championship, **Mercedes** led with 333 points, followed by Ferrari (255 points) and McLaren (179 points).

Top 3 Positions at 2026 British GP:

Rank	Driver	Team	Country
1	Charles Leclerc	Ferrari	Monaco
2	George Russell	Mercedes	United Kingdom (UK)
3	Lewis Hamilton	Ferrari	UK

Top 5 Drivers – Championship Standings After 2026 British GP:

Rank	Driver	Team	Points
1	Kimi Antonelli	Mercedes	179
2	George Russell	Mercedes	154
3	Lewis Hamilton	Ferrari	147
4	Charles Leclerc	Ferrari	108
5	Lando Norris	McLaren	97

About British Grand Prix:

Overview: The Silverstone Circuit hosted the inaugural F1 World Championship race on 13 May 1950 and is renowned for its 5.891- kilometer (km) high-speed layout, where drivers spend nearly 80% of the lap at full throttle while experiencing immense lateral G (Gravitational)-forces.

Edition: The 2026 British Grand Prix marked the **77th** edition of the event.

Telangana to Host 8th Khelo India Youth Games in November 2026

On July 8 2026, Union Minister **Mansukh Mandaviya,** Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports (MYAS), announced that **Telangana** will host the 8th Khelo India Youth Games **(KIYG)**.

- KIYG 2026 is scheduled to be held in November 2026 to provide a platform for young athletes to showcase their talent.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What Event?** 8th Khelo India Youth Games (KIYG)
- ✓ **Host State:** Telangana
- ✓ **Announced By:** Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, MYAS
- ✓ **Expected Schedule:** November 2026
- ✓ **Previous Host (2025):** Bihar.

About Khelo India Youth Games (KIYG 2026):

Objective: The KIYG aims to identify and nurture grassroots sporting talent in line with the vision of Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi.

Participation: Around 8,000 athletes, officials and support staff are expected to participate in the Games.

Previous Edition: The **7th KIYG** were hosted by **Bihar** in May 2025, where Maharashtra **(MH)** emerged as the overall champion, followed by Haryana and Rajasthan.

About Khelo India Programme: The Khelo India Programme was launched in 2018 by the MYAS to strengthen the sports ecosystem, identify talent at the grassroots level and promote a sporting culture across India.

Sourav Ganguly became the 12th Indian to be inducted into the ICC Hall of Fame

In July 2026, the International Cricket Council **(ICC)** inducted former India captain **Sourav Ganguly** into the **ICC Hall of Fame** during its Annual Conference in Edinburgh, Scotland, recognising his outstanding contribution to international cricket.

- The honour, conferred on his 54th birthday, made Ganguly the **12th Indian overall** and **10th Indian male cricketer** inducted into the Hall of Fame, celebrating players whose achievements have left a lasting impact on the game.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Induction into the ICC Hall of Fame
- ✓ **Who?** Former India captain Sourav Ganguly
- ✓ **By Whom?** ICC
- ✓ **Significance:** 12th Indian & 10th Indian male cricketer inducted into the ICC Hall of Fame
- ✓ **Features:** Honours legendary cricketers, with eligibility beginning five years after their final international appearance.

About Sourav Ganguly:

Career: Ganguly represented India in 424 international matches, scoring 18,575 runs, including 38 centuries and 107 half-centuries, establishing himself among India's greatest left-handed batters.

Achievements: Led India to the 2001 Border-Gavaskar Trophy win, the 2004 Test series victory in Pakistan, runner-up finishes in the 2000 ICC KnockOut Trophy and 2003 ICC Cricket World Cup, and scored 7,212 Test and 11,363 One-Day Internationals (ODIs) runs, earning the nickname "God of Offside."

Administration: Following retirement, Ganguly served as President of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) from 23 October 2019 to 18 October 2022 and later became President of the Cricket Association of Bengal (CAB).

ICC Hall of Fame: Launched in January 2009 during the ICC's centenary celebrations, it honours cricketers with outstanding contributions to the sport, with eligibility beginning five years after their final international appearance.

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Wimbledon Championships 2026: Jannik Sinner and Linda Nosková Won Men's and Women's Singles Titles

The **2026 Wimbledon Championships**, a major tennis tournament, was held at the All England Lawn Tennis and Croquet Club **(AELTC)** in Wimbledon, London, England from 29 June to 12 July 2026, where World No. 1 **Jannik Sinner** of Italy won the **men's singles title** by defeating Germany's Alexander Zverev 6-7(7), 7-6(2), 6-3, 6-4 in the final, securing his fifth Grand Slam singles title.

- **Linda Nosková** of the Czech Republic, the ninth seed, won the 2026 Wimbledon **women's singles title** by defeating fellow Czech Karolína Muchová, 6-2, 5-7, 6-3, the 10th seed, in the final.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Wimbledon Championships 2026
- ✓ **Where?** Wimbledon, London, England
- ✓ **When?** 29 June to 12 July 2026
- ✓ **Organiser:** AELTC
- ✓ **Winners:**
- ✓ **Men singles** – Jannik Sinner (Italy)
- ✓ **Women singles** – Linda Nosková (Czech Republic)
- ✓ **Men doubles** – Harri Heliövaara (Finland) & Henry Patten (UK)
- ✓ **Women doubles** – Guo Hanyu (China) & Kristina Mladenovic (France)
- ✓ **Mixed doubles** – Marcelo Arévalo (El Salvador) & Jeļena Ostapenko (Latvia)

About Wimbledon Championships 2026:

Grand Slam: The 2026 tournament was the **139th edition** of the Wimbledon Championships and is one of the four Grand Slam tournaments, alongside the Australian Open, French Open, and US Open (United States of America, USA).

Organisers: Wimbledon, established in 1877, is organised by the AELTC in association with the World Tennis (formerly International Tennis Federation, ITF).

Events: The championships feature men's and women's singles, doubles, mixed doubles, junior, wheelchair, and invitational events.

Playing Surface: All matches are played on outdoor grass courts.

Prize Money: The 2026 Wimbledon Championships offered a total prize pool of 64.2 million pound sterling, a 20% increase from 2025, with the men's and women's singles champions receiving 3.6 million pound sterling each and the runners-up 1.8 million pound sterling each.

Highlights:

Men's Singles: Sinner became the 10th man in the Open Era to successfully defend the Wimbledon men's singles championship and also achieved his **100th Grand Slam match victory**, becoming one of the few active players to reach the milestone.

Women's Singles: Linda Nosková won her maiden Grand Slam title, becoming the youngest Wimbledon women's singles champion since **2011**.

Women's Doubles: The 10th-seeded pair of Guo Hanyu (China) and Kristina Mladenovic (France) won the 2026 Wimbledon women's doubles title by defeating Gabriela Dabrowski (Canada) and Luisa Stefani (Brazil) 6–3, 7–5 in the final, marking their first Grand Slam title together, Guo's maiden Grand Slam title, and Mladenovic's seventh Grand Slam women's doubles title and first Wimbledon women's doubles crown.

Men's Doubles: Harri Heliövaara (Finland) and Henry Patten (United Kingdom) successfully defended their Wimbledon men's doubles title by defeating Marcelo Arévalo (El Salvador) and Mate Pavić (Croatia) 7-6(4), 7-6(3).

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Mixed Doubles: Marcelo Arévalo (El Salvador) and Jeļena Ostapenko (Latvia) won the mixed doubles title after defeating Marc Polmans (Australia) and Storm Hunter (Australia) 4-6, 7-5, 6-2.
Achievement: British wild card Arthur Fery became the first wild card in 25 years to reach the Wimbledon men's singles semi-finals, defeating World No. 10 Flavio Cobolli in the quarter-finals before losing to Alexander Zverev in the last four.

Winners & Runners of Wimbledon 2026:

Category	Winners	Runners-up
Men's Singles	Jannik Sinner (Italy)	Alexander Zverev (Germany)
Women's Singles	Linda Nosková (Czechia)	Karolína Muchová (Czechia)
Men's Doubles	Harri Heliövaara (Finland) / Henry Patten (United Kingdom, UK)	Marcelo Arévalo (El Salvador) / Mate Pavić (Croatia)
Women's Doubles	Guo Hanyu (China) / Kristina Mladenovic (France)	Gabriela Dabrowski (Canada) / Luisa Stefani (Brazil)
Mixed Doubles	Marcelo Arévalo (El Salvador) / Jeļena Ostapenko (Latvia)	Marc Polmans (Australia) / Storm Hunter (Australia)

About World Tennis:

International Tennis Federation (ITF) was rebranded as **World Tennis** in June 2026, is the world governing body for tennis, wheelchair tennis, and beach tennis.
President – David Haggerty
Headquarters – London, the United Kingdom (UK)
Founded – 1913

Indian Women's Cricket Team Defeats England in Women's Test at Lord's, London

In July 2026, the **Indian Women's Cricket Team**, led by Harmanpreet Kaur, defeated **England** by 270 runs in the first-ever **Women's Test** at Lord's Cricket Ground, London, United Kingdom (UK), successfully defending a target of 457 runs, marking India's **second-largest win** by runs in Women's Tests and the fourth-largest overall.

- The victory was powered by **Kranti Gaud's** seven wickets in the match, **Yastika Bhatia's** historic century, and **Sneh Rana's** four-wicket haul in the second innings.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India won the first-ever Women's Test at Lord's.
- ✓ **Where?** Lord's Cricket Ground, London, United Kingdom.
- ✓ **Winner:** India Women's Cricket Team
- ✓ **Opponent:** England
- ✓ **Result:** India defeated England by 270 runs, dismissing them for 186 in pursuit of 457.
- ✓ **Player of the Match:** Kranti Gaud
- ✓ **Key Performances**
- ✓ Kranti Gaud – **5/37** (first innings), **7 wickets** in the match.
- ✓ Yastika Bhatia – **113** (first century in a Women's Test at Lord's).
- ✓ Sneh Rana – **4/42** in England's second innings.

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- ✓ Smriti Mandhana – Fifties in both innings.
- ✓ Harmanpreet Kaur and Richa Ghosh – Half-centuries.

About India's Historic Women's Test Victory at Lord's:

Result: India scored 285 in the first innings and 341/7 declared in the second innings to set England 457 runs (the second-highest target in Women's Tests), before dismissing them for 170 and 186.
Batting: Yastika Bhatia (113) became the first woman to score a Test century at Lord's and entered the honours board, **Smriti Mandhana** scored 70 and registered half-centuries in both innings, while **Harmanpreet Kaur** (62) and **Richa Ghosh** also contributed valuable half-centuries.
Bowling: Debutant **Kranti Gaud** was named **Player of the Match** for her match-winning 7/91, including 5/37 in the first innings, the first five-wicket haul by a woman in a Test at Lord's, while **Sneh Rana** (4/42), **Deepti Sharma** (3 wickets), and **Sayali Satghare** provided effective support.
Captaincy: Harmanpreet Kaur registered her fourth Women's Test victory as captain, surpassing Mithali Raj's three to become India's most successful Women's Test captain.
Records: India remained unbeaten in Women's Tests in England (3 wins, 7 draws), and the match established a Women's Test attendance record of 37,846 across four days.
Retirements: The Lord's Test marked the final international appearances of England's **Tammy Beaumont** and former England captain **Heather Knight**, with India's players honouring them through a **guard of honour** and **signed Team India jerseys** after the match.

About Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI):

President – Mithun Manhas
Headquarters – Mumbai, Maharashtra
Established – 1928

Padma Shri Anjum Chopra and Kevin Pietersen Were Inducted into ICC Hall of Fame

In July 2026, the International Cricket Council (**ICC**) inducted former Indian women's cricket captain **Anjum Chopra** and former England captain **Kevin Pietersen** into the **ICC Hall of Fame** during its Annual Conference in Edinburgh, Scotland, recognising their outstanding contributions and exceptional performances in international cricket.

- Anjum Chopra became the **3rd Indian woman** after Diana Edulji and Neetu David, and the **13th** Indian overall to be inducted into the ICC Hall of Fame, taking the total number of inductees to **125.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Induction into the ICC Hall of Fame
- ✓ **Who?** Former India captain Anjum Chopra, former England captain Kevin Pietersen
- ✓ **Total ICC Hall of Fame Members:** 125
- ✓ **Indian Inductee:** Anjum Chopra – 3rd Indian woman and 13th Indian overall in ICC Hall of Fame
- ✓ **Significance:** Honours legendary cricketers, with eligibility beginning five years after their final international appearance.

About Anjum Chopra:

Profile: She was a former captain of **Indian Women's Cricket Team** and represented India from 1995 to 2012. During a 17-year international career, she became the **first Indian woman** to feature in **100** One-Day Internationals (**ODI**) and reached 1,000 ODI runs.
Recognition: She earned a place in the Hall of Fame for her pioneering role in the growth of women's cricket in the country.
Leadership: She assumed captaincy in **2002**, leading the team to its first overseas Test series victory against South Africa. She earlier served as **Vice-Captain** in the 2000 Women's World Cup semi-finals and helped India reach the 2005 World Cup final.

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Achievements: In a career spanning 12 Tests, 127 ODIs, and 18 Twenty20 Internationals (T20Is), she scored 3,645 runs, including 2,856 in ODI and took 11 wickets and featured in six World Cups
Honors: The Government of India (GoI) awarded the **Padma Shri**, India's fourth-highest civilian award, to Anjum Chopra in **2014** for her contributions to the field of Sports (Cricket)

- She was also awarded Honorary Life Membership of the Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC) in 2016 and received ICC Player of the Match Awards in 2000, 2005, and 2009.

About Kevin Pietersen:

Recognition: Pietersen's induction recognises a career built on fearless batting and match-winning performances, contributing to England's rise in international cricket during his tenure.
Achievements: He played a key role in England's famous 2005 Ashes triumph. In 2010, he was named Player of the Tournament as England won the ICC Men's T20 World Cup, and by 2013, he became England's highest run-scorer across Tests, ODIs, and T20Is.
Legacy: He reached the No. 1 spot in the ICC ODI batter rankings and was a multiple-time selection in the ICC Teams of the Year.

- He retired as England's highest international run-scorer across all three formats, with more than 13,700 international runs.

About ICC Hall of Fame:

Launch: The ICC Hall of Fame was launched in **January 2009** as part of the ICC's centenary celebrations.
Legacy: The ICC Cricket Hall of Fame honours cricket's greatest legends, featuring players from all ICC Full Member nations across men's and women's cricket.
Eligibility: Players are eligible 5 years after their international retirement.

About International Cricket Council (ICC):

Chairman- Jay Shah
Headquarters- Dubai, United Arab Emirates
Established- 1909

Inaugural Asian U23 Athletics Championships 2026: China Tops; India Finishes Fourth with 3 Gold Medals

The 2026 Asian Under-23 (U23) Athletics Championships, the inaugural edition of the international athletics competition, held at the Ordos Sports Development Center Stadium in Ordos, China, 9th to 12th of July 2026, where India concluded its campaign with **16 medals** comprising **3 gold, 4 silver and 9 bronze**, finishing **fourth** in the overall standings.

- **China** topped the medal table with 23 gold, 17 silver, and 12 bronze medals (**52 total**), followed by **Japan** with 7 gold, 8 silver, and 7 bronze medals (**22 total**), and **Uzbekistan** with 5 gold, 4 silver, and 1 bronze medal (**10 total**).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Asian U23 Athletics Championships 2026 (Inaugural)
- ✓ **Where?** Ordos, China
- ✓ **When?** 9–12 July 2026
- ✓ **Organiser:** Asian Athletics
- ✓ **Top 3 countries:** China – 23 Gold (52 medals), Japan – 7 Gold (22 medals), Uzbekistan – 5 Gold (10 medals)
- ✓ **India's Position:** 4th
- ✓ **India's Medal Tally:** Total – 16, Gold – 3, Silver – 4, Bronze – 9
  Indian Gold Medal Winners
- ✓ Mixed 4×400m Relay.

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- ✓ Anand Singh – Men's Javelin Throw.
- ✓ Women's 4×400m Relay.
- ✓ **Best Indian Performer:** Shravani Sachin Sangle – 2 Gold, 1 Bronze.

About Asian U23 Athletics Championships 2026:

Overview: The 2026 Asian U23 Athletics Championships provided a continental platform for emerging athletes preparing to transition into senior international competition.

Organiser: The championships were organised by the **Asian Athletics** (AA) (Formerly Asian Athletics Association, AAA).

Eligibility: Athletes born between 2004 and 2006 were eligible to compete.

Events: The competition featured 45 events, comprising 22 men's events, 22 women's events, and one mixed event.

Highlights of Indian Athletes:

Gold Medals: India won three gold medals through the **Mixed 4×400 metres (m) Relay** (Astik Pradhan, Sandramol Sabu, Setu Mishra, and Shravani Sangle); Anand Singh in the **Men's Javelin Throw** (80.57 m; personal best), and the **Women's 4×400 m Relay** (Shravani Sangle, Sandramol Sabu, Pravallika Narimalla, and Nofisa Khatun).

- **Shravani Sachin Sangle** emerged as India's most successful athlete by winning three medals, two golds in the Mixed and Women's 4×400 metres Relay events and a bronze in the Women's 400 metres Hurdles.

Top 5 medal winners at Asian U23 Athletics Championships 2026:

Rank	Country	Gold Medal	Silver Medal	Bronze Medal	Total Medals
1	China	23	17	12	52
2	Japan	7	8	7	22
3	Uzbekistan	5	4	1	10
4	**India**	**3**	**4**	**9**	**16**
5	Qatar	3	2	3	8

Indian Gold Medal Winners at Asian U23 Athletics Championships 2026:

Athlete	Event
Anand Singh	Men's Javelin Throw
Shravani Sachin Sangle, Sandramol Sabu, Pravallika Narimalla, Nofisa Khatun	Women's 4x400m Relay
Astik Pradhan, Sandramol Sabu, Setu Mishra, Shravani Sachin Sangle	Mixed 4x400m Relay

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About the Asian Athletics (AA):

It serves as the governing body for athletics in Asia, having previously been known as the Asian Athletics Association (AAA) from 2002 to 2025 and the Asian Amateur Athletics Association (AAAA) from 1973 to 2002.

President – Dahlan Jumaan al-Hamad (Qatar)
Headquarters – Pathum Thani, Thailand
Established – 1973

India Wins First-Ever Women's T20I Deaf Cricket Series Against Sri Lanka

In July 2026, the Indian Deaf Women's Cricket Team won the **first-ever Women's Twenty20 International (T20I) series 2026**, defeating **Sri Lanka Deaf Women's Cricket Team 5–0** at the De Soysa International Cricket Stadium in Moratuwa, Sri Lanka.

- India sealed the series with a seven-wicket victory in the fifth and final match after bowling out Sri Lanka for 40 runs in 13.5 overs, reinforcing its growing stature in global deaf cricket.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Women's T20I series 2026
- ✓ **Where?** De Soysa International Cricket Stadium, Moratuwa, Sri Lanka.
- ✓ **Winner:** Indian Deaf Women's Cricket Team.
- ✓ **Opponent:** Sri Lanka Deaf Women's Cricket Team
- ✓ **Awards:**
- ✓ **Player of the Final:** Shradda Vaishnav (India)
- ✓ **Player of the Series:** Reddy Jyoshna (India)
- ✓ **Best Batter:** Needa Zabi Shaikh (India)
- ✓ **Best Bowler:** Chandani Khan (India)

About India Deaf Women's T20 Series:

Milestone: The series marked the first overseas assignment of the Indian Deaf Women's Cricket Team under the Indian Deaf Cricket Association **(IDCA)**.

Awards: Indian players dominated the individual honours, with **Shradda Vaishnav** named Player of the Final, **Reddy Jyoshna** adjudged Player of the Series, **Chandani Khan** winning Best Bowler, and **Needa Zabi Shaikh** receiving Best Batter.

Support: The tour was supported by the Serum Institute of India Private Limited (SIIPL), Cyrus Poonawalla Group, and the Villoo Poonawalla Charitable Foundation (VPCF) to promote deaf women's cricket internationally.

About Indian Deaf Cricket Association (IDCA): IDCA established in 2020 and headquartered in New Delhi (Delhi), is the governing body for deaf cricket in India and is headed by President Sumit Jain.

Delhi CM Rekha Gupta Unveils 'Mayur' Mascot for Commonwealth Table Tennis Championship 2026

In July 2026, **Rekha Gupta,** Chief Minister (CM) of Delhi, unveiled **'Mayur'**, the official mascot of the **22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championship**, in New Delhi, Delhi.

- The mascot was unveiled in the presence of Ashish Sood, Delhi Education and Sports Minister; Vivek Kohli, President of Commonwealth Table Tennis Federation and other dignitaries.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Launch of the official mascot 'Mayur' (Indian Peacock)
- ✓ **Event?** 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championship
- ✓ **Unveiled By:** Rekha Gupta, CM, Delhi

- ✓ **Where?** Thyagraj Stadium, New Delhi
- ✓ **Organisers:** Delhi Government & Table Tennis Federation of India.

Key Details of Mascot:

Design: The mascot **'Mayur'** is inspired by the **Indian Peacock** (Pavo cristatus), the national bird of India. Its feathers represent the flags of participating Commonwealth nations and symbolise energy, enthusiasm, pride, and unity.

Tournament: The Commonwealth Table Tennis Championship 2026 was held at Thyagaraj Stadium**, New Delhi,** Delhi from 27 July to 2 August 2026 as a 7-day tournament featuring competitions across 7 categories.

Organizer: The championship is being jointly organised by the Delhi government and the Table Tennis Federation of India (TTFI) and is expected to attract players from more than 35 Commonwealth nations

Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships: It was initiated in 1969 at the World Championships in Munich (Germany) by Commonwealth delegates. Before becoming part of the Commonwealth Games in 2002, 15 editions were conducted since 1971.

MYAS Grants Conditional Recognition to Judo Federation of India

In July 2026, the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports **(MYAS)** granted **conditional recognition** to the Judo Federation of India **(JFI),** enabling it to resume governance of the sport and participate in national and international competitions.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Conditional recognition granted
- ✓ **To Whom?** Judo Federation of India
- ✓ **Granted By:** Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports
- ✓ **Purpose:** Restore governance and enable participation in national and international judo events
- ✓ **Condition:** Compliance with National Sports Development Code of India, 2011 and MYAS directives.

Key Details of Recognition:

Significance: The recognition restores stability in Indian judo by enabling JFI to conduct activities, organise championships, select athletes, and ensure India's participation in domestic and international events.

Condition: The recognition was issued after the federation agreed to comply with the MYAS's directives and the National Sports Development Code of India, 2011 (Sports Code).

Governance Reform: The JFI was under a court-appointed administrator since 2022. Following a Delhi High Court (HC) ruling in February 2026, the federation conducted its Annual General Meeting (AGM) and aligned with the National Sports Governance Act, 2025.

- An interim Executive Committee was elected, led by **Mukesh Kumar** (President), Banee Brata Das (Secretary General), and Shailesh Shrikant Tilak (Treasurer).

Asian U-19 & U-23 Boxing Championships 2026: Uzbekistan Tops; India Wins 29 Medals Including 5 Gold

The Asian Under-19 (U-19) & U-23 Boxing Championships 2026, inaugural edition of the combined boxing tournament, held in **Jakarta, Indonesia** on 3-16 July 2026, where **India's** boxers secured **29-medal** haul with 5 gold, 13 silver, and 11 bronze medals, to finish third in the overall medal standings.

- **Uzbekistan** topped the medal table with 33 medals (21 gold, 6 silver, and 6 bronze and **Kazakhstan** finished second with **30 medals** (11 gold, 11 silver and 8 bronze).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Asian U-19 & U-23 Boxing Championships 2026
- ✓ **Where?** Jakarta, Indonesia
- ✓ **When?** 3–16 July 2026
- ✓ **Organiser:** Asian Boxing & Indonesian Boxing Federation
- ✓ **Top countries:** Uzbekistan (33 medals); Kazakhstan (30 medals)
- ✓ **India's Medal:** 3rd – 29 medals (5 gold, 13 silver, and 11 bronze)
- ✓ **India's Gold:**
- ✓ **Women:** Chandrika Bhoresh Pujari (U-19), Prachi (U-19), Nisha (U-23)
- ✓ **Men:** Vishvanath Suresh (U-23), Ganga (U-23)

About Asian U-19 & U-23 Boxing Championships 2026:

Organiser: The championship was officially organised by **Asian Boxing**, the continental governing body affiliated with World Boxing, in partnership with the Indonesian Boxing Federation (Persatuan Tinju Amatir Indonesia – PERTINA), which served as the Local Organising Committee (LOC).

Categories: The competition features two age-based development tiers for men and women, Under-19 (Youth Tier) for elite junior athletes born in 2008 and 2009, and Under-23 (Senior Pipeline) for advanced prospects born between 2004 and 2007, to ensure fair competitive matching.

Highlights of India's Performance:

Women's Champion:

- **Performance:** India's women boxers finished the championship with a 19-medal haul comprising 3 gold, 10 silver, and 4 bronze medals. The U-19 women's team contributed 2 gold and 6 silver medals, while the U-23 women's team added 1 gold, 4 silver, and 4 bronze medals.
- **Gold:** India won three gold medals through **Chandrika Bhoresh Pujari** (U-19, 51 kilogram, kg), who defeated **Nazokat Mardonova** (Uzbekistan) 5–0, **Prachi** (U-19, 57kg), who beat **Dira Artika** (Indonesia) 5–0, and **Nisha** (U-23, 54kg), who defeated **Koiin Kokufu** (Japan) in the final.

Men's Champion:

- **Performance:** India's men's boxing team secured a total of 12 medals at the championship, comprising 2 gold, 3 silver, and 7 bronze medals. The U19 team won 2 silver and 4 bronze medals, while the U23 team contributed 2 gold, 1 silver, and 3 bronze medals.
- **Gold:** India's two gold medals in the men's competition were won by **Vishvanath Suresh** in the U-23 50 kg category and **Ganga** in the U-23 55 kg category.

Asian Boxing U19 Championships (Men & Women) 2026:

Rank	National Federation	Category	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1	**Uzbekistan** Boxing Federation	Men	7	1	1	**15**
		Women	4	2	0	
2	**Kazakhstan** Boxing Federation	Men	2	4	2	**14**
		Women	3	0	3	
3	Boxing Federation of **India**	Men	0	2	4	**14**
		Women	2	6	0	

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4	Boxing Association of **Korea**	Men	1	1	2	**5**
		Women	0	0	1	
5	Pengurus Besar Tinju **Indonesia**	Men	0	0	2	**4**
		Women	1	1	0	

Asian Boxing U23 Championships (Men & Women) 2026:

Rank	National Federation	Category	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1	**Uzbekistan** Boxing Federation	Men	4	2	3	18
		Women	6	1	2	
2	**Kazakhstan** Boxing Federation	Men	3	4	1	16
		Women	3	3	2	
3	Boxing Federation of **India**	Men	2	1	3	15
		Women	1	4	4	
4	**Japan** Boxing Federation	Men	1	1	1	6
		Women	0	1	2	
5	National Boxing Federation **Kyrgyz Republic**	Men	0	2	4	7
		Women	0	0	1	

Indian Gold Medal Winners at U19 & U23 Boxing Championships 2026:

S. No.	Athlete	Category	Weight Class (in kilogram (kg)
Women			
1	Chandrika Bhoresh Pujari	U-19	51kg
2	Prachi	U-19	57kg
3	Nisha	U-23	54kg
Men			
1	Vishvanath Suresh	U-23	50 kg
2	Ganga	U-23	55 kg

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About Asian Boxing:

Asian Boxing is a dedicated non-profit organization founded to promote and develop Olympic boxing across the Asian continent.

President – Pichai Chunhavajira

Headquarters – Bangkok, Thailand

Established – 2024

ICC Approves New Formats for Men's ODI and T20 World Cups to Enhance Competitiveness

In July 2026, the International Cricket Council **(ICC)** approved major format changes to the **ICC Men's** One Day International **(ODI)** World Cup and the **ICC Men's** Twenty20 **(T20) World Cup**, introducing a **Super 7** round-robin stage in the 14-team ODI World Cup and a **Super 10** stage with Eliminators in the 20-team T20 World Cup, during its annual Board meetings held in Edinburgh, Scotland.

- The revised formats aim to create more meaningful matches, improve competitiveness, strengthen tournament structures, and enhance the experience for players and fans.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval for New formats for the Men's ODI and T20 World Cups.
- ✓ **By Who?** ICC
- ✓ **ODI Changes:** 14 teams retained, Introduction of Round 1, New Super 7 stage, Total matches increased to 57
- ✓ **T20 Changes:** 20 teams retained, 5 groups of 4 teams, Super 10 replaces Super 8, Eliminator matches introduced.
- ✓ **2028 T20 Qualification:** Scotland enters the Europe Regional Final directly, while seven teams qualify through the Global Qualifier.

ICC World Cup Format Changes:

ODI Format: From the 2027 ICC Men's ODI World Cup onwards, a new **four-stage forma**t will be introduced, featuring a Preliminary Round, two groups of six teams, a Super 7 stage, and the knockout stage.

- The revised format will increase the total number of matches from 48 to **57**, with the top three teams from each group and the best fourth-placed team advancing to the Super 7.

T20 Format: From the 2028 ICC Men's T20 World Cup onwards, the tournament will begin with **five groups of four teams,** followed by a Super 10 stage replacing the Super 8, with the top two teams from each group progressing.

- Eliminators will decide the remaining semi-finalists, while the expansion of the second stage from 8 to 10 teams aims to improve competitiveness and reduce dead-rubber matches.

Qualification: Scotland will qualify directly for the Europe Regional Final. Teams from the 2026 T20 World Cup that do not secure automatic qualification will enter the Global Qualifier, while the remaining slots will be decided through regional qualifiers.

- The remaining eight Global Qualifier spots will be filled through regional qualification, Africa (2), Asia (2), Europe (2), Americas (1), and East Asia-Pacific (1), with the five regional winners and the next three highest-ranked eligible teams qualifying for the 2028 tournament, subject to minimum performance criteria.

Additional Proposal: The ICC approved the revised qualification pathway for the 2028 Men's T20 World Cup and endorsed a proposed 16-team global tournament for Associate Members, subject to final approval.

About International Cricket Council (ICC):

Chairman – Jay Shah

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Headquarters – Dubai, United Arab Emirates (UAE)
Established – 1909 (as Imperial Cricket Conference)

Japan Open 2026: India's PV Sindhu Wins Women's Singles Title; France's Christo Popov Claims Men's Singles

The **2026 Japan Open** (officially known as the Daihatsu Japan Open 2026), the **43rd** edition of the Badminton World Federation (BWF) Super 750 tournament held at Tokyo Metropolitan Gymnasium in Tokyo, Japan, from 14 to 19 July 2026.

- Pusarla Venkata **(PV) Sindhu**, India's two-time Olympic medallist, won her maiden Japan Open **women's singles title** by defeating Japan's Akane Yamaguchi 21-17, 21-17 in the final.
- France's **Christo Popov** claimed the Japan Open 2026 Men's Singles title with a 21-11, 21-19 victory over Japan's Koki Watanabe.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 2026 Japan Open held
- ✓ **Where?** Tokyo, Japan
- ✓ **Organiser:** Badminton Association of Japan
- ✓ **2026 Winners:**
- ✓ **Men's Singles:** Christo Popov (France)
- ✓ **Women's Singles:** PV Sindhu (India)
- ✓ **Men's Doubles:** Fajar Alfian and Muhammad Shohibul Fikri (Indonesia)
- ✓ **Women's Doubles:** Kim Hye-jeong and Kong Hee-yong (South Korea)
- ✓ **Mixed:** Feng Yanzhe and Huang Dongping (China)

About Japan Open 2026:

2026 Tour: The 2026 Badminton World Federation (BWF) World Tour, officially known as the **2026 HSBC BWF World Tour**, was the ninth season of the circuit comprising **30 tournaments** divided into 5 levels with higher-level tournaments offering greater ranking points and prize money.

Prize: The tournament's **USD 950,000** prize pool was distributed according to BWF regulations, with USD 66,500 allocated for each singles event and USD 70,300 allocated for each doubles event.

Organization: The tournament was organized by the Badminton Association of Japan **(BAJ)**, governed by BWF, locally managed by the **Tokyo Badminton Association**, and sponsored by **Daihatsu Motor Co., Ltd.** as the title sponsor.

Background: The Japan Open is an annual badminton tournament established in 1982 as the First Yonex Cup Japan Open, becoming Japan's first international badminton tournament to offer prize money of 10 million yen.

- The tournament became part of the Badminton World Federation (BWF) Super Series in 2007 before being classified as a Badminton World Federation (BWF) World Tour Super 750 event from 2018.

Highlights:

Men's Doubles: Fajar Alfian and Muhammad Shohibul Fikri (Indonesia) defeated Kim Won-ho and Seo Seung-jae (South Korea).

Women's Doubles: Kim Hye-jeong and Kong Hee-yong (South Korea) defeated Jia Yifan and Zhang Shuxian (China).

Mixed Doubles: Feng Yanzhe and Huang Dongping (China) defeated Tang Chun Man and Tse Ying Suet (Hong Kong).

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About PV Sindhu's Achievement:

Journey: Sindhu defeated Han Yue (China) in the Round of 16, advanced past Nozomi Okuhara (Japan) in the quarter-finals after her retirement, advanced past Chen Yu Fei (China) in the semi-finals after her retirement

Achievements: PV Sindhu became the **first Indian** to win the Japan Open and secured her maiden BWF Super 750 title by clinching the 2026 championship.

- The triumph ended her title drought of over two years and marked her first BWF title since the Syed Modi International 2024, as well as her biggest victory since winning the 2019 BWF World Championships.

Winners of Japan Open 2026:

Championship	Winner	Runner
Men's Singles	Christo Popov (France)	Koki Watanabe (Japan)
Women's Singles	PV Sindhu (India)	Akane Yamaguchi (Japan)
Men's Doubles	Fajar Alfian / Muhammad Shohibul Fikri (Indonesia)	Kim Won-ho / Seo Seung-jae (South Korea)
Women's Doubles	Kim Hye-jeong / Kong Hee-yong (South Korea)	Jia Yifan / Zhang Shuxian (China)
Mixed Doubles	Feng Yanzhe / Huang Dongping (China)	Tang Chun Man / Tse Ying Suet (Hong Kong)

About Badminton World Federation (BWF):

BWF is the international governing body for the sport of badminton, officially recognized by the International Olympic Committee (IOC) and the International Paralympic Committee (IPC).
President – Khunying Patama Leeswadtrakul
Headquarters – Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia
Established – 1934

Spain Clinches Second FIFA World Cup Title, Beats Argentina in 2026 Final – Part I

The International Federation of Association Football **(FIFA) World Cup 2026**, the **23rd** edition of the men's FIFA World Cup, the quadrennial international men's football championship held from **11 June to 19 July 2026**, and co-hosted across 16 host cities in the United States of America (USA) (11), Mexico (3), and Canada (2).

- **Spain** secured their second FIFA World Cup title by defeating defending champions **Argentina** 1–0 after extra time in the 2026 final, held at MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey, USA, with substitute **Ferran Torres** scoring the decisive goal in the 106th minute.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** FIFA World Cup 2026
- ✓ **Host:** (USA) (11), Mexico (3), and Canada (2)
- ✓ **Winner:** Spain
- ✓ **Runner-up:** Argentina
- ✓ **Awards:**

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- ✓ Golden Ball (Best Player) – Rodri (Spain)
- ✓ Golden Boot (Top Scorer) – Kylian Mbappé (France)
- ✓ Golden Glove (Best Goalkeeper) – Unai Simón (Spain)
- ✓ Best Young Player – Pau Cubarsí (Spain)
- ✓ FIFA Fair Play Trophy – The Netherlands

About FIFA World Cup 2026:

Format: The 2026 FIFA World Cup featured an expanded 48-team (from 32) format with 12 groups of four teams, a 104-match schedule, and a new Round of 32 involving the top two teams from each group along with the eight best third-placed teams.

Organizer: It was organized by FIFA under the leadership of FIFA President Gianni Infantino.

Background: The FIFA World Cup has been held every four years since its inaugural edition in 1930, except in 1942 and 1946 due to World War II.

- Over its history, the tournament has been won by eight different national teams, with Brazil holding a record five titles and remaining the only nation to have participated in every edition.

Highlights:

Results: Substitute **Ferran Torres** scored the winning goal in the 106th minute to secure Spain's FIFA World Cup title, while England defeated France 6–4 in the third-place play-off to achieve their best-ever FIFA World Cup finish on foreign soil.

Performances: Cape Verde drew with Spain and Uruguay to finish second in their group before losing 3–2 to Argentina after extra time in the knockout stage, while the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DR Congo) drew with Portugal and advanced from the group stage.

Awards & Records: Spain's Rodri won the Golden Ball as the tournament's best player, while France's Kylian Mbappé claimed his second consecutive Golden Boot with 10 goals.

- Argentina's Lionel Messi, aged 39, became the oldest outfield player to start a FIFA World Cup final and the first player to start three FIFA World Cup finals, finishing with 8 goals, 4 assists, and the Silver Ball, while Spain's Unai Simón set a FIFA World Cup record by keeping 7 clean sheets in 8 matches, conceding just one goal.

Individual Awards at FIFA World Cup 2026:

Award	Winner
Golden Ball (Best Player)	Rodri (Spain)
Silver Ball	Lionel Messi (Argentina)
Bronze Ball	Kylian Mbappé (France)
Golden Boot (Top Scorer)	Kylian Mbappé (France) – 10 goals
Silver Boot	Lionel Messi (Argentina) – 8 goals
Bronze Boot	Jude Bellingham (England) – 7 goals
Golden Glove (Best Goalkeeper)	Unai Simón (Spain) – 7 clean sheets
Best Young Player	Pau Cubarsí (Spain)
FIFA Fair Play Trophy	The Netherlands

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About International Federation of Association Football or Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA):

President – Giovanni "Gianni" Vincenzo Infantino
Headquarters – Zurich, Switzerland
Established – 1904

Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya Unveils 'Peacko' As Official Mascot For BWF World Championships 2026

On 18 July 2026, Union Minister **Mansukh Mandaviya,** Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports (MYAS) along with Dr. Himanta Biswa Sarma, Badminton Association of India (BAI) president-cum- Chief Minister(CM) of Assam**,** unveiled the official mascot **'Peacko'** and launched the championship **anthem** for the Badminton World Federation **(BWF) World Championships 2026,** in New Delhi, Delhi.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** BWF World Championship 2026 Mascot & Anthem unveiled
- ✓ **Unveiled by:** Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya (MYAS) and Dr. Himanta Biswa Sarma, President, BAI
- ✓ **Event Venue:** New Delhi (August 2026)
- ✓ **Mascot:** 'Peacko', inspired by the Indian Peafowl
- ✓ **Anthem:** Features India's 16-member BWF World Championships contingent

About Mascot:

Mascot: The official mascot **'Peacko**', inspired by the **Indian Peafowl,** and the championship anthem featuring India's 16-member contingent were unveiled to showcase the spirit and unity of Indian badminton.

Anthem: The official anthem featuring **India's 16-member** World Championships contingent, including PV Sindhu, Lakshya Sen, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, Chirag Shetty, Ayush Shetty, Unnati Hooda, Gayatri Gopichand, and Treesa Jolly, was launched to showcase the energy, ambition, and unity of Indian badminton.

Tournament: The **30th edition** of the BWF World Championships scheduled to be held from 17–23 August 2026 at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium in New Delhi, featuring 400+ shuttlers from over 50 countries.

About BAI: Established in 1934 and headquartered in New Delhi, the BAI is the national governing body for badminton in India, responsible for promoting and regulating the sport.

FIFA World Cup 2026: Prize Money, Retirements & Records – Part II

In July 2026, the International Federation of Association Football **(FIFA)** announced a record prize pool of **USD 871 million** for the FIFA World Cup 2026, making it the most lucrative tournament in football history.

- Following Spain's victory over Argentina in the final, the Royal Spanish Football Federation **(RFEF)** received **USD 51 million** as champions, while runners-up Argentina Football Association **(AFA)** earned **USD 34 million** and England received USD 30 million for finishing third.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** FIFA World Cup 2026 – Part II
- ✓ **Prize Money:** Total record USD 871 million pool
- ✓ **Distribution:** Spain (champions – USD 51 million); Argentina (runners-up – USD 34 million); England (3rd – USD 30 million);

- ✓ **Retirements:** Cristiano Ronaldo, Neymar Jr, Manuel Neuer, Guillermo Ochoa
- ✓ **Key Records:** Lionel Messi (30 World Cup matches, 3 finals), Lamine Yamal, Kylian Mbappé, Emiliano Martínez, Enzo Fernández.

FIFA World Cup 2026 Prize Money:

Structure: The prize fund comprised USD 703 million in performance-based rewards and USD 168 million in non-performance financial support, including preparation grants and participation payments.

Guarantee: Every participating nation was guaranteed at least USD 12.5 million, comprising a USD 10 million participation payment and a USD 2.5 million preparation grant.

Retirements:

Overview: FIFA World Cup 2026 marked the end of an era as **Cristiano Ronaldo (Portugal), Neymar Jr. (Brazil), Manuel Neuer (Germany), and Guillermo Ochoa (Mexico)** confirmed that it had been their final appearance on football's biggest stage.

Cristiano Ronaldo (41): He ended his FIFA World Cup career after Portugal's Round of 16 defeat to Spain, making a record-equalling sixth FIFA World Cup appearance, scoring three goals, competing as the tournament's second-oldest player, retiring without winning the trophy, and expressing gratitude for his extraordinary career.

Neymar Jr. (34): He retired from international football after Brazil's Round of 16 loss to Norway, scoring Brazil's only goal from a penalty, returning after long-term injuries, and finishing as Brazil's all-time leading goalscorer.

Manuel Neuer (40): He concluded his international career after Germany's Round of 32 penalty shootout defeat to Paraguay, having returned from international retirement for one final FIFA World Cup and ending a career widely regarded among football's greatest goalkeepers.

Guillermo Ochoa (40): He ended his FIFA World Cup career after representing Mexico in a rare six tournaments, receiving a standing ovation during his final campaign, and retiring following Mexico's elimination by England.

Records:

Lionel Messi: Argentina captain Lionel Messi continued to rewrite football history at FIFA World Cup 2026, achieving several unprecedented milestones despite Argentina finishing runners-up after a 1–0 defeat to Spain in the final.

- He became the **first footballer** to play **30 FIFA World Cup** matches after captaining Argentina against Cape Verde in the Round of 32, leading the attack alongside Lautaro Martínez, entering the match with a tournament-record **19 FIFA World Cup goals**, needing one more to become the first player to score 20.
- He became the first footballer to start **three FIFA World Cup Finals**, the first captain to lead his country in **three FIFA World Cup Finals**, the oldest outfield player to start a **FIFA World Cup Final** at **39 years and 25 days**, recorded **54 touches** against Spain

Lamine Yamal: Spanish teenager Lamine Yamal enjoyed one of the greatest breakthrough tournaments in football history by becoming the first teenager to play in both the Union of European Football Associations **(UEFA) European Championship** final and **FIFA World Cup** final.

- He also became the third-youngest player to appear in a FIFA World Cup Final, the fourth-youngest FIFA World Cup winner, and started the final at 19 years and 6 days.
- **Emiliano Martínez:** Argentina goalkeeper Emiliano Martínez produced one of the greatest goalkeeping performances in FIFA World Cup Final history by making 11 saves against Spain, the most by a goalkeeper in a FIFA World Cup Final in the past 60 years.

  Enzo Fernández: Argentina midfielder Enzo Fernández became the sixth footballer to receive a red card in a FIFA World Cup Final and the first player to be sent off in the final since Johnny Heitinga for the Netherlands in 2010.

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Coaches:

- **Lionel Scaloni:** Argentina head coach Lionel Scaloni reached a major coaching milestone by taking charge of the national team for the **100th time** during the Round of 32 victory over Cape Verde, having been appointed in 2018.

Luis de la Fuente: Spain head coach Luis de la Fuente became the **oldest FIFA World Cup-winning coach** and extended his unbeaten run to 15 major tournament matches.

Pakistan to Host 14th Edition of SAF Games in March 2027

In July 2026, **Pakistan** will host the **14th** edition of the South Asian Federation **(SAF) Games** from March 23rd to 31st, 2027. This will be the **3rd time** that Pakistan will host games after 1989 and 2004.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announcement of Host Country for SAF Games 2027
- ✓ **Host Country?** Pakistan
- ✓ **Edition:** 14th
- ✓ **Host Cities:** Islamabad, Faisalabad and Lahore
- ✓ **SAF Games Scheduled:** March 23rd to March 31st, 2027.

About SAF Games 2027:

Host Cities: Pakistan's 3 cities namely, Islamabad, Faisalabad and Lahore, will host the SAF Games 2027.
Participation: The multi sports event is expected to witness the participation of 3500 athletes from the 8 South Asian countries.
About SAF Games: SAF Games, established on November 26, 1981 in New Delhi, Delhi, aimed to promote friendship and goodwill among the member countries of South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) (Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka).

Menuires International Chess Championship 2026: Indian GMs S. Rohith Krishna & Raja Rithvik Win Gold & Silver

In July 2026, Grandmaster **(GM) S. Rohith Krishna** of Tamil Nadu **(TN)** won the **gold** medal, while **GM Raja Rithvik** of **Telangana** secured the **silver** medal at the inaugural **Menuires International Chess Championship 2026** held at Le Break des Menuires, Savoie, France on 11–18 July 2026.

- Both players finished unbeaten on 7 points from 9 rounds, with Rohith Krishna clinching the title on a superior tie-break score of 43 ahead of Raja Rithvik, who recorded a tie-break score of 41.5.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Inaugural Menuires International Chess Championship 2026
- ✓ **Where?** Savoie, France
- ✓ **When?** 11–18 July 2026
- ✓ **Organiser:** FIDE
- ✓ **Gold:** GM S. Rohith Krishna (TN, India)
- ✓ **Silver:** GM Raja Rithvik (Telangana, India)
- ✓ **Bronze:** GM Omelja Artem (Ukraine)

About Menuires International Chess Championship 2026:

Overview: The championship featured an international field of 86 players competing in a nine-round Swiss-system tournament, where players with similar scores were paired each round to ensure competitive balance without elimination.
Regulation: The tournament was conducted under International Chess Federation or Fédération Internationale des Échecs (FIDE) regulations, with standings determined by total points followed by the

prescribed tie-break methods.
Performance: Fourth-seeded Raja Rithvik remained unbeaten with five wins and four draws, including a final-round victory with the black pieces over higher-rated French GM Maxime Lagarde (Elo 2622), despite his own Elo rating of 2521.
Bronze: GM **Omelja Artem** of Ukraine secured the bronze medal after finishing with 6.5 points.

PCI and CPSFI Sign MoU to Bid for 2029 World Abilitysport Games

On 22 July 2026, the Paralympic Committee of India **(PCI)** and the Cerebral Palsy Sports Federation of India **(CPSFI)** signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) in New Delhi, Delhi to jointly pursue India's bid to host the **2029 World Abilitysport Games**.

- The partnership aims to prepare and submit a competitive bid to bring the international multi-sport event for athletes with disabilities to India, strengthening the country's role in the global **Paralympic movement**.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** India's bid for 2029 World Abilitysport Games
- ✓ **MoU Signed By:** PCI and CPSFI
- ✓ **Venue:** New Delhi, Delhi
- ✓ **Event:** 2029 World Abilitysport Games
- ✓ **Potential Cities:** Chennai & Bhubaneswar
- ✓ **Previous Host in India:** IWAS World Games, Bengaluru (2009)

Highlights of the Bid for World Abilitysport Games:

Background: India previously hosted the International Wheelchair and Amputee Sports Federation (IWAS) World Games in Bengaluru, Karnataka in 2009.
Host Cities: Chennai (Tamil Nadu, TN) and Bhubaneswar (Odisha) are under consideration as host cities for the 2029 World Abilitysport Games, based on infrastructure, accessibility and Games readiness.
Participants: The 2029 World Abilitysport Games are expected to feature **1,500+ participants** across Para sports disciplines including Para Athletics, Para Swimming, Para Badminton, Para Fencing, CP Football, Para Table Tennis and Para Wheelchair Basketball (3-a-side).
About PCI: The PCI, established in 1992 and headquartered in New Delhi (Delhi), is the national governing body for promoting and managing Para sports in India, headed by Devendra Jhajharia (President).

Argentina's Nicolás Otamendi Retires from International Football

In July 2026, **Argentina**'s veteran centre-back **Nicolás Otamendi** announced his **retirement** from **international football** at the age of 38, ending a distinguished 17-year career during which he made 139 appearances for the national team.

- Although retiring from international football, Otamendi continues his professional club career after joining Club Atlético River Plate, an Argentine professional sports club

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Announcement of retirement from international football
- ✓ **Who?** Nicolás Otamendi
- ✓ **Age:** 38 years
- ✓ **International career:** 17 years, 139 appearances, 2022 FIFA World Cup winner

About Nicolás Otamendi:

Career Overview: Serving consistently as a first-choice central defender, Nicolás Otamendi made 139 appearances and scored 8 goals for Argentina while representing his country at four Fédération

Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) World Cups in 2014, 2018, 2022, and 2026.
Major Achievements: As a key member of Argentina's golden generation during one of the most successful periods in its football history, he won two Copa América titles in 2021 and 2024 alongside the 2022 FIFA World Cup in Qatar.
Final Appearance: The 38-year-old centre-back made his final international appearance as a substitute in the 2026 FIFA World Cup Final in the United States of America (USA).

2026 ISSF World Cup Rifle/Pistol Held in Hangzhou; China Leads, India Finishes Third with Four Medals

The International Shooting Sport Federation **(ISSF)** World Cup was held at Fuyang Yinhu Sports Centre in **Hangzhou, People's Republic of China**, from 20 to 29 July 2026, where **India** finished its campaign in third place with **four medals** including 1 gold, 1 silver and 2 bronze.

- China topped the medal tally with 7 gold, 6 silver, and 5 bronze medals (18 total), followed by the United States of America **(USA)** with 2 gold and 2 silver medals (4 total).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** 2026 ISSF World Cup Rifle/Pistol held
- ✓ **Where?** Hangzhou, China
- ✓ **Organiser:** ISSF
- ✓ **Top Countries:** China – 18 medals (7gold, 6silver, 5 bronze) & USA – 4 medals (2gold, 2silver)
- ✓ **India:** 3rd with 4 Medals – (1gold, 1silver, 2bronze)
- ✓ **Indian Medal Winners:** Esha Singh (Gold); Sainyam Vij (Silver); Manu Bhaker (Bronze); Sonam Maskar & Himanshu Dhillon (Bronze).

About ISSF World Cup 2026:

Edition: The 2026 ISSF World Cup is the **41st** edition of the annual Olympic shooting competition, held from 25 March to 8 December across eight host nations.
Events: The competition features Men's Individual, Women's Individual, and Mixed Team events in Rifle/Pistol and Shotgun disciplines.
Hangzhou: Hangzhou, China, hosted the **sixth** Rifle/Pistol leg of the 2026 ISSF World Cup.

Indian Performance:

Gold: Esha Singh won gold in the Women's 25m (metre) Pistol with 40 hits, securing her second ISSF World Cup gold of 2026.
Silver: Sainyam Vij won silver in the Women's 10m Air Pistol with 243.4 points, finishing just 0.2 points behind the gold medallist.
Bronze: Manu Bhaker won bronze in the Women's 25m Pistol with 28 hits, while **Sonam Maskar** and **Himanshu Dhillon** secured bronze in the 10m Air Rifle Mixed Team event with 441.2 points.
Performances: India's Elavenil Valarivan and Parth Mane finished fourth in the 10m Air Rifle Mixed Team, Udaivir Singh Jaijee/Pragati Dubey and Bhowneesh Mendiratta/Kirti Gupta missed the Trap Mixed Team final, and Bhavesh Shekhawat was India's best performer in the Men's 25m Rapid Fire Pistol, finishing 22nd.

Records:

Women: Three-time Olympic champion **Kimberly Rhode**, from United States of America (USA), won a record-extending 27th ISSF World Cup gold and her 41st World Cup medal by defeating fellow American Samantha Simonton in the women's skeet final.
Men: Qatar's Rashid Saleh Al-Athba won the men's skeet title after equalling the world record with 35 hits, defeating Spain's Jose Maria Mielgo Moneo by one target.

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